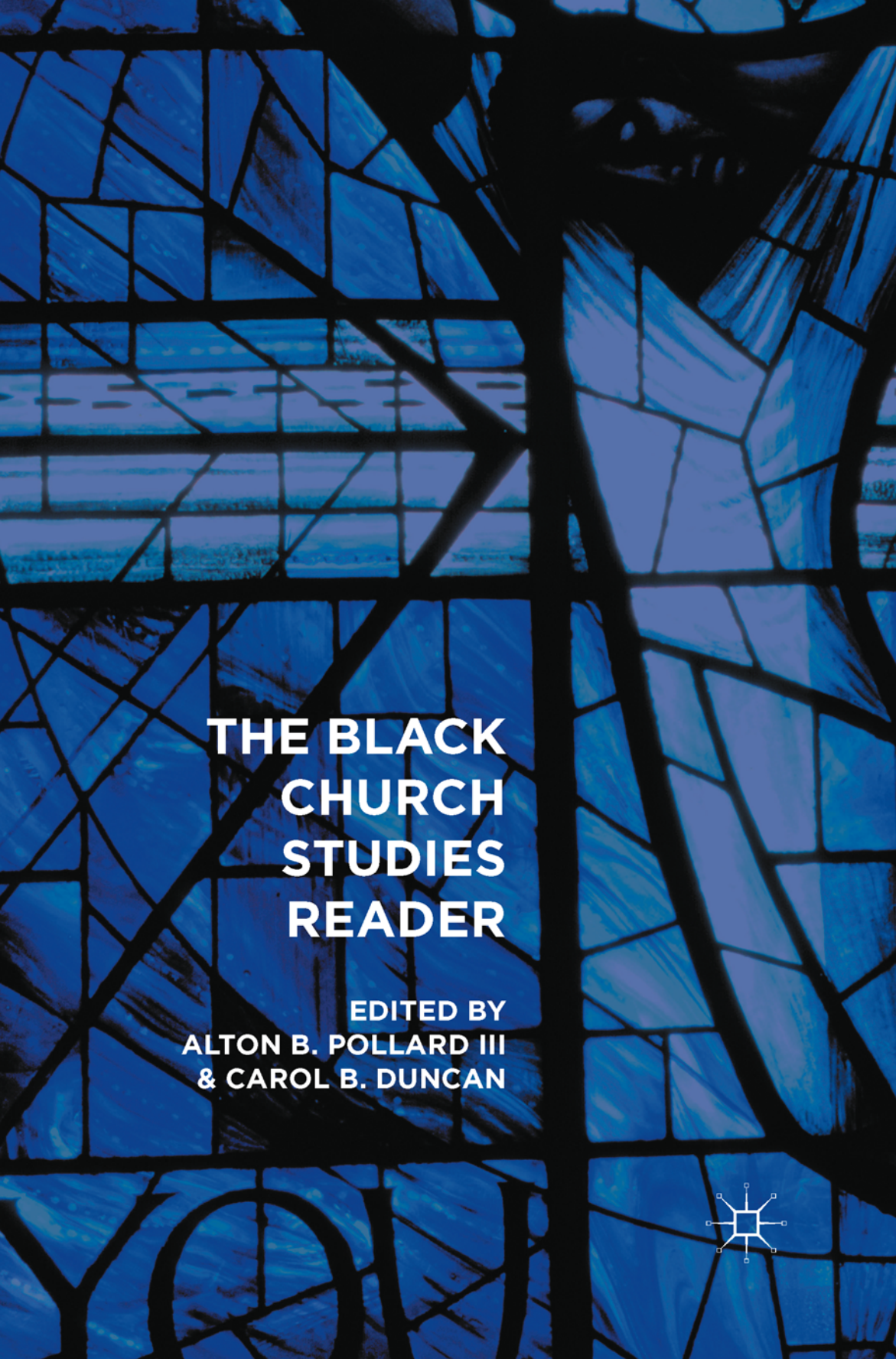


The background of the cover is a blue-toned stained glass window. The leaded glass pattern is prominent, with various geometric shapes. In the upper right quadrant, a portion of a person's face is visible, looking downwards. The overall aesthetic is artistic and spiritual.

THE BLACK CHURCH STUDIES READER

**EDITED BY
ALTON B. POLLARD III
& CAROL B. DUNCAN**

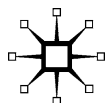


The Black Church Studies Reader

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Edited by Alton B. Pollard III and Carol B. Duncan

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THE BLACK CHURCH STUDIES READER

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Foreword

Forrest E. Harris, Sr.

What would life in America be for the poor and the oppressed if the faith, prophetic hope, justice-seeking quests of the Black church were the nation's reality? How has the Black church survived the supremacist history of America, or has it become overly complicit with the social agenda of excessive capitalism and individual autonomy? Who has the Black church been, who is it now, and what does it offer today for transformation of systemic racism, sexism, and a myriad of oppressive conditions in the North American reality? Does the Black church remain a healing agent for the psychological, social, and spiritual wounds of Black life left from the diseased imagination of white Christianity's colonial past? How can the Black church forge a usable future for social justice against nihilistic threats in what Johnny B. Hill calls "a new age of technology, globalization and empire"? In sum, these questions are addressed from interdisciplinary, ethical, and theological perspectives in *The Black Church Studies Reader*, coedited by Alton B. Pollard III, and Carol B. Duncan. What knowledge(s) do Black churches need to unmask injustice in public life and enhance theological and political literacy, thereby empowering the Black church to speak publicly and prophetically for social justice change? How do we build an ecumenical movement, multicultural, multiethnic, and multiracial for economic justice? Contributors to this rich anthology offer a creative synthesis for understanding the recapitulation of these inquiries in light of the ecclesiological traditions and theological imagination of the Black churches.

Black Church Studies has emerged within the academy as a bridge between Black church congregational praxis and the academic study of Black and womanist theologies. As a field of theological and ethical inquiry, Black Church Studies has a contextual theological commitment to exploring the liberating logic and faith of Black Christianity that fluctuates between what James Cone labeled as "Martin's Dream and Malcolm's Nightmare,"¹ Delores Williams' "Sisters in the Wilderness,"² and Emilie Townes' "A Troubling in My Soul."³ White supremacist values in many forms, systems, and xenophobic realities persist against the flourishing of Black life, while the dream of totalizing justice in America is a determined and reoccurring focus of womanist and Black theologians and the Black churches and communities for whom they write.

For the past twenty-six years, as director of Vanderbilt's Kelly Miller Smith Institute on Black Church Studies, I share in the hopes and aspirations of totalizing justice for the Black community with many of the contributors to this volume. The chapters here are realistic about the American reality of oppression, its reoccurring commitment to white supremacist values, and its deployment of power and hegemonic hold on both the Black and white religious imaginations. Although the Black church has morphed and survived the terror and brutalized realities of North American racism, now in the age of President Barack Obama and assumed post-racialism, a realistic assessment of the current state of Black churches and the communities they serve is needed. Some believe the Black church is at a crossroads of irrelevance and prophetic inertia, no longer "prophesying deliverance" but on trial as a complicit consumer of the worst

habits and values of American patriarchy, individualism, and materialism. The widening gaps of generational knowledge about the struggles of Black Christianity, the “MAAFA” experience, “The New Jim Crow of Mass Incarceration,” equality for LGBTQ persons, and Black youth culture’s disconnect with the traditional mainline Black churches create a set of imperatives for Black church leaders and theological educators. These imperatives are tied not only to understanding racism as a system but also to the continuing “American dilemma” of race, gender, culture, and justice lingering still in the psychosocial makeup of the Black poor in need of inner and outer liberation and the guidance of a consistent and persistent prophetic voice.

The thread that runs through each of the chapters in this anthology is what James Baldwin prophesied decades ago:

The American crisis, which is part of a global, historical crisis, [is not] likely to resolve itself soon. An old world is dying, and a new one, kicking in the belly of its mother, time, announces that it is ready to be born. This birth will not be easy, and many of us are doomed to discover that we are exceedingly clumsy midwives. No matter, so long as we accept that our responsibility is to the new born: the acceptance of responsibility contains the key to the necessarily evolving skill.⁴

Ethical and theological empowerment for sustaining “the necessarily evolving skill” represents the educational and liberating human capital of the Black church. This anthology builds upon the significant work of *The Black Church in the African Experience*⁵ by C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence H. Mamiya, and follows the pedagogical aims of the epic work of Gayraud Wilmore’s, *Black Religions and Black Radicalism*,⁶ and healing what Raphael Warnock calls *The Divided Mind of the Black Church*.⁷ It is a part of the growing discourse on Black Church Studies as represented by the publication of *Black Church Studies: An Introduction* coauthored by Stacey Floyd-Thomas, Juan Floyd-Thomas, Carol B. Duncan, Stephen Ray, and N. Lynne Westfield.⁸ These works accept responsibility for advancing “the necessarily evolving skill” that bridges ecclesiology and theology with public justice activism for contemporaries of the Black churches.

The chapters in this volume also critically examine contemporary meanings of “Blackness,” womanism, and Black sexuality, and the circumstances of their construction from a range of cultural, racial, gendered, and ethnic locations. They link the urgent life forces that birthed the spirituality and faith of Black churches on American soil for freedom and justice. What escapes many avowed American Christians today, even those who espouse the prosperity theologies of some black churches, is the necessary understanding of the union between faith and freedom that tempers prophetic radicalism and justice, particularly when injustice stands in the way of human flourishing. The text *Black Church Studies* wisely calls Black people “to think creatively about justice and politics” or, as my Vanderbilt colleague Victor Anderson notes, “creative exchange” to keep life open to the event of Beloved Community. According to Victor Anderson,

traditionally, civil rights get cast in a narrow interpretive prism that focuses on preventing injuries and injustices from recurring supremacist practices of racism. But America’s continuing dilemma of rectifying racial injustices calls for restorative justice and much more . . . the construction, innovative deployment of concepts such as race, God, world to do the work of interpretation, criticism, and directing possibilities toward openness, particularly for justice in social world of poverty as well as in the social spheres of difference.⁹

Anderson’s call for “a justice process of reclaiming moral wholeness to rectify past injustices and bring a quality of life and human flourishing to the existence of black and brown children, women and men” is at the forefront of Black Church Studies.

Also these chapters address the need for active alliances between civic entities, the academy, and the church, and Black and womanist theologians to be in dialogue with Black church leadership and agencies of hope in the Black community. As I have repeatedly stated in other articles and essays, I can think of nothing more urgent than the task of building up the civic capacity and the unity necessary for creating alternative realities that reconnect Black churches to their faith heritage of liberation for the oppressed. If Black churches are to be viable instruments of liberation, the way forward is to encourage honest self-critique of Black churches as well as the theologies that undergird them.

As a study text for theological and ethical reflection, *Black Church Studies* can be used as a vital resource and interpretive tool for unpacking new social-cultural-political forms and resurgent powers of racism, sexism, heterosexism, and classism in the Black community. The hope for this anthology of *Black Church Studies* is that it becomes a theological resource that helps nurture communal commitment to shape public policy advocacy and social action of Black churches.

I conclude with a personal testimony. I am a child of the Black church and a product of Black Christian faith through the agency of my parents' faith, piety, and public witness. They love the Black church. The last prayer I heard my father pray before his death in 2010 was for the faith of the next generation. After a long life of practicing a liberating faith, raising a family of nine children, confronting racism, facing oppressive confrontations, and resisting social humiliation, my father closed his eyes to immortality with the dream of Jesus and the Black church still vibrantly alive in his soul. His faith lives on in the future of Black Christianity. With my mother and siblings who remain, I live with this faith daily to testify that the God of Black faith is a liberating and saving reality for the life of future generations. I seek to do what this anthology hopes to accomplish—the reclaiming of liberation and prophetic justice to make real what people need physically, socially, spiritually, and aesthetically for wholeness of life. The tragic murders of Black people in American cities, the disappearances of millions of Black males due to mass incarceration, early homicide, and military-type community policing make urgent the need for Black churches to become inclusive liberating centers for all that love and justice requires—transformation and liberation in the world.

Prologue

Alton B. Pollard III

A central characteristic of African faith traditions everywhere is “telling the story.” The several stories that begin this prologue come from my own experiences as the former director of a Black Church Studies program.¹⁰ Collectively, the following narratives represent the past and present, young and old, male and female, gay and straight, Africa and diaspora, Christianity and culture, valences of empire, and surpassing dreams and visions. These narratives are representative of significant levels of relationship in, and through, Black communities including ancestors and elders, daughters and sons, sisters and brothers, and kith and kin worldwide. Moreover, they link intricate and often ignored dimensions of the African experience, spanning gender, generation, genealogy, and geography in a “darkly radiant” way, to borrow an expression from Vincent Harding. While not always acknowledged and celebrated, indigenous to the sacred and social worlds of Africa’s progeny are ancestral recognitions, communal life, and a wide range of beliefs, experiences, and practices associated with the Black religious faithful. For untold millions of believers from the Americas to the Caribbean to Europe to Asia to Africa, focal and fontal to this experience is the witness of the Black church.

Ancestors and Elders

In what has become an annual rite, hundreds of the Black faithful gather the third week of every September for a “celebration of the ancestors and those who came through” at Emmanuel Baptist Church in Winston-Salem, North Carolina. For seven days and seven nights, members of the congregation and the broader community call to lived remembrance the transfigurative events of *Maafa*: the forced and forlorn exodus of entire generations of Africans to the so-called “New World”; the horrific trade in human cargo that would engulf a continent and ultimately reconfigure the world; and the enslavement, colonization, dispersal, violation, and dehumanization of untold millions of Black children, women, and men, the consequences of which reverberate to the present day. *Maafa* is a Kiswahili term meaning “great disaster” or “terrible occurrence.” For growing numbers of diasporic Africans the term has also, and even more, become a rallying cry, a clarion call, a sacred summons, to tell their own story of survival won and humanity sustained over long centuries and against all odds.¹¹

At the center of the weeklong commemoration of *Maafa* at Emmanuel Baptist Church is the celebration and visitation of the ancestral presence made manifest in the form of an “ole time prayer meeting.” Nearly a dozen spiritual choirs and their adherents have come together from near and far to lift their hearts and voices in prayer, praise, fellowship, testimony, and song. The groups in attendance are of various sizes and means and come from across North and South Carolina. Some have donned their Sunday best—suits and dresses—while others wear traditional field clothes or African attire. The choirs are proud representatives of churches with names like Christian Home, First Mt. Zion, and Morningstar. These names, in themselves,

are indicative of early Black Church history rooted in the intersection of the histories of escape from slavery, the Underground Railroad, and Black community development north and south of the Canada/US border.¹² The calendar may say that it is Saturday but, spiritually speaking, Sunday has come.

It is early evening. The time has come. Like the brush arbors and praise houses of old, the congregation assembles in joyous expectation for the Holy Spirit to descend. Slowly but surely, strands of congenial conversation drifting across the sanctuary give way to contemplative moans and groans. Silent sounds are heard to emanate from deep places and, mostly, they emerge from the communion of saints gathered in front pews. The sounds are not owing to what the unsuspecting and uninitiated have mistaken for emotional distress so much but bliss.

Barely audible at first, an elderly woman rises to sing and usher the spirit in. As she intones the first line, the choir comes to its feet. The cadence is slow and unhurried as the music gets under way. As the tempo and volume build, emotions find release, tongues are set loose, and tears begin to flow. Slowly but surely, the entire congregation is enveloped in the spirit of revival, heart-rending humming, singing, rocking, and swaying. Black bodies sway in singular motion, feet stomp, hands clap, and heads bob to African vocalities in words and melodies and rhythmic influences that require no other instrumentation to powerfully interrogate, complicate, and critique often staid and conventional Christian norms. Through seemingly spontaneous melodic variation the antiphon of call and response reverberates throughout the sanctuary and pays its soaring and lasting tribute.

Out of the rough-hewn lives of a few dozen elderly Black women and men and not a few younger people, too, the spirituals homiletically and holistically bear witness to past struggles while simultaneously issuing a response to current realities. These are spirituals whose form and pedigree, intensity and attitude, rival the work songs and “field hollers” of old. Their meaning, value, and function predate that of the more formalized anthem music and spirituals made famous by groups like the Fisk Jubilee Singers and similar groups at Tuskegee, Hampton, and Morehouse and, later, the Wings Over Jordan Choir.

In substance as well as in intent, the annual commemoration of Maafa is ritual healing for a people whose faith journey requires they “go back in order to go through.” Embodied in the Adinkra, powerful symbols of philosophical meaning expressed in the Akan language of Ghana, Sankofa, “to go back and get it,” is visualized in the symbol of a large bird reaching over its shoulder with an egg in its beak. Sankofa symbolized the idea that the terrain of possibilities is linked inextricably to the past. Mediated through the power of the ancestral, theirs is the full and embodied recognition that “time is filled with swift transition.” For Emmanuel Baptist Church and for other communions of the faithful—St. Paul Community Church in Brooklyn, New York; Allen Chapel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Washington, DC; Allen Temple Baptist Church in Oakland, California; and Kingshill Lutheran Church, St. Croix, US Virgin Islands, to name but a few—the remembrance of Maafa represents that ineffable and inspired turn toward the luminous darkness, *Sankofa, in illo tempore*, in the beginning, the first times.¹³

Daughters and Sons

In Atlanta, Georgia, similar numbers of young people turn out for an extraordinary experience of their own, called “the Black out college tour.” Headlined by a group of local artists called “Destinations,” they are billed as the “hottest hip hop and spoken word show in Atlanta.” For a nominal fee, one Friday night a month, college students from across the metro area come out to experience the flow, lyrics, and reality of Destinations.

This month’s performance is taking place on a local college campus. The crowd is visibly multiethnic but predominantly African American. As people mingle and then gradually take their seats the mood is set for the evening. The auditorium is dark and even the tables are

draped in Black, except for the small fluorescent centerpieces. Heavy bass beats, synthesized brass sounds, and faith-infused rap lyrics blare from loudspeakers near the front stage. From a dimly lit platform in the back, at a tech booth with turntable banks, young women and men operate audio and lighting equipment and the disc jockey spins favorite tracks. The auditorium has been transformed into a combination club/concert hall/sanctuary. In this mundane space marked by the symbols of hip hop metanoia or change—hot beats, tight lyrics, and nightclub lighting—permutations of the sacred emerge to fire the imagination and to quite possibly empower a new generation of young people to become part of the very change they seek.

The stage lights up. Multiple microphones are primed. The audience is ready. The emcee appears. For the next two hours the crowd listens avidly to the musical stylings of Mic, Aija, Godswill, Celita, JustOne, and more. All the artists are under the age of twenty-five. They are charismatic young women and men, many of whom are dressed in the casual attire of their generation—hats cocked to the side, oversized clothing, and crisp sneakers. A few wear T-shirts that to some hip hop heads and conventional Christians communicate a contradictory if not incongruous message: “Bang Bang, Jesus Gang, We Some real Disciples.”

One by one, the artists rock the mike with rhyming and rhythm, with energy and respect, with love for themselves and their own generation. Through spoken word, song, rap, humor, and occasional dance, these young adults present a conscious message that chronicles their turbulent life with God. Some offer lyrics that are fast-paced and hard-edged, while others are more searching and slow. Verses flow, exploring the depths of human frailty and divine sovereignty, interpersonal struggles and redemptive relationships. The men speak candidly about God, sex, and race; the women speak knowingly about violence, violation, and love. From the first set to the last, heads bob, fingers snap, and bodies sway to the spirit of hip hop praise. As E. Patrick Johnson has so cogently argued in his article “Feeling the Spirit in the Dark: Expanding Notions of the Sacred in the African-American Gay Community,” there are places and spaces in which the spirit is engaged and engaging that move beyond the walls of the church.¹⁴ Like Alabama-born and Chicago-raised singer and guitarist Sister Rosetta Tharpe playing gospel songs in church and in nightclub settings in the 1940s, in major urban centers in the United States, the blend of secular and sacred, popular performance and sacred rite continues to emerge in a variety of contexts in Black worship and performance spaces and musical genres. For Tharpe’s generation beginning in the 1930s, it was a heady mix of gospel, blues, and early guitar stylings that influenced rock n’ roll performers throughout the mid-twentieth century and arguably beyond. Today, these same issues emerge in the encounters between contemporary genres including hip hop, R & B and gospel music.

Destinations is the college age ministry of Destiny Metropolitan Worship Church, one of the fastest growing congregations in Atlanta, Georgia, and rapidly approaching megachurch status.¹⁵ Destiny represents a small but influential trend of Black and multiracial churches—Greater Hood Memorial African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church in Harlem, New York; Holy Trinity Lutheran Church in Inglewood, California; The House Covenant Church in Chicago, Illinois; The Sanctuary Covenant Church in Minneapolis, Minnesota, and hundreds of other church contexts ranging from storefront to megachurch in membership—who are seeking to do twenty-first-century ministry in first-century fashion.

Their theologies and politics vary widely, but emblematic of Paul’s model of engagement with the culture and city of Athens in the Book of Acts (17:17ff), these churches and ministries are as one in their commitment to speaking the language of faith in the vernacular of the streets. For ministries like Destiny, they are confronting the staid conventions of the church, on the one hand, and the challenges presented by a new generation via hip hop culture, on the other. In important respects, they are reaching out to the youth, especially young Black and brown women and men, who are so often confined to the margins of society and oblivious to the church.

For those who are careful to listen hip hop—the poetry, creativity, and visual expression of African American and other socially marginalized youth—is the locus for much that is authentic and liberating (and, not to be dismissed, what is violent and misogynistic as well) in contemporary theology. From Kanye West’s Grammy-winning single “Jesus Walks” to Kirk Franklin, Cross Movement, Thema Bryant, Mary, Mary, Tragedy, Da’ T.R.U.T.H., and Sean Simmonds, the word is out. Socially conscious rap, spoken word activism, a contemporary aesthetic expressed in adornment, hairstyles, musical choices, and high-tech outreach are welcome and worthy contextualizations of worship for our day and time. On college campuses, in coffee houses, back on the block, in the blogosphere, on streaming webcasts, and here and there from church pulpits, forceful lyrics and focused praise are “bringing down the house.”

Hip hop is the “hook” or signal attraction for many young people who have never been to a worship service before or are seriously reflecting on matters of faith for the first time. For the burgeoning hip hop church movement or “holy hip hop” (hip hop also has its Muslim, New Age, and nonreligious adherents), at the center of the message, always there is Jesus. At the same time, the dynamic interplay between religion and culture points to another truth. The same divine presence that was at work with the ancestors and elders is no less evident with Africa’s daughters and sons today.¹⁶

Sisters and Brothers

In observance of the national Martin Luther King, Jr., holiday, another Atlanta-based group called Lifting Our Voices for Equality, or the Love Coalition, Inc., sponsors an annual prayer breakfast. In keeping with the “spirit of equality and unconditional love taught and advocated by Martin and Coretta Scott King,” the prayer breakfast strives to embody the timeless teaching, preaching, and practice of two of the most beloved leaders of the Black freedom movement. The purpose of the prayer breakfast is to cultivate a spirit of unity and inclusion within the church, especially African American churches, with respect to same-and-both-gender-loving-and-transgender persons.

There is warmth and joy and expectancy among the one hundred or so people who have gathered for the prayer and breakfast at the main public library. These are the people of the disinherited, women and men who live on the margins of the already marginalized; people who have been in and out of the closet; people who are battling through substance abuse and addiction; people who are infected and affected by HIV/AIDS; people who have experienced homelessness; people who have known incarceration; people who are workers in the sex industry; people who have been rejected by their kith and kin; people who have been deemed irredeemable; people who have lived and loved and lost; and people who have strong morals and convictions—people who truly love the church.

The Love Coalition has teamed up with several community and church partners like LaGender, Inc., Unity Fellowship Church, and the National Black Justice Coalition to sponsor this feast for the body and soul. The membership of this mostly African American coalition is made up almost exclusively of church and unchurched Christians. They are seized by a singular and magnificent obsession, a surpassing belief that beyond all qualifiers of affection the church is one family in God. In the interregnum, through the best of times and bad, they minister to one another and those who advocate and are aligned with them in the radical hope that their own—the Black church community—will one day welcome them home as sisters and brothers at last.

Like the church on the day of Pentecost in the Book of Acts (2:1–21), the assembled worship in anticipation of the Holy Spirit. Sanctified prayer, praise, testimony, dance, and song are prelude to the stirring message delivered by the speaker, a local minister and professor who

is respected for his generous spirit. The sermon is poignant and moving and narrates God's dream for humankind of love, justice, and peace. In the preacher's soaring, astounding, numinous, and breathtaking proclamation of the good news—that God partners with us in the movement for beloved and inclusive community—the absolute worth and dignity of all people everywhere is celebrated and affirmed, without condition and without reservation.¹⁷

Dotting the national landscape, prophetic Black churches are found that welcome and affirm persons who self-identify as lesbian, gay, bisexual, queer, intersexual, or transgender. The Unity Fellowship Church Movement; The Fellowship of Affirming Ministries; Metropolitan Interdenominational Church in Nashville, Tennessee; City of Refuge United Church of Christ in San Francisco, California; Victory for the World Church in Stone Mountain, Georgia; Church of the Open Door in Baltimore, Maryland; Trinity United Church of Christ in Chicago, Illinois; and Inner Light Ministries and Covenant Baptist United Church of Christ Church, in Washington, District of Columbia, are among those prominently known. Still, such churches are the remnant, few and far between. In company with the children of neglect and abuse, the severely disabled, and the incarcerated poor, lesbians and gays are among the most wounded and silenced members of the African American community.

For many Black church bodies, homophobia, heterosexual preference and power, is palpable and real. Achieving the intended result, the authority of biblical scripture is invoked to invalidate the morality of same-gender-loving people. The self-image and self-esteem of many Black lesbians, gays, bisexual, and transgender people are dealt a series of crushing blows by churches, families, and friends who steer clear, and stigmatize and reject even when there may be what appears to be partial acceptance based on well-honed stereotypes such as gay male choir directors and church musicians, to say nothing of evolving understandings in society at large. Black gay and transgender people and their families deserve no less than full and unfettered access to domestic tranquility, fulfillment and security, and love and life, which includes among other issues the freedom to marry, to know marriage equality.

On June 26, 2015, the U.S. Supreme Court ruled in favor of marriage equality, making marriage between persons of the same gender legal throughout the country. In 2005, Canada led the way in legalizing same sex marriage in the Americas. That Black lesbians, gays, bisexual, and transgender people continue to be made to feel unwelcome in Black churches, in what should be the most caring and compassionate of communions, is to deny equality in the ecclesial as well as civic body and, ultimately, the sacred worth of us all. There is no greater challenge before Black churches—and certainly no greater reward—than for the faithful to love and receive their own with courage, gladness, and exceeding joy.

The Blood that Unites

In an arresting sense, the Black church movement is also a series of movements around the world, extending beyond the contiguous borders of the United States. Related yet distinct, the Black church faithful are found on the African continent, the Caribbean, South America, Canada, Britain, France, India, and elsewhere. Indeed, transnational linkages of church communities and individual and family histories characterize the experiences of many Black Christians in the African diaspora within the United States and elsewhere in the world in the twenty-first century. This, in itself, is not a recent phenomenon as previous generations from slavery through the Great Migration of the early twentieth century and the decades following the Second World War have been shaped by transnational crossings.

During 2007, a variety of activities marked the two hundredth anniversary of the abolition of the transatlantic slave trade by Britain, the leading exporter of captured Africans in the eighteenth century. Fifty years earlier, Ghana led the way in 1957 as the first African country south of the Sahara to gain independence from colonial rule. In commemoration of her

Golden Jubilee, and the beginning of the abolition of the Atlantic slave trade, Ghana sponsored a series of anniversary observances and celebrations throughout the year, popularly called “Ghana@50.” One of the year’s key initiatives was The Joseph Project/Panafest/Emancipation, Ghana’s invitation to the African diasporan family “to reconnect with the land of their ancestors and their brothers and sisters in the homeland.”¹⁸

The Joseph Project takes its name from the biblical Joseph of Genesis 37–50. Reminiscent of Joseph, generations of African children, women, and men have been held down by the legacy of their chains only to rise above them. Much like Joseph, Africa’s progeny were cast into the hellhole of captivity—enslavement, exploitation, colonization, servitude, violation, terror and trauma, and the utter assailing of their humanity—and yet they triumphed still.

In the postmodern onslaught against Black life, modern “Josephs” and “Josephines” continue to epitomize undaunted excellence and work to elevate their African kith and kin worldwide. Recalling echoes of its Pan-Africanist foundations (a movement championed by Ghana’s first prime minister and president Kwame Nkrumah, along with such visionary leaders as Tanzania’s Julius Nyerere, Guinea’s Sekou Toure, Cape Verde’s Amílcar Cabral, and Zaire’s Patrice Lumumba), the government of Ghana has jubilantly decreed “the twenty-first century the African century.”¹⁹ The nation’s launching of The Joseph Project is a strategic first step on the road to facilitating greater intellectual, cultural, material, and capital exchange among Africa’s disparate and gifted peoples.

On August 1, 2007, an extraordinary healing ceremony took place outside Elmina Castle, once the epicenter and main outpost for human trafficking along the Cape Coast. The inscription on the plaque at Elmina reads thus:

In everlasting memory
Of the anguish of our ancestors
May those who died rest in peace
May those who return find their roots
May humanity never again perpetuate
Such injustice against humanity
We the living vow to uphold this.²⁰

On these sacred grounds were assembled dozens of traditional rulers from states and kingdoms that had engaged in the slave trade across the West and Central Coast of Africa, the traditional rulers of states whose people still have living memory of being hunted by slave raiders, Ghanaians from every sector of contemporary society, and thousands of Africans descended from the diaspora.

Operating at the intersection of African traditional religion, Africanized Christianity, and, to a lesser extent, Islam, the chieftains publicly sought expiation for the crimes of their predecessors, offering petitions for forgiveness and leading ritual cleansings for members of the African family who finally and at last had returned “home.”²¹ “The spirit of our ancestors are not developed because of the disconnect between people in the Diaspora,” said one official. “It doesn’t matter where you are. Whether you’ve made your home in the U.K. or the U.S., you still have the blood of Africa in you.”²²

The Joseph Project’s sacred ceremonial healing—to right historic wrongs, to remember the ancestors, and to restore Africa’s children at home and abroad—would extend one hundred and twenty kilometers east and seventy-two hours later to the sacred space of Independence Square in Accra, venue for many national celebrations. Thousands poured into Independence Square for what was billed as “The Healing Concert.” Thronged among the expectant were Christian worshippers and music enthusiasts, elders and youth, homeland and returnees—all Africans.

The concert featured such gospel greats as Grace Ashey (Ghana), the Winneba Youth Choir (Ghana), Princess Ifeoma (Nigeria), Dilys Sillah (Britain), Sherwin Gardner (Trinidad and Tobago), and headliner Donnie McClurkin (USA). Pastoral prayers offered in English, Ga, and Twi and drum appellations from the National Dance Company ushered in an historic night of traditional, choral, kpalogo, reggae, dance hall, soca, and praise-inflected gospel music. Six hours later, the people were still on their feet singing, dancing, and waving handkerchiefs, which for many West African Christians symbolizes victory in Jesus. The Healing Concert was one more way for Ghana to signify to the wider African family her commitment to mythic renewal, reconciliation, and rapprochement, with Ghana as the gateway to the homeland.

Notes

1. James Cone, *Martin and Malcolm and America: A Dream or a Nightmare* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1992).
2. Delores Williams, *Sisters in the Wilderness: The Challenges of Womanist God-Talk* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1993).
3. Emily Townes, *A Troubling in My Soul: Feminist Perspectives on Suffering and Evil* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1993).
4. James Baldwin, *No Name in the Street* (New York: Dial Press, 1972), 196.
5. C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence H. Mamiya, *The Black Church in the African-American Experience* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1990).
6. Gayraud S. Wilmore, *Black Religion and Black Radicalism: An Interpretation of the Religious History of African Americans* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1998).
7. Raphael G. Warnock, *The Divided Mind of the Black Church: Theology, Piety & Public Witness* (New York: New York University Press, 2014).
8. Stacey Floyd-Thomas, Juan Floyd-Thomas, Carol B. Duncan, Stephen Ray, and Nancy Lynne Westfield, *Black Church Studies: An Introduction* (Nashville: Abingdon, 2007).
9. Victor Anderson, *Creative Exchange: A Constructive Theology of African American Religious Experience* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2008), 3.
10. Candler School of Theology at Emory University from 1998 to 2007.
11. See Marimba Ani, *Let the Circle Be Unbroken: The Implications of African Spirituality for the Diaspora* (Lawrenceville, NJ: Red Sea Press, 1994).
12. See Denise Gillard's article, "The Black Church in Canada," *The McMaster Journal of Theology and Ministry*, Vol. 1 (1998), <http://www.mcmaster.ca/mjtm/volume1.htm>
13. The Maafa commemoration was conceived and originated by Rev. Johnny Youngblood and the members of St. Paul Community Baptist Church in Brooklyn in 1994. The remembrance, including the dramatic Maafa suite, has since spread to hundreds of churches and communities.
14. See E. Patrick Johnson, "Feeling the Spirit in the Dark: Expanding Notions of the Sacred in the African-American Gay Community," *Calaloo*, Vol. 21, no. 2, (Spring 1998), 399–416.
15. On the ministry of Destinations, see <http://www.myspace.com/destinations> (accessed September 19, 2007). Black megachurch refers to a predominantly Black congregation that averages at least 2000 people in attendance weekly at Sunday services. See also the chapter by Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs in this volume.
16. Representative writings on the hip hop church phenomenon include Efrem Smith and Phil Jackson, *The Hip-Hop Church: Connecting with the Movement Shaping Our Culture* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2005); Cheryl Kirk-Duggan and Marlon F. Hall, *Wake Up: Hip-Hop, Christianity, and the Black Church* (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 2011); Emmett G. Price, ed., *The Black Church and Hip Hop Culture: Toward Bridging the Generational Divide* (Lanham, MD: The Scarecrow Press, 2012); and The CERCL Writing Collective, *Breaking Bread, Breaking Beats: Churches and Hip-Hop—A Basic Guide to Key Issues* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress press, 2014).

17. See Desmond Tutu, *God Has a Dream: A Vision of Hope for Our Time* (New York: Doubleday, 2004), and Yvette A. Flunder, *Where the Edge Gathers: Building a Community of Radical Inclusion* (Cleveland: The Pilgrim Press, 2005).
18. *Never Again: Published in Honour of The Joseph Project/Panafest/Emancipation*, Ghana Ministry of Tourism and Diasporan Relations, 2007, 17.
19. *Ibid.*
20. Inscription on the dungeon walls at Elmina and Cape Coast Castles in Ghana. The plaque is in commemoration of the apology offered to the world and especially the African Diaspora by the president of the Ghana National House of chiefs in 1994. The atonement event was initiated by the Afrikaania Mission of Ghana. See also Emmanuel Larrey, "Black Memory: Commemorating the Sacred and the Traumatic in the African Diaspora," in Kay A. Read and Isabel L. Wollaston, eds., *Suffer the Little Children: Urban Violence and Sacred Space* (Birmingham, England: University of Birmingham Press, 2001), 157–168.
21. The Muslim community, while prominent, for instance, in the Zongo section of Accra, has a less pronounced presence in Ghana than in many African countries.
22. Danielle Woods, "A Campaign in Ghana Invites African Americans to Come Back Home," <http://www.essence.com/essence/lifestyle/voices/0,16109,1660756,00.html> (accessed September 14, 2007).

The Black Church Studies Reader: An Introduction

Alton B. Pollard III and Carol B. Duncan

In the twenty-first century, Black Church Studies, both as an academic discipline and programmatic thrust and as a congregational and communal commitment, is at an important crossroads. Numerous media headlines underscored in the nation's most recent presidential campaign and the two-time election of President Barack Obama that the "Black Church" is the fault line between many progressives and conservatives, women and men, the young and the old, the haves and the have-nots, wherever communities of African descent are to be found. A cursory survey of Black church scholarship in the United States discloses substantive resources in African American church history and Black and womanist theology for African American faith communities, for which we can be grateful. However, such an "endarkened" epistemological stance is far from pervasive among theological scholars and schools, and stands alongside our considerable naiveté about Africanized Christianity beyond (and African and Caribbean immigrant churches within) the borders of the United States.¹

Scholars who study Black religion today are necessarily interdisciplinary and, perhaps, multidisciplinary and interrogate theological accounts as but one component, crucial yet distinct, of the Black religious experience. A vast array of religious traditions, beliefs, and practices from Christianity and Islam to African indigenous and derived forms are ripe candidates for investigation, informed by insights from the humanities and the physical and social sciences, often in critical conjunction with discourses of gender, race, class, ethnicity, sexuality, ability, and other socially contested values. African studies, diasporan studies, cultural studies, women's, gender and sexuality studies, phenomenology, public policy, and literary analysis provide further conceptual tools for helping to understand how African descended cultures continue to generate new templates of collective wisdom and incarnate truth in twenty-first-century contexts. While this volume deals with the study of Black churches, as editors we acknowledge that the area of Black religious studies encompasses more than Christianity and we support explorations of these myriad religious traditions using approaches that do not privilege Christianity as the normative center of religious experience for all people of African descent. Black Church Studies is part and parcel of Black Religious Studies, broadly. The study of religious expressions of Africans and their descendants must necessarily take into consideration multiple religious traditions that, in many instances, have been in dialogue with each other. The scope of this volume, however, does not expressly address the study of religious expressions other than Christianity.

While perhaps not the easiest proposition for some "believing scholars" Black Church Studies must acknowledge, address, and dare to advocate for those elements of the Black church legacy that are so commonly held to be nontheological, ranging from the sociopolitical to the

literary-cultural.² W. E. B. Dubois was the first scholar to observe that a vital understanding of cultural antecedents and social currents was imperative to making sense of Black churches in the United States and the Caribbean, which churches were never exclusively Christian in any case, calling them “the sole surviving social institution of the African fatherland.”³ People of African descent the world over have encountered the West for centuries, forging new identities—born of oppositional and self-authenticating impulses—routinely refracted through the lens of worship, and always reflected in everyday life. Paul Gilroy’s thesis of “the Black Atlantic” espoused in his 1993 book of the same name explicitly outlined an argument that the experience of Black people and the development of modernity in the West were intricately and intimately connected. To the point, due diligence must be applied to matters of inheritance in relation to religious faith, whether the touchstone is social, political, economic, or cultural.

Black theological assessments of church beliefs, practices, values, events, movements, and institutions will not only benefit from careful “meta” analysis but also from “thick” internal discussion, description, disruption, and application. In all their commonalities and complexities, symbiotic splendor and sobering contradictions, the churches of African descended peoples and the constituencies they serve deserve more nuanced and emancipating analysis than even our most accomplished scholarship has been able to provide to date. In short, the great and unrelenting challenge before Black Church Studies scholars and practitioners is this: *To at once affirm and address the limitations of the discipline’s connection with canonical Christianity, and to do so always in ways that celebrate and authenticate Black life.* The *Black Church Studies Reader* (The BCS Reader) begins to embrace that challenge, opting for greater depth and breadth in Black Church Studies theory, practice, and relevance.

Not at all surprising, then, many of the chapters found in this volume problematize, reprioritize, and recast normative theological assumptions from the Bible, theology, ethics, and pastoral care to congregational studies, homiletics, religious education, and worship. They also interrogate the canonical authority of affiliated disciplines such as history, sociology, cultural anthropology, education, economics, literature, popular culture, and public health. Conjoined to specific sociopolitical, historical, and regional contexts, they further privilege and illumine a coalescence of commonly contested thematics such as sexuality, gender, generations, family, immigration, race, social class, aesthetics, cyberspace, HIV/AIDS, globalization, and incarceration. Last but not least, they are careful to move Black Church Studies beyond theoretical and methodological considerations alone (while not presuming to leave either behind) to provide pragmatic and prophetic insights for ministries and communities “on the ground,” at the local level and in living communities.

Still, it is well to remind ourselves that research and reflection in Black Church Studies, however rigorous, is the more straightforward task; providing contextual preparation for leadership in churches as well as on rural, urban, suburban, and exurban streets—in the homes, businesses, classrooms, community centers, day cares, elder cares, jails, prisons, domestic violence shelters, homeless shelters, addiction rehabilitation clinics, halfway houses, crack houses, AIDS clinics, food banks, health clinics, cooperatives, and other nongovernmental organizations of the African world—is the far more difficult task. A primary task for Black churches is to discover anew how to reach the barren places in the souls of Black folk and others of the disinherited. As legal emancipation dawned in the mid-nineteenth-century United States, the first important decision of Black churches was to try to institutionalize the quality of Black religious leadership by building seminaries, colleges, and common schools. A prominent preacher once put it this way: “Our ancestors could not spell college or pronounce university but they had the vision to build schools and establish curricula anyhow.” It is with precisely this same liberating and reciprocating spirit that Black Church Studies must now bear witness. For our people’s sake, for all people’s sake, and for God’s sake, Black Church Studies must prepare a twenty-first-century leadership of hope.

The relentless loss of young Black lives during interactions with police in the United States has pointed national and international attention to the need to address the structural, social, economic, and political issues that undergird these crises. Far from being a US-only occurrence, there have been cases in Canada, the United Kingdom, and elsewhere that bear a striking resemblance. Recent protests by Ethiopian Jews, against police brutality in Israel, offer another glimpse into racial injustice in international terms. The slogan “#Black Lives Matter,” which emerged from social media discourse about the shooting of teenagers Trayvon Martin in Sanford, Florida and Michael Brown in Ferguson, Missouri, has become a rallying cry for a new generation of social activists. The Charleston, South Carolina church shooting that occurred as this book was going to press in which nine African-Americans, all members of the historic Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church, were fatally shot on June 17, 2015 is a tragedy which underscores the need for national conversation and action against systemic racism.

Let it here be acknowledged that not all the chapters in this volume are in simple heuristic compliance or agreement. The work of scholars in Black Church Studies runs the gauntlet from those whose primary dedication is preservation of the African American Christian tradition to those who advocate for radical ecclesial change or espouse alternative visions of the same, and virtually every stance in between. For some scholars, pastors, and laypersons, Black Church Studies means taking up the struggle to model change in conservative and traditional theological communions. For others, it means researching, writing, and blogging, as well as teaching, preaching, and organizing to transgress for more intensely liberative purposes.

The conflicts between theology and religious studies, the church and the academy are real and complicated and, at times, explosive; they are not at all to be ignored or dismissed, and are sometimes on display even in these very pages. The relationship between Black theological scholarship and Black Religious Studies may be characterized—as is the case with Black theology and Black churches—as a tentative and fragile dance.⁴ Both partners still have need of each other. On the other hand, the chemistry between Black Religious Studies and Black churches is largely nonexistent. Both parties seem to have conveniently forgotten the fact that Black churches are no more a monolith than Black religion; neither then should their understandings of Black Christian beliefs, values, practices, and institutions be characterized by erroneous oversimplification. What all this means in terms of this anthology is that no attempt has been made for authors to be in visionary lockstep. Rather, the range of scholarly offerings well illustrates the development of Black Church Studies and profiles some of the best new analyses and applications in the field.

The BCS Reader articulates yet another inconvenient truth: that the matter of singular faith, multiple faiths, or no faith at all belies the experiences of Africans and their descendants in the United States, throughout the diaspora and on the African continent. Like a protean mass, the witness of the Christian tradition—for good, bad, or otherwise—is intertwined with the existence of African peoples virtually everywhere. This recognition has little if anything to do with the adequacy or authenticity of the Christian faith. Nor is it to privilege Christianity above all others. Rather, it is to give due recognition to the fact that tens of millions of Africans the world over have found meaning, value, and power—personhood, community, and freedom—in its varying impulses. At the same time, countless others have experienced it as Christendom, an imperial, hegemonic, and oppressive force to be met with resistance by any means necessary. There are important lessons yet to be gained from searing and searching inquiry into the extraordinary complexity, variety, and ambiguity; the height and depth and breadth that collectively is the Black church. The authors of this book take a giant step forward in that direction.

It here bears repeating: African American Christian experience, in all its variegated genius and weakness, lies at the heart of this text. Attention to the shifting dynamics and dimensions of the faith among the children of Africa in America is urgently required and extensively addressed in these pages, but not at the expense of broader diasporan and continental themes

and implications. Areas of coverage certainly remain, with no pretense of comprehensiveness offered here, but *The BCS Reader* attends to a variety of African and diasporan circumstances in ways that we believe will lay the groundwork for future investigations. In an increasingly globalized world, such attention is imperative.

In quite analogous ways, the anthology seeks to broker another long-standing conceptual impasse, making vital connections not only between the academy and the church, Africa and the diaspora but also between analysis and activism, and theory and practice. Most importantly, it confidently announces its intent to establish and extend the data and analyses for its own work—discrete religious traditions, denominational structures, embodied cultural discourse, ritual, belief, and practices, and more—beyond the reified articulations of academe and the church to address such issues as disparities in health care, the megachurch phenomenon, homophobia and heterosexism, internalized oppression, African indigenization, global connections, community development, the prosperity gospel, and ethical leadership in the public square and congregational contexts. Methodologically, the chapters are analytic, sermonic, narrative, and poetic in their approach. Authored by an interdisciplinary blend of new and leading theological and religious studies scholars, Black Church Studies directors, and local pastors, *The BCS Reader* is at once an encompassing array of leading scholarship in the field and a pragmatic template for the Black faith community.

The editors are children of the Civil Rights and Black Power era. We grew up either directly with, or hearing about, the movement that challenged the consciousness of the United States, and that defined much of the public policy and civic discourse in this nation for nearly a quarter of a century. Canada, too, had its Civil Rights Movement from the 1950s through the 1970s although not as publicly acknowledged as the United States, which is perhaps reflective of the de facto segregation of Canadian life and institutions. Canadians of African descent were indelibly affected by what happened south of the border in the United States. Many of us had family ties that extended into the United States and there were Black Americans who moved to Canada during the Civil Rights era who became a part of African Canadian communities. Alton B. Pollard III also grew up in the landmark sacred institution of the African American community often referred to as the Black church. He is an ordained minister and a former pastor, having served African Methodist Episcopal, Baptist, and Presbyterian congregations over the years. He is also a scholar of religion, an avid student of the protean and idiomatic worlds of religion and culture, especially where the interchange of Africa's richly diverse peoples are concerned. In the Caribbean and Canada, Carol B. Duncan grew up as a member of the Anglican Church, which worldwide has a significant membership of Black Christians from Africa and the Caribbean, initially a legacy of British colonialism and slavery but also a testament of the significance of Christianity interpreted from the perspectives of African and Caribbean peoples. Today, there are more Anglicans of African descent worldwide than there are white Anglicans. Research interests in Caribbean religious community development in transnational contexts such as the Spiritual Baptists in Toronto and in Black Church development in Canada, historically, have been hallmarks of her scholarship and teaching.

Through research and by conviction, we drink from the well of religious and biblical traditions that has been constituent to the Black faithful of so many descriptions the world over, from the National Baptist Convention, Pentecostal Assemblies of the World, and African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church to the Spiritual Baptists, Hebrew Israelites, Kimbanguist Church, and more. Through assessment and by disposition, we privilege modes of inquiry that take seriously the ultimate, proximate, and intimate habits of mind and heart. For us, these are not at all exclusive or contradictory understandings but exquisite and complementary comprehensions. Having come this far by faith, we are fully committed to critical dialogue and radical engagement with Black churches, which are poised on the edge of a future, full of the provincial, perhaps, but also pregnant with possibility for insurgent renewal and change.

Religious and biblical traditions that engender faith are arguably the most important of cultural precipitates among African descended peoples, and therefore of consummate importance to any researcher who professes to engage in the life of the mind and the life of the spirit with equal seriousness. We take as our point of departure the following generic definition of Black religion: *the imperatives of the sacred in the midst of the demands of Black life are what properly constitutes the parameters of African descended religious organization and engender specific strategies and insights.* We will use this working definition of Black religion—and by critical distillation Black churches—as our point of entry into the meaning and value of Black Church Studies.

The following preliminary questions guide our introduction to this anthology: What constitutes Black Church Studies as a discipline or a field of study? How did there come to be a need for Black Church Studies? What is the role of Black Church Studies in theological education? What is the relationship between Black Church Studies and the broader academic study of Black religions? What is the relationship between Black Church Studies and local congregations? What is the relationship between Black Church Studies and other faith-based entities and traditions? What is the role of Black Church Studies in the public sphere? What is the meaning and value of Black Church Studies for Africa and the broader diaspora? What is the future of Black Church Studies?

Defining “Black,” “Church,” “Studies”

There are important insights to be gained from a careful consideration of the meaning of the constituent words of “Black Church Studies.”

Black

In the wake of the postcolonial euphoria, Bernard Dadie, the celebrated Ivoirian poet, playwright, novelist, and government administrator penned the following refrain: “I give you thanks my God for having created me Black.”⁵

Dadie’s psalm of thanksgiving soars beyond the politics of phenotype and ontology to inform us at levels far deeper than appearance and beyond all understanding. In the name of pluralism, civility, political correctness, and choice, many people have chosen to deny the deeper implications of Blackness. In the face of pernicious and widespread repression, the children of Africa have but one choice: to assert themselves into the world as a dynamic force for change. Ascendant faith, self-consciousness, social analysis, and aesthetic vision; cultural distinctives, critical catalysts, and global partners—these are some of the entailments of Blackness in our day and time.⁶

The meaning of “Blackness” in human terms not only is far-reaching in scope but extensive in time. It is a saga of mythic beginnings and the myriad of experiences of Africa’s children antedating antiquity and stretching forward to the transatlantic epic, counting the vast millions of women, children, and men who were taken from Africa over a period of some 400 years and their yearning to finally and at last be at home. It is an originating story whose roots also lie in the oft-forgotten and perhaps never to be told discomfiting remembrances of African families, mothers, fathers, siblings, elders, chiefs, and clans, entire communities who grieved for the return of their lost relatives to the Old World.⁷

Despite their colonization at home and enslavement abroad, the descendants of Africa never stopped searching for ways to reunite the severed links. Differences of language and region aside, throughout the Americas and in African lands claimed by Portuguese, Spanish, Dutch, French, Belgian, German, and English occupying forces, the children of Africa everywhere

found powerfully creative ways to transcend the degradation of their estate. Out of the great diversity of oppressed Black humanity was forged a common bond, a unified set of experiences, the constituent universals that would lead to a proverbial recognition on the continent and throughout the diaspora: “The blood that unites us is thicker than the waters that divide us,” and a positive if rather enigmatic understanding of Black being—mind, body, and soul—on both sides of the Atlantic. We are Africans.

Church

As we have just seen, Blackness as an identity marker is constantly being negotiated anew in ways religious, cultural, and social. The term “church” also has differentiated meanings for religious bodies that are self-constituted as opposed to administrative, geographical, and temporal designations. Corresponding examples include the local religious assembly, the congregational form of polity, the Western church, and the early church.

“The Black church” is analytical shorthand for the vast network of racial-ethnic communities of Christian faith, worship, and life born out of, and informed by, the historic and present-day experiences of people of African descent, whatever the tradition and wherever they are found. Accordingly, Black churches have incorporated a host of self-understandings into their language and images, singing and preaching, pastoral care and counseling, worship and leadership patterns, social advocacy and service, assumptions about meaning, power, and morality, and especially in their definitions of membership and inclusion. “African Initiated Churches”⁸ (also known as AICs) is a roughly analogous term, whose recognition has not yet caught on in the African American context.⁹

Among its many functions, the Black church is a sacred and social movement, representing communities of commitment and, sometimes, arenas of change. In oppressions affecting Black children, women, and men, Black churches have access to liberative and holistic resources and reconciling potentiality, to restoring the ancient ancestral wisdom and the distilled wisdom found in texts—and contexts—that uphold the wonder and dignity of Black humanity in all its profoundest meanings. When and where the Black church and community upholds and models its own virtues of unconditional love and acceptance for all its kith and kin, and embraces the vast storehouse that is Black spirituality and Black humanity, it bears magnificent witness to the common wealth of God on earth.

Studies

Prior to the 1960s, the academy was largely dismissive of Black churches as the anachronistic and emotional expression of an unsophisticated people. In the United States, the major exceptions were studies conducted by Black scholars, the most significant being W. E. B. DuBois’s *Souls of Black Folk* and his Atlanta-based study *The Negro Church*, both published in 1903, and Benjamin E. Mays and Joseph Nicholson’s *The Negro’s Church*, published 30 years later. Complementing these foundational works were exceptional monographs by historian Carter G. Woodson, religionist Howard Thurman, anthropologists Zora Neale Hurston, Arthur Huff Fauset, and Melville Herskovits, and sociologist E. Franklin Frazier.¹⁰ American higher education and theological education, in particular, appeared to be innocent of the suspicion that anyone would want to study the Black experience, here or abroad, or that any educational value derived from so doing.

By 1965, the Black church movement in the United States could scarcely be ignored by the wider public or the theological community. The leadership of Martin Luther King, Jr., Fannie Lou Hamer, Fred Shuttlesworth, Bernice Johnson Reagon, John Lewis, Ella Baker, James

Lawson, and Diane Nash and countless others in the Black-led movement for freedom made visible a dimension of the Black religious tradition that belied the earlier caricatures and stereotypes of passivity. So, too, did the militancy of Queen Mother Moore, Malcolm X, the Nation of Islam, independent African nations, the Black consciousness movement, and Black liberation theology.

Out of the creativity and ferment of the 1960s, Black Studies programs and departments were born, including a subdiscipline, Black Church Studies. Seldom did the host institution make a serious effort to fund, staff, or regulate these initiatives in a way that would lend institutional prestige or offer any confidence that they were an integral and valued part of the university complex.¹¹ On theological campuses the commitment to Black Church Studies programs—mildly popular in the late 1960s and early 1970s—went into precipitous decline.

Fortunately, there continued to exist a handful of theological schools with more serious intentions and more honest—that is to say less politically deceptive—motivations. These schools established programs that were decidedly more than educational placebos for African American students and not a few well-intended whites. Today, about one dozen formal Black Church Studies programs are in existence, complementing the six historically Black theological schools. After four decades of existence, the notion of Black Church Studies as a rigorous and critical component of mainstream theological education still rarely finds enthusiastic support. Moreover, various social and political forces continue to work to roll back real gains.

The fact that such institutional resistance continues has to do with more than a simple denial of the relevance of Black religious experience, Christian or otherwise, on the part of white (and some brown and Black) theological faculty. This is hardly to deny the existence of racism in theological education. Rather, one should more critically name the rejection for what it is—a defense mechanism, a precautionary measure, a reflex action, a “homeland security” system of sorts, intended to ward off Black interlopers who embody the discomfiting proposition that sacrosanct learnings and preparations may also be turned upside down. For what Black Church Studies confirms, both in analysis and application, is that beyond the normative, canonical, and hegemonic exist vast, nonracist, just, and inclusive sources for the radical transformation of the social order. In the world that is not yet (or else, to recall Martin Luther King, Jr., we will perish together as fools), Black and white, Latino and Latina, African and Aboriginal, Asian and European, young and old, women and men, gay and straight, Buddhist and Hindu, Muslim and Jew, Orthodox, Protestant and Catholic, religious and not will heed their people’s sacred stories.

Is it realistic, then, to suppose that Black Church Studies can still offer significant “believing” scholarship and leadership for the twenty-first century? The answer is a simple and emphatic “yes.” Long before the onset of the modern Civil Rights movement Black graduate theological education, most notably Howard University School of Religion in Washington, DC, and Gammon Theological Seminary in Atlanta (the first fully accredited Black graduate theological institutions) pioneered in the study of Black religious life and the preparation of learned Black clergy for ministry.¹²

In 1969, in the aftermath of the assassination of Martin Luther King, Jr., Henry H. Mitchell was invited to establish The Martin Luther King, Jr. Program of Black Church Studies at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozier Theological Seminaries in Rochester, New York, the pioneering program in predominantly white seminaries.¹³ Complementary to that, the scholarship of C. Eric Lincoln (sociology of religion), George Kelsey (Christian ethics), James H. Cone (liberation theology), Gayraud Wilmore (liberation history, theology and ethics), Henry H. Mitchell (homiletics), J. Deotis Roberts (liberation theology), Leonard Barrett (anthropology of religion), Wyatt Tee Walker (practical theology), and others also figured prominently at the time.

Twenty-five years ago, one of the pioneers of Black liberation theology and Black Church Studies, Gayraud Wilmore, published the landmark *African American Religious Studies*:

An Interdisciplinary Anthology.¹⁴ This edited collection of essays is a valuable exploration of the *manyness* of African American Christianity as viewed through the lens of biblical studies, theology, homiletics, pastoral care, womanist studies, and history of religions, and so on, and also its *oneness* as an alternate worldview expressing authentic Black being. The volume is also remarkable for Wilmore's passionate introduction and preferential option for "believing scholarship" above "armchair theorizing" in service to the church, community, and world. *African American Religious Studies* is a superlative collection containing some of the best treatments of African American Christianity ever assembled until then.

In 2003, Cornel West and Eddie Glaude released *African American Religious Thought: An Anthology*, a vital collection of seminal writings in Black religious scholarship.¹⁵ Respectfully departing from Wilmore's focus on "believing scholarship," the editors succeed in establishing new "meta" trajectories for Black religious thought. They identify five historical periods—(1) enslavement, (2) emancipation, (3) segregation, (4) the Black freedom struggle, and (5) contemporaneity—that serve as the framework for their apt assessment of the current state of African American religious studies. Yet and still, the ecclesial and religious traditions of other African people do not merit inclusion, while emphasis on the "lived religion" of contemporary African American churches lies beyond the pale of the editors' overall conceptual schema.

In 2007, *Black Church Studies: An Introduction*, a coauthored text by Stacey Floyd-Thomas, Juan Floyd-Thomas, Stephen Ray, Nancy Lynne Westfield, and Carol B. Duncan was published. This multidisciplinary work brings together perspectives from the subfields of Christian social ethics, history, theology, congregational studies, and sociology to present a nuanced introductory approach to the study of the Black church. Carol B. Duncan, a coauthor of this work, is a coeditor of the *Reader*.

The Black Church Studies Reader draws on the respective approaches of the above works and, accordingly, reflects the best of both worlds. At the same time, given our principled focus on Black churches, this work is primarily conceived as a successor volume to Wilmore. In a significant departure, this volume is comprised of original contributions. Like its predecessor, the work emerges from a specific series of contexts, done conceptually and in community.

A number of the chapters gathered here are the fruit of work done by the authors at a series of National Black Church Studies Forums held by the Program of Black Church Studies at Candler School of Theology of Emory University, the Kelly Miller Smith Institute on the Black Church at Vanderbilt University, and the ongoing series of consultations held by the Black Religious Scholars Group held prior to the American Academy of Religion/Society of Biblical Literature meeting.¹⁶ These events, among others, have proven beneficial to the flourishing of this work and the field as a whole.

Some of the authors presented papers at the conferences based on suggested themes, while others determined their own. Scholars and pastors who were participants in broader conversations soon joined this project as well. Each chapter of *The BCS Reader* represents its author's unique sense of perspective and research priorities regarding Black Church Studies. All not only agree that Black Church Studies matters but also that it is crucial to the progressive future of theological education and the Black church. In this introduction, we have had the first word on the subject. In the chapters that follow, our colleagues will speak for themselves. You, the reader, will have the last word on whether our undertaking has met with success and to add your own words, too, hopefully in dialogue and discussion, for it is our intent that this collection extend and invite conversations

The Black Church Studies Reader

The Black Church Studies Reader is organized into seven sections. Part I forms the historical foundation, with analysis and reflection on the origins of and rationale for Black Church

Studies. The “Dean of Black Church Studies” Henry H. Mitchell offers prefatory remarks from his own experience in the 1960s and 1970s. Gayraud S. Wilmore advances several key strategies for helping Black Church Studies to serve as friendly advocates and prophetic critics of Black Christianity. Lewis V. Baldwin provides the most definitive historical account of Black Church Studies written to date as well as an array of recommendations for said programs, Black churches, and Black religious thought.

Part II establishes the institutional parameters for the field, examining contemporary Black Church Studies programs in several theological contexts. Stacey M. Floyd-Thomas emphasizes the need for programs to engage in critical praxis with churches by means of affirmation, agency, and advocacy. The case study presented by Arthur L. Pressley and Nancy Lynne Westfield speaks to the profoundly pragmatic possibilities inherent in the work of Black Church Studies programming everywhere. Robert M. Franklin investigates the uniqueness of Black religious leadership and argues that in the Black community, religious leadership is an explicit public vocation, called to respond to salient social imperatives.

Part III attends to disciplinary considerations, conceptualizing Black Church Studies through expansive theological understandings. Teresa Fry Brown discusses the integral role of Black homiletics, critiquing contemporary forms of Black preaching and setting forth challenging pedagogical considerations for twenty-first-century Black Church Studies curricula. James Abbingdon does likewise for music and worship in the Black church experience, offering constructive models and extensive resources for worship planning. Rodney S. Sadler, Jr., chronicles the African American encounter with the biblical text and goes on to outline distinctive elements that merit our particular consideration. All the chapters in this section offer detailed pragmatic resources for assisting Black Church Studies programs in equipping seminary students for transformative ministry.

Part IV models the integration of practical theological concerns with other areas of theological inquiry. Each chapter reveals through preaching and poetics the capacity to retool, re-create, and express change that reflects the demography of our time. The late Ella P. Mitchell, pioneering womanist preacher-theologian, offers a soaring sermonic prologue emphasizing the inclusivity of God. Yvette Flunder’s message reflects on the radical implications of welcoming same-gender-loving and other marginalized persons to the household of faith. Otis Moss speaks with dynamic cadence and liberating insight to the current and next generation of young people. Pamela Lightsey speaks justice on behalf of women of color and especially the clergy-scholar. Cheryl Kirk-Duggan’s composition is a triumphant praise-song for women of faith everywhere throughout the Black world.

Part V represents explicitly congregational commitments by the Black Church Studies community. Whereas Parts II and III begin with theological education, the following chapters attend in precise ways to praxis or involvements with the church. Pastor-theologian Dennis W. Wiley eschews the “Platonized” instruction so symptomatic of seminary education in favor of practical theology born of the lived experiences of Black life. Harold Dean Trulear underscores the critical need for Black churches to challenge systemic social concerns via public policy. Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs discusses the emergence of megachurches as new forms of Black church community and organization that engage contemporary moral issues including same-sex marriage.

Part VI brings us to indigenized understandings of the Black church beyond African America to the African continent and the broader diaspora. Emmanuel Y. Lartey leads off this section with an incisive exploration of the African religious milieu that takes seriously the relationship with Black Church Studies. Claudette Anderson’s chapter on the Caribbean strongly insists on the notion of “spirit” as key to understanding the beliefs and practices of Black church communities in that region. Carol B. Duncan brings us back to North America, arguing for the adoption of a “transnational perspective” that takes seriously manifestations

of the Black church in Canada and other international diasporic contexts. In the United Kingdom, Doreen McCalla argues for greater engagement by Black churches in educating children in Britain, illuminating the issues and impact of school exclusions, especially on young males of African descent.

Part VII offers crossings of another sort in Black Church Studies, namely the interface between African descended people, our own kith and kin, people of color, and global recognitions. Dwight N. Hopkins contends that the current project of the Black church must be to “internationalize” the best of its traditions, linking the local and global, implementing gender equality, and ensuring the future of young people of color. The next three chapters focus on fissures in the African American context. Dorinda G. Henry examines internalized oppression in the Black community and the isolation of its trans-and-same-and-both-gender-loving members, suggesting a model of socio-praxis for churches that will lead to reconciliation, transformation and more. Selina A. Smith analyzes the role that Black churches have played in addressing health disparities, proposing a curriculum for Black Church Studies that merges academic enterprises with the lived experiences of the Black faithful. Juan M. Floyd-Thomas turns to global recognitions, proposing that Black Church Studies programs pay more rigorous attention to the corresponding concerns of economic justice, political economy, and globalization.

The epilogue is Alton B. Pollard III’s vision of holistic Black experience, written as a parable and guided by a principle he calls “The Endarkenment.”

Conclusion

In the end, *The Black Church Studies Reader* endeavors to speak to the continuous and contiguous character of our enterprise. The Black church as we have defined it is the repository of a people, conceived in the individual struggle and the historical travail created by the past, the challenges of the present, and the possibilities of the not yet. It is atrocity, pain, and suffering seared indelibly on a body collective that somehow also unfathomably and impossibly soars. It is prophetic hope outwardly directed toward public causes and solutions, and inwardly focused on a defining vision of religious and spiritual faithfulness with regard to African life. It invokes natural, supernatural, and sacred agency that aids individual and communal survival and salvation, and seeks to make sense of that which is beyond the scope of current human understanding. Diversely engaged by the community in terms of gender, generation, indigenization, sexuality, socioeconomic level, immigration, religious denomination and community, and so on, Black Church Studies celebrates the rational Black mind and the spirit of the ancestors—decolonizing our understanding of inherited traditions, creating a new word when and where necessary, and affirming the Black faithful every step of the way. Ashé. Amen.

Notes

1. See Pollard’s chapter, “The Endarkenment,” in this volume. Missiology and evangelism offer proximal understandings of the African world often devoid of Black self-definition and agency.
2. Gayraud Wilmore, “General Introduction,” in Gayraud Wilmore, ed., *African American Religious Studies: An Interdisciplinary Anthology* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1989), xii–xiii.
3. W. E. B. DuBois, *The Negro Church: Report of a Social Study Made Under the Direction of Atlanta University; Together with the Proceedings of the Eighth Conference for the Study of the Negro Problems, Held at Atlanta University, May 26th, 1903*. Edited with a new introduction by Alton B. Pollard III (Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2011), 6.

4. The same is true in religious studies as a whole. Illustrative of this fact is the ongoing debate over formal relations between the American Academy of Religion and the Society for Biblical Literature, leading academic guilds more or less identified with religious studies and Bible/theology, respectively.
5. Alan Lomax, ed., *3000 Years of Black Poetry: An Anthology* (New York: Dodd Mead, 1970), 142–43.
6. An insightful collection of essays on the subject is Wahneema Lubiano, ed., *The House that Race Built: Black Americans, U.S. Terrain* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1997).
7. See, for instance, Michael A. Gomez, *Reversing Sail: A History of the African Diaspora* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005).
8. The initials AIC also stand for African Independent or Indigenous Churches depending on the context. All refer to the importance of African initiative in forming independent movements and traditions. While rarely applied to the US context, African American denominationalism falls within the same purview. Adrian Hastings, *The Church in Africa: 1450–1950* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994).
9. Tragically, Western Christian “civilizing” influences and discourses have had a deleterious effect on many Africans from the diaspora and the Continent, causing them to dismiss the significance of African-centered traditions and adaptations and to develop an anti-African bias. Womanist theologian and religionist Dianne M. Stewart brilliantly analyzes and terms the Western disposition toward Continental African recognitions *Afro-phobia*. See her *Three Eyes for the Journey: African Dimensions of the Jamaican Religious Experience* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005).
10. Early researchers of African religious culture include Jomo Kenyatta, Bengt G. M. Sundkler, C. G. Baëta, Harold Turner, and John Mbiti. Leonard Barrett, George Eaton Simpson, and Roger Bastide are early representative scholars of Caribbean and South American Diasporic traditions.
11. An outstanding history and assessment of the current state of Black studies is Noliwe M. Rooks, *White Money/Black Power* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2006).
12. Later renamed Howard University School of Divinity; today Gammon is one of the constituent members of the Interdenominational Theological Center.
13. See Henry Mitchell’s personal reflections in this volume as well as the chapters by Gayraud Wilmore and Lewis V. Baldwin.
14. Wilmore, *African American Religious Studies*.
15. Cornel West and Eddie S. Glaude, Jr., *African American Religious Thought: An Anthology* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2003).
16. The Consultation at the Kelly Miller Smith Institute in 2007 was co-sponsored by the Program of Black Church Studies, Candler School of Theology, Emory University. The Black Religious Scholars Group has similarly benefited over the years from the consistent collegial sponsorship of several theological institutions and Black Church Studies programs.

Part I

Origins

The roots of Black churches lie in the interpretation of Christianity as a liberating religious tradition by enslaved Africans and their descendants. This rich history can be approached from multiple disciplinary perspectives including social sciences and humanities as well as theological studies. The historical periodization of Black churches is typically approached along the following trajectory: the social and political context of black enslavement in the United States, the systematic race-based segregation which became known as “Jim and Jane Crow,” the civil rights movement, and the post-civil rights era of the last four decades. The essays in this first section explore the development of Black Church Studies as a multidisciplinary field of study which emerged with this rich history as a focus while being deeply connected to advocacy and social justice (Baldwin). The contemporary significance and future of this rich area are also considered. As Wilmore, one of the authors in this section, notes,

it is time for us to define Black Church Studies as a partner with the African American churches and communities in prospecting for a creative, liberating lifestyle today that builds upon our racial and religious history and heritage, but looks forward to the future with compassion, hope, and good will for the whole world.

Black Church Studies: Some of the Roots

Henry H. Mitchell

*Editor's Note: The Rev. Drs. Henry H. and Ella P. Mitchell were partners in life, ministry, and education for over 60 years. Henry from Columbus, Ohio, and Ella from Charleston, South Carolina, met in New York City when they were students at Union Theological Seminary. Both graduates of Union Theological Seminary (Henry '44 and Ella '43), the Mitchells went on to stellar careers as scholars and organizers balanced by their steadfast commitment to the church through ministry. Their 1999 book, *Together for Good*, was a dual biography which also commemorated their then 55 years together. In 2008, Ella passed away at 91 years of age. The chapter, below, was originally drafted by Henry prior to her death. As editors, we think it appropriate to keep the present-tense voice in which it was written.*

It is the sincere desire of me and my wife Ella to do all that we possibly can to assist the teaching and learning of Black Church Studies, toward the end that professionally trained clergy may serve Black churches with natural effectiveness rather than frustration and count it all genuine joy. And it is our hope that this, a written record of how we, the Mitchells, escaped cultural captivity, may save readers many years of on-the-job learning of the sort through which we have had to go. We are still writing, lecturing, preaching, and consulting in the field of Black Church Studies. Our itinerary hardly reflects retirement, and these could be called the best years of our lives.

The fledgling academic discipline called "Black Church Studies" stands in often misunderstood relationship to the older discipline of "Black Religious Studies." The Society for the Study of Black Religion (SSBR) was organized in 1970, while the groups related to Black Church Studies have met from time to time since 1992, with the most focused in 2004 and 2006 (with sponsorship by Emory's Candler School of Theology and Vanderbilt's Kelly Miller Smith Institute in the Divinity School). However, there is still no stable, self-sustaining professional group comparable to the SSBR.

From the outset, the SSBR was committed to the study of "religion," as opposed to study of the Black church as an institution. By their very name, Black Church Studies programs were primarily designed to prepare students in seminaries for the practice of ministry in Black congregations and communities. The inadequacy of this preparation in existing seminaries, white and Black, was precisely at the point of culture as a major factor in the effectiveness of all ministries. Prior to this time, all seminaries were unaware that practically all of their existing

curricula subconsciously presupposed a cultural matrix of white, middle-class congregants. The greater tragedy lay in the widespread unawareness of and/or disrespect for a rich African American culture, both sacred and secular, with no separation of the two in its African roots.

The irony of the situation was that, in the minds of many, Black Church Studies turned out to be major in the abstractions of Black Theology and Philosophy. Too many students supposedly trained in this loosely named study of the Black *church* were graduated and sent forth to flounder in the seas of a strange and not very flexible collection of institutional folkways. Gayraud S. Wilmore has well described the problem of preparation for service in Black churches, given, of course, some prominent exceptions: "I weep for the men and women I have taught who are out there struggling but who have little to show for what they presumably learned from me and scholars of my generation."¹

It is my studied conclusion that there are at least four main reasons for this odd and unfortunate state of affairs in the pastoral preparation of Black women and men:

- 1) The leaders of the SSBR have been expected to do what they never ever claimed to do. They were primarily researchers, writers, and teachers in institutions of higher education, including schools of religion. These worthy scholars have related to churches primarily as highly critical prophets, as it were, like Amos, from the hills to the South. They have not claimed to have workable answers for the problems of the majority of Black churches.

When a committee of Black religious consultants was engaged to evaluate the first full-blown program of Black Church Studies, at Colgate Rochester Divinity School (CRDS), only one in five had ever served as pastor of a Black church. Their assessment included the charge that there were no real Black scholars on the faculty.

- 2) The terrible truth may very well lie in the fact that many of our most gifted critics have found refuge in the classrooms of academia, only after their deficit in Black cultural communication skills rendered improbable the call to the pulpit of a Black congregation. This treatment by many of the twentieth-century Black churches does not fully justify many Black scholars' little love for, and less dedication to, the Black church.

A case in point would be my own early resort to a college and then to the administration of missions. However, my re-entry into academia followed two full-time pastorates and a total of 24 years of work among Black congregations. I would still gladly serve a church if I were not 12 years from 100.

- 3) A third issue may arise out of the fact that Black Religious Studies programs have had such a powerful influence and appeal. Many college students with absolutely no experience in a Black church have felt called to serve. However, the realities of that great majority of small, struggling congregations have been so traumatic as to drive them to seek employment in social work and public schools and colleges.
- 4) Related to the issue of youthful inexperience is the fact that there are so few places for doctoral-level instructors to learn the nuts and bolts of Black pastoral service. Few if any of the modern Black aspirants to seminary faculties would have the farm-boy and farm-girl omni-competence still expected in a Black congregation or among those who serve as instructors in Black Church Studies.

My urgent plea is that this need for training be filled with gifted and experienced adjunct faculty (pastors and others), who have led successfully in construction of buildings, resolutions of Black church conflicts, fund-raising, and family-wide activities. No individual full-time professor need be embarrassed by such holes in her or his comfortable cloak of skills and experience, especially when so wide a variety of talent is expected and available.

The question arises irresistibly:

How on earth can we move from the popular, if no longer so prevalent, division between middle class Black churches with professionally trained clergy, and churches of the Black masses which prefer a pastor fluent in Black culture (but inadequately educated in Western culture) rather than an educated pastor to whom they find it much more difficult to relate?

This problem of overcoming cultural alienation raises a fourth issue, for which there is no simple answer. How then did we find and cross over the bridge of Black Church Studies? Having personally lived through such a process, I can offer a sample case based on my own experiences plus share some of the results in curricular offerings.

I was reared in what was then a typical family of strong Black nationalists.² They were called "RACE men and women."³ As a child I was introduced in person to people like William Pickens⁴ and Walter White⁵ of the NAACP,⁶ right there in my home church. However, our fierce ethnic loyalty applied only to social, political, and economic issues, ignoring Black culture. White Western culture was by default assumed to provide the cultural and educational criteria, the mastery of which we were very proud. In my home church, the Second Baptist Church, founded in 1836, we sang none of the emerging "gospel" music, because Thomas Dorsey and his type sang music so close to the music of the "world."⁷ My overwhelming call to love and serve the Black church came in this oddly dichotomized cultural context in 1937.

In 1943, as a student at Union Theological Seminary, I took a course in Religious Symbolism, as taught by Professor Paul Tillich.⁸ One day he assigned a report paper on all the symbols in the churches where we were doing our "Field Work." After class I felt led to inform him: "Prof. Tillich, you should know that I am a Negro, and we don't have any symbolism. The symbolism in the Concord Baptist Church in Brooklyn, where I work, is left over from the original white congregation who built it. We don't pay it much attention." The tongue lashing which followed changed the course of my life. The main idea was, "*Every* race and/or society has its own symbolism, and you had better go find yours and bring me back your report." I faithfully obeyed, and my professor was pleased, but not nearly so much as the person who was awakened in me. The results were far-reaching.

In 1963, I was pastor of what we jovially referred to as "St. John's by the Cotton Patch." It was the Second Baptist Church of Fresno, and when it was built, it was actually across the street from a cotton field. This land was then used for housing, but cotton was still close by. There came to my Board of Deacons a recruit from Minnesota named Lacy K. Curry.⁹ He had been a star shortstop in the Brooklyn Dodger chain, but he had also finished college with certifications as lab technician and office manager, which roles he served in his brother's medical office. This brother was US Curry, MD, chairman of our Board of Deacons. Another Curry brother was M. K. Curry, Jr., Baptist clergyman and president of Bishop College. The father of these brothers was a retired Baptist pastor in Denver, Rev. Milton K. Curry, Sr. After confessing a call to the ministry (to nobody's surprise), Lacy enrolled at Berkley Baptist Divinity School, now American Baptist Seminary of the West. One day he showed me a paper from his theology class. It had abundant red-ink comments from his professor, some of them downright insulting. As I looked it over, it became obvious that this was no traditionally assigned paper; it was a sermon to be listened to. In fact, it was a powerful Black sermon, very accurately interpreting Prof. Tillich to Lacy's new congregation, down to Tulare. This was scholarship at its best, but the professor, born and educated in Scotland, had not a clue to this excellence.

I happened to be enrolled in a graduate seminar in Linguistics at Fresno State University. When we were assigned a project dealing with a problem in linguistics, my proposal of a study of the problem between Lacy Curry and the Scottish professor was approved. The

report grade was A, with the suggestion that I submit it to *Christian Century*. To my surprise, it was accepted and featured as one of two main articles in the annual issue on Theological Education. With such concrete evidence as this mistreatment of a student, the dire need for Black Church Studies was underscored. Among the many schools to which I was sent as a consultant was CRDS, later joined by Bexley Hall and Crozer Theological Seminary. I recommended some curricula and, for faculty, a very scholarly Black pastor, Rev. William J. Shaw of Philadelphia. Nothing was done about this until the death of Martin Luther King, Jr., and the lockout of the school by Black students, in 1968. In the settlement reached between the striking Black students and the administration, six Black trustees and five Black faculty were appointed. I was hired to head the MLK program by mutual agreement of the administration and Black students. I had 14 years as a respected Black administrator in the American Baptist Convention, and the striking students knew me as a radical Black scholar. I was appointed, and in my inaugural address I urged the seminary to complete its repentance for all those years with no Black faculty and an annual quota of only two Black students. As their new MLK professor of Black Church Studies I thus seemed ungrateful. Suddenly, on less than three months' notice, I had to address the task of designing and teaching new culture-sensitive courses and with almost no credible bibliographical resources. A whole curriculum of Black Church Studies was implied by the Black appointments, but they came the same time I came, so the overall curriculum was put in place before I had arrived. The main courses to which I contributed with my own concerns were taught by me. The curriculum and faculty were as follows:

- *BIBLICAL STUDIES*: One of the most popular courses was Black Hermeneutics, taught by Werner Lemke, ThD in Old Testament, Henry H. Mitchell. He would exegete a text; I would interpret it in Black-culture imagery and sermon outline, and students would follow these models in their assignments.
- *CHURCH HISTORY*: I taught Black Church History, with general lectures and student presentations on their own local churches and connections. Lecture materials later appeared in *Black Church Beginnings*, Eerdmans, 2004.
- *PHILOSOPHY*: Leotis S. Belk taught Black Philosophy II; Ethics and Urban Subcultures; Myth, Metaphor, Models, and Religious Language; and the Christian Cosmivision of Antonio Caso.
- *PREACHING/HOMILETICS*: Gardner C. Taylor taught Introduction to Homiletics. His classes drew many white students also. I taught preaching courses using my then recent book *Black Preaching* (1970). William A. Jones came in to teach the Gospel and the Ghetto, using his then recent text by the same name.
- *THEOLOGY*: Frederick D. Jefferson taught Black Systematic Theology, Black, African and Caribbean Theologies, and Introduction to Theological Ethics. He also mentored individual studies in Ethics.
- *THE WORK OF PARISH MINISTRY*: I taught a two-course sequence: The Black Parish: Its Education and Administration, and the Black Parish: Its Worship and Pastoral Care. Concrete and specific Black congregational needs were dealt with. In the administration phase of the course, the class was retained as consultants to Enon Baptist Church, as they chose between moving and building on-site. Pastor "Pop" Greer was strongly opposed in his recommendation that they buy and move. Some rejected a far-superior site "already worn out by White people."

Misguided racial pride blinded them to the facts. Their existing property was off the main traffic pattern and very severely limited in space. A tiny new building on it would cost millions. The class assessed program needs, measured square footages, projected new building costs,

and computed parking lot legal requirements and costs. Their report showed that the pastor's recommendation was vastly less expensive and larger and better. The class's documented recommendations were adopted by the whole congregation, and that fine church on Genesee is still thanking the class. Meanwhile and later, the members of that class returned more gratitude for this class's experience than for any other. And something of this same sort was echoed by white students in such classes as those taught by Dr. Gardner Taylor.

The whole program flowed well; at least, so it seemed on the surface. I wrote a proposal for an MLK, Jr., Program for Developing Bibliographic Resources in Black Church Studies: textbooks in the study of ministerial practice in the Black-culture parish and community. It was funded at a total of \$184,000, by the Irwin Sweeney Miller Foundation. We studied some six weeks in West Africa, to identify our spiritual roots (1972); another six weeks at ITC in Atlanta, the summer of 1973, to get Black documentation; two weeks in the Caribbean, to trace the flow of our culture; and a final, six-week writing session (1974) in Rochester. With one volunteer dropout, CRDS, Bexley Hall, and Crozer Theological Seminary awarded 19 DMin degrees in 1975.

However, there dissatisfied persons emerged, each amounting to opposition of one sort or another. The opposition of students and the unsuccessful opposition of a few faculty all occurred at a point where our only son was dying of acute myeloblastic leukemia. It was nine years after his exposure to atomic radiation, as a laboratory intern. I had been busy all week, after the faculty meeting, building an iron-clad defense of the MLK program. The following Sunday, I arose to preach at Enon Baptist Church, only to find that no sound came from my moving mouth. I was rushed to an early-detection heart clinic two doors away and placed immediately in an oxygen tent. My dear wife Ella took my notes and preached my sermon. After that she visited son and husband in two different hospitals, both patients in critical condition. I recovered enough in a week to teach a half load. Then I took a year's sick leave.

When, in a year, I failed to recover sufficiently to preach, I offered outright resignation from my post as tenured full professor at CRDS. This period of "illness" yielded a ThD in Black Church History, at Claremont School of Theology, and a book called *Black Belief* published by Harper & Row (1975), my dissertation. During this same period I agreed to join a Black PhD student in establishing the Ecumenical Center for Black Church Studies (ECBCS) in Los Angeles. Abandoned by my partner, who joined a national denominational staff, I pushed on. This center still lives, offering bachelor degrees in religion from the now University of LaVerne, a fully accredited ministry of the Church of the Brethren. They had highly respected, off-campus classes as far afield as the US Navy base in Athens, Greece. ECBCS classes were scheduled in convenient city locations and on weekends. The courses were offered for credit to students without high school diplomas, if they did well on 12 hours of conditional registration. Many such special pastor registrants easily surpassed their regularly admitted classmates.

Another successful innovation at the ECBCS was called "Tandem Courses," where upper division religion courses were yoked with standard introductory courses in basics: English Composition (Preaching); Intro to Psychology (Pastoral Care); Intro to Sociology (Church and Urban Problems), etc. An ex-GI could accrue 12 hours of credit, on Friday night and Saturday morning, to qualify for a full load and GI Bill benefits. And the more mature pastor did not have to question the relevance of basic courses to her or his "late vocation"-based ministry.

During this same period (1972–1982), I taught several terms at Fuller Theological Seminary (Homiletics; Church Administration; and Black Culture and World View). Also, the last one of these years, I taught nearly full time in African American Studies at California State University at Northridge, in the San Fernando Valley. All the while I was directing and teaching full loads at the Ecumenical Center. I rescinded acceptance of a distinguished professorship at Northridge to become interim and, shortly, full dean of what is now the Samuel D. Proctor School of Theology at Virginia Union University.

From 1982 to 1987, Ella and I regularized the scheduled offerings, time-wise, of the Non Traditional Hours Program to bring its MDiv schedule parallel to the BA schedule at the center in Los Angeles. This immediately expanded the enrollment by 50%. Ella left in 1986 to serve for two years as the first female dean of Sisters Chapel at Spelman College, while I joined her in Atlanta a year later. We then served 12 years as visiting (joint) professors at the Interdenominational Theological Center in Atlanta, with additional work as mentors in the DMin program at United Theological Seminary at Dayton.

Notes

1. Gayraud S. Wilmore, "The Black Church in the Age of False Prophets: An Interview with Gayraud Wilmore," in Iva E. Carruthers, Frederick D. Haynes, III and Jeremiah A. Wright, Jr., eds., *Blow the Trumpet in Zion!: Global Vision and Action for the 21st Century Black Church* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005), 175–176.
2. Henry Mitchell was born in 1919 in Columbus, Ohio, to Orlando and Bertha Mitchell. He was the grandson of Henry H. Mitchell who pastored the Second Baptist Church in Columbus which was founded in 1836.
3. The terms "race men" and "race women" were used to refer to black men and women whose political ideals and activities were devoted to the cause of eradicating discrimination against people of African descent. It was a term that emerged in the early decades of the twentieth century in the United States during the time of legalized segregation. In *Race Men: The W. E. B. DuBois Lectures* (1998), literary studies scholar Hazel Carby notes that St. Clair Drake and Horace Cayton in their 1945 book, *Black Metropolis*, accounted for the emergence of the "Race Man" in light of the need for black people to prove their worth and value in the face of a larger white society which systematically devalued both. The race man and race woman, therefore, stood up for "the race" meaning black people, collectively, and sought out equitable changes not solely for their own personal gain on behalf of all other black people.
4. William Pickens (1881–1954) was born in South Carolina. The son of people who had survived slavery, Pickens went on to graduate from Yale University. An educator and activist, he served the NAACP.
5. Walter Francis White (1893–1955) joined the NAACP in 1918 becoming its leader from 1931–1955. During his time of service with the NAACP, White contributed to crucial activities such as the establishment of the Legal Defense Fund which in turn launched legal challenges against segregationist policies and practices in areas such as education and the military.
6. The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) was founded in 1909 in the United States. It is the oldest American civil rights organization devoted to advocacy for the civil rights of black people and other minority groups in the United States. The NAACP has played a crucial role in anti-lynching campaigns in the early decades of the twentieth century and during the civil rights era; its Legal Defense and Educational Fund won crucial legal battles in areas such as educational reform.
7. Thomas A. Dorsey (1899–1993) is often referred to as the "father of modern gospel music." Born in Villa Rica, Georgia, Dorsey was the son of a Baptist minister. He became a barrelhouse piano player known as Georgia Tom. A prolific composer of jazz and early rhythm and blues, Dorsey's best-known song is the classic gospel composition, "Precious Lord" composed in 1932. He founded the National Convention of Gospel Choirs and Choruses.
8. Paul Johannes Tillich (1886–1965) was an influential twentieth-century theologian and philosopher. Born in Brandenburg, Germany, Tillich was ordained as a Lutheran minister and received his scholarly training in Germany and began his career as a professor in Germany before emigrating to the United States in 1933. He was dismissed from his position at the University of Frankfurt upon Hitler's rise to German Chancellor in 1933. Tillich subsequently taught at Union Theological Seminary from 1933 to 1955 in New York City. From 1955 to 1962, he taught at the Harvard Divinity School and then for three years, until his death in 1965 at

the University of Chicago. Tillich's *Systematic Theology* has become a classic text in theological studies.

9. On May 2, 2010, Rev. Lacy Kirk "L. K." Curry was conferred an honorary doctor of humane letters degree by Georgetown College President William H. Crouch, Jr., assisted by Rev. Rogers Jackson, pastor of Emmanuel Baptist Church of Chicago, Illinois. Curry has held numerous leadership roles including past president of Chicago's interdenominational ministerial alliance and a board member of the National Baptist Convention and Northern Baptist Seminary.

Black Church Studies as Advocate and Critic of Black Christian Ecclesial Communities

Gayraud S. Wilmore

In 1967, Black seminarians at Colgate Rochester Divinity School created a Black Student Caucus and began to press for an educational program that would include the history of the Black church, the appointment of Black faculty members and trustees, and provide for particular instruction for ministry in African American churches. One year later, on December 10, 1968, the caucus presented an ultimatum to the president, Dr. Gene E. Bartlett. Either the school would appoint Blacks to four open faculty positions and ten Blacks to the board of trustees or the Black caucus would take drastic action. The demands were not met, so on March 2, 1969, 19 Black students, under the leadership of Rev. John S. Walker, took over Strong Hall, the main administrative and classroom building, effectively shutting down all activities on the campus for 17 days.¹ During the lockout Rev. St. Julian Simpkins (rector of the local Black episcopal church) and other Black clergy in the city brought food to Strong Hall for the barricaded students.

Later in 1969 Dr. Henry H. Mitchell was appointed the first Martin Luther King, Jr. Professor of Black Church Studies at Colgate Rochester and, as far as I have been able to find, inaugurated the first Black Church Studies Chair in the nation. Henry resigned in 1974 to become the director of the Ecumenical Center for Black Church Studies in Los Angeles, and I succeeded him at Colgate Rochester, which by that time had merged with Bexley Hall and Crozer Theological Seminary.

I can't help but wonder if a group of Black scholars in religion, representing all the disciplines of graduate theological education, would be sitting here today if it had not been for the radical vision, the revolutionary witness, and the courage of 19 Black seminarians in Rochester, NY, who laid their degrees and careers on the line in the spring of 1969 to make Black Church Studies an undisputed part of American theological education.

I am using the word "undisputed" more hopefully than "factually" because after 45 years of scores of PhD and DMin dissertations, hundreds of articles, books, conferences, and forums on Black religion and Black Church Studies, as a sub-area under the general rubric of religious studies, we see little evidence that the concern which brings us to this meeting is regarded as important by more than a small handful of the 150 plus institutions that make up the Association of Theological Schools (ATS) in the United States and Canada.

As early as 1968 the ATS initiated pathfinding explorations of the concept of African American Church Studies by establishing a special committee on the Black Religious Experience and a conference on the subject held at Howard University from February 20–22, 1970. But the follow-through has been weak. Today the ATS has little or no substantive or statistical information on where Black Church Studies programs exist, how they are staffed and funded, what their declared purposes and goals are, what curricular and pedagogical norms they posit, or to what extent the member schools of the association are committed to such programs for Black and non-Black students who may be interested in teaching and researching African American churches.

What I want to say is that Black Church Studies is indispensable for the preparation of women and men for ministry in ecclesial communities in which persons of African descent predominate in the United States, Canada, the Caribbean, and Latin America. I am specifically referencing Black *ecclesial communities*, particularly Black Christian congregations and denominations, but I would dare say that some introduction to Black Church Studies ought to be required of all persons preparing to be leaders of Christian churches in the United States and Canada.

Someone here is probably ready to throw up his or her hands in horror at such an exclusionary proposal. The idea of emphasizing the Black church is controversial enough to cause a small war to break out in the vast majority of the member schools of the ATS today. But to limit such studies to Christian churches would be highly offensive to many of our colleagues in the general field of African American religion.

But I want to go further than that: I want to make a case for three pedagogical proposals, strategies, or lifestyles focused on the African American Christian churches that I believe can be pursued almost simultaneously by people like us. These proposals are not new. We've heard them before, but history has taken away their priority in American theological education. I want to raise them again in this new forum: (1) a Black Church Studies program that is a quasi-independent counterpart of the mainstream theological curriculum; (2) a Black Church Studies program that is a friendly advocate of African American ecclesial communities (i.e., congregations, denominations, church-sponsored institutions, caucuses, and ecumenical agencies); and (3) a Black Church Studies program that is a constructive and emancipatory critic of Black churches as we know them today.

I

Before I begin to unpack the bare bones of these three proposals I would remind us, if indeed we need reminding, that not all of us are institutionally oriented Christians and, therefore, not all of us feel a special calling to prepare ministers for the church. That's a problem that we need to talk about here, but I'll say now that I don't believe that not being Christian necessarily disqualifies one from teaching in Black Church Studies programs. It's perhaps too trite to say that we need help from wherever we can find it. This week from conservatives. Next week from liberals. And the week after from raving radicals. There is no question that as you go around observing our churches and listening to the sermons of many of the ministers we taught over the past quarter century or more, you have to say that the Black church generally and Black Church Studies particularly are both in trouble. Our popularity and influence today is severely limited. As an academic program we're still kicking but, as my retirement home "inmates" like to say, we're not kicking very high! We have no settled philosophy, no cadre of recognized leaders, no programmatic policy guidelines or norms, and no journal with which to publish our findings, ideas, and experiences.

If it's true that we're all in trouble, where does the fault lie? That's something else we should discuss and it's a complicated question indeed. But before we blame the ATS, the guilds, the American Academy of Religion, or white administrations and faculty members, we ought to

blame ourselves, sisters and brothers, because we, who so enthusiastically entered this field over the period of the last 45 years, have gradually but steadily withdrawn from the commitments some of us made when we created the Society for the Study of Black Religion back in 1970.

I don't think it's unfair to say that in those days Shelby Rooks and Charles "Chuck" Long were the two people who deserve our highest commendation, but two people who also dominated the direction in which the society chose to move. It was not a totally wrong direction, but in my opinion, it was a too-limiting one. Under Shelby and Chuck's benevolent influence most of the members tacitly agreed to avoid confrontation with the white power structure of the seminaries and the elite university departments of religion and divinity schools. Although I served as president from 1976 to 1980 I was not happy with that decision and said so, though perhaps not loudly enough. But most SSBR members rallied around the idea that we ought to be interested in scholarship for the sake of scholarship, and that was that. Shelby Rooks wrote in 1990:

I was convinced . . . that the SSBR should provide the opportunity for African American scholars to be involved and reflective, with the emphasis upon reflection. There were many arenas for action. There were few for reflection . . . That is why I continually supported keeping the Society open primarily for scholarship's sake. That is not everything the Society did or should do, but it is better equipped than any other group in African America to provide the detached intellectual inquiry that will be forever required.²

In *Revolution in Zion*, Shelby identifies me and James "Jim" Cone with a minority who did not share his vision of the society as a group of detached scholars mainly interested in quiet reflection, but rather a group of advocates who wanted to push the SSBR toward a more political and activist agenda. I, for one, had a friendly disagreement with Shelby on the idea of scholarship for scholarship's sake because as a national church executive during the civil rights movement, I had learned the hard way that truth without politics in this society is like that old battleship that used to be tied up on the Hudson at a pier on the Westside Highway in midtown Manhattan. It looked good, it was educational, it told a great story, but it wasn't going anywhere! I still believe in activist scholarship, although I deny that my interests then or now have been exclusively polemic or political.

The question I am begging when I speak of a Black Church Studies program that is a quasi-independent counterpart of the standard curriculum is, to what extent can we really depend upon the conventional disciplines of the mainstream to take care of our concerns for the Black church and community? I mean no disrespect, but I simply fail to see the ATS or the power structures of the predominantly white administrations, faculties, or boards of trustees supporting and funding programs of graduate study that have the intrinsic purpose of empowering African American Christians to deal with the most depressing and destructive problems of Black existence. In fact, I don't believe that our historic Black universities and seminaries are themselves ready for such agency, though I did sense some possibilities for our Black schools when Dean J. T. Roberson of Shaw and I worked together for a consultation on that problem two years ago. Today, however, I am less sanguine about those possibilities being any more real among Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) than among white institutions.

I don't want to be misunderstood here. This is not an argument for what Tommie Shelby renounces as the "thick blackness"³ of the ethnic solidarity that would trap African American religious scholarship behind a wall of outmoded Black nationalism. But if Black scholars in religion are not prepared to argue for a partly independent program of Black Church Studies that will insist upon first-rate scholarship, that will take it out of the passive mode of mainstream theological education and reconstruct it for a praxis-oriented program of the social, cultural, political, and economic empowerment, I do not see to whom we can turn for Black liberation and reconciliation on this side of the Jordan. The 2002 issue of the journal *Theological Education* entitled "The Promise and Challenge of Racial and Ethnic Diversity in Theological

Education,” contains ample evidence that ATS does advocate diversity and has even included it in its standards for accreditation.⁴ But I fear that concern for diversity, without facing the need for semi-autonomous administrative power to develop Black Church Studies in collaboration with Black church and community structures, will leave us to celebrate diversity but frustrated in trying to make it serve our purposes of empowerment.⁵

An article by Julia M. Speller in the same issue of *Theological Education* reports on an ATS workshop session in 2002 that she attended as a participant-observer. Dr. Speller describes what I believe is a meaningful and insightful contribution to the diversity emphasis of ATS discussions thus far:

One of the major points of discussion in several groups was the concern about maintaining the current theological “canon” and the tensions around broadening the dialogue to include other voices. This very critical issue is much deeper than simply adding racial/ethnic scholars to the syllabi. It has major implications for the shape of theological discourse, the redefining of who should be the “gatekeepers,” and the “decolonization” of curriculum, as one group described it.

We can argue about what strategy and tactics will be required to institute a quasi-independent Black Church Studies program, but I stand squarely with Forrest E. Harris, Sr. in his call for activist engagement of the Black church with the principalities and powers. What Forrest has called for cannot be properly explored and implemented for Black ecclesial communities without politics, without a change in what Speller calls “the gatekeepers.” At the end of his *Ministry for Social Crisis: Theology and Praxis in the Black Church Tradition*, he sums up the challenge in this way:

We have emphasized the pragmatic spirituality of the Black religious tradition that makes spirituality and social transformation inseparable. Black faith will not permit us to hide behind pious passivity and spiritualization of religion which make it an inward, private experience that has small consequences in the real world of power structures, social and economic decision-making, and electoral politics.⁶

II

My second proposal is for a Black Church Studies program that is a friendly advocate of African American ecclesial communities, which, I remind you, means not only local congregations, but denominations, clergy and laity groups, and ecumenical agencies. We have not always been considered dependable and friendly allies by individual congregations and denominations because we are often suspected of having given up on them.

Not long ago I received a letter from a friend, a highly regarded professional in the field of church administration, in which he declared that educational preparation for ministry in the African American church has become inferior education and, given the present decline of the historic Black institutions, should not be expected to be around much longer than a few more painful years. He pointed out that just as most historic Black colleges are on the verge of financial collapse and are being closed, one by one, we will soon be forced to concede that assimilation into welcoming white churches and white seminaries is the inevitable destiny of Black Church Studies, Black seminaries, and indeed Black liberation theology itself.

I have already said that our African American churches and some other Black ecclesial communities are in trouble, perhaps more than ever before in our memory. But I don’t believe that they are anywhere near extinction. With more than 29 million⁷ African Americans members of Christian churches and affiliate groups of every description, from Pentecostal prayer bands to Roman Catholic cathedrals, there is a good probability that the peculiar

appropriation that Black folks continue to make of mainline Christianity will be around for another 500 years. It may change many times in substance and overt appearance, as it did in the past, but there is something “Black” or African-centered about how and why we worship that is almost indelible. After all, Ethiopian Christianity has existed for almost 1,700 years and is still going strong, and Nubian Christianity, pressed by Islam, persisted for more than 800 years in what is now the southern Sudan. I don’t expect the Black church to transmute into a thoroughly integrated multi-ethnic and multi-cultural institution before the middle of this millennium, if then, unless Jesus comes more quickly than some of us anticipate.

Black Church Studies, whether pursued by the course offerings of most predominantly Black theological seminaries, or carried on as specialized programs of a few predominantly white university divinity schools, has a more solid constituency than any academic program existing today that emphasizes culture and ethnicity in the United States and Canada. Almost everybody else has succumbed to the seduction of a fuzzy multiculturalism, but for good or ill we continue to make Black church history and Black theology our academic baseline for preparing women and men for ministry in this country. I am not saying that we’re doing a particularly great job of it, but the fact that we’re here at Candler this week means that we’re still on that course, and I hope that we’ll remain on it.

We have yet to learn how to enlist, recruit, and teach Black prospective pastors and professors. We have yet to involve Black celebrities, the Black entertainment industry, and the Black corporate world in the quest for a constructive renovation of the Black church in terms of its secular relevance in today’s world. We have yet to put the kind of policy and financial platform under theological education that can mobilize and deploy our spiritual and material resources to their maximum degree. In this I am beginning to believe that we may have more success with interdenominational and nondenominational ecclesial communities, like the mega churches, the annual National Black Pastors Convocations (such as Hampton and the Samuel DeWitt Proctor conferences that Dr. Iva Carruthers heads up), the Potter’s House of Bishop Jakes, and some new incarnation of the National Congress of Black Churches, than we can have with the conventional congregations and denominations.

But Black Church Studies must, first of all, claim and advocate the African American institutional churches. I don’t mean that Black Church Studies should idolize them. Rather it should describe itself as a servant of a new, creative, and resourceful Black Christian community before we can expect Black Christians to take us seriously. King, Abernathy, Andy Young, and Jesse Jackson were fond of describing themselves as “poor, Black, country preachers.” We laughed and knew that they had their tongues in their cheeks while sporting expensive Brook Brothers’ suits on their backs, but Black Christians loved it and were willing to follow them to the Klan courthouse and back. Black scholars in religion have to do the same thing. We have to engage our disciplines on the level of ordinary Black church people. We have to keep the faith. If we want the church to trust our scholarship and our leadership we have to serve the largest and most humble congregations by preparing for them the highest quality of pastoral leadership of which we are capable and then demonstrating our constructive partnership by following our graduates up with critical and regular pastoral oversight.

I’m well aware that not all of us are Christians who claim to be working at being so in our personal lives and in the lives of our families. But I dare say that most of us weren’t summoned into this profession by the allurements of being a member of some prestigious guild of scholars. Most of us were called by the Holy Spirit to take up the vocation of teaching for the sake of the church and the world for which Christ died. If the churches have left us, it well may be because we appear to have left the churches. I am not naive about the failures of the Black church. My third proposition calls for Black Church Studies to be an emancipatory critic of the Black church, but it stands to reason that the church will never accept our criticism if it is not assured of our friendship.

III

Anthony Pinn has taken me to task for what he calls the “Christianization” of the field of religious studies by an exclusionary emphasis on the Black church at a time when a deeper and more complex analysis of the meaning of religion requires transcending the boundaries of any single body of dogma.⁸ I take that criticism seriously, but he may be misunderstanding the intention of the course I have pursued and am recommending here. The most effective criticism of the Black church will be a criticism from the inside rather than from the outside.

In the first place I am more concerned about the salience of Black Church Studies than about *religious* studies as such. I think of the latter as the broader field of inquiry and the latter as the specific target of almost 50 years of discussions about what we as Black Christians ought to be about. In the second place, everything that I am saying has to do with a severe but constructive and emancipatory critique of this ecclesial institution that Black religion has created—namely, the organized African American congregation and denomination.

No one can doubt that the contemporary Black church leaves much to be desired. I share Tonyaa Weathersbee’s dismay when she writes in her commentary about greed in some Black churches:

Sometimes Black churches do things that make me want to say amen. But a few in Alabama have been doing things that just make me want to holler. My latest screaming fit comes courtesy of those Black churches in Birmingham who sold their souls to coddle Richard M. Scrusby, the embattled founder of HealthSouth Corp. and a wealthy white man who, it seems, figured that through them, he could buy not only spirituality, but influence . . . Scrusby—who left his mostly white, evangelical suburban church in 2003 to join a Black church after he was indicted on fraud and money-laundering charges—had been paying [Audrey Lewis, a writer] through a public relations firm to come up with glowing pieces about it in The Birmingham Times, the Black weekly newspaper . . . According to BusinessWeek Online, Lewis came to do work for Scrusby through her church, Believers Temple Church. The pastor, Herman Henderson, claims that Scrusby hired him to organize Black pastors to attend his trial—to form an “amen corner,” if you will—and to do public relations work on his behalf. Weathersbee concludes this part of her commentary on the Black churches of Birmingham with the remark: “That troubles me—because it tells me that too many Black churches are no longer about the business of justice as much as they are about the business about business, period.”⁹

There is no time here to list all the manifold sins and shortcomings of the Black church, but before I close I’d like to list three or four clusters of problems that Black Church Studies ought to address in its role as a constructive critic that seeks to be an instrumentality of emancipation and liberation rather than the church’s flunkey, anxious to cover over all her spots and blemishes with a patina of academic vanishing cream.

First, I think we have a responsibility to liberate the church from a creeping conservative evangelicalism that is grounded in an outmoded biblical literalism. That is probably the major source of our homophobia and our theological illiteracy. We need to reinstate the mystery of God and the Third Person of the Trinity in order to help our people break out of the stranglehold of white fundamentalism and open up to a more humanizing gospel.

Secondly, and somewhat paradoxically, Black faith is being trivialized by a banal and conventional secularism that wants to bring into the sanctuary everything that our children think is cool and that is too frequently vulnerable to crass commercial exploitation. Black Church Studies needs to work on a theology of worship that lets God be God and not get so buddy-buddy with God that whatever makes people feel good gets too easily sanctified and placed on the altar of dumbed-down religiosity.

Thirdly, Black Church Studies ought to militate against that kind of Christian narcissism that Anthony Pinn and other Black humanists are justly worried about. I don't believe that to attempt to give Black churches theoretical and practical guidance for a liberated ministry in the real world is to narrowly restrict the general field of religious studies to what Pinn calls "the historical 'trappings' of religion" that somehow misses the significance of religion per se.¹⁰

While I agree that the proper study of religion is the human quest for "complex subjectivity" (i.e., for a fuller sense of what it means to be human), I believe that Black Church Studies—as a sub-area under the more general rubric of religion per se—ought to be primarily concerned with the historical and institutional manifestations of African American Christianity as the flawed but always improvable battering ram of Black Americans for truth, justice, and liberation in the space we occupy. I am committed, therefore, to the continuation and empowerment of that particular part of the One Universal Church of Christ that is the legacy of African American believers for the humanization of individuals, the healing of the nations, and the salvation of the world.

Luke 4: 16–30 and Matthew 25 emancipate the Black church from the temptation of dogmatic exclusivity and make it open to truth from African Traditional Religions, Islam, secular humanism, and everywhere else God has permitted more light to shine upon the problems of our human condition. Black Church Studies ought to encourage interdenominational and interfaith dialogue to that end.

Finally, in keeping with its emancipatory role Black Church Studies, it seems to me, ought to promote and strategize the Black church's use of responsible power in the places where decisions are made that affect the quality of life and destiny of all people. This relates directly to our political role and I will leave it at that. Politics is always dangerous, but it appears that we have yet to outgrow the wise statement of the National Committee of Negro Churchmen (NCBC) on July 31, 1966, that calls for the capacity to participate with power in the creation of a new world.

We regard as sheer hypocrisy or as a blind and dangerous illusion the view that opposes love to power. Love should be a controlling element in power, Not power itself. So long as white churchmen continue to moralize and misinterpret Christian love, so long will justice continue to be subverted in this land.¹¹

These are a few fragmentary thoughts about the nature and task of Black Church Studies as a program of theological education in the twenty-first century. I pass them on not as settled arguments, but as grist for our discussion mill as we continue to assess the space we occupy in the arena of American theological schools and university departments of religion. If I were to sum up the main burden of my argument I would say that it is time for us to define Black Church Studies as a partner with the African American churches and communities in prospecting for a creative, liberating lifestyle today that builds upon our racial and religious history and heritage but looks forward to the future with compassion, hope, and good will for the whole world.

Notes

1. Rochester, NY, *Democrat and Chronicle*, March 4, 1984, 1B.
2. Charles Shelby Rooks, *Revolution in Zion* (New York: Pilgrim Press, 1990), 138, 139.
3. Tommie Shelby, *We Who Are Dark: The Philosophical Foundations of Black Solidarity* (Cambridge: Belknap Press, 2004), in a review by Orlando Patterson in *New York Times Book Review*, January 8, 2006, 10.
4. See the article by Francis A. Lonsway, an ATS staff member and others, entitled "Student Diversity and the Data," *Theological Education*, Vol. 38, No. 2, 2002, 51.
5. *Ibid.*, 61.

6. Forrest E. Harris, Sr. *Ministry for Social Crisis* (Macon: Mercer U. Press, 1993), 129.
7. I am using figures of a careful student of Black church demographics, Mary R. Sawyer, in Rebecca Moore, Anthony B. Pinn, and Mary R. Sawyer (eds.), *Peoples Temple and Black Religion in America* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2004), 190, n.9.
8. Anthony B. Pinn, "Peoples Temple as Black Religion," in Moore, Pinn, and Sawyer (eds.), *Peoples Temple and Black Religion in America* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2004), 1–2.
9. Tonyaa Weathersbee, "Why Has Greed Made Far Too Many Black Churches Lose Their Way?" BlackAmericaWeb.com, Tuesday, January 24, 2006.
10. Ibid., 5.
11. James H. Cone and Gayraud S. Wilmore (eds.), *Black Theology: A Documentary History*, Volume One: 1966–1979 (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1993), 21.

Black Church Studies as an Academic Interest and Initiative: A Historical Perspective

Lewis V. Baldwin

Black church studies has emerged in recent decades as one of the most interesting and significant components of theological education. Commonly described as “the academic study of the religious traditions and experiences of Americans of African descent,”¹ this particular field has come to embrace a wide range of disciplines, among which are African American church history and Black liberation theology.² With these and other developments in focus, this essay seeks to answer the following questions: (1) *When, where, and how* did Black Church Studies programs begin, and what forces gave rise to them? For what purpose(s) were they established? What initially were their goals and/or objectives, and to what extent have these been achieved? What are the major challenges confronting these programs—in the past, present, and future? Answers to these questions are essential for understanding Black Church Studies in historical terms.

Four major contexts must be seriously considered in any discussion of the origins of Black Church Studies as an academic interest and initiative. First, the rise of educational institutions committed primarily to the religious and/or theological training of African Americans in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, developments which, on their own terms, reflected a deep interest in the life of the Black parish and the preparation of preacher-intellectuals for the church and the race.³ Second, the earliest scholarly investigations of African American religious life by W. E. B. DuBois, Carter G. Woodson, Benjamin E. Mays, E. Franklin Frazier, and others, who subjected the Black church experience to the scrutiny of scientific research and analysis, thus prepared the ground for subsequent generations of African American religious scholars.⁴ Third, the quest for civil rights and Black power in the 1950s and 1960s, which highlighted the demand to integrate the Black studies project as a whole into the curricula of America’s academic institutions. Finally, the rise of Black liberation theology as an academic discipline, which provided a scathing critique of the white church and white Western theology and which challenged the nation’s seminaries, the divinity schools, and the broader academic establishment to take seriously the faith, traditions, and leadership needs of the Black church.⁵

The history of Black Church Studies is related in some measure to the founding of institutions such as Shaw Divinity School in Raleigh, North Carolina (1865), the Theological

Department at Howard University in Washington, DC (1870), Gammon Theological Seminary in Atlanta, Georgia (1883), Payne Theological Seminary in Wilberforce, Ohio (1891), Virginia Union School of Theology in Richmond, Virginia (1898), and Hood Theological Seminary in Salisbury, North Carolina (1910).⁶ These institutions, some of which were started by African American denominations,⁷ pioneered in the study of various aspects of Black church life and culture, and they first established the view that the Black church was worthy of scholarly attention and examination. Howard and Gammon were particularly important in this regard, for they, as “the first fully accredited, predominantly African American graduate schools of religion,” afforded the arenas in which “the most serious investigations of African American religions before the 1960s were done over many years by students and professors . . .” Numerous dissertations and monographs were produced, and new directions for the scientific study of the Black church in connection to social matters were explored.⁸ Moreover, it was in these settings that the scholarship of DuBois, Woodson, Mays, Frazier, and other pioneers in the Black Church Studies field were first studied, discussed, and analyzed.

But efforts to create Black Church Studies programs officially began in predominantly white divinity schools and seminaries in the late 1960s, a period during which the Black church emerged to prominence as *the Black church*. According to Gayraud S. Wilmore, “Black Church Studies,” or “African American Religious Studies programs,” developed as an outgrowth of “the Black Studies movement, the artistic and intellectual efflorescence of the civil rights period . . .”⁹ Critical to these developments was the assassination of Martin Luther King, Jr. on April 4, 1968. In response to the tragedy, and to the challenge of Black power and the Black liberation theology of James H. Cone and others, African American students and faculty in mostly white divinity schools and seminaries, though small in number, virtually demanded that African American religions and the special needs of the Black church be carefully included in their curricula. But few white administrators and students listened with a sympathetic ear, and even in cases where support for Black Church Studies existed, the struggle for programmatic support and legitimation proved to be long and arduous.¹⁰ As Wilmore recalled, whites in even the most liberal divinity schools and seminaries were receptive to the idea of academic chairmanships named and established in King’s honor and memory but failed to see the value of any program in Black Church Studies. In other words, “certifying the academic legitimacy of Black church studies to white faculty was one of our greatest challenges,” Wilmore observed. “White faculty had to be convinced that what we were doing was significant.”¹¹

In any case, the drive to make a Black Church Studies program “an integral part of the seminary curriculum” began with Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries in Rochester, New York.¹² An uprising by Black students in 1969, which resulted in the take-over of the main administration building, ended only after white administrators and faculty agreed to meet certain demands, which included an increase in African American faculty and a range of course offerings in African American religious and cultural studies. With the assistance of the Lilly and the Irwin-Sweeney-Miller Foundations, The Martin Luther King, Jr. Program of Black Church Studies was established in that same year, thus becoming “the first of such programs to be established in a predominantly white theological seminary,” or “the oldest program of its kind in the nation.”¹³ In 1970, a year later, Arthur R. McKay, the president of Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, explained the significance of its Black Church Studies program in terms that merit extended quotation:

To meet the special needs of the Black church—needs too long ignored by most seminaries—the Martin Luther King Program of Black Church Studies was established last year. Through such courses as Black Preaching, The Black Bible and Black Imagination, and Protest Ideology within the Black Community, the program seeks to educate ministers skilled in dealing with the problems of the ghetto . . . , but who have retained their Blackness, and who can relate to

the people. The program also gives white students an opportunity to learn the Black church's unique contributions to American culture . . . It's pretty clear that over the years seminaries have largely neglected the needs of the Black church. If we are to educate Blacks for ministry to their churches, we must seek more Black professors and students who understand the Black church's unique needs. We've produced many Black clergy, but we've done it with our models being models appropriate to a constituency our Black graduates seldom serve.¹⁴

Henry H. Mitchell, an African American Baptist clergyman and theologian who helped conceive and develop the program at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, became the Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial professor of Black Church Studies and the program's first director.¹⁵ Mitchell had actually gone to the seminaries as a consultant before the student take-over in 1969. Described as "one of only two or three scholars pioneering the new field of Black Church Studies," Mitchell, who earned a ThD from Claremont School of Theology, brought to the program a wealth of intellect and organizational skills and accomplished a great deal in his four years as director. He was assisted by a number of African American faculty and visiting professors and lecturers, among whom were Leotis S. Belk (Philosophy of Religion), Frederick D. Jefferson (Theology), Joseph A. Pelham (Field Education), William A. Jones (Black Church Studies), Gardner C. Taylor (Homiletics), and Lucius M. Tobin (Black Church History and Sociology of Religion). Henry Mitchell, who was replaced as the program's director by Gayraud S. Wilmore in 1974, went on to become the founding director of the Ecumenical Center for Black Church Studies in Los Angeles, serving in that capacity from 1974 until 1982.¹⁶ Wilmore directed the program at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries until 1983. He was followed by a number of young highly accomplished African American clergymen and scholars, among whom were Robert M. Franklin, Dwight Webster, Walter E. Fluker, Darryl M. Trimiew, and Lawrence Hargrave, who served as the acting dean of the program. Currently, the acting dean is the Rev. Adrienne L. Phillips, a 2004 graduate at the seminaries.¹⁷

Some accounts hold that the Black Church Studies program at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries was not the only one instituted in 1969. What some have described as "an urban Black church studies program" began in that year at the Graduate Theological Union in Berkeley, California. Referred to as the Center for Urban Black Studies, this program was started by William Hazaiah Williams (1930–1999), a Black Baptist clergyman and civil rights activist who had been trained at Boston University, the Pacific School of Religion, and the Church Divinity School of the Pacific.¹⁸ The program was funded by the Graduate Theological Union consortium, which consisted of Berkeley Baptist Divinity School (now American Baptist Seminary of the West), Pacific Lutheran Theological Seminary, Church Divinity School of the Pacific (Episcopalian), San Francisco Theological Seminary (Presbyterian), Pacific School of Religion (interdenominational), the Starr King School for the Ministry (Unitarian), the Dominican School of Philosophy and Theology, the Jesuit School of Theology at Berkeley, and the Franciscan School of Theology. According to the GTU President James A. Donahue, the Center for Urban Black Studies, the first Black Church Studies program at a consortium of seminaries was designed to "address the needs and issues of African American students and ministry" in an urban context.¹⁹

Williams directed the Center for Urban Black Studies for some 20 years and was succeeded by Dorsey O. Blake, a Baptist minister and educator with degrees from Brown University, the Pacific School of Religion, and United Theological Seminary. Like Williams, Blake, who now pastors the historic Church for the Fellowship of All Peoples in San Francisco, brought to the GTU program a keen sense of the need for the kind of cooperative educational initiatives and experiences that would involve seminarians of various racial, ethnic, and religious backgrounds. Howard Thurman, Lucius M. Tobin, Herbert O. Edwards, Kelly Miller Smith, Charles B. Copher, and other great preacher-intellectuals either lectured or taught courses

in the program, an initiative that had become well established by 1973. The question of which of the Black Church Studies programs actually blossomed first—the one at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries or the one at the Graduate Theological Union—is not as important as it might seem at first glance, for the series of events that ultimately led to both programs, and to the one at Garrett Theological Seminary, were occurring at roughly the same time. At any rate, a growing deficiency in programmatic support resulted in the demise of the Center for Urban Black Studies in 1994.²⁰

Garrett Theological Seminary in Evanston, Illinois, a predominantly white institution affiliated with the United Methodist Church, would become the center of one of the most reputable programs in Black Church Studies. Activities toward that end began in May 1968, only weeks after the King's assassination and months before the student uprising at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries. Garrett's Black students issued "a series of manifestos couched in provocative language," chief among which was "An Action Program for the Elimination of White Racism in Theological Education at Garrett Theological Seminary, Demanded by the Black Student Body," a document that urged "changes in curriculum, more Black faculty, active recruitment of Black students, financial aid, and continuing education."²¹ Faced with pressure from the Garrett Black Seminarians, who, in early 1969, presented another challenge to "The Board of Trustees, Administration, Faculty, Staff, and Students of Garrett Theological Seminary," the board approved a proposal for a Black recruiter and director of Black studies, and the chair and Office of the Church and the Black Experience came to fruition in 1970. Professor Edsel A. Ammons, a Black United Methodist minister who would later be elected a bishop, helped conceive the program, and Hycel B. Taylor, a Black Baptist minister who received a doctor of ministry degree from Vanderbilt University's Divinity School, became its first director. There was a "great change in Black representation" on Garrett's faculty in 1970–1974, as John H. Cartwright (Christian Ethics), Merrel D. Booker (Pastoral Psychology), Philip A. Harley (Church Administration), Carl H. Marbury (New Testament), and Larry G. Murphy (History of Christianity) joined Ammons (Church and Urban Society) and Taylor (Applied Theology) as professors in the Church and the Black Experience program.²²

Characterized as "an unprecedented commitment to redress its own institutional racism by reordering its teaching of the Christian faith and its recruitment practices in order to attract Black students and faculty," the objectives of Garrett's program were very similar to those set forth previously by Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries:

Considered a first priority, this program is unique in that the school as a whole seeks to understand Christian faith from an interracial and intercultural perspective. By trying to approximate authentic Christian community in living and learning, it hopes to sensitize white leadership to the issues faced by the Black community in a pluralistic society at the same time it prepares Black clergy for the Black church.²³

But the Garrett program went a step further in that it was to give special attention "through advanced degree programs to preparing Black leadership for college and seminary teaching and research." It was thought that this part of Garrett's mission would be significantly enhanced by its close academic links to the Graduate School of Northwestern University, with which it administered a joint PhD program in Religious and Theological Studies.²⁴ In any event, Taylor, who invited Henry Mitchell to Garrett to do lectures in the early stages of the program, directed Garrett's Office of the Church and the Black Experience for a decade, before assuming a new title as the seminary's professor of Applied Theology and the Black Experience in 1980. Philip A. Harley, an associate professor of Practical Theology and Field Education, succeeded Taylor as director.²⁵ Other directors of the Garrett program include Henry J. Young, Edward P. Wimberly, Peter Nash, Larry G. Murphy, Daniel T. Hembree, Linda E. Thomas, and Jeffery L. Tribble, all

of whom are known for significant contributions to the ministry of the Black church and Black religious and theological scholarship. Reginald Blount became the interim director of Garrett's Center for the Church and the Black Experience in the mid 2000s. Angela Cowser is its current director.²⁶

A number of other programs in Black Church Studies began in the 1970s, as some of the nation's most popular divinity schools and seminaries struggled to accommodate an increasing Black presence and demands for more inclusiveness. Of particular significance were the programs at Duke Divinity School in Durham, North Carolina, and Fuller Theological Seminary in Pasadena, California, both of which have maintained a low profile when compared to the programs at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries and Garrett Theological Seminary. The efforts that culminated in Duke's program must be viewed in relationship to the civil rights activism in North Carolina, beginning with the student sit-in in Greensboro in February 1960.²⁷ Inspired by the activities in Greensboro, student activism reached Duke in the early 1960s, making it possible for Martin Luther King, Jr. to visit the campus in 1964. Over the next five years, pressure for a Black Church Studies program reached fever pitch, especially as Philip R. Cousin, who pastored an African Methodist Episcopal Church (AME) in Durham, and who would later become a bishop, began to meet with some of the earliest Black seminarians at Duke. In 1969, Cousin and Frederick Herzog, a professor of Systematic Theology at Duke, taught the first course on Black theology at that institution, and an intense search for a director to develop a program in Black Church Studies, spearheaded by the recently appointed Dean Thomas Langford, unfolded over the next three years.²⁸

The Office of Black Church Studies was officially instituted at Duke Divinity School in 1972. Joseph B. Bethea, a Black United Methodist pastor and future bishop, trained at Gammon Theological Seminary in Atlanta, helped develop and implement the program, and also served as its first director. Herbert O. Edwards (Ethics), C. Eric Lincoln (Religion and Culture), Charles H. Long (History of Religions), Clarence J. Newsome (American Christianity), and William C. Turner (Systematic Theology and Homiletics) were among the African American professors and instructors who served at Duke after the creation of the Office of Black Church Studies, and they either taught in the program or made their courses available to students in the program. The purpose of the program would be stated in numerous sources over the next three decades:

The OBCS calls the entire Divinity School community to serious and realistic dialogue with the Black church and the ethnic community. The office was developed in response to the needs of African American and other minority student body and ensures that all students derive the greatest possible value from their theological education. The office provides counsel and advice to prospective Black seminarians, especially those in undergraduate schools. Additionally, the office works closely with university organizations that provide support for minority students.²⁹

The ties between the Divinity School and the broader and highly academic setting of Duke University made the Office of Black Church Studies seem all the more promising, especially from the standpoint of its intellectual rigor and the sheer magnitude of resources on which it could draw. In this sense, it shared similarities to the program at Garrett, with its relationship to northwestern, another first-rate institution. Joseph Bethea directed the Duke program for a few years, before relinquishing the position to Lawrence E. Johnson, a local pastor and educator. Grant S. Shockley, who had been trained at Columbia University, and who had previously taught Religious Education at Garrett Theological Seminary, succeeded Johnson, and, as the program's first scholar-director, devoted time and resources to reorganizing the Office of Black Church Studies.³⁰ Directors of the program who came after Shockley included Karen Y. Collier, William C. Turner, C. Jarrett Gray, and Rodney and Madeline Sadler, all of whom went on to

notable careers in ministry and Black theological education. The Rev. Tiffany Marley currently directs Duke Divinity School's Office of Black Church Studies.³¹

The Black Church Studies initiative at Fuller Theological Seminary, a predominantly white and progressively evangelical institution, developed under a somewhat different set of circumstances. Fuller's African American Church Studies Program, as it is commonly called, dates back to 1974, and it began under the leadership of William Pannell, "an associate of Tom Skinner" and a "persuasive critic of the hypocrisy of white Evangelicals."³² It was "a program for Black pastors, supported with funding from the Rockefeller Foundation."³³ Strangely, the program, which was largely inspired by the work that Henry Mitchell was doing with the Ecumenical Center for Black Church Studies in Los Angeles, was shaped and implemented without a curriculum supported by tenured Black faculty. Also, there was no formal director, in part because the institution's administration was uncomfortable with the theological liberalism of the nation's most highly trained and accomplished Black professors and scholars, and it was perhaps convinced that there were few esteemed African American intellectuals who could fit in and speak its evangelical language. Over the years, those listed as being in charge of the program include academics like Pannell, Stanley Long, Velma Union, Eric G. Pearman, and Ralph C. Watkins, and graduate students such as Rick Stevenson, Radorah Dodd, and Candace Shields.³⁴

Organized "to further equip" African Americans "and those of other ethnicities who have expressed a call to minister to their community and beyond in pastoral and academic arenas," "The African American Church Studies Program," according to its own mission statement,

ascribes to the three-fold purpose of admissions advocacy, degree development and commitment to enhancing the African American student's experience within the Fuller community, and encouraging involvement in the larger church community. The larger goal of the African American Church Studies Program is to empower African American congregations to fulfill their divine destiny.³⁵

Over the first two decades of its development, Fuller's program did attract a number of Black faculty to the seminary. William Pannell (Urban Evangelism), who had been elected to Fuller's board of trustees in 1970, "became the first Black faculty member of the regular faculty."³⁶ Others who represented a Black presence on the faculty from time to time included Leonard Lovett (Social Ethics), Henry H. Mitchell (Homiletics and Black Culture and Worship), J. Alfred Smith (Evangelistic Preaching), Kenneth Ulmer (Homiletics), and Rick Gray (Urban Studies). But despite such developments, Fuller's African American Church Studies Program seemed to some to be a program only in name, and not in substance, mainly because it was not academically rigorous nor connected to a core of tenured Black faculty. These features were questioned at times by Eric G. Pearman, a young Black professor hired in connection with Fuller's African American Church Studies Program in 2002. In 2006, with the hiring of Ralph C. Watkins, who holds a Doctor of Ministry from Pittsburgh Theological Seminary and a PhD in Sociology from the University of Pittsburgh, Fuller's program came under even greater scrutiny. Due largely to Watkins' efforts, a course on Black liberation theology was scheduled for the very first time at Fuller during the 2006–2007 school term. Watkins wore the titles of both assistant dean of the African American Church Studies Program and associate professor of Society, Religion, and Africana Studies. But, interestingly enough, Bishop Candace Shields, who graduated from San Bernardino Bible College and Fuller Theological Seminary, and who pursued a PhD in Practical Theology at Fuller, was listed as the program's director.³⁷

The stage was set for a reorganization of the African American Church Studies Program at Fuller. Watkins released, in ten steps, what he terms the "Mission Objectives Specific to the African American Church Studies Theology Advising Program":

1. Orient first-year students and transfer students.
2. Serve as an academic support and mentoring arm in conjunction with the Theology Center.
3. Develop scholars and church practitioners who are committed to advancing the African American religious experience.
4. Serve as a catalyst to involve pastors of predominantly African American congregations in the life of the seminary and work to connect our students, faculty, and staff with African American congregations.
5. Develop an extended family for prayer, support, advice, and shared leadership of the African American Church Studies Program.
6. Work with the seminary to develop appropriate recruiting and other materials that promote the mission of the program and Fuller Seminary.
7. Advocate for diverse representation throughout all sectors of the seminary.
8. Serve as a center, in conjunction with and under the guidance of the Alumni Office, to maintain a healthy relationship with Fuller Alums and keep them abreast of the state of the African American Church Studies Program.
9. Work with the campus community to integrate African American traditions into the total life of the seminary to include worship experiences.
10. Develop and maintain a list of scholars who specialize in African American religious experiences.³⁸

The foregoing discussion suggests that the 1970s constituted what might be called “an embryonic and/or experimental stage” in the development of programs in Black Church Studies in predominantly white divinity schools and seminaries. Perhaps more than the initiatives at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, the Graduate Theological Union, Garrett Theological Seminary, and Duke Divinity School, the Fuller experiment in Black Church Studies attested to this. The same might be said, perhaps more emphatically, of the ultimately unsuccessful efforts to create a Black Church Studies program that would involve the major divinity schools and seminaries in the Boston area in the early 1970s. Preston N. Williams, who became the Martin Luther King, Jr. Professor of Social Ethics at Boston University in the late 1960s, was in the forefront of such efforts. Williams was among the first African American academics to promote Black Church Studies as a vital part of theological education in mostly white divinity school and seminary settings, but his activities in pursuit of this initiative at Boston University were frustrated by a lack of programmatic funding and support.³⁹ Williams left Boston to become the Houghton Research Professor of Theology at Harvard Divinity School in 1971 and was replaced by Gayraud S. Wilmore, who brought similar concerns to his position as the Martin Luther King, Jr. Professor of Social Ethics at Boston.⁴⁰

In 1972–1973, Williams and Wilmore, along with other Black faculty, brought together Black students from the Boston School of Theology, Harvard Divinity School, Episcopal Divinity School, and Andover Newton Theological School, and actually offered what was the very first seminar in Black Church Studies. Interestingly enough, this effort, employing the same design as that embraced at GTU three years earlier, promised to be the second ongoing Black Church Studies program in a consortium of seminaries. But, again, the financial and moral support required to keep it going did not come from the institutions involved. Be that as it may, the struggle to integrate Black Church Studies into the curricula of divinity schools and seminaries in and around Boston was part of a national quest and, thus, could not be separated from what was occurring with Henry Mitchell at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, W. Hazaiah Williams at GTU, Hycle Taylor at Garrett, Joseph Bethea at Duke, William Pannell at Fuller, and, in the late 1970s, Zan W. Holmes, Jr. at Perkins School of Theology in Dallas.⁴¹ But the divinity schools and seminaries in the Boston

area never developed a whole curriculum around Black Church Studies. Their contributions to the field were limited to a course here and there on Black church history and Black theology and to ongoing forums with local Black pastors.

The various commitments to Black Church Studies in the 1970s found expression on many levels, even as questions loomed regarding the need for well-funded programs in that field. At places like Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries and Garrett Theological Seminary (became Garrett-Evangelical Seminary in 1974), some detected the results of those commitments in the gradual but significant increases in Black faculty, trustees, administrative staff, and students. Relations between students and faculty-student relationships were reshaped and redefined in profound ways as Black seminarians and divinity school students organized their own distinct groups and caucuses, demanded autonomous rights, pressed for more scholarship aid for Black students and funding and moral support for Black Church Studies, and took other steps which made white faculty and students feel uncomfortable and isolated.⁴²

Through their programs in Black Church Studies, Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, the Graduate Theological Union, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, Duke Divinity School, and Fuller Theological Seminary sought, in their own distinct ways, to adapt their curricula to the particular needs of Black pastors and the Black church, while, at the same time, challenging the deeply ingrained attitudes of white faculty, students, and clergypersons. This was indeed one of the greatest challenges confronting predominantly white divinity schools and seminaries that developed Black Church Studies initiatives in the 1970s. The curricula at the aforementioned institutions, with the exception of Fuller, were redesigned to incorporate courses in the Black Parish, Black Church History, Black Biblical Hermeneutics, Black Pastoral Care, and Black Liberation Theology. In part, this meant that the kind of scholarly treatments of the Black religious experience projected decades before by DuBois, Woodson, Frazier, and other pioneers in the field, and more recently by James H. Cone, J. Deotis Roberts, Henry H. Mitchell, Edward P. Wimberly, and others, were taken seriously for the first time in predominantly white theological institutions.⁴³

Because Fuller's program was tailored largely to the needs of Black pastors who did not have bachelor degrees, the emphasis throughout much of the 1970s was on getting Black students acclimated to the basics, such as reading, writing, and composition. In other words, students were exposed not so much to social-scientific studies of the Black church, Black biblical hermeneutics, Black pastoral care, and Black liberation theology, but to writing and research techniques and how to use the library. In Fuller's case, then, Black Church Studies was not as integral to the seminary curriculum, and there was far less of a conscious effort to understand the Christian faith from an interracial and intercultural perspective and to shape a type of theological education appropriate to the needs of Black churches. This policy would change slightly in the 1980s and significantly by the 1990s, when Fuller's curriculum allowed for course offerings in Black urban ministries, the training of lay counselors in the African American Church, Black spirituality, Afrocentric biblical hermeneutics, Black pastoral counseling, African American church administration, Black preaching, and the history of the African American religious experience. The first course in Black theology was recently introduced into the curriculum.⁴⁴

Some of the programs in Black Church Studies sponsored curriculum design projects, institutes, conferences, visiting professorships, and special lectureships as an added dimension of their efforts to train Black pastors for leadership for the church and the broader society. In June 1975, the program at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer, through a three-year project funded by the Irwin-Sweeney-Miller Foundation, awarded doctor of ministry degrees to 31 candidates, 19 of whom were prominent Black pastors. Henry Mitchell, the dean of the Black Church Studies movement, served as the project's director.⁴⁵ "The overall purpose of the organization of the Martin Luther King Fellows, Inc.," as this doctor of ministry group was

labeled, "was to produce a series of books, journal articles, and monographs on the professional practice of ministry in the African American community."⁴⁶

In 1976, the Mordecai Wyatt Johnson Institute of Religion was started in connection with Black Church Studies at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, and it was to function as part of a continuing effort on the part of Black seminarians and pastors to engage in study and dialogue around urban violence, drug addiction, and other issues of significance to the Black church and community.⁴⁷ In 1977, a year later, the Institute for Black Religious Research, under the directorship of Larry G. Murphy, began as part of Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary's focus on African American religious life and culture. In that same year, Garrett's Black Church Studies program held one of the first major conferences on Black women in ministry.⁴⁸ Martin Luther King, Jr. lectures and other special lectureships with a focus on various aspects of congregational life and culture were occasionally sponsored under the auspices of most of the extant programs in Black Church Studies throughout the 1970s.

Most Black Church Studies programs in the 1970s sponsored educational activities and special events for the involvement of both Black and white students and faculty and for the larger church community as well. In 1979, Gayraud Wilmore, the director of Black Church Studies at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, reported that "Mutual respect and understanding" between the races "at our school have been enhanced by a project in Black church leadership and faculty development, funded by the Lilly Endowment, which for two years brought together 'non-seminary' Black pastors and white professors for intensive weekly dialogue and cross-fertilization." While such projects were a rarity in theological education at that time, Black Church Studies programs sponsored other activities and events in which Blacks and whites could engage each other on what Wilmore termed "a deep level of understanding and partnership."⁴⁹

Interracial and ecumenical worship and prayer services, which were a marked feature of life at Fuller Theological Seminary, became quite common in all of the institutions in which such programs existed. Annual Martin Luther King Day celebrations occurred, bringing together Black and white students and faculty at Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer, the Graduate Theological Union, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, and Duke Divinity School. The Martin Luther King, Jr. Consultation of Black Theological Scholars, a product of Garrett's Office of the Church and the Black Experience, was genuinely open to the entire seminary community, and the lectures honoring King and Wilbur Christian Harr were held jointly in 1978.⁵⁰ This was not simply about ecumenism and interracial cooperation as ends in themselves. Such efforts actually grew out of the conviction that whites had much to learn from Black Church Studies and that a proper engagement between the Black church experience and white seminary and divinity school communities was essential for all who desired and hoped to be prepared for effective ministry and mission in the larger world.⁵¹

But despite all of the commitments and investments in time, energy, and resources, the state of Black Church Studies programs at the end of the 1970s left much to be desired, in part because of the scarcity of programmatic funds and support. "Black church studies is doing well enough where it exists," wrote Gayraud Wilmore in 1979. "The problem is that in too many of the so-called leading theological schools in the United States it simply doesn't exist." "And since the effort is well worth the trouble," he continued, "it is to the shame of the academic community that such a state of affairs is allowed to continue." Noting that "we are still the oddities," Wilmore identified much of the problem as one of conceptual clarity and of defending the academic legitimacy of Black church studies in a society stunted by the tragic legacy of white supremacy:

Even our colleagues are not really sure of what we are about. Fewer than 100 full-time Black professors work in 186 predominantly white, accredited seminaries, and no more than a

dozen of them are involved in programs designed for the academic study of the religions of Afro-American people and the special needs of the Black church. American theological schools have given only a polite nod in the direction of Black religious scholarship, and five predominantly Black seminaries employ almost half of the full-time Black faculty.⁵²

Wilmore elaborated the point at greater length, explaining the enormity of the challenge that confronted Black scholars, professors, and students:

no one here thinks that we are safely out of the woods in regard to the problem Black studies face at a predominantly white seminary. Well meaning persons, within the institution as well as outside it, will doubtlessly continue to ask: "What is Black religion? Why Black theology? Why a Black church studies program?" The questions are admissible, and those of us who have chosen to study for a degree or to teach in a predominantly white seminary should be willing and able to wrestle continually with them in order to give account of our stewardship.⁵³

At the end of the 1970s, Wilmore identified several "tension points between Black Church Studies and the predominantly white seminary," all of which had to be seriously considered and addressed if programs in Black Church Studies were to achieve legitimacy and respectability. One "is the fact that, like no other area of the curriculum," Black Church Studies "programs involve a certain deference to the real and/or imagined power of the Black church, the largest and most influential mass-based institution that is 'owned and operated' by Black people." Thus, "however 'nonideological'" such programs "are expected to be by white administrators and faculty," Wilmore added, they "are oriented to an ethnic-specific institution—one in which a vast majority of the clergy have had to struggle against white institutions and agencies to maintain their self respect and deal with the problems of ministry in the ghetto."⁵⁴

Second, Wilmore asserted that "any respectable Black church studies program" necessarily had to assume the "formidable assignment" of examining, interpreting, and teaching the values of the Black religious tradition by attempting to translate that tradition into the normative concepts, terminology, and disciplines of a national academic community which is mainly white, middle class, and committed to the traditions of British and continental theological scholarship.⁵⁵

"Not only must the religious experience of Black people be translated into the thought-forms of the white theological seminary," said Wilmore, in identifying a third point of tension, "but it must then be communicated back to that massive institution to which it is partly responsible—the Black church—in such a way that the folk are able to recognize a compatibility between what the seminary espouses and the reality of their historic faith and condition." Wilmore was absolutely convinced that "Black church studies" could not "escape standing muster" before "Aunt Jane" and "the thousands of Black preachers who are already out there in the community and who exercise determinative power in their denominations."⁵⁶ Such observations could not have been more perceptive and timely in a period in which a deep chasm existed between predominantly white theological institutions and the Black church, and between what Black theologians were writing and what Black congregants were affirming on Sunday mornings.

Finally, Wilmore insisted that Black Church Studies had to make "the Black religious inheritance" and its contributions "to the shape of American Christianity" available "to the entire theological education enterprise, if not to the denominations themselves." This would involve, he maintained, not only making "Black church studies invaluable for the education of white as well as Black seminarians," but also making known "its implications for interracial cooperation in mission," a particularly demanding task in view of the pervasiveness and intransigence of white supremacist attitudes and structures.⁵⁷ For Black Church Studies programs, accomplishing such goals invariably meant challenging what Wilmore called "the largely white-determined

disciplines of American theological education,” which largely rendered the religious reality of African Americans invisible.⁵⁸

Milton C. Sernett would later contribute to a greater understanding of the problem with his focus on what he called “the invisibility question” in Black Church Studies. Throughout the 1970s, and even earlier, professors, scholars, and students in Black Church Studies had to constantly face the claim that there was an inadequacy of sources and resources for achieving what they desired in the field.⁵⁹ The Society for the Study of Black Religion, which brought together African American scholars in religion and theology, was organized in 1970 not primarily as a response to this claim, but as organizational support for the conviction that serious and productive scholarship in Black Church Studies was indeed a possible and worthwhile endeavor.⁶⁰

The aforementioned problems and challenges confronting Black Church Studies programs would extend, in one form or another, throughout the 1980s and 1990s. The issue of academic legitimacy as it relates to such programs was continuously raised, and programmatic funds for purchasing books, sponsoring conferences, and implementing other activities remained scarce in some cases and virtually non-existent in others. Even so, a few new programs in Black Church Studies originated in the 1980s. In 1983–1984, Gayraud S. Wilmore, who had directed the program at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries for almost a decade, assumed leadership in making Black Church Studies a significant part of the offerings at New York Theological Seminary (NYTS), with a special focus on the urban church. Wilmore went to NYTS to self-consciously develop Black Church Studies at a time when the institution was becoming predominantly Black in student body, and he, as dean of the Master of Divinity Program and professor of Afro-American Studies, remained there until 1987. George W. Webber, the president of NYTS, was very supportive of the idea that the institution should make the transition from the model of the old biblical seminary to the new urban seminary, with special attention to the Black church.⁶¹

But because NYTS viewed itself as essentially a Black seminary, it, like Payne Theological Seminary, Howard School of Divinity, and other traditionally Black theological schools, did not see itself as having the need to officially create a program in Black Church Studies. In any event, the program that emerged with Wilmore has continued down to the present time. Harold Dean Trulear, who holds a PhD from Drew University, followed Wilmore, and, over time, African American professors and scholars such as Hillary Gaston, Sr., Edward L. Hunt, and Obery M. Hendricks, Jr. have taught at NYTS.⁶²

In 1985, yet another development occurred in the general crusade to make Black Church Studies a significant force in theological education. The Kelly Miller Smith Institute on Black Church Studies was inaugurated at Vanderbilt Divinity School (VDS) in Nashville, Tennessee, in April of that year. The program was established in memory of Kelly Miller Smith, Sr., a Baptist pastor who had also served as an assistant dean of Vanderbilt Divinity School from 1968 until his death in 1984. Smith had worked closely with the civil rights movement in Nashville and with Martin Luther King, Jr., and the institute on Black Church Studies at VDS was designed to perpetuate “his legacy of theological and academic excellence and prophetic witness” and also to bring “Black churches, the Black community, and the Divinity School into partnership to study and examine faith and ministry issues in the Black churches.” Because there was a pressing need “to promote educational opportunities for leaders in the Black churches,” a certificate program in Black Church Studies was instituted, primarily “to assist pastors, laity, and Divinity School students in broadening their understanding of ministry in the Black church.”⁶³ Courses in Black church history, Black theology, and other areas of the African American religious experience increased at VDS and were also opened to students, pastors, and the laity.

Two professors at VDS were appointed by Dean Jack Forstman to coordinate the program until a director could be found. They were Peter Paris, an African American of East Canadian

background and a professor of Social Ethics, and Walter Harrelson, a white gentleman with a Distinguished Professorship in Old Testament. At the inaugural event for the Kelly Miller Smith Institute on Black Church Studies, Paris offered the following observations:

I am hoping that the event will bring together in a significant way large numbers of people from the Black churches and the community at large with the Divinity School community in order to generate a new, on-going commitment to our understandings of the thought and mission of the Black churches. This was the primary function that Kelly Miller Smith played in the Divinity School, and we want to perpetuate that function through this institute.⁶⁴

Paris left VDS for Princeton Theological Seminary in the fall of 1985, and Lewis V. Baldwin, an African American and an assistant professor in Church History in Vanderbilt's Department of Religious Studies, became an acting coordinator, along with Harrelson, of the institute.⁶⁵ In 1988, Forrest E. Harris, Sr., a Black Baptist pastor who had studied with both Kelly Miller Smith and Peter Paris, became the director of the Kelly Miller Smith Institute on Black Church Studies, a position he has held up to this point. Harris, who received his doctor of ministry degree from Vanderbilt, brought to the program an intense interest in both the academy and the Black parish. One of his first steps involved sponsoring a conference on "The Religious Thought of Kelly Miller Smith," an event at which Paris delivered two lectures.⁶⁶

Over the next two decades, the Kelly Miller Smith Institute (KMSI) developed programs and sponsored numerous other conferences, covering issues such as theological education in African American congregations, ministry with children and youth in the Black church, South African apartheid, pastoral care in the Black church, Black women and ministry, homosexuality, and the Black church.⁶⁷ In 2001, the KMSI and the American Baptist College, a historically Black institution in Nashville, were awarded "a generous grant from the Lilly Endowment, Inc." to "strengthen theological education in African American congregations across the country" and "to develop a model for theological education to enhance the social ministry of the local church."⁶⁸ In September 2004, the institute was heavily involved in the sponsoring of a consultation on African American Religions and Black Church Studies at Vanderbilt Divinity School, an event that drew together accomplished scholars in the field, among whom were Victor Anderson, Lewis Baldwin, Dennis C. Dickerson, Brad Braxton, Riggins R. Earl, Jr., William Hart, Anthony B. Pinn, Eddie S. Glaude, Jr., Dianne Stewart, and Dwight N. Hopkins.⁶⁹ In April 2006, a major conference on the Black church and public policy occurred under the auspices of the KMSI at Vanderbilt, an event that attracted pastors, laypersons, public officials, and scholars for presentations and discussions.⁷⁰

Programs in Black Church Studies began at Ashland Theological Seminary (ATS) in Ashland, Ohio, and Candler School of Theology at Emory University in 1989. The program at Ashland was started by William H. Myers, who held a PhD in New Testament from the University of Pittsburgh. When Myers went to Ashland Theological Seminary in 1983, a third of the students were Black, but there was no Black Church Studies program. He organized a program in 1989 and offered the first course on African American biblical hermeneutics in 1990.⁷¹ As Myers himself put it, he "set out to organize a Black Church Studies Program that would be comprehensive, addressing the academic needs at every level of matriculation." The program includes a Diploma of Theology in Black Church Studies for ministers and laity who do not have college degrees to get into seminary. Consequently, almost 200 students have gone on to seminary as "special students" after completing the diploma.⁷²

The ATS program also offers a variety of master degrees with concentrations (36 credit hours), or majors and minors (24/12 credit hours respectively), in Black Church Studies. Myers took the position that "Black Church Studies courses should be fully integrated throughout all of the seminary disciplines," thus making it possible for such courses to be available in Bible (African American Biblical Interpretation, Womanist Hermeneutics), Theology

(Black Theology), Church History (History of the Black Church), Practical Theology (Black Preaching, Pastoral Care in the Black Church, Dynamics of the Black Church and Family), and Counseling (Pastoral Counseling in the Black Church). Furthermore, the ATS program includes not only a master of arts degree in Practical Theology, but also a doctor of ministry degree, which sets it apart from some of the aforementioned initiatives in Black Church Studies. The doctoral program consists of three components—foundational courses in Black Theology and African American Biblical Interpretation, personal electives in Preaching in the Black Tradition, Pastoral Care in the Black Church, the Dynamics of the Black Church and the Black Family, and the Life and Thought of Martin Luther King, Jr., and the Final Project in Ministry Application. Myers describes the program as “quite unique,” noting that it is designed to “give the student a geographical, geopolitical, and interdisciplinary experience, while at the same time modeling the importance of collaborative ministry.”⁷³

Myers has remained the only director of the program at Ashland Theological Seminary, which is called the McCreary Center for African American Religious Studies, since its founding. He has collaborated with and employed the services of Black social activists such as Marian Wright Edelman and of guest lecturers and visiting professors and scholars such as Cain Hope Felder, R. Drew Smith, Walter E. Fluker, Dwight Hopkins, and Marvin McMickle.⁷⁴ Moreover, mainly because of the leadership of Myers, the program at Ashland Theological Seminary awards a Diploma of Theology in Black Church Studies for ministers and laypersons who do not have bachelor degrees and who, for whatever reasons, cannot matriculate at a divinity school or seminary.⁷⁵

The Program of Black Church Studies was formally organized at Candler School of Theology in the fall of 1989. Candler’s faculty “appointed a standing Black Church Studies faculty committee and approved ‘A Comprehensive Proposal for Black Church Studies’” at the institution, a proposal which advocated enhancing “the core curriculum by integrating Black studies,” sponsoring “research and programming significant to the study of Black churches,” expanding and deepening “Black church core offerings” and orienting and supporting “Black students during their seminary matriculation.” Candler’s program “was officially inaugurated in the fall of 1990 with two days of events on September 5–6,” highlighted by a major address by Black liberation theologian James H. Cone of New York’s Union Theological Seminary.⁷⁶ A historical sketch underscores the circumstances and considerations that gave rise to the program:

The Black Church Studies Program was initiated in response to student demands in the 1980s for a more holistic commitment to the needs and mission of the Black Church. Faculty, administration, students, and alumni/alumnae have spent considerable energy in the years since discerning how the mission of the Black Church and multiracial congregations and the preparation of leadership for that mission required Candler to respond more inclusively and authentically, arriving at the following conclusions: (1) help students understand the historical influences, the development of movements within the Christian tradition, and the pedagogical perspectives that shape race (and also gender, ethnic, sexual and socio-economic) issues in the Black Church and larger society; (2) help faculty understand how their teaching and scholarship could better reflect needed perspectives on race, racism, and diversity; and (3) help church leaders—Black and white and others—to bear witness to those matters of race that have helped to liberate a people on the one hand and inhibited the church from being a vital witness to inclusive community on the other.⁷⁷

The purpose and goals and/or objectives of the program have been carefully outlined in various issues of the Candler School of Theology catalog over the last two decades. According to a most recent issue, Candler’s Program of Black Church Studies prepares men and women to provide learned, prophetic, and compassionate leadership in Black and multiracial churches; and, educates the entire Candler community about the origins, development,

and contemporary diversity of the Black church tradition. The program also explores religious traditions among peoples of African descent across Africa and the diaspora. . . . The program seeks to integrate Black church studies into foundational courses at Candler and to expand and deepen Black Church Studies courses. The program also seeks to respond to the need for literature in Black religion, in particular the need for primary field research on Black congregational life. The Program of Black Church Studies also sponsors chapel worship, orientation, and supports events as well as an annual series of lectures on Black religious life that include the Howard Thurman Lecture, the Anna Julia Cooper Lecture, and the Bishop James S. Thomas Lecture.⁷⁸

The first director of Candler's Black Church Studies program was Robert M. Franklin, an assistant professor of Ethics and Society at the institution. Steeped in Pentecostalism and trained at the University of Chicago, Franklin brought to the program the dynamism of a master preacher and the erudition of a first-rate scholar. Franklin was followed by Noel L. Erskine, an associate professor of Theology and Ethics with roots in the Caribbean. Erskine served as interim director in 1995–1996, a period during which "Candler took the innovative step of approving a certification component," thus underscoring the institution's "strength of commitment to the program." Erskine was succeeded by two other interim directors, Rosetta E. Ross and Teresa L. Fry Brown. Alton B. Pollard III, an associate professor of Religion and Culture, who holds a PhD from Duke University, was installed as the director of Candler's program in 1998, a position he occupied up to July 2007.⁷⁹ Under Pollard's strong leadership, Candler's program achieved a high level of prominence and visibility in the Black Church Studies field. Pollard's central role in planning and implementing a National Black Church Studies Forum at Candler, in the winter of 2006, has done much to publicize the program on a national scale. The same might be said, but perhaps to a lesser extent, of the National Black Church Studies Forum that occurred at Vanderbilt Divinity School a year later.⁸⁰

Since its inception, Candler's program has sought to meet its goals and/or objectives "in a multitude of ways," such as through seminars, guest speakers, the occasional sponsorship of conferences, attending conferences organized around Black church themes, leading and engaging the community in discussions that seek to influence institutional policy on recruitment, hiring and retention, curriculum planning and teaching, and the advancement or research, scholarship, and teaching. A significant feature of the program is its Certificate in Black Church Studies, which was first awarded in 1996 and which "provides students an opportunity to develop in-depth academic and practical knowledge about Black religious life and culture." Alton Pollard declares that

The Program of Black Church Studies has been intentional in responding to the interests of our certificate students and to the distinctive needs of students of African descent, including those from Africa, the Caribbean, the United States, and the broader diaspora, alumni and alumnae. We are no less intentional in offering more expansive visions of a Black religious future.⁸¹

In the 1980s and 1990s, the Black Church Studies programs at New York Theological Seminary, Vanderbilt Divinity School, Ashland Theological Seminary, and the Candler School of Theology were emerging while those at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, and the Graduate Theological Union were declining. For most of the programs that dated back to the late 1960s and early 1970s, there were scarcely enough funds to support annual Martin Luther King Day events or to sponsor conferences or visiting lectureships here and there. There was not much of a program at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries when Walter E. Fluker was brought in as its dean and Martin Luther King, Jr.

Memorial professor in 1991.⁸² The program at the Graduate Theological Union actually ceased to be in 1993, a year before it was officially dismantled.⁸³ The programs at Garrett-Evangelical Seminary and Duke Divinity School functioned with insufficient programmatic funds. The program at Fuller Theological Seminary was actually the only one to show signs of new life in the 1990s, as it, despite limited resources, took greater shape with a wider range of course offerings in African American church studies.⁸⁴

The declining significance of certain Black Church Studies programs in the academy paralleled the ascendancy of programs in women's studies. As early as the 1970s, women's studies began to take shape in divinity schools and seminaries and, by the 1980s and 1990s, were competing with programs in Black Church Studies for the few available funds and other resources. Such competition was quite evident at times in institutions like Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, and Vanderbilt Divinity School.⁸⁵ In some cases, this spirit of competitiveness significantly influenced how white seminarians and divinity school students related to programs in Black Church Studies.

Although the various Black Church Studies programs had contributed much in terms of the promotion of an interracial and intercultural understanding of the faith in theological education, their impact on white faculty and seminarians in the 1980s and 1990s is open to debate. Back in the 1970s, Gayraud Wilmore had predicted that white seminarians and clergy "of the 1980s and 1990s will not be able to escape the ubiquitous reality of the Black church and the power of its witness for the marginated but expanding minority communities of American society."⁸⁶ This prediction proved valid in the case of programs like the one at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, where much effort had been devoted to integrating Black Church Studies into all divisions of the curriculum, despite lingering questions about its academic legitimacy.⁸⁷ But the 1980s were characterized by a rise in religious and political conservatism, a trend that extended through the Ronald Reagan presidency into the 1990s, and the exposure of whites to the power and traditions of the Black church in the seminary and divinity school environments did not translate into radical changes in their local congregational life. In other words, patterns of segregation in the American churches remained essentially what they had been when the first programs in Black Church Studies were assembled.⁸⁸

The beginning of the twenty-first century triggered new questions and ideas and inspired action around the future direction of Black Church Studies among authorities in the field. Activity along these lines occurred at the Vanderbilt Divinity School's "Consultation on African American Religions and Black Church Studies" in April 2004 and at "The National Black Church Studies Forum" held at Candler School of Theology in the winter of 2006. Professors and scholars from various parts of the country were involved in both events.⁸⁹ In 2005, a new Black Church Studies program was founded and shaped at the Brite Divinity School at Texas Christian University in Fort Worth, Texas. Organized and directed by Stacey M. Floyd-Thomas, an associate professor in Ethics, who holds a PhD from Temple University, this program offers an "Introduction to Black Church Studies" course that has to be taken in the first year of study for the master of divinity degree. Courses on Black Theologies, the Black Religious Experience in America, the African American Experience in Social Ethics, and Christian Education in the Black Church are also offered. The purpose and/or objectives of the program are stated in these terms:

A concentration in Black Church studies is available within the Master of Divinity program for (1) seminarians of all races interested in shaping their ministerial preparation and theological reflection to be inclusive of a wider knowledge of, a deeper appreciation for, and increased sensitivity to the issues and exigencies of Black life within American Christianity; and (2) individuals interested in preparing for ministry within a Black Church context and/or

tradition as leaders (pastors, preachers, lay leaders, chaplains, pastoral counselors, campus ministers, Christian educators, etc.).⁹⁰

Some in the field have concluded that the most successful Black Church Studies programs in the country today are at Vanderbilt Divinity School and Candler School of Theology, especially from the standpoint of the availability of resources. But the availability of resources does not always translate into progressive programming. Programs still exist at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, Duke Divinity School, Fuller Theological Seminary, New York Theological Seminary, Ashland Theological Seminary, and Brite Divinity School, but they seem to be operating with less support and resources, and their futures will obviously present many challenges, old and new. Of course, this might be said to some degree about all programs in Black Church Studies. But even those programs that no longer exist, and those that may appear on "the brink of folding," offer what William Myers calls "a history of vanguards that made the way possible when nothing existed at all." In other words, "they show us some early paradigms."⁹¹

A range of issues and concerns must be seriously addressed if Black Church Studies programs are to be relevant, productive, and successful in the future. First, the issue of conceptual clarity must be addressed as it relates to the meaning of the Black church, African American religious thought, and Black Church Studies. In other words, we need to reframe how we view and define these programs. The rise of the mega church phenomenon, with its emphasis on praise and prosperity, and of powerful figures like T. D. Jakes, Eddie Long, Creflo Dollar, and others, has changed the face of the Black church. For Black Church Studies, then, the issue is no longer one of academic legitimacy, but of conceptual clarity. Thus, there is the need to revisit and seriously struggle with questions that have been raised from the very beginning of Black Church Studies: What is the Black church? What is Black religion and Black theology? What should constitute Black Church Studies in divinity school and seminary settings? As Gayraud Wilmore has consistently pointed out in his speeches and writings on Black Church Studies, our tendency has been to either ignore or deny diversity while stressing powerful commonalities within the African American religious experience.⁹² Recent trends in Black church life means that this approach is no longer acceptable or defensible.

Second, new and more creative ways of integrating Black Church Studies into the total curriculum of predominantly white divinity schools and seminaries must be found, especially if white faculty, students, and clergypersons are to be genuinely and permanently influenced and changed for the better. From all indications, most whites in the academy have not yet understood the value of Black Church Studies for their own education, enlightenment, and fulfillment. While much of this is attributable to deeply entrenched white supremacist attitudes and structures, it also speaks to the failure of the academy to reshape curricula so that whites in theological education and the churches can truly understand and celebrate the Christian faith from interracial and multicultural perspectives.⁹³

Third, more needs to be done in terms of bridging the chasm between theological education in the academy and what African Americans believe and affirm in the context of the Black church. In some ways, this harks back to the issue of conceptual clarity. "Aunt Jane" and others in the pews on Sunday morning want to know that their scholars, "whether in the classroom or the study, have been with Jesus and have learned from him the superlative strategy of the Christian life, the message and mission of salvation and liberation." If professors and scholars in the field cannot translate the values and traditions of the Black religious experience into the normative disciplines and concepts of the predominantly white, middle-class divinity and seminary communities, while showing the meaningfulness of those disciplines and concepts for the spiritual and intellectual growth of ordinary church people, then Black Church Studies holds virtually no legitimacy and/or relevance for Black congregations. Mindful of this, William Myers has developed a program at Ashland Theological Seminary in which

“theological education of the best quality and highest degree” takes “place contextually” or “in the Black community” itself. This is accomplished through the McCreary Center for African American Religious Studies in Cleveland, Ohio, a center founded by Myers, and that developed out of the doctor of ministry program at Ashland Theological Seminary. The center is actually located in the inner city of Cleveland, and for some time it offered lectures, seminars, workshops, and courses without accreditation.⁹⁴

Fourth, Black Church Studies programs need to do more in terms of preparing young men and women for special kinds of ministry and mission in Black churches. This relates also to the third point made in the previous paragraph. Highlighting his own disappointment with “seminary graduates whose preaching and public ministries give no hint that they ever earned a Master of Divinity degree,” Gayraud Wilmore declares:

Black liberation theologians and other seminary professors have simply not instructed well enough about how to help ordinary folks in the pews become the vanguard of a new interpretation of that old, old story of Jesus and his love. Nor have our Black seminaries helped. We have not yet been able to come together as educational institutions to define what we mean by African American theological education at all levels of the church's life and how it differs from what is taught in most predominantly white seminaries and universities that have no viable Black Church Studies program. I weep for the men and women I have taught who are out there struggling but who have little to show for what they presumably learned from me and scholars of my generation.

There are, I hasten to say, some prominent exceptions whose names I could call, but they are an unheralded minority in today's climate of charismatic showmanship, biblical literalism, and historical and cultural “know-nothingism.”⁹⁵

Wilmore's comments are quite instructive for professors and scholars working in Black Church Studies in this information age. They reinforce a point made earlier in this essay; namely, the need to reexamine and reframe our thinking and approach regarding Black Church Studies and what it means to prepare young men and women to relevantize the gospel and the biblical revelation in churches on Sunday mornings. Wilmore is essentially calling for a new vision of Black Church Studies.

Fifth, more interaction and collaboration between authorities in Black Church Studies need to occur in order to accomplish goals and/or objectives across institutional and denominational lines. The “Consultation on African American Religions and Black Church Studies” at Vanderbilt Divinity School (2004), “The National Black Church Studies Forum” at Candler School of Theology (2006), and “The National Black Church Studies Forum” at Vanderbilt Divinity School (2007) might serve as models for what could happen in this regard on a wider scale in the future. A model can also be found in the Black Church Studies program at Ashland Theological Seminary, where William Myers, the director, collaborates with The Leadership Center at Morehouse College in Atlanta and the Children's Defense Fund (CDF) at Alex Haley Farm in Clinton, Tennessee. The Ashland Seminary program also partners with the McCreary Center for African American Religious Studies in Cleveland. Myers draws upon his African American colleagues in all disciplines throughout the nation, while rotating the courses from his McCreary Center for African American Religious Studies to the Morehouse and CDF locations. To help facilitate collaborative efforts of this kind, program directors might consider developing a newsletter similar to the one circulated twice annually by Duke Divinity School's Office of Black Church Studies. Referred to as *Gatherings*, this newsletter provides space for information and dialogue for students, alumni, churches, faculty, and staff affiliated with the Office of Black Church Studies and Duke Divinity School. A newsletter of this kind, with more of a geographical outreach and wider circulation, would be an important vehicle for communication between Black Church Studies programs nationwide.⁹⁶

The various directors of Black Church Studies programs have much to learn from a kind of ongoing sharing ideas, especially in light of the different existing models for such programs in predominantly white seminaries and divinity schools. There is the essentially non-degree program at Candler Theological Seminary, which offers certificates. Fuller Theological Seminary affords another model for a predominantly white institution that offered Black Church Studies at one time with no Black faculty. For years, Black faculty from programs at other seminaries and divinity schools were actually brought in for intensive courses at Fuller during the summer. Black faculty were eventually added at Fuller, as indicated previously. The program at Ashland Theological Seminary, according to William Myers, “shows us a model of a comprehensive Black Church Studies program,” which involves “independence and partnership with a seminary, collaboration with other Black colleagues, and institutions and programs” established in the Black community “to impact the academy, church, and community.” Even so, interaction and collaboration between the brightest minds in Black Church Studies would undoubtedly provide answers to some very important and lingering questions that, as Myers points out, continues to confront us: Why are the majority of Black Church Studies programs relegated to ministers, or the ordained? If indeed they are Black Church Studies programs, why are they so confined to the academy? What has happened to the African American community in all of this?⁹⁷

Sixth, Black Church Studies programs ought to establish a degree of independence even as they function in partnership with predominantly white divinity schools and seminaries, an approach strongly advocated by Myers. This approach can enhance any program’s capacity to receive funding and other necessary resources.⁹⁸ Nothing could be more important for Black Church Studies in the future, especially given the deficiencies in programmatic funds and support provided by most white divinity schools and seminaries in the past and up to this point in history.

Finally, Black Church Studies programs might consider doing more with international students. The program at Duke Divinity School offers a model for this. It has developed a partnership with the United Methodist Church in Southern Africa, in which students can participate in field education placements and the “Pilgrimage of Pain and Hope,” which is a study seminar. Duke’s Office of Black Church Studies, currently under the directorship of the Rev. Tiffany Marley, also contributes to the management of such programs in Uganda and Brazil. Leading International Pilgrimages, known as Pilgrimages of Pain and Hope, have become a unique feature of Duke’s program. In 2005, international pilgrimages were made to Uganda and Rwanda, where divinity students were exposed to persons who had survived the genocide of 1994. Pilgrimages to Peru, Brazil, and South Africa have also been made. The program at Emory’s Candler School of Theology has also been involved in international pilgrimages on a smaller scale. Such exposure is essential for students who are preparing to minister to a world that, due to the availability of information and highly sophisticated means of travel and communication, is becoming smaller every day. Moreover, exposure of this nature will become increasingly important as the growth and epicenter of world Christianity shifts from the West toward Africa and Asia.⁹⁹

Hopefully, Black Church Studies programs will remain a critical component of theological education. If Gayraud S. Wilmore is correct, such programs will indeed survive because they have something that “Black studies programs in secular colleges and universities” do not have; namely, a “well-defined external constituency,” or an “institutional base,” in the form of “the Black church itself.”¹⁰⁰ In the meantime, *a luta continua* (“the struggle continues”).

Notes

1. Gayraud S. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” *The Christian Century* (April 11, 1979), 411; Gayraud S. Wilmore, “What is African American Religious

- Studies?," in Gayraud S. Wilmore, ed., *African American Religious Studies: An Interdisciplinary Anthology* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1989), xi–xiv (General Introduction); Gayraud S. Wilmore, *Pragmatic Spirituality: The Christian Faith through an Africentric Lens* (New York: New York University Press, 2004), 15–17; and James H. Evans, Jr., "Black Church Studies and the Theological Curriculum," unpublished statement (n.d.), 1.
2. Evans, "Black Church Studies," 22.
 3. Larry G. Murphy, J. Gordon Melton and Gary L. Ward, eds., *Encyclopedia of African American Religions* (New York: Garland Publishing, Inc., 1993), 358, 362, 376–377, 577–578, and 690.
 4. Wilmore, "What is African American Religious Studies?," xi.
 5. Gayraud S. Wilmore refers to black theology as "the keystone . . . of black church studies." See Wilmore, "Tension Points in Black Church Studies," 412.
 6. Murphy, et. al., eds., *Encyclopedia of African American Religions*, 358, 362, 376–377, 690, and 802–803; and James P. Brawley, *Two Centuries of Methodist Concern: Bondage, Freedom, and Education of Black People* (New York: Vantage Press, 1974), 323–324.
 7. Richard R. Wright, comp., *The Encyclopedia of the African Methodist Episcopal Church* (Philadelphia: The Book Concern of the A. M. E. Church, 1947), 16; and William J. Walls, *The African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church: Reality of the Black Church* (Charlotte, NC: A. M. E. Zion Publishing House, 1974), 318–319.
 8. Wilmore, *Pragmatic Spirituality*, 16.
 9. Wilmore, ed., *African American Religious Studies*, xi (General Introduction).
 10. Frederick A. Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett* (Evanston, IL: Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, 1978), 212–213; Wilmore, "Tension Points in Black Church Studies," 411–413; Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Gayraud S. Wilmore (June 2, 2006); and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Henry H. Mitchell (June 3, 2006).
 11. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
 12. *Colgate Rochester Divinity School—Bexley Hall—Crozer Theological Seminary: Announcements, 1971 (1971–1972)*, 12; Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006); and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Mitchell (June 3, 2006).
 13. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Mitchell (June 3, 2006); *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary, 1983–85*, 28–29; and *Colgate Rochester Crozer Divinity School: 2005–2007 Catalogue*, 24–25.
 14. *Continuity and Contemporaneity: The 1970 Annual Report, Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary* (1970), 4–5 and 10–11.
 15. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Mitchell (June 3, 2006); *Continuity and Contemporaneity: The 1970 Annual Report*, 4; "Major Grant Backs Project for Black Church Studies," in *Bulletin: Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer*, Vol. XLIV, no. 3 (March 1972), 1; *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: Catalog, 1973–75*, 20; *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: Catalog, 1983–85*, 28–29; *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: The Divinity School Catalog, 1991–93*, 28; and *Colgate Rochester Crozer Divinity School: 2005–2007 Catalogue*, 24.
 16. Ella P. and Henry H. Mitchell, *Together for Good: Lessons from Fifty-Five Years of Marriage* (Kansas City: Andrews McMeel Publishing, 1999), 213; Murphy, et. al., eds., *Encyclopedia of African American Religions*, 502; and "Wilmore Leads Black Church Studies," *Bulletin: Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer*, Vol. XLVI, no. 4 (June 1974), 1–2.
 17. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Walter E. Fluker (August 5, 2006); *Colgate Rochester Divinity School: 2005–2007 Catalogue*, 91; and Lewis V. Baldwin Personal Interview with Adrienne L. Phillips (February 12, 2007).
 18. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Larry G. Murphy (August 6, 2006); Lucinda Glenn, "A Brief History of the GTU," *The GTU Advantage* (2006), 2. Accessed July 17, 2015 at <https://web.archive.org/web/20060630005534/http://www.gtu.edu/page.php?nav=13>; "Paid Death Notices: Williams, W. Hazaiah, The Rev. Dr.," *The New York Times* (April 28, 1999); and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Dorsey O. Blake (August 11, 2006).

19. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Murphy (August 6, 2006); James A. Donahue, "What Ought We Do? Who Ought We Be?: The Ethics of Theological Education," an Inaugural Address to the GTU Community and Friends on February 15, 2001, in *The GTU Advantage* (2006), 5; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Blake (August 11, 2006).
20. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Murphy (August 6, 2006). The Center for Black Urban Studies was actually inaugurated on January 15, 1969, Martin Luther King, Jr.'s birthday, and it can make a convincing claim of being the very first Black Church Studies program. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Blake (August 11, 2006).
21. Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 214–215; and Edsel A. Ammons, "A Tribute," in *The Black Who's Who at Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary: The Church and the Black Experience Bulletin*, (Evanston, IL: Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, 1977), 2.
22. Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 215–218; and "CBE Celebrates Ten Years at G-ETS," in *Aware: News and Information for Alumni and Friends of Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary* 4 (Fall, 1980), 4.
23. *The Garrett-Evangelical Catalog*, 1974–75, Vol. 1, no. 2 (September 1974), 7; *The Garrett-Evangelical Catalog*, 1975–76, Vol. 1, no. 3 (September 1975), 9; *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary Catalog*, 1976–77, Vol. 1, no. 4 (September 1976), 10; Hycel B. Taylor, Larry G. Murphy, Phillip A. Harly and Carl H. Marbury, "Prologemon to a Theological Response to Roots," *The Church and the Black Experience Bulletin: Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary*, Contemporary Issues Bulletin Series I (February 1977), ii; Merlyn W. Northfelt, *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary: The President's Annual Report, Academic Year 1977–78*, (Evanston, IL: Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary, 1978), 4; and Ammons, "A Tribute," 2. "The Garrett-Evangelical emphasis upon preparing black clergy," stated one source in the 1970s, "places it among the first seminaries to recognize the centrality of the Black church in the history of Black people." See *The Church and the Black Experience at Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary: A Bulletin* (n.d.), 3.
24. *The Garrett-Evangelical Catalog*, 1974–75, 7; *The Garrett-Evangelical Catalog*, 1975–76, 9; Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 122–123, 218, and 235; and "CBE Celebrates Ten Years at G-ETS," 4.
25. "CBE Celebrates Ten Years at G-ETS," 4; "Introducing the New Director of CBE: Dr. Philip A. Harley," *The Church and Black Experience Newsletter*, Vol. 4, no. 2 (Fall, 1980), 4; *The Church and the Black Experience Newsletter*, Vol. 2, no. 1 (1980), 15; and *The Church and the Black Experience News*, Vol. 3, no. 1 (1980), 9–11.
26. *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary Catalog* (September 1980), 26; *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary Catalog* (September 1982), 26 and 47; *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary: Academic Bulletin*, 2005–2007, 57; and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Larry G. Murphy (August 6, 2006).
27. The events in Greensboro are treated in Clayborne Carson, *In Struggle: SNCC and the Black Awakening of the 1960s* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1981), 9–11 and 215. Dr. Karen Collier, who was pursuing graduate studies at Duke, recalled that civil rights activities did influence developments toward a Black Church Studies initiative. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Karen Y. Collier (August 1, 2006).
28. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with William C. Turner (August 7, 2006).
29. *Resources for Students of Color at Duke Divinity School: A Guide to Maximizing Your Seminary Experience*, 2005–2006, Issue III (Durham: Office of Black Church Studies at Duke Divinity School, 2005), 1; Baldwin Telephone Interview with Collier (August 1, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Turner (August 7, 2006); and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Raymond R. Sommerville, Jr. (August 7, 2006).
30. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Collier (August 1, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Turner (August 7, 2006); Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 180 and 215; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Sommerville (August 7, 2006).
31. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Collier (August 1, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Turner (August 7, 2006); and *Resources for Students of Color at Duke Divinity School*, 2005–2006, 1.

32. Richard Quebedeaux, *The Young Evangelicals: The Story of the Emergence of a New Generation of Evangelicals* (New York: Harper & Row, Publishers, 1974), 116; Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Ralph C. Watkins (July 24, 2006); Ralph C. Watkins' E-Mail Response to Lewis V. Baldwin (August 7, 2006); Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Anthea D. Butler (August 7, 2006); and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with William Pannell (August 8, 2006).
33. George M. Marsden, *Reforming Fundamentalism: Fuller Seminary and the New Evangelicalism* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1987), 264; Quebedeaux, *The Young Evangelicals*, 116; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Pannell (August 8, 2006).
34. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Watkins (July 24, 2006); Watkins' E-Mail Response to Baldwin (August 7, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Butler (August 7, 2006); Marsden, *Reforming Fundamentalism*, 264; Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Larry D. George (August 7, 2006); and Candace Shields, "Fuller Theological Seminary: African American Church Studies Program," an unpublished one-page document (2006), 1.
35. Watkins' E-Mail Response to Baldwin (August 7, 2006); and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Watkins (July 24, 2006). Also check the website for Fuller Theological Seminary's African American Church Studies Program at <http://www.fuller.edu/afam.asp>.
36. Marsden, *Reforming Fundamentalism*, 264. Unfortunately, Marsden gives far too little attention to Fuller's program in African American Church Studies.
37. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Watkins (July 24, 2006); Watkins' E-Mail Response to Baldwin (August 7, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Butler (August 7, 2006); and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Henry H. Mitchell (March 15, 2007).
38. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Watkins (July 24, 2006); and Watkins' E-Mail Response to Baldwin (August 7, 2006). This ten-step statement of mission objectives can be obtained through Fuller's African American Church Studies Program. It can be contacted via e-mail at afam-studies@dept.fuller.edu.
39. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
40. Murphy, et. al., eds., *Encyclopedia of African American Religions*, 846; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
41. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
42. Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 216–218; Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006); and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Mitchell (June 3, 2006).
43. *Continuity and Contemporaneity: The 1970 Annual Report*, 4–5; *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: Announcements, 1971*, 5–14; *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: Catalog, 1973–75*, 20–46; Baldwin Telephone Interview with Murphy (August 6, 2006); *The Garrett-Evangelical Catalog, 1974–75*, 7 and 63–97; *The Garrett-Evangelical Catalog, 1975–76*, 9 and 65–101; *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary Catalog, 1976–77*, 10 and 45–57; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Turner (August 7, 2006).
44. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Pannell (August 8, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Butler (August 7, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Watkins; "African American Church Studies Course Offerings, 1995–2005," Fuller Theological Seminary, unpublished document, 1–3; "African American Church Studies Concentration & Course Offerings Prior to March 31, 2006," Fuller Theological Seminary, unpublished document, 1.
45. "69 Receive School's Degrees; MLK Fellows Earn D. Mins.," *Bulletin: Colgate Rochester/Bexley Hall/Crozer*, Vol. XLVII, no. 4 (June 1975), 1.
46. *Mo' Better Newsletter, Sponsored by the Program of Black Church Studies at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary* (Spring, 1992), 1; and "69 Receive School's Degrees; MLK Fellows Earn D. Mins.," 1.
47. "The Black Church: Where Do We Go from Here," *Program Booklet*, The National Conference of Black Seminarians, hosted by the Mordecai Wyatt Johnson Institute of Religion (March 14–17, 1984), 1–38; and "The Vision of Hope Unfolds: A Community's Response to Urban Violence," *Program Booklet*, The Sixteenth Annual Mordecai Wyatt Johnson Institute of Religion,

- sponsored by the Office of Black Church Studies and the Black Student Caucus (March 9–11, 1993), 1–2.
48. *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary Catalog, 1976–77*, 17; “New Center Will Focus on Black Religious Life,” *Aware: News and Information for Alumni and Friends of Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary* (Fall, 1977), 4; Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 219; “News Notes,” *Aware: News and Information for Alumni and Friends of Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary* (Spring, 1980), 5; *Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary: The President’s Annual Report, 1977–78*, 6; “Progress Report: Institutes and Projects,” *The Church and the Black Experience Newsletter*, Vol. 2, no. 1, 1–2; and Alice Wiley, “Black Women in Ministry Conference,” *CBE: The Church and the Black Experience Newsletter*, Vol. 1, no. 1 (1977), 1.
 49. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413; and “Alternative Studies Initiated for Area Black Clergy,” *Bulletin: Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary*, Vol. LII, no. 2 (January 1980), 2.
 50. Baldwin Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006); Norwood, *From Dawn to Midday at Garrett*, 218–219; “The Black Religious Experience: Retrospect, Aspect, and Prospect,” *Program Booklet*, The Third Annual Martin Luther King, Jr. Consultation of Black Theological Scholars, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary (April 1–2, 1976), 1–4; “Race Relations: Where are We Headed?,” *Program Booklet for the Wilbur Christian Harr Lectures and the Martin Luther King, Jr. Consultation*, Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary (April 4–5, 1978), 1–4; and Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413.
 51. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
 52. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411 and 413; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
 53. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
 54. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
 55. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411.
 56. *Ibid.*
 57. *Ibid.*; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006).
 58. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413.
 59. See Milton C. Sernett, ed., *Afro-American Religious History: A Documentary Witness* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1985), 1–2.
 60. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411; and James H. Cone, *For My People—Black Theology and the Black Church: Where Have We Been and Where Are We Going?* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1984), 25–26.
 61. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006); Murphy, et. al., eds., *Encyclopedia of African American Religions*, 846; and Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Gayraud S. Wilmore (August 11, 2006).
 62. *New York Theological Seminary Catalog, 2006–2008* (New York: New York Theological Seminary, 2005), 57–59; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (August 11, 2006).
 63. *The Bulletin of Vanderbilt University Divinity School, 2004–2005*, Vol. 104, no. 2 (July 2004), 11 and 49; Dale A. Johnson, ed., *Vanderbilt Divinity School: Education, Contest, and Change* (Nashville: Vanderbilt University Press, 2001), 20, 192, 244–245, 250, and 396 n12; and “Smith’s Legacy Perpetuated in Institute Inauguration,” *The Spire: Vanderbilt Divinity School and Oberlin Graduate School of Theology*, Vol. 10, no. 1 (Spring, 1985), 4.
 64. Until his death on June 3, 1984, Kelly Miller Smith, also a lecturer in church and ministries at Vanderbilt Divinity School, “planned and presided over the annual Conference on the Black Church.” “These conferences,” according to one source, “brought together the Black Church and the local community as partners with the Divinity School and the University in the analysis

- and pursuit of critical issues confronting both university and community.” See “Smith’s Legacy Perpetuated in Institute Inauguration,” 4.
65. *Continuing Studies Classes: Vanderbilt Divinity School, September 1986–May 1987*, a brochure (1986), 10; and *Continuing Studies Classes: Vanderbilt Divinity School, September 1987–April 1988*, a brochure (1987), 11.
 66. Johnson, ed., *Vanderbilt Divinity School*, 250–251. As colleagues at the same university, Forrest Harris and the author of this essay have discussed the KMSI on the Black Church on numerous occasions and have participated together in many of its programs and/or conferences.
 67. Forrest E. Harris, Sr. to Lewis V. Baldwin (June 28, 2001); “Smith Institute: Enrich Ministry with Children,” *The Spire: Vanderbilt University Divinity School and Oberlin Graduate School of Theology*, Vol. 11, no. 3 (Winter/Spring, 1987), 6–7; “Smith Institute: King’s Vision Invoked,” *The Spire*, Vol. 11, no. 1 (Spring, 1986), 7–8; “Focus on Pastoral Care in the Black Church,” *The Spire*, Vol. 11, no. 2 (Summer/Fall, 1986), 6.
 68. Harris to Baldwin (June 28, 2001).
 69. See Forrest E. Harris, et. al., “Notes on the African American Religions and Black Church Studies Consultation at Vanderbilt University,” unpublished document (September 9–10, 2004), 1–139; and “Linking the Academy with the Black Church,” *The Spire: Vanderbilt Divinity School, Graduate Department of Religion, and Oberlin Graduate School of Theology*, Vol. 25, no. 1 (Fall, 2004), 23.
 70. Forrest E. Harris, Sr. to Lewis V. Baldwin (August 22, 2005); and E-Mail Message from Sha’Tika Shavon Brown to Lewis V. Baldwin concerning the Program for the Church and Public Policy Conference of the KMSI (March 29, 2006).
 71. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with William H. Myers (July 18, 2006).
 72. E-Mail Message from William H. Myers to Lewis V. Baldwin (January 22, 2007), 1–2.
 73. William H. Myers, “Doctoral Program in Black Church Studies,” unpublished document (2006), 1; Baldwin Telephone Interview with Myers (July 18, 2006); and E-Mail Message from Myers to Baldwin, 1–2.
 74. William H. Myers, “Doctor of Ministry Classes in Black Church Studies, September 2006–July 2007,” unpublished document (2006), 1; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Myers (July 18, 2006).
 75. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Myers (July 18, 2006).
 76. Alton B. Pollard III, “The Program of Black Church Studies at Candler School of Theology, Emory University,” unpublished document, which appeared in the *Fifteenth Anniversary Celebration Program Booklet for Black Church Studies* (2005), 1.
 77. Pollard, “The Program of Black Church Studies at Candler,” 1.
 78. *Candler School of Theology—Emory Catalog, 2005–2006*, 33; and Pollard, “The Program of Black Church Studies at Candler,” 1.
 79. Pollard, “The Program of Black Church Studies at Candler,” 1; and *Candler School of Theology—Emory Catalog, 2005–2006*, 33.
 80. E-Mail Message from Alton B. Pollard III to Lewis V. Baldwin (February 2, 2006), 1; “Black Church Studies: Prospects and Implications for Academia, Church & Society,” unpublished *Program of the National Black Church Studies Forum*, Candler School of Theology, Emory University Conference Center, Atlanta, Georgia (January 31–February 2, 2006), 1–3; and E-Mail from Alton B. Pollard III to Lewis V. Baldwin (February 7, 2006), 1.
 81. Pollard, “The Program of Black Church Studies at Candler,” 1; and *Candler School of Theology—Emory Catalog, 2005–2006*, 33.
 82. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Walter E. Fluker (June 4, 2006). The rate of decline of the program at Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminaries was amazing in some ways, despite the continuation of the alternative education initiative for black pastors and the activities held in connection with the Mordecai Wyatt Johnson Institute of Religion in the 1980s and 1990s. See “Alternate Studies Initiated for Area Black Clergy,” 2; “The Black Church: Where Do We Go from Here?,” 1–18; and *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: The Divinity School Catalog, 1991–93*, 11.

83. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Blake (August 11, 2006). Interestingly enough, the Center for Jewish Studies (1969) and the Center for Women and Religion (1970), programs that developed parallel to that of the Center for Black Urban Studies, still exist at the Graduate Theological Union.
84. *African American Church Studies Course Offerings, 1995–2005*, Fuller Theological Seminary, unpublished document (2005), 1–3.
85. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Fluker (June 4, 2006); and Tom Russell, “Narrative of a Legacy: Women and Ministry at OGST and VDS,” *The Spire: Vanderbilt Divinity School and Oberlin Graduate School of Theology*, Vol. 11, no. 2, 7–9. Much of this author’s claim is based on personal observations shaped while he was a student at Garrett in the late 1970s and early 1980s, and reinforced by his experiences as a faculty member at Vanderbilt University from 1984 to the present. The competition for resources between Black Church Studies and women’s studies programs, though often occurring behind the scenes and on a low key, has continued unabated, even as African American and feminist liberation theologians speak of the interrelatedness of their oppression within the over-arching structures of white male privilege and domination.
86. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413.
87. *Colgate Rochester Divinity School/Bexley Hall/Crozer Theological Seminary: The Divinity School Catalog, 1991–93*, 28.
88. Gayraud Wilmore had struggled in the 1970s with the impact that Black Church Studies might have in terms of promoting church unity across the boundaries of race and class. See Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 413.
89. “Linking the Academy with the Black Church,” 23; and *Program of the National Black Church Studies Forum*, 1–3.
90. Lewis V. Baldwin Telephone Conversation with Stacey M. Floyd-Thomas (August 7, 2006). Information on the program and its course offerings and requirements is also available on Brite Divinity School’s website at <http://www.brite.tcu.edu/about/catalog/mdiv.htm>, from which some of the information provided in this essay was gathered.
91. E-Mail Message from Myers to Baldwin, 2–4.
92. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411–413.
93. Scholars like Henry H. Mitchell and Gayraud S. Wilmore were raising such issues from the very beginning of Black Church Studies in the academy. Baldwin Telephone Interview with Mitchell (June 3, 2006); Baldwin Telephone Interview with Wilmore (June 2, 2006); and Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411–413.
94. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 412–413; and E-Mail Message from Myers to Baldwin, 2–4.
95. “The Black Church in the Age of False Prophets: An Interview with Gayraud Wilmore,” in Iva E. Carruthers, Frederick D. Haynes, III and Jeremiah A. Wright, Jr., eds., *Blow the Trumpet in Zion!: Global Vision and Action for the 21st-Century Black Church* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005), 175–176.
96. “Linking the Academy with the Black Church,” 23; *Program of the National Black Church Studies Forum*, 1–3; and *Gatherings: The Newsletter of the Office of Black Church Studies*, Duke Divinity School, Vol. 4, no. 1 (Summer, 2006), 7. Visiting scholars such as James H. Cone, C. Eric Lincoln, Emilie Townes, Dwight Hopkins, Cheryl Townsend Gilkes, R. Drew Smith, Walter Fluker, Clarice Martin, Renita Weems, Anthony Pinn, Vincent Wimbush, and Cain Hope Felder, along with a local staff of Myers, Marvin McMickle, Otis Moss, Jr., and A. G. Miller, have taught as visiting scholars in the program based at Ashland Theological Seminary. According to Myers, “from the program’s inception, no one has taught a course in the Diploma, Master, or Doctor Degree levels who does not have an earned doctorate degree.” See E-Mail Message from Myers to Baldwin, 1–4; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Myers (July 18, 2006).
97. These insights came from William Myers. See E-Mail Message from Myers to Baldwin, 2–4; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Myers (July 18, 2006).

98. E-Mail Message from Myers to Baldwin, 2–4; and Baldwin Telephone Interview with Myers (July 18, 2006).
99. Margaret Mathes to Lewis V. Baldwin (July 31, 2006); Tiffany Marley, “All in the Family,” *Gatherings: The Newsletter of the Office of Black Church Studies*, Vol. IV, no. 1, 2; “Divinity Students Rally in Support of the People of Uganda and Sudan,” *Ibid.*, 3; *Resources for Students of Color at Duke Divinity School, 2005–2006*, no. III, 9; *Resources for International Students at Duke Divinity School, 2005–2006* (Durham: Office of Black Church Studies, Duke Divinity School, 2005), 1–19; and “The Divinity School: Brazil, A pilgrimage of Pain and Hope, May 16–31, 2006,” *The Pilgrimage of Pain and Hope Worship Guide*, fifth edition (Durham: Office of Black Church Studies, Duke Divinity School, 2006), 3–90.
100. Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411.

Part II

Program Initiatives

Having outlined the origins of Black Church Studies programs and the contemporary challenges that they face, this second section focuses on outlining innovations that have been developed by specific individuals and programs. The chapters by Stacey Floyd-Thomas and Arthur Pressley and Nancy Lynne Westfield discuss Black Church Studies as a dynamic area of study in divinity school and seminarian contexts and academic religious studies with deep links to church communities and society. The final essay in this section by Robert Franklin returns to a theme introduced in Wilmore's essay in Part I: the connection between religious leadership of Black churches and Black Church Studies. Creative repositioning and interaction (Floyd-Thomas) are crucial for the continued development of Black Church Studies. Pressley and Westfield provide an overview of a model for the teaching and implementation of Black Church Studies programs in their discussion of the God Talk Project at Drew Theological Seminary. The series involved the participation of pairs of scholars who teach intensive courses as well as participate in the life of Drew Theological Seminary during the course of their visit. The program which began in 2002 and ran for a decade suggests that pedagogical initiatives in Black Church Studies need to incorporate not only specific content-based goals but must also be intentional regarding what the authors term "an incarnational-redemptive approach" which pays specific attention to the issues of identity and belonging in the immediate social worlds and wider community contexts of each student. Franklin concludes this section, arguing that "the public vocation of black religious leadership is authorized by a distinctive theology and world view which claims that God loves the world and has not given up on fallen humanity."

A Field of Study as a Field of Dreams: The Contours of Black Church Studies

Stacey M. Floyd-Thomas

Introduction

According to historian Winthrop Hudson, “All religious and ethnic groups reach a point in their historical development when they become self-conscious and look back on their origins as a means of defining their identity. Almost always the first step is an attempt to find their roots in an ancient lineage.”¹ Whether we agree with E. Franklin Frazier’s argument that such a feat is hopeless for African Americans, due to our cultural amnesia caused by the ravages of the transatlantic slave trade, or whether we adopt Melville Herskovitz’s claim that we African Americans have, in fact, retained our African roots, even if only aesthetically, it is undeniable that the most knowable history of African Americans is rooted in the history and wisdom of the hush harbors and invisible institutions of that which has preserved and promoted the faith of Black people.²

A striking feature of Black life in America has been the strength and vitality of Black religiosity in the midst of oppression and the ability of Black wisdom to subvert those forces that, otherwise, would have obliterated our race. This feature, in large part, was cultivated and nurtured within what we have now come to understand as one of the strongest institutions within the not-so-ancient lineage of African Americans, that is, the Black church tradition. This realization compels us, as theologians and religious scholars, to map the contours of a field that will help us as a people not only to find the means of defining our salient identity as a people, not only of color, but also of faith. Moreover, this would allow us to mine and translate that motherlode of wisdom for the thoroughgoing task of critical theological reflection that will lead to liberative ends.

Theological Education within the African American Community

In his classic work, *The Mis-Education of the Negro*, African American historian and educator Carter G. Woodson devoted much time and attention to examining the importance of education for the African American community within the context of Jim and Jane Crow

America. Within his thorough assessment of a range of disciplines from the fine arts to business to the sciences, the upshot of Woodson's research found that the practices and philosophies by which Black people were trained (rather than taught or educated) were ultimately antithetical to the best interest of the Black community. Of particular concern for Woodson is the way in which theological education undermined the needs of the Black church and underdeveloped its leadership. Despite his open condemnation of the Black church as anti-intellectual, quietly complicit with social oppression, and faltering in its leadership of malpractice, Woodson also praises the institution for its pivotal role within the larger Black community as a safe haven from sorrow and suffering. Woodson states that the Black church, as a whole,

has taken the lead in education in the schools of the race, it has supplied a forum for the thought of the "highly educated" [Black individual], it has originated a large portion of the business controlled by [African Americans], and in many cases it has made it possible for [Black professionals] to exist.³

However, Woodson argues,

in schools of theology [Blacks] are taught the interpretation of the Bible worked out by those who have justified segregation and winked at the economic debasement of [Black people] . . . to the point of starvation. Deriving their sense of right from this teaching, graduates of such schools can have no message to grip the people whom they have been ill trained to serve.⁴

Though perplexed by the perpetual vicious cycle of miseducation of and malpractice by Black graduates of theological education, Woodson held steadfast to the belief that the Black church could be revitalized through a new vision of theological education that could nurture a more enlightened, activist vision of ministry within the Black church tradition. Woodson's observations illustrate a looming question that has profound implications for today's understanding of the Black church and the formation of the field of Black Church Studies: *"Knowing the perils of the Black Church and theological education, what new visions of Black theological education are needed in order to restore the Black Church to its promising legacy and power as the bedrock for education within the Black community?"*

This chapter explores Black Church Studies as an interdisciplinary theological enterprise that works to overcome the aforementioned conundrum by studying the Black church tradition not only as the historic bedrock of African American life and identity but also as a viable site for Black liberation and human flourishing. While the various definitions of Black Church Studies have been heuristic, and thus open for examination and experimentation, the contours of Black Church Studies have been consistent in their aims to introduce elements of both theories and praxis for racial advancement, social rehabilitation, cultural revitalization, and spiritual authentication of the Black church community not only to promote Black history and experience as the context for the self-determination of Black people but ultimately in order to theologically respond to the plight of Black people with sound analysis, data, and dialogue in its preparation of religious leaders and laity who seek to join theoretical reflection and critical praxis through a three-fold process of affirmation, agency, and advocacy. Black Church Studies, then, seeks not only to redress the faults of theological education viz Black people and their faith community but also to render this particular type of intellectual formation useful to the preservation and promotion of the Black church community.

So What Is Black Church Studies? Defining Black Church Studies

In the classic text *African American Religious Studies*, James H. Evans, Jr. defines Black Church Studies as an undertaking that focuses on the Black scholar, the Black Christian experience, and a particular methodological approach:

There are several ways to describe Black Church Studies. For some people it is any theological or religious research engaged in by African American scholars. Thus *the Black scholar* is the focal point of Black Church Studies. For other people it is any theological or religious research which takes as its subject *Black religious experience*. Thus the subject matter is the distinguishing characteristic of Black Church Studies. For a third group it is the *methodological* advocacy that sets Black Church Studies apart. That is, it is a way of doing theological research which is aimed ultimately at the liberation of African Americans from economic, social, and political oppression. It is the *telos*, or goal, of Black Church Studies that gives it its uniqueness . . . the distinctiveness of Black Church Studies is its liberating analysis . . . which is directed toward the deliverance of African American experience from the corruption of neglect and willful misinterpretation.⁵

In its contemporary context, Black Church Studies continues this endeavor by reflecting the vibrant wellspring of the intellectual richness within various fields of theological reflection within the academy for the purpose validating Black Christian experience and empowering the Black Church Studies scholar and the Black Church community to be agents of change. This fundamental understanding of Black Church Studies is necessary to reconcile that which normatively has been devalued, distorted, or altogether denied in theological education. As normative theological education concerns itself with the dominant white racial group and maintaining white privilege as a theological norm, Black Church Studies implicitly functions as a corrective to white supremacy. Not only is it a corrective to theological thinking but it is also prescriptive for the theological practice of Black Christianity both in how the Black Church functions as an vital institution within the larger society as well as how Black Christian faith acts as a force that links divine justice to social justice. Thus, a thinking-doing-being continuum inherent within Black Church Studies as an integral whole and symbiotic process is a signature of Black Church Studies. This is the major contribution of the field to both the Church and the Academy. The noted insistence within the mainline Eurocentric Christendom and white theological education to separate the sacred and mundane, religious and ethical as well as theory and practice, most often results in transforming the two institutions with the greatest potential to bring forth healing and enlightenment to become major proponents of suffering and ignorance. Therefore, Black Church Studies is a field that synthesizes the practices and theologies which make up the genius of the Black Church. Just as the Black Church is an institution that serves as a change agent within a racist and xenophobic society, the formal study of the Black Church must also demonstrate its ability to investigate and interrogate the intricacies of this complex structure via scholarship that is both multidisciplinary and interdisciplinary.

Multidisciplinary and Interdisciplinary Aspects of Black Church Studies

Much like theological education in general, Black Church Studies is multidisciplinary because it encompasses several fields of study that are brought into conversation to illumine the object of study, in this case the Black church. The process of bringing together homiletics, biblical studies, pastoral care, and ethics among others in the teaching of theological education for ministerial leadership is hardly a new phenomenon for this is the case in traditional forms of theological education. But this is not to suggest that the multidisciplinary perspective Black Church Studies (as evidenced in its subdisciplines Black Biblical Hermeneutics,

Black Theologies, African American Christian Social Ethics, Black Church History, Sociology of Black Religion, African American Christian Education, African American Pastoral Care, African American Homiletics, and Worship and Spirituality) is simply an analogue of white theological subdisciplines and, thus, merely “blackening” white theological education. Rather, the subdisciplines which make up its multidisciplinary are genuine outgrowths of Black church thought and culture. But analogous to the normative approach to theological education are the ways in which the multidisciplinary perspective may allow for an in-depth analysis to be made within one subdiscipline or among those that have an affinity.

But it is the interdisciplinary aspect of Black Church Studies that is both novel and characteristic of this enterprise within the realm of theological studies. As critical theorist Roland Barthes has stated,

Interdisciplinary work . . . is not about confronting already constituted disciplines (none of which, in fact, is willing to let go). To do something interdisciplinary, it is not enough to use a “subject” (a theme) and gather around it two or three sciences. Interdisciplinarity consists of creating a “new” object that belongs to no one.⁶

For Black Church Studies scholars, an interdisciplinary approach to studying the Black church is teleological. That is to say, it is goal-oriented rather than rule-based (deontological) or disciplinarily driven which is the dominant approach to religious and theological scholarship and teaching. Normatively, the various disciplines and work of religious and theological studies are hierarchically ordered and weighted. Theoretical/classic disciplines such as Bible, History, Theology, and Ethics, and Sociology of Religion (in that order) typically outrank or outweigh the more practical/contemporary disciplines like Practical Theologies, Pastoral Care and Counseling, Homiletics, and Worship and Spirituality. Though all are seen as necessary academic approaches for the study of Christianity and/or ministerial preparation, the work of these disciplines tends to be done separately and apart from each other and carried out in such a deductive manner that concerns itself with questions and concerns emanating from the academy rather inductively, taking its cues from the church or its congregations. In that our goal is the liberation of Black people and revitalization of Black Church Studies, we disavow the hierarchical categorization and territorial nature of disciplines within normative theological studies. Furthermore, Black Church Studies is also interdisciplinary in that it is a communal enterprise rather than a privatized endeavor. As Toinette Eugene notes, “one does not make or remake anything alone; one cannot ignore the relations one has. To know one’s self and one’s situation is to know one’s company (or lack of it) is to know oneself with or against others.”⁷

Thinking-being-doing Continuum within Black Church Studies

As interdisciplinary theorists and practitioners, Black Church Studies scholars perceive both Barthes and Eugene’s insights to be reflective of two inseparable features of Black Church Studies: the goal-orientated, creative work of interdisciplinarity and the non-hierarchical, collaborative process that “doing the work” entails. There is a dynamic interaction between studying the Black church and the students and scholars who engage the subject. The student-scholar changes in the process of “doing the work” and “the work” changes in the company of others.⁸ This thinking-being-doing dynamic between self and subject culminates in the collaborative creation of a “new object that belongs to no one” yet better informs the academy and the church, the Black scholars, and the Black church, transforming the entire terrain of the teaching-learning, participation-observation process.

As a major feature of the work of Black Church Studies, interdisciplinarity relates more to a conscious effort to integrate the knowledge and perspectives of various disciplinary approaches

and scholarly expertise to collaboratively solve real-life problems, thus changing negative conditions into positive life chances. An example of this work is bringing biblical interpretation, theological reflection, and sociological analysis together to bear on perennial issues and life crises in the Black community (e.g., institutional racism, gender bias, rising incarceration rates, global HIV/AIDS pandemic, dissolution of Black families, etc.). In addressing complicated problems through innovative and resourceful means, Black Church Studies not only is a field of study concerned with the study and description of the Black church in and of itself as a religious institution and social phenomenon, but also uses what is gleaned from the research towards the constructive task of strengthening the larger Black community as it meets contemporary challenges.

Framing a Black Church Studies Curriculum

Intended to give voice to the public and internal dimensions of the Black Christian experience for emancipatory learning, intentional living, and meaningful ministry, Black Church Studies has two main curricular objectives: (a) to develop a theological perspective attentive to relations of race, class, and gender that connects theological education, cultural context, and professional ministry to the struggles of Black people in their quest for linking social justice to divine justice; and (b) to prepare students with language and critical skills of theological discourse, pastoral competencies, and personal fitness for ministry in a pluralistic world and among Black people within their own spiritual and cultural context. By this token, Black Church Studies courses explore the historical legacy, progressive traditions, spiritual depth, and social witness of the Black church as it has been studied through theories and methods that make up the interdisciplinary field of Black Church Studies. These courses facilitate opportunities for the intellectual, professional, and inspirational development of transformational leadership for students interested in working in or in collaboration with Black churches and their communities. Whether in interdisciplinary courses such as “Introduction to Black Church Studies,” “The State of the Black Church Since Civil Rights,” “Black Church, Culture and Society,” and “Black Sacred Rhetoric,” or in subdisciplinary courses such as “African American Biblical Hermeneutics,” “Black Theologies,” “African American Social Ethics,” “African American Religious History,” “African American Pastoral Care,” and “The Sociology of the Black Church,” there always should be an intentional connection made between the study of Black theological education for the practical bearing it will have on Black church practices thus ameliorating the mutual betrayal and alienation between the academy and the church noticed by Woodson several decades ago. In an attempt to undo such a sordid state of affairs, the academic aims of Black Church Studies course offerings always tend towards:

- introducing a critical component of theological education that contextualizes the cultural diversity of American religious life as espoused by the Black church tradition;
- surveying a range of interdisciplinary scholarship (written by Black scholars of religion) whose content and method focus upon the religious formation of Black Christians, as well as the empowerment of the Black community writ large;
- providing both academic contexts and field settings for ministerial study conceived as a “living laboratory” wherein all seminarians, regardless of race and ethnicity, can work together to gain wider knowledge of, deeper appreciation for, and increased sensitivity to the issues and urgencies of the Black Christian community;
- reaching out to the Black churches and Black clergy and community groups in the local, regional, national, and global context; and
- fostering a transformative teaching-learning context for shaping the ministerial preparation of seminarians and the theological reflection of graduate students of all races.

These aims manifest themselves in numerous ways within the seminary, divinity school and university context. For example, the curriculum helps to familiarize students to the Black church tradition more than merely introducing them to it. Herein, students have real-life encounters with the Black church rather than mere church visitations or campus programming that incorporates Black church practices. Through assignments that require them to prepare and present Christian education curriculum for the Black church or work in partnership with Black church leaders in producing and facilitating forums throughout the community that provide a theological response concerning perennial issues that the Black community is presently confronting, students participate within a Black church context in informed, integrative ways that are more than merely experiential and observant. This also occurs through the intensive study of Black religious scholarship and the immersion travel-abroad opportunities (to Accra, Ghana, Cairo, Egypt, Dakar, Senegal, Kingston, Jamaica, and Salvador de Bahia, Brazil, among countless other locales) that are central to Black Church Studies curricula, students are also made aware of the particular tenets and attributes of Black church traditions that transcend the parameters of normative Christianity and hearken more directly to the African heritage of Black traditional religions and the religious pluralism of an ever growing African diaspora. In this fashion, the study and engagement of African cultural traditions reveal the ways that Black church musicology, sacred rhetoric, and worship traditions are much more clearly recognized as conveyors of African retentions rather than products of Eurocentric religiosity.

The Critical Praxis of Black Church Studies

The academic aims of Black Church Studies, though committed to practical relevance, are not efforts that conflate informing praxis with “doing Black Church.” In this regard, Black Church Studies serves as a set of tools that equips leaders for effective ministry rather than a bag of tricks from which she or he can pull. If we establish Black Church Studies as a theological intervention stemming from the intellectual and programmatic enactment of the praxis of the living faith of the Black church, we then can identify clearly the points of accountability and modes of engagement for the project. Radical pedagogue Paulo Freire once said, “The oppressed, having internalized the image of the oppressor and adopted his guidelines, are fearful of freedom” because, in the words of Freire, they innately understand that “[f]reedom would require them to eject this image and replace it with autonomy and responsibility.”⁹

In light of Freire’s freedom mandate and Woodson’s identification of the Black theological educational context as a transformative space for both the academy and the Black church, I propose that we explore *affirmation*, *agency*, and *advocacy* as the three tenets of Black Church Studies that facilitate our identification of the territory we must navigate in order to cover the mission of Black Church Studies.

The first aspect of Black Church Studies praxis is the *affirmation* of the Black theological enterprise as a vehicle for creating a liberating teaching-learning experience. In this schema both the teacher and the learner must become aware that the intentional ideology of oppression of traditional theological education is intended to divide the disinherited. Once again, Freire offers a vital insight by stating, “In contrast, achieving their unity requires a form of cultural action through which they come to know the *why* and *how* of their adhesion to reality—it requires de-ideologizing. Hence, the effort to unify the oppressed does not call for mere ideological ‘sloganizing.’”¹⁰ According to Gayraud Wilmore,

This requires taking the student’s personal faith and life experiences, and the life and faith of the local congregation he or she serves during the seminary years, with utmost seriousness. The object [of affirmation] is the enhancement of personal faith, not only by the acquisition of abstract knowledge, but by the appropriation of *meaning* for life and vocation.¹¹

A sense of connection for each person must be regarded as a deliberate call to remake the world by means of speaking truth to power and not simply providing insincere lip service. But above and beyond identifying the forces amassed against Black women, men, and children, the core concerns of Black Church Studies must focus and account for a vision of Black survival, liberation, and human flourishing. Incumbent in Black Church Studies praxis must be a continuous process of self-critique and appraisal to avoid falling into the pitfalls of Black essentialism.

The second central aspect of Black Church Studies is the validation of *agency*. This mandates our commitment to the axiom that “no [critical study] which is truly liberating can remain distant from the oppressed by treating them as unfortunates and by presenting for their emulation models from among the oppressors. The oppressed must be their own example in the struggle for their redemption.”¹² In order for the elevation of the subjugated to full prominence and recognition in our midst to be fully realized, Black scholars must be able to see ourselves as capable of both posing and solving problems, rather than merely ruminating about, commiserating with, or being the actual source of the problems. Taking a more engaged role of working within the academy and the Black church as two diametrically opposed institutions, Black Church Studies scholars have to accept that our teaching-learning engagement has prophetic dimensions since we are all called to be agents of change; therefore, we must become agents of change. Nevertheless, it is clear that this task is easier said than done.

In keeping with the notion of affirmation, agency mandates that both the scholar and students in the Black Church Studies classroom situate themselves within a mutual process of “bearing witness” as a means of critical engagement with the dominant society. Bearing witness, in this instance, takes on a deeper, more urgent dimension, which entails the following: the consistency of words, thoughts, and actions; the audacity to risk everything in the quest for freedom, justice, and equality; the radicalization that occurs when the teacher and learners are able to speak truth to power; the courage to love one another into wholeness in spite of how and why we are broken; and the faith in the fact that, no matter what forces are arrayed against the weak and dispossessed of the world, truth fears no trial and eventually the truth liberates both speakers and listeners alike.

Agency is the scholarly commitment to “make it plain,” that is, to make their work understandable and relevant to the realities of Black people in the pulpit and pew, sanctuary and streets, remembering that their interpretive genius is authenticated not by the imaginations of the academy but by the real-life witness of many Black church communities. An example of this prioritization of agency is to remember, as Wilmore states that:

“Aunt Jane” is still in the pew on Sunday morning. Today she may have a high school or even a college diploma, a late model car in the church parking lot, and other appurtenances of the Black middle class, but she still has a no-nonsense attitude about her religion. She wants it straight, no chaser. She remembers what racism and oppression are like and sees more subtle and disguised manifestations crippling her children and grandchildren. She knows that Jesus, the Holy Ghost, and the struggle for survival are real, and she expects her seminary-trained preacher to “tell the story” in symbols and images that rise to the heights of passion and creative imagination without losing a grip on the practical requirements of daily life—on whatever Black people have to do to remain sane in this world and secure for the world yet to come.¹³

Agency, as an aspect of the work of Black Church Studies, is dependent on creating a dialogical space that is informed by

love, humility, and faith, [wherein] dialogue becomes a horizontal relationship of which mutual trust between the participants is the logical consequence. It would be a contradiction in terms if dialogue—loving, humble, and full of faith—did not produce a climate of mutual trust, which leads the people involved into ever closer partnership in addressing the social ills that confront all people.¹⁴

In a dialogical space where love, humility, and faith are absent, the necessary prerequisites for a genuinely liberating Black Church Studies teaching-learning experience are undeniably lacking.

The third and final aspect of a Black Church Studies praxis is the importance of advocacy. Advocacy is understood as ministry that is “understood in terms of competent and faithful leadership in worship, nurture, education, and corporate action in behalf of God’s mission of liberation.”¹⁵ In spite of our best intentions, many scholars seem to “forget that their fundamental objective is to fight alongside the people for the recovery of the people’s stolen humanity, not to ‘win the people over’ to their side.”¹⁶ To reiterate this key issue, the paramount goal of the liberationist scholar or seminarian is “to liberate, and be liberated,” with the church—not to be led by them, but neither to lead them as if we are the talented tenth sent to release the captive masses.¹⁷ This dimension of our critical praxis operates very much in accordance with the traditional West African philosophical adage, “I am because we are.” Taken further, the core belief in the reflexive nature of this praxis is the idea that, as bell hooks suggests, the “learning process comes easiest to those of us who teach who also believe that there is an aspect of our vocation that is sacred; who believe that our work is not merely to share information but to share in the intellectual and spiritual growth of our [communities].”¹⁸

By conceiving of our scholars, seminarians, and their faith communities as partners in ministries of healing and transformation, and not merely as objects of study or cultural artifacts with little value beyond curiosity, Black Church Studies programs model and inspire a praxis in which Black churches become the sites for the production of salvific knowledge and redemptive theological reflection.

The contours of Black Church Studies, as outlined, are by no means a guaranteed panacea for resolving the miseducation or malpractice confronting the Black church and plaguing theological education by any stretch of the imagination. Nevertheless, the work that has been done thus far to develop Black Church Studies scholarship and curricular programs is an important envisioning of a dream as well as an implementation of a field of study that has the potential to allow the Black church and its community to engage in the task outlined by Hudson and Woodson years ago, namely, to reach a point in our development when we become self-conscious and look back on our origins as a means of not only defining our identity but transforming ourselves as well as theological education into a relevant, life-affirming, and critically engaged social enterprise that seeks to offer affirmation, agency, and advocacy as mainstays of Black Church Studies for generations to come.

Notes

1. Winthrop S. Hudson, “The American Context as an Area for Research in Black Church Studies,” *Church History*, Vol. 52 no. 2 (June 1983), 157.
2. For a fuller discussion, see Melville Herskovits, *The Myth of the Negro Past* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1958) or E. Franklin Frazier, *The Negro Church in America* (Liverpool: University of Liverpool Press, 1963).
3. Carter G. Woodson, *The Mis-Education of the Negro* (1933 reprint; Trenton, NJ: Africa World Press, 1998), 53.
4. *Ibid.*, 5.
5. James H. Evans, Jr., “Black Church Studies and the Theological Curriculum,” in Gayraud S. Wilmore, ed., *African American Religious Studies: An Interdisciplinary Anthology*, (Durham: Duke University Press, 1989), 26. It is important to state here that though integral, one to another, the terms “African American Religious Studies” and “Black Church Studies” are not synonymous. Black Church Studies privileges the church and Christianity as the institutional focus on its analysis of Black religious experience. African American Religious Studies involves

critical engagement and assessment of the thought and practice/ritual associated with the various ways in which African Americans express themselves religiously. It does not privilege any religious tradition or expression. By extension, the two should be seen as conversation partners but it should be noted that they are premised on a different theoretical arrangement. What results from such a theoretical arrangement involves a vocabulary, grammar, and language that extend within or beyond Christian conceptual frameworks, signs, and symbols. To conflate the two, as many texts (like Wilmore's *African American Religious Studies*), is to weaken the richness and undermine the autonomy of the varieties of African American religions and their faith communities.

6. Roland Barthes, cited in J. Clifford and G. Marcus *Writing Culture: The Poetics and Politics of Ethnography* (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1990), 1.
7. Toinette M. Eugene, "On 'Difference' and the Dream of Pluralist Feminism," *Journal of Feminist Studies in Religion*, Vol. 8, no. 2, Fall 1992: 91.
8. For a more detailed discussion on the symbiotic nature of the scholar and subject within interdisciplinary studies see Stacey Floyd-Thomas, Katherine Allen and Laura Gillman, "Interdisciplinarity as Self and Subject: Metaphor and Transformation," *Issues in Integrative Studies*, Vol. 20 (2002), 1–26.
9. Paulo Freire, *The Pedagogy of the Oppressed* 30th Anniversary Edition (New York: Continuum, 2005), 23–24.
10. Freire, 141.
11. Gayraud S. Wilmore, ed., *African American Religious Studies: An Interdisciplinary Anthology*, (Durham: Duke University Press, 1989), xvii.
12. Freire, *The Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, 30.
13. Wilmore, *African American Religious Studies*, xviii.
14. Freire, *The Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, 64.
15. Wilmore, *African American Religious Studies*, xix.
16. Freire, *The Pedagogy of the Oppressed*.
17. *Ibid.*, 67.
18. bell hooks, *Teaching to Transgress: Education as the Practice of Freedom* (New York: Routledge, 1994), 13.

God-Talk with Black Thinkers: An Innovative Model for Black Church Studies or James Who?

Arthur L. Pressley and Nancy Lynne Westfield

Introduction

This essay is a description and analysis of the God-Talk project, which was developed at Drew Theological Seminary in 2002 and ran until 2012. This project began with the concern of two Black professors discussing the need for Black students to be more aware of their intellectual and cultural history. The colleagues believed that clergy must see their intellectual tradition in correlation with the social and political needs of their community. The model, called God-Talk with Black Thinkers, informed by womanist thought, engaged pedagogy, liberation theology, and psychological theory, began as a series of intensive courses that experimented with issues of introducing Black students to the wealth of African American scholarship. The project then moved towards having the students use Black intellectual scholarship to think critically about the needs of African American communities. Part I of this essay recounts the story of the project's genesis. Part II describes some of the component parts and how the project functions at Drew. And Part III provides psychological and pedagogical analysis and reflection upon the learning theory of the model.

Part I: The Genesis and Articulation of the Problem

James Who?: A Lack of Knowledge

The "God-Talk with Black Thinkers" project had its beginning one afternoon in the Seminary coffee house. While talking with an African American student, Professor Pressley suggested that *Black Theology and Black Power* by James Cone would be essential to the essay the Black student was writing on liberation theologies. The response of the student was to ask, "James who?" This moment began a conversation between Westfield and Pressley about the current state and needs of African-American theological students at Drew University. It was clear that Black students not only had no idea about James Cones, but that they had little critical knowledge of Liberation Theology or Black Theology. As we reflected on their discourse in class, their sermons

and papers, especially as these related to the African American community, we became acutely aware of a number of deficits. Namely, that they possessed limited understanding of the wider field of theology and other related disciplines particularly as these disciplines assisted them in thinking about the lives of Black folks, and the experience of Black churches. Black students were unable to bring to bear the richness of Black intellectuals and theological reflection on the needs of African Americans to address structural problems of domestic violence, racism, poverty, HIV/AIDS, substance abuse, and the long list of other social, political, and spiritual concerns. Students who are unaware of the major thinkers in their community are not able to think critically about the lives of African Americans. Critical analysis requires that students have multiple perspectives to investigate a problem, and yet that these perspectives share some common goals and cultural assumptions. Students learn multiple perspectives from being aware of what others have said about the problem they are investigating. More important, our students, symbolized by the question of “James Who?” did not know to think critically about the ontological reality of blackness in a scholarly, critical way. Without this ability they are unable to design and implement ministries that will bring about healing and growth in Black communities. For the most part the students were rather parochial in their approach to problems, typically offering solutions that have already been tried and that had failed to bring needed change. Students are unable to develop ministries in their churches and communities that facilitate spiritual and emotional growth. Most students enter seminary with unhealed personal wounds from social and childhood traumas. Until they have encountered a healing community in the process of their education it is impossible for them to imagine how to provide this for others.

James Who? An Antiquated System

The problem of “James Who?” is a problem that exists not only at Drew but exists throughout much of theological education. The fundamental question confronting theological education is about training students to use traditional and contemporary intellectual thought in organizing for change and to move communities into new paradigms. In order for students to use theological and philosophical thought to facilitate change in communities, they needed to have experienced change themselves. The problem for most theological schools has been that most students graduate thinking much like they did when they started seminary. Students graduate without a clear understanding of pastoral ministry. They have not spent significant time developing their approach to social policy or developing insights into the nature of the good community. The curriculum, for the most part, does not give opportunity or time to foster ideas about creating healthy families, healthy relationships, or healthy congregations. It is not that traditional courses in church history, Bibles, church administration, and pastoral care are not taught—on the contrary they are taught in precisely the same manner that they were taught decades ago. Theological education remains unchanged for the past six or seven decades while the church and the world have drastically changed. In short, the current approach of theological education courses fails to grapple with the lived reality where the students will practice ministry.

James Who?: An Issue of Liberation

To state that students are unchanged by theological education is to argue that they are unredeemed by the process. The problem of unredeemed students, “James Who?” students, is more than a problem of course content or the failure to use intellectual traditions to think critically about social issues. The problem of unredeemed students is, at its core, an issue of liberation. Students need the experience of liberation if they are to be a liberating presence in their

communities. The current approach values the re-creation and perpetuation of systems of oppression that further harm members of their congregation and community.

Part II: The Model

Administrative Support

Pressley and Westfield proposed a model that would be a series of intensive courses to the dean of the theological school. The courses were designed to put Drew seminarians and graduate students in dialogue with some of the best African American minds of the twenty-first century. The project held in relative tension the mission to educate students for practical leadership, teach them to be theologians in residence, and provide them with a healing/redeeming/liberating experience.

The “God-Talk with Black Thinkers” project was launched in the fall of 2002 with Delores Williams, Carlyle Fielding Stewart III, Cheryl Kirk-Duggan, Karen Baker-Fletcher, and Gwinyai H. Muzorwa. This first intensive brought theologians and ethicists who applied their discipline to the needs of the worshipping communities. Since then, our intensive courses have been taught by Vincent Harding, Arthur Jones and Ferninand Jones, James Cone, Stacey and Juan Floyd-Thomas, Zan Holmes, Carol B. Duncan, Alton Pollard, and Anthony Pinn.

Semi-retreat Structure

The intensive, three-credit, elective course is offered by different guest lecturers each semester. We promote the retreat-like experience by limiting class size to 20 students. The class is provided at least one meal each day encouraging students and guest faculty to eat together. Often, the dean and other Drew faculty will come and share in the meal. Worship is built into the schedule by the class attending campus worship, often the visiting scholar preaches in chapel.

This compact schedule assists students in ignoring the non-academic distractions and resting from the responsibilities of their ministries and families. It is intended that this semi-retreat structure would become a liminal time in the life of students where they could learn and enter a period of self-discovery. The design of a retreat fosters the development of basic trust and knowledge of each other so that students and faculty might move toward becoming a community of scholars. In situations where we felt that students could not tolerate the intensity of this type of learning environment, we asked the student, in consultation with the Dean, not to enroll in the courses.

Invitation of Scholars

A key, perhaps essential element, to the project is the guest faculty who are invited to mentor our students. “Mentoring” is perhaps a more accurate term than “teaching” for the leaders of the intensives. Though there are many scholars’ work to which we would want to expose our students, there are limited numbers of scholars who we feel can create the kind of nurturing, pastoral ethos, which is our priority. We did not want teachers who use tactics of shaming, humiliating, or blaming as teaching tools. We bring teachers who possess the ability to cultivate ideas and, as importantly, teachers who embody transforming, compassionate leadership. We seek teachers who would model liberation theology, redeemed pedagogy. In short, we expose our students to mentors who have a passionate love of Black people. Cornel West, and many other educators, emphasizes the importance of having the structure and experience

of any institution match the content of what is being communicated in the classroom—and vice versa. Consequently, students desiring to learn about liberating theology need teachers who could give them a liberating educational experience. As human beings we are our experiences. This required that the faculty would need to be available for our students, spiritually, socially, emotionally, and intellectually. It is never enough to simply communicate ideas in the God-Talk classrooms. Compassion for our students, commitment to justice, and desire to make the classroom the beloved community have to be demonstrated in every aspect of their work. We invite scholars who are people of faith with active relationships to worshipping congregations. We want to model to students that faith and intellect are not anti-theoretical. We wanted to provide conversations which would assist seminary students who would combat the anti-intellectualism that plagues many of our churches and denominations. We seek scholars who would be as invested in the personal and professional development of the students, in addition to being concern for their mastery of the academic materials. We invite scholars who used a variety of teaching methods that we felt would educate the heart, the soul, as well as the mind of the students. This has included the use of music, movies, art, worship, discussion, dance, and a variety of other methods of engagement. When there are colleagues whose work we want to bring to our students, but for whom we are not personally acquainted, we make every effort to check the references of the scholar in terms of ability to relate genuinely and warmly to students. We want academic rigor and intrigue in the classroom with kindness and compassion. The scholars who we invite must have a vitality that inspires students to want to know more, question deeper, and act with greater courage to make significant change in the churches and neighborhoods where they will serve.

When we invite scholars to teach in the project we simply tell them that they may teach whatever they want to teach. We suggest that they teach their most recent work, their most passionate ideas, and their “best stuff.” Although we do not tell them what to teach, we are very careful to interpret our expectations and goals for the experience through which they will be guiding the students. We have crafted a detailed letter that describes the project. We have several conversations answering questions and making plans. We feel that teachers are at their best when the subject matter is not dictated. We encourage guests to be creative, even unorthodox in our classrooms.

Public Forum

Each guest scholar is asked to give a public presentation to the seminary community of their work in the course. Some choose to give public lectures; others preach or perform some kind of artistic/musical liturgy in chapel. Some of the presentations have been part of the theological school’s major lecture series, such as Martin Luther King Day Celebrations, while others have been simply held as a separate lecture series. In each case, the wider community seems transformed by the quality and depth of the presentation. The infusion of the multiple Black intellectual voices into the larger seminary community has served to inform, inspire, and challenge the entire community, both faculty and students alike. It appears that the diversity of presentation is critically reflecting the diversity of Black intellectual thought. Our hope is that this challenges the seminary faculty to include more Black scholars in their syllabi and course discussions. Our hunch is that this public aspect of the project has served to argue the importance of the project to the overall theological enterprise.

Experimentation—the Evolving Model

We began the project by convening in a kind of mini-conference. Our mini-conference entailed inviting five scholars over three days to do two lectures each. We quickly abandoned this style

as it was too labor-intensive. Next, we thought it important, early on in the project, to model for students familial collaborations. We wanted students to see, firsthand, families of scholars working together. To that end, we invited Art and Ferdinand Jones who are brothers. We invited Vincent, RoseMarie, and Rachel Harding who are mother, father, and daughter. We invited Juan and Stacey Floyd-Thomas who are husband and wife. Though we are still interested in familial collaborations, our attention has turned to collaborations of folks who are in writing projects together. We thought it would be helpful to the co-writers to co-teach as a way of working through some of their ideas.

There have been several delightful surprises thus far along the way. Stacey Floyd-Thomas has taught with the project twice and has brought with her students from Brite Divinity School. As a result of this, we began an institutional affiliation between Brite Divinity and Drew Theological. We co-taught a course to Ghana, West Africa, in January of 2006 with both Brite and Drew students enrolled in the course. Another unexpected benefit of the project has been the ongoing networking with project faculty. We are able to be in sustained conversations with those persons who have participated in the project. The network that has developed has been tremendous. As the program matures, Drew is being petitioned by students from other schools to enroll in the God-Talk courses. Students from Emory, University of Chicago, and Harvard have asked to enroll in the course. Our hunch is that Drew students are recruiting their friends from other schools to the courses.

Part III: Contextual Learning Theory: Incarnational Approaches and Engaged Pedagogy

Contextual Learning Theory

There are a variety of approaches and uses of contextual learning theory in educational arenas. It is widely used in field education, cross-cultural education, clinical psychology, and other disciplines. For our reflection, we have used contextual education as the theoretical foundation upon which to design the God-Talk project as a liberative model of education. For our purposes, contextual learning, utilizing principles of engaged pedagogy and an incarnational-redemptive approach, assumes that education must assist students to be a liberating force in their communities. Contextual learning demands teaching for integration and congruence. The teacher's task is to make every effort to create an experience of congruence between the content of the material being taught and the method by which the class goes about analyzing the material. Additionally, the teacher is also charged with assisting students in their ability to see basic principles and concepts and the multiple and complex ways those concepts make connections. For example, in talking about racism, students must be able to see the multiplicity of definitions, experiences, and outcomes of racism.

Teaching for congruence and integration is critically important because there is a direct correlation between how students are taught in the classroom and how they go about ministry. For example, teaching students to be prophetic entails more than talking about the nature of the prophetic. From this perspective, the students must experience in the classroom a sense of their own ability to be prophetic, to be prophets. The experience of self in the classroom as prophet assists the students in wrestling with their identity and assists the students in formulating their leadership role and responsibility in the local church. Experience, then, is not only what the student brings from beyond the classroom, but experience is simultaneously what is happening in the classroom. The classroom then becomes the place where students experience and reflect upon all of experience. It is after reflection on these experiences that students are able to consider how to effectively transfer this experience to other environments, that is, the local church. Creating and maintaining classes which are integrative of a student's culture, history, tradition, and politic while at the same time creating conversations which are congruent is difficult, but doable. Even though the experiences in God-Talk are brief, we assume that the

intense retreat design and the feelings of being part of a community of scholars have lasting influences on the students and the rest of the seminary community.

Engaged Pedagogy: The Practice of Freedom

The God-Talk project is a model of engaged pedagogy. Engaged pedagogy has its philosophical roots in the theories reflected by bell hooks in *Teaching To Transgress*.¹ Dr. hooks writes that teaching at its best is the practice of freedom. Leaning heavily upon the work of Paulo Freire,² hooks defines engaged pedagogy as a sacred act where teacher and learner, together, strive in search of life-changing and life-affirming truth. As co-learners or partners, both the teacher and the student have passion to teach and learn, motivating one another toward transformation. While transformation is likely to occur individually and personally, the aim of engaged pedagogy is social transformation, social redemption, and societal healing. Engaged pedagogy teaches to challenge the status quo of society that would keep students passive and would keep teachers bored and under-appreciated. It also teaches to inform students to resist domination by raising issues of race, class, gender, and sexuality as critical, foundational categories in all conversations. Engaged pedagogy encourages the experience of embodiment, that is, persons bringing all of who they are to the learning moment; body, mind and spirit. The classrooms of engaged pedagogy are places that perpetuate the idea of teaching and learning as ecstasy, risk-taking, and joyful.

Praxis

Black seminarians, particularly those attending white seminaries, do not have the luxury of a course of study that does not contain significant conversation about practical knowledge needed for Black church leadership. A seminary curriculum steeped primarily in white church practices and tradition will not sustain a Black pastor for an adequate or competent career in the local church. Furthermore, with the urgency of the twenty-first century—new forms of old racism, renewed US global supremacy and imperialism, and he seemingly unending appeal of domination on all levels of US society, while the population of the poor are increasing—neither do Black seminarians have the luxury of completing an MDIV degree that is not steeped in critical thinking, theological reflection, and intellectual rigor. Black seminarians need a course of study in seminary that is balanced in and integrative of theory and practice for justice while taking the needs, eccentricities, particularity and complexity of Black culture seriously.

As an engaged pedagogical model, the God-Talk project leans heavily upon the notion of praxis to strengthen Black seminarians for local church leadership. Praxis involves the integration of both theory and practice for justice. Praxis teaching is teaching action and reflection upon action with the agenda to change the world for liberation of all peoples—both the oppressed and the oppressors. The courses engage in deep and significant dialogue, integrating issues of practice and theory that reflect the particular needs of Black people in a racist world. The conversations have a particular grounding in Black social, cultural, historical, and spiritual reference. God-Talk, with the aim of praxis, introduces or re-introduces Black students to ideas of African American scholars and the achievements and mistakes of exemplars as a way of preparing church leaders for thinking through and doing innovative leadership in the twenty-first century. In other words, praxis brings the task of problem-solving for survival and hope of oppressed people into the classroom and challenges the students, teachers, and subjects to speak to genuine situations of hurt, harm, and danger. Students report that the experience of praxis in the classroom in and of itself is liberating, transforming and redemptive. Students

having experienced in the classroom moments of grace, mercy, insightful ah-hahs, healing and joy ringing halleluiahs can now replicate, duplicate or vision anew these experiences of praxis in their parish settings.

Role of Teacher/Role of Learner

Engaged pedagogy postulates that rather than students being passive recipients of the teacher's ideas, learners are expected to question, think critically, wonder, be curious, and hone intellectual rigor and creativity. In turn, teachers are also active learners who are striving to deepen and broaden their own experiences. Teaching recognizes that the world is multicultural and requires learning, un-learning, and re-learning in ways that challenge domination. Learners come to the teaching enterprise, not as blank slates or with blank minds. Instead, learners bring a wealth of experiences, perspectives, and knowledge in order to passionately and critically engage in dialogue with the teacher, other learners, and the subject. Engaged pedagogy leads to self-actualization by requiring emphasis on the well-being of the oppressed as well as the well-being of the oppressor. Teacher and learner alike are asked to risk vulnerability as all are responsible for the conversation and for participation in the conversation. In other words, teachers and learners risk sharing the power of the learning process.

Sense of Community

Education as the practice of freedom establishes intellectual community in the classroom where the participants, teachers, and learners all are passionate and willing to be deeply influenced and significantly changed by one another and the subject. Each guest professor in all the courses, as a way of modeling the value of each individual student and as a way of setting the expectation that each student must fully engage in the conversation, began each course with extensive time for introductions of themselves and invited each student to introduce themselves. These introductions were announcing to the students the expectation of full participation and risk-taking. By asking students to introduce themselves to one another and to the guest faculty, a collective agenda was declaring that anonymity and passivity would not build a cohesive thinking community.

Community building is critical in engaged pedagogy as all the participants in the classroom are required to speak and listen and dialogue. This expectation not only builds community, but it makes learning risky and uncomfortable. The risks of learning are both heightened and lessened when done in community. Risk is heightened when persons have the experiences of accountability and responsibility for their thoughts and actions. Risk is lessened when mistakes, experimentation, and new ways of thinking are considered part of the function of members of the intellectual community and affirmed. Engaged pedagogy seeks to create a learning community where every voice is recognized and valued, and the students use their own voices strategically to speak, critique, and analyze. It espouses that learning is process-oriented and understands that the means of new thinking are just as important as the acquisition and demonstration of new thinking.

Knowledge—an Expanded Definition

With mistakes, experimentation, and new ways of thinking as critical ways of being in the classroom, knowledge is not static, not based in data, facts, and memorization. Neither is knowledge out of reach of the learners—only the possession of the teacher. Knowledge includes the lessons of the classroom, the experiences of life, and the wisdom of tradition. Knowledge includes,

but moves beyond the traditional canon of information traditionally accepted by scholars. Critical thinking includes and trusts intuition, hunches, and gut reactions just as it depends upon proven theory and traditional practice. This expansive definition of knowledge means that multiple perspectives are honored and affirmed in the classroom as new learning and new thinking is to take place. Engaged pedagogy seeks critical awareness through body, mind, and spirit. It promotes engagement of self, God, and neighbor for a holistic practice of learning. Challenging the dualism of the traditional banking system of education that is dis-embodied, engaged pedagogy restores the importance of subjectivity to the classroom experience. In the God-Talk classrooms knowledge of folk-ways or cultural wisdom of the church mothers is not seen as “extra” or as anecdotal appendage to the conversation. Personal experiences of faith, awareness of God’s activity in the community, and the wisdom of the ancestors are viewed as primary sources and necessary fodder in conversation.

The Classroom

Engaged pedagogy assumes that the classroom is the place where students grapple with the issues that have seized our communities and that threaten to annihilate the present generation. The pedagogy strives to link the social, theological, and emotional with the cultural, economic, and political aspects of Black life. The classroom is not viewed as somehow being cloistered “away” from the community, but instead seen as a place that is part of the community and responsible to the community. The classroom does not “become relevant” in engaged pedagogy. Instead by grappling with the needs of the community with members of the community as teachers and learners, the classroom is a place where the relevant dialogue becomes deeply meaningful and germane to issues of survival and hope. In other words, engaged pedagogy espouses that in order for education to have liberating possibilities for the world, the world must be brought to bear on the classroom—pushing, stretching, creating doubt, confusion, surprise, and sparking deep meaningful conversation. The community is significantly influenced by the classroom as the intellectual and theological ideals, morals, mores, values, beliefs, practices, and history of the community are all part of the educational enterprise through conversation, critique, and renewed vision. Engaged pedagogy takes seriously the understanding that the survival and health of the entire community are tied to its ability to shape the education of future generations.

Language

Language is a powerful tool or weapon and can be used to dominate or liberate. Because conversation, thinking, and dialogue are considered the responsibility of all in the classroom, the use of “the King’s English” is not considered to be critical nor is it required. Students are encouraged to speak and write in the vernacular of their own choosing for their own comfort in expressing their own ideas. The elitism of western culture and the superiority of the “well-educated” upper class are called into question when persons are given the freedom to speak as they know without being penalized, punished, or stigmatized. The community is charged to learn the vernaculars of those who are part of the community as a gesture of affirmation and willingness to admit that culturally influenced language possesses insight and wisdom that may not be translatable and perhaps should not be translated. Students moving from voiceless to voiced do not have to strain to communicate in an English that is the language of the oppressor. The use of vernacular frees up the listener and the speaker to communicate in authentic ways. While dialogue across differences and across boundaries creates opportunity for challenging bias and moving toward new thinking and new ideas, the dialogue must

remain framed in words, phrases, and idioms which are meaningful to the one who is speaking the thought.

Inherently political

Engaged pedagogy for Black students is creating classroom experience that acknowledges the inherent spiritual and political nature of education and that slants the political agenda of these classes toward the enrichment and liberation of African American peoples and the African American church. Teaching and learning are never politically neutral, racially neutral, gender neutral, or sexually neutral. In this approach teaching and learning is inherently a political enterprise having implications for every aspect of the community, that is, home, business, church, mosque, government, jail, and marketplace. Black students do not need to employ a double-consciousness³ in the classroom as their single-consciousness, in its complexity, is fully acknowledged, represented, and respected. An example of the political nature of teaching occurred midway through a seminar on ethics. During one of the seminar breaks, a Black student went to the university snack bar to get a sandwich. The student felt that she was treated improperly by a Hispanic employee and concluded that race was the reason for the mistreatment. The student returned to the classroom and reported the incident to the class and guest professors. Without hesitation, the guest professors integrated analysis and action of the incident into the course. As a living case study, the incident became the focus of the lesson for the next four hours and expanded to include the Dean and her office personnel to arbitrate the racial offense as well as the cafeteria employee and the cafeteria manager. Had this not been an engaged pedagogical classroom, the experience of the student would have been discarded in the conversation as a typical racist occurrence and the class would have resumed to “more important” work. As an engaged classroom, the incident was connected to and folded into the conversation and into the work of the classroom community. This connection moved the classroom out into the larger seminary bringing the Dean, her staff, and the cafeteria staff into the classroom as teachers and learners and problem-solvers.

Incarnational-Redemptive Approach

The incarnational-redemptive approach to the God-Talk project has three major assumptions. First, Black Church Studies programs and theological education must be placed where students can discuss their racial identity in relationship to their anticipated professional roles. This approach views the formation of racial identity and professional roles as a corporate process that requires the formation of a community. Second, it recognizes the reality of “gloss” in the African American diaspora. “Gloss” is a psychological term that means diversity that exists within all communities. This approach avoids any essentialist definitions of blackness. It emphasizes multiple, even contradictory definitions and insists that the complexity of the community be reflected in every aspect of the learning experience. Third, the primary reason students chose ministry as a vocation is their desire to redeem the communities and individuals. As discussed in the section on engaged pedagogy, it is essential, then, that students experience redemption in the classroom setting if they are to bring healing and salvation to others.

Racial Identity: Understanding Ourselves as Black People in a White World

The incarnational-redemption approach of the God-Talk project assumes that education must begin with an understanding of the humanity of the student. This requires that students have

an opportunity to explore their personal and professional identities. Incarnation suggests that every aspect of the seminarian's life must now be part of the learning process for analysis as well as serving as a resource for theological reflection. For Black students this means the discourse must explore the experience of living in a racist world, for example, living with the experience of life in a color caste system. For women, the experience of gender discrimination must be part of the conversation. For Black students born outside of the United States issues of immigration are critical. In short, Black students are no longer the other but are normative to the educational enterprise. The conversations of the classroom reflect the normativity of the student.

With this incarnational-redemptive approach we created a model where students could reconsider the meaning of living as Black people in a racist world. This educational enterprise embodies the soul of liberation theology. The point of departure for liberation theology is the life and existential condition of African Americans. For much of their academic life, African American students are rarely treated as subjects who shape discourse and determine the parameters of intellectual debate. In the God-Talk project, unlike typical education, African American students are treated as subjects. They are treated as persons of value with a vibrant intellectual and philosophical tradition and are encouraged to respond to each other as subjects rather than objects of curiosity.

In addition to exploration of Black identity through conversations about the multiplicity of ways of being Black, male and female, the project modeled the complexity of blackness by presenting course materials through artistic expressions including popular culture, as well as through the rich variety of faculty teaching in the project. This diversity of identity was carefully represented in the faculty who were at times composed of husband and wife teams, brothers, father-daughters, and male and female teams. This display of diverse teaching teams, that is, diverse in ways of living and working as Black people seeking the liberation of Black communities, provided ample opportunity for students to experience the complexity of Black identity.

Secondly, the incarnational-redemptive approach to the God-Talk project means that we take seriously the issue of gloss. The concept of gloss acknowledges that multiple definitions exist for what it means to be African American and that ethnic groups are composed of multiple smaller communities. Gloss recognizes that these smaller groupings redefine and challenge previous assumptions about the nature and character of any ethnic or social group. The notion of gloss is concerned with the harm caused when people feel they are excluded by others' definition for their ethnic or social group. Thus debates about who is Black enough, or who is an Uncle Tom or Oreo, are avoided when the concept of gloss is made operative in Black church programs. For African Americans this reality acknowledges that some families have had graduates from Harvard Medical School for three generations, while there are other families who have been in housing projects for four decades. In their own way, both are expressions of the African American experience in the United States. It is important to point out that most of the intellectual conflict with Black Church Studies and African American Studies has been when people have felt that they have not been included by others' definition of "blackness."

Much of the challenge lies in the theoretical problem of "gloss" in that no two African Americans would agree to the meaning of being African American or agree to an appropriate representation of the community. For example, there was considerable debate about the use of the movies *Rize* by David LaChapelle and *Hustle and Flow* by Craig Brewer. Some students argued that the films were not worthy reflections of the Black community. Some students were concerned about the use of profanity and the lack of strong moral message. Some students went so far as to say the movie should not be viewed in a seminary context. As a contextual course, based on the life of African Americans, much of the discussion centers around definitions and framing of the ontological notions of being African American.

For these reasons, it was crucial for us that no static or monolithic definition of "blackness" shapes the God-Talk project. In designing the God-Talk seminars, scholars were chosen who

understood and represented a varied and at times conflicting understanding of the African American experience. We were intentional to include scholars born outside of the United States and who came from diverse theological, academic, social, and religious backgrounds to engage students about African American life.

And lastly, the incarnational-redemptive approach assumes that all learning must bring to focus the individual's social and cultural world, appreciating its embeddedness with other such cultural worlds in a continual flow of reciprocal and mutual influences. This means that Black Church Studies not only is forced to ask questions about the health of the African American community but also must evaluate the health of its relationship with the larger white community. This incarnational-redemptive approach to learning assumes that theoretical separations between social, individual, and corporate worlds are viewed as false dichotomies. Put in theological terms, we sought to create a structure that understands learning as redemptive and incarnational so that our students might be nurtured as creative leaders in multiple worlds.

For our purposes, redemption is understood as reconnecting people to their immediate social world and their wider communities. Within this framework, brokenness or "sin" does not suggest a state that exists within the individual but points to the un-relatedness and alienation of peoples and communities. One of the many aims of the God-Talk seminars is to reaffirm individuals' connection to their social groups (the Black community) and to understand and transform relationship with the wider society in and beyond the United States. Redemption!

Conclusion

We wanted to re-create educational opportunities for Black pastors that would assist them in thinking about their identity as leaders and provide a model that would inspire seminarians to rethink the ministry and mission of the Black church in the world today. The structure of this course is designed to teach students how to theologize and work contextually. This approach to learning does not eliminate education's traditional focus of teaching students to think critically; rather it contextualizes learning and thinking. The problem with classical educational theory is not its focus on memorization, the banking of cultural values, or diverse social values competing for the minds of students. The problem is the inability to recognize that learning is a social process. It is a social process that requires community, social and cultural context, where people consider their action within this complex matrix of values and identities. As social beings we exist within a nexus of living systems and are profoundly context-dependent in every aspect of our lives. We understand this process to be the essence of contextual education.

Notes

1. bell hooks, *Teaching to Transgress: Education as the Practice of Freedom*. New York: Routledge, 1994.
2. Paulo Freire, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*. New York: Continuum, 1981.
3. For further information on double consciousness see *Souls of Black Folks* by W. E. B. Dubois.

The Public Vocation of Religious Leaders and the Mission of Black Church Studies

Robert Michael Franklin

We are now nearly fifty years removed from the turbulent events which signified the end of America's domestic and foreign innocence. Dr. King was murdered in Memphis on April 4, 1968 while lending his support to the movement of local striking sanitation workers. Had he not been slain, one month later he would have led mass marches and campaigns of civil disobedience in Washington, DC, protesting economic injustice, militarism, and racism. That night, 110 cities in America exploded in violent rage and frustration.

Two months later Senator Robert Kennedy, the most visible symbol of white liberal decency, was slain on June 6, 1968 while consolidating his promising race for the White House. Meanwhile, the war in Southeast Asia escalated and thousands of young men and women began to disappear from the cities and villages of America only to return in shiny metal boxes draped with the stars and stripes. Among the 58,138 names etched in the Black granite Vietnam Monument in Washington, DC, my youngest uncle, Willie Franklin of Detroit, can be found. And to make matters more severe, Richard Nixon ascended to the imperial presidency.

Dr. King's assassination immediately became the trigger for the collective ventilation of rage pent up within the masses for numerous years. Most leaders and scholars of the movement agreed that the traditional civil rights movement had come to a dramatic end. Whereas the Black church had been the organizational base of the civil rights movement prior to 1968, thereafter it was eclipsed by secular militant organizations that called into question the relevance of religiously informed social change methods. Elegant moral rhetoric about color-blind integration, collaboration, and reconciliation yielded to the impatient rhetoric of the Black power, Black Panther, and Black pride movements.

James Cone's *Black Theology and Black Power* was a first serious academic attempt to demonstrate the affinity between the defiant Christianity of Black folk and the radical quest for social justice embodied in the Black power movement. The prophetic Christian activism to which Cone gave academic articulation was the very spirit which guided the formative years of Black Church Studies and Black studies programs on white campuses around the nation. Young Black seminarians began to press the questions: "How does one bear witness to the liberating, justice-seeking spirit of Jesus Christ in an unjust, racist society? In the context of institutions

which have systematically excluded Blacks and women from positions of decision-making, what does the gospel call Black and white Christians to do?"

Although Dr. King was dead and the movement he led largely eclipsed by the student-led movements, the future of social Christianity remained up in the air. Who would represent the social gospel perspective after King? Fortunately, some of that leadership would come from seminary-educated Black clergy along with a few white counterparts. James Cone and his counterparts in feminism would provide the intellectual framework for the new outlook those clergy brought to America's churches.

The student movements at places like Colgate Rochester Divinity School where the first seminary-based Black Church Studies program was founded along with Yale, Harvard, Cornell, Berkeley, San Francisco State, and others were expressions of the rising visibility of those new Christian progressive voices.

Many of those voices also emerged not merely as protesters but leaders in the public square. King's own cadre of assistants became the first line of progressive politicians who brought social conscience into the halls of power which had excluded King and other prophetic preachers. Note the emergence of Rev. Andrew Young who became Georgia's first Black congressman since Reconstruction 100 years ago and later went on to become Atlanta's mayor and the US representative to the United Nations; Rev. Walter Fauntroy who became the first congressman to represent the District of Columbia; Rev. Hosea Williams who was elected to a Georgia State Representative seat and sat next to one of Georgia's youngest and best-known elected officials, Julian Bond who had been nominated symbolically for vice president of the United States by Democrats in Chicago in 1968 despite the fact that he was then too young to accept the nomination; John Lewis who defeated Julian Bond for the seat in Congress that Andrew Young had occupied a few years earlier; and of course, Rev. Jesse Jackson who ran for president of the United States twice during the 1980s, something no one would have predicted after he withdrew from the MDiv program at Chicago Theological Seminary in order to lead Operation Breadbasket. All of these, not to mention the hundreds of elected Black officials throughout urban and rural America which have transformed municipal politics, remind us that religious leadership in the Black community has an explicit public vocation.

I wish to argue that the public vocation of Black religious leadership is authorized by a distinctive theology and world view which claims that God loves the world and has not given up on fallen humanity. According to the Black church's appropriation of the tradition of Hebrew prophecy, God is profoundly concerned with the moral hygiene of society, and God calls fallible women and men to proclaim that concern. Hence, the enormous authority we ascribe to the preaching office. But the preacher's word must be validated by action; the preacher must embody the intimate relationship between truth and freedom. The Black church is profoundly committed to praxis. I believe that this model is one which can and should be seized by white Christian leaders at this kairotic moment in history. Riverside Church pastors William Sloan Coffin and James Forbes, Jr. represented hopeful embodiments of biblically grounded prophetic ministry. I am convinced that if America is to undergo the next phase of the revolution which Dr. King sought to initiate—a revolution of values and a transformation in the minds and spirits of human beings—then this country needs a white Martin Luther King, Jr.

Indeed, America needs a charismatic, mainline white woman or man who knows how to preach and how to paint a vision of our shared, public life which is so compelling that even yuppies will gradually disengage from the greed ethic and commit themselves to the common good. And that moral leader must be able to mobilize all kinds of Americans to aspire to that broader vision. In my opinion, only a few personalities in our time have approached that noble calling including Rev. William Sloane Coffin and Governor Mario Cuomo.

If we accept the claim that living the gospel entails responding to social imperatives such as refusing to be silent or neutral in the face of a moral crisis, identifying with the social position

of the poor and outcast, and working to establish justice, reconciliation, and peace among all persons, then we are left with the question, what is the responsibility of the seminary to equip persons to do this sort of ministry? I believe that an important starting point is to identify, tentatively, that ensemble of knowledge, skills, and character virtues which are likely to generate and sustain a socially conscious and transforming ministry.

In this chapter, I'd like to propose a substantive model of ministry under the three rubrics: knowledge, skills, and character virtues or knowing, doing, and being. Throughout, I will sketch what I take to be the mission of a professor and program of Black Church Studies in this bold and ambitious enterprise.

Socially Transforming Knowledge

First, seminarians need to possess competence in the basic areas of theological knowledge as (Friedrich Schleiermacher outlined them) the bible, church history, systematic theology, and practical theology. From the perspective of Black Church Studies, every seminarian needs to possess bi-cultural literacy in each of these—areas of theological knowledge—that is, to know the established norms and classics and to know how and why those norms are flawed or limited by fault of positing one group's experience as a standard for everyone in a pluralistic society.

Bible

I may be preaching to the converted here, but for the record, I wish to state that there is no substitute for competence in biblical exegesis and hermeneutical methodologies. In order to become effective proclaimers of God's word of forgiveness and redemption, ministers must understand the character of the text which Jews and Christians take to be authoritative in matters of faith and life. Students may not embrace warmly the historical critical method of textual analysis, but they must understand that it is one among many important and useful tools for getting at the truth contained within, underneath, and beyond the words of the text.

Professors should remember that new knowledge often shatters old worlds. Students from theologically conservative cultures often perform poorly in biblical studies courses taught from a critical and liberal perspective precisely because they are resisting the epistemological onslaught of a threatening and alien world view, one created by Western males profoundly committed to the Enlightenment notion of the autonomous, rational self detached from family, community, and culture. For, not only is one's personal identity wrapped in a particular approach to scripture, but the hope of oppressed communities is often thought to be grounded in certain biblical claims about God's agency in history. Hence, this is a call for pastoral sensitivity and patience on the part of the seminary faculty.

Students should be acquainted with the classics in biblical studies but should also be conversant with the critiques of those classics such as those advanced by feminist scholars like Elizabeth Schussler-Fiorenza and Alice Laffey and African American scholars such as Cain Hope Felder, Renita Weems, and Michael Brown. In 2007, *True to Our Native Land: An African American New Testament Commentary* was published. Since the work of Black biblical scholars has been often ignored in academic institutions, white scholars have a moral obligation to become familiar with those resources and to introduce students to new perspectives. I am convinced that these newer perspectives can empower seminarians for socially transforming action. Not only can Blacks and women find empowerment through discovering their presence in and contributions to the Bible, but everyone can be empowered by the knowledge that God is no respecter of persons but moves and works through all who would be faithful to God's desires.

History

With respect to the history of the church, particularly of the churches in the United States, students need to receive a bi-cultural remedial education. Much of the scholarship documenting the presence of African peoples throughout the history of the Christian church is yet to be done. It is pioneering work for which we need a large cadre of committed scholars, Black and white. Thanks to the important efforts of Black historians such as Albert Raboteau, Gayraud Wilmore, Vincent Harding, James Melvin Washington, and Evelyn Brooks Higgenbotham, and of white historians such as Milton Sernett, David Wills, and Randall Burkett, we are beginning to appreciate the reciprocal relationship between Black and white religion during the formative years of the church in the United States. We can no longer talk about the religious practices of white Christians in America without reference to African and indigenous American religious folk.

A socially transforming ministry will be aided by the knowledge that there are resources in the Christian faith which empowered slaves and poor people and women and even, privileged, white males to take dramatic action in pursuit of God's kingdom. The modes of creative survival and coping developed by African Americans throughout history may offer needed spiritual and psycho-social models and resources for post-modern persons seeking to maintain sanity in a violent and acquisitive society. Recall, for instance, how some of the Negro Spirituals provided the civil rights movement with a hymnody of joy, sorrow, and hope.

Theology

With respect to bi-cultural literacy in the area of theology proper let us consider the life of Dr. King. In 1963, while sitting in a jail cell in Birmingham, AL, he penned the memorable epistle "Letter from Birmingham Jail." Martin Marty has observed that this letter should be added to our canon of sacred writings. In it, King responded to local white clergy who questioned his right and purpose for being in Birmingham. Throughout the letter, which he began composing on the margins of a newspaper and other scraps, he referred to theologians such as Thomas Aquinas, Martin Luther, Paul Tillich, and Martin Buber. King knew these monumental figures and employed them in a socially transforming manner by putting them in conversation with the prophetic tradition of African American Christianity. To my palate, this was most delicious.

Suddenly, Aquinas spoke to the Black predicament and could be heard urging Blacks to disobey unjust laws because they were contrary to God's higher law. You will recall that his speeches were full of references to Hegel and Shakespeare and Carlyle. We could say that contrary to rejecting the Western intellectual tradition, King critiqued and transformed the legacy of the Enlightenment and other periods by applying them to the lives of oppressed persons by way of Tillich's correlational method.

King saw the problem of racism posing questions to which Western thought, especially theology, was compelled to offer powerful answers and solutions. At times, the tradition seemed to be too thin or excessively culture-bound to offer meaningful responses. This compelled him to look in new directions. Imagine that, a Black Baptist preacher from Georgia studies Hinduism and the life and thought of Mahatma Gandhi in order to create a bold and effective method for countering social evil. Dr. King offers to us a paradigm of prophetic ministry grounded in the evangelical faith of his fathers and mothers but enriched and launched by a pluralistic, graduate theological education. Given his example, we should perhaps be more intentional about encouraging seminarians to put the monumental theologians of the past in dialog with contemporary problems and theologians who are committed to changing the world, such as King, Allan Boesak, Jos   M  guez Bonino, Rosemary Reuther, and so on.

Ethics

In the area of Christian ethics, I am persuaded that most seminarians graduate without adequate preparation in practical, systematic moral decision-making and analysis. Many have no idea about where to start in enabling persons to think through the private and public moral crises which overtake their lives. Also, many do not think clearly about the relationship between love, power, and justice. How can ministers empower Christians to resist evil in social institutions when they do not know how to identify and diagnose power transactions? Where is the power in this community? And how can that power be impacted by the demands of justice as advanced by a community of loving and tough Christians? The seminary can and must provide some answers to these questions not only through courses, but also through supervised field education where students are required by the supervisor to deal critically with justice issues and by the modeling faculty members do as we interact with institutions in the world.

Also, I believe that we must move toward the day when our students are required to think about Christian faith in relation to at least one other major faith tradition. Harvard and the University of Chicago have done well in this area. Either we must hire someone who can offer courses in the history of religions of the world or urge students to take such courses at the university.

Practical Theology

With regard to the practical theological knowledge students need in order to do socially transforming ministry I would offer the following observations.

First, I am critical of what has become the governing model of ministry for many seminarians, churches, and faculty members. I characterize it, somewhat suspiciously, as the professional but wounded healer. In this model, emphasis is shifted away from the vocation of prophetic ministry with its notions of sacrifice, risk-taking, and faithful obedience to God. Rather, emphasis is placed on the minister as a professional, distinguishable from other professionals largely by the content of academic preparation and salary level. Ministers are thought to be persons who select ministry as one of many available professions. Professional ministers work certain hours of the day and choose where they will serve depending on the level of remuneration and benefits. A large literature has emerged that challenges this professional paradigm and aims to restore the theological understanding of calling to ministry.

In the subculture inhabited by seminarians, this professional image has been wedded to Henri Nouwen's compelling metaphor of the wounded healer who is personally vulnerable and theologically uncertain and searching. Such persons tend to be ambivalent about asserting themselves as leaders and symbols of authority in the community. Hence, such ministers come to think of themselves as ecclesial therapists charged with caring for, and curing, the souls of that bruised humanity which gathers each week for word and sacrament. The ecclesial therapist frets over the authenticity of his or her personal theology and the degree of church growth realized annually. But the world is treated like an afterthought, the arena to which the church attends when it needs something, or when society's problems become so enormous that the church must become a more public force. We need a conception of ministry which holds together meaningfully God, the world and the church.

The Black church community embraces, and may be able to offer to a wider public, a theology of ministry based on biblical images of the prophet. Black preachers understand themselves to stand in a continuous, unbroken line of prophetic leadership and discourse which goes back to Moses, Deborah, Elijah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Amos, Hosea, and John the Baptist.

Black preachers, from Jarena Lee and Henry McNeal Turner to Martin Luther King, Jr. and Cecelia Bryant, understand themselves to be called to a ministry which may require ultimate

sacrifices. While many Black preachers aspire to middle income, most do not aspire to the middle class. Rather, they are critical of a political economy which condones radical inequality and economic exploitation.

Pastoral Psychology

Although I am critical of the ecclesial therapist image, I do affirm the need for seminarians to have adequate training in pastoral psychology, care, and counseling, particularly for those who will serve Black working class and poor communities. Based on my travels, study, and limited experience, I am passionately persuaded that there is a tremendous need for students to develop diagnostic sophistication through board learning in human sciences, especially psychology and sociology. Many Black seminarians reject pastoral care as a white, clinical, privatized enterprise, choosing instead to deepen their knowledge of systematic and liberation theology and preaching, since the payoffs for these are immediate. But I think that this rejection has been too uncritical and far-reaching. To be sure, pastoral counseling as a one-on-one enterprise has its limitations. However, an adequate knowledge of pastoral psychology would empower seminarians to do what Malcolm X did so brilliantly. That is, to diagnose the depths of the Black psyche in order to name, to elaborate, and to heal self-hatred, powerlessness, and detachment from communal bonds.

In my judgment, diagnostic sophistication entails knowledge of how persons mature throughout the human life cycle (taking note of gender, class, and racial differences), the nature of human unconscious life (as Freud and others elaborated the mind), and the systemic context and dimensions of all behavior (as Frantz Fanon and, more recently, Archie Smith have demonstrated). These and other factors have implications for the adequacy of our ministries of religious education and preaching.

Beyond the boundaries of practical theological knowledge per se are the lively horizons of possible dialog between religion and law, and religion and medicine. Many attorneys and health-care professionals are anxious to benefit from the theological community's expertise in normative thinking, especially now that the society faces a crisis in professional ethics. I believe that theologians in formation need to possess introductory-level knowledge of how the legal and criminal justice systems function and malfunction. Ministers need some awareness of those basic rights which are contained in the Bill of Rights and the Constitution. With so many of her young, Black males incarcerated, the Black church of the twenty-first century must expand its ministries to inmates.

With respect to health care, the Black community presently stands on the growing edge of several public health crises. The percentage of AIDS among young, Black female teenagers and infants is alarmingly high. Sexual illiteracy and unplanned teenage pregnancy threaten the life prospects of the economically disadvantaged or lowest quarter of the Black community. Again, the churches can impact these problems significantly if they can get beyond denying the seriousness of the crises or leaving other agencies to tend to them.

Having identified the Black church's theology of prophetic ministry and some substantive learning agenda, I now consider briefly the practical skills seminarians need to possess in order to do socially transforming ministry.

Socially Transforming Skills

As I examine the lives and leadership genius of persons such as Martin Luther King, Jr., Malcolm X, Marcus Garvey, and Nannie Helen Burroughs, the Black woman who helped to found the Woman's Convention of the National Baptist Convention in 1900, I find that certain

identifiable, teachable skills were present. I will focus on the two which I take to be most important: preaching and organizing/administration.

If the liberal church is to reclaim a place in the sun, theologians must learn to become better preachers. Thanks to members of the American Academy of Homiletics, numerous theoretically rich and innovative approaches to reviving sacred rhetoric are on the scene. Fred Craddock, Eugene Lowry, Thomas Troeger, David Buttrick, Gardner Taylor and Henry and Ella Mitchell, Carolyn Knight, Vashti McKenzie, and Martha Simmons are calling attention to the evocative power of imaginative language, images, and narrative theologizing. Pulpit rhetoric needs a renaissance, and the oral culture of the Black church may have much to contribute to this phenomenon.

During the civil rights movement, one of the most effective means of persuading people to put their bodies on the line for the sake of the wider good was Dr. King's rhetorical ability (I have in mind Aristotle's notion of rhetoric as the art of persuasion.) Through preaching, King created group consciousness, rallied people, stimulated new thinking, mobilized powerful emotions, and channeled energies into constructive avenues.

The ability to persuade and inspire persons must be allied with the ability to gather, organize, and empower them. Socially conscious pastoral theologians must be able to gather small groups of people for the purpose of defining common goals and dividing labor. The pastor must know how to affirm and empower every member of the group, as King affirmed all of the fiery spirits on the early Southern Christian Leadership Council's leadership board.

In addition to knowing what to do with a small group, seminarians should develop some managerial skills for guiding massive institutions as well. Thanks to Lyle Shaller and others, we understand what is necessary to keep a small church alive and hopeful. But some seminarians will someday be denominational leaders, bureaucrats, and bishops. They must understand the dynamics and stasis of macro-institutions. I understand that the Congress of National Black Churches has conducted executive seminars with the leaders of traditional Black denominations. But this conversation should be engaged during seminary training in order to ensure that theological reflection on church and institutional administration happens in a regular, disciplined manner.

To summarize, seminarians who are in the process of acquiring classical theological knowledge, some interdisciplinary knowledge, and the basic skills of preaching and organizing are well on their way to doing socially transforming ministry.

I turn now to consider in an exceedingly sketchy form, those character virtues which seem to be essential for such ministry.

Socially Transforming Character Virtues

Subversively speaking, everything I've said is useless if the seminarian is not, or does not intend to become, a certain kind of human being—a Christian. Christians are persons who have been grasped by the power of a new reality, to use Tillich's wonderful image. Seminarians ought to be Christians.

I cannot initiate within the confines of this chapter an ambitious, constructive ethics of virtue. But I am strongly attracted to this approach to ethics, particularly as it has been employed by Aristotle and Jesus and their many loyalists such as Peter Paris, Preston Williams, and Alistair McIntyre. It is exceedingly important for theological schools to specify those traits of character which should be incorporated into one's identity and journey. And it is exceedingly naive for faculties to expect students to automatically become faithful ministers upon graduation simply because they have completed the requisite courses.

It seems to me that socially transforming ministry is done by persons who witness to having been grasped by Jesus Christ by seeking to manifest certain "fruits of the Spirit" (as Paul

referred to them in Galatians 5:22ff) in their personal lives. He identified the traits of love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.

Obviously, a laundry list requires a rationale to justify the selection of a particular set of virtues. Paul did not provide a rationale for his list but seemed to believe that the virtues would emerge inevitably if Christians yielded to the work of the Holy Spirit (and to ecclesial authority figures.)

The rationale which grasps me is the Black church's appropriation of biblical traditions of prophetic leadership. We believe that God is profoundly concerned with the moral hygiene of human society. In other words, God expects humans to love God by loving our neighbors. Hence, we must be in the business of practicing justice and reconciliation. God is offended by even the slightest evidence of willful oppression, estrangement, and injustice. And because God has not forsaken God's good creation, God has called women and men to lead the church and the society toward wholeness and justice.

While Paul's list of virtues is central in my theology, I think that we can specify some additional public virtues which can sustain a socially transforming ministry. Among them I would include the following:

1. Integrity: the inspiring adherence to a code of moral values
2. Discipline: the ability to control and refine oneself
3. Courage: firmness of mind and moral strength to resist opposition
4. Style: personal manner or method of behaving

Unlike a body of knowledge which can be taught, these virtues must be embodied in someone—a moral exemplar. In a seminary community, faculty members particularly should seek to model these public virtues by the ways in which they relate themselves to the wider community whether within or beyond the seminary confines. For wherever one finds a diverse community, one will immediately find opportunities and need for the hard work of practicing justice and reconciliation. And, in such contexts, one will need to exhibit integrity, discipline, courage, and style.

Perhaps it is illuminating to observe how these public virtues were lacking or distorted in the meteoric ministerial careers of Jim Bakker, Jimmy Swaggart, and Henry Lyons. Similarly, it is fascinating to see how masses of persons are attracted to ministers such as Floyd Flake and Jesse Jackson who seem to credibly embody integrity, discipline, courage, and style despite what one might think of their partisan political choices.

Conclusion

I am persuaded that ministers who possess the ensemble of socially transforming knowledge, skills, and character virtues are well on their way to empowering the church of Jesus Christ to do the work of ministry in the world. One significant component of that ministry is to revive American public life—that space which we all share in common. This revival will require many styles and levels of action including ministers entering public life, churches working in society to create the conditions in which strangers may overcome mutual fear, ignorance, and tension. If this happens, perhaps the common good will reemerge as a serious concept in modern religious and political discourse.

Part III

Purpose and Power

In Part III, the chapters address approaches to the study of Black churches from a variety of theological perspectives which examine the worship experience itself and preparation of clergy as crucial to the continued vitality and relevance of contemporary faith communities especially in light of contemporary social justice issues. These linked issues are discussed in the fields of homiletics (Fry Brown), music and worship (Abbingtion), and biblical studies (Sadler). Brown, like the authors in this section, challenges contemporary Black Christian faith communities and institutions that prepare clergy to take preaching seriously. Abbingtion, similarly, makes a strong argument for Black Church Studies programs to “integrate the study of music and worship into their required curricula in order for their graduates to be truly prepared for parish ministry in the 21st century.” For Sadler, biblical studies is an intrinsic and important component of Black Church Studies. The interpretation of the Bible in the development of African American biblical hermeneutics is crucial and continued study in the contemporary context is necessary. Franklin’s reflections on the significance of theology and the Black worship experience emphasize the vocational dimension of religious leaders in public contexts.

Reestablishing the Purpose and Power of the Preached Word through Black Church Studies

Teresa Fry Brown

Within Black congregations, bad preaching is the unforgivable sin.¹

I enter the engagement of an analysis of the Black church and the preached word as a child of the 1950s–1980s Black Baptist Church where we stayed all day on Sunday, participating in services, dinners, Baptist Training Union (BTU), choir, Sunday school, and the missionary society. As a maturing adult I left the church of my youth to join the African Methodist Episcopal church singing in choirs, teaching Bible study, and serving as Sunday school superintendent and director of Christian Education until I entered ordained ministry in 1984.

Having served as supply pastor, assistant pastor, and associate pastor at churches in Colorado and Georgia as well as guest preacher/teacher/psalmist in churches across the United States and elsewhere for the past 32 years I have had extensive opportunity to listen to sermons emanating from Black pulpits. Listening to “the preached word” for 63 years through, in Melva Costen’s words, the African American worship pillars of song, testimony, prayer, movement, fellowship, and sermon I have a love for the Black church experience with all its shortcomings and significant actions.²

Another part of me is that of scholar/teacher/illuminator. I have been teaching preaching for the past 30 years. As one who teaches preachers and is a preacher herself, I often wonder if part of the searching for faith, the transitory nature of belief, the lack of trust in humanity, and the preoccupation with fear in contemporary society is due in part to the mode, mannerism, and method by which preachers, arbiters, teachers, purveyors, or proclaimers of belief convey moral-ethical choices.

As a Black church insider participant-observer of Black preaching and an outsider academician who teaches homiletics I would like to posit my interpretation of the integrity and corruption, the power, and the paucity of Black preaching in Black churches. Although I am often called iconoclastic, I understand my call is to investigate possibilities for transformation for God’s faith community through the preached word. As a former speech/language pathologist I am drawn to analyze how Black churches in general and faith communities in particular use the language of faith, the preached word, the salvific discourse, the redemptive motif, and the expression of belief in both church and academy. I affirm sociologist and theologian Cheryl

Townsend Gilkes' statements that one of the unforgivable sins in Black Christian churches is preaching that is vapid, manipulative, boring, irrelevant, and lacking theological grounding. This essay will present a review of the content of Black proclamation, an assessment of the conduit of Black preaching, a brief critique of contemporary Black preaching, and pedagogical considerations for Black Church Studies programs teaching homiletics.

Content

The purpose of preaching is to present the acknowledged Word of God, regardless of the translation or version, verbally and nonverbally with such passion and purpose that the listener or observer senses the impulse of change or conversion in his or her own life. The central focus of preaching is seeking to mine the mysteries of God—the who, what, when, where, how and why of God—in relationship to God's creation. It is an oral-aural-psychological-spiritual-theological-social-physical-emotional-ethical endeavor that seeks to engage both the preacher and the listener. This sacred rhetoric connects the community in a divine/human encounter that celebrates God's presence, power, promise, and plan for humanity. The marriage of God's word and human creative language can be a symphony of hope and healing, or a dirge of defeat and depression, depending on the skill and intent of the orator. Preaching is didactic, that is, the truth telling of God's directions for a particular situation, issue, or concern through reiteration of centuries of stories, legends, myths, fables, proverbs, illustrations, images, fables, or texts of faith. The duty of the preacher is to address the relevant needs of the listeners, grounded in the biblical text and transforming message of Jesus while affirming the humanity of all persons.

According to ethicist Robert Franklin in a January 2001 National Public radio interview, at its best Black preaching is "spiritual pharmacology." It is a "healing reservoir of transfiguration and transformation" experienced through congregational call and response. I would define Black preaching as a fundamentally creative, artistic cultural form of African Diaspora sacred speech marked by distinctive expressive styles and flavor for communicating religious information. Such a holy speech is a "divine activity" where the Word of God is proclaimed or announced concerning contemporary and often contradictory issues with a view toward ultimate response to God. James Harris, noted homiletics professor, states that:

There are enough—indeed too many—proponents of the status quo. This is why there is an urgent need for effective preaching that is truthful, indicting, confrontational, straightforward—a radical simple strategy that will be heard and acted upon rather than alienating—preaching that will challenge and transform.³

Black preaching historically has had a redemption motif. Through faithfully following the dictates, commands, instructions, or imperatives of God, humanity is able to overcome any negative behavior—individual, communal, national, or global. Consistent preaching of redemption through the reiteration of crucifixion and resurrection is to instill encouragement and recognition of God's promise that injustice by anyone for any purpose never stands. It is through the radical nature of Black preaching that social movements have been strategized, staged, sustained, and have ultimately succeeded. It is through the liberative messages and melodies of Black preaching that Black individuals and communities have been empowered to critique, challenge, and change. To preach prophetically is to persuade listeners to accept the power God gives them to implement changes in their lives and in the lives of others.

Conduit

The origins of Black preaching stem from the charismatic custodians of ancient Africa who facilitated worship through dynamics, direction, and development. Enslaved and free men and women were the vessels of the Word of God. In “The Politics of Silence” womanist scholar and preacher Cheryl Townsend Gilkes states:

Although the Black male preacher was the leader recognized by whites and their religious institutions, Black women emerged as worship leaders, preachers, catechizers, exhorters, prayer warriors, singers, teachers and storytellers—all authoritative agents of the Black religious tradition⁴

The role of the Black preacher is to assist the listeners in the identification of spiritual, social, cultural, psychological, and economical issues that impact daily life. The preacher presents the realities of Black life through a hermeneutics of suspicion and examination of the status quo. These trained spiritual specialists and orators are called to address the reality of disenfranchisement that stagnates personal pursuit of relationships, goals, and objectives for God’s people. These shepherds of the souls, pastors of the sheep, and prophets to the people provide holistic leadership, perform all rites, and advocate for the transformation of individuals and community. Theologian W. Paul Jones wrote that the truth of one’s faith perspective as a Christian is its “livability, tested in the midst of a supportive and accountable faith community.”⁵ The Black preacher’s prophetic preaching is never discontinuous with the past but “finds resources internal to the tradition of the community of faith to call that community to its true identity.”⁶ They assist the listener in the identification, examination and resolution of alienation, conflict, and oppression located within the biblical text and society. Through telling and retelling stories of salvific incidents of God’s self-revelation, action, and promises in human history, preaching’s purpose is accomplished.

Conversely, over the centuries there have been Black preachers who have thrived as celluloid caricatures, hungry for chicken, arrayed in outlandish cabaret-like attire, touting affected spiritual gifts for sale, scamming or manipulating congregational funds, and demanding sexual favors. This is particularly evident in the current “celebrity culture” television franchises, so-called, such as *The Preachers of LA* and *The Preachers of Detroit*. Others present sermon material with acerbic damnation of listeners, predictable endings, time worn and clichéd illustrations, sexist or homophobic language, theologically vapid exhortations, and market share-competitive publicity campaigns with little or no connection to the realities of congregants’ lives. Some seemingly view the business of fund-raising as more important than assisting listeners in raising their spiritual consciousness.

Sadly, exemplary early Black preachers such as John Marrant, Nancy Prince, Andrew Bryan, Mattie Jackson, Harry Hoosier, Elizabeth, Richard Allen, and Jarena Lee are all but forgotten or never known in many contemporary faith communities. While teaching Contemporary Black Preaching, I am continually amazed at the number of students who have never heard of Black church leaders and prophetic preachers like Adam Clayton Powell, Gardner Taylor, Pauli Murray, Henry and Ella Mitchell, James Forbes, Frederick Sampson, Prathia Hall, or Vernon Johns. These exemplars have been replaced by numerous ordained and self-proclaimed lay speakers, pastors, evangelists, overseers, ministers, elders, shepherds, priests, preachers, missionaries, apostles, bishops, and archbishops who have the temerity to appear before God’s people in pulpits, on the Internet, street corners, iPods, televisions, and conference stages, daily proclaiming an interpretation or their interpretation of the Word of God. The contemporary spiritual experts frequenting the “Church of Oprah-Super Soul Sunday” or Iyanla Vanzant’s

“Fix My Life” reach more congregants worldwide than the worship experiences of the many Black megachurches.

Critique

Contemporary Black preaching is often relegated to threshing floor sexual innuendo objectifying women as needing a covering to worship or white-faced minstrel-like pronouncements of God’s desire to be a spiritual automated teller machine (ATM) for those who faithfully and blindly follow. There are so-called leaders who extort millions in the name of giving first fruits (offerings) while extending invitations to visiting preachers to the master’s meat (sexual favors). Connectional or congregational ordination of ministers is frequently replaced by the extolling of one’s own elevation to apostolic ascendancy. Construction of Nebuchadnezzar-like cathedrals on urban and exurban Plains of Dura are routine, mandated by preaching, and that all fall down in submission to their greatness. Biblically illiterate masses are extorted while the person receiving the “impartation of the Spirit” hawk is the latest rhema word they or their ghostwriter published last night. The latest crossover lyrics receive more credence than the songs of Zion or the Word of God. Worship and the Word is infected with what musicologist James Abbington calls charismania (“turn to your neighbor,” “high five,” “roll over when I say,” do calisthenics, and so on) over a God-ordained spiritual move to affirm God’s Word.⁷ Listeners are leaving services with gaping wounds, starved for a word of hope from a neo-Gnostic word that no one can obtain on this side of glory.

Thankfully, there are those who study the Word of God with a passion and exhibit careful and theologically sound messages. They immerse themselves in the text and seek spiritual guidance for a particular time and a particular people. They acknowledge that in order for one to be truly prophetic one has to have a pastoral core. This group is more interested in the saving of souls than the size of their honorarium. They preach for 5 or 5,000 people with equal fervor. These preachers understand that their role and message extends beyond the pulpit or the walls of the sanctuary. They are spiritually, socially, emotionally, and politically relevant.

Pedagogical Considerations Prospects and Implications for the Academia, Church, and Society

“To know nothing is bad . . . to learn nothing is worse.”—African proverb

This essay has been a review of my professional and personal assessment of the state of contemporary Black preaching. It is grounded in signification. Signification allows us to convey information from person to person and across generations. We gather these ideas even though we may never have met face to face. It allows words to enflame our emotions and passions. I tell my students that it is not enough to critique, deconstruct, or signify. One must also suggest some viable options for reconstruction and alternative means of activating a new way of being or doing. At the intersection of Black Church Studies programs and the discipline of Homiletics, particularly Black Preaching, I would suggest the following list of non-prioritized, non-exhaustive pedagogical considerations.

Historical Considerations

Black Church Studies classes may include both present and past architects of “preaching moments.” They must address those places and persons who continue to deny leadership and ordination to women. Intensive study of the person of the preacher—age, gender, education, denomination, charisma, spouse, title, calling, and social-political engagement—would

also flesh out our understanding of the church and its leadership. Issues of church administration, pastoral responsibilities and salary, honoraria, care of self, conflict management, family support, confidentiality, alternative ministerial professions, community development, and navigation of denominational politics are critical areas of concern for twenty-first-century preachers.

Theological Considerations

What is the nature of God, the image of God, the name of God, the action of God, and the love of God spoken or heard in the Black church and Black homiletics? How do Black preachers discern whether the message is shaped by a theology rooted in Scripture or by current views of reality today or are the two in conflict? How can the sermon illuminate the gospel already active in the lives of the people and in ways they have not considered? What is the spectrum of theological viewpoints represented among the congregation? What negative life experiences, circumstances, or influences have a bearing on my preaching and how? What “peak” experiences of faith have shaped my theology and expression of faith? What is happening in the world as the sermon is prepared? How is God calling the preacher and the listeners to respond to the preached word?

Exegetical Considerations

Biblical studies and biblical language professionals are essential to teaching Black preachers how to use the biblical text with integrity. The avoidance of bibliolatry or “Bible worship” will yield sermons with textually sound foundations. Biblical scholar Richard Hayes states,

If the sermon is not informed by careful study of scripture, the preacher is likely to offer the congregation recycled common sense rather than the proclamation of the Word of God.⁸

The preacher needs a serious wrestling with the text to preach effectively. She or he should limp after immersion in and questioning of the text for its appropriate usage in a particular situation. Isogesis (reading meaning into the text) is traditional in Black preaching but some preachers wring all of the life out of the text and make up their own agenda-driven interpretation.

Sociological Considerations

Black preachers have been pastoral and prophetic socio-historically. There is a continued need for congregational studies not just in terms of demographics but an assessment of recipients of the preached word. Congregational studies focusing on individual and corporate realities are essential to effective preaching. What is the dominant interpretation of the world and how does it affect the communication of the Word of God? How does the dominant perception of the world affect our view of ourselves and of our society? What is the ethnic, cultural, gender, age, racial, health, theological, social, and educational composition of your congregation? How has Black preaching and the Black preacher been influenced by popular culture presentations and depictions of the preaching moment, definition of truth, relevance of faith, completion for listener, or lifestyle and character of persons who called to preach? Black Church Studies programs need to engage in a deeper analysis of congregational makeup in terms of social location, generational differences, cognitive processing, language usage, cultural heritage, duration

of church history and membership, inherited leadership, shifting social cultural demographics, communication styles, and theological grounding, each of which directly impacts the preached word.

Pastoral Care Considerations

Preachers must speak to the hungers of the people who sit in the pews. They need a sense of place, roots, and history.⁹ Sermons are to effect behavioral change through conversion, discipleship, forgiveness, honesty, generosity, and humility. Preachers are called to do more than console and answer questions. Those who teach homiletics and those who preach must consult with practitioners and professors in the field of pastoral theology and pastoral care to avoid pop psychology-based sermons and group counseling from the pulpit that leaves more persons in pain after the “living word” than before the sermon. The “just have faith,” “tell all of your story now,” “just get over it,” “it wasn’t that bad,” and “it is all your fault” mantras of many contemporary preachers, particularly at large conferences, need to be examined in pastoral care and counseling classes. While preaching is often therapeutic it can prove detrimental if the preacher has no sense of the human condition or the personal histories of the congregants.

Ethical Considerations

Preaching about justice issues is fraught with difficulty. One can be bombastic or avoid societal ills. Preaching is the transformative work of challenging the status quo—hermeneutics of suspicion. It is the acknowledgement of our need to change. It is consciousness-raising. It is a process of seeking justice, reconciliation, and transformation. Injustice depends on either active or passive support (resulting from silence, indifference, or fear) of the majority. Violence is any personal, interpersonal, institutional, or systemic act, attitude, or policy that dehumanizes, diminishes, or destroys. It thrives by passive or active support. The Black preacher may choose to be silent, ignore an issue, or speak out for justice.

Homiletician Charles Campbell stipulates that preachers should be cautious when preaching about ethical issues. The preacher should consider, among other things, the negative consequences and ostracism in speaking up about a particular subject, the penalty for failure to speak publicly, the danger of identification with something larger than life, scapegoating, blaming the victim, ingraining a sense of hopelessness, and trivialization of the Christian message.¹⁰ Black preaching should continue to address the “web of systemic oppressions”¹¹ that comprise exploitation, marginalization, powerlessness and imperialism, and the hopeful expectation of their eradication rather than deteriorate into vague promises of material gain. Employing my background in ethics, my preaching Contemporary Black Preaching and Prophetic Preaching classes engage how to preach about the spiritual-social issues of disease and addiction, handicappism (ableism), crime and punishment, global human rights, sexism, sexual orientation, ecological justice, ageism, materialism (conspicuous consumption), racism, classism, domestic violence, abuse (rape, legal), suicide, health (HIV/AIDS, diabetes, heart disease, obesity, cancer, breast cancer, stroke, infant mortality, etc.), and the myriad of issues facing the Black community. Care is taken to analyze the social context and use current statistics and supported facts, and careful exegesis of the biblical text. As Salvadoran Archbishop Oscar Romero reminded us not long before his assassination in 1980:

A church that doesn’t provoke any crisis, a gospel that doesn’t unsettle, a word of God that doesn’t get under anyone’s skin, a word of God that doesn’t touch the real sin of the society in which it is being proclaimed, what gospel is that? . . . Those preachers who avoid every thorny matter so as not to be harassed, so as not to have conflicts and difficulties, do not light up the world they live in.¹²

Black Church Studies programs that fail proactively to address social crisis will become silenced and dimmed by more than academic budgetary concerns.

Linguistic Considerations

Black preachers traditionally have had a love of the poetic power of language. The articulation of the sacred “Word of God” can free persons to weep away their pain or shout with cathartic joy. Black preachers’ rhetoric, communication channel, imagery, poetics, style, metaphor, simile, intonation, pregnant pausing, self-disclosure, message-intent body movement, and facial expression at times relay more faith information than vocalizations. Language is also potentially dangerous in its use for “othering” or objectifying people. It can open deep wounds or ostracize any person who does not comply with the standards of the preacher or the church. I agree with the writings of John S. McClure that state the preacher must learn to take risks and address and erase the abusive hegemony of language that harms others.¹³

Those who teach in Black Church Studies programs need a reevaluation of how we describe each other, how we name God, and how we explain our faith without demeaning other people, beliefs, or faiths. The exclusive use of “Father,” “brothers,” “men,” “man and wife,” “birth mothers,” “those people,” “those sinners,” and “them” and similarly exclusive terms erect linguistic spiritual barriers.

Media Considerations

Black Church Studies programs, to remain relevant, will need to broaden the range of churches considered. There are of course traditional community churches and a growing number of churches that exist only in studio, hotel room, or computer with a camera attached. We live in the age of cyber spirituality. Televangelist Mark Kellner once described the Internet as “one of the greatest mission fields in history.” Web evangelism is one of the highest priorities for the evangelical community at large. A perusal of websites presents a twenty-first-century cyber world of representation by most denominations and faith groups of tearful close-ups, camera angles, “aw shucks” humor, constant music by guest soloists, groups or professional musicians, introduction of esteemed audience members, special guest celebrities and athletes, tear-filled testimonies of deliverance from depraved lifestyles, or socially critiqued lifestyles, well-dressed hosts, diverse languages, pledge drives, opulent settings, multiethnic representations, reports on international missions, ministries named for living persons rather than buildings honoring the dead, calls for patriotism, managed ethos, talk show host formats, and calls for salvation. Electronic church preaching may include any or all of the following elements:

- Self-disclosure life story
- Authority
- Patriotism, American values
- Family
- Gender/sexuality
- Care of the preacher
- Spirit power
- Compassion for listener
- Use of biblical text
- Speaking in vernacular or simple “in-language”
- Responsibility
- Sin
- Prosperity/favor

- Healing
- Ascribed roles
- Rare social justice issues
- Necessity of personal conversion
- Fund-raising
- Sale of media (consumer-based pleas, varied media platforms, or website ministry sales)

There has been a subtle assimilation of content, delivery, and style among the “cyber preachers.” The clear-cut “Black preaching” style and the “conversational White preaching” style of the twentieth century are imperceptively fusing into a uniform televangelist style. At the same time worship is rehearsed rather than spontaneous. It has become almost exclusively small group (praise team) lead than congregational. At times, when observing worship services by churches on the Internet or in studios one is left with the impression of performance rather than service, of concert rather than church, and of play rather than profession of faith.

There is an increase in social media of a type of “Facebook Church” where persons moralize about current events, post and repost opinions based on kneejerk understandings of breaking news, moralize about “those people,” and post advertisements for their upcoming services, Instagram photos, or video clips as service progresses and transmit reviews on the efficacy of the sermon. Additionally, with the development of “I-preaching” Black preachers are obligated to work even more diligently on “Tweetable” purpose statements, illustrations, and ideas that listeners can Tweet or Retweet in 140 characters or less while maintaining a sense of cultural authenticity and faith-filled spirituality.

Concluding Matters

According to Maria Harris, *Proclamation Jubilee! A Spirituality for the Twenty-First Century* purports that the five major challenges for believers are to demand liberation, emphasize connectedness, provide a corrective for suffering, use the power of imagination, and repair the world.¹⁴ These are the same challenges faced by the Black church in its origins. Those who teach homiletics in Black Church Studies programs must be attuned to the realities and challenges of the historical and contemporary church, the persons called to the preaching profession, and the context of proclamation. Areas of concern warranting special consideration consist of history, theology, biblical studies, sociology, pastoral care, ethics, linguistics, and media. Black Church Studies programs must continue to provide support for and instruction in accountability to those who utilize the preached word through critique, social analysis of context, evaluation of content, and education of the conduits. Black religious leadership, preachers and academicians, must work together and move from the possibility of becoming stagnant and spiritually corrupt colonies crying out “Unclean, Unclean!” as others approach, to becoming integrity-filled transformative proclamation vessels validating all humanity as agents for and recipients of God’s holistic word.

Notes

1. Cheryl Townsend Gilkes, “Some Mother’s Son and Some Father’s Daughter,” in Cheryl Townsend Gilkes, ed., *If It Wasn’t for the Women* (Maryknoll: Orbis, 2001), 129–130.
2. Melva Wilson Costen, *African American Christian Worship* (Nashville: Abingdon, 1993), 40–47.
3. James Harris, *Preaching Liberation* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1995), 38.
4. Cheryl Townsend Gilkes, “The Politics of Silence,” *If It Wasn’t for the Women* (Maryknoll: Orbis Books, 2001), 102.

5. W. Paul Jones, *Worlds within a Congregation: Dealing with Theological Diversity* (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 2000), 36.
6. Steven Long, "Prophetic Preaching," in William H. Willimon and Richard Lischer, eds., *Concise Encyclopedia of Preaching* (Louisville: Westminster/John Knox, 1995), 385–389.
7. James Abbingdon, *Let Mount Zion Rejoice: Music in the African American Church* (Valley Forge: Judson, 2001), 111.
8. Richard B. Hays, "Exegesis," in William H. Willimon and Richard A. Lischer, eds., *Concise Encyclopedia of Preaching* (Louisville: Westminster/John Knox, 1995), 122–128.
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10. Charles Campbell, *The Word Before the Powers: An Ethic of Preaching* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2002), 33–39.
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12. Oscar Romero, *The Violence of Love: The Pastoral Wisdom of Archbishop Oscar Romero*, trans. and comp. James R Brockmen (New York: Harper and Row, 1988), 64.
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Music and Worship in Black Church Studies Curricula

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In his enduring classic *The Souls of Black Folk*, published in 1903, W. E. B. DuBois declared, “Three things characterized this religion of the slave—the Preacher, the Music, and the Frenzy.” One needs only to visit an African American church in worship to witness the significance and reality of DuBois’ statement in the twenty-first century.

The sermon, or more accurately the *preaching*, and the music, or more accurately the *singing*, are the focal points of worship in the Black church as magnets of attraction and primary vehicles of spiritual transport. C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence Mamiya concluded, “In the Black Church, good preaching and good singing are almost invariably the minimum conditions of a successful ministry.”¹ With this understanding and reality of the Black church experience, seminaries and divinity schools must develop and integrate the study of music and worship into their required curricula in order for their graduates to be truly prepared for parish ministry in the twenty-first century. Courses in biblical studies, theology, and church history primarily serve the preaching moment, providing students with the requisite tools to do exegesis with integrity and construct sound theological positions. However, the whole of worship is at the very heart of the Black church, and music is the bloodline. Therefore, formal preparation for this integral aspect of the Black church’s life must begin in seminaries and divinity schools.

The purpose of this chapter is four-fold: (1) to address the need for critical historical, sociological, and theological reflection on what is being preached and what is being sung in the Black church; (2) to establish the need for music and worship education in the curricula of seminaries and divinity schools, in general, and Black Church Studies programs, in particular; (3) to explore the role of seminaries and divinity schools in the preparation of ministers, worship leaders, and musicians for effective ministry in the Black church in the twenty-first century; and (4) to provide resources by African American scholars, theologians, pastors, ministers, and musicians for such programs of study.

In most seminaries and divinity schools, music and worship are *not* required courses, if they are offered at all. If music and worship, hymnody, or liturgy courses are offered, they are generally electives and often neglected. The implicit assumption is that music is not central to worship. This is unfortunate and often accounts for the fact that many pastors, ministers, worship leaders, and musicians have no biblically based, theologically sound understanding of worship or the role of music in worship. This neglect of music and worship in theological

education is even more critical for Black Church Studies programs because of the significant emphasis that is placed on music, or singing, in the Black church.

Wyatt Tee Walker writes, "If you listen to what Black people are singing religiously, it will provide a clue as to what is happening to them sociologically,"² and James H. Cone asserts, "Black worship is connected with Black life, and it is characterized by a religious sense inseparable from the suffering that determined it." Cone continues, "To understand the interplay of the past, present, and future as these are expressed in black worship, it is necessary to examine first the historical context that created its unique style and the theological content that defined its meaning."³ Both Walker and Cone make it clear that the music and worship of the Black community cannot be properly analyzed or understood apart from the people who sing it and the context that produced it. Hence, in addition to studying music for form, rhythm and meter, and studying worship for liturgical elements, appointments and parameters, the study of music and worship should incorporate the studies of sociology, history, and theology in order to more fully, authentically, and comprehensively understand music and worship's meaning and significance. Walker and Cone provide compelling support for the position that the interdisciplinary study of the music and worship of the Black church become a required course of study in theological institutions.

A comprehensive overview of the development of Black Gospel music in America is essential to understanding the historical and theological development of the Black church in the twentieth century. In his extensive essay, "I am the Holy Dope Dealer: Problems with Today's Gospel Music," which compares traditional spirituals with contemporary gospel music, Obery Hendricks concludes that in comparing the importance of "collective root experience"⁴ of composers of Black sacred music with today's Gospel music composers, there is a disconnect. Hendricks writes:

Despite the empowering nature of Black sacred music of the past, in the dominant mode of Black religious music today—which is contemporary Gospel music—the prophetic voice, this resistance voice, this biblical logic of justice, is all but stilled. Gospel music is heard everywhere today; yet unlike the spirituals, it does not press out suits of freedom; it does not call, like the spirituals did, for "Moses, way down in Egypt land, [to] tell ole Pharaoh to let my people go."⁵

As Hendricks asserts, a significant amount of contemporary gospel music is ungrounded. That is, it does not have its foundation in the Bible's mandate to serve the least of these and to liberate. To be sure, all gospel music need not articulate the same message; some attention and expression should certainly be given to national and international concerns and conditions. One of the greatest problems with contemporary music is that it is "temporary." It is here today and gone tomorrow. "The pathetic aspect is that the music, often enjoyed by worshippers, offers little by way of Christian education or kingdom building, and the effect lasts only a few minutes after its 'embers' fade away," said Wendell P. Whalum. He continued:

As I see it, the clergy and musicians are both to blame for what has occurred, and logically, it is their responsibility to correct it. [Some] of the blame, too, will inevitably point to many of us who, in addition to being practicing church musicians, also have, little by little, abdicated our responsibility of instructing those who have not had good training but who, for various reasons, assume the task. We are, therefore, guilty of standing by through the years watching music in the Black church, to a large degree, deteriorate and, to some extent, decay.⁶

The infiltration of contemporary gospel music in many of today's worship services severely encroaches on the spirituals' place of historic, theological, and cultural honor in the corporate liturgical life of the Black church. Not only are the spirituals at risk of being cast off, but also are our hymns. In a lecture given at the Hampton University Ministers' Conference and Choir Directors' Organists' Guild Workshop several years ago, J. Wendell Mapson, Jr. declared:

Congregational hymn singing is almost a lost art in the Black church. We allow the choir to do all the singing with their special arrangements and contemporary songs that people may enjoy, but cannot participate in. This spectator worship is not the kind of worship pleasing to God. Congregational singing is in the intensive care unit breathing its last breath.⁷

Ministers must be equipped, not only with the historical aspects of music and worship in the Black church, but they must be knowledgeable of the theological foundations. Cone cautions:

Black worship is more than an expression of our historical struggle to be free. Because it is more than what we do, a mere historical analysis of the context of its origin is simply not adequate But we have not really touched the heart of Black worship from the perspective of the people until we deal with the *theological* claim affirmed in prayer, song, and story.⁸

Theology, history, and more are neither disparate nor disconnected from the study of music and worship in the Black church but rather are essential disciplines for pastors, ministers, and music leaders if they are to render ministry that is relevant and has integrity. The Black church must never abandon the historical and theological legacy of psalms, spirituals, or hymns, and the Black church must continue to include them in the worship service, making them relevant and meaningful in this twenty-first-century context.

In addition to theological and historical reflection and study, Black church pastors, ministers, and music leaders must give critical attention to the current cultural trends and musical expressions and their influence and impact on the Black church. One of the Black church's most challenging cultural phenomena is hip hop culture. Michael Eric Dyson makes this profound observation:

Although widely celebrated as the East Coast's answer to the rhetorician of glorified violence out West, Biggie Smalls could deliver brilliant social analyses and moving portraits of poverty with metaphoric wittiness and rhythmic flow, as he does on a lyric from his first album, *Ready to Die*, remembering how "the landlord dissed us/I used to wonder why Christmas missed us/Birthdays were the worst days/Now we sip champagne when we thirsty/Damned right I like the life I live/Cause I went from negative to positive." Biggie shares honors with Tupac in the articulation of a grassroots secular urban theodicy.

Of course, that's a perennial theological problem that preachers at their best have always paid attention to. It was evident, too, when Shakur pleaded: "Somebody help me/Tell me where to go from here/Cause even thugs cry/But do the Lord care?" Here's a rapper asking, in effect, "Does God care about the human suffering I see and endure? I want moral leadership. I want ethical guidance. I don't derive that from a connection to a religious community. But I am still obsessed with God language." Tupac's like a Reformation-minded Martin Luther in FUBU! What fascinates me about young rappers who are critical of religious culture is that they are obsessed with many of the same problems and questions that are debated among believers. The farther many rappers claim to be from religious culture, the closer they prove themselves to be to these communities in the moral grammars and even the secular heuristics they deploy. In fact, hardcore hip hoppers like Tupac Shakur and Snoop Dogg were reared in the church or influenced by its discourse, practice, and witness.⁹

While there are pastors and ministers who have developed hip hop services and are reaching out to the hip hop community, many pastors, ministers, and church leaders are not in active, substantive conversation with anyone enlightened or informed on hip hop culture or its issues. Churches are overlooking the great potential for reaching a new generation of believers through hip hop music. Fortunately, some preachers are raising relevant social concerns, perspectives, and/or questions regarding issues of theodicy (albeit expressed differently from rap artists); new topics have emerged for contemporary Black church preaching

that mark a radical departure from what has been the predominant substance of Black preaching.

Martha Simmons, president and publisher of *The African American Pulpit*, shared with me some very interesting discoveries about contemporary preaching topics. In reviewing five years of sermons submitted to *The African American Pulpit* (a total of 800-plus messages) and in spending three years reviewing 300 years of African American preaching in preparation for the first *Norton Anthology of African American Preaching*, she identified topics that have been repeatedly articulated in Black preaching within the last five to six years. They are: (1) God will prosper you, (2) the devil will attack because God is doing major things in your life, (3) the roughest circumstances are segues to your success, (4) eliminate the things and people who are blocking your success, (5) praise God and be blessed, and (6) no weapon formed against you shall prosper. Toward the end of our conversation, Simmons remarked, "How will the illiterate and unchurched in this post-modern age know the 'whole' Gospel if this is all we preach?"

Conspicuously absent from much of today's preaching is the social and historical contextualization of our current world within the sermon. The social critique and commentary that was once a main component in much of Black preaching has been replaced almost exclusively with the kinds of individual, self-oriented, and self-serving theology and language aforementioned. One of the challenges of the Black church in the twenty-first century is how to marry preaching and music that is complementary and relevant to social and historical contexts and to worshippers in and of these contexts and how to do it with biblical and theological integrity and continuity. Collaboration and partnership between pastors and musicians is the best and yet most neglected way to accomplish this.

One of the most critical needs in theological curricula is the opportunity to explore and examine the relationship between the pastor and the musician. Current thematic trends and expressions in music and sermons are sometimes in competition with one another, and other times they are in conflict with each other. Too often, musical selections fail to prepare congregants for the preached Word and fail to complement the Scripture and the sermon. Sunday after Sunday congregations must endure liturgical collisions and casseroles of unrelated themes and elements in worship. This is unacceptable, and it robs both God and worshippers of the harmonious worship experience where God is glorified and worshippers experience God's power and presence. Pastor and musician working together in the planning of music and worship is the only remedy.

In any worship service, there should be a thematic thread that runs throughout the entire service. Both pastor and musician need to know how to develop, sustain, and strengthen their relationship, accomplished by first knowing, understanding, and respecting the scope of each other's responsibilities. This knowledge should not be gained as part of "on-the-job training," but rather as an integral component of the formal, academic preparation for ministry. Among the many forms these learning and development opportunities can take include colloquiums, practicums, and seminars where pastors and musicians work collaboratively and become conversation partners before graduating so that partnership and collaboration are expectations and not anomalies of the pastor-musician relationship.

It is unfortunate that in so many churches, pastors and musicians give little, if any, attention to developing strong and fruitful partnerships. In part, it is because neither had ever been advised (or warned!) about how vital this relationship is to their respective ministries and the worship life of the church. Further, pastors and musicians must always remember that their relationship is one of the most public relationships in the church. The nature of the relationship between the pastor and the musician will almost always manifest itself in the context of the worship service, for better or worse. The point is that any places of disunity or poor, little, or no communication are sure to be exposed in the worship service, and worship of God should not be affected or infected by deficiencies in the pastor-musician relationship, whatever they are and with whomever they lie. Pastors and musicians must always be mindful that they serve

to help others worship, so the pastor–musician relationship and the service they each render directly impact the congregation’s worship experience.

It will remain bad theology so long as the theologian and the artist refuse to communicate with one another, as long as the theologian regards the artist as fundamentally a temperamental trifter, and [the artist regards] the theologian as an obstinate and ignorant theorist, the best we shall get is patronage from church to music, together with tentative moralisms from musicians to musicians,

Eric Routley wrote in his classic, *Church Music and Theology*, “At worst it will be, as it often in practice is, a wicked waste of an opportunity for glorifying God through fruitful partnership.”¹⁰

Routley’s stringent indictment challenges each party in the pastor–musician relationship to revise their view of the other as a first step toward forging the kind of partnership that will produce worship that truly glorifies God, as opposed to the tug-of-war matches that often occur during worship. However, not all worship services have turf wars as a liturgical element. There are some churches where the musician is responsible for everything related to music and worship, and all the pastor does is preach! This should not be the case either. It is the pastor’s responsibility to lead in worship (or as some have said, be the lead worshiper). This non-negotiable role should not be confused with the pastor as “micromanager,” as is the case in many churches where the pastor alone makes too many decisions about music and worship. However, there are churches where the pastor *has* to make all the decisions, lead worship, play the organ, and preach because he or she has no one in music leadership with whom to share the planning or execution.

There are also churches who have musicians who oppose the pastor’s involvement in the music ministry because as trained, skilled, and gifted leaders of music, they feel they should have complete control and be in charge of all music-related decisions and selections. It is this type of egocentric and arrogant attitude that has sustained and fortified much of the unbalanced, unfocused, unbiblical, and non-theological music offerings (and choir conflicts) that churches have become addicted to and notorious for perpetuating. To be sure, there are pastors who possess neither musical talent and skills nor the ability to sing, play, or beat a drum. However, their lack of musical talent, skill, and ability *does not* exclude them from the suggesting, decision-making, and evaluating elements and processes that relate to worship. Too often, ministers endure and allow poor theology to be sung and taught musically in worship because (1) the people seem to like it and respond emotionally by shouting, applauding, and cheering the choir or soloist on, (2) they are insecure about their own musical/liturgical knowledge, and/or (3) they are intimidated by the person(s) in musical leadership.

Ideally, pastors and musicians should plan worship together so that the musician will always operate in harmony with the Word, and the pastor does not feel that she or he is in competition with the musician. I have personally witnessed great sermons be vastly diminished and dismantled by an inappropriate musical selection that followed the sermon. When pastors and musicians are in partnership before and during worship, incidents like this can be greatly diminished and even eradicated. Optimally, partnerships and partnership expectations would begin in seminaries and divinity schools where pastors and musicians are enlightened about the responsibilities of the other and where they are taught that a healthy professional relationship with each other is vital to their respective ministries and the life of the church. Thus, seminaries and divinity schools, specifically theological curricula that include music and worship education, become integral components of the formation and development of pastors and musicians who will serve the Black church in the twenty-first century.

In classes that I have taught, I have required students, many of whom were pastors, to select not only pre-sermon hymns that supported their sermons, but also an invitational and a closing

hymn that would reinforce and enhance their message. This simple exercise afforded pastors a practical, first-hand opportunity to explore how the relevance, value, and strength of the worship experience is deepened by relevant text choices and musical connections. Many adopted this practice in their own churches. Although these students were unable to play or sing the tunes, they were more secure and informed to select hymns by texts that were appropriate for worship and that best supported their sermons. More importantly, they understood that it was the primary responsibility of the *musical* leadership to produce what they had requested and selected. Their input was essential to the worship planning process and provided the musical leadership with stronger selections of music for the service. It is tragic when pastors and musicians do not plan worship together or are improperly prepared to do so. In the book *African American Worship: New Eyes for Seeing*, Frederick H. Talbot says:

Two contemporary management planners have defined planning as “deciding in advance *what* to do, *how* to do it, *when* to do it, and *who* is to do it.” The definition summarizes the essential elements in planning: *what*, *how*, *when*, and *who*. Planning bridges the gap from where we are to where we want to go. It makes it possible for things to occur which would not otherwise happen and although the best-laid plans can fail to materialize, without some form of planning events are left to chance. Experience shows that nothing significant happens when left to chance. In fact, the dictum rings true: “to fail to plan is to plan to fail.”¹¹

Additionally, planning worship should not be sporadic, seasonal, or for convenience. It must be consistent and viewed as a sacred task. There must be sufficient time for the musician to select and prepare the choir for regular and special occasions in the life of the church. Worship planned in advance will allow both the pastor and the musician to investigate, gather, and study relevant materials. Pastors and musicians must have weekly time set aside to plan all worship services. In addition to these weekly planning sessions, they should meet at least twice each year to review the church calendar and plan worship accordingly. The twice yearly sessions should occur in concert with other members of the church community.

In her book *African American Christian Worship*, Melva W. Costen adds the following suggestions for worship planning:

- Consider the lived experiences of worshipers and their understanding of worship.
- Consider the worship space.
- Become familiar with your denominational polity and theology of worship to determine what elements are required and what your denomination believes about each of these elements.
- Use Scripture to undergird the entire worship event.
- Consider the flow of the service to determine what pattern facilitates worship in the particular congregation
- Take care that the language of the liturgy is inclusive.

Although it is essential to prepare a well-planned worship service, there will be times when the manifestation of the Holy Spirit will be so intense that this same Spirit will require a reordering and redirecting of even the best planned worship service. William Watley, pastor of St. James AME Church in Newark, New Jersey, cautions, “We must be flexible in our worship and not get so caught up and upset about what is on the printed bulletin.” He continues:

One Sunday at Saint James the Spirit fell, and it was obvious that it was preaching time. I called for the sermonic hymn and took my text. After the service, one of my anal-retentive, high-liturgical members came up to me and said, “Reverend, you forgot to acknowledge the visitors and call for Sister So-and-So who had a presentation to make to the Building Fund.” I told her that I didn’t forget but that when the Holy Ghost comes everything changes. Ever

since that Sunday, at the top of our bulletin is the heading: "The worship is under the direction of the Holy Spirit and subject to change without notice."¹²

In addition to partnering and planning, continuing education is needed. If a pastor, minister, or worship leader has had theological training in a seminary or divinity school, it is likely that neither music and worship nor liturgy was required in their course of study, if they were offered at all. The same can be said for musicians. If they have received formal training, it is very likely that courses in church music, hymnology, theology, or music in worship were not required. Musicians earn degrees in applied vocal or instrumental performance, music education, choral conducting, etcetera. However, few are trained to understand the role of music in worship, liturgy, or to have a solid, working knowledge of biblical and theological music literature that is appropriate for the church. All of this makes continuation education critical for pastors and musicians!

Leith Anderson wrote:

There is a growing realization that classical theological education has not appropriately prepared men and women for leadership in the late twentieth-century American churches. One well-known evangelical seminary has developed a continuing education model, which insiders have dubbed the "recall program." Like cars being called by Detroit automakers for correction for poorly designed brakes or fuel lines, our schools need to bring back graduates from the 1970s and 1980s, recent graduates, and warmly welcome local pastors and musicians who are wrestling with problems before they experience failure in their churches. Like all recall programs, it is based on the recognition that many have already failed and the reason is an initial design error.¹³

It is most appropriate that seminaries and divinity schools provide opportunities and resources to build and strengthen partnerships between pastors and musicians by offering seminars each semester, one- or two-week sessions during the summer and evening courses on days that do not conflict with church duties and responsibilities. It is important that students, faculty, and administrators see worship as an important and legitimate discipline of study. I am sure that many theological school faculty and administrators will shrug or sigh at the thought of expanding the curriculum and faculty, but theological education should not disregard or ignore the needs of the local churches for whom they are presumably preparing pastors, ministers, and musicians to serve. Fortunately, some seminaries and schools of theology, denominational bodies, and other institutions are offering effective means for pastors and ministers to retool their skills, and they must be commended for their efforts. *However, whether we like it or not, unless we are an active part of the solution, we, as institutions, are a major part of the problem!*

In his book *The New Worship: Straight Talk on Music in the Church*, Barry Liesch makes this painful—but oh, so true—observation:

Those who become worship pastors receive a *different* education in a *different* location than seminaries. Musicians receive their education at conservatories, colleges, and universities, whereas pastors and church educators receive theirs at seminaries and schools of theology of the pastoral dimension of ministry. Musicians experience no contact with seminarians, nor do they study theology or the pastoral dimension of ministry. The two groups share no common core courses where they can dialogue with each other, nor do they have the privilege of rubbing shoulders together in practicums. In the few seminaries that teach worship, the music and worship programs are often not combined.¹⁴

Robert Webber attests to the state of affairs in seminaries. He writes:

What is needed . . . is the recognition of worship as a legitimate discipline among the other disciplines . . . It is a field in its own right. Indeed it is an inter-disciplinary study demanding

expertise in biblical, historical, and systematic theology as well as the arts, practical expertise, and personal formation.¹⁵

While Liesch and Webber identify the shortcoming in theological curricula with regard to music and worship education, Paul W. Wohlgenuth boldly informs us that there is a bridge missing between the academy and the church. Wohlgenuth writes:

Seminaries need to become more aware of [various] trend[s of worship] and prepare students to guide their congregations in [these] and other worship patterns that are meaningful, enlightened, and experientially biblical. Ignoring these influences may lead the church community to miss a powerful and positive contribution to Christian worship as we approach the 21st century Even though theological education has facilitated and often pioneered significant changes in religious thought and worship practices, it has at times exhibited an inability to respond to changes that occur within the larger Christian community. In particular, the need is for trained leaders of the church's worship life who are at least informed about significant, new, and even threatening music and practices.¹⁶

Just as Lutherans are required to know the texts of Martin Luther and Methodists are indoctrinated in the texts of Charles Wesley, pastors, ministers, and music leaders in the Black church must be equally well versed and faithful to the spirituals and Black hymns and gospel songs by writers such as Charles P. Jones, Charles A. Tindley, Thomas Dorsey, Lucie Campbell, Roberta Martin, Kenneth Morris, William Brewster, James Cleveland, Andrae Crouch, and Margaret Douroux. These texts must not simply be familiar or known; they must also be subject to text analysis and exegesis so their significance and contribution to the legacy of music in the Black church is neither lost nor diminished.

On the other hand, contemporary gospel and praise and worship music must be subject to even more stringent critical analysis, not because of its doctrinal soundness or theological profundity, but rather because many of its biblically inconsistent lyrics and theologically ill-formed texts have the effect of birthing, developing, and sustaining weak, spiritually mal-formed Christians. Pastors, ministers, and music leaders must never forget that they are stewards of sound doctrine and biblical teaching and as stewards are responsible for biblical and theological soundness and integrity of communication.

Historically, the best and most effective hymns, biblically based and theologically sound, were written by priests, theologians, ministers, and those trained in Bible and theology. These include such giants as Martin Luther, Isaac Watts, Charles and John Wesley, William Williams, Dwight L. Moody, Ira D. Sankey and such early African American hymn writers as John Marrant, John Jea, Charles P. Jones, G. T. Haywood, Robert C. Lawson, and Charles A. Tindley. Many of them were not musicians; however, they composed texts that were set to music by musicians. Their biblical, historical, theological, and social insights of the times are reflected in their texts. Today's Black church needs contemporary hymn writers, not just contemporary gospel composers, but writers who possess this training to compose new, relevant, and appropriate congregational music for the church.

These are critical considerations for today's theological education and explain, in large measure, the music that is being composed. Today, most contemporary Gospel composers/artists/musicians have limited biblical knowledge, no theological education, and shallow and misinformed embedded theology duplicated from other artists or personal experiences. This is frightening when one considers that people leave worship humming and remembering the songs of these composers/artists/musicians and forgetting the title and texts of the sermon by the time they reach the parking lot! There are well-trained, gifted, and talented musicians who do not understand the church or her history, the denomination or its doctrine, liturgy, theology of worship, or appropriate sacred music literature but make weekly decisions

about what the congregation will hear and sing. *This is where the pastor must assume the role of teacher, model, and supervisor for the musician whose skills will not substitute for his/her lack of biblical, theological, liturgical, and pastoral understanding of the church and her people.*

I must pause here to state my own position on the various genres of music in the Black church. Variety of genre in a church's musical repertoire is not problematic for me at all. Clearly, there are many, many ways to present God's word in song, and I think that it is important and spiritually healthy for churches to broaden and diversify their music offerings. However, I am concerned that our debates, conflicts, and "wars" are more over *style* than substance and context than content. Our music becomes at risk when we are more concerned about the style or genre being presented than we are about whether the Word of God is being reinforced as biblically based, theologically sound, culturally relevant, or "rightly divided."

The pastor must take responsibility for what is being taught and rendered in the presence of the people of God. Ministers and musicians are sometimes guilty of selecting music from the Gospel, Christian, or "Inspirational" top 40 list that has been professionally recorded, commercially marketed and nationally and internationally distributed without considering the biblical or theological content for its soundness of theology and doctrine and appropriateness in worship for God's people. Unfortunately, the selection of music and styles of worship in many of our churches is being dictated by the mass media and record companies whose goal is not winning souls to Christ but selling music to consumers. Ministers must be taught to be aware and beware of this practice and commercial conspiracy that has overwhelmingly invaded many Black churches. The result is that whatever sells on radio, television, CDs, or DVDs becomes adopted as the repertoire for the church. This is the nadir of pastoral irresponsibility on the part of the minister when this happens. These observations form the basis and critical need for music and worship education in Black Church Studies programs.

In what I presume is an attempt to be relevant and contemporary, the Black church has become unusually limited and impoverished with its language, vocabulary, and gestures by duplicating, imitating, and impersonating the earthy vernacular, hip hop slang, comical colloquial expressions and sports lingo to define and represent the Divine, Holy, and Supreme Being in our music and worship. Some pastors and worship leaders have become better comedians, entertainers, and religious salespersons in the pulpit and are reinforced by the congregation commonly referred to as the audience.

As a result of this takeover by the god Entertainment, we find that many Black churches have chosen to provide religious entertainment and amusement, slammin' and jammin' praise and worship, worship that is "exploding," "cranked up," "off the hook," and "off the chain," in hope of attracting, drawing, and evangelizing the current generation. In some cases pastors expect musicians and "praise bands" to set the stage for their grand entrances (surrounded by guards called "armor bearers") which rival the entrance of the president of the United States or a hip hop or R & B recording artist on stage on a concert. The concept of a grand late entrance is most commonly associated with secular entertainment. There are the opening acts and then there is the main attraction, star, or artist. I am convinced that everyone—ministers, choirs, deacons, trustees, mothers, armor-bearers, etcetera—should all begin and end worship *together*. Worship should begin with all of the participants who lead and take part in the liturgy present, accounted for, and in place in the sanctuary.

A. W. Tozer reminds us of the following:

For centuries, the Church stood solidly against every form of worldly entertainment, recognizing it for what it was—a device for wasting time, a refuge from the disturbing voice of conscience, a scheme to divert attention from moral accountability. For this she got herself abused roundly by the sons of the world. But of late she has become tired of the abuse and has given over the struggle. She appears to have decided that if she cannot conquer the god Entertainment she may as well join forces with him and make whatever use she can of his

powers *The church that can't worship must be entertained. And men [and] women who can't lead a church to worship must provide the entertainment.*¹⁷

[emphasis added]

In 2002, the Barna Research Group of Ventura, California, prepared a report for the Christian Music Symposium at Baylor University in Waco, Texas, entitled "Music and the Church: Relevance in a Changing Culture." A nationwide survey revealed that large numbers of people who attend Christian churches are not clued in to what true worship is all about. For example:

- Among Christian adults who regularly attend worship services, *one-third* said they had never experienced the presence of God.
- When Christian adults who regularly attend worship services were asked to explain, in their own words, what "worship" is, *two-thirds* had no idea or provided a vague or meaningless explanation that had no apparent connection to worship.
- *Fewer than one half* of all Christian adults who regularly attend worship services described worshipping God as one of the top priorities of their life.
- *Only one out of every four* Christian adults who regularly attend worship services described worship as something that we do for God; most adults consider worship to be something that we undertake for personal benefit.
- *Relatively few* Christian adults who regularly attend worship services deem personal preparation for worship to be significant.

The question was asked of 601 senior pastors: "How important is worship in the overall ministry agenda of your church?" When asked to identify the two or three top ministry priorities of their church, the survey revealed that worship placed *third* among the dozens of possibilities, named as a top priority by 26 percent of senior pastors. The ministries that bested worship were evangelism (listed as a priority by 41 percent) and preaching/teaching (34 percent).

Thus, the good news is that worship ranked as the third most important ministry priority. The bad news is that only one out of every four pastors considers worship to be among the three highest priorities of their church's ministry. According to the report, worship is more likely to rank as a priority among mainline pastors (43 percent) than among pastors of charismatic (21 percent), African American (7 percent) or Baptist (18 percent) churches. It is twice as likely to be mentioned by pastors who possess liberal theological views (49 percent) versus those with moderate (25 percent) or conservative (23 percent) theological views. Worship was also more likely to be a top consideration in churches where the senior pastor chooses the worship music (32 percent) and in those congregations where the senior pastor leads the church's worship music (37 percent).

It would be very interesting to specifically survey Black churches and their senior pastors and worship leaders to see how similar the results would be! I contend that in many Black churches, pastors, ministers, worship leaders, and musicians have no real or adequately informed understanding of worship. They define worship as the rituals and procedures that are repeated week after week, month after month, and year after year in their churches. The truth is that these practices, habits, customs, rituals, and liturgical actions can become rituals without reason, ceremonies without content, singing without substance, services without sincerity, and music without meaning, relevance, or understanding in the lives of the congregation. Worship leaders may be guilty of maintaining worship traditions that have long since outlived their usefulness and meaning.

Overfamiliarity with worship rituals can exhaust a congregation of its enthusiasm and spiritual vitality. Repetitive engagement of ritual can sometimes have the unwanted effect of

spiritually desensitizing worshippers to the depths of spiritual reality and presence of God. If we worship God in only one way, we get in touch with only one aspect of God's character. For example, if we sing only songs of joy, we rejoice that God is great and awesome and benevolent. However, do we overlook our brokenness, our laments, and our need for healing, confession, and forgiveness? The church must be careful not to fall victim of a severe criticism when she fails to be in the community, city, and society what she confesses to be in worship, not only to be a worship center in the community but to live worshipfully within the community. The need for this more comprehensive and holistic understanding of worship as a lifestyle, engaged both existentially and ritually, is equally urgent though often neglected in the Black church. Lisa M. Weaver, assistant pastor of Trinity Baptist Church in Bronx, New York, offers this insightful observation:

Since worship is an individual's response to an encounter with God, worship must be understood more broadly than something that happens in a building on Sunday morning. A response can take place anywhere and anytime. So, then, Christians not only worship corporately with other believers at worship services, but Christians must also understand that worship is a *lifestyle*, for we encounter God everyday, everywhere, and our desire should always be to revere, adore, and honor God in all we do and say. For this reason, soundness and integrity in preaching and music is absolutely essential and non-negotiable Worship does not only serve to build up believers; worship leads to mission.

Authentic worship continues long after the formal liturgy has ended, the benediction pronounced, and the finally doxology is sung! It is not uncommon to see "We enter to worship God; we depart to serve God" printed on weekly bulletins. Acts of service are also acts of worship, which can be informed or deformed by what is sung and what is preached.

Another part of continuing education is making use of resources. Fortunately, in the past two decades, there has been a tremendous increase in such resources as textbooks, hymnals, hymnal supplements, and printed music, and more resources are forthcoming. Since 1977, more music has been published for congregational singing than at any other time in the history of the Black church. This is a very good sign for hymnody in the Black church. More than 20 African American hymnals have been published including the 2001 GIA Publications release of the *African American Heritage Hymnal*, a hymnal for African American Protestant churches.¹⁸ This hymnal is a much-needed compilation of Black sacred music of all genres, in addition to standard Euro-American Protestant hymnody that functions as both an anthology and practical worship resource.

Hymns provide congregations an opportunity to express their beliefs about faith and doctrine and their experiences of the Christian life. To be an authentic expression of faith, the beliefs embodied in the hymns must be true, based on Scripture, and consistent with the accepted doctrines of the church. Hymns express doctrinal truths about God and God's presence in the world, truths about Jesus Christ the Son and His work as Savior and Redeemer, and truths about the Holy Spirit, the Enabler, Sustainer, and Comforter. Moreover, there are now resources for and by African Americans consistent with their worship styles and their theologies of worship. I am confident that new theologies of worship in the Black church are emerging as a result of these works. The list at the end of this article contains a variety of resources that will help pastors, musicians, students, and faculty begin to develop a worship library of African American worship resources.

The Worship Renewal Grants Program at the Calvin Institute of Christian Worship is designed to strengthen and sustain well-grounded renewal in congregations throughout North America. Made possible through the generous support of the Lilly Endowment Inc., these grants are intended to serve a grassroots constituency who value the vitality of the worship life in their local Christian communities including African American congregations. Through

its grant program, the Calvin Institute of Christian Worship (located at Calvin College in Grand Rapids, Michigan) intends to stimulate thoughtful and energetic work that will result in worship services that exhibit renewed creativity, theological integrity, and relevance. Further information may be found at Calvin's website: www.calvin.edu/worship.

In conclusion, it is essential that music and worship education become an integral part of the required theological curricula of seminaries and divinity schools, in general, and Black Church Studies programs, in particular, especially as they continue to prepare pastors, ministers, and music leaders for leadership in the Black church in the twenty-first century. The need is now incumbent upon Black Church Studies program directors and faculty in seminaries, divinity schools, and schools of theology to provide this critical area of study.

There are extremes in many churches—those that have consistently chosen to provide religious entertainment to attract members and those who have held on to traditions they are unable to explain or justify, and, as a result, “God has become an amiable bore, and worship a memorial service to a fire gone out.”¹⁹ In either case, theological education must take responsibility for providing instruction and leadership to its students as they face a variety of church music and worship challenges and experiences in this pluralistic twenty-first-century context. A clear understanding of worship will greatly assist in pastors and musicians being keenly aware that the church is not a religious theater where performers are paid to amuse those who attend. It is an assembly of redeemed sinners—men and women called unto Christ and commissioned to spread His gospel to the ends of the earth. Music and worship education must be acknowledged and integrated as a legitimate and essential part of the required curriculum so that the Black church may continue to fulfill the call and commission of Christ with honor, relevance, and integrity.

Selected Resources for African American Music and Worship

- 2013 James Abbingon, ed., *Readings in African American Church Music and Worship, Volume 2* (Chicago: GIA Publications)
- 2012 Emmett G. Price, III, *The Black Church and Hip Hop Culture: Toward Bridging the Generational Divide* (Lanham, MD: The Scarecrow Press)
- 2011 Kenyatta Gilbert, *The Journey and Promise of African American Preaching* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press)
- 2010 Martha Simmons and Frank Thomas, ed., *Preaching with Sacred Fire: An Anthology of African American Sermons, 1750 to the Present* (New York: W. W. Norton)
- 2010 Kip Lornell, ed., *From Jubilee to Hip Hop: Readings in African American Music* (Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice Hall)
- 2009 James Abbingon, *Let the Church Sing on! Reflections on Black Sacred Music* (Chicago: GIA Publications)
- 2008 Deborah S. Pollard, *When the Church Becomes Your Party: Contemporary Gospel Music* (Detroit: Wayne State University Press)
- 2008 Valerie Bridgeman Davis and Safiyah Fosua, *The Africana Worship Book: Year C* (Nashville: Discipleship Resources)
- 2008 Mary E. McGann, *Let It Shine! The Emergence of African American Catholic Worship* (New York: Fordham University Press)
- 2007 Valerie Bridgeman Davis and Safiyah Fosua, *Companion to the Africana Worship Book* (Nashville: Discipleship Resources)
- 2007 Valerie Bridgeman Davis and Safiyah Fosua, *The Africana Worship Book: Year B* (Nashville: Discipleship Resources)
- 2007 Kathlyn Gay, *African American Holidays, Festivals, and Celebrations: The History, Customs, and Symbols associated with Both Traditional and Contemporary Religious and Secular Events Observed by Americans of African Descent* (Detroit: Omni Graphics, Inc.)

- 2007 Ralph C. Watkins, *The Gospel Remix: Reaching the Hip Hop Generation* (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press)
- 2006 Robert Darden, *People Get Ready! A New History of Black Gospel Music* (New York: Continuum International Publishing)
- 2006 Mellonee Burnim and Portia Maultsby, ed., *African American Music: An Introduction* (New York: Routledge)
- 2006 Charles Albert Tindley, *Beams of Heaven: Hymns of Charles Albert Tindley (1851–1933)*, edited by S. T. Kimbrough, Jr. and Carlton R. Young (New York: General Board of Global Ministries, The United Methodist Church)
- 2005 Timothy J. Nelson, *Every Time I Feel the Spirit: Religious Experience and Ritual in an African American Church* (New York: New York University Press)
- 2005 Cheryl A. Kirk-Duggan, *More African American Special Days: 15 Complete Worship Services* (Nashville: Abingdon Press).
- 2005 Efreem Smith and Phil Jackson, *The Hip Hop Church: Connecting with the Movement Shaping Our Culture* (Downers Grove: InterVarsity Press)
- 2004 Barbara A. Holmes, *Joy Unspeakable: Contemplative Practices of the Black Church* (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress Press)
- 2004 Mary E. McGann, *A Precious Fountain: Music in the Worship of an African American Catholic Community* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press)
- 2004 Anne E. Streaty Wimberly, *Nurturing Faith and Hope: Black Worship as a Model for Christian Education* (Cleveland: Pilgrim Press)
- 2004 Melva W. Costen, *In Spirit and In Truth: The Music of African American Worship* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press)
- 2003 Cheryl A. Kirk-Duggan, *Soul Pearls: Worship Resources for the Black Church* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 2003 Cheryl A. Kirk-Duggan, *Mary Had a Baby: An Advent Study Based on African American Spirituals* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 2003 Bruno Chenu, *The Trouble I've Seen: The Big Book of Negro Spirituals* (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press)
- 2003 Teresa L. Reed, *The Holy Profane: Religion in Black Popular Music* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky)
- 2003 Linda H. Hollies, *Trumpet in Zion, Year C* (Cleveland: Pilgrim Press)
- 2003 Wyatt Tee Walker, *Spirits That Dwell in Deep Woods: The Prayer and Praise Hymns of the Black Religious Experience*, edited by James Abbingtion (Chicago: GIA Publications)
- 2002 Linda H. Hollies, *Trumpet in Zion, Year B* (Cleveland: Pilgrim Press)
- 2002 James Abbingtion and Linda H. Hollies, *Going to Wait! African American Church Worship Resources between Pentecost and Advent*. (Chicago: GIA Publications)
- 2001 James Abbingtion, ed., *Readings in African American Church Music and Worship* (Chicago: GIA Publications)
- 2001 Cheryl A. Kirk-Duggan, *The Undivided Soul: Helping Congregations Connect Body and Spirit* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 2001 Linda H. Hollies, *Trumpet in Zion: Worship Resources, Year A* (Cleveland: Pilgrim Press)
- 2001 James Abbingtion and Linda H. Hollies, *Waiting to Go! African American Church Worship Resources from Advent through Pentecost* (Chicago: GIA Publications, 2002)
- 2001 James Abbingtion, *Let Mt. Zion Rejoice! Music in the African American Church* (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press)
- 2000 Diana L. Hayes, *Were You There? Stations of the Cross* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books)
- 1998 Frederick H. Talbot, *African American Worship: New Eyes for Seeing* (Lima, OH: Fairway Press)
- 1997 Grenae D. Dudley and Carlyle F. Stewart III, *Sankofa: Celebrations for the African American Church* (Cleveland: United Church Press)
- 1997 Elochukwa E. Uzukwu, *Worship as Body Language: An Introduction to Christian Worship: An African Orientation* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press)

- 1996 Brenda Eatman Aghahowa, *Praising in Black and White: Unity and Diversity in Christian Worship* (Cleveland: United Church Press).
- 1996 Cheryl A. Kirk-Duggan, *African American Special Days: 15 Complete Worship Services* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 1996 William Farley Smith, *Songs of Deliverance: Organ Arrangements and Congregational Acts of Worship for the Church Year Based on African American Spirituals* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 1995 Jon Michael Spencer, *Sing a New Song: Liberating Black Hymnody* (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress Press)
- 1995 Horace C. Boyer, *How Sweet the Sound: The Golden Age of Gospel* (Washington, DC: Elliott & Clark Publishing)
- 1994 James Melvin Washington, *Conversations with God: Two Centuries of Prayers by African Americans* (New York: HarperCollins Publishers)
- 1994 Tricia Rose, *Black Noise: Rap Music and Black Culture in Contemporary America* (Hanover, NH: University Press of New England)
- 1993 Arthur Jones, *Wade in the Water: The Wisdom of the Spirituals* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books)
- 1993 Melva W. Costen, *African American Christian Worship* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 1992 Jon Michael Spencer, *Black Hymnody: A Hymnological History of the African-American Church* (Knoxville: The University of Tennessee Press)
- 1992 Michael W. Harris, *The Rise of Gospel Blues: The Music of Thomas Andrew Dorsey in the Urban Church* (New York: Oxford University Press)
- 1992 Bernice Johnson Reagon, ed., *We'll Understand It Better By and By: Pioneering African American Gospel Composers* (Washington, DC: Smithsonian Institution Press)
- 1990 Jon Michael Spencer, *Unsung Hymns by Black and Unknown Bards* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press)
- 1990 Jon Michael Spencer, *Protest and Praise: Sacred Music of Black Religion* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press)
- 1990 William B. McClain, *Come Sunday: The Liturgy of Zion—A Companion to Songs of Zion* (Nashville: Abingdon Press)
- 1984 J. Wendell Mapson, Jr., *The Ministry of Music in the Black Church* (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press)
- 1979 Wyatt Tee Walker, *Somebody's Calling My Name: Black Sacred Music and Social Change* (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press)
- 1972 John Lovell, Jr., *Black Song: The Forge and the Flame—The Story of How the Afro-American Spiritual Was Hammered Out* (New York: Paragon House Publishers)
- 1972 James H. Cone, *The Spiritual and the Blues: An Interpretation* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books)

Notes

1. C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence H. Mamiya, *The Black Church in the African American Experience* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1990), 346.
2. Wyatt Tee Walker, *Somebody's Calling My Name: Black Sacred Music and Social Change* (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press, 1979), 17.
3. James H. Cone, *Speaking the Truth: Ecumenism, Liberation, and Black Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1986), 129–130.
4. Hendricks employs this phrase in the context of describing the foundational (or core) corporate experience of African Americans in the United States in the context of their experience of oppression in a white supremacist social order. Their collective oppression at the hands of the dominant culture, their collective rejection of the dominant culture world view along with its definitions and concepts, and their collective construction of alternative concepts, definitions, and world view that, as Hendricks writes, “serve the liberative interests of the oppressed” function as the corporate core (i.e., “collective root”) experience out of which the spirituals emerged. Hendricks further suggests that the spirituals, as a genre of prophetic resistance, also find their

formative ethos in the interdependent, communal, cooperative efforts of the agrarian existence of African Americans at that time. Hence, like an agrarian community, the work of identifying and calling out injustice, calling for resistance and rejection to it, and expecting and effecting justice on this side was a corporate, communal labor of the entire community and not wrought or achieved by and for one or a few. See "I Am the Holy Dope Dealer: The Problem with Gospel Music Today," in James Abbingtion, ed., *Readings in African American Church Music and Worship* (Chicago: GIA Publications, 2001), 560–565.

5. Obery M. Hendricks, "I Am the Holy Dope Dealer," 554.
6. Wendell P. Whalum, "Church Music: A Position Paper (with special consideration of music in the Black Church)," in James Abbingtion, ed., *Readings in African American Church Music and Worship* (Chicago: GIA Publications, 2001), 503.
7. J. Wendell Mapson, Jr., *Strange Fire: A Study of Worship and Liturgy in the African American Church* (St. Louis: Hodale Press, 1996), 85.
8. James H. Cone, *Speaking the Truth: Ecumenism, Liberation, and Black Theology* (Grand Rapids: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1986), 137–138.
9. Michael Eric Dyson, *Open Mike: Reflections on Philosophy, Race, Sex, Culture and Religion* (New York: Basic Civitas Books, 2003), 294–295.
10. Eric Routley, *Church Music and Theology* (Philadelphia: Muhlenberg, 1959), 110.
11. Frederick Hilborn Talbot, *African American Worship: New Eyes for Seeing* (Lima, OH: Fairway Press, 1998), 135.
12. William D. Watley, "Theological Linguistics," an address delivered at the 2000 Hampton University Ministers' Conference, Hampton, Virginia. To my knowledge, as of this writing, this address has not been published.
13. Leith Anderson, *A Church for the Twenty-First Century: Bringing Change to Your Church to Meet the Challenges of a Changing Society* (Minneapolis: Bethany House Publishers, 1992), 74–75.
14. Barry Liesch, *The New Worship: Straight Talk on Music and the Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2001), 230.
15. Robert E. Webber, "An Evangelical and Catholic Methodology," in Robert K. Johnson, ed., *The Use of the Bible in Theology: Evangelical Options* (Louisville: John Knox Press, 1985), 139–140.
16. *Ibid.*, 90–91.
17. A. W. Tozer, *Tozer on Worship and Entertainment*, compiled by James L. Snyder (Camp Hill, PA: Christian Publications, 1997), 111–112, 115.
18. James Abbingtion, ed., *Readings in African American Church Music and Worship, Volume 2* (Chicago: GIA Publications).
19. Leander E. Keck, *The Church Confident: Christianity Can Repent, but It Must Not Whimper* (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1993).

Black Church Studies and Scripture

Rodney S. Sadler, Jr.

11 Then Daniel asked the guard whom the palace master had appointed over Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah: 12 “Please test your servants for ten days. Let us be given vegetables to eat and water to drink. 13 You can then compare our appearance with the appearance of the young men who eat the royal rations, and deal with your servants according to what you observe.” 14 So he agreed to this proposal and tested them for ten days. 15 At the end of ten days it was observed that they appeared better and fatter than all the young men who had been eating the royal rations. 16 So the guard continued to withdraw their royal rations and the wine they were to drink, and gave them vegetables.

Daniel 1:11–16

Introduction

There is something about the story of Daniel and the “Hebrew boys” that rings true with a people who have been oppressed. To live by the precepts of those who have oppressed them is generally a recipe for disaster. Daniel and his companions knew the value of their history, their heritage, and their ways of being and because of it, they were able to see beyond what looked good about their master’s table and seek those things that would nourish them body and soul. This is less a story about the young men’s choices of food, and more about their ability to define themselves on their own terms in spite of where they were and who seemed to control their destinies. Because they were able to choose their food, they were able to exercise the requisite control over their own lives to keep them from being lost to Babylon and eventually to transform Babylon itself in keeping with the precepts of their God. But ultimately what was most important is that their ability to define themselves kept them from forgetting the God that could sustain them in perilous times.

In many respects, Black Church Studies programs in predominantly “white” seminaries represent the opportunity for us to eat our own food at the master’s table. It is an opportunity to remember our own traditions, to celebrate what is unique about who we are and whence we have come, and to get back to those things that will best sustain us in alien territory. Even in seminaries defined by traditions that are not our own, Black Church Studies programs allow us the space to define ourselves, to explore our traditions, and to live them out in an alien environment. By allowing us space to celebrate who we are, we not only affirm the validity

of our ways of being, we also transform the larger environment, making it more in line with God's vision of a church that fully appreciates all of humanity. Black Church Studies programs are, thus, crucial organs in the life of mainstream seminaries, influencing not just the displaced "Hebrew boys," but the larger culture of "Babylon" as well.

Beyond Parochialism

Theological education can readily be critiqued for its parochialism. Despite the breadth of what the general umbrella of theological education encompasses, most theological educators cling to specialties in a very limited portion of a single field. In many institutions, scholars from one field rarely have meaningful discussions with scholars from other fields because the intricacies of individual disciplines (as well as the politics of "competing" departments) make conversations across field boundaries impractical. Indeed, it is hard enough to master one small portion of a larger field like "Old Testament Studies," without trying to wrestle with the intersection of that field with, say, "African American Religious Studies," for instance. Parochialism is the haven of those who dare not risk wading into unfamiliar waters and wrestling with the Leviathans that dwell there. Parochialism is a luxury of an elite uber-field not burdened with the need to be relevant because its understanding of faith is as object of inquiry, not as sustaining, life-giving, world-changing, hegemony-defeating, Divine-intervening necessity which binds all aspects of the world together.

Perhaps this is one reason Black Church Studies is conspicuous amid the fields of study in the academy. Unlike the various disciplines traditionally associated with training in theological studies in seminaries, Black Church Studies cannot be deemed a single "field of study." It is, instead, of necessity an organic dialogue between the theological fields about the holistic nature of a God on whom our very existence depends. Black Church Studies exists as a conversation between the seeming disparate fields of theological education, presenting, at best, scholarship from across the various disciplines that comprise vocational theological studies.

What is further distinctive about this particular conversation called "Black Church Studies" is that it adds a significant "qualifying constituent element" to this discussion, the notion of "blackness." This "blackness" however defined as either Diaspora African heritage, or distinctive American identity becomes a matter of no small relevance in the interplay between these various fields, focusing on a definitive reading of theological reality through an ethnically particular lens. Black Church Studies focuses attention on how Diaspora Africans engage our Christian faith through the various theological fields including the history of African American denominations and congregations, pastoral care and counseling for African Americans and the study of Scripture by this group.

In addition to Black Church Studies as a theoretical construct comprised of different fields, Offices of Black Church Studies (OBCS) are practical organs responsible for many diverse tasks in the seminary. For example, during my time at Duke Divinity School,

- 1) Faculty members identified under the rubric of the Black church program provided required and elective courses in Black Church Studies (OBCS, to some extent, has direct or indirect academic dimensions).
- 2) The office itself ran two annual lectures and co-sponsored several annual events (OBCSs are charged with overseeing program activities).
- 3) The office facilitated relationships between African American clergy and the divinity school—even helping secure field education placements in African American congregations (OBCS was involved in community relations).
- 4) It provided student support services for African American and other "minority" students. This responsibility meant that the director of Black Church Studies was faculty

advisor to the Black Seminarians Union, counseled students both about vocational and personal concerns, provided additional academic support programs for students, and wrote recommendations for students seeking employment or interested in further graduate studies (OBCS engaged in student services).

During my brief stint as interim director of OBCS at Duke I gained a much greater appreciation of what it is that the office added to the divinity school environment. Not only was it a conversation between different academic fields, it facilitated for the divinity school a conversation about our nation's protracted obsession with "race" and the deleterious effect this perverse idea has had on all of us. These conversations inevitably took place in the numerous Black Church Studies classes and program events sponsored by our office. Because of our presence, however, similar conversations also took place in student lounges and in the hallways, on the shuttle buses, and in the parking lots. Conversations about the role "race" played in the segregation of what Douglass called "the Christianity of this land" (106) and the need for "racial" reconciliation were ever present. Though never ending in definitive solutions, the questions were always on the minds of our students, who became our graduates and who also went on to pastor churches throughout the nation. Such conversations had a consciousness-raising effect on the lives of many who had never previously considered the fact that "racial identity" continues to deform our Christianity in the United States.

For me, one of the principal reasons to encourage the proliferation of Black Church Studies programs is this "consciousness-raising effect." Black Church Studies programs serve as a constant witness to one of the initial and persistent failures of Christianity in the United States. Christianity was never allowed to fully flower on these shores due to a prior idolatrous commitment to the concept of race. As such, a religion built upon the *reconciliation* of various disparate groups (God to humanity, Jewishness to Gentile-ness, maleness to femaleness, the enslaved to the freed), had been perverted to a religion that *reified the divisions Christ died to eradicate*.

Though we often celebrate the genius of the advent of Black churches as an expression of our own unique self-understandings and styles of worshipping God, what can never be forgotten is that it is the tragic failure of "white" Christians in the United States to accept us in the same pews worshipping on equal terms that necessitated segregated African American congregations. More than just genius, and clearly more than a separatist impulse, pragmatism necessitated the advent of Black churches. The pragmatic need for "space" to come together, find ultimate meaning in the Divine, to *Shabbat*, and to strategize for liberation within a world diametrically opposed to our being because of its perception of our "race" made segregated institutions for worship inevitable. Black Church Studies, as such is a constant reminder of this failure in our faith traditions, challenging any perception that we have gotten our faith "right" in the United States.

As a discipline, BCS serves as a constant reminder that Black churches (however defined) have not always seen things in the same way as their "non-qualified" counterparts. The existence of Black Church Studies as a conversation is itself an acknowledgement that "blackness" qualifies our faith life, making it distinct from the "non-Black" church expressions.

This has become increasingly clear since the 1960s–1970s when Black Theology emerged in partnership with/response to the Black power movements and began to carve out a space in the larger theological realm.¹ Black Theology was instrumental in providing the context wherein other theological disciplines could find legitimacy. Now there are various "color qualified" emerging sub-disciplines in the theological realm appealing to the needs and responding to the unique concerns of African Americans, such as Black Church Administration, Black Church Studies, African American Pastoral Care, and African American Biblical Hermeneutics, etcetera. It is in this regard that the matter of Scripture comes to the fore.

The Black Church and Scripture

African Americans have from their first encounters with Scripture developed their own distinctive hermeneutical approaches to the text. Though this is due in part to certain aspects of our cultural heritage and the retention of a theological seed planted within our ancestors long ago on West African shores, it is also just as clearly due to our experiences on these shores.

It would have been easy for African Americans to reject the Judeo-Christian Scriptures out of hand since the Bible was often used to justify both the enslavement and the denigration of Africans. Legions are the accounts of plantation worship services where preachers of "slaveholding religion" repeatedly "whipped" their congregations with the notorious Ephesians 6 passage, "Slaves obey your masters." Further, since at least the seventeenth century the Genesis 9 narrative announcing a curse on Canaan had been twisted into a universal curse on all African peoples through their eponymous ancestor Ham. Because of this supposed biblical "curse," supremacists could deem the God of their faith the staunch opponent the very being of enslaved and brutalized Africans and would argue that their plight was just as God prescribed. Indeed, even Old Testament laws permitting slavery, found amid a host of legislations deemed no longer applicable, were routinely revisited to rationalize the enslavement of African peoples.² Such sacralizing, or employing Scripture for oppressive purposes, could easily have deterred our ancestors from becoming Christians for the Bible itself was used as a weapon against Black being.

Yet in spite of the many reasons not to become Bible-believing Christians, Africans in America were drawn to the Scriptures. Perhaps it was the nascent historical critic in our ancestors that led them to see that Scripture was not the property of the oppressors for it was composed by the oppressed! After gaining acquaintance with a Scriptural tradition that developed among a people reflecting on a moment of Exodus, wrestling with instances of Exile, and culminating in the innocent suffering, death, and resurrection of the Christ-man, *African American Christians began to gain a new appreciation for the Bible*. In fact, their ability to identify with the characters and themes explored in the Bible radically transformed the thinking of enslaved African peoples. Because of Scripture, the distant God of the "slaveholder's religion" could be envisioned as a "come down" liberator-God who actively got involved in mighty acts of deliverance for those distressed. To a people hopelessly lost in a system completely arrayed against them, Scripture provided hope, backed up with the proven power of a God who frees slaves.

Encountering the Bible radically altered African American cosmological assumptions, introducing a new agent who could function on an unseen level to transform their reality. Scripture provided ideological content that made the hope of gaining holistic freedom possible. Several significant assumptions about the larger world were debunked when enslaved African began to develop their own hermeneutic, once they began to interpret Scripture for themselves. Assumption:

- 1) **Almost all of the empowered characters in the Bible were "white."** As early as 1836 when Robert Lewis published his *Light and Truth . . . A Universal History of the Colored and Indian Race*, African Americans began to chronicle the presence of prominent African peoples in the Bible. Thus, the "Black Presence" argument developed as a way of defining African Americans' connection to a glorious African past and affirming "African-ness." Because they learned that the Bible did not denigrate African identity, our ancestors were able to use it to ground their humanity, to subversively rebut biblically based supremacist readings, and to validate their right to be free and function as equals in this nation.
- 2) **The Bible demonstrated God's contentment with and ordination of the status quo.** As African Americans became familiar with the Bible it soon became apparent that the

same book that was used to justify their oppression also provided hope for American African liberation. Writers such as Frederick Douglass, Peter Randolph, David Walker, and Maria Stewart each attest that the God they followed stood in opposition to the systems of oppression that haunted African peoples. In Scripture they encountered a God who would act without human intervention to provide justice for enslaved peoples.

- 3) **The Bible was the oppressors' book.** By appealing to Scripture Africans found a means to argue for their full equality in terms that their adversaries would have to respect. After all, even their adversaries would have to heed (and be accountable to) what they deemed "the Word of God." The sanctity of the Bible itself for "whites" became a weapon that could be effectively wielded against supremacists and their arguments against the full humanity of African peoples.
- 4) **The Bible was an apolitical spiritual document.** African American interpreters quickly found that the sacred script had secular potency grounding subversive political arguments against the type of Christianity practiced by southern slaveholders. For African Americans Scripture generally had both spiritual and political implications;³ in fact, it could not have had one without the other.

In addition to the assumptions that an emerging African American hermeneutic debunked, there were further practical reasons why African Americans gravitated toward Scripture:

- 1) **Mythopoeic dimensions:** Scripture provided a mythic system that could explain our ancestors' plight and a symbolic world that resonated with their own. Further, the new mythic system demonstrated God's fidelity to those who were in similar situations (i.e., slaves, exiles, sufferers, etc.).
- 2) **Flexibility:** The Bible allowed our ancestors the latitude to emphasize or exclude portions of Scripture based upon their needs without compromising the central core of the Christian message. Further, it continued to be flexible enough to address their evolving plight in America (slavery, segregation, persistent in-equality, etc.).

For each of these and other reasons, Scripture soon became a tool useful to African Americans who sought to affirm their humanity and argue against the oppressive system under which they lived. Characteristic of their appropriation of the texts is a hermeneutical move I have identified in other essays as the acceptance-reversal pattern. This acceptance-reversal pattern allowed for the wholesale appropriation of supremacist readings of the Bible by African Americans despite the fact they were currently being used to argue against their interests. It is evident, for example, in the appropriation of the Table of Nations in Genesis 10 as a legitimate description of the origin of racialized discourse in Scripture.

That Genesis 10 described the origin of racist thought in the Bible was a critical interpretive move for supremacists, who used this chapter to declare that racial identity was an inherent God-given determinant of the very character of human beings. To this end, the sons of Noah, Shem, Ham, and Japheth represented the origins of three racial groups, the Semitics (Asiatics), Blacks, and whites respectively. Once this was established, they turned their attention to reading race through the narrative found in Genesis 9 where, they argued, Black Ham was cursed by God for his moral laxity. Genesis 9:25–27 read, "Cursed be Canaan; lowest of slaves shall he be to his brothers." 26 He also said, "Blessed by the LORD my God be Shem; and let Canaan be his slave. 27 May God make space for Japheth, and let him live in the tents of Shem; and let Canaan be his slave." Though Ham was not even mentioned in the curse, for his offence, the curse is leveled against all of his descendants. Now the effect of racializing Genesis 10 becomes clear, for because of the cursing of their primogenitor, all Blacks were cursed.

Josiah Priest, a minister from New York State who sought in 1843 to discover the derivation of “the negro race,” will serve as an example of this type of supremacist interpretive tradition. Priest suggests that Ham became Black contrary to the color of his parents due to the “miraculous intervention of the Divine Power”⁴ and was appropriately named. Ham meant “Black.” “Blackness” was not an innocuous quality since for Priest, “Black” meant not only phenotypically Black, but “Black in the literal sense . . . point[ing] out the very disposition of his mind.” Hence Priest stated that the name, Ham, implied that this son of Noah was:

exceedingly prone to acts of ferocity and cruelty, involving murder, war, butcheries, and even cannibalism, including beastly lusts, and lasciviousness in its worst feature, going beyond the force of these passions, as possessed in common by the other races of men . . . the word signifies deceit, dishonesty, treachery, low mindedness, and malice. What a group of horrors are here, couched in the word Ham, all agreeing in a most surprising manner with the color of Ham’s skin, as well as with his real character as a man, during his own life, as well as with that of his race even now.⁵

Priest contrasts the blackness of Ham with Japheth the:

fair white man . . . the progenitor of a race who were to fill the world with their glory . . . for the white man, and the white woman are paramount in all the improvements of the earth.⁶

It is in this context, with similar ideologically charged readings of Genesis 10 that African Americans were introduced to this text. Recognizing the power of the argument for race from Genesis 10, it seems unusual that African Americans would also employ it in their own work. However, the “Table of Nations” found new meaning among African Americans who **reversed** the implications of both the issue of “race” and the “curse of Ham.”

Rufus Perry, a late nineteenth-century African American author, illustrates this point. Writing his book *The Cushite* in 1893, Perry begins addressing the interpretive pattern that had become pervasive in mainstream biblical scholarship.

[T]he most favored race of men [whites] preach about their own superiority till it becomes a kind of second nature. Then they piously incorporate it in their religion, and put it in their schoolbooks to be imbibed by their children . . . they have egregiously falsified the true history of the Cushites, or the Hamitic branch of the human family.⁷

His clearly political aim is to inspire

the thoughtful Negro to look back to his remote progenitors and trace up his lineage in the hope of finding something of ancestral greatness with which to . . . kindle in his breast a decent flame of pride of race.⁸

To accomplish this aim, he **accepts** the view of the “Table of Nations” in Genesis 10 popular among his supremacist opponents, deeming it to be “the most ancient and reliable ethnographic table known to historians.”⁹ But Perry’s **reversal** evolves over two discrete moves. First, he **accepts** the notion that the “sons of Ham” describes the ancestors of all Diaspora Africans. Because of this move, he is able to uncover evidence of the glorious past of Black people, tracing narratives about the “sons of Ham,” in the Bible and from extra-biblical sources that “did not bend the knee to the Caucasian Baal.”¹⁰

And second, instead of arguing against the validity or legitimacy of the “Curse of Ham,” he **accepts** it, determining that it is currently negatively impacting Africans and Diaspora Africans. Like Priest, he determines that the “Curse of Ham” was the reason for the present degradation of African peoples, explaining the contrast between their present status and their glorious

past.¹¹ The reversal, however, is manifest inasmuch as he is able to offer hope for modern “Cushites” in the prophesied moment when, as suggested in Ps 68:31, Cush will “stretch out her hands unto God.”¹² With this Ethiopianist move, the “Curse of Ham” becomes a temporary disadvantage destined to be reversed by God’s providence at a near future moment. As Perry concludes, “God often brings good out of evil, and harmonizes eternal purposes which neither men nor devils can thwart.”¹³

African Americans have used and continue to use this “Acceptance-Reversal” pattern of interpretation to redeem Scripture from the uses of their ideological foes and thereby to foster their own arguments for their full humanity and their liberation in the United States. Certain contemporary African American ideological readings can be said to similarly make use of historical critical exegetical strategies deemed the product of racist concepts¹⁴ to liberative ends.¹⁵ Such “playful” hermeneutic moves have typified African American appropriations of Scripture and demand further attention by contemporary scholars.

Black Church Studies and Scripture

As such, Black Church Studies needs to bear witness to the particular appropriations of Scripture found in our communities, reminding the academy that neither German, nor French, nor British, nor Euro-American exegetes have the final say as to the meaning of sacred texts. There is another witness that historically and contemporarily demands a hearing. Addressing the unique understandings of biblical interpretation among African Americans provides a context through which our “white” brothers and sisters gain a vision of the Scripture that eludes them. *The story* is not told until *our story* is told, too. As a marginalized people who have been freed from slavery, who wrestle with oppression, and who have cried out to the Lord using the standard “lament” forms of the Psalter, we provide American Christianity with an understanding of biblical literature that it could never hope to have from solely viewing Scripture from the vantage point of the dominant “racial” group. The need for a Divine agent to mediate events in this world is not as clear for those who cannot remember a time when they were not politically, socially, and economically empowered. However, for African American people the need for an Exodus is ever present, from the seventeenth century until this very moment! We have never had to speculate about what the Psalmist meant in 137:4 when asking, “How could we sing the LORD’s song in a foreign land?” for we have lived this psalm for 400 years. Black Church Studies thereby gains further significance as it serves as mediator of African American biblical hermeneutics to mainstream institutions of theological education.

In this regard, there are several distinctive aspects of African American biblical hermeneutics merit reflection in the context of Black Church Studies programs. There is a need:

- 1) to explore the historical debate over the Black presence in the Bible. Though this issue now may be passé, we need to recognize the historical implications of the “whitening” of the Bible on which the subjugation of African peoples is predicated. We need to explore the political implications of the use of the Bible as a weapon in a war over race. As such, recognizing the historical necessity of corrective historiography provides a greater context for understanding the development of Christianity in the United States.
- 2) to explore the theological particularities of “reading Scripture while Black” in this context, noting the disparate ways that Diaspora Africans have appropriated Scripture due to our unique experiences in the Western world. This would include diachronic analyses of patterns of interpretation. In this regard, we need to explore the theological appropriations of texts as well as the political, while recognizing what the interplay between the two says about the nature of our experience with the God of Scripture.

- 3) to address history of interpretive traditions of biblical passages that have negatively impacted Diaspora Africans (i.e., Genesis 9:18–27; Amos 9:7; Ephesians 6:1–9). The goal of this exercise would be to emphasize that *how we read Scripture matters*. The impact of the interpretive tradition can be seen in the way Africans have been viewed through a Scriptural lens throughout time.
- 4) to influence, prescriptively, the way our community interprets Scripture. As such, there is a need to guard against deleterious strategies (e.g., prosperity Gospel) that prove detrimental to our community's survival.

Black Church Studies has a responsibility not only to mine the rich interpretive tradition of African Americans and share their unique readings with the academy; it can also play a more pragmatic role in the overall struggle to advance the cause of African American biblical hermeneutics. Inasmuch as “studies” is part of the title, such offices should, themselves, engage in the descriptive work of understanding how Diasporan Africans in various historical and theological contexts appropriate Scripture and foster research into the ways people in congregations and other contexts continue to use the texts distinctively as African Americans. Understanding how we have used Scripture is fundamental to understanding the nature of the Black church.

Black Church Studies programs must also remind their seminaries/divinity schools/universities that there is an emerging mass of African/African American biblical scholars. Randall C. Bailey in his article “Academic Biblical Interpretation among African Americans in the United States” published in 2000 noted that there were then 45 African American biblical scholars that held the PhD.¹⁶ Since his article the number has perhaps doubled due to the arrival of many newly minted scholars and the identification of others that escaped Bailey's notice. No longer is there a reason why any theological studies program should not have African American biblical scholars on faculty. Not only has the number of such scholars grown, it is evident by the quality and quantity of the work that they are producing that they have much to offer to the academy. The prejudices of old that make the biblical department the one remaining bastion of lily-white maleness amid increasingly diverse theological studies faculties must finally give way.

Further, Black Church Studies programs are uniquely positioned in theological institutions to be able to share with the entire community (faculty, students, administrators, and alumni) works of African American biblical hermeneutics. From suggesting that the writings of African and Diaspora African authors like Charles Copher, Cain Felder, Renita Weems, Randall Bailey, Clarise Martin, Vincent Wimbush, Musa Dube, N. Samuel Murrell, Abraham Smith (as well as the chorus of new voices like Hugh Page, Emerson Powery, Valerie Bridgeman, Brad Braxton, Madeline McClenney-Sadler, etc.) be incorporated into the basic required introductions to Old and New Testaments; to pioneering distinct courses that explore African American biblical hermeneutics; to suggesting that the classic texts by Rufus Perry and Robert Lewis (and maybe even counter-texts of Josiah Priest and Robert Dabney) be incorporated into American church history classes, there is much that Black Church Studies programs can do to bring African American biblical hermeneutics to the fore in the academy.

Black Church Studies programs can also regularly bring African American biblical scholars to their campuses to discuss their works. Thereby they place their institutions into the emerging dialogue about biblical interpretation from our contexts, further expose their campuses to the significant work being produced in the field, and begin to develop a following for this brand of scholarship among their constituents.

OCBS are the appropriate organs in theological schools to serve as conduits through which African American appropriations of Scripture can flow. As they begin to reclaim their name as locations of “study,” the work of examining historical to contemporary appropriations of Biblical texts, themes, and motifs can find a new place in the academy.

Notes

1. Not that African Americans had not long since had their own theologies, just that it is at this moment that they began to find acceptance in the academy as a whole.
2. We should note that laws permitting slavery were deemed applicable while others decrying kidnapping for the purpose of enslavement were patently ignored (i.e., Exo 21:16; Deut 24:7).
3. C. Eric Lincoln notes that there was “no division between sacred and secular, especially between religion and politics” in African communities, *The Black Church in the African American Experience* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1990), 199–200. Aspects of this integration of sacred and secular persist in African American Christian contexts determining that the religious character of the Black church was necessarily political. For a larger discussion of politics and African American religion, see pages 199–204.
4. Josiah Priest, *Slavery as It Relates to the Negro, or African Race* (1843; repr., New York: Arno Press, 1977), 27.
5. *Ibid.*, 33.
6. *Ibid.*, 36.
7. Rufus L. Perry, D. D., PhD, *The Cushite or the Descendants of Ham as Found in the Sacred Scriptures and in the Writings of Ancient Historians and Poets from Noah to the Christian Era* (Springfield, MA: Willey and Company, 1893), 12.
8. *Ibid.*, 12.
9. *Ibid.*, 3.
10. *Ibid.*, 61.
11. *Ibid.*, 80–85.
12. *Ibid.*, x.
13. *Ibid.*, 164.
14. See, for example, Shawn Kelley, *Racilizing Jesus: Race, Ideology and the Formation of Modern Biblical Scholarship* (New York: Routledge, 2002).
15. An example would be Cain Hope Felder, *Troubling Biblical Waters: Race, Class, and Family* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1989).
16. Randall C. Bailey, “Academic Biblical Interpretation among African Americans in the United States,” in Vincent L. Wimbush ed., *African Americans and the Bible: Sacred Texts and Social Textures* (New York: Continuum, 2000), 707.

Part IV

Preaching and Poetics

The chapters in Part IV, whether explicitly or implicitly, question the separation of practical theological concerns from other areas of theological inquiry. All the essays in this section highlight the connections between the work of the authors as scholars, pastors, and practitioners concerned with engaging issues of internal questioning, voice, identity, and broad public concern. As Ella Mitchell states, “The Lord made it plain that questions are always welcome and in order. Indeed we should never be so fearful or presumptuous as to wonder if our questions ever threaten God. Questions are a way of loving our Lord with our minds as well as our hearts.” These chapters consider the inclusion of “women of color intellectuals” (Lightsey), Black women in a variety of roles including leadership roles in Black churches (Kirk-Duggan), sexual orientation diversity (Flunder), and next generation leadership (Moss) as necessary concerns to be taken up by contemporary congregations of the Black church. The essays take up sexism, racism, and homophobia and hip-hop as crucial concerns for faith communities. They challenge those who study Black churches and are committed to their development to consider both the exhortations as well as critiques that emerge from the experiences of segments of congregations whose voices historically have not always been central in shaping the narrative of their faith communities about what constitutes church, faith, or belonging. The current context presents urgent issues that require regrouping. Such regrouping requires that individual scholars, church members, and clergy take stock and become familiar with, and involved in, addressing contemporary contexts and concerns. The plea is issued in urgent terms: “Things are different now” (Moss), and different times require a revision of theologies, worship practices, and thoughtful reflection and action on the very meaning of “church.”

All Flesh Is Eligible: A Sermon

Ella P. Mitchell

And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh, and your sons and your daughters shall prophecy . . .

[Joel 2: 28a]

As a woman, I have greatly enjoyed the prophet Joel's famous words about God pouring out the spirit on *all* flesh. Recently, however, I have sensed a scope of meaning in them that is startling to say the least. So I entered into a kind of prayerful meditation/conversation with God about this "all flesh." I invite you to turn up your spiritual imagination and listen in on the flow, as it were:

Ella: "O gracious, almighty Creator, I am humbly seeking to know what you meant when you told Brother Joel that you would pour out your blessed, powerful Holy Spirit on *all* flesh. That was a broad and sweeping promise. Please pardon me for being so presumptuous as to ask."

The Lord made it plain that questions are always welcome and in order. Indeed we should never be so fearful or presumptuous as to wonder if our questions ever threaten God. Questions are a way of loving our Lord with our minds, as well as our hearts. Then came an answer that stretched my mind.

God: "Now, dear Ella, that '*all* flesh' is the hope of *all* the people of the world, though first delivered, of course, to Israel. It goes far beyond the 'daughters' that I *call* to prophecy. That word *all* includes everybody you can think of in every possible human category: genders and social classes that Joel mentioned. I mean levels of education, and even ethnic groupings and *all* religious affiliations."

Ella: It sounded impressive but I still wondered. Surely not "*all*," when you consider *all*, the people we would normally exclude from the prophesying role—the pulpit. So I just asked God point blank, "Will you *actually* pour out your Spirit without regard to formal training—folk whose backgrounds are very limited? I ask this especially since there are so many printed Bibles and other resources. No excuse for ignorance."

God: "My beloved Ella, I delight in the way my Word is circulated in print. But have you ever considered the fact that the disciples who launched the worldwide church were likely *all* non-readers, except for Matthew the tax collector? Are you aware that, as recently as the 1700s and early 1800s, these United States were amazingly revived in two Great Awakenings, most of whose preachers did not have nearly the level of the training you have? If the Western USA had had to wait for everybody to go to college and seminary, it might *never* have been won to Christ.

Listen carefully as I list some of the people on whom I poured out my Spirit. Remember that famous overseer, Francis Asbury, whom Wesley sent over, and who was later consecrated bishop? He came *originally* as a layman! And don't you know that I poured out my Spirit on his coachman, known as Black Harry, said to be the better preacher of the two. Since neither was trained as a preacher, did you ever wonder why Harry was the better preacher?"

Ella: I didn't have a clue. "No, Lord. I never *really* dug into that."

God: "Well, you see, I pour out my spirit on *all* flesh, and both Asbury and Black Harry received it. But Black Harry had cultural gifts that Asbury didn't have. Asbury no doubt had gifts in administration from England, and the Spirit used those. But Harry had storytelling gifts from Africa, and with those you can make the Bible *really* come alive. The Spirit needs educational and cultural equipment to kindle the flame."

Ella: "Are you suggesting that you give *no* particular recognition to the fact that some preachers go to the very best of schools? Like Yale and Princeton, Howard and Virginia Union and ITC?"

God: "No, dear, but remember that I pour out my Spirit on *all* flesh. Schools do not make good preachers, automatically. It's like it is with a piano. It does not matter how much training and practice the preacher has if the cultural system of communication is poor. But when a well-trained preacher with cultural gifts is used by the Spirit, I have the best of both worlds with which to communicate.

Look at Priscilla. She studied theology by oral tradition, with no books or scrolls whatever. She learned while she and her husband mended tents with the Apostle Paul. When the fledgling Apollos came up short on theology, she was used by My Spirit to correct his deficiencies. Then Apollos could *really* preach.

And no preacher dare ask Me to reveal things to him or her that are easily available at the seminary. *all* flesh is given the gift of my Spirit only *after* they have done their best with what is already available. For young men and women today, that means striving step by step until they have at least finished basic theological training."

Ella: "Thank you, Lord for clearing that up. Please tell me about family backgrounds. It is a brutal fact that '*all* flesh' does not have 'proper' parentage. Lord, we have a lot of broken homes, single-parent families, and teenage mothers with no marriage even considered. The children from these homes cause a lot of problems. How could offspring from such dysfunctional families be capable of being *really* used by an outpouring of your Spirit?"

I knew that the wisdom of God is true and righteous altogether, but I was utterly amazed at how God's Spirit is distributed.

God: (a new variety of voice came forth, a tiny bit harsh): "Did it ever dawn on you that My own Son's earthly family tree included a number of women with less than supposedly 'proper' histories? The first few verses of Matthew reveal Rahab, an ex-street-person, as David's great grandma. That didn't stop David from receiving the anointing. And *all* through the intervening years I have poured out my Spirit on saints, many of whom had an unfortunate family background. In your day and age, you may happen to find a number of preacher friends who have come out of one-parent homes. But did you notice these preachers are at the *top* of the list, not the bottom?"

Ella: It was true. One night my husband did a lecture-sermon, preceding the main revival sermon. He talked about manger babies, and Jesus's family tree. The main revival preacher rose to preach and said, "I'm one of those babies who never knew a father." This giant of a preacher had been born of an unwed mother, in an unheard of village, but God had poured out more of the Spirit on him than almost anybody. The same was true of other preachers. No matter who your parents were or were not, *all* are eligible to have the Spirit poured out on them. It's been decreed from God Almighty!

But I had one more wonderment about those on whom God pours out the Spirit. I said, "Lord, what about the wannabe preacher-prophets whose morality is open to serious

question? What about the host of preacher-men who, as they say, harass women? Lord, they are not included in the *all* flesh, or are they?"

God's answer this time was *really* shocking.

God: "You know very well that I pour out my Spirit, at times, on those whom you *call* grand rascals. You've seen it countless times, but Ella, you keep forgetting that I said *all* flesh is eligible. If I were to wait to pour out my Spirit on perfect people only, I'd never give away a drop. I know you rightly assume that you yourself don't go to the extremes to which some may go, but could I give any of the Spirit to you, if I demanded perfect purity?"

Ella: I was wiped out. I wanted to cry, or hang up the phone, or do something. But my *all*-knowing Maker and Creator and Redeemer read my mind and saw one last question, even though I was scared to ask it out loud: "Lord, don't you even care about those grand rascals who are so popular on TV?"

God: "Be not deceived, my child. I am not mocked. Those grand rascals reap what they sow, and don't you ever forget it. But *all* flesh is still eligible, and I reserve the right to pour out my spirit on *all* grades of sinners."

Ella: The more I think about it, the more I realize that the eligibility of *all* flesh has been in effect ever since the *fall* of humanity in the Garden of Eden. Scan three of the greatest biblical characters: Moses, David, and Paul. God's Spirit was poured out in abundance on *all* three, and yet *all* of them could be convicted of first degree murder, directly or by conspiracy.

All of us are sinners. But *all* of them and us are still in that sweeping category
called *all* flesh. And *all* flesh is eligible!

Lord, I hear of showers of blessing;

Thou art scattering full and free;

Showers the thirsty soul refreshing;

Let some drops now fall on me.

Even me, Lord, even me!

Let some drops now;

Fall on me.

Good Food

Yvette Flunder

The typical, acceptable interpretation of the dinner party parable in Luke 14:16–24 and I Cor. 11:20–21, 33 suggests that God is the inviter, the Jews are the invitees, and the gentiles are the “B” list . . . the folks who were the afterthought because the “A” list turned the invitation down. I find this troubling, because I qualify for the “B” list and as such I struggle with being the afterthought of God. I would like to give this story a remix.

Imagine the church as the inviter and Religious folks on the first list with everyone who feels distant from religion represented by those in the highways and hedges. The custom of the day addressed in this parable was that the host would invite you to save a date for the feast; when all was ready, the host would send out his or her servant and let you know all things were ready. Somewhere during this interval, the folks prepared excuses not to come. In my imagination I can hear folks talking; “Oh no, not another invitation to his/her dinner . . . Lord what am I going to say in order to get out of this? I’ve got to come up with something, and it can’t be the excuse I used last time.” We all do it when we don’t want to go and can’t just say no because it is not professionally prudent or politically expedient or because we feel obligated due to some past kindness the host has done for us.

The real question, though, is what was it about this dinner that nobody on the list wanted to come to it? Even the man’s friends made up excuses. Why?

The poor, sick and lame folks had to be seriously entreated and recruited . . . almost hogtied and dragged back to the dinner. Was there something about the food or the atmosphere of the dinner?

I have found that when food is good you don’t have to beg people. My church was out on a camping trip one year, and one of the pastors was frying fish for the group. We were right next to a very upscale wine and cheese gathering and we noticed that one of the extremely well-dressed participants holding a wine glass kept edging his way over to our area. Finally his taste buds got the best of him and he abandoned his party and asked us if we could give him a piece of fish, which later led to some greens and some potato salad. He left his people and his wine and his cheese altogether and joined us for the balance of the afternoon. Good company and good soul food will do it every time.

But even good food is distasteful in bad company. I would suggest that the atmosphere of the dinner party addressed in the parable was perhaps not welcoming, but that begs another question: Is it possible that the church of Jesus Christ, established to be inclusive of all, could be hospitality challenged?

I would like to step into another dinner where there may be some answers. The story in the letter of Paul to the Corinthians is often used as the text for communion or the Eucharist, but buried within it is the potluck from hell. Several things were wrong with the supper, due in large part to the divisions that existed among the Corinthians. Divisions like classism, racism, sexism, religionism, and nationalism.

There were private separate networking parties going on, and they were set up by time in order to intentionally exclude some of the folks. Those who did not have to work or could get there early rushed to eat the best food and drink the best wine before the others arrived. They were a part of the elite, those on the inside where decisions are made even before the meeting starts. They felt they had a right to eat the best. After all, they contributed the most money and provided the best food.

Many others were left humiliated, possibly because their work schedule excluded them from the meal entirely, or even if they did get there early they did not have the means to contribute to the lavish preparations, and felt guilty partaking in the meal.

It was a mockery of the common meal that was designed to be accessible to all. The meal was to commemorate an act of love by sharing love with one another. The meal was to bring the high down and the low up until they were one body.

Being made uncomfortable for the advantage of others is not for the disadvantaged alone. I was among the youngest of my grandparents' grandchildren, and as such I was often called upon to help them as they were aging. I traveled often with my grandmother, and on one of our bus trips we bought a ticket to the wrong stop. We were let off the bus at a truck stop bar. I had to go in with my Pentecostal church suit wearing alligator purse and bearing grandmother and seek to find someone to come and rescue us from this bar. My grandma's disposition was poor as she had earlier dropped one of her alligator shoes, which had been run over and squashed. Just prior to the call for help, my grandmother realized our luggage had not been taken off the bus and sent me running and screaming in an unsuccessful attempt to catch the bus.

At the end of this long hard day I told my grandma that I had taken just about all I could take, and my grandma said to me, "Yvette, you should be glad you have had the opportunity to wait on me. It is good for you to learn to serve." Good for me? I certainly did not think so, but I have come to understand better with time how true these sage words were and are.

Like grandma said, it's good for you. Random acts of kindness look good on us. During the Indonesian tsunami I watched the whole world turn away from useless acts of violence to senseless acts of beauty in response to the cry of the Rachel's all over Southeast Asia and Africa—the mothers mourning at the loss of their babies, and fathers groaning at the loss of their livelihood. For a while we were humanity at our best—Muslim, Hindu, Buddhist, Jewish, Christian, American, Asian, European, rich vacationer and fisherman together, working, loving rescuing, grieving, praying—numbered among the dead and the living. We saw countries forgiving debts and sending money. It was a sad, tragic loss yet it was so good for us to have something to come together around. John Lennon's song "Imagine" comes to mind, "imagine there's no countries / it isn't hard to do, / nothing to kill or die for / and no religions too, / imagine all the people, / living for today, living life in peace, sharing all the world." Imagine all the people practicing dangerous unselfishness. We saw it; we lived in it with the whole world.

We were right thinking people, and we can practice right thinking as a lifestyle. It is good for us. When women could not vote in this country, right thinking men changed that foolishness. When Black people could not vote, own property, eat in certain restaurants, or live in certain neighborhoods, some right thinking white people changed that foolishness. And now as same-gender-loving people are seeking to have this country honor their relationship and their right as tax paying citizens to expect no less, a group of right thinking straight people are putting themselves in harm's way to put an end to this foolishness. My thoughts go to Bayard Rustin, a Black gay man who planned King's great march on Washington, and the scores of Jewish sisters

and brothers who undergirded Dr. King with their presence and their money when prominent African American preachers berated him from their pulpits.

Class, denominations, political affiliation, race, nationality, gender identification, and affectional orientation separate us, and we use religion and the name of Jesus to reinforce these divisions and barriers. Much of the current brand of intolerant fundamentalist religion touted in the world today is so against a welcoming table of the Lord where there is good spiritual food and an authentic welcome. Paul suggests a remedy to bring us back to a real remembrance of what authentic communion embodies. What should happen at Jesus's dinner party? I Cor. 11:33 says when you come together for the supper, wait for one another. This implies that everyone has a right to be a part of the supper, although we are not all in the same place at the same time. We don't all see things the same. We don't all believe things exactly the same. We don't all have the same balances in our bank accounts, but the table of the Lord is for all of us. I have to bear with you and you have to bear with me. It is good for us. Dangerous unselfishness ought not to be dangerous at the Table of the Lord. It is the way things ought to be.

When we give the working poor a fair wage it helps all of us.
 When every family has access to health care it will be good for all of us.
 When everyone has safe affordable housing it will work well for all of us.
 When all families are affirmed and strengthened it will be good for all of our children.

And we can do most of this with the cost of one war. Peace is better than war. It looks better. It feels better. Dr. Martin King's notion of the beloved community was simple. For him it was a dream. We must work to make it a reality. Come over here, the table is spread and the feast of the Lord is going on!

That Was Then, This is Now

Otis Moss III

Now Joshua son of Nun was filled with the spirit of wisdom because Moses had laid his hands on him. So the Israelites listened to him and did what the LORD had commanded Moses.

Deuteronomy 34:9 (New International Version)

After the death of Moses the servant of the LORD, the LORD said to Joshua son of Nun, Moses' aide: "Moses my servant is dead. Now then, you and all these people, get ready to cross the Jordan River into the land I am about to give to them—to the Israelites. I will give you every place where you set your foot, as I promised Moses. Your territory will extend from the desert to Lebanon, and from the great river, the Euphrates—all the Hittite country—to the Great Sea on the west. No one will be able to stand up against you all the days of your life. As I was with Moses, so I will be with you; I will never leave you nor forsake you." Be strong and courageous, because you will lead these people to inherit the land I swore to their forefathers to give them.

Joshua 1:1–6 (New International Version)

Several years ago, there was a film that captured the imagination of the American public. This film was created by a promising cinematic neophyte who hailed from Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. His name is M. Night Shyamalan. He created a hair-raising thriller titled the *Sixth Sense*. This film starred one of the best-known actors of our era, Bruce Willis. Willis played a child psychologist investigating what might have been severe psychological trauma upon a little boy, or possibly even extrasensory perception. A statement by the young boy in the film has since been canonized as part of the pop-culture lexicon of America: "I see dead people, but they don't know it yet."

Today, "I see dead churches, but they don't know it yet." Many churches are dead to the fact that it is 2006 and not 1956.¹ They are dead, seemingly unwilling, and unable to engage the critical issues facing an unchurched generation. Dead to the fact that three points, a poem, and a whoop, is not enough to reach a Joshua generation. Dead because they still use antiquated theological constructs, outdated doctrinal motifs, irrelevant traditions, and romanticized liturgical forms for a postmodern, post-soul, post hip-hop, virtually equipped generation. Too many are dead to the reality that our stalwart institution, the church, is in danger of losing her power.

Why would I make this statement? I am one of the chief apologists for the church. I am a pastor of the church. I love the church. I know the church has been our citadel of hope, and our shelter in the time of storm. Why would I make the statement that the church is in danger of losing her power? I understand, to paraphrase Cornel West, "that the church has created

organic theological constructs in order to protect ourselves from the absurdity of racism in Western society.” I understand that the church has created an alternative worldview so that we can see ourselves in full human dignity.

Why would I say that the church is in danger of losing her power? I know that it is in the church where Phyllis Wheatley found her *Poetic Muse*. It is in the church where W. E. B. DuBois found out about the *Souls of Black Folk*. It is in the church where Marcus Garvey talked to the Holy Spirit and declared there is “One God! One Aim! One Destiny!” It is in the church that Jarena Lee hammered out a womanist ethic long before Alice Walker or bell hooks could write. It is in the church that Zora Neale Hurston created her literary characters, Janie and Tea Cake, and kept their eyes watching God. It is in the church where Bishop Henry McNeal Turner devised an Afro-centric and liberation theology long before James Cone was Black and Molefi Asante knew anything about Africa. It is in the church where Benjamin Elijah Mayes found the inspiration to educate Black men and not curse the darkness. It is in the church where Howard Thurman rescued Jesus from the ineptitude of neo-orthodox scholars who wanted to turn the Nazarene into a genie and not a Savior. It is in the church where Sandy Ray, Samuel Proctor, Frederick Sampson, Adam Clayton Powell, Vernon Johns, Fannie Lou Hammer, Ella Baker, Septima Clark, and Martin Luther King, Jr. bathed in the prophetic waters of resistance and redemption.

How can this church with all of her tragedies and all of her triumphs be in danger of losing her power? She is in danger of losing her power because urban poets, whom we sometimes call rappers, carry more weight and influence with our youth than any preacher, priest, potentate, apostle, bishop, or self-proclaimed prosperity prophet. If the church does not wake up and smell the coffee, we will not be able to reach this unchurched generation. There is a paradigm shift taking place in America. And if we don’t understand the ecclesiastical landscape and societal changes, we will miss out, and our ministries will be “then” and we will not understand the “now.”

Deuteronomy, Chapter 24, gives us an understanding of how God deals with the generational gap. Our text says that Moses is dead. They had a grand funeral for the grand patriarch of the Hebraic tradition. That was then. When you move to Chapter 1 in Joshua, you see that this is now, that once someone is removed, God has somebody else waiting in the wings to do something to transform the people. Maybe I should repeat that for people who have mythologized and romanticized their tradition and their past: Moses is dead. Moses isn’t coming back any more. Moses is now dead. No longer will the great patriarch of the Hebraic tradition dispense wisdom and transmit to the people the elusive and ever-present power of God. God, who was able to create the world *ex nihilo*. Moses is dead. The progenitor of liberation theology, the originator of clinical pastoral education, would no longer share the church meetings when Pastor Aaron tried to split the church. Moses is dead. No more wandering in the wilderness, living in makeshift houses, relying on manna from heaven, living in shotgun homes, drinking water from rocks. Moses is now dead.

The songs of a previous generation will no longer be sung the same way. For no longer will they pass the music from mouth to ear. There is a new generation that will take the old school songs with a remix and pass them onto a new generation. For you see, Moses is now dead. No longer can the high priest of yesteryear ministries assume biblical or canonical literacy among this generation. Somebody has to break it down so they understand what you’re trying to say. The current generation did not experience segregation, they did not experience slavery, and they do not know the hymn book. Somebody has to break something down so they understand what you’re trying to say.

Even going to the tabernacle now is completely different than when we used to dress to the nines, looking so sharp we could cut somebody. Now we have a generation making long paper and major cheddar. In the words of Tupac, “we no longer have just a group of people who are trying to make a dollar out of fifteen cents, but we now have a completely different aesthetic

of dress.” Instead of wearing Brooks Brothers someone might be wearing Phat Farm or Roc-a-fella. Moses is now dead. It’s a different world. A different ministry is required to reach this unchurched and post-civil rights generation. And we must recognize the shift if we’re going to do ministry in the twenty-first century. I have news for dead churches that there has been a shift in ministry. I’m sorry to tell you that ministry has changed.

Things are different now. Prior to the 1960s, the Black church was the epicenter of all cultural, social, and political activities within the community. But there is a shift taking place. We now live in a “post-soul” era. What do I mean by this? Previous to the 1960s, we lived in a soul era, where nearly every person who came out of the African American cultural matrix came specifically out of the church and brought that sensibility into what we call the secular arena.

Before Marvin Gaye could sing *What’s Going On*, he first had to sing in his daddy’s Pentecostal Church. Before Aretha Franklin could sing *Respect*, she had to sing *Amazing Grace* in her daddy’s church. Before Sam Cook could sing *You Send Me*, he had to sing with the Highway Q.C.s. These are soul-singers because they brought the cultural sensibilities of the church with them into the secular arena. But when I talk about T. I. and Lil’ Kim, and Ludacris, and Jay-Z, you’re talking about post-soul. They don’t have the same understanding of the faith language. They come out of the hip-hop tradition.

Hip-hop did not start five, ten, or 15 years ago; it didn’t even start 20 years ago. It began more than 30 years ago in a neighborhood called the South Bronx. In 1972, in the South Bronx, a brother by the name of DeeJay Kool Herc had two turntables and a microphone to get the party started. He didn’t have enough money to purchase a guitar or some drums, so he simply carried the two turntables, had a James Brown record, and found the break beat in the record. As a result of finding the break beat, he could then create a new song in the process, because he did not have enough money to buy a variety of records. And he served as the griot in the South Bronx because he would say things like “party over here” and “party over there.” He would tell people what was going on in the other five boroughs of the community. And so the deejay was at the forefront of the hip-hop community, for the deejay was the griot.

But from 1972 to 1978, hip-hop was pretty much an underground phenomenon. Nobody had heard about it unless you were from New York or Chicago or LA. If you were from one of the smaller cities, you didn’t know anything about hip-hop. But in 1979, things changed when some brothers from Sugar Hill Gang and Harlem created a song that went national and reached everybody. It was called *Rapper’s Delight*. It went something like “i said a hip hop the hippie the hippie to the hip hip hop, a you dont stop the rock it to the bang bang boogie say up jumped the boogie to the rhythm of the boogie, the beat.” So in 1979, we have the first hip-hop song that goes national, but it’s still controlled by our community. It is still sold out of the trunks of young men who are selling mixed tapes for two and three dollars.

Something happens in 1982. Another song comes out to critique the Reagan era, because it was in this era that youth unemployment in New York rose above 70 percent. Hip-hop then develops a consciousness to critique the community. Some young men get together, by the name of Grandmaster Flash and Furious Five, and they come together to create a song called “The Message,” in which they rapped: “Don’t push me ‘cause I’m close to the edge. I’m trying not to lose my head. Huh huh huh. It’s like a jungle sometimes, it makes me wonder how I keep from going under.” You have a song that then begins to critique the Reagan era. The consciousness of hip-hop is developing in the 1980s.

I’m not a conspiracy theorist, but I gotta’ tell you that something transforms at this moment. Something happens here at this moment that all of a sudden corporations realize there is money to be made off hip-hop. Corporations then say we will buy all of the independent labels, but in order for you to be signed up with us, we got to make sure you use the “b” word so many times, use the “n” word so many times and when you communicate to your sisters make sure you use the “h” word when you’re talking to them. It’s already documented; just check the

Internet: corporations are willing to give 30,000 dollars a year if you sign up with them. They will give you a record contract if you take away the consciousness in your hip-hop, and then we will give you a check. Simultaneously, as Sony MCA, now Time Warner found out that there was money to be made in hip-hop.

Then, something hits the streets in 1984 and 1985 that transforms the urban landscape forever. It hits the streets and it hurts families across America; crack cocaine hits the streets the same time. I'm not a conspiracy theorist, but it's mighty strange that corporations buy out hip-hop the same time crack hits the streets. Then, we see the birth of gangsta rap, not necessarily coming from the streets, but coming from the corporate boardrooms. In the 80s, gangsta rap is born; so the prophetic voice is now silenced.

As this is going on, we also see the transformation of America in terms of architecture. Because beginning back in the 1960s on to the 1970s and through the 1980s, we see a transformation of the community. We now have suburban cul-de-sac communities. Previous to 1968, homes always had a front porch. Front porches were designed out of the South Carolinian tradition, specifically in Charleston, South Carolina, where West Africans came over to America. They designed the front porch so you could communicate with somebody. When you have a front porch, what do you do? You get in other people's business. You sit on the front porch and find out what's going on. You know all the kids in the community when you're sitting on the front porch. And if you make the mistake of showing up at home earlier before school and you're not supposed to be home early from school, there's going to be Big Mama on the front porch, uncle on the front porch, before you even get to your house. Somebody has already called your mama, or you've been beaten three or four times before you get home. There is power on the front porch; the front porch demands that you create community.

But as a result, after the death of Dr. King and people moving to the suburbs, we then wanted to create cul-de-sac communities, where we do not have a front porch but a back porch with a privacy fence. We no longer have to communicate with our neighbors, so we don't have to know what's going on in the neighborhood. Thus, we have the death of public space, we have the rise of this gangsta rap, and we also have the death of consciousness and propheticness in rap. What is the church doing? Nothing in the process!

We see the rise of mega ministries, during the 70s and 80s, which also coalesced with the rise of the Reagan administration, and the rise of prosperity ministry which mirrors Reaganomics. And so we see here that the church is blind to what is going on with all of these kinds of cultural and social changes. And so we see, Moses is dead. Yes, Moses is dead; but Joshua is alive.

The text is telling us to go ahead and mourn Moses but not to stay in Chapter 34 too long because we would miss the move of God. If you stay in Chapter 34, you won't realize that God has a ram in the bush. You see, Joshua knew the Decalogue. Joshua witnessed Moses's pastoral ability. He saw the stress and strain of ministry. Joshua was even there when Aaron tried to set up United Golden Calf Ministry. He was there and loyal to Moses. And Joshua had his own personality; even though he was mentored by Moses, he had his own personality. Even though he was raised by Moses, he could do it in his Joshua kind of way. You can't use a Moses methodology to reach a Joshua generation.

It takes a new methodology to reach this generation. We get so caught up in methodology that we miss out on the message. The methodology will change, but the message always stays the same. For Jesus always chooses a different method. For some people, Jesus says just go on home, everything's going to be alright. For another group of people, they may just have to touch the hem of his garment. For someone else, they may need to be touched by Jesus. Jesus is always using a different methodology, but he always has the same message.

Some of us get so caught up in the message, not realizing it is the message. Some of you remember growing up on music on a 78. Some of you remember music on a 33. Some of you remember music on a 45. Do I have any 8-track folk in the house? Some of you remember

music on an 8-track. Some of you remember music on a LP, some of you on a cassette, now on a CD, DVD, MP3. I can take the song *Amazing Grace*, and I can play it on a 78, a 33, a 45, a 8-track, a LP, a cassette, a CD, a DVD, an MP3; it's the same song, but a different method of delivery. But you see we have 8-track churches in a CD world. And we're wondering why we cannot reach this generation. It's because we're focused on the wrong methodology.

If you use the pillars of hip-hop, you can also create a new methodology to reach this generation. Hip-hop has four pillars—graffiti, dee-jaying, rapping, and break dancing. How is that going to help the church? When you think about the first one, graffiti, you think about vandalism, but I'm talking about aesthetic urban art. If you understand art form, and that art is universal, take this generation and allow them to use their artistic creativity within the church. If you go to a Catholic church, they got graffiti in there; they call it stained glass. If you use this particular pillar, you can reach this generation.

You might say, I got the graffiti thing, but how are we going to use dee-jaying? Ain't going to be no scratching and swiping up in my church. We will not have a deejay. That's alright. The universal of dee-jaying is the appropriation of technology. We have a generation that is not technophobic. Stop putting people in charge of the sound ministry who don't even know how to program the VCR. You need to have somebody who understands technology. So we have a generation that understands technology.

You might say I get the graffiti thing, I get the dee-jaying thing, but I'm not going to have rapping in my church. Well, if you're from the African American traditional background, you know there's some rapping in the church. Every time someone gets down to what they call the whoop, you know there's going to be some rhyme "up in here, up in here." So when we take the orality and understand the universal is using rhyming, we can then create a more culturally literate generation who understands the power of orality and the power of literature.

What about break dancing? The universal is movement. The Bible says that we are to praise God, not just with tambourines, praise God not just with drums, praise God not just with song, praise God with the dance. So, utilizing dance within ministry appropriates and brings another generation into the church.

This is what I love about Joshua; Joshua is not a Moses clone. I respect Moses, but I'm not a Moses clone. Joshua says I can do this remix style. God is always doing a remix. God says you can take a sample from Moses, but you got to remix it for your own generation. A remix is when you take an old song and put a new beat to it. As a matter of fact, a whole lot of preachers do a whole lot of remixing, don't we? We take some stuff from somebody else and remix it again. We have to learn how to remix. Joshua was trained by Moses, but he had solid theology and a new methodology. Joshua was not a Moses clone.

My favorite deejay is Jesus, because Jesus knows how to remix some stuff. Jesus says that "Man does not live by bread alone;" that's a remix from Leviticus. Jesus says, "the spirit of the Lord is upon me because [God] has anointed me to preach the good news to the poor"; that's a remix from Isaiah. You've heard it said before, "love thy neighbors, but hate your enemies" but I tell you remix to "love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you." Matthew is a remix of Mark. Paul remixes the gospels. Origen remixes Paul. Tertullian remixes Origen.

Every generation brings something new to the table, sampling from the old to create something new. For Moses, it might've been doo-wop; for Joshua, it's hip-hop. For Moses, it's a whoop; for Joshua, it's a holla. For Moses, it's a letter; for Joshua, it's e-mail. For Moses, it's Aretha Franklin; for Joshua, it's Alicia Keyes. For Moses, it's Coltrane; for Joshua, it's Common. For Moses, it's a devotion; for Joshua, it's praise and worship. For Moses, he says I'm going to dress up; for Joshua, he says, I'm going to dress down. Moses says I got a hymn book; Joshua says I got a laptop. Moses says I got a radio; Joshua says I got the Internet. Moses says I got a board; Joshua says I got ministries. Moses says it's low-tech; Joshua says it's hi-tech. Moses says let's build a church; Joshua says let's build a community. Moses says sisters can't preach; but Joshua says, "I will pour out my Spirit upon all flesh." It's a different generation!

The principle here is that Joshua could remix because Moses gave him the tools to sample. Moses placed his hand on Joshua. In 34, he was passing on the wisdom tradition from him to this next person. He says I'm going to give you the tools to sample. You're not going to do it like me. You're not going to be walking in the wilderness as long as I was. You're going to have new enemies and new victories. So you got to do it your way. But, I'm going to give you all the tools in order to sample.

By laying hands on him, he was passing on the anointing on some level from him to someone else. Not the ointment, he was passing on the anointing. Some of us have confused ointment with anointing. Ointment is an external topical solution that you put on the outside, but anytime it rains, it's gone. The anointing is that which works on the inside that God is doing in your life. No matter if you are going through a storm, you still got your anointing. Moses was passing on his wisdom tradition from him to the next generation.

When you're in close proximity to the outpouring of the Holy Spirit, when you are in close proximity to where someone else is being blessed, that means you might end up getting wet in the process. Some of us like to hate when God is pouring out something on someone else. We stand over here, mad that so and so is getting blessed over there. But if you stand over there, you ain't going to get wet. If you stand next to the person when the outpouring is come, then some of that that's being poured on them might splash on you. But if you stand over there, off at a distance, you are upset about the fact that someone else is being blessed. We need to stop all the hating in ministry every time someone gets blessed. You don't need to be upset with your neighbor when your neighbor is blessed. When your neighbor is blessed, it just means that Jesus is in the neighborhood. You need to be excited about the fact that someone else is being blessed.

If we don't lay our hands on this generation, they will kneel down to the altars of free market culture, and then they will lift up and become self-proclaimed prosperity prophets because they do not have someone that will pass the wisdom tradition from one generation onto the next. In this day and age, where we love to talk about blessings, everybody on TV talks about "blessings," "big house, blessings," I'm here to tell you that the blessing is not what is material; that's residue. That ain't the blessing.

My grandmother taught me that very clearly. When my grandmother was living, she used to make something—teacakes. When I was eight, I used to be able to stand next to my grandmother when she was making these teacakes. She made those teacakes for me. They were my teacakes, my blessing, and my teacake. Nobody else could get those teacakes except me. So I was standing next to my grandmother when she was making those teacakes, and she would mix up the batter and pour it into a pan. Then, she would take the bowl and say, "Otis, you may lick the residue, but don't eat too much of the residue because you're real blessing is in the oven." Some of our ministries have overdosed on the residue. Your house, residue. Your clothes, residue. Your job, residue. The real blessing is the power and presence of God. And we've got to focus people on what the real blessing is, to have a relationship with God, and not this other residue because the residue does not have the necessary nutrition to sustain you through life's journey. And so, we see here that Joshua is alive; Moses is dead. But Moses passed on the wisdom tradition. God is doing a new thing. God is about to do something new in your life. God is about to do something new in your ministry. If you do not allow God to move in a mighty way, not only with you and the next generation, we will not see God's power and favor in a unique way in this urban environment that we live in, because if Moses had not passed on his wisdom to the next generation, we would not even be here today.

You see if Moses hadn't done it, then there would be no Joshua. If there was no Joshua, there would be no Deborah. If there was no Deborah, there would be no Jephthah. If there was no Jephthah, there would be no Samson. If there was no Samson, there would be no Saul. If there was no Saul, there would be no David. If there were no David, there would be no Solomon. If there were no Solomon, there would be no Davidic line. If there was no Davidic line, there

would be no prophets. If there were no more prophets, we would never know about Isaiah. If we didn't know about Isaiah, we'd never know "For unto us a child is born." If we never had a preannouncement of Jesus, then Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John would never write about him. If they never wrote about him, we wouldn't know the Gospel. If we didn't know the Gospel, we wouldn't know Jesus. If we didn't know Jesus, we wouldn't know Calvary. If there was no Calvary, there would be no Resurrection. If there was no Resurrection, then there would be Pentecost. If there was no Pentecost, then Peter would never have preached. If Peter had never preached, then Stephen would never have been stoned. If Stephen was never stoned, then Paul would never have been converted. If Paul was never converted, then he'd never have set up churches in Africa and Asia. If he never set up churches in Africa and Asia, there would be no Ignatius. If there was no Ignatius, there would be no Tertullian. If there were no Tertullian, there would be no Origen. If there was no Origen, there would be no Augustine. If there was no Augustine, there would be no Aquinas. If there was no Aquinas, there would be no John Wycliffe. If there was no John Wycliffe, there would be no Martin Luther. If there was no Martin Luther, there would be no Protestant Reformation. If there was no Protestant Reformation, I wouldn't know John Calvin. If I didn't know John Calvin, I wouldn't know John Wesley. If I didn't know John Wesley, then Wesley would have never landed in Savannah. If Wesley never landed in Savannah, then there would not be a Georgia Methodist movement. If there was no Georgia Methodist movement, then there would be no Emory University. If there was no Emory University, then in 1914, there would be no Candler. And we wouldn't be here today. But, I'm so glad that God was willing to lay hands on somebody. But I got to tell you, that was then, this is now.

Note

1. Sermon Preached at Candler School of Theology, Emory University, on March 22, 2006.

For Women of Color Scholars Who Have Considered Giving up/When the Church was Not Enuf

Pamela R. Lightsey

As a child, my siblings and I enjoyed going down to the train station with my father—a former railroad employee—to sit on the high wooden wheel carts and watch the trains pull into the station. We giggled with joy as we listened to the “man-talk” of my father and his peers and did our best not to be seen enjoying the *signifying* and the *playing the dozens* of these beautiful Black men whose dark skin glistened with sweat produced from the scorching south Floridian temperatures. We *jetty-bugs* knew better than to appear engaged in the affairs of grown men.

One Saturday morning, while seated at the train station, an accident occurred on the street adjacent to the station. When the traffic police arrived they immediately came over to us hoping to find a “witness” to give an account of the events that had transpired. I eagerly became that police witness. Oh, what a wonderful thing I had done! “I have told the truth,” I thought. “I have surely helped someone out!”

But like a sudden scene shift in an enjoyable dream, my grand moment became a nightmare as my father swiftly gathered us up and presented my case at home. When all was declared, my mother summarized my certain future with these words: *You talk too damn much! One day, your mouth is gonna get you in trouble!* And so it has. Mama was prophetic several times over.

Each Sunday that I literally ascend my preaching post as pastor of a very thriving United Methodist Church, I do so in defiance of not only Mama’s warning but also as a living example of the words written in 1974 by Theresa Hoover: “To be a woman, black, and active in religious institutions in the American scene is to labor under triple jeopardy”.¹

Today, as we consider the plight of women of color in the local church and specifically women of color intellectuals, I want to suggest that not only myself but also many thousands of you have *mouths* that get you in trouble. I want to also extend that statement by saying that the trouble, which we get into, is the kind of trouble that we can ill-afford to avoid. That is to say that to the extent that our tenuous labor in the church is being recognized, it is only because women before us had the audacity to open their mouths, *cry out and spare not* in order to speak

a liberating and witnessing word of truth within the context of the very tragic and nefarious *troubling* events of our times.

Over the past 60 years the global stage has presented a full array of such events, the likes of which one is tempted to cast as names of consanguinity, given that each has resulted in a deep wound to an overwhelmingly broad spectrum of humanity. To each event—Jim Crow, segregation, Vietnam war, Apartheid, Intifada in Israel, the Wall in Palestine, September 11th, war in Iraq, HIV/AIDS, Genocide in Rwanda, Enron Scandal, Hurricane Katrina, and so on—women, laboring in ministry in the local church and its extension ministries to include the academy, have by the words of her mouth (if she would be true to her call) been a powerful and efficacious opponent against injustice and oppression.

Nevertheless, the work of women in ministry is often uncelebrated and certainly under-rewarded. Though many have called to task the inequities of privilege, income, and responsibilities afforded women in leadership roles in the church, the startling details of their predicament have yet to be fully unveiled. In the case of women of color—ethnically speaking—as leaders in the local United Methodist Church, just a glimpse at the statistical data is alarming. According to the 2005 General Council on Finance and Administration Clergy Membership Report, of the 45,414 total clergy 9,483 were women. Of this approximate 21 percent female clergy leadership, 1,064 are racial ethnic clergywomen and less than ½ of 1 percent (691) are African American women.² While many are calling for minorities to tone down their cries of oppression, it seems to me, given their paltry numbers in the United Methodist Church, that unless women of color stand up, speak up, and at times *holler*, they would never be heard.

Having spent nearly 38 years doing ministry within the local church (Pentecostal, military chapels, and now United Methodist), in America and among African Americans serving in the military abroad, I bring the wealth of that experience to this chapter that captures what I assert to be three consistent challenges plaguing Black women intellectuals who serve as clergy leaders within the Protestant church. While I toyed with ignoring them because, I admit, I have become almost nauseous by their long-standing presence in our beloved church in particular and catholic church in general, I nonetheless address them because this is a celebration and I feel no event is worthy of celebration without a remembrance—an anamnesis—of how we got, and are *getting over*.

This work will cover the tripartite challenges of being (1) female, (2) a woman of color (specifically African American), and (3) too damn smart. Based on my earlier comments, this work will not only address the challenges of being an African American leading *mouthpiece*—a clergy—scholar—in our predominantly all-white, all-male denomination but, in the spirit of the richness of womanist theology, I have chosen to speak these fierce words with the help of the fierce poetry of Ntozake Shange's phenomenal work that I hope some of you will remember, *for colored girls who have considered suicide/when the rainbow is enuf*. I have in my title intentionally substituted the term "rainbow" for the term "church" because for so many the church is seen as that pot of gold at the end of the rainbow. And so the title stands as the initial subversive activity within this work.

Warning: Because of some very flavorful and sharp language, this work is not suitable for either young audiences or those of you who are offended by the use of profanity.

Necrophilic Preoccupations

without any assistance or guidance from you
i have loved you assiduously . . .
i want you to know
this waz an experiment
to see how selfish i cd be
if i wd really carry on to snare a possible lover

if i waz capable of debasing myself for the love of another
 if i cd stand not being wanted
 when i wanted to be wanted³

Sexism

Despite the many years of debating, the admonition of progressive biblical scholars against sexist proof-texting, and even the acceptance of female clergy into many leading church bodies, there remains that lot of persons who perceive the presence of women in ministry as repugnant iconoclastic. Though proclaiming the commands and will of God is a historic practice of the Christian faith and has been the major evangelical tool of the church, the normative and canonical standards of the church have until recent generations considered it anathema for women to engage themselves not only in preaching but in pastoring as well. Women, considered as subordinate to and weaker than men, should never be “over” a man lest she, at the very least, rise beyond control or, at the very worst, “become” the man. I suggest that in the case of the Black church the matter of ultimate concern is the latter yet with a more complex twist.

Let me contend that in the high, and certainly questionable, theology of the Black church, there is an understanding of God that suggests that in the act of proclaiming the Word, it is not the preacher who speaks but it is God—as first person, in Trinitarian language—who enters the body of the messenger and speaks through the preacher. This accounts for such cries as “speak Lord” from lively congregations during grand preaching moments. Because the male pastor is often seen as somewhat of a demigod, “speak Lord” is to suggest, in one sense, that God is speaking and, in another sense, as extreme adoration of the demigod who speaks.

I want to suggest that this lofty theology also accounts for this pietistic yet ridiculous opening prayer of many African American preachers prior to beginning their sermonizing: “Lord, hide me behind the cross, so that your people might not see me but Christ!”

The desired goal is that the ontological nature of the preacher will be temporarily transformed. One becomes a bit more than the paragon of virtue as preachers are so often esteemed to be. There has been this accompanying mystical presentation within the ethos of the Black church of the Black male preacher who is lifted up so high and given such reverent regard that—with few exceptions—one might understand the black male preacher as one who is as close to God as is humanly, indeed superhumanly possible. And so, black men preaching have been said to be *caught up by the Spirit* as sweat pours from their bodies, as foam appears from the corners of their mouths, and as bass voices ascend to falsetto sopranos. Though some cringe from such sights, by and large the Black church has received such behavior as par for the course, as a common manifestation of the presence of God within the being of the preacher. God is on the inside working on the outside!

Yet, aside from God entering the body of woman to lay seed, the Black church’s approach to its clergywomen is not as extraordinary. In the United Methodist Church, because of its itinerant nature, there still remains those churches who see female clergy of all hues as no more than “supply” pastors whom they will tolerate until a male pastor is episcopally dispatched. In recent years, women have been increasingly subject to pastoral teaching—from male and female clergy alike—that stresses a male/female relationship of *depositor/receptacle* wherein the woman is obliged to play *seed receiver* while the man occupies the role of *thrusting seed planter*. Otherwise ingenious clergywomen have bought into this rigid asininity hoping to demonstrate their total and complete acceptance of what is espoused as God’s *perfect* will for the believer. (Much more could be said, but I refrain for one could write a book on this matter)

Such thinking is found even in schools of higher education where one would generally hope for more objectivity and logic. In my predominantly African American seminary, female clergy were encouraged on more than one occasion to maintain culturally distinguishable feminine

standards (especially with liturgical wear and tone of voice in preaching) while no such time was spent on encouraging men to maintain their masculinity. Though the African American female clergy may outpace her male counterparts in the areas of education, skills, and talents she is always cognizant of the implicit acceptable standards of behavior. There remains the persistent defiance of the Black church against respecting the pastoral role and authority of that clergywoman who is *perceived* as “trying to act like a man.” And so, to hear clergywomen blindly praying—as quoted above—yet another prayer to their own unending demise is in some small way one of the few times when she may be allowed to emulate her male colleagues.

Nevertheless, my disdain with such seemingly humble and pious prayers comes with my awareness of both the sexism and racism still very much at work in the church. What is gained from *hiding behind the cross*? Is not the best witness and *seeing* of Christ and his work done when parishioners are *made to see* God at work *through* us, such as we are? Women of color scholars must not embrace yet another silencing rhetoric. As *cute* as it sounds, the church is not benefited by ignoring or closeting yet another segment of its membership. Instead of asking God to *hide* us, our prayer instead should be the following:

Lord use me even as you are renewing and transforming me so that your people might know of your unearned grace and love for humanity. Remind your people through your anointing in my life—such as I am right now—that if we but yield ourselves to your will that thou art able to do great things and draw all persons unto thee.

Racism

... ever since i realized there was someone callt
a colored girl an evil woman a bitch or nag
i been tryin not to be that & leave bitterness
in somebody else's cup ...
i cdnt stand it
i cdnt stand bein sorry & colored at the same time
it's so redundant in the modern world⁴

Concomitant to the disease of sexism, African American clergywomen have also to suffer the absurdity of racism that is still sustained in the twenty first century in large part by an intrinsic characteristic of the church to maintain a unified construct of reality. This reality asserts an archaic commitment to a single and powerful ideology of God as both male and white. As James Cone wrote in his 1968 work, *Christianity and Black Power*, “Even though Paul says that Christ ‘has broken down the dividing walls of hostility’ (Eph. 2:14), the *Church’s* community life reflects racism through and through. It is still possible to be a racist, a black-hater, and at the same time a member of the *Church*.”⁵ And so it is, the woman of color scholars who serve as pastors and leading voice pieces within the church do so within the grips of a strange and precarious love affair: *i cdnt stand bein sorry & colored at the same time*. Instead of walking out on this strange lover (who wants us on one side of the bed but not another—that is, it may accept us in one local church but not another), we have *been trying not to be that & leave bitterness in somebody else's cup*. Unfortunately, we realize that the Church is hopelessly a microcosm of the greater society. Indeed, on the subject of racism it is worse; it has exhibited a frightening powerlessness.

In 1969, the World Council of Churches gave this assessment on racism: “... the Church is not using the weapons it possesses to eradicate racism itself—even within its own institution.”⁶

To eradicate racism, the church would have to contract a case of highly developed autoimmune problems within its own catholic body launching a massive attack against its own self,

ideologies, teachings, and callous solipsism. Nearly fifty years after the WCC's report, racism within the church has not ended. Black clergywomen, in order to thrive within this context, have been trying diligently not to be overcome by the bitterness of oppression.

Rather than run in defeat, our numbers have not only increased but we have exemplified a dogged determination to be better, to think better, to do better than our oppressors. Walking on thin ice we decided to dance! Proof of that is this dynamic gathering that includes a wonderful assembly of African American clergywomen scholars. But before we came to this point we endured the pain of having our gifts disregarded and our visions "stolen" while others reaped the benefit.

Somebody almost walked off wid alla my stuff . . .
 what can anybody do wit somethin of no value on
 a open market/did [they] getta dime for my things/
 hey man/where are you goin wid alla my stuff/
 this is a woman's trip & i need my stuff/
 i want my stuff back/my rhythms & my voice/open my mouth/ & let me
 talk ya outta/throwin my shit in the sewar/
 now you cant have me less i give me away⁷

After years of watching Black clergywomen have portions of their *stuff* taken, after the loss of some of my own revered *stuff* taken, it occurred to me that rather than having *alla my stuff taken* I had better shake myself of my own self-imposed naivety. I have resolved that without the continued grace of God and the willingness of God's people to yield themselves to the will of God for this world the church can be an evil institution. Therefore, it behooves all clergywomen of color to take a lesson from the words of Angela Bassett's character in one scene from the movie *Waiting to Exhale*. As she is sitting at the bar reviewing her predicament of divorce from a man she worshipped and a marriage she thought would never end, she looks over at Wesley Snipes and concludes, "my problem is that I didn't have plan B."

Intellectual Apprehensions

i knew i waznt sposeda
 but i ran into the ADULT READING ROOM
 & came across
 Toussaint
 TOUSSAINT L'OUVERTURE
 waz the beginnin uv reality for me . . .⁸

Plan B: Be a cut above; have vocational options for your life. I have often felt that clergywomen do not have the luxury of being anything less than their highest level of brilliance and marketability. The same mother who told me I talked "too damn much" was also the person who taught me to avoid dependency. It was my love for reading and specifically my love for words—their colorfulness, their sharpness, their richness, the ability to paint a beautiful picture with words—that birthed within me a passion for intellectualism. I carried home books in which brilliant white men, militant Black men, and strong Black women were able to convey their own unique rotundity of speech.

The ability to learn new things, to apply skilled and sophisticated intellectual rigor to the practice of doing ministry in the local church is a gift to the church in an age where persons truly have "itching ears" yet are precipitously consuming *pop-theology* filled with self-hatred, sexism, racism, homophobia, and elitism. Notwithstanding its need for the intellectual, the

Black church, which was fed by the genius of men and women who saw it as their responsibility to be critical thinkers and conveyors of thought, has in these modern times developed a virulent disregard for the life of the mind and those who practice it. Though I have often been cautioned: *if you get a little learnin' you'll lose your burnin'*, the African American community and indeed other communities of marginalized persons would do better to follow these words of W. E. B. DuBois:

Internal problems of social advance must inevitably come,—problems of work and wages, of families and homes, of morals and the true valuing of the things of life; and all these and other inevitable problems of civilization the Negro must meet and solve largely for himself, by reason of his isolation; and can there be any possible solution other than by study and thought and an appeal to the rich experience of the past?⁹

Reflecting on these words in contrast to our present state has made me lachrymose as I have come to acknowledge that we have within the Black community a seductive ideology that makes not only our children believe that higher education will persuade and transform one into someone less than Black and almost (“tryin’ to be”) white but also—in the case of our churches—that we will also lose our passion, charisma, and ability to touch the heart of our listening congregation through “anointed” preaching because we will become so erudite in our sermonizing and so *saddity* in our living.

Women of color scholars in the African American context are in the precarious position of being intellectual powerhouses in a community that loves her brilliance but prefers it demonstrated in small doses while wrapped in subservience. In her work “Black Women Intellectuals,” bell hooks gives a candid biographical look at what I call the *intellectual profiling* that begins at an early age in the Black community.

Learning early on that good grades were rewarded while independent thinking was regarded with suspicion, I knew that it was important to be “smart” but not “too smart.” Being too smart was synonymous with intellectuality and that was cause for concern, especially if one was female. For a smart child in underclass and poor Black communities, to ask too many questions, to talk about ideas that differed from the prevailing community worldview, to say things grown Black folks relegated to the realm of the unspeakable was to invite punishment and even abuse.¹⁰

Faced with the choice between being “smart” and “too smart” many gifted Black children choose mediocrity instead of excellence. For the Black female who chooses and is successful in the latter, one continuously walks a tightrope between acceptance in the academy or acceptance in the community including the church.

Sexist assumptions about women’s roles inform the Black communities’ expectations of Black women. Many Black folks share the assumptions held by diverse groups in this society that women are “inherently” destined to selflessly serve others. This thinking is often reinforced in Black communities by religious teaching emphasizing the necessity of selfless service as the highest expression of Christian charity . . . Cultural insistence that Black women be regarded as “service workers” no matter our job or career status as well as Black female passive acceptance of such roles may be the major factor preventing more Black women from choosing to become intellectuals. Intellectual work, even when it is deemed socially relevant, is not seen as “selfless work.”¹¹

The challenge is that very often, intellectual work is seen as less than relevant in the struggle against oppression. It is considered not Black enough, not militant enough, not willing to get down in the trenches with the people enough. “It is this devaluation of intellectual work that

often makes it difficult for individuals from marginalized groups to feel that intellectual work is important, that it is a useful vocation".¹²

I find this becoming more and more apparent as more than a few of our most notable clergy *take* on credentials that on the surface appear legitimate but lack the academic standards to be regarded as such. Religious bible colleges, whose degree work is nontransferable to institutions, which have gone through rigorous accreditation processes, are handing out "doctorates" at astounding rates. Tele- bishops, prophetesses, evangelists, and apostles are now adding to their *titles* the once hard-earned letters *PhD*. These titles sound good but are a shrill cry and faithless facade when one really looks beyond the title to the governing institution. The rejoinder to my critique would be to say that at least the Black church is attempting to legitimize what had been the acceptable practice of calling our male preachers "doc" anyway.

In some ways it is as a stubborn resistance to this devaluation of intellectual work that I endeavor to remain connected to not only the local church but also a diverse assortment of organizations and groups within the African American community. Having spent an entire week as the evening preacher for a group of African American teenagers attending Chicago's Pembroke Institute I was reminded again of the need for the church to have not only intellectuals but also women of color intellectuals.

This program sponsored by the area's Black Methodists for Church Renewal brings youth together for the purpose of understanding the call to ministry while at the same time providing opportunities to nurture their spiritual walk and theological interests. I am convinced that our work on the frontlines of the local church is tremendously important not because the majority of the students are young females but because they are all young and malleable and living in an age of increasingly sexist teaching by way of music videos. Each day young persons sat with me interested in "what good books" they might read or what seminary I would recommend. I know we have been effective because in the last three years of my being on staff we have had three enrolled for seminary and many others going off to college.

Summary

I see myself as part of a burgeoning subculture, working as both intellectual and pastor. I admit that this has been difficult but doable. If the Black community is ever to truly value the gift of the intellectual, then it must start by the active presence of the intellectual in its day-to-day affairs. If it is to happen in the church, then the best of all possible scenarios is that it starts from the presence of clergywomen intellectuals in the pulpit. We call to task sexist and racist assumptions as we embody what it means to be in love with a people who are not always loveable. *Love bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, and endures all things.*

The church must take seriously clergywomen not as an addendum but as a viable and *necessary* part of its ministry, ministry to a fragmented world and church in the midst of sanctification. That clergywomen of color would give themselves to the task of continuing education and scholarship affords the church the very best of cutting-edge theological focus and conversations. The membership of the church, lay, and clergy together with these scholars stand at the cusp of a new way of doing church that holds as vital ministry a hermeneutical approach that takes seriously the responsibility of the *faithful* to *seek an understanding*.

Despite the continued challenge of being female, Black, and too smart I agree with Shange's *lady in yellow* that "being alive & being a woman & being colored is a metaphysical dilemma/i haven't conquered yet."¹³ What are we to do? I have found it best to continue the work while in the midst of a supportive group such as the Women of Color Scholars' program and persons passionate about the life of both church and academy and the need for inclusiveness.

In the end, I have found it impossible to be a true *child of God* while despising the presence and gifts of God within one's life. Our commitment to the church as women of color scholars

goes far beyond our abilities to preach, teach, be pastors, deacons, or professors, but it is the embodiment of both diverse leadership and humble discipleship in a world that consistently depreciates the value of one over the other. To such thinking we have found hope and joy in resistance. Our determination is emboldened by the creativity of each other's ministry and reflected in these words: "i found god in myself & i loved her/i loved her fiercely".¹⁴

Notes

1. Theresa Hoover, "Black Women and The Churches," in James Cone and Gayraud Wilmore, eds., *Black Theology*, vol.1, (New York: Orbis Books, 1993), 293.
2. General Council on Finance and Administration, 2005. The United Methodist Church.
3. Ntozake Shange, *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide/When the Rainbow is Enuf* (New York: Scribner Poetry, 1997), 13–14. Shange's choreopoem is a soaring and empowering telling of the challenges of being Black and female in America. Her stories of caution and celebration, passion and critique are part of a venerable African American wisdom tradition that transcends the ages with a fierce loyalty to women.
4. Ntozake Shange, *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide/When the Rainbow is Enuf*, 42–43.
5. James Cone, "Christianity and Black Power," in James Cone, ed., *Risks of Faith* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1999), 12.
6. John Vincent, "Statement from the World Council of Churches Sponsored Consultation on Racism. Notting Hill, London, May 19–24, 1969," in Ans J. Van Der Bent, ed., *Breaking Down the Walls* (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1986), 37.
7. Ntozake Shange, *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide/When the Rainbow is Enuf*, 49–50.
8. *Ibid.*, 40.
9. W. E. B. DuBois, *The Souls of Black Folk*, ed., Henry Louis Gates, Jr. and Terri Hume Oliver (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, Inc. 1999), 73.
10. bell hooks, "Black Women Intellectuals," in bell hooks and Cornell West, eds., *Breaking Bread: Insurgent Black Intellectual Life* (Boston: South End Press, 1991), 149.
11. *Ibid.*, 155.
12. *Ibid.*, 148.
13. Ntozake Shange, *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide/When the Rainbow is Enuf*, 45.
14. *Ibid.*, 62

Noble Nubian Priestess, Sister Friends and Church Mothers, Preachers and Teachers in the House

Cheryl A. Kirk-Duggan

The mules of the world?

We are not beasts lowly, controlled, manipulated.

The weaker sex?

Who are you kidding:

We been working, working many thousand gone

Hours and hours, without pay for the faith, accept the smile of one young or old,

Who let us know they appreciated all that we did, that we do.

The mules of the world?

We are not mules, make no mistake

Despite the insanities of slavery,

Us, along with our kin, torn from the Motherland

As a despised lot, desecrated for cash

Through middle passage, emerged triumphant inside

Though many, many thousands gone, watery graves their resting place

For the peaceful repose of their souls, we pray; Ashé!

Many of our great, great grandmothers survived,

Sisters could get a prayer through

Those prayers sustain us today!

Holy, holy, holy!

Some of us be so close to slavery

The time has not been that long

That we were there.

Because they sat there at the mourner's bench

In the clearings, the brush arbor,

Some chopped cotton

Some chopped sugar cane;

Some in the field,

Some in the big house

*Some were free born,
All are part of our legacy.*

Of women, faithful, proud

*We be sacred vessels, holy, holy, holy;
Jesus inside us shouts glory.
Bless us all, bless us now.*

We be a vast spectrum of blackness

*With different attitudes, different faith persuasions, different likes and dislikes
We be Baptist, Methodist, Catholic, Holiness, Sanctified, Disciples
We be Apostolic, Church of God, United Church of Christ, Presbyterian
We be Lutheran, Episcopalian, Ecumenical, Interfaith
Some be Womanists, some be Black Feminists,
Some be political activists,
For we do lift as we climb
Whatever the alphabet soup of our faith
We know us some Jesus,
We know us some God,
We claim the anointing of the Holy Spirit.*

When then was then, and now is now, we believe

*We have believed, we do believe;
If no belief, we could not be
Our realities have not collapsed in on us.*

Because we can get prayers through and other folks be praying for us too.

*And it is these women and their power and their prayers
And how they touch heaven
And how they birth babies and buried the dead
And made punch and cookies for Bible School
And taught speeches for Christmas and Easter pageants
And made sure the children of the community had
A Sunday “go-to-church” meeting outfit
So they could praise the Lord and feel good about themselves.*

These are the women, since Black bodies touched these shores

Who have helped the women folk, men folk, and children folk survive.

These women be strong,

*sometimes vulnerable,
feeling weak—*

*They helped nurture the faith of their mothers and fathers,
and uncles and aunts, and cousins twice removed.
And other cousins, and extended family so they can stand:
stand tall in the midst of good times and bad.
They hold onto the rhythm of Ezekiel’s wheel in the middle of the wheel
They climb up Jacob’s ladder daily, as each round goes higher and higher.
To these women, we shout glory, glory, glory and offer much thanks.*

Many of the women are famous;

*We hear their names and we know them personal like
For their ministries, lay, and clergy,
have left an indelible mark on the fabric of our lives;
Many of the women
Remain unnamed in the annals of institutional history,
Yet their names are implanted
On the fibers of our hearts:
we are because they were.
Such women of wisdom, virtue,*

Boldness with a fierce faith.

From churches doubling as one room school houses

To those the size of athletic arenas

Many Church women have a tireless commitment to love and take care of God's people

Sometimes not honored for their work;

Sometimes dismissed, betrayed, taken for granted.

Who are these women?

They are those whose numbers are many

Who sing soprano, alto, and tenor

Who wear incredible hats or no hats at all

With short hair, curly hair, long hair, straight hair, dreds, locks, twists, no hair—

Stylish, plain, colorful, sedate, linen, cotton, polyester, silk

Quiet, soft-spoken; sometimes vocal, all up in your face!

No monolith, cookie cutter, people here:

Don't put them in a box!

Followers and leaders,

Lay and clergy,

In choirs, altar guilds, stewardess, stewards, deacons, deaconess

First Lady, musicians, church clerk and administrative assistant,

Teacher, missionary, janitor, nurse, cook, educator

Sunday School teacher, youth director, treasurer, trustee;

Professor, scholar, researcher, author, nonprofit exec

She is spiritually large and often in charge

Who is given the platforms to do the work of God's calling on her life.

And then she looks around

And has to deal with patriarchy and oppression

She may choose

to be in a setting that does not ordain her, call or not.

The church she loves says women ought not speak, ought not preach

She remains there all her life and fights you if you say otherwise.

She may be in a church who honors her gifts with qualifications;

So if she preaches, she can't call it that,

She has to say it's a presentation or speech;

If she preaches, she can't call it that

And she can't stand behind the pulpit.

Misinformation and miseducation are catalysts for abuse, misuse, misinterpretation

Genesis 1 teaches mutuality

Genesis 2, woman made from rib of the earth creature

(God NEVER names Adam)

Does not stamp woman as inferior, weak, or incomplete male!

Genesis 3, the expelling out NOT a fall from the Garden

Does not make woman responsible for all evil

Given that woman keeps churches open

Given that woman teaches the first theology, the first prayers

Given the woman is body that carries graced reality for nine months

And then pushes out a live, really real, human being

Methinks saying woman is weak, inferior, or evil

Is a gross misstatement of truth and of reality

Is a lie foundational to too many a historical reality

A lie that keeps us all crippled.

Funny thing about oppression,

So deep into it, sometimes we can't see it

We have become comfortable with it

*If uncomfortable, we see no way out of it
 So we go along to get along.
 And stress comes along and eats our lunch;
 As these folk, in church in academe have “unloved” us to death.*

If she can preach and teach

*She may never get a call or appointment.
 She may hit the stained glass ceiling right out of seminary
 She will have to deal with a language
 That wants her to be included in exclusive language
 Where her voice does not count.*

Never mind Mary Magdalene, Apostle to apostles

*In all four Gospels
 She was told to go tell the good news
 Was not a whore or prostitute
 (Somebody made that one up, to erase her power!)
 Hmm, telling the good news, ευαγγελιον in the Greek they tell me—
 Go preach, in other words
 Jesus, sometimes an angel, sometimes a young man
 Told dear Mary Magdalene to “Go and tell it!”
 Had she not told it, the disciples would not have known it*

Not WHAT would Jesus do?

*But what DID Jesus do?
 Told a woman—the Mary of Magdala—to go tell it,
 “Go spread the good news, go preach!”
 And if the word about the Resurrection had never gotten to the disciples
 From the lips of a woman,
 Where would the church be today?
 Would it exist?*

And so, “If it wasn’t for the women” there might be no church

*For who would have gone to tell the good news back then
 That life did not end with Golgotha
 That there was a great getting up morning
 In the first century, that first Easter
 That it did happen
 Glory, glory, holy, holy!!
 And it was a woman
 who first told the Good News.*

And Black women have shared in tellin’

*The Good News of Resurrection and of Emancipation
 The Two go hand in hand,
 For one cannot be truly saved if one is not truly free.*

From the likes of Sojourner and Harriet Jacobs and Harriet Tubman and Jarena Lee then

*To Bishop Vashti, Reverends Dr. Sujoy and Reems in the church house
 Drs. Cannon, Gilkes, Townes, Weems, Williams in the school house now
 In the church house, in the school house, from town to gown
 And all the good sister leaders and followers in between
 We honor and celebrate each and every one of you, and study you, too.*

Women in the Black church

*Have much to celebrate, much to lament
 We have helped to educate, mentor, nurture
 With God as our helper, we have been able to make a way out of know way
 Have taken scraps and made haute cuisine
 Helped to organize and strategize.*

There would have been no 1960s Civil Rights Movement,

*No Montgomery Bus Boycott without the women
 There would be no churches without the women's guilds,
 No women's home missions
 No choirs without the women.*

Women then and now engage in

*Teaching and learning, learning and teaching
 Visiting the sick, feeding the hungry,
 Clothing the naked, bringing hope
 Nurturing minds, challenging thoughts,
 Encouraging ideas, bringing hope
 In the church, in the academy—women engage in ministry
 So much work done; so much work to do!*

The road has not and in this moment is not easy for Black women

*Engaged in church work,
 In studying about the work of the Black church
 For in these studies, we must face the egregious realities:
 Racism, sexism, classism, heterosexism
 The institutional inequalities, the challenges, the thankless tasks
 The demands for subservience, silence, submission, obedience
 The state of being sick and tired of being sick and tired
 And needing to press on anyhow
 The disrespect of being classed as
 Domineering, aggressive, independent, and matriarch.*

The same qualities in a man

Are dubbed as forward thinking and superb leadership.

The negation of her elegance, her bold courageous faith

*whether located in the pew, church pulpit, or classroom podium
 Told to get back into her place, to remain silent, asked,
 "Who does she think she is?"*

We, yes we, many of us, female and male

*Threatened by our perceptions of her uppityness
 Want to focus on her dress, wanting to put her in a box
 Wanting to control her preaching, her teaching
 Limiting the focus of church and guild on what is acceptable to teach and preach*

Don't really want to know, don't really care about the poor

*For some of us have so arrived
 We disengage from those who cannot articulate as we do
 In the church, we do not want those po' people on our mama's and papa's pews
 We really don't want them in our churches,
 As if the churches belonged to us;
 We are uncomfortable with them in the classroom
 For we do not speak the same language, and are wondering how they got here.*

Oh, how realities of Black church and Black Church Studies

Must trouble the One who created us!

And where do we go from here?

*How do we embrace blackness and Faith
 amid a world that is not a bad world,
 A world where life is cheapened by bullets and dope
 A world rife with violence of systemic oppressions:
 Sexism, racism, classism, domestic violence, sexual assault,
 homicide, suicide; prison and military industrial complexes
 The misuse and abuse of body and language*

And power and authority.

Where do we go from here?

We teach and learn from each other:

We excavate history, in interdisciplinary ways.

We cannot move forward

If we do not know what has already happened.

How can we have hope, if we cannot honor what has already been accomplished?

We listen to our hearts, heads, and spirits

We celebrate ourselves, and value people

We treat respectfully everyone who comes into our presence.

We honor the ministries of Black women, lay and clergy

Ministries of care and concern,

Ministries of music and hospitality,

Of preaching, poetry, dance

Of being spiritual presence;

Ministries of critical thinking and political activism

We honor personhood and refuse silence in the face of evil.

We cannot afford to dismiss:

exclusive language, sexual harassment, domestic violence;

We cannot afford to practice:

self hate and hate of others; we cannot afford to teach and practice lies

to demean women and keep them in their place.

We cannot use scripture to demonize women

We need to be as radical and subversive as Jesus was

Jesus was no wimp and was certainly not a pimp.

We pimp Jesus

When we allow others to be abusive and dismissive of women

We pimp Jesus

When ignoring the gifts of women and give accolades to the same gifts in men;

We pimp Jesus

When we allow incest, domestic violence, adultery, and rape

to happen inside our families, faith and learned communities and we remain mute.

We pimp Jesus

When our children remain ignorant

And graduate illiterate from high school?

We pimp Jesus

When we push ineffective programs

and the numbers of Black folks in prison continue to escalate.

We pimp Jesus

When we sabotage ourselves and commit slow suicide

through excessive or poisonous food, drink, sex, gambling,

lying, cheating, stealing of things or of character:

What idolatry and blasphemy!

Holy, holy, holy!!

Where do we go from here?

"We tell the truth and shame the devil!"

We learn from the past and live each day to the fullest like its our last!

Shout Gloooooooooooooory somebody!!

We honor and celebrate the legacy of women

in all the arenas of Black church life and thought.

We commit each day to do the best that we can, modeling the best that we can

We practice Sabbath.

We see the relatedness between what we do, say, and think

*We realize our faith in how we pray, pay, and not obey bad practices.
The world of Black Church Studies and women is a rich history, a powerful legacy
We must tell, and we can live with creativity, ingenuity, through the Graced love of God.
To do otherwise is to forfeit a powerful avenue of transformation
To engage is to experience salvation, reformation, and resurrection.*

Part V

Practices and Policy

The chapters in Part V discuss the significance of community in a variety of contemporary Black churches. These chapters fall within the subfield of “congregational studies” as they engage and are directly related to the study of the development, maintenance, and evolution of congregational relationships. Significantly, they also emphasize the importance of human relations as the central task of theological inquiry. As Wiley notes, “As far as I am concerned, Black Church Studies, by definition, *is* practical theology.” Trulear takes up this notion by underscoring the need for Black churches to pursue “adequate response[s] to the systemic dimensions” of social problems and issues facing Black communities. Tucker-Worgs analyzes the emergence of megachurches as new forms of Black church organization in the United States noting that their growth and proliferation since the 1980s are both a reflection of post-Civil Rights-era economic prosperity as well as the “suburbanization” of Black communities during the 1980s and 1990s. The authors in this section, both explicitly and implicitly, challenge the separation of practical theological concerns from other areas of theological inquiry. All the essays in this section highlight the connections between the work of the authors as scholars, pastors, and practitioners concerned with engaging public issues.

Black Church Studies as Practical Theology

Dennis W. Wiley

The term “practical theology” is a pleonastic expression. It is like referring to “wet rain” or “hot fire.” The adjective and noun, when used together, are redundant. Rain is inherently wet and fire is inherently hot. Similarly, theology *ought to be* inherently practical. What good is theology if it is not practical? What purpose does it serve? Indeed, how can it *not* be practical?

The contextual nature of all theology means that it is not done in a vacuum, but it is done by *particular* human beings at *particular* points and times in history. Hence, just as there is no such thing as a “neutral,” “disinterested,” or purely “universal” theology, there is also no such thing as an “impractical” theology. Since theology is *always* done by human beings, it *always* emerges in response to some practical human question, problem, issue, or concern. Its practicality, therefore, lies in its ultimate relevance to some particular aspect of the human condition. As James Cone makes clear,

Although God, the subject of theology, is eternal, theology itself is, like those who articulate it, limited by history and time . . . Theology is not universal language; it is *interested* language and thus is always a reflection of the goals and aspirations of a particular people in a definite social setting.¹

Traditional seminary education tends to divide theological education into various components, such as biblical studies, church history, theology and ethics, and the so-called *practical* field. *Systematic* theology and *practical* theology are often juxtaposed. Whereas the former deals with the intellectual organization of theological concepts and doctrines, the latter deals with what is frequently called “pastoral theology”—that is, worship, homiletics, administration of the sacraments, church administration, pastoral care and counseling, Christian education, and other aspects of pastoral ministry.

The problem is that when practical theology is viewed as a separate discipline, it *appears* to exist in a vacuum with little or no connection to the other theological disciplines. This problem raises two concerns: (1) What is the purpose of the *study* of theology if it does not exist to inform the *practice* of theology, as manifested in the practice of ministry? and, (2) Where does practical ministry derive its theological foundation, if not from these other areas of theological reflection? The fact that the study of theology and the practice of ministry *belong together* seems, at least to me, like a no-brainer. And yet, it is amazing how many

students, including African American students, go through seminary without any intention of *ever* applying the often uncomfortable insights of theological inquiry to the ever-demanding challenges of practical ministry.

It is revealing that a conference of this nature would dare to include a discussion of “Black Church Studies as Practical Theology.” As far as I am concerned, Black Church Studies, by definition, *is* practical theology. How can it be anything else? And yet, the very real necessity of dealing with this topic is indicative of just how totally we, as African American Christians, have bought into what Kelly Brown Douglas calls “platonized Christianity”—a Christianity that fosters a false dualism between the mind and the body² and, consequently, I would add, a false dualism between what we *study* in the classroom and what we *do* in the Black church. The way I see it, what we study in seminary should inform what we do in the Black church. But, all too often, my experience has been that once we walk across the stage on graduation day, receive that degree, and attach those abbreviated letters behind our names, we leave the insights of the seminary behind and adopt, instead, the narrow, debilitating views of conservative televangelists, prosperity preachers, and a “religious right” that is seldom either religious or right.

This duplicitous behavior on the part of many so-called “educated” Black clergy is usually a coping mechanism utilized by seminarians who view seminary as a necessary hurdle—a credentialing requirement, if you will—rather than as an experience to deepen one’s theology and broaden one’s intellectual grasp of the gospel. Thus, many Black seminarians enter seminary determined to get through the process without losing “their” Jesus. In fact, it has been suggested that, upon graduation from seminary, Black preachers—if they want to be called to a “good” church—would do well to “leave all of that seminary training behind.” They would be foolish, according to this line of thinking, to try to take that “book learning” into the pulpit. Black folks, it is argued, do not want to hear that intellectual stuff—they just want to know if the preacher *knows* Jesus on a personal level. Or, as is often humorously stated, Black church folk are not impressed by a preacher’s BA degree unless the BA stands for “born again.”

Quiet as it is kept, this kind of mentality is killing us as a people and, if left unchecked, will eventually kill the Black church. The separation between the study and the practice of theology is foreign to our African heritage and extremely problematic when it comes to our African American heritage. Broadly speaking, traditional African culture knows of no sharp dichotomy between the sacred and the secular, or between the God of religion and the God of life.³

With this African cosmological background,⁴ African American Christians have never been comfortable compartmentalizing God for two primary reasons. First, the centrality of the Black church in the African American community has made it difficult for Black people to separate the God they talk about on Sunday morning from the God they walk with during the rest of the week. This is because the place where our ancestors worshipped was often the same place where they socialized, held community meetings, attended school, conducted business, and did just about everything else essential to the life of the community.

The second and perhaps even more significant reason that Black people have frowned on divine compartmentalization has to do with the hypocritical behavior of white Christians. How could slave masters be so pious on Sunday and so evil on Monday? The perceived disconnect between white folk’s God and white folk’s behavior has been a constant reminder to Black people of the dangers of making a sharp distinction between the God of our learning and the God of our living.

More recently, the emergence of Black Theology, Womanist Theology, and other theologies of liberation have reminded us how devastating it can be, both personally and collectively, to sever academic theology from practical theology. Indeed, to do so is not only (1) to risk the loss of one’s own purpose and identity, but also (2) to betray the very people one is called to serve.

A brief review of the development of Black Theology will help to crystallize these two points with special reference to James Cone and Gayraud Wilmore.

As a systematic discipline, Black Theology emerged in the late 1960s in response to a two-pronged attack that challenged the validity and viability of the Black church. One prong stemmed from both white Christian conservatives and Black Christian assimilationists who claimed that Black religion was *not authentically Christian*. The other came from Black non-Christian nationalists who argued that Christianity was *not authentically Black*. The implication was that Christianity was “the white man’s religion” and that the Black church was no longer relevant to the struggle of Black people for justice, freedom, and equality.

Because this attack was aimed directly at the Black church, it should not be surprising that the Black church launched a counterattack—its very survival was at stake. It responded to the first assault by arguing that Black Christianity was *the* authentic Christianity because of its refusal to separate the gospel of Jesus Christ from the struggle of Black people—and all people—against the forces of injustice, discrimination, and oppression. It responded to the second offensive by insisting that Jesus Christ was not a blond-haired, blue-eyed Savior, but one who was ontologically *and, if need be*, physiologically Black. The name eventually coined for this two-fold counterattack was “Black Theology.”

The important thing to understand is that Black Theology, like other theological movements, was not born in a vacuum. It was an impassioned, no-holds-barred defense of the Black church that originated from within the context of the Black church. The landmark Black Power statement by the National Committee of Negro Churchmen, which appeared as a full-page advertisement in the *New York Times* on July 31, 1966, provided “the ideological and the institutional” foundation upon which Black Theology was built.⁵ The authors and endorsers of this statement were not ivory-tower academicians but active clergy serving as pastors and denominational leaders within the Black church.⁶

When Cone, the “father” of Black Theology, learned of this historic statement, he “shouted for joy... because it showed that prophetic voices were still present in the Black church.”⁷ Consequently, in writing his classic 1969 text, *Black Theology and Black Power*—the first full-length academic treatment of Black Theology—Cone had no qualms about abandoning the objective, dispassionate approach usually associated with Western scholarship. Due to his disenchantment with white theology, which often seemed to dodge the difficult issues of life, he understood that his primary allegiance lay not with white academia, nor even with Black academia, but with the Black church and the African American community. This helps explain why Cone could boldly write in the “Introduction” to his pioneering volume: “This work . . . is written with a definite attitude, the attitude of an angry Black man, disgusted with the oppression of Black people in America and with the scholarly demand to be ‘objective’ about it. Too many people have died, and too many are on the edge of death.”⁸

For Cone, the writing of *Black Theology and Black Power* was “a therapeutic and a liberating experience” that found concrete expression “in the energy and passion” of his writing.⁹ What was “at stake” was his identity, first, as a Black person, and, second, as a Christian.¹⁰

Not only does maintaining the connection between academic theology and practical theology help us as clergy, whether scholars or practitioners, not to lose our identity but it also helps us not to betray our brothers and sisters whom we are called to serve. Pertaining to this same time period when Black Theology, as a systematic theology, was surfacing, Gayraud Wilmore recalls a tense experience in a hotel room in San Antonio, Texas, where he spent all night pastoring a group of young Black militants who were raising critical questions about the relevance of the Bible, the Black Church, the white Church, Jesus Christ, and Black preachers to the Black Power movement, in general, and to James Forman’s demand for reparations, in particular. Wilmore talks about how shocked he was to find that not only were these young people passionate in their rhetoric but some of them had also smuggled some guns into his room to demonstrate how serious they were about being able to back it up. He says that when he finally

emerged from his hotel room the next morning, he was drained and “drugged with fear.”¹¹ Not knowing what these young people would do, what he did know was that he had been their pastor, at least for a night, and that together they struggled to carve a theology of liberation out of their plight of desperation. Wilmore further reflects,

Whatever one can say about the truth or error of our attempt to do theology at the street level, it did not emerge primarily from libraries, doctoral dissertations, and lectures in seminary classrooms but, rather, from the hurly burly of the real world, from the physical strain and emotional distress of interracial conflict in the inner city. But it also came from a new enthusiasm, a bounding sense of hope, an experience that can be best described by the Greek term *kaïros*, a moment of blinding revelation that the times are suddenly full of transcendent meaning and an ultimate decision must be made whether to be faithful to the God who creates, judges, and redeems or to cut and run.¹²

As a pastor-scholar who has dedicated my life to trying to bridge the gap between the Black church and the academy from the vantage point of the former over the last 20 plus years, I have come to the conclusion that, in the face of the daunting challenges of the twenty-first century, too many of my ministerial colleagues have decided “to cut and run.” And it is important to understand that these colleagues may include some who are rooted, primarily, in the academy as well as some who are rooted, primarily, in the Black church. While my observations pertain, especially, to my brother and sister clergy who are engaged in the *practical* ministry of the Black church, I do not want to lose sight of how my brother and sister clergy who are engaged in the *academic* ministry of the Black church, for example, Black Church Studies programs, may inadvertently aid and abet a nagging, persistent, and increasingly detrimental separation between the *study* of theology, on the one hand, and the *practice* of theology, on the other.

In order to address this crisis that, in my opinion, is having a seriously debilitating effect on the Black church, despite all appearances to the contrary, I would like to propose three emphases that Black Church Studies programs can focus on that will at least begin to lead the seminarians under their charge in the right direction. These are certainly not the only areas of needed emphasis, but they are critical. Drawing heavily from my own personal experience of testing the theology of the seminary in the pulpit of the sanctuary, I offer these three themes for consideration by the Black church of the twenty-first century.

A Redefinition of Success

I must admit that I have become rather weary of what seems to have become a culture of competition among ministers and ministries within the Black church and, indeed, within the Church Universal. Instead of staying focused on Jesus Christ and humbly seeking to serve God by serving our fellow brothers and sisters, too many of us seem to be caught up in the superficialities of ministry: who preaches the best, who has the best “whoop,” who can bring in the most members, who has the largest congregation, who has the biggest choir, who has the most impressive edifice, who has the most worship services on any given Sunday, who can boast the most ministries, who has the largest budget, who has the most popular television and/or radio ministry, who has the most impressive economic development ministry, who has the best school, who has the greatest Family Life Center, who has the largest Senior Citizens Home, who has the most extensive housing project, who has the most government clout, who has the most spirited worship service, etcetera.

Don’t get me wrong. I am not saying that there is anything wrong with having a dynamic, vibrant, exciting ministry with any or all of these features. What I am saying, or rather asking,

however, is whether or not these are the *only* indicators of success in the Christian ministry. Could it be that there are other “successful” models of ministry that may not look so successful in the world’s eyes but may be just as successful as these other ministries in the eyes of God?

The fact of the matter is that the vast majority of Black churches are not megachurches. And when we look at the Bible, from the Old Testament prophets through the missionary ministry of the apostle Paul, we look in vain for the megachurch. In fact, the only possible example of one that I am aware of is in the book of Acts when, on the day of Pentecost, Peter preached and 3,000 souls were added in one day. But even then, there is no solid evidence, to my knowledge, that all of those people remained together as one church.

Perhaps a more helpful model to examine is Jesus Christ himself. What did success look like for him? I remember Cone raising this issue as a member of Tavist Smiley’s televised “State of the Black Church” panel a few years ago. Remember, Jesus was born in a manger, had nowhere to lay his head, traveled around with a small group of motley disciples, depended on some women to finance his ministry, didn’t seem to have a steady job, could attract a crowd but also attracted his share of enemies, was ultimately forsaken by his followers, was denied three times by his most loyal disciple, was arrested, beaten mercilessly, and nailed to a cross and, finally, was buried at a young age while having hardly accomplished anything that the world would call successful.

Am I suggesting that Black Church Studies programs should teach their seminarians that this is the model of “success” to which they should aspire? Not necessarily. However, even as I reject this suggestion, we must not forget that the Bible does say,

If any want to become my followers, let them deny themselves and take up their cross daily and follow me. For those who want to save their life will lose it, and those who lose their life for my sake will save it. What does it profit them if they gain the whole world, but lose or forfeit themselves?¹³

By suggesting that we may want to redefine success in ministry, I am challenging Black Church Studies to consider seriously (1) that all are not called to pursue the same type of ministry, or to pursue it at the same level, and (2) that if the Black church is to speak with the prophetic voice that is absolutely essential in the unpredictable world of the twenty-first century, church leaders must be prepared to embody the courage, the character, and the commitment to take some risks sometimes. All the benefits that Black people enjoy today are because somebody was bold enough and faithful enough to take a risk. Jesus Christ took a risk, Denmark Vesey took a risk, Harriett Tubman took a risk, Mary McLeod Bethune took a risk, Marcus Garvey took a risk, Adam Clayton Powell took a risk, Rosa Parks took a risk, Malcolm X took a risk, Fannie Lou Hamer took a risk, and Martin Luther King Jr. took a risk. Furthermore, many of these risk takers paid with their lives.

And so you ask, then, why should ministers be taught to redefine success? Why should they be taught to take a risk? Do we want them, also, to pay the ultimate price by giving their lives? While this remains an open question, the fact of the matter is that, whether we literally pay with our lives or not, a whole lot of oppressed people in this nation and throughout the world are literally paying with their lives everyday. And with a political culture that seems bent on turning back the hands of time, the gap between the “haves” and the “have nots” grows wider and wider every day.

All of the glittering signs of material success are quite impressive when we look at the contemporary “stars” of the Black church. But, as a popular saying reminds us, “All that glitters is not gold.” What will all of our “success” mean if, in the final analysis, we have gained the whole world, but have lost our souls? It seems to me that if the Black church and Black people are to move forward in the twenty-first century, we must seriously consider a redefinition of success.

A Redistribution of Power

Sometimes we in the Black church talk glibly about empowering others to be all that they can be. This is a noble ideal, but I sometimes wonder how serious we are about achieving it. To empower someone else means that somebody has to give up some power. And I have found that, in the Black church, that is the last thing that anyone wants to do, especially those who have the most power—the clergy. If we are serious about empowerment, this is one of the risks that must sometimes be taken.

I am reminded of the story of Jesus and the woman who had suffered with an issue of blood for some 12 long years. When she touched the hem of his garment in the middle of a crowd one day, not only was she immediately healed but also, immediately, Jesus was aware that “power had gone forth from him.”¹⁴ We often forget that in order to empower someone else, even Jesus had to give up some power.

Especially for those of us who enjoy the benefits of male privilege in the Black church, it is difficult for us to give up any power. It was Frederick Douglass who said, “Power concedes nothing without a demand.”¹⁵ In the Black church, many of our sisters in ministry will tell you that power concedes nothing, whether there is a demand or not. As much as we may not like to talk about it, the Black church is still one of the most sexist institutions on the face of the earth. Some brothers are struggling with this issue and are openly and honestly confessing their own sexism and working to do something about it. I appreciate, for instance, the candidness of my brother, Dr. Jeffery L. Tribble, Sr., director of the Black Church Studies program at Garrett Evangelical Theological Seminary, in his recent book, *Transformative Pastoral Leadership in the Black Church*. After being challenged by a female ministerial colleague who helped him to examine his own behavior, Tribble was able to talk about his “journey of healing from [his] own sexism.” He says,

I have discovered that healing not only takes time; it takes work. For me, this work includes my advocacy for the acceptance of qualified female clergy at all levels of the church through my research and writing as well as by my teaching and mentoring of female and male clergy.¹⁶

When dealing with this issue, I often refer to myself as “a recovering sexist.” Even though I believe I have come a long way, I know that I still have a long way to go. I also know that I will never completely recover “on this side of the Jordan”¹⁷ because sexism, just like racism, is so systemically and structurally entrenched in the society in which we live. Therefore, drastic situations require drastic solutions.

One such solution is currently being tested at the Covenant Baptist Church in Washington, DC. Covenant has an interesting and unique history that renders the congregation a fertile ground for bold, unorthodox experiments in prophetic ministry. For example, this originally all-white, Southern Baptist congregation, founded in 1945, took the radical step of calling an African American pastor in 1969, during a period of white flight from, and racial transition within, an inner-city community. That pastor happened to be my father, the Rev. H. Wesley Wiley. During his tenure, Reverend Wiley took the radical step of including women as equal members of the diaconate and licensed the church’s first woman to preach the gospel. That woman eventually became my wife, the Rev. Dr. Christine Y. Wiley.

After my father had served as Covenant’s pastor for some 16 years, I was called to succeed him and served along with my wife, as pastor and assistant pastor, respectively, for almost 20 years. Approximately two years ago, however, we led the church in calling us together as a genuine co-pastor team. The word “genuine” is used here to distinguish our model of co-pastoral leadership from other models in which the woman may be “co-pastor” in name, but her power does not equal that of her male counterpart. To the contrary, at Covenant, each

pastor (or “co-pastor”) shares equal authority, equal responsibility, and equal compensation. In order for this pastoral transition to occur successfully, and in order for my wife to become adequately empowered, I had to be ready and willing to give up some power and she had to be ready and willing to receive it.

While the overwhelming majority of the congregation supported and eventually approved this “new paradigm for a new day,” as we called it, the transition did not occur without a struggle. I was willing to relinquish the necessary power, and my wife felt ready, prepared, and indeed “called” to accept it, but a small, determined faction within the membership worked diligently to prevent the implementation of this co-pastor model.

Much of the resistance appeared to be based on an unwillingness, by some, to depart from tradition. That tradition included an idea, prevalent in the Black church, that a church is supposed to have one, and only one, pastor. In support of this idea, we sometimes heard the admonition that “anything with more than one head is a monster.” This tradition also included the notion that the pastor should be a man—not a woman. Support for this conviction often stemmed from church backgrounds in which a male pastor had simply been the only model to which certain individuals had ever been exposed. This is all they had ever seen and, consequently, this is all they could comfortably envision.

Because of the limited opportunities available for women to use their ministerial gifts and pursue their “calling,” especially to the pastorate, in some of our more conservative Christian denominations, it becomes imperative for progressive male pastors to be creative in opening more doors of opportunity for women to serve. This can only be done effectively if men are willing to share power with women. Interestingly enough, I have discovered that not only do women clergy benefit from this shared model of leadership but so does the Church as well as the men who share.

The Church benefits not only because, as another old saying goes, “Two heads are better than one,” but also because a successful male/female partnership results in the complimentary blending of gifts and perspectives that could never be achieved by a woman or man pastoring alone. Surprisingly to some, the man who shares power benefits also because, in the final analysis, he loses nothing, but gains everything. The ministry is broader, richer, and more comprehensive because all that he used to attempt alone is now done more effectively by two. Jesus was right when he said “those who want to save their life will lose it, and those who lose their life for my sake will find it” (Matthew 16:25). In God’s strange economy, the way to preserve one’s power is to give it up, and those who share power will not lose it, but find real power.

This principle applies not only to the issue of gender but also to other categories of membership within the church family. Whether we are talking about the young or the old, the rich or the poor, the able or the disabled, the clergy or the laity, the more people feel empowered, the more they will feel invested and, hopefully, the more positive contributions they will be willing and able to make for the benefit of all.

One important caveat here is that the empowerment I am talking about has nothing to do with the internal politics and petty power struggles that characterize, handicap, paralyze, disrupt, and even destroy the life and fellowship of the Black church in so many instances. I am not talking about territorialism, egoism, or status seeking. Nor am I talking about “majoring in the minors.” To the contrary, I am talking about the Holy Spirit power that Jesus promised his disciples in Acts 1:8 that enabled them to become effective, liberating witnesses at home and abroad.¹⁸ I am talking about power, not as a possession, but as a life-building force that, when shared, allows the church to be all it can be through allowing the people of God to be all they can be.

This radical redistribution of power requires the church to break away from tradition and be bold and creative enough to do new things in new ways. At Covenant, we tried to capture

the essence of this “new thing” that we believed God was doing among us¹⁹ in the following song I wrote titled “A New Paradigm for a New Day”:

It's a new paradigm
 For a new day;
 Come, let us seize the time
 To walk a new way,
 And as we move ahead,
 Don't be afraid—
 The God who has brought us here
 Is leading the way.
 Don't you get left behind,
 Get on board,
 The train leaves right on time,
 And we're movin' forward.
 Don't you let anything
 Stand in your way,
 'Cause it's a new paradigm
 For a new day.
 It's a new way for a new day,
 It's a new walk for a new talk,
 It's a new mind for a new time,
 It's a new heart for a new start.
 It's a new plan for a new stand,
It's a new power for a new hour,
 It's a new mission . . .
 Come on and catch the vision.²⁰

It seems to me that a redistribution of power is essential for the Black church of the twenty-first century to do the “new thing” God is calling it to do as it endeavors to realize its full God-given potential.

A Reassessment of Morality

In a recent newspaper article, the pastor of a large African American congregation contends that for him, personally, gay marriage “is a moral issue and not a civil rights issue.” I find this interesting because I thought that civil rights was also a moral issue. It seems to me that what is reflected in this quotation is a rather widespread tendency among some Christians to restrict the concept of morality to the private realm and, further, to reduce morality to issues of sex and sexuality. While sexual concerns must certainly be a part of any comprehensive discussion about morality, moral considerations extend far beyond the narrow confines of this one issue. In addition, the restriction of sexual issues to the private sphere overlooks their social and political ramifications.

Unlike others, I must admit that I am not offended by the comparison that some make between gay rights and civil rights. Although there are distinct differences between the two movements, I do not believe that Black people have a lock on civil rights. Instead, I believe that there are certain basic human and civil rights to which all human beings are entitled, regardless of race, ethnicity, class, religion, gender, age, physical ability, or sexual orientation. And if members of the homosexual²¹ community want to borrow from the lessons, principles, insights, and strategies of the historic civil rights movement²² in their struggle against oppression, then I say

more power to them. I do not believe that the gay and lesbian struggle for liberation takes anything away from the ongoing Black struggle for liberation.

Unfortunately, the contemporary Black church, not unlike other conservative expressions of American Christendom, has too often viewed morality as a private, personal concern rather than as a public, social concern.²³ With the Ten Commandments as a backdrop, our preoccupation with the *personal* sins of murder, adultery, stealing, lying, and covetousness, for instance, runs the risk of our overlooking how even more devastating these same offenses are as *social* sins. The proliferation of other so-called “sins,” including excessive drinking, smoking, drugging, gambling, cheating, and a multiplicity of “unorthodox” sexual behaviors, are also connected to larger, social forces. Even concentration on activity, the sinfulness of which is debatable (such as dancing, playing cards, working on Sunday, or listening to “the devil’s music,” for example, jazz and rhythm and blues), may preclude the Black church from focusing on the larger, systemic sins of a racist, classist, sexist, capitalist, militarist, and heterosexist society. The inextricable connection between personal and social sin must be understood if the Black church is to address questions of morality in a constructive, comprehensive, and responsible manner.²⁴

Returning to the issue of gay marriage, the pastor mentioned in the newspaper article referred to above made two other points that demand our brief attention. First, he commented that in all his years of ministry, he had never had two men or two women come to him requesting to be married. The implication is that no request indicated no interest or desire. What he failed to mention is that same-sex marriage is illegal in his jurisdiction. But even if he was referring to a same-sex union ceremony other than marriage, my experience with this issue suggests that he probably will never be approached to perform such a ceremony unless and until he takes a bold moral stand renouncing heterosexism and affirming the validity of same-gender relationships. It is likely that many, if not most, homosexual members of a traditional Black church congregation remain closeted because of the intense stigma, rejection, bias, and downright hostility associated with the issue of homosexuality. Furthermore, those members who are openly gay or lesbian may still be reluctant to request a union ceremony, even in a welcoming and affirming congregation, because support for gay rights does not automatically translate into support for gay marriage.

Second, the pastor observed that there were too many other issues far more important to his congregation than gay marriage that needed to be addressed. While in one sense he may be correct, in another sense I believe he is totally wrong. He is correct in the sense that it is a shame that so much time and emotional, psychological, and physical energy must be spent on the basic moral question of whether same-gender loving persons should be accorded the same dignity, respect, protection, rights, and privileges as that enjoyed by any other human being. In many ways, this debate seems so “twentieth century.” As we learn to develop a greater appreciation for the rich diversity of the human family in the global village of the twenty-first century, we are reminded of Rodney King’s immortal question: “Can’t we all get along?”²⁵ We are also reminded of Martin Luther King Jr.’s prophetic statement: “We must all learn to live together as brothers [and sisters] or we will all perish together as fools.”²⁶

In another sense, however, since the human race has not yet learned to live together across various lines of cultural, geographic, religious, ethnic, racial, gender, class, and other divisions, I submit that there is no issue any more important than homophobia that the contemporary church needs to address. Why? Because I believe that homophobia is one of the last great frontiers that stands between us, as human beings, and our ultimate victory over xenophobia. In other words, if those of us who are heterosexual can conquer our fear of the homosexual—that is, one whose sexual orientation is different from our own—it will go a long way toward helping us conquer our fear of the stranger—that is, one who is different from us in any kind of way. So when I talk about homosexuality in the church, I am not just talking about homosexuality. Essentially, I am talking about overcoming whatever it is within us that prevents us from

welcoming, affirming, and loving persons who are different from us. This may make some of us uncomfortable, but then *Jesus* makes us uncomfortable!

In Washington, DC, my wife and I have led Covenant Baptist Church in becoming a welcoming and affirming congregation. It is an ongoing process that presents many challenges and requires much prayer, patience, and perseverance. Because of the volatility of the issue, people get mad, leave the church, and act out in a variety of other ways when they are uncomfortable with the open acceptance of homosexuals within the life and ministry of the congregation. To help reinforce our stance on this issue, we ask the congregation to stand and recite the following vision statement every Sunday morning:

Affirming our African heritage, our vision is to build an *inclusive* body of biblical believers who continue to grow in Christ as we love, serve, and fellowship with the community and each other.²⁷

We have also distributed a ten-point pastoral vision statement that includes the declaration that we are “an *inclusive* congregation where *all* are welcome, regardless of race, ethnicity, class, gender, age, or sexual orientation.”²⁸

The cornerstone of my teaching on the issue of homosexuality is that it is not a sin. Whether it is innate or acquired, homosexual orientation is not something that is chosen. There may be sinful homosexual acts, just as there are sinful heterosexual acts, but the condition of homosexuality is no more sinful than the condition of heterosexuality. I have not always held this position. In fact, there was a time when I was just as homophobic as anyone. But several experiences changed my perspective, including (1) my interaction with the homosexual community when I worked in a local high school for the arts; (2) my observation and counseling of a young man who struggled with his own sexual identity when I served as his youth director in my church; (3) my exposure to the diverse atmosphere of New York City and the liberal environment of Union Theological Seminary, where a gay caucus is one of the approved campus organizations; (4) my study of Black Liberation Theology with James Cone and my conversations with Womanist Theologian Kelly Brown Douglas, through which I developed a deeper understanding of, and appreciation for, the multidimensionality of oppression; and, (5) my study of Howard Thurman, who emphasizes the infinite value of every human being.

One example of how these experiences affected me, my ministry, and my vision of the Church can be derived from the “Words of Comfort” I delivered at the recent funeral of one of my former gay colleagues at the local arts high school mentioned above. In an excerpt from those “Words,” I described him as not being so much a “religious” person as a deeply *spiritual* person who, in turn, experienced the theater as a deeply spiritual phenomenon. I went on to explain that three examples of this spirituality were his emphasis on theater as *ritual*, as *pastoral care*, and as *radically inclusive community*. *Ritual* was seen in his approach to theater as an act of worship in which the finished artistic product was a precious offering to God. *Pastoral care* was evident in that he was so much more than a teacher to his young students—he was their pastor and they were his adoring congregation.

Closely related to these emphases was his emphasis on theater as *radically inclusive community*. In this highly xenophobic society in which so many of us harbor a profound fear of anyone or anything that looks different, acts different, walks different, or talks different from us or from that to which we are accustomed, he taught his students, by precept and by example, to welcome, to affirm, to accept, and to embrace *every* human being because we are *all* precious in the eyes of God. In other words, he taught them how to love. And, I tell you, if the church that I pastor, or any church for that matter, could be half as real, half as caring, and half as authentic as he was in fostering authentic love among his students and within the world of theater in

general, not only would the church be more effective, but this world would be a much better place in which to live. The truth is I believe that I am a much better pastor, Christian, and human being because of my exposure to this brother than I would ever have been otherwise.²⁹

This exposure and other experiences, as enumerated above, inspired me to revisit the Bible, and especially the life of Jesus Christ, to determine if there was any biblical justification for the rampant hateful, judgmental, and often vicious attitudes and feelings against homosexuals that permeate Church and society. It did not take me long to reach the conclusion that the sin is not homosexuality, but homophobia/heterosexism. The Bible's, and especially Jesus's, overwhelming emphasis on love absolutely precludes the hostility, intolerance, and violence that are directed toward non-heterosexual children of God. A reassessment of morality in Black Church Studies programs will help students understand that the morally upright church is not the one that bashes gays and lesbians, or even the one that silently ignores them, but the one that embraces them with unconditional love. This is just one issue that the Church needs to reexamine in order to craft a more viable morality for the twenty-first century and beyond.

Conclusion

There is no such thing as *impractical* theology. All theology is practical because it emerges out of the real-life struggle of real-life human beings to make sense out of the world in which we live and to explore the ultimate purpose for our existence. To that end, Black Church Studies programs should prepare Black seminarians to use their theological education to lead the Black church and the Black community to new levels of insight, new vistas of understanding, and new plateaus of commitment to make this world a better place. By teaching these seminarians to consider a *redefinition of success*, a *redistribution of power*, and a *reassessment of morality*, Black Church Studies programs can go a long way toward producing religious leaders who possess the integrity, character, humility, compassion, and courage, not just to critique Church and society, but to "turn the world upside down."³⁰ As a result, the twenty-first-century Black church will be well positioned to serve God, humanity, this present age, and generations yet unborn.

Notes

1. James Cone, *A Back Theology of Liberation* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1986), 39.
2. Kelly Brown Douglas, "The Black Church and the Politics of Sexuality," in Anthony B. Pinn and Dwight N. Hopkins, eds., *Loving the Body: Black Religious Studies and the Erotic* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2004), 347–362. See also her *Sexuality and the Black Church: A Womanist Perspective* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1999) and *What's Faith Got To Do With It? Black Bodies/Christian Souls* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2005).
3. See John Mbiti, *African Religions and Philosophy*, 2nd Revised & enlarged ed. (Heinemann, 1990).
4. See C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence H. Mamiya, *The Black Church in the African American Experience* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1990), Chapter 1.
5. See Cone and Wilmore, eds., *Black Theology: A Documentary History, 1966–1979*, 1st ed. (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1979), 17–16, 23–30.
6. Note: The term "Black church" is used here to include not only historically Black denominations, but also local Black congregations within predominantly white denominations.
7. See Cone, *My Soul Looks Back* (Nashville: Abingdon, 1982), 44.
8. Cone, *Black Theology and Black Power* (New York: The Seabury Press, 1969), 2.

9. See Cone, *My Soul Looks Back*, *ibid.*, 47.
10. *Ibid.*, 44, 51.
11. Gayraud S. Wilmore, *Pragmatic Spirituality: The Christian Faith Through an Africentric Lens* (New York: New York University Press, 2004), 233.
12. *Ibid.*, 235.
13. Luke 9:23 (NRSV).
14. Mark 5:30 (NRSV).
15. See Frederick Douglass, "West India Emancipation, Speech Delivered at Canandaigua, New York, August 4, 1857," in Philip S. Foner, ed., *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass, vol. II: Pre-Civil War Decade 1850–1860* (New York: International Publishers, 1950), 437.
16. Jeffrey L. Tribble, Sr., *Transformative Pastoral Leadership in the Black Church* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 18.
17. An expression often used in the Black church and other Christian contexts to refer to earthly life as opposed to eternal life beyond the grave.
18. Here Jesus says, "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth." (NRSV)
19. See Isaiah 43:19 in which God, speaking through the prophet, proclaims, "Behold, I will do a new thing..." (KJV).
20. Copyright 2004 by Dennis W. Wiley.
21. My use of the term, "homosexual" is a broad reference to a variety of persons—including gay, lesbian, bisexual, and transgender (GLBT) individuals—who do not consider themselves to be exclusively heterosexual. These same-gender loving (SGL) persons are all included in my discussion, even if they are referred to simply as "homosexual," "gay," or "gay and lesbian."
22. Here I refer to the movement against racial segregation in the United States that effectively began with the Montgomery Bus Boycott in 1955 and ended with the assassination of the Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. in 1968.
23. See James H. Cone, *Black Theology and Black Power*, *Ibid.*, 103–115; and Gayraud S. Wilmore, *Black Religion and Black Radicalism: An Interpretation of the Religious History of African Americans*, 3rd ed. (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1998), 163–195. Also, see Dale P. Andrews, *Practical Theology for Black Churches: Bridging Black Theology and African American Folk Religion* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2002).
24. Please note that I am well aware of Reinhold Niebuhr's classic text, *Moral Man and Immoral Society* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1960), in which he argues that whereas human beings can be moral agents, human societies and social groups cannot. He contends that every human group is necessarily self-interested and that, consequently, "there is less reason to guide and to check impulse, less capacity for self-transcendence, less ability to comprehend the needs of others and therefore more unrestrained egoism than the individuals, who compose the group, reveal in their personal relationships." (pp. xi–xii.) Be that as it may, the United States calls itself a "Christian" nation and claims to be "one nation under God." The Black church, among others, must be the moral conscience that prevents this civil religion from being swept under the rug of patriotism whenever it suits the imperialistic purposes of a tyrannical government. Niebuhr notwithstanding, the connection between personal and social morality still exists, regardless of the difference between individuals and social groups, because the people who lead the nation and head multinational corporations are the same people who claim to worship a Christian God.
25. Rodney King was the African American man whose merciless beating at the hand of white Los Angeles policemen was captured on video tape in 1991. The acquittal of the police by an all-white jury in 1992 ignited an urban rebellion in the Black community of Los Angeles.
26. Martin Luther King Jr., "Remaining Awake Through A Great Revolution," in Clayborne Carson and Peter Holloran, eds., *A Knock At Midnight: Inspiration from the Great Sermons of Reverend Martin Luther King, Jr.* (Warner Books, 1998), 207–208.

27. Covenant Baptist Church "Vision Statement."
28. It was suggested to me that we also need to add "physical disability" to this list, a point with which I wholeheartedly agree.
29. From "Words of Comfort" delivered at the funeral of a gay brother for whose life I will eternally be grateful.
30. See Acts 17:6 (NRSV) in which it is said of the early Christian believers, "These people who have been turning the world upside down have come here also."

The Black Church and Public Policy: Retrospect and Prospect

Harold Dean Trulear

Public theology and engagement have characterized African American Christianity and its institutional face, the Black church, virtually from the first gatherings of Black Christians in the Western hemisphere. Christian faith intersected with public issues from the first recognition of the tension between biblical stories of freedom and the racial conventions of slavery, segregation, and discrimination. When one reads the sermons, speeches, addresses, and writings of African American Christians in any era, public theology is at work. Even when Black Christians seemingly eschewed public engagement of the forces of oppression, they did so in full recognition of their existence. Even to be otherworldly was to acknowledge that something was profoundly wrong with this world.

Yet, there seems to be a waning of public theology in African American Christianity. To the extent that congregations do respond to social ills and problems, they have exhibited a propensity toward reducing their efforts to more individualistic means of engagement. The church ministers to the poor solely through acts of charity. One addresses the breakdown of the family through counseling or workshops. Employment issues find address through training classes, while poor performance by youth in schools receives attention through mentoring. On top of it all, preaching, whether Sunday morning sermons or televised broadcasts of “the Word of God,” reinforces this trend through developing theo-therapeutic solutions to worldly challenge and brokenness, without considering that there may be something amiss with the system, worldview, and institutions within which such problems emerge.¹

In my teaching in seminary, I offer a group exercise assigning each group a case study, normally involving a child failing in school, an addicted mother with a small child, and an unemployed young man recently returned from incarceration. I make each group a “church” and ask them to spend significant time crafting an appropriate response to the situation.

The responses are often thoughtful and comprehensive, at least where meeting the individual need may be concerned. The child having trouble in school is prescribed a tutoring program, sometimes even a mentor who will walk with him through his difficulties. Sometimes, there will be the proffer of a parenting skills class for his/her mother so that she can become more involved in her child’s educational development. The addicted mother can join a support group in the church, have services for her child as well as parenting classes. The “church” may even find a rehab facility for her and support her time in a 12-step program upon release.

The young man returning from prison receives a mentor and job training, maybe even a reference to an employer who is willing to “take a chance” on a young man with a record. Some compassionate church member assists with housing, while another directs our “returning citizen” to a life skills program, where they can learn “pro-social” behaviors such as personal budgeting and grooming, time management and parenting skills. All of the above serve as important dimensions of a congregation’s service delivery system—their ministry to the “least, the last and the lost.” A measure of self-satisfaction and affirmation can swell within such a congregation because the measures they have chosen often exceed those of churches that do not want to deal with such persons, or who simply offer them prayer and evangelism.

Yet, one thing they lack is an adequate response to the systemic dimensions of the problems involved in each of the three cases. The youth failing in school receives attention, but not a problematic school district. Is the school system constructed to properly educate this young person? Does the school board’s budget clearly reflect a “students first” mentality? Is the district cash-strapped because of state-mandated funding laws that tie school funding to local property taxes, thereby limiting resources in the districts with the most distressed economic situations? Are the teachers properly educated (often in public colleges and universities supported by state tax dollars), supervised and help accountable? Have we weakened the pool for prospective teachers through rewarding other professions more lucratively, or offering those professions more status (such as when we celebrate certain scholastic achievements on Student Recognition Sundays but minimize others)?

The mother battling addiction faces systematic challenges. Drug and alcohol facilities require funding, dollars that insurance companies are reluctant to provide lest they cut into the profit margins their stakeholders (including church members in large pension funds) expect. The drug and alcohol facilities with the strongest records of success often can cost as much as 25–30,000 dollars per month. Without insurance, this is impossible for many.

And even if insurance is available, normally it is provided only once, making the financing of treatment for a relapse beyond the reach of many. Clearly, treatment for drug and alcohol abuse in this country is tied to economic well-being. This is a systemic issue.

Finally, the young man returning from prison certainly benefits from all of the services listed above. But the systemic issues arise in his situation as well. Access to employment goes beyond job training and pro-social skills. Collateral sanctions, those strictures imposed upon an individual subsequent to their release from prison, play a part as well. In many states, having a felony conviction denies access to any number of jobs, including those in cosmetology and barbering (the state does not want to give someone with that type of record a license to carry scissors). While some sanctions make sense (someone convicted for child molestation should not teach kindergarten, nor should someone with multiple drunken driving convictions be given a commercial driver’s license), others require serious review.

In addition, collateral sanctions often include housing strictures. For instance, a felony conviction can make one ineligible for public housing. This means that if you lived with your family in public housing before your conviction you cannot go home. Furthermore, these sanctions impact the exercise of citizenship through voting sanctions, and access to education through the denial of certain public scholarships and grants, and can even by law lead to termination of parental rights.

When we rehearse these systemic dimensions of the challenges posed by those who come to the newly formed “church” in the class or workshop, participants admit that they have not been trained to think in those terms. Because some congregations struggle simply to provide services, the formation of a fully developed plan of service delivery constitutes a progressive ministry. Yet, even such a progressive system of delivering services misses the prophetic dimension of advocacy: the articulation of the systemic dimensions of human malaise that works against human wholeness and community. It is as if the civil rights movement had confined itself to providing opportunities for oppressed persons within the system of segregation rather

than challenging the system itself. It parallels making enslaved Africans comfortable with their world under enslavement: having a good family life or learning to be “single, saved and satisfied” in spite of the rapes and auction blocks that tore families apart. This contemporary address to injustice reduces all public issues to private trials, as if a certain inevitability and permanence to structural evil and oppression exists.

The solution is not to abandon service delivery in favor of advocacy. To preach and teach prophetically, to organize for social change, and to mobilize against policy injustice does not absent the church from the responsibility to share a cold cup of water, feed the hungry, or clothe the naked. Agitating for health-care reform should not supplant visiting the sick, nor advocating alternative sentencing substitute for visiting the prisoner. Advocacy on behalf of either the “pro-life” or “pro-choice” agendas ought not to obfuscate the need for care posed by the real-life challenges of pregnant teens and single mothers. Support for legislation protecting the rights of the physically and mentally challenged must be accompanied by ministries to both populations. The real tragedy comes in service and advocacy becoming bifurcated and disjointed, seemingly separate tasks, as opposed to representing a multifaceted response to injustice. The real danger occurs when dealing with public policy and social services becomes a choice and not a mandate.

Such was not always the case. The history of African American Christianity reveals instances and even eras where service and advocacy served as two sides of one coin. Speaking or writing a prophetic word walked together with caring for the sick and dispossessed. Agitating for access to services went along with service provision itself. Addressing the laws that oppressed people and denied them opportunity reflected a climate where love, mutuality, and service itself thrived. Calling for justice in America sprang from the practice of justice and charity within the church, as the African Methodist Episcopal motto “God Our Father, Christ Our Redeemer, Man Our Brother” (and its later gender inclusive renderings) posited congregational life in what Peter Paris calls the “non-racist” vision of the Black churches.² Rehearsing this history gives visibility to contemporary possibilities. Indeed, the adage often criticized by Black church leaders: “we’ve never done it that way before,” is rendered null and void when reading the history of public engagement in the African American Christian tradition. If anything, the contemporary Black church needs a recovery of the “way before” as a way forward.

Retrospect

This long history of public engagement lends itself well to typologizing and schematization. No less than eight discernible strategies emerge when considering the ongoing public work of Black churches. Each, arguably, dominates a particular era of African American³ history, though there is no time when any exists as the sole strategy for public engagement. These strategies are: moral suasion, education, economic uplift, legislation, litigation, direct action, community development, and community organization.

I review these strategies not to provide a comprehensive or exhaustive documentation of them. That work has been done well by others. Rather the intent here is to recognize a broad spectrum of public engagement strategies in order to expand our vision of current possibilities. Public engagement that yields in policy awareness and change emerges from a variety of historical forms.

Reviewing these strategies assists us in thinking through the need for deliberate and strategic public engagement in contemporary society. It provides us with alternatives to the narrowly focused individualistic models of change that characterize contemporary religious vision. The real weakness of so-called prosperity preaching may be less so its materialism and consumerism and more its captivity to a post-modern individualism, presenting current arrangements as ills that must be overcome, and not transformed. Indeed, even when civil rights marchers sang “We Shall Overcome,” it was understood that to overcome was/is to transform, that overcoming

represented a radical egalitarian enactment of justice and not simply individual success in spite of the injustices faced.

We begin with the dominant political strategy of early America, *moral suasion*. Moral suasion refers to the strategy of addressing social ills from an ethical perspective through the written and spoken word. African American churches and their leadership adopted the strategy of exerting public moral influence through speeches, sermons, addresses, pamphlets, essays, articles, books, and other media designed to communicate their vision of justice. Their challenges to racism and slavery, segregation and discrimination found expression in the public square through public discourse, much in the tradition of the time.

African American moral suasion drew on a number of sources in its antiracist vision for society. Biblical texts, enlightenment philosophical anthropology, and African understandings of community all fused in the moral vision of preachers such as Richard Allen and Absalom Jones, pamphleteers such as David Walker, and orators like Maria Steward and Frederick Douglass, as they used appropriate platforms within and without the congregational and religious setting to press for social change in existing public conventions.⁴

Moral suasion spoke directly to the challenges of crafting just policy for the oppressed. In addressing the racist policies, advocates of moral suasion sought changes in the public arena. Drawing on the language and concepts of the freedom in the Enlightenment, liberation in the Bible, and African understandings of communal life, moral suasion clearly identified public policy as the business of the church. But practitioners of moral suasion saw the critical need for service provision. Richard Allen and Absalom Jones not only spoke and wrote eloquently against the evils of slavery and the slave trade, they worked as part of the Free African Society in Philadelphia, which provided relief and educational services, economic support, and other forms of ministries of caring for the citizens of their community. Maria Steward taught school and later served as a volunteer at Freedman's Hospital at Howard University. Frederick Douglass not only wrote and spoke passionately about abolition of slavery but offered his home as a station on the Underground Railroad.

Education as a strategy drew on African traditions of wisdom and Western philosophical connections between knowledge and leadership, as Black churches, often in partnership with their white counterparts, founded educational institutions in the mid to late 1800s. Historically Black colleges and universities sprang from efforts by African American and white Christians as institutions of social change.⁵

Examinations of the curricula of these schools revealed strong emphasis in religion and education as potential and actual professions for students. These professions represented agencies of racial uplift in the struggle for justice. Unlike contemporary preprofessional curricula that press for successful job attainment and placement, these institutions developed curricula that clearly connected moral betterment, social change, and racial uplift as dimensions of professional responsibility.

Their vision implicitly and explicitly challenged legal barriers to equality. The implicit challenge lay in the demonstration that African Americans, properly educated, could take a rightful place in a society of equals, thus revealing the laws of discrimination and segregation to be philosophically bankrupt, morally unjust, and empirically fallacious. The explicit challenge emerged from the graduates of those institutions (Francis Grimke, Kelly Miller, Anna Julia Cooper), as well as their faculties and administrations (John Hope, Octavius Catto, Fannie Coppin).

Legislative and litigation efforts crystallized around the turn of the century. However, this form of public engagement also reflected a growing separation between large-scale efforts toward social change, and public religious activity. Gayraud Wilmore points to the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries as the "Dechristianization of Black Radicalism and the Deradicalization of the Black Church." Documenting the ways in which nonsectarian organizations move to the forefront of social engagement, Wilmore laments the retreat from public activism on the part of religious leadership.⁶

Though church bodies kept alive a social vision, their institutional activism diminished in the public square. Their vision for social change could still be found in speeches, addresses, and sermons, but institutional activism shifted from the denominational efforts that produced the development of schools and colleges to nonsectarian organizations specializing in forms of engagement such as legislation (NAACP) and litigation (NAACP Legal Defense Fund). Even the introduction to specialized efforts in *economic uplift* (The National Urban League) moved the center for such activity from specifically religious institutions.

In this regard, economic uplift became a strategy where public policy was sometimes in tension with the services of job training and access. The gradualism of Booker T. Washington comes to mind. However, it is notable that in the work of the National Urban League's first executive director, George Edmund Haynes, one clearly saw the twin foci of assisting Blacks in securing work, and fighting job discrimination as a matter of policy engagement.⁷

Significantly, both efforts in legislation and litigation specifically address issues of public policy. The legislative and lobbying efforts of the NAACP clearly targeted unjust laws regarding segregation and discrimination in a variety of venues, including housing, voting, employment, and education. Frustrated by the slow pace of legislative change, and its dependency on a larger moral consensus than was available to move elected representatives to action, litigation efforts by the NAACP Legal Defense Fund, its leading strategist Charles Hamilton Houston,⁸ and his stellar student at Howard University School of Law, Thurgood Marshall, targeted the court system as the means of changing public policy. The landmark Supreme Court decision, *Brown vs Topeka Board of Education* in 1954, culminated in a strategic initiative of policy intervention bypassing a stubborn racist consensus in federal and state legislatures, and opened the nation to an ongoing avenue of social change through the courts that continues into the first decade of the twenty-first century.

It would be a mistake however, to see the "deradicalization of the Black Church" as a full abandonment of social activism on the part of African American Christianity. cursory review of local leadership in these organizations often reveals the steady involvement of religious leaders, clergy and lay, as the social vision cast by the Black church found expressions through its members' participation in the NAACP, Urban League, and even the Garvey Movement (UNIA) and the YMCA.⁹ Additionally, rehearsing the story of *Brown vs Topeka Board of Education* reveals a number of church leaders involved at the local level of both the *Brown* case and the suits from South Carolina, Delaware, Virginia, and Washington, DC, attached to it.¹⁰

As the twentieth century progressed, the *direct action* of the civil rights movement gained traction within organizations that ranged from those with clearly religious overtones such as the Congress of Racial Equality to the intentionally Christian Southern Christian Leadership Conference. The civil rights movement both reflected its religious roots, and gave space for religious leadership in ways not realized in the first decades of the century. The emergence of Martin Luther King, Jr. as the preeminent voice for justice in America signaled a type of reunification of Black Christian leadership and public engagement.

The participation of Black churches was not uniform. This diversity reveals the complexity with which the public engagement strategies of Black churches struggled regularly. While the divisions within the Black churches seems to have been given its biggest audience in the 2008 presidential campaign with the rift between candidate Barack Obama and Rev. Jeremiah Wright, scholars such as Peter Paris, Barbara Savage, and Rosetta Ross have documented such multilayered approaches to public engagement in their analyses of Black church history and ethics.¹¹ The popular myth of uniformity in Black church public engagement derives much fuel from a misreading of Black church support for the civil rights movement. Direct action as a unilateral strategy for public engagement stems from the same misreading. In addition, the writings of Ross and Savage make clear that the leadership of Black women in Black public engagement, both in public policy advocacy and ministries of service, enable us to see a more articulated form of social engagement, moving beyond viewing the movement solely in terms

of speeches, and recapturing the community formation within the movement reflecting the ministry of service.

Succeeding the direct action of social protest was the emergence of the *community development* movement. Black churches, especially larger ones with some economic capacity, joined with the structures created by Lyndon Johnson's Great Society to form community development corporations designed to develop housing, economic opportunity, and other substantial services in poor communities in both the urban and rural centers. Interestingly, such cooperation is often overlooked when accusations of "selling out" to government funding are leveled at religious organizations that participated in the "Faith-Based Initiatives" of the administration of George W. Bush. Bush's misguided politics notwithstanding, the establishment of the White House Office of Faith-Based and Community Initiatives in 2001 and its successor, The White House Office of Faith-Based and Neighborhood Partnerships under the administration of Barack Obama, represented the culmination of many efforts under presidential administrations from Johnson forward. This includes community development efforts crystallizing during the Carter years (such as the maturation of programs such as Rev. Leon Sullivan's Opportunities Industrialization Center under of the Comprehensive Employment and Training Act of 1973), and the first establishment of a federal faith-based office by President Bill Clinton as part of the United States Office of Housing and Urban Development.¹²

Community Development Corporations developed as extensions of congregational ministry, enabling churches to form partnerships with the public and private sectors to attract funding and other resources that could not be moved to or maintained within budgets of explicitly religious organizations such as congregations. It gave congregations capacity to engage in large-scale housing and economic development opportunities, as well as the delivery of human services that required professional social workers, counselors, and others in the engagement of human need in distressed neighborhoods. It also developed trade associations like the Christian Community Development Association¹³ and financial support from a growing interest on the part of national philanthropic organizations such as the Annie E. Casey Foundation, the Ford Foundation, and Pew Charitable Trusts as well as local philanthropy.¹⁴

However, the community development movement struggled with public policy as a means of social change. Its commitment to social service delivery, reliance on funding sources from powerful institutions, and the social distance between the commuter congregations who operated them and the community people they serviced worked against their being voices of transformation in the realm of policy. In so doing, the movement engaged in speaking truth to power in ways that could shift power structures to benefit those living in the distressed communities they served. This challenge came to be met in the work of the *community organizing movement*, where residents of those communities came together to discern the nature of the problems and challenges they faced and crafted strategies to influence the powerful in the public and private sector to develop and enact policies consistent with historic norms of biblical justice.

Community organizing differed from community development in its intention and form. The latter mobilized resources for service delivery. In many cases congregations whose membership no longer lived in the neighborhood provided services for those that remained. In community organizing, congregations and their members were mobilized as members of the community to discern and discover the social challenges that faced them, and develop coherent strategies of activism. This activism incorporated both the delivery of services and advocacy for policy reform. Supported by national community organizing associations, congregations could mobilize their members for meaningful community change.¹⁵ Interestingly, serious reading of the history of the civil rights movement reveals a serious commitment to organizing strategies as well.¹⁶

One key component to community organizing strategy instructs us as we consider the revival of advocacy ministry: the Black church and public policy in the twenty-first century.

Community organizers argue that successful mobilization around policy issues does not emerge from familiarity with, or the urgency of, policy issues themselves. Rather, the key to mobilizing around public policy is the group's embrace of the issue through experiencing its implications as *their issue*, and *the issue of their neighbors*. Carl Dudley's important work in mobilizing congregations points to this very reality. In his research among socially engaged congregations, he discovered that preaching or teaching "an issue" did not motivate congregations to action so much as seeing the issue's impact on members and friends of the congregation.¹⁷

Similarly, the effort to develop congregation-based ministries around juvenile justice, incarceration, and prisoner reentry coalesced in the late 1990s as congregations in cities such as Boston, Philadelphia, Los Angeles, Cleveland, and Brooklyn began making direct contact with gang members, youth and young adults in prison and their families. Often, they discovered that, though they did not know many of these young people personally, through family connections, they were no more than two or three degrees of separation from a local church.¹⁸ In each case, juvenile justice reform advocacy emerged from the efforts of service delivery.

Community organizing's ability to move from "private trial" to "public issue" frames our shift to a look ahead. Its holistic understanding of service delivery and advocacy, empowerment of community residents to identify and address their own issues, and reappropriation of biblical notions of community and justice provides context for identifying comprehensive means of contemporary public engagement—and to do so in a manner sensitive to current theological trends in African American churches.

Prospect

The singular prophetic voice—the "voice crying in the wilderness"—betrays a caricature of prophetic public activity and a historical ignorance bred of hagiography. The caricature stems from an inadequate reading of the Hebrew Scriptures that isolates the activities of individual prophets from their social context and community membership. Though clearly at odds with the status quo, prophetic voices had their followings, schools of the prophets practiced their activity, and prophetic discipleship bred new generations of prophetic activity. The historical ignorance overlooks the immense and detailed organizing strategies undergirding the movements for which prophets such as Martin Luther King, Jr. came to speak and symbolize. The historic voices of the African American church who spoke truth to power and policy had organizing apparatus including the field workers of SCLC and SNCC, the benevolence society supporting Richard Allen, or the newspaper distribution networks of Frederick Douglass. To focus on the voice apart from the support system is to risk emulating prophetic speech without a sounding board.

The malaise of the lone voice finds further complication in the fact that the profound voice of the civil rights movement spoke as a staff minister in a congregation that gave him a freedom not due to many pastors especially to offer support to the prophetic vision with appropriate infrastructure and voice it beyond the Sunday sermon. Even King recognized the limitations of attempting to embrace the prophet's full public mantle while handling the basic expectations of congregational life when he left Montgomery for Atlanta in 1960.

However, not just structure and image, but culture confounds the struggle for public engagement in the contemporary African American church. The well-documented rise of the megachurch rightly diagnoses a cultural captivity to individualistic notions of trial and problem, eschewing systematic redress as a whole. Jonathan Walton, Shayne Lee, Milmon Harrison, and others note how there lies a deeper philosophical vein of individualism and self-interest beneath the exterior of consumerism and materialism in prosperity gospel preaching.

Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs's groundbreaking treatment of Black megachurches reveals a service first mentality, with secondary attention given in these congregations to policy change and advocacy.¹⁹ A culture that sustains the level of self-interest that characterizes post-modern America, and its African American adherents, works against systemic change by its very nature.

Walton's excellent chapter on Reverend Ike as the "father" of contemporary prosperity preaching, and his ability to trace Reverend Ike's philosophy through to contemporary prosperity preaching raises a cultural and systemic question: how did a theology characterized as marginal at best, and cartoonish at worst, move to a more centrist position within a matter of a generation? I offer here that the plausibility structures sustaining an individualistic gospel in the contemporary era did not exist in 1960s Black America when the communal dimension of self-identity allowed people to come together for community and social change. The corporate dimension of historic racism that clearly identified individuals as oppressed by virtue of skin color (and had institutional structures to match) gave way to a selected upward mobility that appealed to large numbers of African Americans with little or no actual memory of, and often little experience with, the conditions that gave birth to the civil rights movement. Similarly, the prevalence of consumerist culture and market choice gave way to a theology where individuals had the freedom to pursue success in spite of obstacles, rather than seeking to transform the obstacles themselves. This rise in individualistic understandings of Christianity predates the indictments of the Black church for losing its prophetic voice by cooperating with conservative politicians in the era of faith-based initiatives. Such an indictment would require an African American Christianity engaged in prophetic witness and public policy prior to the election of George W. Bush in 2000.

The hegemony of a culture of individualism not only shapes public engagement by reducing public issues to personal trials, it also wrests biblical texts from their communal context and reinterprets them in light of self-interest. Biblical mandates to be enacted in and for community become prescriptions for individual victory over trouble both personal and public. The building of the church as the body of Christ becomes subsumed to constructing an aggregate of individual success stories "proving" the "favor of God" amidst oppressive social circumstances, but with no norms for systemic address.

Consider, for example, the parallel move of prosperity congregations into a neo-Pentecostal (now called "full gospel") adaptation of the gifts of the spirit. Though the Pauline admonition in I Corinthians 12 clearly points to a communal benefit and context (and if one misses it there, the corporate dimension has clear ascendancy in Chapter 13 in his exposition of agape love), the corporate dimensions of the gifts seldom receive as much attention as do their benefits for the individual believer. Interestingly, each of the gifts also has implications for public theology that should frame our thinking about systemic oppression and public policy.

Wisdom, Knowledge, and Education Reform

The gifts of wisdom and knowledge both involve the supernatural bestowal of information and insight, based on the Divine Agency of God. The spirit gives them for the profit of all (I Corinthians 12: 6, 8). This takes supernatural insight beyond the bounds of knowing what to do per personal success; rather, the aim is a communal benefit. How does this information benefit the group? Is this a fair question to ask of any divinely imparted information or insight?

Additionally, the source and direction of information and insight critiques public conventions concerning the delivery of information and insight in contemporary America. Because God gives as God wills, God does not circumscribe knowledge and wisdom to social location, as does American society. If so, God would give the "best" information to those who can afford the tuition or at least live in a municipality whose tax base is sufficient to provide the maximum per pupil expenditure for public education.

Therefore, if the gifts of wisdom and knowledge come from God without respect for social location, why should any human system that ties education to social location be considered just? Church leadership that is serious about education must not simply provide tutoring to compensate for systemic imbalance, it must search for ways to deliver wisdom and knowledge as God does without regard to social location. This requires a vivid imagination and willingness to consider a variety of educational options from vouchers for school choice, to charter schools, to the reform of funding allocation streams for public schools, to adjustment for teacher compensation. African American Christian reaction for and against the “No Child Left Behind” Act and the charter school movement demonstrates that energy can be generated over education reform. If it is God’s will to bring the gifts of knowledge and wisdom, information and insight, to strengthen the body corporate, then Black church efforts must ask what that would look like in the public square.

Healing and Health-Care Reform

We follow much the same logic in considering the gift of healing. First, there seems to be much more popular discourse within the church on individuals “walking in divine healing” than manifesting the gift of healing for the benefit of others. Could it be that there lurks an implicit “not you” in the singing of “What God has for me, is for me?” Jesus’s healing ministry reflected a communal context in his healing of others as family members, for example, Peter’s mother-in-law, Jairus’s daughter, and dramatically, the son of the widow at Nain. That latter healing, actually a resurrection, culminates with Jesus returning the young man to his mother, thereby bringing economic benefit to the household. It is not healing for healing’s sake although that would be a miracle nonetheless, but the glory of God comes in the restoration of a family and their economic opportunity.

The healing of the man with the withered hand also contains a powerful community component. In an era where the fastest growing population among the disabled in America is young Black men, it is instructive to note that Jesus brings the candidate for healing into the center of the community to affect the miracle. Moreover, Jesus requires the man to activate his human agency in the command to “stretch forth your hand,” refusing to equate physical disability with mental incompetence. The context for healing here is in community and recognition of the agency and dignity of the one healed. The implications for health-care reform in America are startling. If the integrity of the afflicted and the communal context within which they receive healing is clear in Jesus’s healing, then should not the same ethic be required for the just delivery of health-care services?

Second, returning to the theo-logic of the gifts of wisdom and knowledge, should not healing and the delivery of health-care services similarly be disengaged from social location? Health care dependent upon socioeconomic status flies in the face of the free gift of God for integrity and community. Protecting the economic interests of those whom the church would consider to be “tools in the hands of the Master Surgeon” (at least that is what we pray when someone faces hospitalization) should not supersede the values of community and integrity in healing. The development of health ministries by such denominations as the Church of God in Christ reflects such integrity. So does African American support for the Affordable Care Act.

Critically, we must note that any public engagement of policies that impact the economics of health care cannot be treated as if the evil were “out there” in the system apart from our own benefit. Many African American congregants have heavy investments in the current system through their pension plans, endowments in their schools and colleges, personal stock portfolios, and other corporate enterprises that might currently be expected to maximize personal gain if the central philosophy is personal success and victory. It may cost some pension dollars to bring the young men in wheelchairs back into community.

Discernment and Criminal Justice Reform

The gift of discerning of spirits calls the church to see the depth of spiritual evil as well as the presence of spiritual good. Walter Wink's call for naming the powers²⁰ contains as much urgency for the contemporary African American church as it did the whole of the church four decades ago. Indeed, given the renewed interest in Pentecostal spirituality and spiritual gifts, African American churches may be in a better position here relative to Wink et al. than when his writings first appeared. The challenge, again, is to not limit the gift to individual utility, and allow them to address the larger good. Because we will close with the argument that discernment of spirits impacts the whole of policy engagement, our consideration of criminal justice as a purview of public advocacy receives more attention below.

When we consider the criminal justice system in the United States, we can discern the presence of the principalities and powers in the rigid system of supervision and sentencing and disproportionate numbers of contact and confinement. By the end of 2013, over 1.5 million people were held in federal or state prisons, with an additional 731,000 in local jails. Another 4.5 million individuals were under community supervision—probation or parole.²¹ These numbers are exacerbated when we consider that there were 4,777 Black male inmates per 100,000 Black males held in state and federal prisons and local jails as recently as 2008.

The United States incarcerates its citizens at a rate higher than any country in the world. The Pew Center analysis of the data indicates that for African Americans, the numbers reflect an even more daunting situation. One in 15 African American males over 18 is behind bars as opposed to one out of 36 for Latinos and one out of 106 for white males. In addition, the Center reported that one out of nine African American males between the ages of 25 and 34 is behind bars.²² In addition, the US Department of Justice states that approximately 650,000 men and women are released from state and federal prison annually. They come home to neighborhoods that often suffer from lack of social capital, the capacity to develop and maintain strong relationships and networks of personal support.

As Jesus and the Apostles spoke to the spirits and cast them out, so too must African American churches speak. By engaging the families in their own congregations and communities, they can hear the cries of those affected by crime and incarceration. By providing ministries of care, counsel, and support, they, as Dudley and the organizers have argued, discover the stories of those tormented by the evil, and then develop the methods to speak right to the demonic forces controlling the lives of so many African American inmates and families alike. It is not just the harsh conditions of incarceration, rather it is a whole system that rushes to incarcerate, punishes through incarceration, and minimizes success upon release from incarceration.

What can the church say to the powers in the name of the One who came to destroy the works of the devil? The church can address the need for alternative sentencing; the reform of prison conditions; the provision of programs such as education, life skills, and drug and alcohol treatment for the incarcerated; and the reform of collateral sanctions that continue an individual's punishment after incarceration through the limitation of housing, job, and educational opportunities.²³ Churches can become familiar with policies that oppress, discerning the evil, and then join with the forces of reform, discerning the good. Efforts such as the federal Second Chance Act of 2007 and the work of the Sentencing Project represent a movement toward change and justice.²⁴ But discovering these moves of God requires a commitment to active discernment rather than passive reaction. Understanding the role of churches in public activism requires that the church prayerfully seeks its issues and mandate from God and among God's people rather than waiting for the latest media induced popular issue, lest the involvement of churches be subject to the changing interests of an information industry motivated by what sells.

In a real sense, discernment becomes the key to all public policy work, in that the principalities and powers control all the systems, education, health care, criminal justice, etcetera. The revival of Pentecostal spirituality, combined with the historic witness of service provision and prophetic advocacy, opens new opportunities for African American congregations to “go deep” in their analysis of contemporary forms of oppression and speak boldly and strategically concerning their transformation. Such transformation will be reflected in the deliverance (another rediscovery in neo-Pentecostal spirituality) of God’s people and communities from the demonic forces that oppress them. It is an opportunity of churches to embody afresh its Christocentric mission to declare to those systems: “The Spirit of the Lord is upon Me, for He has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor, the recovery of sight to the blind, to set at liberty them that are bruised, to proclaim the acceptable year of the Lord.” (Luke 4:16–18).

Notes

1. Jonathan Walton does an excellent job of chronicling this development in *Watch This! The Ethics and Aesthetics of Black Televangelism* (New York: New York University Press, 2009), especially Chapter 8 entitled “Lift Ev’ry Voice.”
2. See Peter Paris, *The Social Teaching of the Black Churches* (Minneapolis: Augsburg/Fortress Press, 2009).
3. Drew Smith’s edited trilogy, *New Day Begun: African American Churches and Civic Culture in Post-Civil Rights America*; *Black Churches and Local Politics: Clergy Influence, Organizational Partnerships, and Civic Empowerment* (with Frederick Harris); and *Long March Ahead: African American Churches and Public Policy in Post-Civil Rights America* (*Public Influences of African American Churches*), gives a good solid overview to the subject in historical, ethical, and sociological terms. Published by Duke University Press in 2003, 2005, and 2007 respectively, these volumes were part of the Public Influence of Black Churches project, housed at the Morehouse College Leadership Center, and funded by the Pew Charitable Trusts.
4. Tunde Adeleke’s “Afro-Americans and Moral Suasion: The Debate in the 1830’s,” *The Journal of Negro History* Vol. 83, no. 2 (Spring, 1998), 127–142 focuses, as does much of the literature on the subject, on the abolitionist movement. However, the seeds of the strategy—as he acknowledges—predate William Lloyd Garrison and his abolitionist activities.
5. Paul Griffin’s *Black Theology as the Foundation of Three Methodist Colleges: The Educational Views and Labors of Daniel Payne, Joseph Price, Isaac Lane* (Lanham, MD: University Press of America, 1984) illustrates the case well. The late Alfred M. Waller, at the time of his death in 1987, was expanding this view in looking at the relationship between religion and science in these schools’ curricula.
6. In Gayraud Wilmore’s *Black Religion and Black Radicalism: An Interpretation of the Religious History of African Americans*, which Orbis Press issued in its third edition in 1998, this bifurcation receives specific attention in the chapters 7 and 8.
7. Haynes also saw the relationship between religious faith and public engagement, writing the chapter “Organizations and Agencies” for William Stuart Nelson’s edited volume *The Christian Way in Race Relations* (New York: Harper and Brothers, 1948).
8. Genna Rae McNeil’s, *Groundwork: Charles Hamilton Houston and the Struggle for Civil Rights* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1983) remains the standard Houston biography.
9. See Nina Mjagkij’s *Light in the Darkness: African Americans in the YMCA 1852–1946* (University of Kentucky Press, 2003) and her edited volume, *Organizing Black America: An Encyclopedia of African American Organizations* (New York: Garland Publishing, 2001) where this link appears regularly. My own work in New Jersey Black History confirms this in “A Bright Side Somewhere: African Americans and Migration in New Jersey: Some Preliminary Observations,” in *Journal of the Afro-American Historical and Genealogical Society* (Washington, DC, 1985).
10. The 2004 PBS documentary “Black White and Brown” aired on the occasion of the 50th Anniversary of the decision rehearses the words of participants in the case.

11. Peter Paris, *Black Religious Leaders: Conflict in Unity* (Louisville, Kentucky: Westminster/John Knox, 1992), Barbara Savage, *Your Spirits Walk Beside Us: The Politics of Black Religion* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2008), and Rosetta Ross, *Witnessing and Testifying: Black Women, Religion, and Civil Rights* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2003) all go to great lengths to show the diversity of strategies of African American public engagement, and the specifically the relationship between moral suasion and organizing.
12. John DiIulio's *Godly Republic: A Centrist Blueprint for America's Faith Based Future* (Oakland, CA: University of California Press, 2008) provides an interesting retrospect and prospect. DiIulio rehearses much of the history as a scholar who helped shape the 2001 establishment of the White House Office of Faith-Based and Community Initiatives, and material published in his book significantly informed the content of Barack Obama's 2008 presidential platform with respect to the continuance of that office as well.
13. John Perkins, *Restoring At-Risk Communities: Doing it Together and Doing it Right* (Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 1995) both documents the work of CCDA, and provides a blueprint for their vision for community development.
14. Harold Dean Trulear, "Philanthropy and Religion," in Rodney Jackson, ed., *A Philanthropic Covenant with Black America* (Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley Press, 2009), 19–52.
15. In his book, *Faith in Action: Religion, Race, and Democratic Organizing in America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2002), Richard Wood concentrates primarily on the work at PICO (Pacific Institute for Community Organization). However, the history is consistent with the work of the other organizations as well.
16. The records of these and others organizing at the local level can be found in "Records of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference 1954–1970: Part 3," available online at www.lexisnexis.com/documents/academic/upa_cls/1567_recssouthchrleadconfpt3.pdf. Also see Ross, *Witnessing and Testifying*, especially chapters 2 and 3. See also Aldon Morris' *Origins of the Civil Rights Movement: Black Communities Organizing for Change* (New York: Free Press, 1986) for an emphasis upon the local organizing component of the movement, especially the students labor.
17. See his book coauthored with Sally Johnson, *Energizing the Congregation: Images that Shape Your Church's Ministry* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1993).
18. Harold Dean Trulear, *Faith Based Institutions and High Risk Youth: First Report from the Field* (Philadelphia: Public/Private Ventures, 2000). See a full treatment of one such organization in Donald E. Miller and Timothy Sato's *Los Angeles Metropolitan Churches: Organizing to Create Change* (Los Angeles: University of Southern California Center for Religion and Civic Culture, 1999).
19. See Walton, *Watch This!*, op. cit. Milmon Harrison *Righteous Riches: The Word of Faith Movement in Contemporary African American Religion* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), Shayne Lee, *T. D. Jakes: America's New Preacher* (New York: New York University Press, 2007), Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs, *The Black Megachurch: Theology, Gender, and the Politics of Public Engagement* (Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 2012).
20. Walter Wink, *Naming the Powers*.
21. "Correctional Populations in the United States 2013," <http://www.bjs.gov/index.cfm?ty=pbdetail&iid=5177>
22. "One in 100: Behind Bars in America 2008," Pew Center on the States, February 2008.
23. See *What Shall We then Do?*, a manual for congregations addressing both the service delivery needs, and public activism required in ministry to persons affected by crime and incarceration. Compiled by a team of leaders from the Progressive National Baptist Convention and the Annie E. Casey Foundation, it is available at www.healingcommunitiesusa.com/resources.
24. The Second Chance Act is federal legislation passed in 2007 expanding appropriations for criminal justice systems and community organizations to provide additional supports for persons returning from incarceration. The Sentencing Project is an advocacy organization for justice and fairness in sentencing (www.sentencingproject.org).

Black Megachurches and the Paradox of Black Progress

Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs

On a typical Sunday morning in Houston, Pastor Ira V. Hilliard travels from one end of town to the other by helicopter to deliver sermons at two church locations. The church he leads, New Light Christian Center Church, has twin locations—one on the North side, the other on the South side. At Reid Temple AME Church in Glendale, Maryland, the parking lot is staffed by attendants who carefully escort you in and out of the lot. As you park, you are welcomed to walk to one of the shuttle stops, where one of several shuttle buses comes to carry people to the building. If you can't make it to the First Baptist Church of Glenarden (FBCG) in suburban Maryland, you can experience the service virtually via its website. You can watch the sermon, send in a prayer request, donate tithes and offerings, and accept Jesus as Lord and Savior—all online. Helicopters, shuttle buses, and Internet streaming—these are definitely new ways of doing church!¹

New Light Christian Center, Reid Temple, and First Baptist Church of Glenarden are all Black megachurches (predominantly Black churches with at least 2000 people who attend Sunday services). Over the past 30 years, there has been an explosion of these churches in both central cities and suburban areas across the United States. This social and ecclesiastical phenomenon is arguably the most exciting “Black church” development to occur in the post-civil rights era. While large churches did exist 30 years ago, they did not exist with the frequency found today. In fact, the Black megachurch phenomenon is one of the many offspring of the civil rights movement. Their grandiose physical structures alone are a testimony to the aggregation of material resources that have only been possible in post-civil rights America.

Black megachurches are not the only sign of post-civil rights Black prosperity. Since the end of Jim Crow segregation, we have witnessed an expanded Black middle class, an increase in Black college enrollment, an explosion in the numbers of Black elected officials, and even a Black president of the United States. But even with all of these signs of progress, racial disparities in health, housing, education, employment, incarceration, household income, mortality, and more persist and parallel pre-civil rights disparities. Furthermore there are widening intraracial gaps among the African American middle class, the working poor, and the so-called “underclass.” In recent years, as the economy has worsened, the post-civil rights Black middle class has been the first demographic group to slip out of middle-class status (Fletcher). This all indicates that while in some areas Black America has made incredible strides in the post-civil rights era, in others, little progress is evident.

Interestingly, in addition to reflecting the gains that came with the end of Jim Crow segregation, Black megachurches also reflect some of the diverse philosophies and strategies that Black churches employ to engage in public life to address the “paradox of Black progress.” Black megachurches reflect the fruits of the civil rights movement but also reflect the different philosophies about how Black churches should address the post-civil rights challenges that remain. These churches are participating in a very active discourse about the contemporary role of Black churches in public life.

Fruit of the Civil Rights Movement

While there have been a number of transformative movements within the Black church, the Black megachurch phenomenon is most comparable to the explosion of storefront churches during the twentieth century. In the early twentieth century, storefront churches began to proliferate throughout urban America due to the African American Great Migration and the resulting demographic shifts in African American northern communities. The Black migrants moved from the rural South to escape the racial apartheid and to find better opportunities for employment, education, housing, and life chances more generally.

Storefront churches (so named because they were commercial buildings, appropriated for religious use, that were cheap and plentiful) filled the social and religious needs of the numerous Black migrants. When Drake and Cayton did their famous study of Chicago, *Black Metropolis*, they were struck by the number of storefront churches that dotted Chicago. They found that in the 1930s 75 percent of the Black churches in Chicago were storefronts (Drake and Cayton, 437). To many of the Black urban migrants the storefront church brought a sense of home by providing worship services that were “traditional, emotional, and intimate.” Robert Boyd has argued that unlike the mainline Baptist and Methodist denominations that were colder and more distant, Black storefront churches made the North a little warmer (Boyd). These churches felt a little more like “home.” Storefront churches also fulfilled the need for a *greater number* of churches to accommodate the growing Black populations in these cities and often provided much needed social services and information about employment to their members (Boyd).

Like the storefront church phenomenon Black megachurches are also the result of an extensive Black migration—the 1980s and 1990s suburbanization of much of Black America. During the 1980s and 1990s the African American population declined in urban areas but increased in suburbia. In fact during this time period the African American suburban population doubled from 6 million to 12 million (Wiese).

Black suburban migration is not only a geographical shift, but also reflects a “class migration”—an expanded Black middle class that is clearly the result of the opening of society. This wave of suburbanization was fueled by the post-civil rights decline in restrictions on housing, increased opportunities for education, and better paying jobs. It is a result of the gains of the civil rights movement and is a manifestation of class upward mobility.

The 1980s–1990s Black suburbanization created transplants from within the central cities or from other places to the suburbs of cities like Washington, DC and Atlanta, Georgia. Just like the storefront church met the needs of the transplanted southern migrants that the established mainline Black churches in the north were not meeting, Black megachurch growth is driven by these newer migrants’ demands for a religious experience that is accessible, enthusiastic, professional, and relevant to the here and now. Accordingly, Black megachurches provide a variety of ministries that help their members to make their new communities “places of their own” (Wiese, 209–54). Whether they develop independent Christian schools or sponsor health seminars, financial workshops, or trips to Africa, each of these churches provides bundles of services and opportunities for their members to engage in civil society. Consequently at least 149 Black

megachurches have developed in metropolitan areas where these transplanted suburbanites are concentrated. Not all Black megachurches are located in the suburbs. In fact about half of them are actually located in central cities. However, megachurches are “commuter churches” and those located in the central cities draw a significant proportion of their members from the surrounding suburbs.

While their founding dates vary (about 50 percent were founded before 1950), over 90 percent of Black megachurches report that they reached megachurch attendance numbers after 1980. Metropolitan areas such as Washington, DC, Atlanta, Houston, New York City, and Los Angeles are all among the ten metropolitan areas with the highest numbers of Black suburbanites (Logan). They are also the cities with the largest numbers of Black megachurches.

Black megachurches are accessible to the suburban migrants. They are open, welcoming, and convenient. They are what Omar McRoberts calls “particularistic spaces” (McRoberts). They are differentiated by the bundles of services and opportunities they offer, their ministries, their reputations, their architectural designs, and their theological orientations as well as their public engagement activities. This particularism operates like a brand and draws people to the church. In one metropolitan area there might coexist the Afrocentric church, the social justice/civil rights church, the psychological/self-help church, the political church, the hip-hop church, the socially conservative evangelical church, and the prosperity church—each of them with megamemberships. The high profiles of these churches, combined with their active evangelizing and their “brand-like” particularism, draws thousands to the Black megachurch week after week.

General Characteristics

Black megachurches are physical marvels with their enormous campuses and sanctuaries that seat several thousand worshippers. While the megachurch baseline definition is at 2,000 people who attend each week (and most of them average 2,000–3,000 per week), a few Black megachurches welcome over 10,000 people each week and count up to 25,000 members.

Interestingly, the style of edifice to accommodate these thousands of worshippers varies from heavily adorned and opulent state-of-the-art facilities to the “big box” churches housed in former warehouses or former big box stores, like K-Mart. These “big boxes” are transformed and appropriated for religious purposes (like the storefront churches mentioned earlier). A number of Black megachurches are housed in traditional-looking church buildings (complete with a church steeple) but with megachurch attendance numbers. Some Black megachurches boast of recording studios, fitness centers, game rooms, bookstores, and bowling alleys. Beyond the edifice itself, Black megachurches are further characterized by multiple ministries that organize the many different “spiritual” and temporal functions of the church. These include the more traditional ministries like missionaries, ushers, and choir, but also cover anything from finances, to relationships, to international travel (Tucker-Worgs).

Philosophical Fissures

An examination of the metropolitan areas where these churches are located shows that even as suburbanization is a sign of upward mobility, it is not evidence that Black/white disparities have disappeared. For example, in Atlanta (which rivals Washington, DC, for the highest concentration of Black megachurches and Black suburbanites), extreme Black/white disparities persist. In Atlanta 33.9 percent of Blacks earn incomes below the poverty level compared to 7.6 percent of whites (Atlanta, Georgia, Poverty Rate Data). In Washington, DC, the pattern is the same. While 7 percent of whites earn incomes below the poverty line, 26.8 percent of Blacks earn

below poverty-level incomes (Washington, DC, Poverty Rate Data). In Houston (another metro area with a high concentration of Black megachurches), 25 percent of Blacks earn incomes below the poverty line compared to 7 percent of whites (Houston, Texas, Poverty Rate Data). In the suburbs the patterns of disparity remain the same. For example, most Black suburbanites in the Atlanta metro area live in the inner-ring suburbs where there has been disinvestment in the housing stock and commercial districts. They pay higher taxes and receive fewer services. They have lower rates of home ownership and higher poverty rates (Wiese, African American Suburban Development in Atlanta).

Beyond these Black/white disparities, there are widening intraracial gaps. According to Robert C. Smith, as some Blacks became better off and benefited greatly from the end of Jim Crow segregation, others did not seem to benefit but instead became more “segregated, impoverished and increasingly . . . marginalized, denigrated and criminalized” (Smith, 179).

Thus Black megachurches exist in a context of contradictory trends. They reflect prosperity but also exist alongside persistent problems. How do they navigate these contradictions? Do they seek to address what ails Black communities?

There are a number of strategies and philosophies that Black churches in general use to respond to this “paradox of progress.” For example, churches with an “otherworldly” orientation might not respond at all, as their focus is the afterlife—where temporal issues are not their concern. Those with a “prophetic” social gospel orientation would focus on a traditional “social justice” agenda—promoting the liberation of the poor and downtrodden of society—or in the words of Howard Thurman, “the man whose back is against the wall.” For churches that do respond to the paradox of progress, they have a number of strategies from which to choose. Some of them become involved in electoral politics, others in community development, or still others in protest politics. Some of them cooperate with government to provide social services. Others engage in economic development. A growing number of them politically mobilize around a rededication of “family values” and a socially conservative morality. Many of them use some combination of these strategies and philosophies.

Often there is a presumption that Black megachurches do not really engage in public life in ways that would respond to social and economic challenges that Black communities face. The presumption is that Black megachurches only worry about making the ministers rich and/or increasing the financial wealth of their members and that they do not really embrace a social mission. My research on the Black megachurch shows however that as a group they tend to be heavily involved in public life. For example, 91 percent distribute food on a regular basis and 78 percent distribute clothing. About 77 percent are in voter registration and education, and 68 percent of them have participated in some type of organized social issue advocacy. Forty three percent have built or renovated affordable housing and 28 percent have a church credit union. Interestingly, over 50 percent of Black megachurches have established a nonprofit community development organization (CDO) that they use as a vehicle to do much of this public engagement. Clearly as a group they are publically engaged (Tucker-Worgs).

While as a group, Black megachurches are generally publically engaged, only a subset of churches participate in the activities mentioned above. Many of them have programs and ministries that target the challenges that Black communities still face, but others don’t make such attempts. The variation on these lines is a result of the variation in their theological orientation.

Theological Orientation and Public Engagement

Black megachurch public engagement varies by their *theological orientations* (or the churches’ sets of basic underlying theological tenets). Their theological orientations serve as the motives to their public engagement. A particular church’s theological orientation is revealed by the answers to the key questions: “Who is God?”, “Is God near or far?”, and especially—“What is the

role of the church in the world?” and “What are human beings’ responsibilities to one another?” (Schreiter). The position that churches take in response to these questions determines how they “make the Word flesh” and participate in public life.

A clear example of a Black megachurch’s theological orientation having direct connections to its public engagement activities is First AME Church (FAME) in Los Angeles. FAME Church’s mission statement reads,

First AME Church exists to embody Christ both WITHIN THE WALLS and BEYOND THE WALLS by equipping all people regardless of race or origin—spiritually, economically, politically, and morally—making the Word become flesh through tools in education, health, housing, feeding, job procurement, business and incubator loans, venture capital, transportation, adoptions, mentoring and other ministries of outreach.

Given this mission, it is no surprise that FAME church has a very active social justice and community development agenda. They have a business resource center, entrepreneurial training, a free legal clinic, job placement, an equity fund to invest in small minority-owned businesses, and many more ministries pursuant to their calling to “embody Christ” and “make the Word flesh” (Tucker-Worgs).

A number of theological orientations are evident in Black megachurches. These varied theological orientations encourage different levels and types of public engagement. In the following pages I will explore several of the theological orientations that are found in Black megachurches and illustrate how they encourage or discourage public engagement that addresses the paradox of Black progress.

The Prosperity Gospel

Perhaps the most controversial theological orientation is the “prosperity gospel.” Advocates of this theology preach that God *wants* his followers to be prosperous (particularly financially), the faithful *will be* prosperous, and believers *can be* prosperous by transforming their behaviors and beliefs. In order to unlock their prosperity, believers need to “know who they are in Christ” and “name it and claim it” (what they want) (Harrison, 9, 11). A number of Black megachurches promote the prosperity gospel. They “name it” and “claim it” through financial faith confessions. Often they have ministries that relate to prosperity teachings—like “millionaires ministries.” Their pastors write books explicating prosperity theology, often specifically applying it to racial disparities. For example, in his book, *Breaking the Spirit of Poverty: Six Steps to take you from Poverty to Prosperity*, Pastor Ed Montgomery of Abundant Life Cathedral in Houston writes that he has “good news for poor pews.” The good news is that African Americans have control over their circumstances. The reason that they are disproportionately among the poor is because they “accept the circumstances of home evictions, unemployment, debt,” and so on. But poverty is not merely “the lack of money.” “Poverty is a spirit.” It is an affliction. Therefore, by obeying the commands that God sets forth for the righteous and *having faith that they are supposed to be prosperous* and not poor they can break this spirit. They too can live the prosperous life (Montgomery).

For the prosperity gospel the root causes of suffering, poverty, and racial disparities are the individuals’ (who are poor and suffering) lack of faith and understanding of their own potential. In support of this view Christ Universal Temple’s (Chicago) mission statement reads,

We believe that, rather than devoting our primary efforts to providing for the needy of the world, the time has come to make available to all people everywhere a teaching that will enable them to provide for themselves by learning to release the divine potential within them.

(Tucker-Worgs)

According to the prosperity gospel the end of suffering lies with the individual. Personal transformation is what leads to a materially prosperous life. Those who promote this theology see the economic system of capitalism as basically fair. Those who suffer from economic poverty are poor because they are afflicted with mental and spiritual poverty and lack faith. In other words, the system is fine. All that is needed is for individuals to first change their thinking, increase their faith, and name and claim their prosperity. Churches that promote the prosperity gospel as their dominant theology focus on the insular and individual needs of their congregations, and shy away from addressing issues in a communal or systemic fashion. This theological orientation, while “thisworldly,” discourages a constructive response to the systematic suffering of Black people. Thus, the prosperity gospel suppresses most public engagement that would address the paradox of Black progress.

The Social Gospel

In contrast to the prosperity gospel, there are a number of Black megachurches that advocate the “social gospel.” Another “thisworldly” orientation, the social gospel promotes the idea that Jesus teaches his followers to be champions for those who are at the bottom of the socioeconomic hierarchy, as he was. The social gospel tradition takes it as a given that there is social inequality and injustice in society and that the church should be involved in addressing these inequities and injustice. For the social gospel the root causes for suffering are systemic and are not evidence of the individuals’ lack of faith or good works. Promoters of the social gospel believe that it is the responsibility of the church to address systemic inequality, and public engagement is a way to do this. Thus the social gospel leads to greater public engagement. FAME church, described earlier, is a good example of a church that leans toward the social gospel as their dominant theological orientation.

Black Liberation Theology

Another theological orientation found in Black megachurches is Black liberation theology. It is evident in the worship styles, symbols, décor, traditions, and rituals of many Black megachurches. There are several Black megachurches that promote Black liberation theology.

At its core, Black liberation theology relates the Christian experience to Black people’s experiences in America—especially within the context of racial oppression and in the struggle for civil and human rights. Theologian James Cone, the author of many of Black liberation theology’s primary works calls it “a religious explication of Black people’s need to define the scope and meaning of Black existence in a racist society” (Cone, 106).

There are important aspects of the “Word of God” that emerge from Black liberation theology. First, Christianity should be interpreted from a “Black perspective” that challenges racism and recognizes an African heritage. Second, Christ is depicted as Black. This is not merely about the skin color of Christ but even more so about Christ’s actions and affinities. The physical appearance of Christ as Black relates to his affinity to the Black freedom struggle. In other words, the Black Christ wants Black people to be free. Finally, Black liberation theology affirms that Christianity is about “liberating the oppressed” and making the world better for “the least of these” (Tucker-Worgs).

Perhaps the most well-known church that promotes Black liberation theology is Trinity United Church of Christ in Chicago (TUCC), Barack Obama’s former church home (which gained political notoriety during the 2008 presidential campaign). Trinity’s motto is “unashamedly Black, unapologetically Christian.” TUCC has a number of ministries that promote a social justice concern for “the least of these” and several ministries exploring the particular relevance of Christianity to people of African descent.

Like the social gospel, Black liberation theology promotes a structural and collective analysis of society and social problems. Accordingly, the church should actively work to end economic, social, and political oppression and seize control of Black communities. Black megachurches that express Black liberation theology as a dominant theology are more likely to engage in a range of activities including building and renovating affordable housing and commercial development, vehicles used to revitalize suffering Black communities.

Nondenominationalism

Whether a Black megachurch is nondenominational or has denominational ties is another important theological cleavage that is related to their public engagement. The denominational affiliation of Black megachurches generally resembles the national trend of Black churches but there are some differences. Most Black megachurches belong to one of the historically Black denominations or conventions, but a significant proportion of them (21 percent) are nondenominational (Tucker-Worgs, 32–33). Regardless of denomination (Baptist, Methodist, Pentecostal, etc.), Black megachurches that have a denominational affiliation have been more likely to participate in public engagement activities than nondenominational churches. For the most part, denominationally affiliated Black megachurches are in either historically Black denominations (which were created in the context of or in response to slavery or racial apartheid) or liberal mainline white denominations (which have legacies of political progressiveness). This makes these churches more likely to participate in public engagement activities. Even if the individual churches were recently established, their connection to these white liberal denominations and historically Black denominations connects them to public engagement traditions.

On the other hand, nondenominational churches do not have access to these denominational traditions and obligations and as a consequence are considerably less likely to participate in public engagement activities that address the “paradox of Black progress.” Instead of the white mainline or historically Black traditions, nondenominational Black megachurches are more likely to identify with the more conservative white evangelical traditions that tend to focus only on personal transformation and exclude structural transformation. So when these churches do participate in public life it is on behalf of issues concerning individual, personal morality. Furthermore, a number of nondenominational Black megachurches identify with the prosperity gospel, which (as stated earlier) also depresses their public engagement.

Black megachurches do not just exhibit one theological orientation and clearly can exhibit multiple theological orientations at the same time (in different combinations). But the more they lean toward Black liberation theology, denominationalism, and/or the social gospel the more likely they are to address the post-civil rights challenges. The more they lean toward nondenominationalism and/or the prosperity gospel, the less likely they are to address these challenges.

Black Megachurch Strategies for Engaging Public Life

When one thinks of the Black church political engagement, often what comes to mind is the protest politics of the civil rights movement, or the electoral politics that was always there but became even more extensive in the post-civil rights era. Today we see examples of civil rights movement-like protest in the Moral Mondays Movement in North Carolina as well as the Black Lives Matter movement in Ferguson, Missouri and cities and towns across the nation. While there are black megachurches that participate in these movements, these churches are in the minority. Protest is not an activity in which most Black megachurches consistently and frequently engage.

One means of responding to the “paradox of Black progress” that Black megachurches do use frequently is to participate in electoral politics. Black megachurches and Black megachurch pastors support candidates, register voters, drive voters to the polls, and encourage voting from the pulpit. They also contribute to the shaping of ideas and political personas for candidates.

For Black megachurches, at no time was electoral participation more evident than the 2008 US presidential campaign and election season. During the heated Democratic primaries, both Hillary Clinton and Barack Obama spoke at Black churches and Black megachurches on the campaign stump. In South Carolina, state senator Daryl Jackson, who is a pastor of a Black megachurch (Bible Way Church of Atlas Road), served as Clinton’s state campaign director, and a member of Jackson’s church, Anton Gunn, was the South Carolina political director for the Obama campaign (Tucker-Worgs).

During the general election, Black megachurch pastors publicly prayed for Obama, endorsed his candidacy, and contributed money to his campaign. Even more interesting was the role that Trinity United Church of Christ, and the former pastor there, Rev. Jeremiah Wright, had in helping to shape Barack Obama’s political persona. In his autobiography, *Dreams from my Father*, Barack Obama describes how his political persona was influenced by the Black church in general, and TUCC in particular. He said that he admired the Black church’s “power to spur social change.” When Obama recalls how he was drawn to TUCC he describes a sermon that Reverend Jeremiah Wright preached, called “The Audacity to Hope” that inspired the title for his book on his political philosophy called *The Audacity of Hope*. “Hope” along with “Change” became sort of a political mantra for Obama during his 2008 campaign for president (Obama). Obama’s description of why he loved *the Black church* does not apply to all Black churches, but rather to a specific type of church: a politically engaged, prophetic, social gospel-oriented Black church (like TUCC)—one that would respond directly to the social and economic disparities that Black communities face.

Even more intriguing than their participation in electoral politics are the nontraditional ways that Black megachurches are engaging in public life. One recent development is the increasing use of the community development model (as opposed to protest politics or electoral politics) as the primary strategy for meeting the post-civil rights challenges. Another new development is employing the “Black moral pathology” thesis as an explanation for post-civil rights disparities and mobilizing politically around a “moral pathology” agenda. An examination of Black megachurches shows that both community development and moral politics are used to answer the “paradox of Black progress.” Black megachurches are not the only Black churches that use these strategies but because of their high-profile status they do apply loud voices to the discourse. The following section will explore these two forms of public engagement and Black megachurch participation in them.

Community Development

A surprising proportion of Black megachurches seek to address the paradox of Black progress through what is broadly termed “community development.” The community development approach is distinct from electoral politics, which consists of supporting or participating in elections. It also can be differentiated from protest politics, which refers to political dissent and the application of pressure to the system from outside the electoral sphere. The community development approach consists of the direct production of goods and services and often it entails collaborating with government.

An impressive number of Black megachurches are pursuing this approach. Over 50 percent of them have developed separate nonprofits for community development—what I call

broadly “community development organizations” (CDOs). These CDOs vary in their focus, their clientele, the size of their budgets, and the diversity of their programs. Some of them build housing (like the typical community development corporation or CDC) while others focus on education and mentoring programs. Still others primarily do social service delivery and provide employment services. Some of them focus on a single activity and others are more “holistic” as they do “hard development” like housing and commercial enterprise but also “soft development” like social service provision. Invariably these CDOs are formed to counteract the lingering challenges facing Black communities that, despite the progress of the civil rights movement and post-political incorporation, still exist (Tucker-Worgs).

Examples of Black megachurches utilizing community development abound. Consider, for example, Abyssinian Baptist Church in Harlem. Abyssinian is an interesting case because the pastor, Rev. Calvin Butts, III, has described how he consciously moved from more protest-oriented public engagement to a community development approach. He and others that use community development see it as an effective strategy to deal with issues like urban fiscal stress, crisis in public education, unemployment, concentrated poverty, and the lack of affordable housing and health care—challenges that face Black communities despite the fluid use of protest and electoral politics. Community development makes noticeable and tangible improvements in these communities. Abyssinian Development Corporation (Abyssinian’s CDO) has renovated multiple units of housing, engaged in commercial development projects and a Head Start program, and they have partnered with the New York Board of Education to help run a public school (Tucker-Worgs).

Another example of a Black megachurch that actively uses the community development approach is Windsor Village United Methodist Church in Houston. Windsor Village has partnered with government to build hundreds of affordable single-family homes in the Hiram Clarke area of Houston. They also developed the Power Center, a business park that houses one of the few commercial banks in the area, an independent school, a Women, Infants, and Children Nutrition Program (WIC) office, a banquet and reception hall, a health clinic, and other small businesses. They have also partnered with the city to build and support a public elementary school (which was named after the pastor’s mother), and partnered with the YMCA to build a local YMCA branch that houses the only community swimming pool in the area (Tucker-Worgs).

It is important to note that not all Black megachurch “community development” is done utilizing the CDO—a good deal of it is done just through the church itself (even if the church has a CDO). Community development organizations, however, do make it easier for churches to partner with government (and other partners) and therefore have access to government grants and other resources. In addition to enabling the churches to attract outside funding for their community development work, CDOs serve as symbols to potential partners and the broader community that the church is an “activist” church—one that is committed to community development and addressing social problems.

The community development approach is an important part of the repertoire of Black megachurch strategies used to address the paradox of Black progress. However, this approach is not without its challenges. Community development usually requires seeking government grants. This means that church leaders are sometimes reluctant to speak out against government actions or politicians if they feel it may put their funding in jeopardy (even if the government is taking action that the church leaders feel is detrimental to their communities). The church leaders’ concerns are not unfounded. There are cases where churches spoke out against local governments and were sanctioned as a consequence (funding was pulled or some other sanction). Still, most Black megachurches are not deterred by this prospect.² Community development is becoming so common an approach that it often seems to supersede other forms of public engagement.

The Politics of Black Moral Pathology

Perhaps the most intriguing form of Black megachurch public engagement centers on a “moral politics” that has emerged in the twenty-first century. To begin with, this moral politics grows out of a “Black moral pathology thesis.” According to this interpretation of recent history, Black people’s own poor moral behavior and attitudes are the cause for post-civil rights racial disparities, and therefore improving Black people’s morality (not primarily systemic reform or community development) will lead to better life chances for Black people in the post-civil rights era. Bishop Eddie Long of New Birth Baptist Church in Atlanta is one of the best examples of someone who has promoted this view.³ As described by Jonathan Walton, Long sees racial disparities persisting because Blacks are *preoccupied* with racism and America’s racial past instead of *actual* racism in the present. Black people simply need to “forgive and forget” and realize that they are “already in the Promised Land” (Walton). According to the Black moral pathology thesis, lapsing moral values, diminishing moral fortitude, lack of hard work, and straying away from “traditional values” are the real reasons for contemporary Black suffering. Consequently, correcting these lapsing moral values and “getting over race” are the keys to addressing racial disparities.

The moral pathology thesis fits well within a larger discourse in American politics about the “culture wars”—where there is a profound political cleavage between those who are committed to “traditional values” and those who have more modern views of society (Wald and Calhoun-Brown). While some have argued that the notion of “culture wars” is an oversimplification of American politics (Fiorna), studies have also shown that the “moral agenda” has been an effective mobilizing tool (Wald and Calhoun-Brown). The “culture wars” theory especially dominated public discourse after the 2004 US presidential election when according to the exit polls a plurality of Americans believed that “moral issues” were the most important issues facing the nation (CNN).

In *Obergefell v. Hodges* (June 2015), the Supreme Court ruled that same-sex couples have a right to marry, regardless of where they live. This was the culmination of a very dramatic shift in public policy and public opinion. For example, in 2012, 38 states had statutory or constitutional provisions that defined marriage as between a man and a woman effectively prohibiting same-sex marriage. By 2015 only 14 states prohibited same-sex marriage (National Conference of State Legislatures).

In a number of states, the laws were the result of heated political mobilization on both sides, and a number of Black megachurches and megachurch pastors have been quite vocal in their opposition to same-sex marriage.⁴ Furthermore, several of them have connected their opposition to same-sex marriage to post-civil rights racial disparities. Increasingly this opposition has taken the form of political mobilization as megachurches and megachurch pastors have taken out advertisements in local newspapers, published editorials, given public speeches, formed coalitions of like-minded people, and participated in protest marches to oppose the rights of same-sex people to marry.

One of the best examples of this was the 2004 Reigniting the Legacy March led by Bishop Eddie Long (of New Birth Baptist Church in Atlanta) and Martin Luther King, Jr.’s youngest daughter Rev. Bernice King (formerly a minister at New Birth). This march, rife with civil rights movement symbolism, denounced same-sex marriage and supported the amendment to the Georgia State Constitution that would define marriage as a union between a man and a woman. For some, this socially conservative agenda contradicts the traditional civil rights movement agenda. Long, though, did not see this as contradictory at all, but totally consistent. As noted, Long’s perspective is that Black/white disparities persist because of Black people’s corrupt moral values and Black people’s failure to take advantage of the opportunities that had been given to them. On the eve of the Reigniting the Legacy March, he stated that this was the direction that many Black people thought civil rights activism should take—back to

“basic, fundamental, moral beliefs” and away from a focus on the effects of institutional racism (Berry).

In Memphis, Bishop A. R. Williams (of World Overcomers Christian Church) provides another good illustration of employing the Black moral pathology thesis—with a particular focus on sexuality and homosexuality. With sermons like “How to Keep Your Husband so that Ho Don’t Get Him,” “Can a Gay Person be a Christian,” and “The Case Against Same-Sex Marriage,” Williams regularly, graphically, and explicitly preaches about sex and sexuality and what he considers appropriate and inappropriate sexual relationships (Tucker-Worgs).

Williams connects his message to the civil rights movement. In his sermon “The Case against Same-Sex Marriage” he warned the congregation that if they do not watch out “this will be a gay nation,” and he wants the Black community in particular to be aware of this threat. “Black people did not move in the Civil Rights Movement until they killed Emmett Till, then they got scared. You wait until they abuse and rape your daughters and sons, then it will be at your front door.” Williams’s use of the moral pathology thesis extends beyond same-sex marriage. He also blamed the victims of Hurricane Katrina in New Orleans for their plight, saying that New Orleans was “a sinful city.” He said the word “Katrina” means “to cleanse” and that Katrina was God’s way of “cleansing the city” (Williams).

Williams’s expression of contempt for what he calls an impending “gay nation” moves beyond the pulpit and extends to full-fledged political mobilization. For example, in 2003, the church spent thousands of dollars to put a two-page advertisement in the *Memphis Commercial Appeal* to protest a Supreme Court ruling that invalidated all state sodomy laws. In 2007, when a federal hate crimes bill that would have extended protected categories to include sexual orientation was being debated, Williams was outspoken in his opposition to the measure and later in 2009, he asked the congregation to pray that Barack Obama would veto the federal hate crimes bill that eventually was signed into law. The church has also erected a 72-foot replica of the Statue of Liberty that they call the “Statue of Liberation.” Instead of a torch, World Overcomers’s “Statue of Liberation” holds a cross in one hand and a tablet with the Ten Commandments in the other. At the foot of the statue are the words, “America: Return to Christ.” The statue has a single tear that signifies sadness with the moral direction that the United States is taking. The Statue of Liberation is a public symbol for moral pathology politics (Tucker-Worgs).

A third example of political mobilizing against same-sex marriage is the February 2005 formation of a group of Black ministers called the High Impact Leadership Coalition. This group of about 100 ministers first met in Los Angeles and was led by politically conservative evangelical Bishop Harry Jackson. Jackson is not a megachurch pastor but Crenshaw Christian Center (a Black megachurch led by Pastor Fred Price) hosted the event and Jackson also had the support of a handful of other Black megachurch leaders. The meeting led to the unveiling of “the Black Contract with America on Moral Values.” This document (obviously channeling the Republican or Grand Old Party’s 1994 Contract with America) highlighted six important “values” (really public policy goals) that the nation should focus on that would benefit Black America. Same-sex marriage topped this list of “moral issues” (High Impact Leadership Coalition). According to Jackson, same-sex marriage leads to a further decline in heterosexual marriage in Black communities to the detriment of these communities. About his sense of the dangers of same-sex marriage Jackson explained, “What tends to happen is that people tend to devalue the institution of marriage as a whole. People start rearing kids without two parents, and the Black community already has this incredibly alarming and, if I may say, this shameful number of babies being born without fathers” (Banerjee). Jackson has risen as a primary spokesperson against same-sex marriage legislation, especially in the state of Maryland, which in February 2012, passed legislation that would allow same-sex couples to marry. Like Eddie Long and A. R. Williams, Jackson’s views are guided by the perspective that focusing on moral pathology politics should be the primary strategy to combat racial disparities.

Obviously, social conservatism is not new to Black political ideology and is particularly entrenched in Black churches. Kelly Brown Douglas makes the argument that Black churches developed a silence around sex and sexuality in response to racist attacks on their sexuality and their humanity (Douglas). Cathy Cohen further explains how the marginalization of gay men and lesbians in Black churches particularly impeded Black churches from being effective against HIV/AIDS. AIDS was initially portrayed as a “gay man’s disease,” and because homosexuality is seen as an abhorrence, pathology, and a sin in Black churches, they (and other mainstream Black organizations) did not acknowledge the devastation of this disease to gay Black men and others in Black communities. Furthermore, Cohen argues, AIDS was seen as a “gay issue” and not a “Black issue”—worthy of concern by mainstream institutions and elites (Cohen). As Black churches ignored issues of sex and sexuality because they were not “Black issues,” they stood by while HIV/AIDS wreaked havoc on Black communities.

Ignoring issues pertaining to sex and sexuality, and defining them as “not Black issues,” is consistent with most Black megachurch participation in the recent discourse about same-sex marriage. Even though most Black megachurch members and leaders have not been out protesting against the rights of same-sex couples to marry, this is not because they support these rights. Instead, they do not perceive the “moral campaign” as a “Black issue.” In addition, many view the moral campaign as distracting and a Republican ploy to divide and conquer the Democratic electoral coalition. Civil rights activist and minister Rev. Joseph Lowery sums up this perspective nicely in a sermon he gave at Howard University’s Rankin Chapel. He said, “Gay marriage, that’s not our issue! Our issues are jobs, income, housing, education, climate control. I’m not worried about who somebody is sleeping with” (Lowery).

While social conservatism is not new to the Black church, what is new and increasingly frequent is Black megachurch *political mobilization* and *public policy advocacy* based on conservative social ideology and a moral pathology thesis. The marches, public statements, and support of conservative ballot initiatives from the pulpit and in the political arena have only increased in recent years, especially when moral issues dominate the public discourse. In the past, these conservative orientations were not the basis for political mobilization. In a number of studies, the “politically active Black church” has been used as a trope for “politically progressive Black church.” It is clear however from these examples of the use of the “moral politics” strategy that these terms should no longer be used interchangeably. Increasingly, select churches are making the claim that “moral politics” are legitimate and effective ways of addressing the post-civil rights disparities.

Conclusion

The Black megachurch phenomenon is arguably the most exciting Black religious development in the past 30 years. These churches simply would not have been possible 40 years ago. African Americans neither had the relative freedom in civil society nor the resources to build or sustain them. These churches respond to the suburban and class migrant and fulfill their desire for a professional and thisworldly church experience.

Just as there is not one monolithic “Black church,” there is not one “Black megachurch.” While they generally have thisworldly theological orientations they still vary a great deal. An examination of Black megachurches illustrates divergent philosophies and strategies on how Black churches engage in public life as they respond (or fail to respond) to the paradox of Black progress.

Black megachurches promote several theological orientations that effect their public engagement. Black liberation theology and the social gospel encourage the type of public engagement that addresses the “paradox of Black progress,” while the prosperity gospel

discourages it. As the prosperity gospel becomes more and more often embraced by Black megachurches, the likelihood that Black megachurches will address the most urgent post-civil rights challenges facing Black communities declines significantly.

One important way that many Black megachurches are making noticeable improvements and addressing the post-civil rights disparities is through community development. The work of community development, providing direct goods and services and building social and political assets, is not new to Black churches. In fact there is a very strong tradition of this type of activity in Black churches, most notably through the work of Black women's church auxiliary organizations. What is new is the frequent use of CDOs. These are beneficial because they help harness much-needed resources from the church and outside sources (especially government) and allow these churches to embark upon large-scale projects that they would not be able to do on their own. However, the community development model also has challenges. Cooperating with the government has the potential to silence church leaders who might want to speak out against the government, for fear of putting their government funding in jeopardy. Cooperating with the government through community development can harness the "prophetic voice" of Black megachurches.

Morality politics is the newest and most controversial strategy that Black megachurches use to address the paradox of Black politics. In recent years select Black megachurches have been mobilizing around "moral issues"—particularly against gay marriage. While the tradition of social conservatism is not new to Black churches, mobilizing politically around the issue is new. Morality politics however, distracts from issues that are more cogent to the paradox of Black progress like poverty and income inequality, school dropout rate, and the prison industrial complex that disproportionately incarcerates African Americans. These systemic issues cannot be addressed by morality politics. Morality politics may ultimately reinforce the status quo that will keep African Americans disproportionately poor, in prison, undereducated, and sick. With their aggregation of material and human resources, Black megachurches owe it to Black communities to deal with systematic inequalities that might truly make "Black progress" more meaningful.

Notes

1. The data about the Black megachurch phenomenon reported in this chapter is based on ITC/Faith Communities Today Project 2000 Megachurch Survey and additional data collected by the author. Project 2000 was a telephone-administered survey and part of a larger survey of Black churches—ITC/Faith Communities Today Project 2000, whose results are reported in Lawrence Mamiya's "River of Struggle, River of Freedom." The megachurch findings are reported in greater detail in Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs's *The Black Megachurch: Theology, Gender and the Politics of Public Engagement* (Waco, TX: Baylor University Press 2011).
2. For examples, of Black churches sanctioned for criticizing government see Michael Leo Owens, *God and Government in the Ghetto* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2007) or Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs, *The Black Megachurch: Theology, Gender and the Politics of Public Engagement* (Waco: Baylor University Press, 2011).
3. Bishop Eddie Long has faced recent accusations of having homosexual affairs with several young former mentees in his church. While he has not admitted to the affairs, the accusations of course undermine the likelihood of Long being able to effectively mobilize supporters around "moral politics" in the near future.
4. For an examination of same-sex public policy debate in Maryland please see Tamelyn Tucker-Worgs and Donn Worgs, "Black Morality Politics: Preachers, Politicians and Voters in the Battle over Same-Sex Marriage in Maryland" in the *Journal of Black Studies*, May 2014, Volume 45 no. 4 pp. 338–362.

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Part VI

Transatlantic Crossings

The historical development of Black churches and their contemporary expressions have typically been discussed as a US-based phenomenon. In this section, the authors broaden the conceptualization of “the Black Church” by pointing to its international and specifically Transatlantic connections in African (Lartey), the Caribbean (Anderson), Canada (Duncan), and England (McCalla). These chapters extend the discussion of Black Church Studies in several important ways. First, the cross-border connections between Canada and the United States are emphasized demonstrating that the Black Church was a key institution in the Underground Railroad movement, historically, and in the emergence of Black communities in Canada (Duncan). Second, the geographical, cultural, and linguistic focus of Black Church Studies as a solely US-based, English-speaking, and Protestant Christian experience is extended by the inclusion of Christian experiences that include a focus on the influence and engagement of African and Caribbean religious and cultural contexts (Anderson, Lartey, and Harvey). Collectively, these essays bring Black Church Studies into an international dialogue with scholars, clergy, and faith communities.

The Ancestors are Everywhere: Black Church Studies and the African Context

Emmanuel Y. Larrey

Soon after I arrived to live and work in the United States in 2001 I started worshipping fairly regularly in a Black church in Atlanta, Georgia. On several occasions I attended worship with a close associate of mine who is also a continental African. After a while she made it clear to me that she did not feel particularly comfortable with the worship in this church. I wished to know why. Her response was:

It's just like a session at the traditional fetish shrine back home in my African village. When the drumming takes a particularly exuberant form and they begin to dance, shout and sway, I feel just like I did at the fetish shrine—not at Christian worship. It's just as if the spirits are being invoked and possessions are about to occur—just like the shrine. It's all so pagan and traditional. It transports me back to and re-enacts that from which I thought I had been liberated in Christ!

I was amazed. What my friend was referring to in 2002 was what scholars of Black Religion in the United States have discussed for very long, namely, the African roots and retentions within Black Christian spirituality—the “Africanization” of Black (especially of Slave) Christianity. Is Africa present (as Herskovits argued) or completely erased from Black consciousness (the view articulated by Frazier) in the United States? Is there and if so in what way is there an African heritage in Black consciousness? W. E. B. Du Bois, of course, with characteristic perceptiveness and penetrating insight, preceded the Melville Herskovits/E. Franklin Frazier debate by many decades. The aspect of Black worship that my friend was specifically disconcerted about, W. E. B du Bois (1903) referred to as the “frenzy” and described it as one of the three crucial elements of the Black church at worship, namely, the Preacher, the Music, and the Frenzy (p. 155). Du Bois's description of this aspect of Black worship is worth quoting:

It varied in expression from the silent rapt countenance or the low murmur and moan to the mad abandon of physical fervor—the stamping, shrieking, and shouting, the rushing to and fro and wild waving of arms, the weeping and laughing, the vision and the trance.

All is nothing new in the world, but as old as religion, as Delphi and Endor. And so firm hold did it have on the Negro, that many generations firmly believed that without this visible manifestation of God there could be no true communion with the Invisible. (p. 156)

Du Bois clearly saw this as nothing new in religion. What is perhaps interesting is the extent to which for the “Negro”, according to Du Bois, it is such a crucial element of worship that without it there was no true communion with God. What is intriguing to me is that an unsuspecting continental African in the twenty-first century, exposed to Black worship, is transported into the arena of African traditional religious practice and ritual, experiencing and, in this case, resisting, the ‘presence of the ancestors’ in African American Christianity.

Du Bois saw direct links between the African traditional priest-healer and the Black preacher. He articulated the connection of African American preachers to their African forbears, declaring the priest or medicine man the “chief remaining institution” of the African past on plantation life, in the following words,

He early appeared on the plantation and found his function as the Healer of the sick, the interpreter of the Unknown, the comforter of the sorrowing, the supernatural avenger of wrong, and the one who rudely but picturesquely expressed the longing, disappointment, and resentment of a stolen and oppressed people. Thus, as bard, physician, judge, and priest, within the narrow limits allowed by the slave system, rose the Negro preacher, and under him the first Afro-American institution, the Negro church.

(Du Bois, 1989, pp. 159–160)

Levine (1977), Raboteau (1978), Stuckey (1987), and many other more recent scholars of Black spirituality, though arguing from different standpoints and often in opposing ways, raise this very issue that lies at the heart of this presentation, namely, the connection between African (traditional) religions and Black Christianity in the African Diaspora and the United States in particular.

In this chapter I make the following arguments:

- There is historical continuity and phenomenological similarity between the Black church in the United States and African religious experience and expression on the continent and in other African Diasporan contexts.
- There is much to be gained by approaching the Black church as an expression of African religious creativity and African Christianity to be precise.
- The Black church could fruitfully be considered an African-derived religious institution or an African (Diasporan) Independent Church and as such studied using some of the tools and categories of analysis that have been developed in the study of African Indigenous churches.
- The work of students and scholars of the Black church and also of Black theologians would be enhanced by more serious and respectful study of the African religio-cultural heritage.
- Creativity is an often ignored characteristic feature of African religions and Black spirituality. Such ingenuity is manifest in the development of the Black church.
- A core aspect of African spirituality is synthetic thinking and practice that incorporates several elements into a “gestalt” in which the whole always exceeds the sum of the parts.
- The creativity of African spirituality often includes an incorporation of “non-African” phenomena such as Western and Eastern cultures and practices.
- Black Church Studies could usefully be seen as a study of global dimensions of African Religion and African Christianity.

African Presence in Black Spirituality and the Black Church

Few scholars now would doubt that Africans enslaved in the so-called “New World,” brought aspects of their religion and cultural values along with them, and that these had an impact on their lives in many and varied ways. African culture most certainly became part of the amalgam they created that shaped the ethos and culture of nineteenth-century Black life and continued to do so for years after Emancipation. Sharla Fett (2002), for example, has recently demonstrated how enslaved women and men on Southern Slave Plantations drew on African precedents to develop concepts and practices related to health and healing that were distinctly at odds with slaveholders’ property concerns. Fett argues convincingly and produces the archeological and other evidence to demonstrate how these Africans enslaved in America embraced a relational view of health intimately related to African religion and community. What is of significance for Black Church Studies, I would argue, is that we are now, perhaps more so than at anytime in the past, in a position to engage in careful and informed study of the nature of the influence of African cultural values and non-Christian African religions upon the development of Black life and thought in those harrowing yet formative years. Scholars and students of the Black church can now study African religions and cultural values more carefully, with a view to gaining insight into aspects of what sustained their forbears who founded the Black church. In this regard, Black theologians could study the theological implications and significance of African religious concepts and practices in the formative periods of the Black church. Another recent example of such study is that of womanist theologian Dianne Stewart’s (2005) work on African religions in Jamaica. Stewart courageously and clearly demonstrates the sustaining power of African religion in the decades before Christianity became a dominant, hegemonic force in Jamaica. She goes on to show the “indisputable relationship between African religions and African revolts against enslavement” (p. 19). Stewart argues, on the basis of her close study of Jamaican religious history, that

if any religious tradition has been a viable force in African liberation struggles in the Caribbean, it is African-derived religion not Christianity. Indeed in those cases where we observe a cohabitation of Christianity with African religion in a single tradition, the evidence demonstrates the primacy of African derived spirituality and religiosity in shaping the identity of the practitioners, even if the practitioners claim to be Christian. (p. 226)

What was true in the Caribbean was also true in North America where the Black church incorporated and manifest the power and creativity of Africans enslaved in the United States in initiating religious institutions out of the bringing together of many sources, not least their African worldview. Yvonne Chireau (2006, p. 5) asserts,

Christianity was but one means by which enslaved African Americans interacted with the divine and acquired spiritual empowerment. And while Christianity became perhaps one of the most visible and institutionally viable religions of African Americans, it should be recognized that potential alternatives, including Islam, African-based practices such as voodoo, and other, more discrete religious possibilities such as Conjuring were present in slave communities during the nineteenth century.

Following the recognition and insight of Du Bois, it is possible, and I would argue necessary, to engage in a more closer study of the beliefs and practices of the traditional African priest-healers to gain a better understanding of one important strand in the development of those early Black preachers. It is possible now to trace more clearly the origins of aspects of the ritual, liturgical, and musical traditions of that great Black institution—the Black church. More careful study can demonstrate the *agency* and the *creative genius* of these largely untutored African Americans. They were sustained by a rich heritage of African values and traditions upon which

they drew, mixed creatively with biblical and New World cultural practices into a fascinating tapestry of worship and Church practices. One character in the chapter on “Herbs and Herb Doctors” in Zora Neale Hurston’s *The Sanctified Church*, is Mother Catherine, who “unlike most religious dictators . . . does not crush the individual. She encourages originality” (p. 25). In Mother Catherine’s worship services, “there is a catholic flavor about the place, but it is certainly not Catholic. She has taken from all the religions she knows anything about any feature that pleases her” (p. 26). Mother Catherine is the epitome of the creativity of Black religious leaders in the United States. Black theologians need to examine more closely both African religious traditions and contemporary Black liturgical and homiletical practices for their African continuities and discontinuities.

African Religious Heritage

In order to gain a richer sense of the complexity of the texture of Black Christianity, we must study African religious, sociocultural, and traditional medical and ritual practices (especially as these existed in the seventeenth, eighteenth, and nineteenth centuries). We must study the presence and impact of the African religious heritage on Black life and thought. Black Christianity, like the other Disaporan African religious institutions dubbed African-derived religions in the Caribbean, South and Central America demonstrate a recognizable trait in African traditional religions—that of creativity and adaptability. African religions survived and have been re-created in the “New World” partly because one of the crucial functions of religion in the African mind is to provide the power by which people are enabled to cope with life successfully.

Any careful study of the traditional religious heritage of Africa engages, in my view, *seven* pervasive characteristics which are manifest in different ways among particular peoples and cultures. These characteristics are discernible in African (so-called traditional) religions on the continent and African-derived religions in the diaspora. They are: (1) The sacredness of all of life, (2) plurality within the divine realm, (3) mystical connectivity through communal ritual, (4) desire for cosmic harmony, (5) creativity and adaptability, (6) affirmation of life, and (7) a pragmatic spirituality.

The Sacredness of all of Life

It is a commonplace that there are no sharp divisions between the sacred and the secular in African thought. Religion pervades every aspect of life so thoroughly that it is often very hard for the casual observer to recognize its presence let alone distinguish it from culture. Evidence of this lies, on the one hand, in the observation by early European adventurers, such as Rudyard Kipling, that the African has no religion or concept of God; and on the other hand, the pervasive religiosity of Africans everywhere commented upon by various commentators on African social life and picturesquely captured in the note by Kenyan theologian, John Mbiti, that Africans are “incurably religious.” The early Europeans were unable to perceive what was woven so closely into the very fabric of African life. Hardly any word exists in most African languages for “religion” per se. Most often the word “religion” has been translated by African words for “ritual” or “ceremony,” or “service.” The reason lies not in the absence of religion but rather in its pervasiveness. All of life pulsates with the rhythms of the spiritual realm.

Plurality within the Spiritual and Divine Realm

In most African religious thought, the divine realm is populated by many players. Dianne Stewart describes this well as a “communotheism” (p. 130). There is a Community even in the Divine realm. Notions of “Supremacy” in this realm are often acceded to for the purposes

of explanation and translation to the foreign mind, especially the Western mind that seems to be so enamored by counting, measuring, and comparing sizes. The Ultimate Reality (e.g., Akan—*Onyame*, Yoruba—*Oludomare*, Ibo—*Chineke*, Ewe—*Mawu*) is so essential and ultimate as to be inaccessible. The Akans say, “If you wish to send a message to Onyame, tell it to the wind” (Gyekye, 1996, p. 9). Onyame is both as close as the air we breath and as distant as to require a messenger to send requests through. As Kofi Asare Opoku (1978) has presented, in the spiritual realm there are many different powers—the deities, the spirits, the ancestors, and others—that though distinguishable, constitute collectively the realm of the “unseen” yet not unexperienced. Reverence is paid to this realm through acknowledgment; prayer in the form of libation, poetry, dance, and the music and rhythm of the drum; and other participatory rituals.

Mystical Connectivity through Communal Ritual

African religion is not so much a matter of “beliefs, dogmas and creeds” as it is of the performance of powerful rituals and the expression of communal solidarity through participation in such rituals. There are several rituals that communities, clans, and families perform around the *rites de passage* of birth, puberty, marriage, and death. There are daily rituals and there are periodic rituals of cleansing, recognition, and invocation. Ritual is essentially an experience and practice that seeks to foster a deep sense of *belonging* and *participation* in the life of the community and to maintain connectivity with the invisible, mystical realm of existence.

The connection between the visible human realm and the unseen spiritual realm is manifest through that which has been described as “possession” or “trance” observable in most African religious ceremonies. Here the plural spiritual realm interacts with the human in ways that incarnate and embody the unseen. Most often such manifestations are ultimately for the good of the human community. Healings, predictions of present and future calamity, proclamations of required ritual performances, and indications of the community’s need to pursue particular lines of action are some of the results of manifestation of the unseen realm through “possessions.” The rhythmic language of the drum and the bodily movement of dance are the media through which mystic connectivity is enacted. The language of the drum creates and mediates the liminal space between the visible and the unseen world enabling beings to traverse this space in both directions.

Desire for Cosmic Harmony

For the human community to flourish, traditional Africans believe that there have to be harmonious relations among the human, spiritual, and divine dimensions of existence. A community’s ancestors are the mediators of such cosmic relations. Dreams and visions are the regular and normal means of cosmic communication as are “possessions” and trance states the more formal liturgical or ritual means. To establish this harmony, religious functionaries must both discern sources of disharmony, conflict, or destabilization of relations and perform the necessary rituals to correct and maintain good relations. Notions of evil and sin (e.g., *mmusu*, Akan,) are related to acts and omissions that affect the *sensus communis* of a community (Pobee, 1979, p. 111). The ritual of libation is the traditional form of prayer believed to mediate this cosmic harmony.

Creativity and Adaptability

African religion is demonstrably flexible, pliable, pluralistic, and adaptable. The rituals and practices, while maintaining their essential form, have been reinvented in different ways and forms throughout the world. Wherever Africans have gone, willingly or unwillingly, in the

world they have formed communities of faith and ritual practice drawing creatively and synthetically on their heritage, features of their current context and other realities they have found. The African-derived religions of the Caribbean and South America, the African Independent churches of Africa and Europe, the Black Church of the United States (including the Black megachurch) are all examples of this African religious creativity. The rhythm, musicality, and oral performance of Africans is a combination of this innovativeness and mystical connectivity with the unseen and the affirmation of embodied life.

It is this creativity and adaptability that arguably has sustained and maintained Africans throughout the world in the face of unspeakable and continuous acts of violence and terror directed at them. Evidence of the creative and surviving genius of enslaved Africans lies in the fact that they have managed to incorporate and renovate aspects of their oppressors religion, transposing it and infusing it with their own latent worldview and culture to the extent that Africa is now spoken of as the center of gravity of Christianity and the Black church in the United States is recognized as among the most vibrant and thriving forms of contemporary Christianity.

Affirmation of Life

The values adumbrated through ritual and practice in African religion are all directed toward the flourishing of human community. Fecundity, bountiful harvests, and peaceful communal relations are key prayers in each ritual of libation. Religion is powerfully present through the drum, rhythmic movement of the body, and dance and not merely through contemplation, reflection, or other mental calisthenics. African traditional theology is not only thought out but also expressed in bodily form.

A Pragmatic Spirituality

African traditional spirituality has a pragmatic focus. The most deeply spiritually or religiously adept or developed person is one who is able to interact with the unseen world in ways that are beneficial for the visible, seen community, especially where ordinary physical and human forces are ineffective. The mark of one's spirituality lies in the ability to help, heal, bless, feed, clothe, and shelter the needy through one's efficacious interactions with the unseen realm.

To state that these characteristics of African traditional religions are discernible in African-derived religions in the Caribbean and North America, the African Independent church movement in continental Africa, the Charismatic church movement, and also the Black church in North America, is I suggest, stating the obvious. To make a study of African Religions a requirement for Black Church Studies is the challenge that I wish to pose.

The early years of the twentieth century saw the emergence of African Independent (Indigenous) churches across continental Africa. These later generated such interest among scholars of religion as arguably to have spawned the development of the study of New Religious Movements throughout the world. (See the pioneering studies of Baëta (1962) Peel, (1968) Sundkler, (1948/61) Turner (1967), and more recently Bediako, (1995), Clarke (2003)). There has been much discussion of their status—as cults, sects, syncretistic movements etcetera. What is of interest to me is the development of a whole new interdisciplinary study to approach these religious groups. Spiritual churches (in West Africa) and Zionist churches (in Southern Africa) have provided the data for many PhD theses. A characteristic feature of these New Religious Movements on the African continent was the creative ability to amalgamate African religio-cultural realities with Western and Eastern beliefs and practices into fascinating syntheses of religious ritual all aiming at promoting the healing and well-being of devotees.

It is my considered view that the Black church in the United States could be approached along similar lines seeing it as the creation of African prophet-healers who creatively constructed communities of faith, healing, and strength out of all the resources that were to hand, including, but by no means solely from, the memories and artifacts of Africa. Zora Neale Hurston again declares,

if we look at it squarely, [Negros are] very original beings. While they lives and moves in the midst of a white civilization, everything they touch is re-interpreted for their own use. They have modified the language, mode of food preparation, practice of medicine, and most certainly the religion of their new country, just as he adapted to suit himself the Sheik haircut made famous by Rudolph Valentino. (p. 58)

To appreciate the presence of an African religio-cultural underlay in Black Christian spirituality, however, requires us to deal with years of suspicion, fear, and downright misinformation concerning non-Christian African faiths. The maligning of these African traditions was a part of the justification of the heinous crime of slavery and the expansion of Europe in its colonialist endeavors. This misinformation has set the stage for a continued fear and reluctance to engage in careful study on the part even of continental African scholars.

My friend's antipathy toward the "frenzy" in Black church worship was informed by this fear, mistrust, and misunderstanding. It seemed too much like non-Christian African cult practice. So in spite of the fairly straightforward Christian content of the service and a strong Pentecostal Christian sermon on discipleship and social holiness with which she would otherwise have been quite at home, the liturgically recognized "frenzy" in Black church worship brought up in her the Afro-phobia that is shared by continental and diasporan Africans alike. What my friend experienced was what theologian Kortright Davis has described as the "African soul" of Black Christianity, a soul without which there would be little vitality or authenticity.

In 2004 I co-led a group of Emory students and alum on a trip to Ghana. Several fascinating accounts have been and could be shared of the experiences we had on that journey. For several of the participants though, the visit to the churches seems to have been the most disappointing part of their journey to the "homeland." They reported that they had expected to find more "authentic African theology and practice" not the Eurocentric Christianity and versions of the "prosperity gospel" they were treated to. Similarly for several months the church I pastor was served by an African American associate pastor from the Presbyterian Church USA. Although tremendously uplifted by the singing of African songs and the music and rhythm, she reported being struck by the traditionalism and even Eurocentricity of the theology of many leaders of the church. In both these cases what is striking is the extent to which traditional African Christianity presents itself as authentically Christian by overtly identifying itself with European Christianity. Continental and diasporan African Christians alike appeal to European scholarship, belief, and practice to legitimize their own church practices. Moreover, continental perhaps even more than diasporan Christians, both manifest an antipathy and very often even a fear of African religio-cultural beliefs and practices that might appear in their Christian worship or life. Much work still needs to be done with both continental and diasporan Africans to help us appreciate the value of our African heritage for our Christian faith, and to move us away from the disdain and antipathy we all still seem to feel toward our African roots.

African Presence in the United States and Contemporary Black Church Studies

In Atlanta alone there are at least 18 churches that could be described as "Ghanaian immigrant churches." That is not counting the Nigerian, Liberian, Congolese, Sudanese, Ethiopian, and

other African nations that have thriving immigrant communities in Atlanta and whose nationals found churches almost by the week. Across several cities in the United States, as in Canada, Europe, and Australia, African immigrants have carried their vibrant, African Christianity with their exuberant worship, with them into their host countries. African indigenous (or “independent”) churches exist in the United States and have branches all over Western Europe. There are African churches of various varieties across the whole of the West. Wherever continental Africans have traveled they have carried their brands of Christian worship with them. The religious creativity of the founders of African-derived religions in the Caribbean and the Black church in the United States seems to be still alive in these recent immigrants. The ancestors appear to still be with us wherever we go.

These newer African churches, fellowships, and communities of faith have significance for Black Church Studies since they constitute examples of the ongoing phenomena of African religious agency, creativity, and adaptability. Divisive questions from within as well as without Black communities have been raised concerning Blackness in the United States today. Are African immigrants Black? Are they aware of the historic struggles of African Americans against racism? Are they treated with less animosity than their American cousins by the European American majority?

What would Black Church Studies look like if in all the churches the majority of the membership and leadership, those of which traced their origins and heritage to Africa, were included? What would happen if Black Church Studies became a site of reconciliation and healing between continental and diasporan Africans? What would it be like if the stolen heritage and legacy of continental and diasporan Africans was restored through Black Church Studies? What would happen if all the sons and daughters of Africa—no matter how recent or distant their heritage—were to join together in careful studies of their complex and multifaceted religious and cultural heritages? Some objections that I have encountered in proposing such an approach include the following:

- It would be too “African.” Black Studies would lose its African American contextual base. We would lose our exclusive focus on the African American experience and be diverted into paths that lead us astray and distract us from the contemporary social, political, and economic needs of Black people in the United States.
- It could run the risk of being too esoteric and mystical. Studying all that voodoo, obeah, hoodoo, and all that dangerous African “superstitious” stuff, that really defies scholarship, would result in the loss of the respectability we have gained by our focus on the study of European Christianity practiced by African Americans.
- We would be engaging in religious studies and not theology. We would become cultural anthropologists and not Christian theologians espousing the word of God.

In response to these objections I would suggest that comprehensive historical, sociological, psychological, and theological studies of African religions, culture, and the continuities and discontinuities of these in the African Diaspora might actually open doors to the claiming and linking of heritages and forging of new destinies for people of African descent together. Perhaps such a study could improve the critical quality of our scholarship and make us all students who cannot easily be dismissed as romanticizing and essentializing Africa into a monolithic, mythic colossus impervious to real inquiry.

Perhaps this kind of study could truly provide us with the historical depth and contemporary rigor that is needed in developing the discipline of Black Church Studies into a robust and invigorating force within seminary and university education facilitating the self-understanding, identity, and thus influence of the Black church worldwide. Perhaps this kind of study could offer a more truthful account of the creative agency of African people in particular, giving credence to the global nature of African religion.

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Freedom to “Catch the Spirit”: Conceptualizing Black Church Studies in a Caribbean Context

Claudette A. Anderson

[African religious traditions were] a challenge to [the] study and understanding, as well as definition of the essentials of the Christian faith. These traditions also suggested the relevance for Christian life of a spiritual worldview that denies the distinction of sacred and secular, associates everyday experience with religious faith, and affirms the importance of community life.¹

Introduction: Spirit Anecdotes

- (1) During a Thanksgiving Service at the Church of Zion in Kingston, a brother who had been slack in attending church “*got into the Spirit*.” After several minutes of agitated glossolalia, he lay motionless—“*slain in the spirit*” until near the end of the service.
- (2) I visit a Revival Modda (Female Healer)² in St. Andrew. She relates the various aspects of healing as “*di spirit use[ing] yuh different*.” She describes her gift of healing as having “*to work in di spirit*” noting that *di spirit* “*ave mi a work out . . .*”³
- (3) I am a participant observer at a Healing Service at the Zion True Church of God, Westmoreland; I observe the “reading” (divination session) of a young female patient who is sternly admonished for her reticence in responding to the healer’s questions: “yuh mus’ answer ‘im, answer ‘im when ‘im talk to yuh, cause yuh only *shaming di Spirit*.”⁴
- (4) Two youngsters on the playground near the Maryland Wesleyan Holiness Church jokingly ask their “hyperactive” playmate: *Yuh ina di spirit or di spirit ina yuh?*⁵
- (5) On her way to the bus stop one weekday morning, a Revival healer encounters a young woman. Upon approaching her she is forced to “go ‘round har two time” because “*di spirit neva right*.”⁶

I cite these examples from Jamaican religious culture as emblematic of the essential “Spirit orientation” of the African-centered and African-derived religions in the Caribbean. I note this spirit orientation as the privileging and centering of Spirit beings and the spiritual realm. It signals the implication of Spirit in every dimension of existence and an unwavering confidence

in a religious vision that is inherently Spirit-directed and therapeutic. Within the context of a discussion on Black Church Studies in a Caribbean context, I want to articulate the concept of *African Spirituology* as the defining characteristic of the Black church in the Caribbean. This Caribbean Black church encompasses a continuum of traditions that transcend Christian boundaries. African Spirituology is, in the language of the Native Baptist, a “spiritual science.” This “science of the Spirit,” defines the ability to create, manipulate, and transform “Spirit.” “Spirit” as conceived and experienced by Afri-oriented religious practitioners is a triad of (1) spiritual beings—*orisas*, journeymen, ancestors, *loas*, the Holy Ghost, the newly dead, old testament prophets, transcended revolutionaries, superstars and premiers *ldots* ad infinitum, (2) human spiritual essences—multiple souls, the life-soul, personality-soul, and guardian shadow-soul and (3) spiritual energy—neutral mystical power. “Spirit” is the plural noun used to represent Spirituology, while “spirit”—the singular noun, references individual instantiations or forms of Spirit.

African Spirituology is constituted by theology and mediation as well as specialized knowledge of, and expertise in Spirit, which are evidenced in the various elements of the Afri-oriented religions such as the language, worldview, rituals, liturgy, iconography, and sacred texts all of which are expressed variously in “spirit terms” such as “manifestations of the Spirit,” “spiritual surgeon” and “spirit doctor,” “commissions of the Spirit,” “spirit work,” “spirit writing,” and “gifts of the Spirit.”

Scholars have generally argued that traditional “African spirituality is based on the notion of the Supreme God and a world of spirits between which and the physical world there is active continuity.”⁷ In this conceptualization, the physical world is seen as a “manifestation of invisible presence and all experience interpretable as the language of intercourse between the two.”⁸ I posit accordingly that African Spirituology is defined by

- a theology or a system of thought concerned with or centered on “Spirit”
- a branch of specialized knowledge regarding the creation, manifestation, and transformation of “Spirit”
- “Spirit” as the mediation between invisible God and visible humans
- techniques or expertise used to create, manifest, and transform “Spirit”
- techniques or expertise used to transform human life—to heal through “Spirit”

The premium placed on Spirit as an immediate and effective force means that knowledge of, as well as getting and maintaining access to, this power is a persistent concern and thus the quest for empowerment is seen in the frequent engagement in ritual discourse with a host of spirits, and in the constancy of divine revelation. African Spirituology, in the language of Barrett’s *Soul-force*, “derives its impetus from the ancestral heritage of Africa, its refinement from the bondage of slavery, and its continuing vitality from the conflict of the present.”⁹ It is a particular rendering of traditional African spirituality that is no less than a vision of the cosmos as engendered, populated, and harmonized by Spirit.

In attempting an exposition of the Caribbean Black church, I argue for the significant impact of African Religious Traditions (ARTs) on the conception and practice of Christianity. The history of ARTs in the diaspora is a history of resistance, rebellion, and liberation and a story of remembering, forgetting, and re/creating. In the Caribbean today, these traditions, some of which have incorporated elements of Christianity to varying degrees, continue to serve as therapeutic, emotional, and spiritual resources in the midst of oppression while simultaneously interrogating the validity of a Caribbean theology that demonizes them. The theological response to the challenge posed by African-derived and African-centered churches in the Caribbean is at best feeble. While Afri-oriented churches tenaciously tend to the spiritual welfare of believers, Caribbean theologians, for the most part, still blinded by the anti-Africanness

of Anglo-Saxon bias and the myopic wisdom of a class-defined racial discourse, remain committed to the "civilizing mission" of their forbears, failing to deliver a contextually, culturally, and racially righteous theology. Using African Afri-oriented religions as the most appropriate basis for Caribbean theology, I argue that Caribbean Church Studies must adapt the liberating ethic of these Spirit-centered traditions, losing and finding itself in the "freedom to catch the spirit."

This conceptualization of Black Church Studies in a Caribbean context acknowledges the eighteenth-century North American Black mission to the Caribbean as a definitive moment in the history of the Black church in the Caribbean and, while critiquing the Christian bias of North American Black Church Studies,¹⁰ privileges its sustained theological affirmation of Black spiritual experience. This chapter focuses primarily on the English-speaking Caribbean with emphasis on religions in Jamaica. Beginning with a brief overview of Black Church Studies in the United States, I then examine Caribbean racial discourse in the Caribbean. I argue that the class-centered discourse on race is an inadequate and deceptive formulation of racial politics in the Caribbean, and engage "smadditization" discourse as a crucial site for the articulation of Caribbean racial concepts. I then explore the Black church in the Caribbean as a part of an *Obeah*-based continuum of Afri-oriented religious traditions. In arguing for the Church as source and basis of theology, I examine a number of Spiritualities present in the contemporary Caribbean and conclude by offering *Spirit Theology* as authentic and indigenous Caribbean theology.

Black Church Studies in the United States

In 1979, nine years after the Society for the Study of Black Religion (SSBR) was founded, Gayraud Wilmore, in a *Christian Century* editorial titled "Tension Points in Black Church Studies," delineated Black Church Studies as referring to "the academic study of the religious traditions and experiences of Americans of African descent."¹¹ This formulation of Black Church Studies was in keeping with the aims of the SSBR, which are (1) to engage in scholarly research and discussion about the religious experience of Blacks, (2) to publish reports of its discussions and research, and (3) to encourage the teaching and discussion of the Black religious experience in the curricula of college or university departments of religion and theological seminaries.¹² In offering this inclusive formulation of Black Church Studies, Wilmore noted that the "vast majority of African Americans were Christians and members of predominantly Black denominations and sects."¹³ For him, Black Church Studies includes the professional training of Black pastors as well as commitment to an ecumenical, interracial, and integrated curriculum aimed at fostering understanding of and appreciation for "the contribution of the Black religious experience to the totality of Christian faith and life" the success of which is dependent on "its ability to return to the people a faith . . . retentive of the spirituality and pragmatism of the Black Christian tradition."¹⁴ The translation of Black religious experience into the thought-forms of white theology and its subsequent communication back to the Black church in recognizable forms compatible with Black reality is noted by Wilmore as one tension point in Black Church Studies. This coupled with the academic racism experienced by Black scholars continues to be a major challenge inherent in the study of the Black church in a white academy.

The tensions inherent in Black Church Studies have served to narrow its focus. As such, the broad definition of Black Church Studies offered by Wilmore has, in practice, been confined primarily to the study of Black Christianity to the neglect of other African American religious traditions, and in particular those that express traditional African cosmologies. Nevertheless, this concentration on Black Christianity has produced a diversity of scholarship in the various subdisciplines including history, musicology, sociology of religion, homiletics, the Bible, and

philosophy of religion that show the continued growth and relevance of Black Church Studies to both the academy and the Black church. Within the discipline of theology, Black liberation theology and womanist theology have been the two most formidable contributions to religious studies. Accordingly, although the original conceptualization of Black Church Studies is yet to be fully explored, as Paris observes, “virtually all African American Religious Scholars have been united (a) in their uniform condemnation of racism and, increasingly, their similar condemnation of sexism; and (b) in their mining the African American experience of suffering, resistance, and hope as a reservoir of theological insight and ethical wisdom.”¹⁵ It is this unity of voice born of cultural solidarity that gives Black Church Studies its authority.

Within a Christian framework, each emerging voice in African American Religious Studies speaks with the conviction that it is possible to be both Black and Christian. Black Christology expounds the importance of Jesus as a friend and liberator of the oppressed and downtrodden while Black Biblical Studies scholars are committed to freeing biblical scholarship of its Eurocentric bias through affirmation of the African presence in the Bible. Within the broader framework of a theology based on Black religious experience, increasing attention is being paid to religion among the enslaved, through a deliberate focus on narratives, prayers, songs, folklore, and sermons. Studied attention to the religion and culture of our enslaved ancestors underscores the importance of accessing all available resources for the achievement of unqualified success for Black Church Studies and accordingly Black liberation. This is particularly significant as Black Church Studies, although emerging out of the Black church and Black religious community, takes place within the context of a hostile environment.

The context of an immediate and persistent racist tension that informs Black Church Studies in the United States is, as Evans argues in “I Rose and Found My Voice,” further exacerbated by the competing sensibilities that characterize the different academic settings. Rationalistic, ecclesiastical, and ecumenical sensibilities contextualize the theological focus of white religious academies within which Black Church Studies programs must not only operate but also succeed. Evans argues that the different cultural contexts of peoples of African descent in the diaspora provide a paradigm for understanding Black Church Studies in its various contexts. He appeals to unity of ancestry, arguing that the “otherness of African cultural sensibility” is a distinctive feature of Black experience that engenders a Black voice which is “one and manifold.”¹⁶ Black church studies based on this paradigm of the African diaspora would focus on both the common Black voice and the various institutional contexts in which that voice is heard. The goal of Black Church Studies furthermore is “the resurrection of ‘suppressed dialogues’ among people with a common ancestral identity.”¹⁷

The articulation of a diasporic paradigm for Black Church Studies is an important moment in the history of the field, for it both acknowledges and affirms the common humanity of peoples of African descent. Indeed, Cone in his 1986 preface to *A Black Theology of Liberation* notes that a serious limitation of the work was his “failure to incorporate a global analysis of oppression.”¹⁸ He states further, “I am convinced that no one should claim to be doing Christian theology today without making the liberation of the Third World from the exploitation of the First World and the Second World a central aspect of this purpose.”¹⁹

The inclusion of a chapter on Black Church Studies in a Caribbean context in this volume is therefore a furthering of this diasporic paradigm. In giving voice to a suppressed dialogue, it provides the unique opportunity for Caribbean theological reflection focused on the concept of “Blackness”—an equally important, yet traditionally neglected, issue within mainstream Caribbean theology.

In conceptualizing Black Church Studies in a Caribbean context we grapple not with an “immediate and persistent racism,” but with the divisive and debilitating phenomenon of “color psychology” that “makes it easier for the dominant minority to keep the dominated in perennial conflict and competition with each other, thus making themselves more susceptible to exploitation and less capable of achieving solidarity against a common foe.”²⁰ We understand

further that "nowhere has Christianity been more effectively used as an instrument for the dehistoricization and depoliticization of people than in the Caribbean Basin."²¹ This is particularly reflected in the Mission Statement of The United Theological College of the West Indies founded in 1965, in the midst of the Caribbean struggle for independence from racist colonial authorities. The Mission Statement reads,

The United Theological College of the West Indies (UTCWI) as a Christian institution seeks to provide theological education in a student-centered environment that promotes spiritual, emotional and social development, and *prepares men and women for mission and service.*
(emphasis mine)²²

The civilizing mission is further reinforced in the UTCWI's Purpose and Aim that in addition to preparing "men and women for Ministry in the Church, promotes theological study and learning," on the doctrinal basis of "belief in one God as Father, Son and Holy Spirit."²³ No space is made in participating communions for the inclusion of Afri-centered religious traditions that define the Caribbean. Further, the curricula demonstrate little conscious effort at the mining of the African Caribbean experience as a reservoir of theological insight and ethical wisdom.

The vexing cultural, social, economic, and political situation in the Caribbean is therefore reflective of a racist orthodox Christianity engaged in the cultural and spiritual impoverishment of Caribbean peoples of African descent. Caribbean history chronicles the evils of conquest, exploitation, extermination, enslavement, colonialism, and neocolonialism. The continued enslavement of Caribbean peoples by a legacy of exploitation now exemplified by neocolonialism signals the failure of Caribbean theology to challenge political authority, speak out against injustice and inequality, and to urgently address the demonization and marginalization of Black religion and culture. Caribbean religious studies scholars have failed to affirm the humanity and dignity of peoples of African descent. They have failed to renounce the persistent anthropological poverty, which plagues the Caribbean Blacks. They have failed to privilege African spirituality and they have failed to decolonize and emancipate theology.

To conceptualize Black Church Studies in this context is therefore to explore and expose the experience and meaning of Blackness within a religious framework as a means of advancing Caribbean theology. The formulation of Caribbean Black Church Studies allows for the transcendence of a Caribbean pre-theology²⁴ of Afrophobia and anti-Africanness²⁵ defined by "containment and conservation,"²⁶ to a theology of Afrophilia engaged in *enspiritment* and liberation. A successful Caribbean theology is only possible with a movement away from a "soteriology of anti-Africanness"—which advocates that salvation is possible only with a rejection of Africanness to a centering "Afrophilic pneumatology" that affirms the importance, relevance, and liberating ethic of Black spirituality. In so doing, a Caribbean Black Church Studies program will further the discourse of Third World Liberation Theology, grounded in the fact that "Black people cannot be served by a White theology."²⁷

Blackness, Caribbean Racial Discourse, and Caribbean Church Studies

In the Caribbean, "Black" as a racial construct does not bear the weight of historically brutal and contemporary institutionalized racism in the United States. Within the context of a Black majority, "Black" and "white" are seen as cultural more so than racial constructs. Caribbean racial discourse has focused on color and class as it continues to be informed by the more nuanced and complex nature of race and ethnicity in the post-colonial era. Franklin Knight offers that "another way of looking at this difference between North America and the rest of the Americas, is that in the former the ideal is one of a stratified society while in the latter the ideal

imposes stratification on the context of ethnic pluralism,"²⁸ so that race becomes important in a "far more subtle way." As Nettleford emphasizes in his articulation of Cari-Jamaican cultural identity, "we are not that unsophisticated to be racist, but we are not that silly not to be race conscious."²⁹

The varying and often conflicted expressions of race consciousness within the Caribbean are, however, not totally devoid of racism. Caribbean culture is seen as characterized by "contradictory omens"³⁰ occasioned by the "agony of options"³¹ open to Caribbean peoples. This "contradictory code"—the Caribbean dialectic of existence—fosters a "submarine unity"³² that is instinctively known and experienced. At the same time, it produces a multiracial myth that is at once the antiracist imperative that seeks to deny the importance of Blackness and refuses to acknowledge the fact that "what has become Caribbean has been forged in the crucible of African experience."³³ After hundreds of years of assimilation, people become distinguished by social status, not unrelated to issues of color, ethnicity, and inheritance. In the Jamaican context for example, Diane Austin-Broos notes "there has been a movement in the meaning of color categories from an emphasis on biology, to a greater emphasis on environment . . . encouraged by the emergence of class as an idiom in the course of the twentieth century."³⁴ She articulates the concept of "heritable identity"—inherited class status related to diverse productive roles and color classifications—as defining race and class relations in Jamaica. The absence of dichotomous race relations then results in a more or less stifled racial consciousness with very few individuals or groups openly advocating race as the basis for political or religious organization.

This class-centered racial discourse, however, fails to acknowledge the fact that the so-called Black middle class is not socially powerful, and the Black upper class, for the most part, do not consider themselves Black so that the "denigration of things African continue with a vengeance."³⁵ In a situation where class and color take primacy over race, it is no wonder that Afro-phobia and anti-Africanness masquerade as "progress" with the imitation of whiteness—the human ideal, constituting the greatest form of self-hate. To have high social status or to be "somebody" is simultaneously a rejection of one's Blackness. In this post-colonial space, "everybaddy waan tun massa."³⁶ So that although "somebodiness" may occasion the "wearing of Africa," it manifests as a "contempt for Africa" that is seen in the gross lack of regard for, and mass exploitation of, the working and poorer classes. In the general context, those climbing the social ladder are "slowly going white,"³⁷ and in instances of rapid change in social status, the white ideal becomes poetic: "Some people are born white/Some achieve whiteness/And some have whiteness thrust upon them."³⁸

The aspiration to whiteness is necessary, because those at the lower end of the social ladder are the "most Black" and "anything too Black nuh good."³⁹ In this way the thrust to be "somebody" is polarized by the thrust to be "smaddy"—human; and the huge gap between the "somebodies" and the "smaddies"⁴⁰ is testament to the fact that "Africa and Blackness . . . don't necessarily carry an emancipatory impulse."⁴¹

The current discourse on "smadditization" is, to date, the most compelling articulation of the Caribbean racial situation. Mills argues convincingly that "if there is a single word that encapsulates the many dimensions of struggle of those historically subordinated in the Caribbean, it is the Jamaican creole term 'smadditizin.'"⁴² Accordingly, "smadditization," as a Caribbean ontological process, defines the "struggle for, the insistence on, personhood, more accurately . . . the struggle to have one's personhood recognized in a world where primarily because of race, it is denied."⁴³ This political, cultural, moral, epistemological, and metaphysical struggle resists "whiteness" as a "deprivileging" and denigration of the Black body; and the consequent extermination of the Black spirit. To the extent that the Black person is Black only in relation to the white person,⁴⁴ the Black person's aspiration and/or consent to whiteness as the human ideal is a movement away from the body, a going out of the body, this out-of-body experience is a loss of Spirit. Conversely, "[s]madditization as the affirmation of Black

humanity is always an 'inbodied' experience in which 'one is not lifted out of, but lifted into one's body.'⁴⁵ It is the re-creation and re-incarnation of self through the re-privileging of the Black body and restoration of the Black spirit.

I employ Caribbean cultural discourse to make the point that smadditization as the affirmation of Black humanity is essentially a spiritual process. African spirituality is part and parcel of Caribbean and diasporan existence. African spirituality is not a Sunday affair—a once a week attendance of worship service. It is a way of life—a way of being—informed and constrained by other social and cultural forces. As C. Eric Lincoln offers in the preface to Barrett's *Soul-Force*:

The Black man's pilgrimage in America was made less onerous because of his religion. His religion was the organizing principle around which his life was structured. His church was his school, his forum, his political area, his social club, his art gallery, his conservatory of music. It was lyceum and gymnasium as well as *sanctum sanctorum*. His religion was his fellowship with man, his audience with God. It was the peculiar sustaining force which gave him the strength to endure when endurance gave no promise, and the courage to be creative in the face of his own dehumanization.⁴⁶

It is the spirit-centered religious traditions—those consciously and unconsciously involved in "working the spirit," such as the Native Baptists, Kumina and Rastafari, that are most engaged in the process of smadditization. Smadditization is a sociocultural religious process concerned with spiritual well-being. Accordingly, within the Caribbean context, the task of defining the Black church is appropriately placed within the discourse on smadditization. In this way, we conceptualize Blackness, not as phenotype, but as *theotype*—a consciousness of, and engagement with, God as indwelling and liberating spirit. In this sense, Blackness becomes conceptualized as the dynamic spirituality of the systematically oppressed⁴⁷ and references a particular quality of spirit—a spirit defined by the continual affirmation of its humanity,⁴⁸ evidenced and confirmed by recurring incarnation. Blackness then as diasporic ethos is an awareness and experience of the ontological re/construction of the dehumanized and oppressed self. It is a conscious expression of cultural solidarity and "stands for all victims of oppression who realize that the survival of their humanity is bound up with liberation from whiteness."⁴⁹

The Black church in the Caribbean is therefore less about ecclesiastical institutions peopled by Africans and descendants of Africans and more about ecclesiastical institutions that are actively engaged in smadditization. This Caribbean Black Church is peopled by theotypes—individuals who understand, appreciate, celebrate, and live the dynamism, multiplicity, and vitality of Spirit that continually defines and sustains the "most" Black among us. The Caribbean Black church is that *body* engaged in *enspiritment*, not "spirit thievery."⁵⁰ It is a consequence and fact of the continued legacy of colonialism and neocolonialism that the enspiritment of Caribbean people occurs not in the established orthodox churches, but in those organizations that are either African, African-derived, or African-centered.

Black Church Studies in the Caribbean context must have as central to its aims and objectives a disciplined engagement with Afri-oriented religious traditions. It must foster research and education in African spiritualities. It must be committed to the process of smadditization, and it must affirm the Spirit-centered Christian experience of Caribbean peoples. For too long, religious studies scholars have neglected to give positive scholarly attention to these traditions. What is required then is a changing of the definition of the Caribbean Church—a reconceptualization that is consistent with Caribbean reality. Central to this redefinition is an appreciation for the transformative impact of ARTs on Christianity. It is an understanding of the role of Spirit as an essential element of Christian faith, the experience of Spirit as a liberating force in Christian life and "freedom to catch the Spirit" as the gift of Christ to the Church.

"Freedom to Catch the Spirit": The Black Church in the Caribbean

The Caribbean Black church, as a Christian institution, refers to the community of believers who participate in the varied and various modes of *Spirit-centered Christ-related* worship, proclamation, and experience. It is a life of communion with God through a spiritual sacrament that expresses spiritual fulfillment not as an abstracted morality but rather as an active relationship. The Caribbean Black church as a way of being in liberating communion with Spirit therefore represents the multiple spiritualities, which exist in an easy tension without and within the mainline orthodox churches. The Caribbean Black church incorporates the Holy Spirit into the body of Spirits (ancestors, deities, divinities, essences, energies) as Pentecostal power to inspire, transform, and renew. These Christian traditions create a space in which Caribbean people who want to worship "in spirit and truth" are free to "catch the spirit." The academic study of the Caribbean Black church must therefore have as its main focus these Spirit-centered religious traditions that define the Christ-related worship of the great majority.

In his historical treatment of the Church in the Anglophone Caribbean, Dayfoot,⁵¹ while acknowledging the variations in ecclesiastical institutions, argues that belief in Christ demonstrated in "Christ-centred worship, proclamation, teaching, fellowship, pastoral help and social concern," are constitutive of the West Indian church. He notes further that the Church, as a "movement of people who profess Christian faith is not united in its understanding of that faith," with even less appreciation for the social implications of their faith.⁵² Dayfoot's account of the West Indian church however, gives primacy to "those churches which lay claim to traditional Christian orthodoxy" and while he notes that ARTs challenged the definition of Christian faith, they are seen more as "part of the environment within which the West Indian Church been shaped,"⁵³ rather than constitutive of it. The "orthodox" treatment of the Christian church in the Caribbean is exemplified by *The Shaping of the West-Indian Church*, as the de-privileging of African sources and voices that is an account from the perspective of the colonial ruling class. Black Christianity is either omitted, given scant treatment, or where extensive treatment is given, more often than not, demonized.⁵⁴ In the Caribbean today, Theresa Lowe Chin reminds us that orthodox Christianity continues to be a significant influence on Christian practice and theology that is characterized by "a lack of serious concrete engagement . . . in the struggles of the oppressed poor and marginated of the region towards personal and societal transformation."⁵⁵

I posit that Black Christianity is constitutive of, not peripheral to, the Caribbean church. As Nettleford observes, while Europe reigns, "Africa rules in the on-going assertion of faith in some Black or African soul-force among the mass of people who, though present in the congregation of the orthodox Christian denominations, continue to be the source of . . . indigenous forms [and] religious expression."⁵⁶ In my focus on the Christian traditions within the Caribbean Black church, I acknowledge the importance of Christ as one of many *organizing principles* of the Church, but privilege those ecclesiastical institutions that are characterized by traditional African religion. This conceptualization articulates the Caribbean Black church as a *Myal movement* that has its roots in the Christian-Myalism⁵⁷ of the 1860s. I use the term "movement" to signal the dynamism of these Diasporan religious traditions that continue to be shaped by the particular historical moment in which they exist.

This position is consistent with McPherson's, who argues for a broader conceptualization of the Black church, as expressions/emanations of *Obeah*. For him, the Black church(es), which is synonymous with African religion, is "a symbol of an evolved 'ethical alternative' by exiled Africans to white racism, white theology, Euro-Western Christianity."⁵⁸ The Christian Black church as a Christian-Myalism, in regions like Jamaica, forms part of the larger framework of the Black church as "emanations of Obeah," or what Dianne Stewart refers to as "spiritual-aesthetic repertoires [which] provide identity structures of meaning as well as therapeutic

resources for overcoming the colonialist project." The Black church is thus broadly defined and includes the independent Black denominations of Pentecostal, Baptist, and Wesleyan persuasions. This Caribbean Black church also includes non-Christian religions involved in the "smadditization" of Caribbean peoples.

The correspondence between African religion and Christianity in so many Caribbean societies demands the inclusion of the manifold traditions that straddle both religious orientations. Among them are Spiritual and Shouter Baptists, Native Baptists-Revival Zion (Poco or Pocomania), Shakers/Converted, Jordanites, Rastafari, Vodun, Kumina, Candomblé, Kele, Orisha, Santería, and Espiritismo. The connection between orthodox mainstream Christian expressions and this eclectic body of religious traditions is most evident in the Spiritual/Shouter Baptist, Native Baptist-Revival Zion, and Shaker/Converted traditions and the corresponding migration of Black Christian bodies and people from the Southeastern United States to the Caribbean region. The most popular and perhaps influential example is the late eighteenth-century mission of George Liele, the African American Baptist preacher who inaugurated the Baptist tradition in Jamaica. During the early nineteenth century, African American Christian migrants also shaped the formation of the African-oriented churches in the eastern and southern Caribbean where the "freedom to catch the spirit" was the most salient feature uniting these fledgling traditions and positioning them along a continuum of spirit-driven religious formation with African-derived traditions such as Vodun, Kumina, Orisha/Santería, and Candomblé.

Moreover, with the emphasis upon liberation ethics and praxis in Black Church Studies, it is imperative to underscore how this "freedom to catch the spirit," which characterizes the Caribbean Black Church, and which is found in ecclesiastical institutions such as Jamaican Revivalism, Trinidad's Shouter Baptists, and the Converted of St. Vincent, is the legacy of the historical impulse that ensured emancipation from slavery. These Native Baptist religions are seen as representative of African-derived religions in the Caribbean. Much has been written about the Liele Mission to the Caribbean in the eighteenth century. I want to emphasize here that these Native Baptists had their origins in the breakaway tradition of the "Shouting Methodists" and "Separate Baptists" whose separation from the orthodox churches was based on the need for freedom of expressive worship. In these meetings people were prone to "crying-out . . . falling down as in fits, and awakening in ecstasies; [with] both ministers and people [having] impulses, visions and revelations."⁵⁹ In these liberated congregations, worshippers were free to "catch the spirit" as evidenced in the uncensored tears, trembling, screams, shouts, and exclamations that defined religious meetings.

In *Religion and Race: African and European Roots in Jamaican Testament*, Lawson notes that "the followers of George Lisle and other Native Baptists called themselves 'spirit Baptists' because of their deeply held cultural belief in the power of their faith and practice to authenticate their lives and advance their position" while in bondage. Noting further that "native Christian beliefs and practices were often indistinguishable from Myal practices"; Lawson states that

[I]t is a fact of history, in the Caribbean in general, and certainly in Jamaica, that there was a constant proliferation of break-away religious sects inside and outside of the Mission Churches. The constantly distinguishing factor was their amalgamation of the best features of African religion and Western Christianity for the purpose of meeting their spiritual, psychological, social and political needs in the alien context of wholesale oppression.⁶⁰

This combination of the best of both worlds meant that the elasticity of African religion could incorporate the spirit of the Christianity trinity with the Pentecostal intensity that gave birth to the Church. Additionally, other spirits could be utilized with the same intensity as healing powers. In "Revival and Black Struggle," Chevannes offers that for Native Baptists

the major God was not Jesus Christ as the white missionaries preached. Higher than Jesus was John the Baptist, who baptized him. *Highest of all was the Spirit*. The Spirit was sought in dreams and visions. He alone gave life, he alone supplied knowledge, faith and repentance, all without the agency of the written word.⁶¹

(emphasis mine.)

Accordingly, I argue that ARTs were more than “a challenge to [the] study and understanding, as well as definition of the essentials of the Christian faith.” In fact, in many ways, African religion became synonymous with Christianity. African religions transformed Christianity into a liberating force for the oppressed, through the privileging of what Christians reference as the “discernment of spirits.”

The reality and immediacy of spirits and the spiritual realm for Afri-centered religious practitioners means that spiritual discernment is as important as it is automatic. Calling on the Holy Spirit and other spirits to lead or give direction in matters of importance is part and parcel of a spirit-centered existence. The first tenet of African spirituology describes a system of thought centered on Spirit. All African-derived religions (ADRs) share this centering of Spirit that is evidenced in the multiplicity of Spiritual entities as well as the intensity and frequency of spirit possession. The faculty to create, appreciate, communicate with, manifest, and use spirit beings represents an orientation toward the spirit world. This spirituology of ADRs references a particular world of ideas and images; of subtle energies and mystical forces—a spiritual world, initiated by, populated with, and centered on Spirit. Metraux captures, for example, the centrality of spiritual chaos in Haitian Vodou. He writes that

To construct a Voodoo theology out of the infinitely varied, often contradictory and fragmentary notions of the supernatural world held by Voodoo adepts, is no easy task. The confusion which exists in this field is made worse by the absence of any attempt to reconcile the traditional African attitudes to gods and spirits with the teaching of the Catholic Church—a teaching which is nevertheless “accepted” without. God, Jesus Christ, the Virgin and the Saints are more or less relegated to the background of religious life while spirits, great and small, invade every ceremony and monopolize the attention of the faithful.⁶²

The principal aim of most ADR ceremonies and rituals is the manifestation of spirits, and this “working the Spirit” as well as other experiences with Spirit represents the existence and use of specialized knowledge. The spirits are made to re/present themselves to individuals through divine revelation and become manifest through praise, hymns, prayers, dance, drumming, and other ritual forms. African-derived religious spirituology constitutes spirit mastery, a type of ordered chaos, which in “repeating” the chaos of the macrocosmic society becomes the very means of surviving/transcending it, for it constitutes what Stewart calls recurring incarnation: the repeated “concrete embodiment of the Divine or ancestor for the benefit of the human community.” In reiterating this “incarnational emphasis” as characteristic of African-derived religions, Stewart affirms “reflection on pneumatology (Spirit) as a theological priority over reflection on Christology.”⁶³

In describing the belief system of the Shango Cult in Trinidad, Simpson⁶⁴ simply lists the gods of the religion. Of the Orisas, also known as “powers,” Oya, Osain, Obatala, Raphael, Mama Latay, and Shakpana were among the most favored, besides Shango from whom the cult derives its name. He discusses the personality of the Orisas in addition to the other category of beings such as the “evil powers” of Kaballah, the *Sukuyans* or *Legawus*, blood-sucking witches who fly at night and, the Dead, which has two special categories, *dwine* and *diablesles*. Simpson then discusses the importance of spiritual proscriptions, dreams, and visions as well as the centrality of spirit possession. Houk⁶⁵ states that the most significant event in the Orisha religion is “the manifestation of an orisha,” and this quest for recurring incarnation is repeated throughout the ADRs.

In the case of Jamaican Revivalism, the Grenadian Converters, and Trinidadian Spiritual Baptist traditions, the beliefs and structure are founded on ideas "about the Divine Community, the Ancestors, and the relationship among forces, spirits, elements and beings in the visible and invisible domains of the world."⁶⁶ Although these religious practitioners hold the Christian deity as supreme, he is considered remote and aloof, and humans can interact with him indirectly through lesser spirits. It is these lesser spirits, as well as the "spi/ritual"⁶⁷ forces of the earth, sea and air that characterize the religion and therefore figure prominently in the daily lives of adherents. It is no wonder then that it is the multitude of deities, personalities, and spirits more than any other aspect of Christianity that has been incorporated into Revivalism. Revivalism, like other African-derived religions, is able to, through its all embracing and elastic polytheism, "accommodate the Christian trinity, the Angels and Saints, the Prophets and the Apostles, combining these . . . with the spirits including the ancestral dead, and even with the diabolical host."⁶⁸ The multiplicity of spiritual entities, spiritual behaviors, and spiritual experiences in Revivalism makes for a complex theology and entry into the religion is signaled by sensitivity and receptivity to Spirit. Every detail of religious life and the greater part of a believer's personal life is dictated by spirits so that the Spirit is implicated and/or represented in every aspect of existence.

African Spirituology is evidenced in the visionary, cognitive, narrative, and metaphorical elements of African-derived religions. The narrative and metaphorical function is seen in the history and tradition of a "spiritual people" who do "spiritual work" through "spiritual science" through the use of a "language of spirit" that extends to "gifts of the spirits" such as "speaking in tongues" and "spirit writing" as well as sacred texts that include spiritually symbolic gestures, touches, clothing, and emblems. The cognitive aspect of the Revival, Spiritual Baptists, and Converted traditions is a spirit-based theology, which arises from visionary manifestations as expressed in the explicit and deliberate movement to experience divine revelation in the form of dreams, visions, trance, and possession. For the Caribbean's Afri-oriented religions, spirituality is a way of life and this fact commits Caribbean Black Church Studies to the exposition and affirmation of *Spirit Theology*.

Spirit Theology: Toward the Liberation of Caribbean Theology

There must be an extension by *the society-at-large* (and throughout *the Americas*) of the "plutocratic-vision"/"plurality of vision"—to the spiritual realms.⁶⁹

Caribbean Theology as Missionary Theology has been "At the Crossroads" for much too long. Attempts to raise it "Out of the Depths" by anchoring ourselves in "Real Roots and (eschewing) Potted Plants" has met with minimal success. We have not actively taken up the challenge of "Decolonizing Theology," and so regrettably, "Emancipation Still Comin'." It is now *Spirit-Time*, time for us to take "Three Eyes for the Journey" into a radical *rew/riteing* of Caribbean theology. This *rew/riteing* of Caribbean theology is a transformative ritual of engagement with the Spirit⁷⁰ and is therefore the liberation of Caribbean theology. While many theologians have made useful contributions to the discourse, there have only been a few voices crying in the wilderness,⁷¹ and Caribbean theologians, for the most part, have become white-collar criminals engaged in spiritual malpractice. The Eurocentric bias of Caribbean theology is what Ashley Smith notes as a misguided overcommitment to what we are not and should not be.⁷² Caribbean theologians have been faithful to a self-defeating religiosity. In their protracted commitment to white theology they have been serving the wrong master. Caribbean theologians must in the words of James Cone "begin to hate their whiteness, asking from the depths of their being: How can we become Black?" The answer to this question must be that since we live by the Spirit we must theologize by the Spirit.

I want to be clear: *Spirit Theology* is not the same as Spiritual Theology. While there exists much debate about what it means to be spiritual and what constitutes Spiritual Theology,⁷³ Spiritual Theology is understood generally as the specialization in moral theology “which defines the nature of the supernatural life, formulates the laws of its growth, and explains the process by which souls advance from the beginning of the spiritual life to its full perfection.”⁷⁴ Within this construct “spirituality,” an equally contested formulation, is understood as “the existential attitude of man which is the consequence and expression of the way in which he understands his religious—or more generally, his ethically committed existence.”⁷⁵

As noted before, Afri-oriented religious practitioners do not engage with Spirit as an individualistic rational abstraction, they engage with Spirit as a life force, as a recurring incarnation. In *Thirsty for God*, Holt offers that African spirituality “include[s] an affirmation of life in this world as well as beyond the grave; the role of the living dead in the communion of saints; the importance of healing; and the presence of the Spirit to work in power.”⁷⁶ While some Afri-oriented religions continue to mask African religion with various elements of Christianity, religious practice is characterized by the general incorporation of the host of spirit beings with a privileging of the Holy Spirit. Spirituality then becomes a personal relationship with God, the community, the self, and the universe. It includes responsibility for, and to, others and is inherently and self-consciously therapeutic. African spirituality as a “science of the Spirit” is manifest healing. Spirit Theology is therefore the disciplined reflection on the experience of God as healing Spirit, and Caribbean theology cannot be considered theology until it concerns itself with indigenous ways of knowing God.

Spirit Theology is concerned with the existence, nature, and form of a spirit-centered religious life. This spirit-talk is the affirmation and development (and in some senses, refinement) of existing lay theology. Spirit Theology is a disciplined approach to African Spirituology—the spiritual science used to create, manipulate, and transform Spirit. Accordingly, it must concern itself with the basic tenets of African Spirituology, namely, theology, epistemology, mediation, transformation, and healing. A Spirit Theology would not engage itself with the racist project of “sorting out spirituality”⁷⁷ but would instead be committed to the understanding of “Spirit” as a multiple, complex, and infinite body of supernatural beings, aspects of the human being, as well as the ritual. It must endeavor to analyze the conceptualization of Spirit as a collective term used to indicate vital force as well as spirit beings and entities. In this way, Caribbean theology will itself become constitutive of African Spirituology—it will become involved in Spirit Mastery—Spirit Manipulation, Spirit Manifestation, and Spirit Mediumship. Spirit Theology is the gift of the Caribbean to the Christian church. It is an expansive pneumatological vision that recognizes that although “spirituality” is not necessarily Christian or universally homogenous, it always involves a responsibility to community. Spirit Theology reflects the open-ended nature of African Spirituology that allows for the incorporation of other spiritualities. The “spirit of the living God,” multiple and infinite, can always “fall afresh” as therapeutic empowerment of the faithful to overcome life’s challenges.

Caribbean theologians must be willing to give “the spirit of the living God” the freedom to “fall afresh” so that we may be transformed by the renewing of our minds. For *our* sakes let us offer our bodies as living sacrifices so that we may possess and manifest spirit, prayerfully beseeching “break me, melt me, mold me, fill me.” Let us affirm and use the spiritual repertoires bestowed on us by our ancestors. Let Caribbean Black Church Studies be defined by its uniform condemnation of Afrophobia and anti-Africanness and its uniform affirmation of afrophilia and enspiritment. Let Black Church Studies be engaged in the decolonizing process of emancipation and the liberating process of smadditization. The Black Theological imperative is the only way forward for Caribbean Theology. A radical rew/riteing of Caribbean theology is necessary, that the words of our mouths and the meditation of our hearts be acceptable, righteous, transformative, and liberating.

Notes

1. Arthur Dayfoot, *The Shaping of the West-Indian Church, 1492–1962*. (Barbados University of the West Indies Press, 1999), 185. It is instructive that Christian theologians continue to see African and other indigenous religious traditions as “challenges to the Church.” The Lutheran Church’s recent publications titled *Ancestors, Spirits and Healing in Africa and Asia: A Challenge to the Church*, and *Spirits, Ancestors and Healing: A Global Challenge to the Church* are two such examples. These publications in some respects represent a step forward for Christian theology because it begins by seeking to understand the concept of Spirit as experienced by non-Christian religious traditions, even if it maintains its Christian bias.
2. A female Revival healer is referred to as “Mother” (Modda) and the healing vocation seen generally as a form of mothering. See William Wedenoja, “Mothering and the Practice of ‘Balm’ in Jamaica,” in Carol Shepherd McClain, ed., *Women as Healers in Cross-Cultural Perspectives*, (New Brunswick and London: Rutgers University Press, 1989), 76–97
3. “You have to work in the Spirit, the Spirit has me working hard.”
4. Refusing to answer the healer is a direct insult to the spirit messenger/s who “works” with him; and a more general disrespect for the spiritual force or power that characterizes *Balm*. To displease the Spirit is detrimental for they may refuse to assist in healing the offender, and may in fact punish her by causing further affliction.
5. “Are you in the Spirit or is the Spirit in you?”
6. “The spirit was not right, I felt like I was upside down.” This expression indicates that the afflicted was an embodiment of spiritual malevolence. Going around her twice is a Balm counteraction ritual where an afflicted individual is circled in an anti-clockwise direction to clear the way for further healing to occur. This is also referred to as one type of “cutting and clearing.” Balm is the major form of folk healing in Jamaica, and is practice by Revivalists.
7. Rawle Gibbons, “Syncretism and Secretism in the Manifestation of African Spirituality,” in B. Sankarelli, ed., *At the Crossroads: African Caribbean Religion and Christianity* (St. James, Trinidad: Caribbean Council of Churches 1995), 67–85.
8. *Ibid.*, 67
9. Leonard Barrett, *Soul-force: African Heritage in Afro-American Religion* (Garden City, NY: Anchor Press, 1974), 2.
10. See Gayraud Wilmore’s “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” *Christian Century* 96, Vol. 13 (1979), 411–413 for a discussion of this bias in Black Church Studies.
11. *Ibid.*, 411
12. Charles Shelby Rooks, *Revolution in Zion: Reshaping African American Ministry, 1968–1974* (New York: Pilgrim Press, 1990), 136.
13. Gayraud Wilmore, “Tension Points in Black Church Studies,” 411.
14. *Ibid.*, 411–412.
15. Peter J. Paris, “The Ethics of African American Religious Scholarship,” *Journal of the American Academy of Religion*, Vol. LXIV, no. 3 (1996), 493–497, 495.
16. James H. Evans, “I Rose and Found My Voice: Black Church Studies and Theological Education,” *Theological Education*, Vol. 21 (Spring 1985), 49–72, 71.
17. *Ibid.*, 71–72.
18. James H. Cone, *A Black Theology of Liberation* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1990), xvii
19. *Ibid.*, xvii
20. Ashley Smith, “Mainline Churches in the Caribbean: Their Relationship to the Cultural and Political Process,” *Caribbean Journal of Religious Studies* Vol. 9, no. 2 (1988), 27–40, 29.
21. *Ibid.*, 26
22. United Theological College of the West Indies. Pamphlet. 2007.
23. *Ibid.*
24. Eric Springsted posits that Christian theology is not properly defined as such unless it is seen as constituted by and constitutive of Christian spirituality. As such, any theology that neglects spirituality is “largely a matter of *pretheological reflection*, a getting ready to do theology.” See

Spirituality and Theology: Essays in Honor of Diogenes Allen (Louisville, Kentucky: Westminster John Knox Press, 1998), 2.

25. Dianne Stewart uses the term "Afrophobia" to define the "hatred and fear of that which is African and of being associated with things and peoples African." Anti-Africanness is a less pernicious bias against things and peoples African. See *Three Eyes for the Journey: African Dimensions of the Jamaican Religious Experience* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 43.
26. Ashley Smith posits that the "dominant motifs of the theology of the conquerors or the 'Great House,' in the Caribbean, are control or containment and conservation." The other-worldly eschatology which had the effect of "creating in the recipients a passive dependent mentality." See "Mainline Churches in the Caribbean: Their Relationship to the Cultural and Political Process," *Caribbean Journal of Religious Studies* Vol. 9 no. 2 (1988), 27–40, 29.
27. Rawle Gibbons, "Syncretism and Secretism in the Manifestation of African Spirituality," 82.
28. Franklin Knight, *Race, Ethnicity, & Class: Forging the Plural Society in Latin America and the Caribbean* (Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 1996), 21.
29. Dennis Scott, "To Be Liberated from the Obscurity of Themselves": An Interview with Rex Nettleford," *Small Axe* Vol. 20 (2006), 97–246
30. See Kamau Braithwaite's *Contradictory Omens: Cultural Diversity and Integration in the Caribbean* (Kingston, Jamaica: Savacou Publications, 1985).
31. Rex Nettleford, *Caribbean Cultural Identity: The Case of Jamaica* (Kingston, Jamaica: Institute of Jamaica, 1978), 9
32. See Kamau Braithwaite's *Contradictory Omens*.
33. Dennis Scott, "To Be Liberated From the Obscurity of Themselves," 203.
34. Dianne Austin-Broos, "Race/Class: Jamaica's Discourse of Heritable Identity," *New West Indian Guide*, Vol. 68, no. 3 & 4 (1994), 213–234, 231.
35. Dennis Scott, "To Be Liberated From the Obscurity of Themselves," 204.
36. Everybody wants to be a Slave Master. This identity denotes the conspicuous ownership of property and people; as well as the ability to exercise undue force and/or control.
37. Mervyn Morris, "Poem To an Expatriate Friend," *Shadow Boxing* (London: New Beacon Books, Ltd, 1979), 64.
38. Said of former Prime Minister Percival Noel James Patterson upon the People's National Party winning the general election of 1992
39. Any person who is too Black (in color) and/or too African (in disposition) is inherently morally corrupt.
40. My use of the term differs from Nettleford's and Mill's. I differentiate between "somebody" as a person of high social status and "smaddy" as the opposite to point out that the "smadditization" impulse of the 1970s, while not a total failure, has to a less than desirable degree produced the "roast breadfruit" class of Black-skinned slave masters.
41. Dennis Scott, "To Be Liberated From the Obscurity of Themselves."
42. Charles Mills. "Smadditizin'" *Caribbean Quarterly* Vol. 43 no. 2 (1997), 54–68, 54.
43. *Ibid.*, 55
44. See Frantz Fanon, *Black Skin, White Masks* (New York: Grove Press, 1967.)
45. Charles Mills, "Smadditizin,'" 66.
46. See the preface to Barrett *Soul Force*, (Garden City, NY: Anchor Press, 1974).
47. Kortright Davis, *Emancipation Still Comin': Explorations in Caribbean Theology* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1990), 117–118.
48. It must be mentioned that given the historical dehumanization of Africans and their descendants, there is a persistent need for recurring incarnation.
49. Cone, *A Black Theology of Liberation*, 7
50. Spirit Thievery defines the characteristic feature of the colonial mission—a religious imperialism aimed at exorcising and replacing the African essence that is spirit. This "soul-sucking" identity theft continues unabated in the orthodox churches of the Caribbean. See Erna Brodber's *Myal* for an instructive portrayal of spirit theivery in the Jamaican context.

51. Arthur Dayfoot, *The Shaping of the West-Indian Church, 1492–1962*. (Barbados: University of the West Indies Press 1999).
52. *Ibid.*, 4–5
53. *Ibid.*, 4
54. While Dayfoot's treatment might not be seen as constituting demonization *per se*, his unwillingness to engage with African traditional religion as more than peripheral to orthodox Christianity is equally problematic.
55. Theresa Lowe Chin, "Latin American Theological Method and its Relevance to Caribbean Theology," *Caribbean Journal of Religious Studies*, Vol. 12, no. 1 (1991), 4–28, 26.
56. Rex Nettleford, *Caribbean Cultural Identity*, 19.
57. See Dianne Stewart, *Three Eyes for the Journey*. The term "Christian-myalism" is used as a means of privileging African religion in the Christian construction of African-derived religions.
58. E. S. P. McPherson, *From the Black Churches: A Historiographic Taxonomy of Religions in Jamaica: Book One* (A & B Book Distribution Inc., 2000), 83.
59. Winthrop S. Hudson, "The American Context as an Area for Research in Black Church Studies," *Church History*, Vol. 52, No. 2 (1983), 157–171, 161.
60. Winston Arthur Lawson, *Religion and Race: African and European Roots in Jamaican Testament* (New York: Peter Lang Publishing, 1996), 106.
61. Barry Chevannes, "Revival and Black Struggle," *Savacou* Vol. 5 (1971), 27–37, 29.
62. A. Métraux, *Voodoo in Haiti* (London: Kessinger Publishing, 1972)
63. Dianne Stewart, "Womanist Theology in the Caribbean Context: Critiquing Culture, Rethinking Doctrine and Expanding Boundaries," *Journal of Feminist Studies in Religion*, Vol. 20, no. 1 (2004), 61–82, 74 and 77.
64. George Simpson, *Black Religions in the New World* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1978).
65. J. T. Houk, *Spirits, Blood, and Drums: The Orisha Religion in Trinidad* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1995).
66. Dianne Stewart, *Three Eyes for the Journey*, 107.
67. The term spi/ritual is used to indicate spirit as the essence of ritual, as well as general sense of spiritual as concerning spirits and/or the sacred.
68. Edward Seaga, "Revival Cults in Jamaica: Notes Toward Sociology of Religion," *Jamaica Journal*, Vol. 3 (1969), 3–15.
69. *Ibid.*, xxxvi.
70. Malidoma Somé defines ritual as "a technology for accessing the spirits." See: *Power, Healing and Community* (New York: Penguin Group, 1993)
71. These liberating voices as the above publication titles indicate include Lewin Williams, Kortright Davis, Noel Erskine, Ashley Smith, Idris Hamid, Burton Sankerilli, and Dianne Stewart.
72. See Ashley Smith, *Pentecostalism in Jamaica: A Challenge to the Established Churches and Society* (Mandeville, Jamaica: Eureka Press Limited, 1973).
73. See for example, Owen Thomas, "Some Problems in Contemporary Christian Spirituality," *Anglican Theological Review*, Vol. 82, no. 2 (2000), 397–415 and Bradley Hanson, "Spirituality as Spiritual Theology," in Bradley C. Hanson, ed., *Modern Christian Spirituality: Methodological and Historical Essays* (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1990), 45–52.
74. Jordan Aumann, *Spiritual Theology* (New York: Continuum, 2006), 22. The debate has led to alternative and broader formulation of spiritual theology as, for example, "disciplined theological reflection of the source, nature, and shape of the Christian life in the Holy Spirit." Robert Davis Hughes, "Starting Over: The Holy Spirit as Subject and Locus of Spiritual Theology." *ATR* 83, no. 3 (2001), 455–472.
75. Jordan Aumann. "Spiritual Theology".
76. Bradley P. Holt, *Thirsty for God: A Brief History of Christian Spirituality*, second edition (Kitchener, Ontario: Augsburg Fortress Publishers, 2005), 193
77. Stephen Jennings, "Sorting Out Spirituality in Jamaica: Pluralism and Particularities in Caribbean Theological Reality," *Caribbean Journal of Religious Studies*, Vol. 15, no. 1 (1994),

3–21. Here a misguided Jennings argues that persons who attend both orthodox Christian and Afro-Christian churches suffer from “spiritual schizophrenia” and need to “sort out their spirituality.”

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“Out of the Bitter Sea”: The Black Church and Migration in North America

Carol B. Duncan

Introduction

In the poem “Testament,” Africadian (African-Nova Scotian) poet and literary studies scholar George Elliott Clarke describes the arrival “out of the bitter sea” of enslaved Africans forcibly transplanted, through the transatlantic Middle Passage, from Africa to North America.¹ “Testament” describes the experience of displacement, exile, and religious construction and reconstruction of Black Christianity with reference to the life experiences of Black people as enslaved within an economic and political system justified by racialized segregation. By the poem’s third and final movement, a Black Christianity, referenced as “my book of songs,” created through the struggle of African ancestors, the “Beautiful Ones,” is proudly claimed as remembrance, inheritance, and proclamation. Simultaneously, the final refrain signals a diasporic yearning rooted in historical connections to Africa and cultural displacement of being Black in North America in “looking eastward [to Africa], ever dreaming, ever wanting.” This poem in its three-part movement from birth of an African American religious consciousness through the Middle Passage and slavery, to religious formation and creation of cultural traditions, to diasporic yearning for community rooted in Africa describes the emergence of Black Christian experiences in North America as fundamentally shaped by experiences of migration.

In this chapter, I highlight the ways in which migration has shaped the development of Black churches in North America. I stress the need to look both north and south of the border, the 49th parallel that separates Canada and the United States to include both Canada and the United States, in discussing Black Christian experiences. Political, economic, and cultural ties connect Canada, the United States, the Caribbean, Latin America, Western Europe, and Africa through a series of transatlantic journeys including the slave trade, the Underground Railroad, and post–Second World War migration, which continues to impact the development of Black churches on four continents. The “Black church” is what British sociologist Paul Gilroy would call a “Black Atlantic” phenomenon. By definition it should include a plurality of experiences, and yet so often our vision as scholars and students of Black Church Studies is structured by our

municipal, regional, and national boundaries so that we may forget to include the transnational as an integral component of Black Christian experiences and church development.

My basic premise, therefore, is that the idea that there is a monolithic Black church formed in the continental United States over the last 200 years needs to be seriously interrogated. In its place perspectives that encourage investigation and awareness of international linkages across national borderlines should be encouraged. Contemporary patterns of migration extend notions of “the Black church” across international geopolitical, linguistic, and cultural borders as Black people from Africa, the Caribbean, South America, and Western Europe migrate to North America and other areas of the world and encounter each other and the wider society in both sacred and secular contexts. Using historical and contemporary examples from Black churches in Canada, I will explore the usefulness of a transnational perspective in the field of Black Church Studies. My conclusion offers some broader suggestions for the field and further methodological questions for consideration.

Blackness in Canada

In Pearleen Oliver’s *Song of the Spirit: An Historical Narrative on the History of the Beechville United Baptist Church*, the author describes African-Nova Scotian (Africadian) Baptist history as “the Divine intervention of God in the deliverance of a remnant of Afro-American slaves to the cold and rocky shores of Nova Scotia.”² Furthermore the author’s poem “Introduction,”³ in which she describes the founders of the African Baptist Association as “The escaped slave Preston and the Welshman Thomas/ [Leading] the way through the wooded wilderness” of Beech hill Baptist Church (1861–1874), squarely places them in Canada. When asked “about the severity of the cold in baptizing in winter,” he supposedly replied, “No, I love the cause too well; and when I have a cold and go into the Baptismal waters, my cold all leaves me”⁴ And lastly, Oliver characterizes the congregation’s history as moving “From the torturous slave fields of the Southern United States to the chilly woodlands of Nova Scotia.”⁵

What these excerpts show is that African Canadian Baptists recognized their northern environment and placed themselves within it. In Willard Parker Clayton’s *Whatever Your Will, Lord: A Brief History Written in Commemoration of the 139th Anniversary of Emmanuel Baptist Church, Upper Hammonds Plains, Nova Scotia* (Hantsport, NS: Lancelot Press, 1984), he reports, “The elder folk still reminded one of the many who were baptized in the dead of winter; the ice being cut so the lake could be used.”⁶

These historical references serve as an appropriate metaphor to describe the early development of Black Christianity in a Canadian context for it points to the continuity and influence of an African American theological heritage, which positioned Christ as intimately interested and involved in the concerns of Black people, while being sensitive to the location of Canada, in northern North America with reference to one of the quintessential (and in some instances, stereotypical) markers of Canadian topography and climate: ice.

The Omission of Blackness

As an African Canadian researcher of Black religious experience, my introduction to the field of Black Church Studies situated it as a continental US phenomenon. If at all discussed in a Canadian context, what was referred to as “the Black church” was often presented as a historical phenomenon brought to Canada by formerly enslaved Black people, who then recreated the religion of the praisehouse, the so-called “invisible institution”⁷ of the US antebellum south as a mechanism of survival and community development under harsh conditions of racial segregation in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries in Canada.⁸ Contemporary Black churches

in Canada, until recently, have received very little popular representation.⁹ This lack of representation is part and parcel of a larger erasure of Black community experiences in popular representations of Canada both within the country and abroad. It is not an uncommon experience for African Canadians whose families go back nine or ten or more generations to be asked, "Where are you from?" or "What island are you from?" or "Where are you from, *originally*?" if the answer to the first two questions resulted in the naming of a Canadian region or city.¹⁰ These questions are based on the common presumption of blackness as fundamentally outside of Canada as a nation. In many ways it is as if in answer to the question, "Will the real Black people stand up?" all eyes are trained south of the 49, suggesting that those of us in northern North America are illegitimate heirs to blackness, Black cultural heritage, and by extension Black religiosity.

Why is this the case? The answer resides in the fact that mainstream representations of blackness in Canada have largely been presented in popular cultural contexts as "American," and rooted, geographically, in the United States. Blackness, from this perspective, in all of its cultural expressions, is fundamentally an "American" phenomenon in its most authentic version. Poet and literary studies scholar George Elliott Clarke protests against the "African Canadian African Americanism", which results from subsuming African Canadian experiences and realities under the broad rubric of African American.¹¹ Representations of US-based blackness in Canadian popular cultural contexts is largely centered on images of commercial hip-hop and rap cultures popularized through mass media such as music videos, recorded music, and the movies. Media images of contemporary Canadian blackness tend to be located in the city of Toronto, specifically, and are typically Caribbean-identified as they are wedded to the annual Caribana, Caribbean-style carnival that takes place every summer in late July and early August.¹²

The implication of this form of popular historiography was the waning significance of Black churches as African Canadian phenomena. This waning was hastened by increased integration and the dissolution of legalized racial segregation in the 1950s and 1960s as a result of the Canadian Civil Rights Movement. Also of significance was the increased non-white migration in the post-1967 era with the institution of a points-based immigration system instead of the previous racial and cultural criteria that virtually limited non-white immigration to Canada to a trickle. While it is undeniable that Black churches in the United States have established a legacy of social change and Black community formation, a closer examination of Black church history in a North American context, including both Canada and the United States, reveals the significance of not only cross-border links across the 49th parallel but also international linkages.

Blackness in Canada is a reality. As much as there is a broad-based erasure and cultural amnesia of Black presence north of the 49th parallel, Black people have been present in Canada for more than 400 years, which includes a history of slavery dating from 1632 and ending in 1834. "Iced in Black" (referring to the physical as well as metaphorical cold of living in Canada) and "the T-dot" (a popular nickname for the city of Toronto, which emerged from Toronto hip-hop culture) are phrases that represent contemporary Black experiences in a Canadian geographical and social context.¹³

Transnationalism and Diaspora

The term "transnationalism" is generally used to refer to social and political conditions of groups and individuals that span across national borders. It has been used synonymously with the notion of modern diasporas. Modern diasporas are those populations dispersed from their homelands due to economic and political forces linked to the development of capitalism as a global economic system. Transnationality also refers to conditions of identity formation that

span national borders, simultaneously. Thus a person of Indo-Trinidadian origin presenting living in Toronto is one example of transnationality.

Aspects of my own biography serve as an example: I was born in London, England, to a father from Guyana, South America, and a St. Kitts-born, Antiguan-raised mother of Franco-Caribbean and Anglo-Caribbean parentage. I grew up in London, England, St. John's, Antigua, and Toronto, my Canadian hometown. Currently, I live and work in Waterloo, Ontario, as a professor. In the context of Black communities, in Toronto, my story is not unique—the specific contours, perhaps, but the experiences of multiple migrations, parents and grandparents from different countries, intermarriage across linguistic, religious, national, and cultural boundaries are common. In a Canadian context, Black community formation is characterized by multiple individual and communal migrations, hence the need for understanding Black churches and transnationality. Before beginning this exploration, let us now turn our attention to exploring “the Black church” and its traditional scholarly definitions in a North American context.

What Is the Black Church?

The Black church emerged as a central institution in the development of Black cultural life in North America, in both Canada and the United States. The sociohistorical context of legalized racial segregation and the resultant political and economic hegemony based on whiteness influenced the development of the Black church as a religious and social institution. Thus, as the single most autonomous institution in Black communities, the church, in addition to meeting the spiritual needs of its members, served in economic, political, cultural, and educational capacities. Like other religious traditions developed by people of African descent during and after slavery, the Black church was, and still is, a vital component of Black community life and a crucible and repository of vibrant intellectual and performance traditions.

In C. Eric Lincoln's and Larry Mamiya's groundbreaking study *The Black Church in African-American Experience*, they differentiate between two usages of the term “Black Church.”¹⁴ In a general sense, any Black Christian who is a member of a Black congregation is a member of the Black church. The specific usage, however, that guided Lincoln and Mamiya's study was an understanding of the Black church as “one of the independent, historic and totally free Black controlled denominations, which were founded after the Free African Society of 1787 and which constituted the core of Black Christians.”¹⁵ As such, the Black church, in the continental United States, by this definition is made up of the seven major Black denominations and a smaller scattering of other denominations. These seven major denominations include African Methodist Episcopal (AME) Church; the African Methodist Episcopal Zion (AMEZ) Church; the Christian Methodist Episcopal (CME) Church; the National Baptist Convention, USA, Incorporated (NBC); the National Baptist Convention of America, Unincorporated (NBCA); the Progressive National Baptist Convention (PNBC); and the Church of God in Christ (COGIC).

It is for good reason that Lincoln and Mamiya have defined the Black church in this way, as they estimate that over 80 percent of all Black Christians in the United States are included in the seven major Black denominations, with an additional 6 percent in the other smaller communions.¹⁶ They use the term “The Greater Black Church” to include both the historic denominations as well as predominantly Black congregations in white denominations.¹⁷ My research on the Spiritual Baptists in Toronto, which I will discuss in greater detail, below, is concerned with this larger definition of the Black church, as “the Greater Black Church,” and the interactions of congregations from this Greater Black Church with the historic Black church.

To reiterate, my central point is that in contemporary urban contexts in North America, including Canadian cities such as Toronto and Montréal, in addition to American cities such as

New York City and Boston, that have experienced massive post–Second World War migration, the definition of Black church as geographically and culturally bounded by the continental United States is necessarily challenged and disrupted. Scholars of Black Church Studies need to expand the conception of Black Christian community experiences to effectively account for the specific geographic and cultural locations in which these churches have developed as well as to take into consideration linkages across national and international borders. Let us now turn our attention to three examples of Black church formation, from Canada, two historical and one contemporary, and the significance of transnationalism in their emergence.

Three Examples of Black Church Formation in Canada

As Toronto's oldest historically Black congregation, First Baptist Church was a haven for Toronto's nineteenth-century Black community.¹⁸ This was the first Baptist church for either blacks or whites in Ontario (then known as Upper Canada) and likely in Canada. The congregation started as a gathering of 12 formerly enslaved people who got together, informally, to worship after they found that they were unwelcome in white churches. The fund-raising initiative taken to construct the building for the First Baptist Church in Toronto, founded in November 1826, reveals its transnational roots. The funds were raised by Elder Washington Christian, himself formerly enslaved in the United States, in Virginia, on his trip to Jamaica. Born in 1776, Christian had been ordained in the Abyssinia Baptist Church of New York in 1822.

One of the oldest AME churches in North America, Grant African Methodist Episcopal Church, was founded in 1833 in Toronto just 17 years after the denomination had been established by Richard Allen in 1817 in Philadelphia.¹⁹ Originally located on Richmond Street in the city's core, the church moved to several different locations spending 63 years at its location on Soho Street. A vital part of Toronto's nineteenth-century community, its membership grew to 128 members by 1851. In 1992, it moved to its current location on Gerrard Street in the East York area of Toronto, where it still continues to play a vital role in Black community organizing in the city.

During the nineteenth century, the congregations of Grant AME and First Baptist Church were mostly made up of African Americans who had fled slavery in the United States and their Canadian-born descendants.²⁰ Along with the African United Baptist Church, a Black denomination established in the province of Nova Scotia in 1854 by Richard Preston and Septimus Clarke, and the British Methodist Episcopal Church, an offshoot of the AME Church founded in Owen Sound, Ontario, in 1856, these historic Black Canadian churches continue to have thriving congregations.²¹ Today, however, in the historic Black churches in Toronto, the largest center of Black migration, significant portions of the congregations are Caribbean in origin, reflecting post–Second World War migration to the city.²² These historic Toronto churches also have a significant number of Black members from a variety of African countries as well as those of long-settled African Canadian and recently emigrated African American backgrounds. The congregations are linguistically and culturally diverse, including English, Spanish, Portuguese, and French speakers as well as those who speak a variety of indigenous African languages.²³

The Spiritual Baptists can be understood as a part of what James Houk calls the "Orisha religion complex"²⁴ in Trinidad and also as part of a larger Yoruba diaspora in the Black Atlantic world. However, my research on the Spiritual Baptist Church also locates it as a part of the Black church in North America including both the United States and Canada.²⁵ My typology as a scholar is in fact informed by the ways in which Spiritual Baptists, themselves, see their faith commitments. There is conflict and debate within the religion itself concerning its relationship to mainstream Christian denominations and its African roots in Yoruban Orisha. Some Spiritual Baptists see themselves as Protestant Christians who worship God in a way that draws

on their African ancestral roots, while others, more loosely, identify themselves as “spiritual people” who seek and serve the Spirit wherever it may reside and however it may manifest, lending to fluidity in ritual and symbolic representation. This fluidity may include borrowings and appropriations from Judaism, Islam, and Hinduism. As a religion with a Methodist order of service, sacred music that includes Anglican hymns and “sankeys” and Spiritual Baptist “trumpets,” Catholic prayers and a cosmology that includes the Yoruban Orisha syncretized with Catholic saints, references to Jewish history as an analogy for understanding slavery and deliverance by a just God, and a spiritual landscape encompassing biblical lands, India, Africa, and China, the Spiritual religion is highly adaptive. It exists at the intersection of Yoruban religion and Euro-American Christianities and a post-colonial imagination that reimagines an African Caribbean past in a multicultural, multireligious, and multiracial transnational context.

Significance of Studying the Black Church in Transnational Perspective

Having established the importance of extending the perspective on Black Church Studies beyond the continental United States, I would like to highlight three points of significance for utilizing a transnational perspective. First, Black churches that developed elsewhere in the African diaspora, such as the Spiritual Baptist Church, have taken root in large urban centers in Canada, the United States, and the United Kingdom through post-Second World War migration. The establishment of these churches is a migratory phenomenon worthy of further research. They include missionizing activity from the Caribbean to North American churches as well as the provision of ritual specialists who instruct and guide clergy and congregations based in Canada. These churches have changed the face of the religious landscape in Canada and the United States.

Second, it is necessary, also, to consider the ways in which mainstream denominations have been transformed through the presence of recently migrated persons of African descent and their descendants. For example, the Anglican Church or Church of England has a large contingent of Black people who belong to the church from the Caribbean and Africa, reflecting Britain’s colonial legacy. In the city of Toronto, for instance, landmark churches that date back to the early twentieth century, such as St. Michael and All Angels Anglican Church, now have majority Black populations from the Caribbean and Africa as a result of Black migration and are essentially Black churches. It is a situation in which “the empire strikes back.” Churches whose congregations were waning in the immediate post-Second World War years have now been revitalized through increased Black membership.

Third, although not thoroughly discussed, in this chapter, it is necessary to also take into consideration the role of mass transportation and mass media in the extension of the culture and worship styles of Black churches across national border lines. Through the production of musical recordings, social media, the internet, and television, the culture and worship of Black churches reaches an international audience and exchange and dialogue is facilitated.

Concluding Questions

The three aforementioned observations point to several unexplored questions that I would like to raise concerning the need to take into consideration the transnational dimensions of Black religious experience in the study of Black churches.

First, how does thinking about Black churches as transnational social and religious phenomena of multiple migrations and diverse experiences of Blackness alter and shape our perceptions of taken-for-granted assumptions about “the Black church” as fundamentally

US-based, Protestant, and English-speaking? Second, if we as scholars venture beyond these parameters to consider, for example, Black churches that are multilingual, that include elements of Catholicism and African-based traditions among congregations, and whose significant portions have emigrated since the post-Second World War, are we still discussing "the Black church" as a central institution of Black community development, or are we discussing other phenomena that may overlap with Black churches but that differ in significant ways? Finally, what types of methodologies must we engage in order to conduct these types of studies? Can we envision interdisciplinary, interdenominational, and interfaith dialogues that move beyond established disciplinary and subfield categories?

While fully answering these questions is beyond the scope of this chapter, let me conclude by saying that in raising them, it is hoped that the dialogue about Black Church Studies is expanded and enriched by their consideration and I look forward to continuing that dialogue.

Notes

1. George Elliott Clarke, "A Testament," in *Lush Dreams, Blue Exile: Fugitive Poems: 1978–1993* (Lawrencetown Beach, Nova Scotia: Pottersfield Press, 1994, 52).
2. Pearleen Oliver, *Song of the Spirit: An Historical Narrative on the History of the Beechville United Baptist Church* (Hantsport, NS: Lancelot Press, 1994), 7.
3. *Ibid.*, 8.
4. *Ibid.*
5. *Ibid.*, 104.
6. Willard Parker Clayton, *Whatever Your Will, Lord: A Brief History Written in Commemoration of the 139th Anniversary of Emmanuel Baptist Church, Upper Hammonds Plains*, Nova Scotia (Hantsport, NS: Lancelot Press, 1984), 34.
7. See Albert J. Raboteau, *Slave Religion: The "Invisible Institution" in the Antebellum South* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2004).
8. While the history of Black community development in the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries is an important and vital one, its presentation, including the role of the Black church, without any subsequent reference to contemporary Black Christianities in a Canadian context could be construed as being of diminishing importance. This was a situation in which the *absence* of reference to contemporary Black religious life, including the Black church, contributed toward an erasure and invisibility of African Canadian experiences.
9. The recent documentary, *Seeking Salvation: A History of the Black Church in Canada* (Vision TV and Travesty Productions, 2004) is the first feature-length video produced for Canadian television that addresses the Black church in Canada in historical and contemporary contexts. The documentary outlines patterns of Black migration and settlement in Canada beginning with the documented history of slavery from 1632 (the year marks the first recorded slave sale, of Madagascar-born Olivier Le Jeune, in colonial New France, now known as the province of Quebec) until its abolition 200 years later in 1834, the migration of enslaved African Americans through the Underground Railroad in the nineteenth century, and twentieth- and twenty-first-century migrations from the Caribbean and Africa.
10. Denise Gillard discusses this phenomenon in which African Canadians who can trace their family history in the country for eight or more generations are presumed to be "foreign" and "immigrant" by virtue of their Blackness in her article "The Black Church in Canada," in *The McMaster Journal of Theology and Ministry* (Prophets and Margins, 1998), <http://www.mcmaster.ca/mjtm/1-5.htm>.
11. George Elliott Clarke, "Contesting a Model Blackness: A Meditation on African-Canadian African-Americanism, or the Structures of African-Canadianité," in his *Odysseys Home: Mapping African-Canadian Literature* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2002), 27–70.
12. Begun in 1967, *Caribana* is a two weeklong celebration of Caribbean music and culture that takes place in the city of Toronto during the latter part of July and early August. The highlight

of the celebration is a Caribbean carnival-style parade that attracts a spectatorship of over one million people, yearly. The parade takes place on the first Saturday of the month of August. The following Monday of the holiday weekend is a Province of Ontario civic holiday, Simcoe Day, named for John Graves Simcoe (1752–1806), the first lieutenant governor of Upper Canada (contemporary southern Ontario in Canada). Simcoe fought for, and was successful, in abolishing slavery in Upper Canada (in 1810) before it was abolished in 1834 throughout the rest of the British Empire.

13. Popularized by Canadian hip-hop artists such as rapper Kardinal Offishal, the term “T-dot” has moved into popular parlance outside of the hip-hop community in Canada as a recognized nickname for the city of Toronto. It exists in tandem with and references to the older name, T. O. (pronounced Tee Oh), which was referenced as “T-dot, Oh-dot,” and then shortened to “T-dot.” For further details, see Kardinal Offishal’s recording “Bakardi Slang” on the album *Firestarter: Quest for Fire, Volume 1* (2001), in which he outlines Toronto-based hip-hop terminology in contrast to that from the United States, thereby asserting an authentic and independent Canadian-based hip-hop culture.
14. C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence H. Mamiya, *The Black Church in the African American Experience* (Durham, NC and London: Duke University Press, 1993), 1.
15. *Ibid.*
16. *Ibid.*
17. *Ibid.*, 411.
18. Philip Daniels, dir., *Seeking Salvation: A History of the Black Church in Canada*. Vision TV, 2004. Film.
19. This information and the statistics that follow are taken for the Grant AME website: <http://www.grantame.com/>
20. Baptist pastor Denise Gillard in *Seeking Salvation: A History of the Black Church in Canada*.
21. Historian, James St. George Walker in *Seeking Salvation: A History of the Black Church in Canada*.
22. This observation about Black church membership in the city of Toronto is based on participant observation by the author.
23. The linguistic diversity of the congregation poses challenges as well as opens up opportunities for liturgical diversity.
24. James Houk, *Spirits, Blood and Druma: The Orisha Religion of Trinidad* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1995).
25. Carol B. Duncan, *This Spot of Ground: Spiritual Baptists in Toronto* (Waterloo: Wilfrid Laurier University Press, 2008).

Towards Greater Involvement of the British Black Church in the Secular Education of Black Youth: School Exclusion and British Black Males

Doreen McCalla

With special reference to the exclusion^{1,2} of young, Caribbean British (African Caribbean)³ males from English State schools,⁴ this chapter argues for greater involvement of the ministry of the British Black Church in the secular education of Black youth. By British Black church I mean Christian Black organizations such as, Black churches and Black faith-based organizations (fbos) on the one hand; and Black Christian leaders/ministers and laity, on the other. The paper thus examines the interplay of Black religion/spirituality, school exclusion, Black British masculinity, education, and Black youth.

There are many social and religious issues arising in the United Kingdom that directly impact on Black people. These are racism, concerns about the reluctance of Christian Black youth to enter church leadership, poverty, interconnection of the penal justice system and crime, and health concerns in relation to mental illness and sexually transmitted diseases. However, the school exclusion of young, Caribbean British males is poignant. Reasons for focus on this social problem and in relation to this specific racial and gendered group shall be made clear in ensuing sections. The chapter notes the social repercussions of exclusions on society more generally and considers the psycho-social impact of school exclusion on the boys affected and their families.⁵ The findings are used to aid in the construct of my argument for greater Black, religious organizational and Christian engagement in the secular education of Black children. The involvement of Black church ministries is intended to ameliorate the school experience of Black children by attempting to combat school and social exclusion and Black educational underachievement. The paper thus seeks to answer four main questions with regards to the involvement of Black church ministries in the secular education of Black children:

1. Why should the Black church get involved?
2. What Black church provision, if any, already exists?

3. If provision already exists, is it sufficient to address the specific needs of Black children and their families?
4. And if not, how can provision increase?

The chapter starts with a brief discussion on the racial and Christian demographics in the United Kingdom. It then looks at Black church and social action. The relationship between secular educational providers and Black youth follows. The third section questions the need for Black church involvement in the secular education of Black children. Fourth, issues of school exclusions in Britain and the position of Caribbean males are then addressed. Fifth, the social and psycho-social impact of school exclusion and Caribbean British males are analysed. The importance of parental involvement in school exclusion is examined in section six. The final section concentrates on the Black church engagement in the secular education of Black children before a concluding summary.

Background: Demographics

The UK 2001 census records a total population of approximately 60 million people of which minority ethnic Blacks comprise about 4.5 million. Of this 4.5 million, 1.7 million are of African and African Caribbean descent. It is this latter group that this chapter is concerned. Given the size of the total UK population, this ethnic group consists of a very small proportion.

In terms of the total number of Black Christians and Black churches, the estimates vary depending on the sources and the purposes for which these figures are gathered and used. A Churches Together in Britain and Ireland (CTBI)⁶ report records approximately 1.7 million minority ethnic Christians from numerous denominations. In his survey of church attendance in England, Peter Brierley⁷ claims a total number of 1,300 ethnic minority denominations where 50 headquarters exist of these. However, the CTBI report⁸ claims only 300 minority ethnic denominations consisting of approximately 3,000 congregations. These figures are arbitrary; however, they allow an understanding of the possibilities for the Black church's response to the scale of the problem of Black boys' exclusion from school given the Black church's size and capacity.

Black Church and Political/Social Action

In the British context Robert Beckford has long highlighted the limited response of the Black church in political action.⁹ He argues that it has created a culture of serving its own spiritual needs while also focusing its attention exclusively on the conversion of unbelievers. By doing so, he maintains that the British Black church fails to acknowledge and respond to the racial and class divisions and politics endemic in British society. Black people are essentially disproportionately discriminated against and issues relating to them are perceived as problematic and contentious. Yet, according to Beckford, the Black church seems uninterested in direct combat where these issues are concerned.

Drawing on writings by James Cone, Beckford gives three responses to political engagement from the church in his book *God and the Gangs*.¹⁰ Gun and gang culture among Black youths in Birmingham, England, is the focus of his attention. He first asserts that the Black church experiences chronic withdrawal symptoms to societal, social action. Instead, it prays for Divine intervention since it does not get directly involved. On reading Beckford, it would seem that the scripture "be not confirmed to the world; but be transformed by the renewing of your mind" (Romans 12:2) is taken to its extreme as congregants prepare for the eschatology through their spiritual devotion alone. Secondly, Beckford flags up the church's generous

project-works in which it acts as a satellite, providing 'good works', social action programs as an indirect and alternative response to specific social problems. For Beckford the church excuses itself from being actively involved in social politics and thus justifies its social irresponsibility to society. Thirdly, through non-violent measures (peace and justice), Beckford argues that the church responds prophetically through a visionary and practical approach to social issues in society. It is this latter response that he suggests is most lacking in the Black church but nevertheless, most needful. Through examination of gun crime and gang violence he puts forward a prophetic action approach for social engagement.

Whilst essentially concurring with Beckford that the response of the British Black church to the social needs of society is wholly inadequate, I nonetheless highlight, through my investigation into a nationalized, Black-majority Church (BMC), their contribution to society.¹¹ I argue that although the church responds through social and voluntary action programs their motivation is prophetic for "where there is no vision the people perish" (Proverbs 29: 18). In this way, they differ from Beckford's project-work response. These practical and visionary programs aim to combat social and religious exclusion for greater Christian and civil engagement. However, unlike the direct combat idea which Beckford promotes in his prophetic action paradigm, not all social provision operates at this level. Some are more passive and function through the churches' social systems themselves,¹² their associated community centers and/or faith-based organizations or flocs that are owned by Black church members but are affiliated with the Black church. My inquiry found that although Black churches do not necessarily engage in matters of racial politics and social injustice beyond that of church connections, they are, nonetheless, attempting to involve themselves with the wider society. The underlying motive is not about the avoidance of response to direct social problems, as the project-work response suggests, but about heeding the Holy Spirit's call to "serve tables" similar to that found in Acts 7. Recent British government policies, specifically geared towards Black and minority ethnic groups, are trying to encourage further development and establishment of Black services for the wider community. Despite the government's attractive incentives, I give a word of caution to Black churches, to remain guided by the prophetic voice and not to allow finance alone, though necessary and important, to determine the nature and level of their social provision.

The literature is virtually silent concerning British Black church involvement in the provision of secular education of Black youth. The few exceptions are found in my book on *Black Success*¹³ and other selective papers. Reference to the influence of the Black church as a community organization, Black Christians, and some Black supplementary schools in the successful education and career trajectory of Black children is made. Courtesy of Anthony Reddie, the British context now has documentary evidence on the importance of Black theology in the Christian education of Black youth.¹⁴ However, in the secular education of Black children, it is the secular community and voluntary sector that are the main providers.

Secular Educational Providers and Black Youth

Specifically relating to school exclusions, recent research shows that it is a combination of mainstream and Black community initiatives that specialize in school exclusions to help African Caribbean children and their families. Statutory organizations are found to be less supportive.¹⁵ These community initiatives provide practical help through the exclusion process such as alternative sites where Black excludees can learn, advocacy, and the representation for school excludees and their families. These organizations are also utilized to assist excluded children with career advice and emotional problems and the reintegration back into mainstream education.

Other studies on secular educational provision more generally show that it is Black community initiatives and organizations that are agents of help, support, and information for Black children, their families, and the local, Black community. These community-led and self-help initiatives respond to a mainstream educational system that is seen by the Black community as misrepresenting Black youth as underachievers and anti-education. These organizations reflect Black social and cultural capital in the form of empowerment, civil engagement, collaboration, and community. They are characterized by Black-dominated environments in which African-centric culture and values are promoted alongside high expectations for successful career trajectories of young people and images of positive Black self-identities. These community initiatives are designed to enhance Black young peoples' self-respect, promote self-discipline, and thus enable young people to successfully achieve in education and employment.¹⁶

In her study of community-based projects designed to support Black pupils and parents, Lorna Cork highlights five distinct types of social action provision. The first is designed to improve the direct relationship between school and home through a Local Education Authority (LEA) liaison role—Linkaid. The second provision—Actionaid—is a community-based Black parents' group. The third type is an organization that serves in a mediation role between home and school—Mediaid. The fourth is child-centered in which parents advocate through Black parents' organizations for their children—Advocaid. Finally, Culturaid is about raising Black historical and cultural awareness through a school-based, parents group.

Black supplementary schools and community mentoring programs are examples of these community initiatives. Only a small amount of Black supplementary schools are religious. Most are secular. Supplementary schools are out-of-school, part-time providers of mainly after-school or Saturday school education in which the curricula and activities foster a positive Black space for learning.¹⁷ Black community-run programs are set up by, and for, the Black community and are designed to guide young people through their education to adulthood employment and/or further education. Examples of these Black-mentoring schemes are 100 Black men in Birmingham, and Windsor Fellowship in London, England.¹⁸ As the secular, Black community is actively engaged in serving the educational requirements of Black children, as limited as this may be, the question is therefore begged as to the need for Black church ministerial involvement. To this question I now focus my attention.

Black Christian Involvement in the Secular Education of Black Children?

The answer to the question of why Black church ministries and Black Christians should be involved in the secular education of Black children is partly summarized in James 1: 27; 2: 14–26. First, 'pure religion' is intrinsically connected to social responsibility for the marginalized, disadvantaged and vulnerable—made possible through loving God firstly, and then secondly, loving humanity (Matthew 22: 36–40; John 12: 30–1). This love includes the welfare and concerns of Black youth. "Pure religion" can therefore never be truly effective and meaningful through dutiful actions that are exempt of love. In the New Testament the fatherless and husbandless, "orphans and widows," are frequently cited as the poor whom, through unfortunate social circumstances, are left without the primary economic provider in their households—the male breadwinner. The importance of education in the transition to adulthood for children means that the absence of it can lead to social exclusion, a point which I shall develop further below, and thus the likelihood of becoming a statistic of society's poor.

Second, Black Christian establishments and Black Christians provide a uniquely redemptive message of liberation, transformation, and hope for oppressed people through Jesus Christ.¹⁹ This redemptive message is unparalleled in the mission and action of any other organization and religious group in society. The Black church and its social welfare programs offer to Black people a culturally sensitive salvation.²⁰ The Black church, in particular, is God's representation of Black Christianity in the world that speaks with a prophetic voice. When the Black church and Black Christians fail to proclaim 'thus says the Lord' on issues of concern to Black and oppressed peoples, their quietness enables 'secular' organizations to speak on their behalf from values that often misrepresent Christian, Black peoples' spiritual and cultural matters. For these reasons, the Black church must play an integral role in society. Black Christians are thus called to be 'salt' and 'light' in the world (see St. Matthew 5: 13–16) and can also be the agency of educational provision and social justice for Black youths.

Having established a need for the involvement of the Black and Black Christianity in the secular education of Black children, I shall now address the issue of school exclusions and Black males in order to later develop my practical model.

School Exclusions in Britain

In Britain the subject of school exclusions has become an issue of considerable attention for academics, practitioners, the public, and the government.²¹ Studies on school exclusion have focused on explaining increasing trends and have pointed to educational policy and the process of schooling,²² as feasible explanations. On the consequences of school exclusion, other studies point to poor educational achievement; poor employment prospects; induced alienation, disaffection, and social exclusion; and links with criminal and other socially corrosive activities and family disruption.²³ The British government has sought ways to reduce school exclusions and had invested nearly £470 million to improve behavior and attendance.²⁴ Performance was target so that by 2004, school truancies would have reduced by 10 percent compared with 2002. However, issues of school exclusions still remain paramount topic of attention.

The 1993, Education Act in England defines the current law on permanent and temporary exclusions. These are the official terms used in England and Wales for being expelled or suspended from school. Fixed-term exclusion (or temporary exclusion) refers to a specific number of school days, not exceeding 15 school days in one term, in which a student is suspended and is allowed to return to the same school. Permanent exclusion results in removal of a student from a school's enrolment. Official statistical evidence on school exclusion is problematic in that some fixed or permanent exclusions are unrecorded. Similarly, they do not always stipulate between the two types of exclusions. Furthermore, although the 1993 Education Act clearly defines types of exclusions, it fails to point out the criteria on which offences would result in exclusions.²⁵ The Department for Education and Skills (DfES),²⁶ that is the Government's administrative department that is responsible for education in Britain, only states that exclusions should be used sparingly, in response to serious breaches of school policy where all the facts of a case, including pupils' age, previous record, health, and other relevant issues, are taken into account. Permanent exclusion must only be taken as a last resort. The decision to exclude is thus left with head teachers, school governors, and senior school management of individual schools to make decisions and form judgments on specific cases. School decision-makers are given the power to set their own policies concerning behavior and exclusion in which all parents are allowed copies of school behavior and exclusion policies.²⁷ However, schools must ensure they do not infringe the 1976 Race Relations Act and the 1975 Sex Discrimination Act. It is this power granted to schools to set their own policy agendas that poses problems for Black boys who are the most susceptible group to school exclusions.

British Black Males and School Exclusion

Research on school exclusion reveals boys in general²⁸ are prone to school exclusion and permanent exclusion at that. Poor literacy, in some cases, is a causal factor. Most boys, aged between 13 and 15, start secondary school with a reading age behind that of their female peers. High truancy levels augment poor literacy.²⁹ Although exclusion rates have fallen, African Caribbean boys in particular are nonetheless more at risk than any other group.³⁰ The office of standards in education (ofsted)³¹ in Britain has shown that young, Caribbean British males account for 9 percent of the school population, yet, according to Tony Sewell, they are 4 to 15 times more likely to be excluded from school depending on regional variations in Britain, compared with other groups.

Unlike white boys, research on African Caribbean boys and their experience of schooling has showed that their combined masculinity, race, and class are attracting vast racism in school³² and this attraction, in many cases, is partly responsible for their exclusion from school.³³ A parent in my study states this well:

There is more hassle for the Black kids because they want to go to school and learn. Whereas white kids, with me being a youth worker I know this for a fact, the white boys don't want to go to the school. They won't have the same difficulties as the Black boys, because they are not there to be told off and then to be excluded.

It is suggested that the way in which Black people display their social distress makes them susceptible to being identified by lay people and the police as deviant, whilst within the school setting it is teachers and other educational professionals who have the power to label the distress of Caribbean British boys (usually manifested as alienation and disaffection) as problematic.³⁴ Studies on school exclusion and Black British boys show that whilst they did not exhibit 'disruptive' behavior prior to attending secondary school and are not disaffected with education, they were among the reasons given for their school exclusion at secondary school. Cecile Wright and colleagues, in their study of *School exclusion and transition into adulthood*, also identify the following reasons given for exclusion:

attitude problems; behavioural problems including disruptive behaviour; stealing; graffiti; violent behaviour including fighting, verbal abuse, aggressive behaviour; truancy; bullying; smoking cannabis, forgery³⁵

In addition to some of these, my own study found sexual harassment and damage to public property as other grounds for exclusion.³⁶

Other research has suggested that the recent changes in government education policy, notably the 1998 Education Reform Act (ERA), are indirectly discriminating against African Caribbean children, in general,³⁷ and African Caribbean boys, specifically.³⁸ At primary school, Caribbean British children's educational attainment is better than other ethnic groups.³⁹ However, while in the main, Caribbean girls dramatically excel at secondary school compared with other groups despite the combined discrimination of racism and sexism,⁴⁰ African Caribbean boys' key stage 4 results (taken at age 16) show a worrying educational decline in relation to other ethnic groups.⁴¹ It is argued that the continual assessment process introduced in the 1998 ERA discriminates against African Caribbean boys in education and is also responsible for exclusion of Caribbean British boys.⁴² It is because African Caribbean males are disproportionately represented in school and social exclusion rates compared with other ethnic groups that, on this occasion, they warrant special attention and thus they are the focus of my discussion. Notwithstanding, the discrimination of women and girls is globally universal and the consequences often, extremely extensive, especially with regards to issues relating to sex

and sexuality. However, in the British context, the impact of school exclusion on boys, their relatives, and society is also significant, to which I now concentrate.

The Impact of School Exclusion and Caribbean British Males

Social and Economic Repercussions

It has been noted that the social implications of school exclusion is far-reaching. School exclusions have a knock-on effect in terms of wider forms of social exclusions such as a channel into educational underachievement, crime (mainly drug- and theft-related), court sentencing, imprisonment, unemployment, poverty, teenage pregnancies, and family disruptions.⁴³ With regards to crime, a 1993 Royal Commission study on the operation of the criminal justice system demonstrated greater proportions of African Caribbean youth, mainly males, stopped and arrested by the police. Once arrested these youth, like Black adults, are less likely to be cautioned; expected to be remanded in custody; prone to plead not guilty; apt to be tried at Crown Court but, nonetheless, more likely to be acquitted. The fact that the acquittal rate for crime is proportionately higher for Black males than other groups clearly demonstrates to me that many of their cases should never have gone so far through the criminal justice system in the first place. African Caribbean males are unnecessarily going through the ordeal of the British criminal system. However, when Black males are found guilty they are more likely to receive longer custodial sentences than their white counterparts.⁴⁴

The social exclusion rate of Black males is not distinct to Britain. In his paper, "Poor Brother, Rich Brother," Dwight Hopkins paints a similar picture of social exclusion among African American males in the United States⁴⁵ which suggests an international problem. I would further argue that Black males in both the United Kingdom and the United States are generally located in one of three settings: (1) castrated within the criminal justice system, (2) sectioned in psychiatric institutions, an area I shall discuss below, or (3) the church. To extend and labor this point even further, as a Christian, Black, heterosexual, professional female, I am also concerned about the impact on this two-thirds of Black male exclusion on Black women in terms of enforced institutionalization and the struggles that this poses for sustainable and long-term partnerships; as well as for mothers as absent fatherhood is eminent and increases. To add, the remaining one-third of Black male churchgoers are prone to be more reluctant to reverse patriarchal discrimination, especially in terms of leadership, if for them, the church provides the only legitimate public space of hegemony. Nonetheless, as pointed out in my book *Unsung Heroes*,⁴⁶ gender egalitarianism is an essential requirement in a theocracy constituted by social justice. Thus, the fact that society has socially excluded our Black boys and men is no justification for them to discriminate against Black women in the church generally and Black church specifically.

Since my observations locate two-thirds of Black males in the United Kingdom and the United States in social exclusion and the effects of both inclusion and exclusion for Black women is noted, this is a matter that clearly requires attention and positive response no less from Black church and Christian thought and practice.

The economic cost to society from social exclusion can also be extensive. Carl Parsons estimates the total in England in 1996/1997 as £81 million.⁴⁷ This includes costs to health services, social services, and criminal justice system. Average educational costs to exclude a child were £4,300, and costs to other services in 1994/1995 were nearly £1,200. To maintain a child in school who would otherwise be at risk of exclusion is calculated at £2,800. These costs do not include those more difficult to calculate such as costs to communities and policing.⁴⁸

Documentary evidence reveals the social and economic impact of school exclusion; however, very little is known about the psychological effects of school exclusion on African

Caribbean boys. What little evidence is available can be drawn on to assess how best Black church ministries can respond to the secular education of Black youth.

Psycho-Social Effects of School Exclusion on African Caribbean Males

It is worth noting that “studies of race and mental health are [often] gender blind, while studies, which include gender analysis, tend to be race blind.”⁴⁹ Similarly, issues relating to mental health and race and culture are still misunderstood and problematic for the medical and other associated professions of mental health. As a 32-year old woman diagnosed with schizophrenia puts it: “Be aware that what may be considered ‘mad’ behaviour in one culture may not be in another.”⁵⁰

With this cautionary preface, it can now be said that recent studies reveal disproportionate representation of African Caribbean people in general, and males, in particular, in admissions to psychiatric institutions⁵¹ and their links with psychological disorder.⁵² Recent data by MIND⁵³ entitled “African Caribbean Community and Mental Health in Britain”⁵⁴ shows racism and its ensuing influence as a major contributory factor. The Mental Health Task Force Project reported a disproportionate representation of African Caribbean males amongst those formally detained in acute in-patient units. They were also more likely to be “taken to a place of safety” under section 136 of the 1983 Mental Health Act. It was found that they are up to three times more likely to be sectioned than their white counterparts.⁵⁵ Similarly, Black men were more likely than white people to receive a diagnosis of schizophrenia or drug-induced psychosis⁵⁶ and are 4.3 times more likely to receive “first time admissions” for the diagnosis of schizophrenia.⁵⁷ In addition to racism being a causal factor in mental illness, I believe that the stressful ordeal of having to go through the process of the criminal justice system is also likely to have psychological repercussions on the psyche of Black men.

In terms of school exclusion, research demonstrates the psycho-social effects on African Caribbean boys in terms of their perceptions of self and institutions in general and the psychological distress experienced.⁵⁸ My study on the psycho-social effect of exclusions on Black boys did not show serious psychological and emotional effects which require psychiatric hospitalization or medication. Nonetheless, it did, along with a recent study,⁵⁹ demonstrate the excluded Caribbean British boys specifically, and children generally, as experiencing feelings of low self-esteem and worth, trauma, paranoia, fear, anger, frustration, and insecurity, especially when they thought they were unfairly treated compared with more favorable treatments received by white students or if they saw exclusion as an injustice done to them. This is demonstrated in the quotation of a father of an excludee in my study:

The Deputy was shouting . . . He was saying, ‘Patrick we don’t believe you. You are a liar.’ Patrick was crying . . . They were hassling Patrick and forcing him to admit things [accused of sexual harassment]. . . when he went back to school what they did, they took him out his class. They locked him up on his own, no breaks, he wasn’t allowed outside. . . he was locked up all day until school finished. We had to take him to the doctors about it and he was off school for months because it was psychologically affecting him. He didn’t have a say and he couldn’t do nothing, nobody wanted to hear his point. Nobody was listening to Patrick.

Despite their ordeal, many of the excluded boys were optimistic and hopeful for the future and their prospects in terms of successful employment and civil engagement. Much of this optimism is accredited to the support of family and community organizations.⁶⁰ However, there were some indications from parents that without this support their boys’ present trauma could have developed into psychological disorder. They felt that continued help, and the absence

of further tragedy, is necessary to prevent serious psychological problems and that in more serious cases professional counseling must be an option.⁶¹ Given parents' concerns in my study, it would not be too deterministic to suggest that some African Caribbean males who experience mental health illnesses that required psychiatric treatment have also encountered a history of poor schooling. In other words, school exclusion was for them the first step to social exclusion. It is to an analysis of parents' involvement in their children's education that I now focus.

Parental Involvement and School Exclusions

There is a growing body of literature on parental support in the successful educational transition of Black children.⁶² Mothers, in particular, have been instrumental in equipping their children with strategies to withstand institutional racism.⁶³ Furthermore, studies show the importance of familial relationships and informal, community, and voluntary networks to encourage a positive identity and a sense of community for Black children when faced with systems of enduring race and class inequalities⁶⁴ and school exclusion.⁶⁵ These studies show that parents are interested in their children's education and their eventual outcomes as they progress through the system. These included many parents of children who are also excluded from school and who are, in some cases, of professional status and middle-class and born-again, practising Christians.⁶⁶ The Christian faith of these parents did not safeguard them against exclusion simply because they are Black and thus experience the same racism as any other Black parents. God "sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous" (Matthew 5: 45). However, these Christian parents were able to turn to their faith, often mainly only in prayer and hope, in addition to the other support networks of community and church. The Christian faith provided for these parents offer another option that was not considered by non-believers although it was limited to Beckford's withdrawal response where there was no action by the church in an attempt to remedy the situation. My study showed the need for greater Black church ministerial involvement as some of these parents expressed a need for increased church support but realized that the church was often ill-equipped to deal with such issues of school exclusions:

We only asked the church to pray for my son. Basically, we can go to church and forget about what happens. The church prays and support.

(Mother)

My wife and I, it [exclusion of son] affected us mentally and physically. It was distressing and devastating. Although we are a very close family, God was in every part of it, the strength of God. Things like this splits up families. Christian faith is a medicine, I say to every situation. We have God to reassure us through the difficult times. Imagine going to bed and you can't sleep. . . . God he takes us through that. We've been involved in the church.

(Father an ordained minister)

Research shows that close relatives often get caught up in the exclusion process and perform a supportive role. These studies show that the psycho-social impact of exclusion on families was as traumatic for them as it was for those excluded. Parents appeared to be most at risk of psychological distress. They suffered stress and insomnia. In my study I found that, in some cases, parents' entire lives were thrown into turmoil as they tried to come to terms with injustice by the statutory services, which they thought would have supported them, their sons, and their families:

You can easily give up after a while. It is very stressful. I think a lot of people must have given up. . . . It takes everything out of you . . . Probably the school should recognise that parents

are stressed by it . . . Doubly so, because we thought this school had failed us to be quite honest.

(Mother)

It knocked me off my feet. I was devastated. I just couldn't function at all. You have nasty dreams, the reality. These things were new to us.

(Father)

Parents supported other siblings and struggled to keep the family unit together:

It was a very difficult time for us, the whole family. Brian [another son] was going through his exams.

(Father)

With Tim (another son) when he sees his brother at home he wants to be at home as well. He started playing up. . . . Trying to be off school.

(Mother)

We had applied at that time for our daughter to go to this school. Then this happened [son's exclusion]. I mean, at the time we were just waiting for the acceptance letter or whatever. This occurred and it was so difficult, it affected the whole family. . . . We had to bear with them [siblings] as well because the other child needs supporting.

(Mother)

Oftentimes, parents concealed the exclusion from extended family members and friends due to feelings of embarrassment; thus they endured isolation. Ironically, it was at these crisis times that these parents needed support from family and friends, yet their concealment prohibited that support:

We didn't want to tell people what was happening. I don't know if that was a good thing or not. But I said to Patrick, if anybody comes, 'go upstairs or don't answer the phone'. If someone came for two hours in the day he'd be upstairs for two hours. That was horrible. That did get to me.

(Mother)

In other situations, parents experienced feelings of guilt:

It is an embarrassing situation. . . . You feel that you are on trial, or you have done something wrong, or you have failed . . . You really could give up.

(Father)

It is quite a close-knit area. I even see people and I'm not quite sure whether to say 'hello'. . . . I don't know what to say.

(Mother)

Parents 'took time off work' (father) to attend meetings and support for their excluded son. Racism was given as the reason for the unfairness they and their sons received which impacted the entire family and disrupted their lives.

Having discussed the involvement of parents and the psycho-social impact of school exclusion on them, it remains for me to address the issue of greater involvement of Black church ministries in the secular education of Black children.

Towards Greater Black Church Ministries in the Secular Education of

Caribbean British Children

The discussion, so far, has identified insufficient provision to address the educational requirements of Black children. The need for greater Black church ministries in the secular education of Black children has also been revealed. However, it has not addressed the scale of existing Black Christian provision or how best to increase the involvement of the Black church.

In the British context some Black church ministerial services already partly exist. The National Black Boys Can Association, a Christian, Black mentoring scheme, is one such example. It was established in 1999 in Birmingham, England, to counter Black boys' failings in British education. It focuses exclusively on "raising the academic and social aspirations of Black boys" from ages 9 to 16. However, this scheme does not serve the needs of Black girls. It is important that whilst the present educational good fortune of achievement in Black girls continues, they are not overlooked in attempts to raise standards for boys. This is because neglect can lead to a reverse or decline in Black girls' educational standards.

While not focusing exclusively on education, the work of the Council of Black-led Churches (CBLC) serves a meditative and facilitative role in the secular education of Black children. As a Christian, Black ecumenical organization which "seek to organize and mobilise the leaders and members of the Black Christian community" CBLC acts as a mediator between existing professional, secular, and Christian services, such as schools, Black churches, local education authorities, Black teachers, education community groups, and parents. It responds to the cultural and spiritual educational needs of Black children in schools. CBLC facilitates the collaborative effort of all sectors concerned in Black children's education through seminars, conferences, information dissemination, and meetings. CBLC is not the provider of services. Other participating parties do this. It is the facilitative organization between and for the other organizations and groups. All other secular organizations do not have a spirituality agenda but the religious input is provided by CBLC. The facilitator acts as an enabler which follows up and monitors progress.

These typologies are by no means exhaustive lists of Christian service providers. Black Parent Support Groups and Black supplementary schools also exist and provide some kind of Black church, secular, educational ministry for Black children. However, in order to actively and practically engage in the secular education of Black children, existing provisions require some adaptation to go beyond their partial services and for application in a spiritual and/or educational framework.

Taking into account the knowledge of school exclusions mentioned above and the experiences of those directly affected by it, it is important that any Black Christian and Black church provision is an integrated service, one which incorporates spirituality, education, intercultural pastoral care/counseling, and welfare information. It must be culturally sensitive, liberating, interventionist, transforming, and holistic. It must also be the spiritual, educational, cultural welfare, and social and psychological needs of Black children and supports parents and families concerned. Furthermore, the provision needs to be effective and efficient to combat social exclusion and its adverse impact on society and Black women and Black children. My prescription includes services that can be replicated nationally and where possible, internationally, to serve local, national, and international needs. My concern is not with providing isolated, almost unknown and invisible services that are virtually ineffective. I am concerned with services that, in addition to community and church or church-agency funding, are likely to also attract public and government funding where necessary and appropriate.

I shall provide two religious educational typologies. Other types can be formulated for employment. Although not necessarily constructed in a religious context, Lorna Corks' models, which have been tried and tested and proven to work in practice in improving the home-school relationships of Black children, can be modified as a basis for possible Black church provision.

Christian Black Supplementary Club and Mentoring Scheme

The traditional Black supplementary school movement seeks to provide a 'Black' education service for only Black children in which qualified, Black schoolteachers provide curricula.⁶⁷ It does not seek to cater for parents or other relatives neither is it integrated. My study of Marcus Garvey Nursery revealed an educational and caring service that not only was for Black children but also gave parents and the community a Black social space.⁶⁸ The nursery preached an African-centric message which was reflected in all of its provision, and since some of its leaders are Christians, Christian social values of community, social justice, and care were implied although not necessarily and explicitly stated in policy and practise. The nursery emphasized the significance of promoting a positive self-image of Blackness for children, parents, and the Black community and had high expectations of educational and/or vocational career progression for all its children and parents.

Black theological values of liberation, social justice, and hope for oppressed people, made possible through the atonement of Jesus Christ,⁶⁹ and linked to prophetic action by the Holy Spirit⁷⁰ underpins the provision of my proposed Black supplementary club and mentoring scheme. Written initially for the Christian Education of Black youth, relevant sections of Anthony Reddie's curricula, *Growing in Hope*,⁷¹ can be adopted for use in this secular educational environment from a Christian perspective. Thus Christian, African, and Caribbean songs of liberation, transformation, and victory and books on Black church heroes and heroines in which the Bible is also viewed from a Black perspective are relevant components of such a provision. The history of Black people and their relations to faith are other components of this service where issues concerning "no respect of persons" is preached. Respect is inclusive of listening to students speak about their spiritual as well as secular experiences and aspirations. It includes using friendly gestures not aggressive ones, using students' preferred names, asking questions rather than making accusation, dealing with problem behavior in private, and avoiding negative comments on cultural style.

The provision is intended to focus on early and longitudinal intervention for prevention in the sense that "prevention is better than cure." The aim is to provide a service from pre-school that continues to track children's progress through schooling, with the help of schools and parents, to avoid underachievement and school exclusions. In my study of school exclusion of Caribbean boys, I found that most exclusions occurred in year nine (ages 13–14) when children were about to select their courses for examination in their final year of schooling. This longitudinal interventionist approach is designed to prevent exclusion at the most critical stage in a child's education. Similarly this service includes good role models of Black success of both genders in the church and society to counter Black underachievement and failure. Furthermore, the service focuses on the development of life skills relating to social interaction and communication, citizenship and social behavior, Christian and social responsibility, stewardship, cultural awareness, and the like.

Even if exclusion or underachievement does not occur for an individual child, Black children are likely to experience some form of racism in their schooling which could lead to some distress or trauma. For this reason, a service that includes some type of intercultural pastoral care and counseling should be offered to which I shall now discuss in the next proposed typology.

Secular Prophetic Pastors/Minister

I am concentrating on educational services; however, secular prophetic pastors/ministers can operate in many secular settings. Given the innovation of the proposal in the British context, the implementation of this typology is likely to be long term rather than a quick-fix response to the educational needs of Black children.

In October 2005, a Churches Together in Britain and Ireland (CTBI) conference⁷² noted concerns about the low take-up of Black, ordained ministries for ecclesial leadership among those less than 40 years. On closer examination, I discovered that some young people were interested and felt a call into ministerial leadership but did not necessarily see this as church-based. In the United States, there are already recognized workplace pastors and some seminaries and religious-based colleges that train ministers for secular ministries other than only for prison chaplaincy. Similarly, secular pastors are also needed given the general decline in church attendance in England⁷³ although Black church membership is growing compared with mainstream churches. If people are failing to attend church, for whatever reasons, the church needs to go to the people. It is with this context in mind that I propose educational pastors for involvement in the secular education of Black children. It is also hoped that this proposal will encourage the under 40s in Britain to consider alternative pastoral ministries in addition to traditional ecclesial ones and for British seminaries to prepare to train ministers for the twenty-first-century where Black churches will either employ or be a cover-church for them.

In his book, *In Living Colour*, Emmanuel Larney provides appropriate affirmations of pastoral care for the Black church that can be applied here. He claims that first, intercultural pastoral care requires collective "seeing, judging and acting." Pastoral caregivers need the visions of many cultures on the issues they seek to respond to. The collective approach is required also in the art of "judging." It is where many examine their evaluations that wisdom is to be found. To act reflectively together is to open the way for more transformative activity.⁷⁴

In education, the collective means for pastoral counselors to work in partnership with Black children and parents through their difficulties and where voluntary and statutory organizations provide education with pastoral cultural support. Larney secondly adds that pastoral carers "need the humility and trust of the divine presence . . . that respects difference and seeks to give itself way in loving service."⁷⁵ Unlike secular, social workers/pastoral carers, these Christian education pastors are to exert selfless, committed, evangelical characteristics and speak with a prophetic voice to affect change in a problematic world that oppresses people of color and in an education system thwart with racism.

Thirdly, Larney sees pastoral care as incarnational theology where God operates in the world. Education pastors are to be concerned with care and counseling of Black children. In addition, in order to be relevant and purposeful, they also need to know the environment in which they are serving, that is, the education system, policies, and practices generally and in relation to Black children specifically. This may mean training as a teacher and acquainting themselves with secular, Black educational provisions already working effectively and efficiently as outlined by Lorna Cork in her book, *Supporting Black Parents and Pupils*.⁷⁶ This training may be in addition to or alongside training for ordained pastoral ministry. Fourthly, Larney suggests that pastoral care must be contextual. He states that:

It is imperative that caregivers have an understanding of where people are "coming from" . . . The texture of the terrain is gauged in historical, social, cultural, gender, economic, spiritual and political terms. Pastoral analysis cannot be undertaken adequately in the absence of these features of the lives of ordinary, living persons.⁷⁷

Although "like all others" in the sense that, like white children, Black children share the experience of compulsory schooling, they are "like some others" in that they are Black and

therefore, unlike their white counterparts, face racism in the British education system but in reality, they are “like no other.”⁷⁸ Each Black child is unique, deliberately created by God to be distinct, and it is this distinctiveness that the Christian, Black educational pastor must never lose sight of when engaging in the secular education of Black children and their families.

Conclusion

This chapter discussed the need for greater involvement of Black church ministries in the secular education of Black children through examining the school exclusion of Caribbean British boys—a highly vulnerable group to school exclusion in Britain. The social impact of school exclusion on society and its psycho-social effect on excluded Black boys and their families is alarming. These impacts suggest a need for alternative education other than the mainstream system that is, itself, excluding Black boys. Although there is some evidence of Black Christian engagement in education, it is minimal. Given the importance of education in the life course of children and that Black children face discrimination in the British education system, compulsory education that is provided by the State needs to be supplemented by some form of Black, cultural provision. Black church ministries can play a crucial element in this as part of its Christian social responsibility to Black children and society at large. The chapter thus calls for its greater response to the need for Christian, Black, secular education by providing some paradigms/models that can be utilized by Black churches and Black-faith organizations and community projects.

Notes

1. A version of this paper was presented at the conference of the International Association of Black Religions and Spiritualities in Cape Town, South Africa, January 2006, and again when I was a visiting professor to American Baptist College, Nashville, Tennessee, USA, in September 2006.
2. The term “exclusion” in the British context is analogous to “expulsion” as a disciplinary action in North American schools.
3. While African Caribbean is more frequently used in the British context, I have decided to use the term “Caribbean British” synonymously with “African Caribbean” to signify the specific ethnic Black British group referred to in this chapter. I think the use of Caribbean British (a term which I previously used in McCalla, “The Academic and the Community Meet: Two Black, Female Voices,” *International Journal of Inclusive Education*, Vol. 6 (2002), 165–83 will help to distinguish between other Black Caribbeans in a global context, namely British Caribbeans in other parts of the world and thus eliminate any confusion.
4. Most schools in Britain are State provided, that is, by the Government, and are attended by almost all children of school age.
5. Due to limited space I cannot draw extensively on the empirical data of a small-scale, ethnographical research I undertook in 2000.
6. Churches together in Britain and Ireland, *Stronger Together, Weaker Apart* (London: CTBI, 2003)
7. Peter Brierley, *The Tide is Running Out: What the English Church Attendance Survey Reveals* (London: Christian Research, 2000)
8. CTBI, *Stronger Together, Weaker Apart*
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10. Robert Beckford, *God and the Gangs* (London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2004)
11. Doreen McCalla, “Black Churches and Voluntary Action: Their Social Engagement with the Wider Society” *Black Theology: An International Journal*, Vol. 3, no. 2 (2005), 137–175.
12. See also Selwyn Arnold, *From Scepticism to Hope: One Black-Led Church's Response to Social Responsibility* (Grove Books: Nottingham, 1992); Peter Paris, *The Social Teaching of the Black Churches* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1985).

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17. N. Dove, "The Emergence of Black Supplementary Schools: Resistance to Racism in the United Kingdom," *Urban Education*, Vol. 27, no. 2 (1993), 43–57; Diane Reay and Heidi Mirza, "Uncovering the Genealogies of the Margins: Black Supplementary Schools," in Doreen McCalla, ed., *Black Success in the UK: Essays in Racial and Ethnic Studies* (Birmingham: DMee, 2003); Department for Education and Skills (DfES), *Aiming High: Raising the Achievement of Minority Ethnic Pupils (0183/2003)* (London: DfES, 2003)
18. Weekes and Wright, "Improving Practice," L. Appiah, *Mentoring: School-Business Links* (London: The Runnymede Trust, 2001)
19. Dwight Hopkins, *Introducing Black Theology of Liberation* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1999)
20. Paris, *The Social Teaching of the Black Churches*; Arnold, *From Scepticism to Hope*; McCalla, *Black Churches and Voluntary Action*
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22. E. Blyth and J. Milner, "Exclusion from School: A First Step in Exclusion from Society," *Children and Society*, Vol. 7, no.3 (1993), 255–278; C. Hayden, *Children Excluded from Primary School: Debates, Evidence, Responses* (Milton Keynes: Open University Press, 1997).
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34. Cecile Wright, "Black Students—White Teachers," in Barry Troyna, ed., *Racial Inequality in Education* (London: Tavistock, 1987), 109–126
35. Cecile Wright, et al., *School Exclusion and Transition into Adulthood in African-Caribbean Communities*, 11.
36. Doreen McCalla, *The Effects of School Exclusion on African-Caribbean Males*
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59. Cecile Wright et al., *School Exclusion and Transition into Adulthood in African-Caribbean Communities*
60. *Ibid.*; McCalla, *The Effects of School Exclusion on African-Caribbean Males and Their Families*
61. McCalla, *The Effects of School Exclusion on African-Caribbean Males and Their Families*
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65. McCalla, *The Effects of School Exclusion on African-Caribbean Males and Their Families*; Hayden and Dunne, *Outside Looking*; Cecile Wright et al., *School Exclusion and Transition into adulthood in African-Caribbean Communities*
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74. Emmanuel Lartey, *In Living Colour: An Intercultural Approach to Pastoral Care and Counselling*, second edition (London: Jessica Kingsley Publishing, 2003), 175.
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Part VII

Coming Full Circle

The Black church has had a rich history of social activism as outlined in the essays in Part I. The essays in the final section discuss the necessity of the Black church's continuity in the twenty-first century for Black people's survival and the creation of just societies. The authors note that the current US and global contexts are rife with social and political issues including poverty and health care (Smith), economic justice (Floyd-Thomas), and sexual orientation and gender diversity (Henry) that urgently demand a concerted effort involving Black Church Studies scholars, clergy, laity, and broader communities. Henry calls for the inclusion of TSBGL (trans-same-and-both-gender loving) people in Black churches as members of faith communities. Smith focuses on the role that Black church leaders could play in eliminating health inequities that place people of African descent in the United States at greater risk for certain preventable diseases. Hopkins sees "mission" as a necessary outgrowth of Black churches in which there would be a "focus on solidarity, healing, and liberation for oppressed communities and nations globally."

The Black Church and Its Mission for the Twenty-First Century

Dwight N. Hopkins

At the dawn of the twenty-first century, one of the major challenges for the Black church in the United States is global mission. However, the church needs to engage in a new form of mission. Rather than follow a type of imperialistic missionary work that we see carried out by Europe and the United States in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, a different Black church missionary activity would focus on solidarity, healing, and liberation for oppressed communities and nations globally. In other words, the African American church would internationalize the best of the Black church tradition in partnership with the darker skin peoples of the world.

This suggestion might seem like an additional or diversionary call to the Black church at this point in its history. Is not the pastoral practice and overwhelming demands of the chocolate inner cities and Black professionals in suburban ghettos already stretching churches to their limit? Do not more immediate life and death issues face us here at home? Look at the continuing HIV and AIDS crisis. How about housing for the working poor and homeless given the decision of major real estate and bank monopolies to flood cities with new expensive townhouses and condominiums? And the job market downsizing and permanent layoffs have wreaked havoc on Black congregations and throughout the entire African American community. It is an old saying but one still bursting with meaning: Black folk are the last hired and the first fired.

These days, Black youth seem to have more meaningful income and cohesive culture by joining gang life. If a young 14-year-old Black boy can earn \$1,000 per day being a soldier in a ghetto gang operation, \$4 an hour flipping hamburgers at the corner restaurant provides no appeal. Yet this immediate gratification and bling-bling lifestyle have shortened the life expectancy of African American gang members to about age 24 or 25. When parents would hope their children would be graduating from the university, city morgues are filling up with young Black folk in their early to mid-20s. And the children of Black professional and upper income families are suffering as well. Private school and college costs are skyrocketing. In some places, the private school tuition at the kindergarten level is the same as some college tuition 20 years ago. If parents are paying that much for five-year olds, we can imagine what the price of the ticket is for college and university admissions.

The youth are the future and the dream for the freedom of the Black community. Lack of legitimate opportunities and community nurture will stunt the growth of Black progress for

generations to come. At the other age group, African American elders also feel the squeeze. Pension funds have been slashed; in some instances they have been raided by multi-millionaire capitalists. Medicaid and Medicare budgets have shrunk. The costs of prescription drugs never go down and cheaper generic brands are blocked from entering the United States.

Housing, health care, jobs, the survival of youth, and the plight of the elders have forced the Black church to take on a variety of ministries in addition to the usual boy scouts and girl scouts. And we have not even mentioned the threats to the spiritual viability of the Black family. The rate of divorce in the United States is over 50 percent. Suicide has increased among Black youth. Teenage pregnancy appears to have no limit. There's always been a practice of the extended family. But today, the grandmother and grandfather, the ones who anchored the extended family, might be less than 30 years old. Added to the pressing time constraints of creative and positive Black church ministries are the day-to-day running of the church building and bureaucracy. There are choir rehearsals and deacon board meetings. And we haven't touched on the patience and preparation needed to prepare Sunday sermons—the heart of spiritual uplift and prophetic vision.

Given these realities, why should mission come to the forefront of Black church practice in the twenty-first century? Why should the Black church internationalize the best of its tradition in partnership with the darker skin peoples of the world? I would argue at least three reasons. One—creation: Black folk were created out of an international system filled with different language and ethnic groups, and today the definition of being African American means an international person. Our African identity and our Black identity already reveal us as international people similar to other darker skin peoples and African peoples worldwide. Two—tradition: The Black church has a long tradition of linking the well-being of the African American community with oppressed nations and darker skin peoples globally. And three—Jesus' mission: The gospel message revealed in the Bible urges all who claim good news for the broken hearted and the oppressed to pursue the *missio dei*, that is to say, to carry forth the mission of God to all far and distant lands on behalf of the liberation of the poor.

Created as an International People

In August 1619, 17 African men and 3 African women were brought by force to Jamestown, Virginia. A Dutch war ship dropped them off after selling them for some food, clothes, and fresh water. This historic arrival points to the metaphorical grandparents of all African Americans up until today. These ancestors birthed Black people. Prior to August 1619, there was no such people called Black Americans or African Americans. Black folk were created beginning with the seventeenth century. African Americans are only 400 years old. What is important to note for our purposes is how African Americans were created. People from 100s of different language and ethnic groups were enslaved on the west coast of Africa, taken against their will across the Atlantic Ocean, and whipped into the slavery system in the so-called New World. Some were stolen from the male and female societies of, what we today call, Sierra Leone and Liberia.¹ We have to remember that modern nation states did not exist in Africa during this time. Instead they had their own international or multi-regional communities and empires. Thousands of different language groups and ethnic peoples existed in all directions on the African western coast. White businessmen and Christians took Black bodies from the Fulani, Mandinke, Wolof, Bambara, and Serer.² What we now call Ghana and Nigeria contributed the Akan, Ashanti, Yoruba, Ewe, Ibo, and Twi. Others were ripped from the Ibibio, Arada, Biafada, and Bakongo language groups.³

Not only did the African ancestors of Black Americans originate from distinct language and ethnic groups. They also built various extended families, villages, clans, confederations, kingdoms, and empires and diverse political states.⁴ They were, in fact, an international people.

The empire of Ghana, dating back to the beginning of the Christian era and lasting into the eleventh century, constituted a large body of land with provinces.⁵ Starting in the early thirteenth century, the Mali Empire rose and surpassed the rule of Ghana. And then the fifteenth century witnessed the Songhay empire come into full blossom. Besides these huge international bodies, there existed lesser groupings of states on the west coast of Africa. For instance, the Wagadugu states ruled in the eleventh century, the Kanem grouping in the thirteenth century, and a smaller Congo empire held sway in the fourteenth century. In fact, even into the nineteenth century, the Oyo empire ruled across vast land areas.⁶

Important to note about all of these political states and empires is their extensive ability to trade across territorial boundaries. Obviously, extensive commercial interaction took place among all of the states in the west and north west coasts of Africa. But, even more, many of the larger empires conducted trade with Egypt and Europe.⁷

Again, we can see a couple of implications for who we are as Black people or African Americans. Prior to European Christian explorers and missionaries, our ancestors who lived with their faith and witness to the High God were already engaged in international communications up and down West Africa, across the Sahara Desert to northeast Africa, and even trading in Europe. These pre-colonial ancestors of enslaved African people in the United States were an international people who linked their domestic affairs and well-being with the plight and hope of darker skin peoples across different borders. The tradition of ancient Africa is a global one.

In addition, the creation of African Americans, beginning in 1619 Jamestown, Virginia, reveals that our blood is constituted by a host of different African cultural, ethnic, linguistic, and regional groupings. The white Christian slave masters in colonial America and similarly in the new United States broke up African communities from the same families, empires, villages, and languages. When these Christian slave owners made decisions on which enslaved Africans would mate to produce more Black workers for the plantation, the masters simply mated whoever was on their farms or whoever they could get from a neighboring plantation. The very being of Black folk means a mixture of diverse ancestry from the African west coast. This creation out of a mixture of peoples has led to a tradition of solidarity with global dark skin peoples.

Tradition of Solidarity with Global Dark Skin Peoples

Though the European Christian slave trade and the white American Christian slave trade in Black bodies made it clear that the majority of Africans never would see their homelands again, still Black people fought for their freedom in the so-called New World while also keeping their eyes globally. They understood that slavery did not create them. God had already breathed life into them before they entered the chattel system; and God stayed with them even during the brutality of bondage. The seventeenth century saw Black folk running away from slavery to Canada, while others remained in Dixie land of cotton, tobacco, and sugar cane. Those left behind kept their dreams on a better land; but for many heaven was their home—a home where folk would one day reunite with family members, ancestors, and other dark skin peoples. Some even dreamed of flying their way back to their earthly home Africa. Whether pursuing their Canaan land of Canada, imagining liberation in heaven, or fixating on returning to the Continent, all plans for freedom had a profound religious basis and motivation.

Perhaps the clearest relationship between religious identity and international connections is found in the eighteenth-century birth of Black Christian churches. During the 1700s, enslaved Black preachers established several African Baptist churches. George Liele, a Black man freed by his master who was pro-British in the War of Independence, organized some African churches in Georgia before he emigrated to Jamaica. Though born in the United States, he built the first

(1782) Black Baptist church in the Caribbean. Andrew Bryan, a slave ordained by Liele but one who decided to remain in bondage in the United States, started the First African Baptist Church in Savannah. Thirteen years later (1793), the First African Baptist Church of Augusta, Georgia sprang up.⁸ Clearly southern Black folk, bond and free, intentionally named their churches “African” because they linked their Christian identity in North America with their African identity globally.

Likewise northern African Americans separated from white Christian brethren to conduct Christian religious affairs among their own kind. Richard Allen and Absalom Jones departed from the white St. George’s Methodist Episcopal Church of Philadelphia in 1787 and organized an African religious association called the Free African Society. Yet 1816 marked the founding of the African Methodist Episcopal denomination when the Free African Society, the Baltimore African church, the Union Church of Africans in Wilmington, Delaware, and others merged.⁹ And the year 1820 brought about the African Methodist Episcopal Zion denomination. Black working-class women, likewise, engaged in tying their Black identity with their cultural identity in recognition of their original heritage from the Continent. In the early 1800s, they organized mutual aid relief societies—pooling their meager pennies to pay for burials, children without fathers, invalid community members, and widows. Specifically, they named their organizations the Daughter of Africa Society or the African Female Benevolent Society. The latter self-help group consisted of African-born ex-slaves.¹⁰

Indeed, the nineteenth century revealed a major blossoming of religious longing on the part of African American denominations toward their distant cousins in Africa and the Caribbean. Moving beyond merely naming their churches African Black Christians took the initiative in the missionary field. Though I will later critique the standard theological doctrine of missiology, that is, the orthodox notion of planting Christian churches on foreign lands, the spiritual impulse to look toward darker skin peoples beyond the North American shores concerns us at this point. The Baptist preacher Lott Carey made several trips to Liberia to share the good news of the gospel. His early leadership across the Atlantic made him, perhaps, the premier symbol of Black American outreach to their original homeland. In 1824, Richard Allen sent forth church representatives to establish Haiti as the first international mission station for the African Methodist Episcopal Church.¹¹ The AME denomination, lest than 30 years later, undertook successful campaigns to broaden church work to Cuba, Antigua, Virgin Islands, Dutch Guiana, British Guiana, Bermuda, Barbados, and Tobago. And AME bishop Henry McNeal Turner planted churches from Liberia to Cape Town.¹²

Back at home under the white Christian slave system in southern United States, some enslaved Black communities approached their relation to darker skin peoples internationally from a different perspective. Instead of undertaking journeys to Africa or the Caribbean, the reverse would be true. Specifically, Denmark Vesey of Charleston, South Carolina, planned a Christian rebellion in 1822 against the slave system partially based on his expectations of definite international solidarity. Vesey had already purchased his own freedom. Yet his Christian good news of liberation for the oppressed focused his witness on destroying chattel existence for the rest of his oppressed sisters and brothers still caught in the grip of slavery. Vesey and other members of the African Church of Charleston planned a massive armed insurrection, which, once initiated, would receive additional troops from Haiti and West Africa. The co-conspirators conjured an elaborate scheme to overpower the local white population with expectations of solidarity and reinforcements from darker skin peoples globally. In fact, some evidence suggests that one of Vesey’s Christian comrades had communicated with the president of Haiti.¹³

The twentieth-century African American struggle for full humanity continues this tradition of fighting for human dignity and justice locally while building networks with the world’s darker skin populations.¹⁴ The premier religious freedom movement of the twentieth century and the civil rights movement led by the Black church, actively stretched forth its hands in solidarity with other oppressed peoples. In 1957, a year after the successful Montgomery, Alabama

bus boycott, Martin Luther King, Jr. attended the independence ceremonies of Ghana. In 1959, King spent a month showing compassion for and building solidarity with the people of India. Note that both trips did not perceive Christian global contact as planting a church or taking people out of their own indigenous religions and forcing or massaging them into or asking them to join Christianity. King, an ordained clergy of the gospel of Jesus Christ, understood mission as standing in solidarity, showing compassion, and aiding the struggle for justice and liberation wherever darker skin communities found themselves. And in a very direct way in his Nobel Peace Prize speech, he stressed this tie between the Black American effort toward civil rights and the world's people of color.¹⁵

Most theologically and most dangerously, his anti-Vietnam War speech of April 4, 1967, displays this drum major for Jesus Christ at his best. That prophetic oration and visionary call for poor people of color's human dignity reveals a progressive understanding of Christian mission. King declared that the poor and oppressed people of Vietnam, like others globally, were inextricably intertwined with the poor and Black folk of the United States. And King spoke explicitly as a preacher of Christ. Again, the substance of his words drew on solidarity, compassion, humanity, and freedom for the world's poor, regardless of their religious choices. For him, this was the good news of the Bible.¹⁶

Fannie Lou Hamer, another stalwart Christian leader of the civil rights movement, embraced the Slave Spiritual, "This Little Light of Mine," as her personal faith expression. Yet the shining of that light helped move her from the life-and-death situations of southern struggle to the new republic of Guinea in West Africa. There in 1964 in her meetings with the country's president and other citizens, Mrs. Hamer received a profound affirmation of her sense of being a child of God. Moreover, her encounter with darker skin peoples abroad not only increased her knowledge and compassion for their struggles. It also deepened further her appreciation for her own challenges in Mississippi.¹⁷ She knew that poor and working-class people were not alone; they operated in a global sphere.

During that same year, 1964, when Mrs. Hamer, the Christian, visited the Continent, Malcolm X, the Muslim, undertook a major inter-cultural and inter-religious tour throughout Nigeria, Ghana, Liberia, Senegal, Morocco, Algiers, Lebanon, Egypt, and Arabia. His travels brought him in contact with leaders of liberation movements throughout Asia, the Caribbean, Latin America, and, of course, Africa.¹⁸ These dark skin freedom fighters of diverse religious and cultural backgrounds shared their solidarity and support for the Black American plight. Malcolm, in turn, offered the same.¹⁹ From his return home until his death in February 1965, Malcolm continually linked full equality and full humanity of African Americans with the darker skin peoples and countries on earth. Malcolm highlighted Pan Africanism and, while maintaining it, moved to a broader extended family comprised of all darker skin countries and communities globally.²⁰ In addition to his political and cultural analysis, what held this majority of the world's population together was at root a spirituality of solidarity and justice.

Organized Black Christian leaders' networks, likewise, continued the tradition of African Americans holding hands with the world's oppressed peoples. The Black Theology Project (BTP) emerged in 1976 and continued into the early 1990s. This Christian grouping represented the progressive wing of Black male and female pastors and professors. It held dialogues between African American women and Black women in Honduras, South Africa, Nicaragua, El Salvador, Mozambique, and Costa Rica. Along with accompanying the All African Conference of Churches on various country visits, BTP members visited Blacks in Brazil. In the same vein, BTP began a program of church exchanges between Black American pastors and those in oppressed countries. Black Cuban Christians were among the first to come to the United States.²¹

Perhaps a fitting place to end this part of our discussion on tracing the tradition of the progressive wing of Black church and Black community approaches to mission is with the

practice and theology of the National Conference of Black Christians (NCBC). NCBC began as the ad hoc National Committee of Negro Churchmen when it published its July 31, 1966, theological interpretation of the Black power slogan.²² This group of Black male pastors and church administrators, along with one woman, launched the contemporary Black theology movement, which rose, not from the academy, but from church sanctuaries and the streets of urban America. An ecumenical gathering of Christian prophets, NCBC initially organized many progressive Black preachers to take stands against the structural sins of white supremacist America. It, too, followed that tradition of working locally while networking internationally. Several trips were taken to Africa in coordination with the All African Conference of Churches (AACC). Global mission work, in these instances, was not so much one of planting churches abroad and trying to convert people to Jesus. Rather, NCBC met with the AACC as partners in solidarity and as Black Americans seeking to learn about their former homeland. What were the commonalities and differences between African Americans and Africans? And how could Black people with abundant resources, living in a American superpower, assist the process of attaining full humanity begun by African sisters and brothers on the Continent—a continent intentionally underdeveloped by Europe and the United States?²³

A 1976 statement of NCBC provides some insight on how the National Conference engaged in mission work globally. The document begins by situating Black theology as the theology of the Black church, Protestant, and Roman Catholic. Then it carves out a specific bridge between Black theology as Black church ecumenism, on the one hand, and the definition of missions, on the other. Black theology, in the words of NCBC, “asserts the operational unity of all Black Christians as the first step toward a wider unity in which the restructuring of power relations in church and society and the liberation of the poor and oppressed will be recognized as the first priority of mission.” The next sentences describe Jesus Christ revealing the divine self to Black people as the liberator of Blacks in Africa, the Caribbean, Latin America, and North America. In fact, the document claims, Africans knew of the gospel by the end of the second century.

But, after asserting this fact, NCBC offers a qualification. Even if the gospel had not penetrated indigenous African Traditional Religions, “God did not leave [Godself] without a witness in Africa before the arrival of Christian missionaries... [God’s] eternal power and deity was shown to all [humankind] from the creation of the world.” The argument here seems to be that, before the message of Jesus reached darker skin peoples throughout the earth, God had already revealed Godself to them. Presumably this divine revelation came in the indigenous religions of Africa, Asia, the Caribbean, Latin America, and the Pacific Islands. If God’s salvation and liberation precede Jesus, then why should white orthodox missionary theology define the goal of mission work to be converting people to Christianity and enrolling them in the Christian church? In other words, why do darker skin peoples globally have to surrender their own indigenous spiritualities and religions and adopt Christ if God is already with them, if God has been with them since the creation of all creation? Here we expect a revolutionary re-definition of white orthodox missions—one whose substance is solidarity with, affirmation, and liberation of the broken hearted, the poor, and the oppressed. We seem to be entering a new era of missiology—one where Black Christians recognize and accept the presence of God among other darker skin people’s spiritualities throughout the world.

However, the document appears to veer back to a white imperialistic type of mission goal when it states: “This truth of God [in Jesus Christ] was hidden in the traditional religions of Africa which awaited their fulfillment in the revelation of Jesus, the Liberator.”²⁴ Okay. Darker skin peoples globally did have God revealed to them but that type of revelation only indicated a partial revelation. And, furthermore, this partial revelation was hidden from them. It is not until white missionaries from Europe and North America and nineteenth-century Black missionaries’ arrival are the majority of the world’s people (that is, darker skin people) saved fully by Jesus Christ. If this be the case then the mission of the African American church and Black theology is the exact equivalent of white orthodox missiology. That is to say, to be a Christian

is to go abroad, plant churches, and force or persuade darker skin peoples to surrender their indigenous spiritualities. Either the Black American Christian's way or there is no way.

The Bible's *Missio Dei*

Part of this apparent double message if not outright contradiction is fostered and nurtured by certain biblical passages around the *missio dei* or mission of God. In Matthew 28: 18–20, the writer of this book remembers the following words of Jesus:

I have been given all authority in heaven and on earth! Go to the people of all nations and make them my disciples. Baptize them in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, and teach them to do everything I have told you. I will be with you always, even until the end of the world.²⁵

Historically, beginning in the eighteenth century and continuing until today, the majority of white orthodox missionaries interpret this passage as starting Christian churches among darker skin people's globally, as well as tearing them away from the religions, spiritualities, clothing, life styles, culture, and language of their parents and their grandparents. Most disturbing today is the growing ultra conservative neo-charismatic, Black American preachers who have contracted with right-wing American white preachers on the international God Channel.²⁶ This international station leaves the United States, beams up into space into a satellite that is controlled by the White House, State Department, and the Central Intelligence Agency and returns to earth to reach millions of oppressed people in Africa, Asia, the Caribbean, Latin America, and the Pacific Islands.

In other words, the God Channel is not an innocent medium of spreading the good news of Christ Jesus. Like any other radio or TV stations broadcasting from the United States, it has to have clearance from the federal government and its secret agencies. My point is that the practice of white orthodox interpretations of Matthew 28 suggests Jesus is like an army officer commanding his troops to conquer the world. One obvious problem exists in falsely depicting Jesus as a military ruler who, through pre-emptive strike, unleashed hoards of followers on the world's darker skin peoples. More substantively, I would argue, the primary purpose of the God Channel and the white and Black American neo-charismatic missionaries is to dominate the world with US civilization and the world policies of the federal government. Here Matthew 28 has become a subterfuge to make the world not in Jesus' image, but in the image of the current administration and corporate elites who run the United States. Neo-charismatic leaders employ Christianity to spread the political, economic, and cultural systems of the one global empire. Wherever Black and white American neo-charismatics go in Africa, Asia, the Caribbean, Latin America, and the Pacific Islands, they use the God Channel and their "deliverance crusades" to accomplish at least two things. They viciously attack peoples' indigenous religions and cultures. And they spread American capitalism and culture. Missionary work is not the theology of Jesus; it is the theology of a superpower.²⁷ Restated, Christianity grows globally only when it is backed by an empire.

We could say that the atrocious and wicked practices symbolized by the perpetrators of the God Channel only represent their false interpretation of the biblical call to missions. Because an imperialistic superpower gives resources to false religious leaders to conquer the globe does not indict Jesus' words in Matthew 28. For example, verse 19 clearly states: "Go to the people of all nations and make them my disciples. Baptize them in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit." Orthodox Christianity calls this the great commission. Yet the words "great commission" appear nowhere in the passage. Great commission actually signifies a white orthodox understanding of Jesus. Furthermore, the phrase "make them my disciples" goes against the

entire ministry of Jesus' earthly witness. Why would a God of love have to "make" others see the beauty of the good news that Jesus brings to poor and oppressed people in order for them to have life and have it abundantly? Perhaps the thrust of these words from Jesus, given only to his 11 disciples on a mountain, need to be juxtaposed with other Jesus teachings.

Specifically, when we go back to Matthew 25:31–46, we discover the final judgment; a scene where humankind has to collectively account for their practice on earth. We do not encounter questions about a prosperity gospel, or a God Channel, or a deliverance ministry, or support of the economics, culture, and politics of a superpower empire. Nor is there a demand to add up and present the numbers of darker skin peoples whom Christians have removed from their indigenous cultures, religions, and spiritualities. Jesus doesn't ask about how many people in the world have been converted to Christianity or how many "word" and "mega-churches" have been built. If we look closely, it also appears as if Jesus does not judge individuals one-by-one, but, instead, he judges the practice of groups of people. And fundamentally, Jesus judges all nations, not just Christians, but all people. Here, Jesus is not concerned whether one is a Christian or not. What makes one a follower of Jesus is if groups of people become witnesses for Jesus. Put differently, we experience ultimate life when we feed the hungry, give drink to the thirsty, give welcome to the stranger, give clothing to the naked, give care to the sick, and visit poor and working class people in prison. Having ultimate life means collectively serving and being with the poor and working people—the unimportant people in society, the least of these. In the entire Bible, Matthew 25 is the only direct instructions and criteria for how to get into heaven.

It should not surprise us that Jesus ends his ministry with his commission in Matthew 25 about serving the poor and working people to have ultimate life. Why? Because, in his first public address where he tells the world what his one mission is, he says the same thing. We can easily see how Luke 4: 18–21 stands as Jesus' inaugural address. The first public words that God gives to the world are not unimportant, insignificant, or off-the-cuff remarks. Christians believe that Jesus is the messiah. Now how does the messiah define his own understanding of mission? What is the theology of mission for Jesus? Luke 4:18–19 reads:

The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because [it] has anointed me to bring good news to the poor. [It] has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to let the oppressed go free, to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor.

Now turning from this new revised standard version translation to the contemporary English version, we find:

The Lord's Spirit has come to me, because [it] has chosen me to tell the good news to the poor. The Lord has sent me to announce freedom for prisoners, to give sight to the blind, to free everyone who suffers, and to say, "This is the year the Lord has chosen."

And the King James' version offers this translation:

The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because [it] hath anointed me to preach the gospel to the poor; [it] hath sent me to heal the brokenhearted, to preach deliverance to the captives, and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty them that are bruised, to preach the acceptable year of the Lord.

The purpose of missionary work around the world does not concern spreading a prosperity gospel, or a God Channel, or a deliverance ministry, or support of the economics, culture, and politics of a superpower empire. Nor is the purpose of mission to add up the numbers of darker skin peoples whom Christians have removed from their indigenous cultures, religions,

and spiritualities. Jesus doesn't ask about how many people in the world have been converted to Christianity or how many "word" and "mega-churches" have been built. Like the final judgment and great commission of Matthew 25, the purpose of mission underscores good news to poor people, healing broken hearts, releasing poor people from jail, curing blindness, and liberating the oppressed people of the world and bringing freedom for those who suffer. The purpose of mission globally focuses on the poor, by struggling together with them in a liberation, freedom, and healing movement and by letting them know that, in fact, right now is their year of liberation and freedom.

Based on Jesus' final judgment and instructions for mission, we judge the words of every other human being in the Bible, including Paul.

Walking in Jesus' Mission

If we walk in the mission of Jesus, we have to take seriously the three major points we have made so far in our conversation. One—creation: Black folk were created out of an international system filled with different language and ethnic groups; and today the definition of being African American means an international person. Our African identity and our Black identity already reveal us as international people similar to other darker skin peoples and African peoples worldwide. Two—tradition: The Black church has a long tradition of linking the well-being of the African American community with oppressed nations and darker skin peoples globally. And three—Jesus' mission: The gospel message revealed in the Bible urges all who claim good news for the broken hearted and the oppressed to pursue the *missio dei*, that is to say, to carry forth the mission of God to all far and distant lands on behalf of the liberation of the poor.

How does the African American church carry this out? I suggest forging global ties through an International Association on Black Religions and Spiritualities. Darker skin people worldwide would come together to learn about and support efforts on behalf of the poor, that is to say, transformation of individuals who suffer and changing systems that keep poor people poor and oppressed.

Today dark skin peoples or Black communities globally share some basic commonalities. First are the variety of expressions of spiritualities and religions. Whether Africa, Asia, the Caribbean, Latin America, the Pacific Islands, or Black people in Europe and the United States, a sense of values glues our peoples, communities, and oppressed nations together. For us, spiritualities and religions unite the sacred and "secular" as one. This progressive worldview and practice exist in all forms of Black spiritualities and religions; such as indigenous, traditional, pre-colonial, post-colonial, Islamic, Santeria, Candomble, Christian, and other mainstream and non-mainstream types. The sacred covers all reality.

A major experience of spiritualities and religions or our sacred values is collective and individual human dignity. The necessity to have human dignity stands at the center of what it means to be a human being. Being human is dignity for the identity of oppressed peoples and of the individual self. And individual human dignity takes place within the context of community human dignity.

Human dignity is close to human rights. But dignity is different from rights. To have human rights assumes that an oppressed community or an individual already enjoys dignity. So human dignity comes before human rights.

What is human dignity? It is made up of at least three parts—self-love, self-esteem, and self-confidence. Self-love means an oppressed people love their own identity—how the sacred has created them and how they are born beautiful and healthy and sacred as a people. Love of self accepts the self without wanting to be someone else. Self-love in an oppressed community embraces its culture (of course, while learning from other cultures), wisdom, languages, spiritualities, religions, ancestors, and ways of being, seeing, and acting in the world. And

self-love includes a love of nature, animals, birds, plants, fish, air, water, earth, and the minerals of the earth.

Self-esteem happens when a people who love themselves put value on themselves. There is worth to our very being. We hold our selves in high regard. When an oppressed community loves itself, it values its history, ancestry, land, language, traditions, unborn, very existence, right to live on earth, and connections to the sacred and all of creation. What worth do we have for ourselves, our bodies, minds, and spirit? What worth do we put on our ancestors, the present, children, and the unborn? What worth do we have for nature and all of creation? What worth do we put on our families and our extended families?

If we love ourselves and hold ourselves in high esteem, we become more self-confident as an oppressed people. Self-confidence helps us to act out our love and esteem of self in the world around us, especially as a people's movement to change the world. With confidence we protect our being and creation. We move in the world to challenge those obstacles that prevent the health of human beings and creation. We have strong confidence in the future and the future of our unborn. We struggle for justice now. And we have a deep hope in a better society and better relations between humans and all of creation. We have hope that healthy societies will one day come on earth. Self-confidence encourages an oppressed people to define its own self and the space around it in such a way that we are in harmony and balance with our selves, neighbors, ancestors, all of creation, and the sacred.

In addition to our spiritualities and religions, defined by collective and individual human dignity, we are all "Black" people. By "Black" we mean the darker skin communities of the world. "Black" is a broad umbrella word. It represents more than skin color. It stands for a tradition of struggle against colonialism caused by Europe and the United States. It represents a history of being the objects of Christian missionary work. Today it indicates attacks on our culture by global propaganda that tries to define what is beauty and the effort to force the entire world to become like the culture of only one superpower. So from the negative side, to be Black is to be ugly, dirty, lacking leadership abilities, ignorant, uncivilized, backward, savage, volatile, overly sexed, low morals, and criminals.

Blackness, in its negative sense, sometimes means passive consumers of products from the major monopoly capitalist corporations in the world. Not only are we seen as easy consumers of these products. Our communities are the ones who work and produce the wealth, products, and income for the small group of families, primarily from the United States and Europe, who own and control the majority of human beings and creation. These elite families and monopoly capitalist corporations have historically stolen and continue today to steal wealth, money, land, and resources from the Third World and from Black folk's labor in the United States. The increasing monopolization of wealth and income taking place globally shows us that the key concern for the world's majority is the elimination of poverty and the establishment of justice.

But we also have to admit that just as Black spiritualities and religions have been positive by sustaining us, helping us to survive and thrive, and resisting negative forces outside of our communities, our own Black spiritualities and religions have a deep negative side. This negative side comes from the unhealthy aspects of our traditions and from us accepting the negative influences of powers seeking to control us and our land. Not all parts of Black religions and spiritualities are positive. A key sign of our harmful spiritualities and religions is the extra oppression faced by women. We have to be aware of negative external and internal factors. But our main vision is to realize that Black religions and spiritualities mean that a better world is possible.

Problems

Various obstacles block the vision of a better world. One of the major problems confronting oppressed Black communities or darker skin people globally is the lack of international

connections. Too many of us are unaware of and not tied to each other. In many examples, we do not know of thousands of grassroots communities struggling for human dignity on a daily basis. If we can connect these life and death movements internationally, it will give us more solidarity, resources, and hope for our local efforts and our children's future. Too often lack of connection keeps our eyes looking at the demands and tasks of local experiences. Yet an international network can help turn our eyes to global friends dealing with similar challenges. Concrete support for the local can come from peoples' movements throughout the world. How can we also learn from all of our local victories? How can we exchange information about the similar ways the small group of major powers are affecting our people's daily existence?

Many of the situations and histories of darker skin peoples around the world show some similarities: gender analysis and balanced gender participation in society, decrease and eventual elimination of poverty, inter-religious dialogue and cooperation, ecology, recovery of indigenous cultures, land dispossession, sexual violence against girls and women, economic fairness, religious freedom, HIV and AIDS, blockades against our countries by a major superpower, youth crime and disillusionment, artistic and material culture, our ability to create new knowledge, democracy defined by our own local cultures and traditions, how can ordinary people have ownership of the resources and governing structures in their own country, what does equality look like if it is defined by the bottom of our societies, and the need to educate our youth.

Other parallel concerns include: the increased presence of transnational businesses, the growth of evangelical Christian missionaries (mainly from the economically developed countries), loss of land, structural adjustment programs demanded by international financial organizations, disruption of cultures due to movements from rural to urban areas, the extra pressures and burdens on women, and centralization of a global mono-culture (through television, movies, music, food tastes, and clothing styles) make critical differences in people's everyday lives. All of these things greatly impact religion and spirituality, especially for poor people who don't have access to wealth, media, and other resources to put their voices into global discussions.

Objectives

An attempt to build an international network on Black religions and spiritualities is one movement to help put oppressed peoples' and poor peoples' voices into international conversations. We think that Black religions and spiritualities throughout the world provide strong, positive resources. Black peoples' countries, communities, and local networks offer unlimited examples of how to work for a better world. An international association can offer another way for progressive religious and spiritual people to show that the dominant, negative religions and spiritualities spreading globally are just one way. Unfortunately the international media, missionaries, and money have come together on a world scale to serve the cultural, political, and economic interests of only a small sector of the earth's six billion people. A Black religions and spiritualities association can try to show a more healthy way in the interests of the world's majority. And important lessons and leadership come from darker skin peoples who occupy every land base and body of water on earth.

The network can link the local to the global. At the same time, the network can encourage its member countries to make alliances with more groups and organizations inside of each country. As people of faith, all of us are working very hard on important issues facing our communities. Because of the demands of our tasks, sometimes we do not have the time or energy to link hands with groups in our own countries. One objective of the international association is to help broaden ties within each nation.

In addition to creating a global network of progressive peoples and encouraging each country to reach out to other groups in their own contexts, an international association on Black

religions and spiritualities can help the development of human dignity for oppressed peoples and communities. We all can become more hopeful to know that solidarity exists across the waters and among continents. The local victories and setbacks are not only part of a larger connection, but they are important. This sense of belonging to a larger relationship and this sense of being important can increase human dignity—self-love, self-esteem, and self-confidence within each of our own unique movements. And so a global association builds human dignity for the local. The lessons and leadership from the local further strengthen the international association. Human dignity of love, esteem, and confidence focuses on working toward a better possible world. The international network can act on issues that all countries have in common. The global association can also agree on a critical issue affecting only one or two countries.

A fourth objective of an international network on Black religions and spiritualities is to practice a new model for women and men working together. Structurally it could always have a 50 percent male and 50 percent female representation. Obviously this structure works against those negative parts of our traditions and current practices that put women in the role of followers. But more importantly, a structure of gender equality offers a way to always draw on the rich wisdom, experience, and intellect that women bring to Black spiritualities and religions. The point is to use all resources we bring from our local contexts into an international network.

Another important objective is the survival, thriving, and future of our youth. History teaches us and common sense tells us that the future of any people or society is in the hands of young people. For instance, Jesus was only 33 years old when he was lynched. The international association can have a special focus on building the human dignity of our youth (girls and boys, and young men and women) by putting youth in contact with youth in other countries. In fact, in each local context, we have at least one thing that ties us together. Some part of our work deals with educating young people and young adults. Perhaps young people and young adults could be one of the major objectives of the network.

Let us conclude by simply stating the following. History, our ancestors, our children, and the gospel itself will judge us. I believe that a better world is possible for the least of these.

Thank you.

Notes

1. Margaret Washington Creel, *A Peculiar People: Slave Religion and Community-Culture among the Gullahs* (New York: New York University Press, 1988), 2.
2. Albert J. Raboteau, *Slave Religion: The "Invisible Institution" in the Antebellum South* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1978), 5.
3. John W. Blassingame, *The Slave Community: Plantation Life in the Antebellum South* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1972), 2.
4. Benjamin Quarles, *The Negro in the Making of America* (New York: Collier Books, 1969), 16. Also see, G. T. Strice and C. Ifeka, *Peoples and Empires of West Africa: West Africa in History 1000–1800* (Nairobi, Kenya: Thomas Nelson and Sons, 1971); Kevin Shillington, *History of Africa*, revised edition (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1995); Roland Oliver, ed., *The Dawn of African History* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1968); and Walter Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* (Washington, DC: Howard University Press, 1974), Chapter 2.
5. Lerone Bennett, Jr., *Before the Mayflower: A History of Black America*, sixth revised edition (New York: Penguin Books, 1993), 13–22.
6. John Hope Franklin and Alfred A. Moss, Jr., *From Slavery to Freedom: A History of Negro Americans*, sixth edition (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1988), 1–11.
7. George P. Rawick, *From Sundown to Sunup: The Making of the Black Community* (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, Inc., 1972), 15.

8. Robin D. G. Kelley and Earl Lewis, eds., *To Make Our World Anew: A History of African Americans* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2000), 149.; and Gayraud S. Wilmore, *Black Religion and Black Radicalism* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1998), 132.
9. Wilmore, op. cit., 108–109.
10. Dorothy Sterling, ed., *We Are Your Sisters: Black Women in the Nineteenth Century* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1984), Chapter 9.
11. Both references to Cary and Haiti can be found in Wilmore, 132.
12. Wilmore, 149–157.
13. Vincent Harding, *There Is a River: The Black Struggle for Freedom in America* (New York: Harcourt Brace, 1981), 65–72; and Dwight N. Hopkins, *Down, Up, and Over: Slave Religion and Black Theology* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2000), 134.
14. America's main intellectual of the twentieth century, W. E. B. DuBois, waged a lifelong campaign bringing Black Americans' issues in concert with the darker skin nations and peoples. One instance: W. E. B. DuBois, "Colonialism, Democracy, and Peace after the War (Summer 1944)," in Herbert Aptheker, ed., *Against Racism: Unpublished Essays, Papers, Addresses, 1887–1961* (Amherst, MA: University of Massachusetts, 1985), 229–244.
15. James H. Cone, *Martin & Malcolm & America: A Dream or a Nightmare* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1991), 312.
16. Martin Luther King, Jr., "A Time To Break Silence," in James M. Washington, ed., *A Testament of Hope: The Essential Writings of Martin Luther King, Jr.* (San Francisco, CA: Harper & Row, 1986), 231–244; and Dwight N. Hopkins, *Shoes That Fit Our Feet: Sources for a Constructive Black Theology* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1993), 187–189.
17. See Stokely Carmichael, *Ready for Revolution: The Life and Struggles of Stokely Carmichael* (New York: Scribner, 2003), 317–318; and Kay Mills, *This Little Light of Mine: The Life of Fannie Lou Hamer* (New York: Dutton, 1993), 134–140.
18. Malcolm X, *The Autobiography of Malcolm X* (New York: Grove Press, 1966), chapters 17, 18, and 19.
19. Malcolm X, *Two Speeches by Malcolm X* (New York: Pathfinder Press, 1965), 22–23.
20. Cone, op. cit., pp. 312–314; and Hopkins, *Shoes*, 189–191. Another leader of the 1960s–1970s Black consciousness and Black power efforts is the Black Panther Party. They advanced a theory of intercommunalism, underscoring the international nature of Black Americans' attempts to be human. See Huey P. Newton, *Revolutionary Suicide* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1973), Chapter 32; and idem, *To Die for the People* (New York: Vintage Books, 1972). Black auto workers in Detroit, Michigan, in addition, show us this global spirituality of solidarity and justice for poor people. In May 1968, African American workers at Ford auto plants formed DRUM—Dodge Revolutionary Union Movement. DRUM supported various international peoples' struggles for self-determination and full humanity: Palestine, South Africa, Mexico, Guatemala, Vietnam, and Rhodesia (Zimbabwe). See Dan Georgakas and Marvin Surkin, *Detroit I Do Mind Dying*, second edition (Boston: South End Press, 1998); and "'Our Thing Is DRUM!' The League of Revolutionary Black Workers," in Manning Marable and Leith Mullings, eds., *Let Nobody Turn Us Around: Voices of Resistance, Reform, and Renewal. An African American Anthology* (Boston: Rowman & Littlefield, 2000), 486–489.
21. *The Black Theology Project* newsletter, Fall 1987, 2–3; and newsletter, Winter 1988, 4–5.
22. The full statement can be found as: "Black Power: Statement of the National Committee of Negro Churchmen. July 31, 1966," in Gayraud S. Wilmore and James H. Cone, eds., *Black Theology A Documentary History, 1966–1979* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1979), 23–30.
23. See Walter Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* (Washington, DC: Howard University Press, 1981).
24. All quotes come from "Black Theology in 1976," 342.
25. This quote comes from the *Jubilee Edition. Holy Bible. African American Jubilee Edition. Contemporary English Version* (New York: American Bible Society, 1995).
26. From February 2005 to January 2006, I traveled to Africa, Asia, the Caribbean, and Latin America and observed the presence of the God Channel and its pro-superpower theology.

Oftentimes, the indigenous, local leaders who have purchased this neo-charismatic, white orthodox missionary posture are more fanatical than the white and Black Americans religious and political leaders who sold them this theology of the empire.

27. For theological analysis of the religion of globalization, see "The Religion of Globalization," in Dwight N. Hopkins, Lois Ann Lorentzen, Eduardo Mendieta, and David Batstone, eds., *Religions/Globalizations: Theories and Cases* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2001), 7–32.

I, too, Sing Songs of Freedom: A Theo-Sociological Praxis toward an Emancipatory Ethic for the Black Church and Its Trans-Same-and- Both-Gender-Loving Members

Dorinda G. Henry

For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present nor things to come, nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

(Romans 8:38–39)

“Star light, star bright, I wish I could, I wish I might have this wish, I wish tonight.” At some point in our lives, we have all recited this nursery rhyme in some form or fashion. Blessed with preadolescent naiveté, we searched the heavens for a falling star or the first star in the sky, to wish for that shiny red bicycle in the window of Sears & Roebuck. If it was not a bicycle, it was a pellet gun or a new pair of shoes, a new dress, a doll, or simply to be in another place—away from the pain, suffering, and abuse of a troublesome household. Whatever the wish, we believed in our heart, our mind, and with all of our soul, that that star had the power to grant us our wish. We closed our eyes as tightly as we could and reached down into the depths of our being to wish that wish turn into reality. We knew for certain, without further contemplation or doubt, that in just a little while our wish would be granted.

Arguably, this was our first existential experience with the Divine. It was our first personal encounter and acknowledgment that there is something out there that is much greater than we are, greater than our parents or our immediate circumstances. So we wished, not only hoping that it would be granted but expecting it to be. In the spirit of this preadolescent naiveté, I come to give voice to my hopes and my fears for the Institutional Black Church (IBC) and its trans-same-and-both-gender-loving (TSBGL) members.

My hope is our reconnection as a community of faith, a community of distinct sociopolitical and historical suffering and rejection. It is a hope for healing, growth, and reconciliation. It is a task that requires a desire and the will to do so on behalf of all parties involved. Without a genuine desire to change from the current behavior and practices of exclusivity and isolation, we are condemned to fail. Gone are the days when religious and spiritual leaders could say just about anything without interrogation, reflection, and certainly without any question of their authority. The IBC is now made up of a multifaceted populace. The church's membership base primarily consists of women and an increasingly formally educated ministerial staff.

Bringing the IBC and TSBGL people together is a task that also demands faith and love. It is a love strong enough to risk being cut off from that which significantly validates my existence—one within the whole of "Blackness." It is also a love that dares to love an institution whose beauty has long been clouded over by short sightedness, covered with pus-filled blemishes of irrelevancy, and foul with the stench of festering sores of exclusivity. I come, hoping to "break bread" with the IBC, to create a partnership that tends to our personal and spiritual wounds, as well as our wounded church.

For African American TSBGL women and men, I use the term "universal," in the sense that there is a certain reality that comes with being born Black in America. We inherit a distinct historical, sociopolitical, and economic experience of oppression and exploitation that is a reality not shared with our white counterparts. We are Black, men and women, and gay—a tripartite condition of being everywhere but not truly welcomed anywhere. Similar to the notion of "universality" is Paul Tillich's concept of "ontological *analysis*," where he places the individual within the collective. He states, "One has to look at things as they are given if one wants to discover the principles, the structures, and the nature of being as it is embodied in everything that is."¹

Tillich expounds this further with the use of the Greek word *prosopon*. Like *persona*, it points to the individual in relation to the universality of the person. Conversely, Tillich's "ontological analysis" and his incorporation of *prosopon* align itself squarely with the "universality" of Blackness as it relates to African American TSBGL people. We "*are*" by way of our relationship to the whole of our particular universal "*being*." The "'person,' [sic] is established in the encounter of an ego-self with another self, often called the 'I-thou,' relationship, and it exists in community with other persons."² It is the spirit of the South African term *Ubuntu*—"I am because we are," or, "I in you and you in me." Thus, the African American TSBGL person's singular cry of "*I am somebody*" (my italics), in the Theo-sociological and historical context of African American people is synonymous with the words used in Martin Luther King, Jr.'s last public address, "*We as a people*, will get to the promised land" (my italics).³

The IBC has denied TSBGL people the sanctity of the congregational experience through its use of inflammatory and obsessive rhetorical preaching of condemnation. The denial of said experience indelibly blocks the most familiar manner by which we were introduced to God. Notwithstanding traditions and the African sacred cosmos that survived the Middle Passage and enslavement, it is the medium by which we are most at *home* with when accessing God. The IBC has participated in and perpetuated the social sin or rather the condition of homophobia (i.e., an irrational fear and hatred of homosexuals) and heterosexism. I charge the IBC with causing additional, undue suffering-and-rejection to its TSBGL members, thereby rendering us *personae non gratae*.

As an African American woman and a lesbian brought up in the South and the Baptist tradition, the significance and the influence of the Black church in the context of the African American experience is paramount. It is a testament to the tenacity of a people to hold on to hope for human recognition, justice in light of said recognition, and an equality that presupposes the inalienable quality of their recognized humanity. It is a church experience born out of slavery, often referred to as "slave religion," the "folk religion of [enslaved Africans]."⁴ Ultimately, it is a community of shared historical, cultural, sociopolitical, and economic

experiences of oppression, systemic racism, and exploitation. By virtue of being born Black in America, we, too, inherit this birthright and are ascribed a predetermined legacy of second-class citizenship. This legacy is not exclusively held by heterosexual African Americans, but one that is shared by *all* bearing the burden of being born Black in America.

In a white, androcentric-dominated society, significant suffering-and-rejection is inevitable and even expected for African American women. As a lesbian, however, the multiplicity of being a Black lesbian in an androcentric, heterosexist society increases that suffering-and-rejection exponentially. We, therefore, have the moral right and obligation to challenge the conservative nature of the IBC and the contemporary inclination for co-optation. We must challenge the status quo of exclusivity, accommodation, and assimilation of the IBC into the mores of the dominant culture, even against its very nature. Challenging the status quo entails remaining within and/or returning to the pews of IBC. It means “encouraging” the IBC—through visibility, socio-theological teachings, political engagement, and conversation—to adhere to the social justice teachings of the prophets and Jesus of Nazareth.

Slavery and Oppression

American chattel slavery got its boost by the inference of a color-identified, economic classification. The coloring of “Blackness,” during slavery, became the defining moment and criteria by which the imperialist gaze and the establishment of “Whiteness,” equating to superiority in all things tangible, and “Blackness,” equating to inferiority in all things tangible, was actualized.

In addition to the kidnapping and forced importation to another land, the African, now enslaved, accordingly endured the separation of tribal connections, family, and friends. He or she was not allowed to engage in or practice their own tribal, communal, or spiritual rituals and ceremonies. The enslaved African’s survival rested upon his or her ability to negotiate one’s new unfamiliar, hostile, and ever-changing social paradigm. And to do so, the enslaved African accepted (at least outwardly) a posture of submissiveness or docility. The “submissiveness” of the enslaved was a necessary condition for the survival of the institution of slavery. Toward that end, inhumane methods of torture and control were used from beatings, the raping of enslaved women, punishment by the selling off of family members, and lynchings. G. W. F. Hegel illustrates this awkward existence:

The [enslaved] consciousness is, for the master, the object which embodies the truth of his certainty of himself . . . for just where master has effectively achieved lordship, he really finds that something has come about quite different from an independent consciousness . . . The truth of the [master] consciousness is accordingly the consciousness of the bondsman.⁵

The survival of slavery was therefore predicated upon the enslaver’s control of the enslaved, not only physically but psychologically, emotionally, and spiritually.

One of the most effective tools utilized in controlling the enslaved African was denying them tools of learning. Laws were quickly enacted to criminalize teaching enslaved Africans how to read. However, it did not stop them from learning and thriving. Through imitation, emulation, adaptation, and syncretism of retained customs and rituals from their homeland, the enslaved Africans established systems of communal governing and ways of expressing commitments, marriages, and methods of worship.

Although many of the slave masters found the worship gatherings entertaining, their practice of Christianity and biblical hermeneutics were closely monitored. Many enslavers took no exception to the enslaved Africans hearing and learning the Bible and the gospels in its “purest” form. While some may dispute any part of Ephesians as having a liberative quality, many of the enslaved highlighted Ephesians 6: 6–9 as proof that their present condition was

antithetical to God and, thus, to humankind. It was, in many ways, the first of many efforts to establish a distinctive canon and hermeneutic for interpreting the Scriptures. While many enslaved Africans embraced Christianity with some passion and urgency, not all subscribed to the enslavers' interpretation of the Scriptures. Some even syncretized Christianity and their selective canon with the beliefs and practices of the African sacred cosmos they brought with them. The God of the enslaved Africans was a God of justice, a God of deliverance. Theirs was "the God who delivered the Israelites,"⁶ and the God who would do the same for them. As a result, Christianity took on an entirely different form from what the enslavers envisioned.

The preachers at the worship gatherings were instrumental in lifting the hopes of the enslaved in what could easily be described as a hopeless situation. They inspired a sense of worth by placing special emphasis on the fact that the Scriptures pointed to a God that saw no distinction between the free and the enslaved. They were the "same [in the eyes of the Lord] whether [they] be slave or free" (my brackets). "By identifying with the Hebrews in Egypt and with other Biblical heroes, the enslaved African telescoped history, replacing chronological time with a form of sacred time."⁷ Hence the God of justice, the God of deliverance, and the God of salvation was the God that would free the enslaved from the yoke of the contemporary Pharaoh in America.

Pride and Prejudice

With "Blackness" concretely established as the distinctive color and feature of chattel slavery, Africans became the most hated and despised group in America. We inherited that legacy. Cornel West adds that "two hundred and forty-four years of slavery and nearly a century of institutionalized terrorism in the form of segregation, lynching, and second-class citizenship in America were aimed at [the] devaluation of Black people."⁸ When a group of people suffer unimaginable oppression, degradation, hatred, and loathing, as have the enslaved Africans and their descendants, one residual effect of that experience may be an internalization of that hatred. A second effect is a projection of that hatred onto another by identifying one that is hated more or—at the very least—equal to what they themselves have experienced. The first identified group adopts the same structures, languages, and methods of oppression against the second identified group in an attempt to elevate itself above a society's lowest standard. In this instance, the second identified group comes in the form of TSBGL people.

African American TSBGL women and men, though beneficiaries of that same inheritance, do not enjoy the same privilege of having our God-given humanity recognized as such. By having our humanity denied, particularly within the context of our racial kinship, we endure the consequences of estrangement by our community, family, friends, and church, with few exceptions. This separation and casting out is in large part based upon the belief that our sexuality is a matter of choice and not a construct of God—an abomination not warranting the same guarantee of inalienable rights and protections as any other group of people. As a result, we emerged as the "permissible victim" of violence and social sin.⁹ Jamie T. Phelps speaks of social sin as

Failure to study and personally integrate the social justice teachings of the church, and the unconscious and conscious inaction on the part of those who possess institutional power and those who are victims of the current structural arrangements, has blocked change and perpetuated the socially sinful status quo.¹⁰

When the dominant group in a society deems certain other members as subhuman and antithematic, an atmosphere of hatred and contempt ensues. We are considered an enemy of the state, of the church, and of God when who we are, the pigment of our skin, who and how

we love, or, when the conflict of our assigned gender, is at war with the gender that we *know* ourselves to be. Our sexuality becomes the identifiable distinction that makes a difference. What follows is the manifestation of that hatred in the form of violence and/or silence by the church when violence occurs against said individuals or group. The silence of the IBC implies consent.

Earlier, I mentioned West's description of "institutionalized terrorism" against African Americans in the form of lynching and second-class citizenship. When an individual's humanity is in question, lack of regard for its humanity follows. Individuals express their irrational fear and hatred in extreme acts of brutality. In the 1600s and the subsequent years, enslaved Africans and their descendants were subjected to years of unthinkable random and systemic acts of violence. The humanity of African American TSBGL persons must be recognized in the same manner deserved by our African ancestors and their descendants.

Between 1992 and 1994, a national survey of lesbian, gay, and bisexual homicides showed that "over half involved extraordinary and horrific violence, including dismemberment, multiple stabbing and gross beatings."¹¹ The violence and discrimination against persons based on their sexuality and gender identity has not waned. The number of recent high-profile shooting deaths of unarmed Black women and men by police—many with impunity—and white men in general, claiming to have acted in self-defense, is indicative of the fact that African Americans remain on the list of "permissible victims." More than 70 unarmed Black women, men, and children were killed by police or while in police custody in the years between 1999 and 2015.¹²

Inasmuch as African Americans continue to suffer the devaluation of our humanity, the transgender community, in general, and transgender women of color, in particular, are finding themselves as the latest contemporary "permissible victims." Founder and executive director of TILTT, Inc., Cheryl C. Courtney-Evans states, "The underlying causes of these assaults and murders, [*sic*] is the devaluing of our humanity. Particularly troublesome, is how the media reports the murders (misuse of pronouns, inaccurate names and gender identification) that exacerbates the pain and the deaths." Additionally, "the continuing exclusion from community and church, coupled with employment and housing discrimination[,] often places transgender women and men in dangerous situations."¹³ We cannot claim the sacredness of Black lives when even among our own kith and kin silence is what eulogizes murdered TSBGL people.

We, along with our allies, must question the selective and subjective interpretations of the church's "sacred canopy"—those scriptural texts that mediate a prescribed and accepted narrative that is perceived to best facilitate the survival of the African American community.¹⁴ Scholars have suggested that the IBC and the African American community's adoption of a social, political, and theological ideology of oppression toward TSBGL people is the result of the dominant culture's oppression and exploitation of Black sexuality.

Cornel West discusses Black sexuality as "the taboo subject." He states,

Americans are obsessed with sex and fearful of Black sexuality. The obsession has to do with a search for stimulation and meaning in a fast paced, market-driven culture; the fear is rooted in visceral feelings about Black bodies and fueled by sexual myths of Black women and men. The dominant myths draw Black women and men either as threatening creatures who have the potential for sexual power over Whites, or as harmless, desexed underlings of a White culture.¹⁵

Kelly Brown Douglas follows closely to this line of reasoning suggesting, "Black people's views toward homosexuality must be understood in light of their responses to sexuality in general, particularly as those responses have been refracted by White culture."¹⁶ West asserts that the response to Black sexuality has been on the level of accommodation. Accommodation in this instance is "to be influenced by the larger society and to take part in aspects of it, however marginal that participation may be."¹⁷ The act of accommodation can be viewed as a means

of survival in a system whose very existence depends upon the assimilation, accommodation, or docility of its subjects. "Avoid any substantive engagement with Black sexuality and your survival on the margins of American society is, at least, possible."¹⁸ Essentially, "see no evil, do no evil, speak no evil," and the majority white culture will at the very least tolerate Black people.

If we accept West and Douglas's representation that the Black community's homophobia is based upon its internalization of oppressive and exploitative messages about Black bodies, then we must also accept that African Americans are still mentally, emotionally, theologically, and spiritually enslaved. If we allow the internalized oppression and exploitation of our bodies to dictate how we authentically live out our sexuality, then we are still physically enslaved as well. If we accept this position as *truth*, and we lay the responsibility for our homophobia at the feet of white culture—which appears to be Douglas's position—then we need to stop lauding the African American community and the IBC, in particular, as being free from, and uncontrolled by, white culture. The notion that we adhere to a distinct "sacred canopy" is nothing more than a clever red herring.

While the IBC may have maintained a distinctly independent and separate existence from the rest of society, it remains controlled by its willingness to be co-opted. Social and political groups that stoke the flames of historical oppression and exploitation of African Americans create an atmosphere that promulgates a culture of "survival of the fittest." Survival in a culture such as this requires some level of power. Power in this context can be measured in degrees of privilege.

Our interpersonal relationships and our need to be among those of privilege—however minimal and illusory that privilege might be—lend themselves as justification for determining that some distinctions do make a difference. In an androcentric society, privilege arises in a hierarchy of power. At the highest level is whiteness (heterosexual or homosexual), maleness (heterosexual), maleness (homosexual), and so on, with heterosexual Black women clinging to one level of privilege above Black lesbians. This creates an obsessive desire in heterosexual black women that demands adherence to the one element that affords them the last little crumb left of privilege—heterosexuality. At the same time the African American community seeks to accommodate white culture, hoping to obtain or retain some modicum of privilege, it becomes a prime target for outside influences. Consequently, the ideation of the heterosexual Black woman then becomes—Black though I may be, female and even poor—but at least I am not a lesbian.

We have been "duped" and "bamboozled" by factions such as the Christian Coalition and the Religious Right into believing that our participation in the social, political, and theological oppression of TSBGL women and men will somehow change what and how they think and feel about heterosexual, churchgoing Black folk. Similar to the circumstances of chattel slavery, the IBC is the place where this inclination of accommodation *should* meet resistance. And meet it, we must.

Increasingly, African American TSBGL women and men are returning to the pews of the IBC without "fear and trembling." We are recognizing that being a sexual minority does not erase the reality of being born Black in America. Audre Lorde instructs us in this paradigm: "In order to perpetuate itself, every oppression must corrupt or distort those various sources of power within the culture of the oppressed that can provide energy for change."¹⁹ Within the context of the broader lesbian, gay, and bisexual community, whiteness appears first on the hierarchy of power and privilege as in the larger society. The same power structure of privilege remains in effect. It is "business as usual" with regard to race and gender.

In like manner, where wider culture refuses to relinquish any amount of power and privilege, heterosexual or homosexual, whiteness is the point of departure for every decision made regarding the rights of sexual minorities. Evidence of this phenomenon can be found in the community's visible leadership, which primarily consists of upper-middle-class white men. Sadly, it has taken a nonchalant attitude about AIDS since the number of new infection

AIDS cases among white gay men has shown a drastic decline. The shouts and demands for funds, policies, and resources have dulled to an ineffectual monotone of contentment even though the numbers of AIDS cases in communities of color and women—particularly African Americans—are rising at an alarmingly high rate. The encapsulation of transgender people within the context of the broader lesbian and gay community highlights our acts of accommodation and collective silence and inaction regarding the rights and protections of transgender people. We, too, run the risk of creating the same oppressive power structures and hierarchical dynamics of privilege.

For many TSBGL people, the singular commonality of being Black in America, coupled with the desire and the need to be at *home*—fully participating in the communal togetherness and the shared experiences of the traditional faith experience of the IBC, is more important than the church's acceptance of our sexuality. Does this mean that there is something universal in the worship experience of the IBC? No, it does not. However, there is something universal in "Blackness" and all that "Blackness" encompasses. James Cone points the reader to the book of Matthew and *The Judgment of the Gentiles* when emphasizing the literal and symbolic interpretation of the Blackness of Christ. He contends that Christ's Blackness is literal:

In the sense that he truly becomes One with the oppressed Blacks, taking their suffering as his suffering and revealing that he is found in the history of our struggle, the story of our pain, and the rhythm of our bodies . . . Christ's Blackness is the American expression of the truth of his parable about the Last Judgment: "Truly, I say to you, as you did it not to one of the least of these, you did it not to me."²⁰

He goes on further to suggest, "The least in America are literally and symbolically present in Black people."²¹ A likely deduction of that proposition is that America's "judgment" is contingent upon its response to the needs of Black people. How then is the "least of these" held accountable for their responsiveness, or lack thereof, when among them, there is yet another considered "least of these"? I challenge Cone to take his theory of Christ's "Blackness" even further, to extend his theology and his horizon to reach out to the outskirts of the outer limits. I contend that Cone could and should go beyond the margins of the marginalized and juxtapose his theory of Christ's "Blackness" in relation to the IBC and its TSBGL members. Cone's statement, however racially and culturally polarizing it may be, becomes equally applicable to African American TSBGL women and men. We, too, can then say of Jesus that "his [gayness] is literal in the sense that he truly becomes one with the oppressed [TSBGL], taking [our] suffering as his suffering and revealing that he is found in the history of our struggle, the story of our pain, and the rhythm of our bodies."

By virtue of being born Black in America, we, too, are ascribed a predetermined legacy of second-class citizenship. It is further compounded by the heterosexist ideology that we are antithetical to "nature" and thus to God. The IBC is often the first line of defense when initiating group recourse for human and civil rights violations. In its condemnation and ostracism of African American TSBGL women and men, we are out of relationship with another. In order to reconnect to the whole of our universal being, we must break our silence and rejoin in community with the IBC. We must do so with honesty and authenticity. The IBC must once again resist accommodating white culture and its exploitation of our bodies. This is our place; it is our lot in life, our cross to bear.

"Take up your cross and follow me"

A word of caution before proceeding with this concept of suffering-and-rejection: it is important to note that this is not a matter of suffering for the sake of suffering. Rather, it is a matter of heeding the call of Jesus to take up our cross and walk in the light with full disclosure that,

by doing so, we risk the possibility of rejection, isolation, and, yes, even death. The first step in this process for African American TSBGL members of IBC is to confront its “sacred canon.” We must be bold in our faith. We must shed the weak physical skin of selfishness and put on the whole armor of God. We must die a death of superficiality and denounce the lie and the social constructs that would keep us from communion with our God, our community, and our church. To accomplish this, we, African American TSBGL Christians, must either return to the pews of the IBC and become outspoken critics or become more visible socially and politically. We, too, must stop participating in our own oppression by accommodating the IBC. We must speak openly and honestly about who we are and whose we are. We have to walk in love and in faith that ours is a righteous cause. Our silence implies consent; it implies shame. We must embrace our liberation without fear and trembling, shouting out loud that we, too, are not ashamed of the gospel and that we, too, sing songs of freedom. Suffering in silence is not our redemption, nor is it the redemption of the IBC.

As African American TSBGLs, one of our great spiritual imperatives is to challenge and deny contentions that we are out of “order,” that homosexuality is inconsistent with Christianity. Not only are we fighting the social condition of homophobia and heterosexism, but we are also fighting the cultural sin/condition of internalized homophobia and heterosexism. We, like many Christians, are subscribing to the cliché, “love the sinner, but hate the sin.” When we recite this mantra, it clears the way for the IBC to continue on its present course of exclusion and condemnation of TSBGL persons. When we subscribe to this seemingly gentler approach and give credibility to it by uttering the phrase ourselves, we once again participate in our own oppression.

We have suffered the indignity of sitting in church while the pastor has taken liberties with the text and performed amazing feats in hermeneutic gymnastics around the creation narrative. Hermeneutic gymnastics is not a spectator sport. It is a call or a challenge for examination, critique, and, when appropriate, rebuttal. When we become partners in our liberation, we flip the script on oppression and the oppressor in a way that precipitates transformation. For homosexuality is not sinful in itself, any more than heterosexuality is sinful in itself.

The sinfulness comes into play when we are denied the right of self-actualization through the denial of health care, employment and housing discrimination, and “marriage,” which, in its purest form, is the joining of two distinct and separate parts into one. In 1996, to the dismay of many of his supporters, President William Jefferson “Bill” Clinton signed the Defense of Marriage Act (DOMA), “barring federal recognition of same-sex marriages for purposes such as Social Security survivors’ benefits, insurance benefits, immigration and tax filing.”²² On June 26, 2013, 17 years later, in the court case, *The United States v. Windsor*, US Supreme Court ruled, “the federal Defense of Marriage Act, which defines marriage as a union between one man and one woman, is unconstitutional.”²³

Since the High Court’s ruling 32 states, including the District of Columbia, now allow marriage between same-gender people. Prior to these victories, DOMA and efforts like Proposition 8 in California, which sought to ban same-gender marriage in California, were driven by an irrational fear, lack of understanding, hatred, and contempt. They were tools of discrimination and practices enacted to oppress marginalized communities. They were unjust laws that could not withstand the bend of the moral arc. Dr. Martin Luther King put it this way: “Any law that uplifts human personality is just. Any law that degrades human personality is unjust.”²⁴ These practices should ring loud in the ears of African Americans, for they are the same oppressive constructs and methods used against our ancestors. They are laws that are based upon a preferred status quo, an accepted moral order that in the not so distant past included African Americans.²⁵

In her essay “*Sexual Orientation and Human Rights Discourse in the African-American Churches*,” Cheryl Sanders states, “As Christians and especially as leaders of faith communities, we are called to practice lifestyles that are consistent with our community’s highest moral

standards for personal piety, ecclesial authenticity and prophetic social response.”²⁶ She goes on to express her disappointment with both conservative and liberal interpreters who engage in what she calls “proof-texting” as a means for substantiating homosexuality. In her opinion, “proof-texting always means what others do with the Bible to support views *we don’t affirm*.”²⁷ I am unclear as to who “we” are for Cheryl Sanders, but I assume “we” refers to heterosexual preachers and other heterosexual African American churchgoing folk who are still enslaved. They are held captive by their acts of assimilation and accommodation to white culture. She seems to ignore the fact that scholars have pointed out time and again that: (1) Romans 1:18–32 is the only passage in the New Testament that speaks of same-sex intercourse, and (2) that Genesis 19, the story of Sodom and Gomorrah, is irrelevant to contemporary understandings of homosexuality. For example, “The gang-rape scenario exemplifies the wickedness of the city, but there is nothing in the passage pertinent to a judgment about the morality of consensual homosexual intercourse.”²⁸

While she concedes that homosexuality is not addressed in the gospels, she states, “There and throughout the rest of the Bible, it is affirmed repeatedly that ‘God has made man and woman for one another and that our sexual desires rightly find fulfillment within heterosexual marriage.’”²⁹ It is not surprising that she does not offer specific scriptural texts for reflection and interrogation to substantiate her position. What we are left with is a preoccupation with genital sex and likely irresponsible assertions that homosexuality and AIDS are synonymous.

Any simplified interpretation of the Scriptures should be challenged. The narrative on the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah informs us more about the failure of the citizens of Sodom to respect the religious practices of Near Eastern culture regarding hospitality than about homosexuality. That this text has remained within our “sacred canopy” is a matter that cries out for earnest dialogue, critique, and some reimagining.

Because it does remain within a “sacred canopy,” it is important to consider alternative interpretations of its meaning, both in scholarship and within the Hebrew Scriptures. It should also be noted that the prophet Isaiah claimed that Sodom was destroyed because of lack of doing justice (Isaiah 1:10; 3:9); Jeremiah spoke of Sodom’s sin as adultery, lying, and being unrepentant (Jeremiah 23:14). Ezekiel tells us, “God was angry at Sodom because the people were proud and overly prosperous and they refused to aid the poor and the needy” (Ezekiel 16:49).

The second most referenced biblical passage regarding homosexuality is in Paul’s letter to the Romans, namely Romans 1:18–32. Romans 1:26, 27 is one scriptural passage that is often referenced by religious leaders and politicians seeking to elevate a preferred and prescriptive normative to validate the condemnation of homosexuality. Romans 1:18–32, specifically verses 26 and 27, has to do with Paul’s understanding of the “natural” and “unnatural” functionality of women and men than it does with the perceived condemnation of homosexuality.

Paul’s letter to the Church of Rome, as some scholars have suggested, is a rhetorical presentation detailing how, according to Paul, human beings slipped into behavioral practices that were contrary to their “nature.” Bernadette Brooten states, “The whole of Romans 1:18–32 is describing a confused people, who do not do what they really want, assuming that people truly want to be in right relation to God.”³⁰

Contemporary post-modernism and theological plurality call for a personal, social, gender, and geographical locating of one’s self in order to get the full measure of each individual’s influences and thought processes. Paul is no exception. Our understanding of Paul, therefore, should be rooted in the same criteria. Paul’s understanding of God and “what has been made plain to them since creation” is by way of the historical, sociopolitical, and religious context to which Paul belonged. Paul was a Pharisee and we can suppose that, as a Pharisee, he “observed the traditions above and beyond the written law.”³¹ Inasmuch as Paul was a Jew and a Pharisee, his charge or rather his “call” was to take the gospel of Jesus the Christ to the Gentiles—a charge that was expressly his by way of his experience of the risen Christ. To take

this message to the gentiles, he had to speak in a manner that was consistent and familiar to the Romans.

Some interpreters, who read Paul in literary terms, believe that he employs the art of rhetorical communication—ancient rhetorical speech, expressly *protreptic*, which means to persuade. “*Protreptic* is also rooted in philosophy, where it can be paired with censure in order to bring people to the truth.” It is arguably a contemporary style of speech that is akin to the delivery and style of sermons coming out of the pulpits of the IBC.³² The oral/aural tradition and a community’s shared understanding, and implicit agreement upon the *truth* of that tradition, is heavily relied upon. Inasmuch as the *truth* of a tradition is implicit, it is also employed as a means to promote the approved elements some scholars have suggested are “how [we] got over.”³³

African American TSBGL persons, as the embodied bridge, make the connection between oppression as oppression and discrimination as discrimination. The African American community and the IBC, in particular, have allowed organizations that hide their political agendas under the guise of Christian piety to come into our churches and community and enlist our services to fight a war that they have declared. In the spirit of accommodation, we enlisted and were sent straight to the front lines, chasing their cleverly crafted red herrings while they retreated to work at abolishing Affirmative Action and chipped away at the Voting Rights Acts of 1964 and 1965.

Reconciliation, Transformation, and Emancipation

“Forgiveness of the sinner supposes a specific hope—hope for the miracle of conversion and the miracle of reconciliation.”³⁴ The goal and ultimate miracle of forgiveness of the sinner is the opportunity for the sinner to be converted and transformed. Jon Sobrino, and his theology of forgiveness, emphasizes the eradication of sin itself. By eradicating the sin, the sinner (the IBC) is liberated from the bondage of opting to sin again.

“Liberation from oppression also means destroying the person [institution] oppressing, in [its] formal capacity as oppressor.”³⁵ What this means is that, as African American TSBGL persons, part of the healing process requires that we forgive the IBC for the sins committed against us. Through our forgiveness, we forgive the sinner as well as the sin. Additionally, the eradication of the sin also requires that the IBC must forgive itself for the oppression of its members in order to bring about the miracle of transformation and reconciliation. Conversion is no small task, for the Black church must then open its doors and welcome *home* its TSBGL members with all rights and privileges as any other member of the church—including ordination.

It must denounce any act of violence or subjugation that occurs based on the sexual orientation or gender identity of the victim. Just as “Black lives Matter,” Our Lives must also matter. either all life is sacred or no life is sacred. By giving voice to the victims and speaking against the structures that create victims, the IBC essentially destroys its susceptibility to be oppressive. Such conversion leads to *Ubuntu*—“I am because we are.”

Freeing itself fully, the Black church becomes malleable and breathes life into the Parable of the Prodigal Son. The children have left. For various reasons, the children have gone and departed. We, like the Prodigal Son, have wandered about, until that still small voice found its way through our anger, our resentment and frustration, and our fears and reminded us of *who* we are and *whose* we are. Although not gender inclusive in language, Howard Thurman provides wisdom around this reclamation:

A man’s conviction that he is God’s child automatically tends to shift the basis of his relationship with all his fellows. He recognizes at once that to fear a man, whatever may be that man’s

power over him is a basic denial of the integrity of his life. It lifts that mere man to a place of pre-eminence that belongs to God and to God alone.³⁶

Once we, like the Prodigal Son, come to our self, forgive our self, and remember our Father/Mother/God, and when we find our feet, straighten up our backs, and rise to return to that place which we call *home*, will the IBC respond in the same way that the parable reads? Will the IBC reach back for its TSBGL members that are reaching out to them? Will the Black church open its doors, its heart, its mind, and its theology to welcome home its TSBGL women and men back into its pews? Will it take this opportunity to repent of its social sin of homophobia and ask for forgiveness so that the healing process might begin?

"Star light, star bright, I wish I could I wish I might, have this wish I wish tonight." I wish that upon our return *home*, the church will fall upon our necks and kiss us and rejoice in our return. I wish that there be a grand celebration, full of laughter, tearful conversation, and play. I wish that we embrace and bathe in the warmth of togetherness and joy. I wish that we, TSBGL women and men and the IBC, say together that we were both dead in our isolation from one another and now, in our togetherness, we are well and alive again. I wish that the IBC would reach for its ordination guidelines and open them up so that it may "bring forth the best robe" to drape around those of us seeking it. "Star light, star bright, first star I see tonight. I wish I could, I wish I might, have this wish, I wish tonight."

Notes

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2. *Ibid.*, 23.
3. James M. Washington, *A Testament of Hope: The Essential Writings and Speeches of Martin Luther King, Jr.* (New York: HarperCollins, 1986), 286.
4. Keith D. Miller, *Voice of Deliverance* (New York: The Free Press, 1992), 17.
5. *Ibid.*, 86.
6. *Ibid.*, 99.
7. *Ibid.*, 21.
8. Cornel West, *Race Matters* (New York: First Vintage Books Edition, 1994), 132.
9. Frances Wood, "Take My Yoke Upon You," in Emilie Townes ed., *Troubling in My Soul: Womanist Perspectives on Evil & Suffering* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1993), 40. The term "permissible victim" is defined as "any group or individuals that can be harmed with little or no negative consequences befalling the perpetrator."
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11. <http://members.tde.com/equality/factsheets/tshate.html>. Hate Crimes statistics.
12. <http://gawker.com/unarmed-people-of-color-killed-by-police-1999-2014-1666672349>. Accessed March 20, 2015.
13. Interview with Cheryl C. Courtney-Evans. Atlanta, GA. February 28, 2015.
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15. West, 119.
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18. West, 124.
19. Audre Lorde, *Sister Outsider* (New York: Kitchen Table Press, 1984), 53.

20. James Cone, *God of the Oppressed* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1997), 125.
21. *Ibid.*
22. <http://www.npr.org/blogs/thetwo-way/2013/06/26/195857796/supreme-court-strikes-down-defense-of-marriage-act>, accessed March 23, 2015.
23. *Ibid.*
24. Washington, 293.
25. *Ibid.*, 294.
26. Cheryl Sanders, "Sexual Orientation and Human Rights Discourse in the African American Churches," in Saul M. Olyan and Martha C. Nussbaum, eds., *Sexual Orientation and Human Rights Discourse in American Religious Discourse* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1998), 179, 180.
27. *Ibid.*, 180.
28. Sanders quotes Richard Hays, *The Moral Vision of the New Testament* (San Francisco: HarperCollins, 1996), 180, 381.
29. *Ibid.*
30. Bernadette Brooten, *Love between Women. Early Christian Responses to Female Homoeroticism* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996), 199.
31. E. P. Sanders, *Paul: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996), 8–10.
32. Bernadette Brooten, *Love between Women*, 197. She quotes from David E. Aune, "Romans as a Logos Protreptikos," in Karl P. Donfried, ed., *The Romans Debate*, revised and expanded from the 1977 edition (Peabody, MA: Henderickson, 1991), 278–296.
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Closing the Academic–Ecclesiastical Gap: Black Church Studies’ Role in Eliminating Health Disparities

Selina A. Smith

Introduction

In recent years, programs of Black Church Studies (BCS) have begun to examine their relevance and viability in relation to the academy, church, and society. In light of a preponderance of social inequities faced by African American communities and considering the historical role of the Black Church as social institution, such critical self-reflection is warranted. An inward assessment is necessary to the advancement of BCS as a field of study in seminaries, as a contributor of scholarship to churches and as a wellspring of ideas for programs and policy for the community.

This chapter addresses two major disparities important to faith communities of African descent. The first is the *disconnect* between the academy (theological training) and the church (theological practice). Although the divergence between the curriculum of theological education and the life of the church is not new, its dissolution is imperative in light of the second inequity: differences in health outcomes for whites and Blacks. In this country, these racial/ethnic health disparities result in more than 60,000 excess deaths from preventable disease among African Americans annually.¹

The purpose of this chapter is to outline the issue of health disparities in conversation with the mission and curriculum of theological education and congregational life, in general, and, more specifically, the growing discipline of BCS in relation to the expanding Black church. To this end, this work seeks to address insights and implications regarding methods for improving leadership education, relevant in the ecclesiastical context, which equip clergy to lead a movement toward the elimination of health inequities.

Racial/Ethnic Health Disparities

Approximately 23 years ago, the world learned of the inequality or difference in health status among Americans. In 1985, *The Federal Report of the Secretary’s Task Force on Black and Minority Health*, the first comprehensive national minority health study, documented the wide

and persisting disparity in health status between minorities and whites.² The report recognized 42.3 percent of all deaths among Blacks less than 70 years of age in 1979–1981 as excess deaths. It raised concern that approximately 60,000 excess deaths were occurring annually because of health disparities, primarily among African Americans.³

The 1985 task force report clearly demonstrated that the difference between the numbers of deaths expected if the mortality of Blacks were the same as the white population was disproportionate. While life expectancy, overall health status, and quality of life have continued to improve for most Americans, racial ethnic minorities, including African Americans, continue to experience disparities in the burden of illness and death. This report concluded that minorities “have not benefited fully or equitably from the fruits of science or from those systems responsible for translating or using health sciences technology.”⁴ Six problem areas were identified that collectively accounted for more than 80 percent of the excess mortality from 1979 to 1981, including cancer; cardiovascular diseases and stroke; chemical dependency; diabetes; homicides, suicides, and unintentional injuries; and infant mortality. In recognition of the increasing severity of HIV/AIDS among the minority community, AIDS was added as the seventh leading health problem.

Twenty-three years later, despite advances in health care, technology, economic wealth and prosperity and the overall improvement in the health status of the American population, African Americans continue to suffer substantially and disproportionately from adverse health conditions. Advances in the public health system have contributed to a dramatic improvement in the longevity and health status of the US population, with average life expectancy increasing from 50 in 1900 to 76 in 2000. For coronary heart disease, the leading cause of death for all Americans from 1987 to 1995, the average age-adjusted death rate declined by 20 percent.⁵ According to the Department of Health and Human Services (DHHS), “for almost all health indicators, each increase in either income or education increased the likelihood of being in good health. Socioeconomic status (SES) has an influence on nearly all aspects of health care, including access to care, behaviors predisposing individuals to health risk, and attitudes surrounding health care.”⁶

Basis for Health Inequities

Despite these recent overall health-care gains, race and ethnicity continue to be powerful determinants of experiences and of health status. As former DHHS secretary Donna Shalala so succinctly stated, “We are two nations: one majority and one minority.”⁷

Based on federal government findings, compared to the white population, African Americans: (1) experience a more than double infant mortality rate, (2) have a 30 percent higher death rate of all cancers, (3) are six times more likely to die from homicide, and (4) are more than seven times more likely to die from HIV/AIDS.⁸ Although the reasons for these differences in health status and health outcomes are complex, it is necessary to acknowledge that racism is a fundamental cause of disparities.

Given past events, it is not surprising that African Americans are much more likely than their white counterparts to have less confidence in the health-care system and to believe that the risks associated with medical interventions outweigh its benefits. One of the most well-known examples for the basis of this mistrust is the Tuskegee Syphilis Study. From 1932 to 1972, 399 poor Black sharecroppers in Macon County, Alabama, who were denied treatment for syphilis, were a part of the systematic racism perpetuated through this nation’s medical care system.⁹ The study by US Public Health Service documented the natural history of the syphilis. Even after discovery of a cure for the disease, study participants were not provided the remedy for their condition, but were instead told that they were being treated for “bad blood.”¹⁰ For the entire study period, government officials also insured that these

men received no therapy from any source, including the penicillin, which could save their lives.

- 1) Many recent experiences of African Americans in the health-care system have also served to reinforce this mistrust. Disparities in health prompted Congress in 1999 to request an Institute of Medicine (IOM) study to assess disparities in the kinds and quality of healthcare received by US racial and ethnic minorities and nonminorities. Congress charged the IOM to
 - Assess the extent of racial and ethnic differences in healthcare that are not otherwise attributable to known factors such as access to care (e.g., ability to pay or insurance coverage);
 - Evaluate potential sources of racial and ethnic disparities in health care, including the role of bias, discrimination, and stereotyping at the individual (provider and patient), institutional, and health system levels; and
 - Provide recommendations regarding interventions to eliminate healthcare disparities.
- 2) The results of the IOM study validates that African Americans receive inferior health care compared to whites. *Unequal Treatment: Confronting Racial and Ethnic Disparities in Healthcare* confirms that minorities experience lower-quality medical care, which contributes to misdiagnosis, improper treatment, greater disease, and premature death.¹¹
- 3) The account consists of a review of more than 100 studies illustrating that even when access-related factors are considered, people of color in the United States receive worse health care when compared to whites. For example, the report stated that relative to whites, African Americans are less likely to receive appropriate cardiac medication (e.g., thrombolytic therapy, aspirin, and beta blockers) or to undergo coronary artery bypass surgery, even when variations in such factors as insurance status, income, age, comorbid conditions, and symptom expression are taken into account. Studies further demonstrate that African Americans with end-stage renal disease are less likely to receive peritoneal dialysis and kidney transplantation. The IOM report also cited evidence that African American patients with bone fractures seen in hospital emergency departments are less likely than whites to receive analgesia.¹²

Racial and ethnic disparities in health care are problems that have significant implications for those in public health. For the health professionals, racial and ethnic disparities in health care pose moral and ethical dilemmas. They are expected to adhere to the highest ethical standards of service that mandate fairness and compassion. In light of historical abuses, it is important to preserve this trust, which is already fragile in African Americans communities, if its members are to actively seek care. The Black church has the potential to help in bridging the breach resulting from painful past experiences. Equally, as a beacon of hope for community, the Black church shoulders a responsibility for ensuring equitable care for its people.

In the two decades since, many have been forced to take head-on the problem of fragmented, unhealthy, and dying communities. Public health has forged ahead, focusing largely on individual health behavior as the agent for changing the health status of the population as a whole. Not unlike the church's concern for individual salvation, behaviors of the person, not the community, have been the focus of public health. Interfacing with the Black church has been a major vehicle used by public health for accessing African Americans and for instituting changes in lifestyle behaviors (e.g., eating, smoking, drinking), screening and detection (e.g., breast cancer screening, blood pressure, and blood cholesterol checks), and in increasing

awareness of diseases such as HIV/AIDS and prostate cancer. The health promotion/disease prevention model serves as the basis to this approach. Little has been done, however, to uncover the systemic causes of differences in health outcomes or in taking steps to their elimination.

Federal Government Response

Unlike other countries (e.g., France and England), the United States has chosen to replace the term “inequities,” a word that resonates the concept of justice as an underlying cause, with “disparities,” which places ownership of the problem with those to which it is attributed. The recognition that the result of decades of social and economic deprivation manifests itself as uncontrolled blood pressure, skyrocketing blood sugar, and elevated blood cholesterol—symptoms of hypertension, diabetes mellitus, and heart disease—remains. Unchanged is the definition of “access to care” as broader than an uncomplicated textbook meaning as the presence or absence of a neighborhood health clinic. Unchallenged is the knowledge that the causes of obesity are more than an imbalance of energy or caloric intake and output.

While the United States has made great strides in advancing the health of the nation, not everyone has benefited. In 2000, the Congress passed Senate Bill 1880, the Minority Health and Health Disparities Research and Education Act of 2000, to create the National Institutes of Health’s newest Center, the National Center on Minority Health and Health Disparities.¹³

The purpose of this center is to focus on conducting and supporting behavioral, social, clinical, and biomedical research among minorities; promoting and building research infrastructure at minority serving institutions; disseminating health information; and enhancing community outreach to minority and health disparity groups.

In this election year, it seems prudent to examine the presidential candidates’ perspective on the healthcare system. As African Americans, people of faith and products of the Black church, it is important that we ask if the politics of Obama, Clinton, and McCain are the politics of equality in health care. In evaluating their health politics, if their stance is ethical and equitable, then they must be given unquestionable support in sanctioning the elimination of health disparities. Conversely, if their politics and positions are not consistent with the same treatment for all Americans, it is important that this is considered as well.

In 2004, Barak Obama became the third African American since Reconstruction to be elected to the US Senate (Illinois). As a candidate for the Democratic Party nominee for president, he offers the following response to this nation’s healthcare issue:

We now face an opportunity—and an obligation—to turn the page on the failed politics of yesterday’s health care debates . . . My plan begins by covering every American. If you already have health insurance, the only thing that will change for you under this plan is the amount of money you will spend on premiums. That will be less. If you are one of the 45 million Americans who don’t have health insurance, you will have it after this plan becomes law. No one will be turned away because of a preexisting condition or illness.¹⁴

Senator Hillary Clinton (New York), as former First Lady, was one of the first in Washington to work to ensure that every man, woman, and child in America has quality and affordable health care. Although her fight for universal health coverage did not succeed, as a candidate for the Democratic Party nominee for president, her American Health Choices Plan “Covers all Americans and improves health care by lowering costs and improving quality. It puts the consumer in the driver’s seat by offering more choices and lowering costs.”¹⁵

John McCain, according to his website, has led the fight for reforming Washington, eliminating wasteful government spending, and strengthening our nation’s armed forces. As a senator (Arizona) and the presumptive Republican Party nominee for president, he

Believes in personal responsibility: 1) we must do more to take care of ourselves to prevent chronic diseases when possible, and do more to adhere to treatment after we are diagnosed with an illness; 2) childhood obesity, diabetes and high blood pressure are all on the rise. We must again teach our children about health, nutrition and exercise—vital life information and 3) public health initiatives must be undertaken with all our citizens to stem the growing epidemic of obesity and diabetes, and to deter smoking.¹⁶

Considering the presidential candidates' position on this nation's growing healthcare problem provides a window into the future of the health disparities issue. Faith and health, though separate disciplines, share a similar ethical core. Conservative politics, conventional religion, and conformist health policies appear to share a common thread. "There is a conscious move on the part of many in our nation to the right, to conservatism, to a privatized fundamental religion that leaves behind any memory of the call to discipleship."¹⁷ The same can be said of the healthcare problem.

Historical Perspective

With its legacy, progressive traditions, spiritual depth, and social witness, the Black church remains the primary institution committed to alleviating the suffering of African Americans. A look to distant antecedents, the advent of the Black church, sets the stage for drawing on past resources for eliminating health disparities.

Reverend Richard Allen, the founder of the African Methodist Episcopal Church and Reverend George Lisle, founder of the Baptist Church in Augusta, Georgia, and Silver Bluff, South Carolina, first preached to enslaved communities in plantation churches. The first free Black churches and societies were founded in the late eighteenth century as both religious and sociopolitical institutions called to reinterpret the gospel in light of the experiences of the Africans in America. The institutional Black church had at its core the central conviction that God is a God of justice.

Liberation theology, with a center of praxis, shares with other approaches a contribution of revelation of God in Scripture. God is seen from the hermeneutical lens as a God of the oppressed, minorities, and those marginalized by society. Sexism, racism, and classism are just a few of the struggles addressed in doing this theology. Liberation theologians make the "option for the oppressed" the key to their theological endeavors.

The advent of Black theology, followed by womanist theology, was met with greater attention to the impact of religion and Scripture on every facet of life for African Americans. The literary Black theology of the 1960s was a practical theological endeavor. James Cone, considered by many to be the founder of Black theology, identifies liberation as the heart of the Christian gospel and blackness as the primary mode of God's presence.¹⁸ Black theology was born out of the Civil Rights Movement, addressing the spirit of "Black Power" by relating the good news of the Gospel to the struggle for freedom wrought by the American Negro. The 1969 Statement by the National Committee of Black Churchmen suggests that Black theology:

... seeks to plumb the Black condition in the light of God's revelation in Jesus Christ, so that the Black community can see that the Gospel is commensurate with the achievement of Black humanity. It is the affirmation of Black humanity that emancipates Black people from white racism, thus providing authentic freedom for both white and Black people.¹⁹

Womanist theologians are calling into question their suppressed role in the African American church, the community, the family, and the larger society.²⁰ This theology dovetails the work of Alice Walker in her book *In Search of Our Mothers' Gardens*, which describes

the courageous, audacious, and “in-charge” behavior of the Black woman.²¹ It affirms Black women’s connection with feminism and with African American history, culture, and religion. Womanist theology is critical reflection upon Black women’s place in the world that God has created and takes seriously Black women’s experience as human beings who are made in the image of God.²² The result of womanism is an approach to Christian theology (and biblical interpretation) that is multidimensional. Proponents, including Jacquelyn Grant, Delores Williams, Katie Cannon, Emilie Townes, and Tracy West, espouse that such a view will help us deal with racism, sexism, and heterosexism because it is better equipped to deal with all types of oppression.

Social Movements

The Black church, with its roots as social institution, its rhetoric as social movement, and its reach as sacred speech across a broad spectrum of socioeconomic stratum, can and must be the change agent for the growing gap in *health* between mainstream and African American communities.

From slavery through the Civil Rights Movement, the church has been a central institution in Black America. The faith community plays an important role by serving not only as a house of worship but as an atmosphere for addressing political and social issues as well. The historic Black church (or African American church) has a broad, direct reach to people, providing social support, volunteers, communications channels, facilities and access to many underserved sub-populations.²³ Reducing disparities cannot be reached through the actions of one sector of society alone and churches are viable partners in this effort.

With the inconsistency in disease incidence and mortality between whites and African Americans in this country, the shared theological foundation based on a collective ethos in the Black church is a viable approach to eliminating health disparities. Vertical integration of the personal and the political, behavioral change, and institutional changes as well as local and national action could assist in efforts aimed at eliminating health disparities. A paradigm shift, one that focuses on the theological and public health impetus to good health for all, is warranted in the development and implementation of a health disparities social movement.

The question of *why* the problem of health, wholeness, and healing of African Americans should be a concern of the Black church is answered thus: it is a matter of *justice*. Justice is based on the premise that no one has the right to the arbitrary assignment of preferential treatment. This justice means dealing with people on the basis of equal treatment in terms of healthcare means being fair, doing to others what you would have them do to you.

In the church, there is an implicit social contract that everyone has the same right to all the benefits as everyone else. Justice is evenhanded distribution of favors and restrictions. It is not enough for members of the church to bury in their own sense of individual piety, of personal justice. Health disparities must be reframed from *being* merely a public health problem to *becoming* a challenge for the Black church. Its goal is to help Black churches discern this call to action and to disclose the dynamics of its actualization.

Since its earliest beginnings, the biblical principal of justice has served as a cornerstone on which the Black church rests. One could scarcely argue that the lack of health insurance, uninformed health decision-making, and low health literacy, all contributors to poor health outcomes among African Americans, is unjust. The Black church must consider the turmoil within individuals who are already dealing with their otherness in life. The injustice of health disparities is but one more illustration of discrimination. Has the Black church become mute to the barrage of issues facing African Americans in this country? How can the Black church determine if it is doing justice?

This call for the elimination of health disparities must be more than just a benevolent hand; it must be an empowerment of communities. How do pastors and deacons and bishops then

mobilize congregations to this call? With the increasing challenge of the Black church to meet the needs of its members and its community, is this kind of mission one that the Black church should be willing to take on? From the author's perspective, attacking the underlying forces that contribute to health disparities is not merely an effort to improve the health of those who suffer disproportionately; it is a matter of the spiritual salvation of a people. This salvation may not take place in the sanctuary, but in those places where God awaits the Black church's response to those in need.

Health disparities have and continue to be a major issue for public health because of premature and excess deaths due to sometimes preventable, often treatable diseases. While both the Black church and public health may feel compelled to attack the problem of health disparities for African Americans, the question, which remains, is not *why*, but *how*. In dialogue with the Black church and public health, this volume seeks to engage these two institutions on the theoretical and praxis realms toward a faithful response to the call for the elimination of health disparities.

Social movement theory provides a viable framework for understanding why oppressed groups develop collective actions, which change social norms. Della Porta and Diani define social movements as "Informal networks based on shared beliefs and solidarity which mobilize around conflictual issues and deploy frequent and varying forms of protest."²⁴

The theories undergirding this definition including collective behavior, mobilization, and political process theories suggest that social movements are a form of collective behavior emerging out of significant social and cultural breakdowns. Because these actions evolved spontaneously, they are considered spontaneous, unorganized, and unstructured phenomena distinct of institutional and organizational behavior. Among its salient features, a shared value system, a sense of community, norms for action, and an organizational structure are included.²⁵ As this structure develops, a recognizable social movement begins. Through participation in goal-oriented actions external to the organization itself, the social and psychological needs of members are met.

The framework of these features suggests three distinctive elements of social movements. First, that social movements have a natural life history, following a certain pattern from the time the issue first emerges until it reaches the stage of majority (or mainstream) opinion and influence. Second, who is involved in the guiding issues of the movement affects the strategies that will be involved in the movement. Finally, the knowledge of the stage of the movement is dependent upon internal and external factors and is important in assessing opportunities each stage offers.

Social movements dealing with health are not new. During the Industrial Revolution, occupational health concerns were a major force for change in the world. In the past two decades, women's health activists have "greatly altered medical conceptions of women, broadened reproductive rights, expanded funding and services in many areas, altered many treatment forms and changed medical research practices."²⁶ Activism around health issues has been important in social change, and social science has had a great impact on these movements. Even with evidence of abundant social movements in health, social movement theory has not been applied to these movements, nor have they been analyzed to determine their most salient features or their applicability to other health issues or concerns, such as racial/ethnic health disparities.

Revisioning Black Church Studies

Many programs of BCS are now entering a fourth generation and there is a need to broaden their base with a greater emphasis on the urgencies and issues of African Americans. As it relates to health disparities, revisiting curriculum by (1) providing a theological investigation of prevailing cultural, political, social, and economical motifs; (2) exploring pivotal events

and key issues that led to the development of these inequities; and (3) examining the compatibility between Christology and Black activism (God's justice) will be helpful to seminary leaders wrestling with the integration of theology and praxis curriculum content, collaborative pedagogy, and contemporary church demands. The goal is to provide professional training in the special knowledge and skills required by those who will be pastors of Black congregations, as they are the ones who must open the doors of the church and the gates of the community to an organized effort aimed at balancing health in this nation.

Biblical Studies

Related to the analysis and interpretation of Scriptures in the Hebrew Bible and in the New Testaments, BCS have increasingly focused on an approach centered on the lived reality of persons of African descent. Hermeneutics is defined as "the rules for searching out the meanings of writings, particularly biblical texts."²⁷ Two embedded assumptions of hermeneutics are that: (1) humans experience the world through language, and (2) this language provides both understanding and knowledge. The term *hermeneutics* is derived from two words—the Greek verb and noun meaning to interpret.²⁸ This method of textual analysis emphasizes the sociocultural and historic influences on qualitative interpretation. It also exposes hidden meanings.

As almost a response to theologies of liberation, African American biblical scholars have begun to reexamine rules of grammar and the confines of historical and scientific research guiding the meaning of the biblical text. They offer an African American hermeneutical perspective as alternative to a European approach to the reading and interpretation of Scripture. According to Cane Hope Felder, "We must reclaim the whole of the scriptural witness. We must not try to short-cut the process of searching out only those passages that seem to hold promise of being specifically 'relevant' for a particular social issue."²⁹ African American hermeneutics is an attempt to invite readers to start thinking about biblical texts in ways that are relevant for modern life and not solely from a "white" perspective. According to Brad R. Braxton, "Freedom, that is ideological freedom, mental freedom, religious freedom and economic freedom, must now be our agenda in the twenty-first century."³⁰ If the Bible is to be viewed as liberative, searching out the meanings of biblical texts which consider the sociocultural and historical influences of Blacks is warranted. Those in the Black community, especially those experiencing poor health outcomes, may see things that support the quest for justice and inclusion. We read the Bible in response to our own social location and that influences how we understand God. Such an understanding of biblical studies is important in the advancement of BCS.

Similar to other belief systems of Hindus, Buddhists, Muslims, and Jews, physical and emotional healing plays an important role in faith for Christians. Scriptures in the Judeo-Christian texts emphasize the mental and physical health benefits of obedience to God.

In the biblical tradition, health and salvation are integrally connected through their common root in the idea of wholeness.³¹ The etymology of health-related words support the need for the development of faith–health praxis. Biblical words for "being saved" and "being whole" have common roots. The biblical perspective of the person is a whole individual with all dimensions, physical and spiritual, well integrated. This holistic view is found in the Hebrew word *rapha* meaning to heal, to repair, or to make whole.³² The Greek word *sōzō*, which is translated as save, rescue, deliver, also means to keep safe, preserve, cure, and make well.³³ "Days may be long," "long life," "health to your body," "joy," and "peace" suggest that religious faith has health benefits.

According to Paul Tillich, in the Gospel of Mark, "Jesus is, first of all, the healer, because the coming of the Kingdom of God implies the appearance of an irresistible healing power."³⁴ Tillich equates bodily health to salvation, or the act of "cosmic healing." Salvation

is basically and essentially healing, the reestablishment of a whole that was broken, disrupted, disintegrated.³⁵

Theology

Black theology, liberation theology, and womanist theology tend to replace salvation with liberation as a theological doctrine. Such a substitution would not negatively impact Tillich's view of health. Reconsidering and rediscovering salvation as a theological doctrine, however, may potentially enhance these theologies.

Black theology refuses to accept a God who is not identified totally with the goals of the Black community. If God is not for us, if God is not against white racists, then he is a murderer, and we had better kill him. The task of Black theology is to kill gods that do not belong to the Black community.³⁶

The theological basis for a health–faith praxis is based on the principle that humanity's health/salvation is dependent on our relationship first to God and second to each other. Our own salvation is actualized in self-protection, as emphasized in 1 Corinthians 6: 19–20:

Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, which you have from God, and that you are not your own? For you were bought with a price; therefore glorify God in your body.

The “salvation” of others is also deeply embedded in the theology of the Christian church. The mission of the church effects change in the world and seeks to empower, educate, and bring the healing gift of Jesus Christ to the neighbor.

There is ample evidence to suggest that religion has a negative effect on health (e.g., Scriptures promoting violence against women; failure to discuss sexuality and how this relates to HIV/AIDS transmission; restrictive dietary and medical care behaviors based on ancient practices), but the extent of these effects has not been adequately described. What is unknown are the specific negative health consequences of religious beliefs and practices. Greater religiosity is associated with fewer negative health behaviors, disease screening, and health promotion. However, it has not been until recently that this has become a priority for the church, in general, and more specifically, for the Black church.

Practical Theology

Crucial in the reenvisioning of BCS is considering how the health–praxis intersection affects church practices. The discipline of practical theology considers biblical studies, theology, and other disciplines as it relates to religious practices. In order to be useful, practical theology must attempt to describe and interpret both contemporary situations and Christian resources. It is defined as “theological reflection that is grounded in the life of the church, society, and the individual that both critically recovers the theology of the past and constructively develops theology for the future.”³⁷ A major challenge for practical theology, according to Mary Elizabeth Moore, is “To discern, conceptualize and respond to people who are most vulnerable to the denigrating and hurtful complexities of modern societies.”³⁸ Institutional activities of religion, such as preaching, church administration, pastoral care, and liturgics, are the mainstay of practical theology. The majority of Americans (90 percent) indicate that religion is important in their personal lives. Religion holds an even stronger place among African Americans, among whom

almost 100 percent point to belief in a divine power. Historically, African Americans have been attached to church activities and are more religious than other Americans.³⁹ This connection to God helps to illuminate the centrality of Black preaching in the Black church.

In the Black church tradition, preachers have proclaimed and interpreted the Word of God, and their preaching has been “the hallmark” of hope and the pivot of promise for a pilgrim people. Olin Moyd offers four characteristics of God in Black preaching: (1) God is the God of Creation; (2) God is the Divine Being who intervenes in human history; and (3) God is the God of presence and God of justice.⁴⁰

Black preaching reminds its listeners that they can be set free by an encounter with Jesus Christ. Cleophus LaRue argues that it is this feature which makes Black preaching the strongest preaching tradition in the world.⁴¹ He suggests that Black preaching characterizes God as no respecter of persons, on the side of the oppressed, and personal and a God of liberation. While theological education is accepted by most Black Christian denominations as necessary for the preacher, too much education is viewed with a hermeneutic of suspicion. There is a fear among many in the congregation that looking too critically at the text is an affront to Christianity. Likewise, many clergy and seminarians feel strongly that too much biblical criticism leaves God out.

As Robert M. Franklin noted, “Black Christians have come to expect sermons to be poetic masterpieces that are biblically rooted, politically prophetic, intellectually stimulating, emotionally evocative, rhetorically polished, pastorally positive, personally sensitive, and reverently and joyfully delivered.”⁴² Black preaching is described as “A survival instrument designed to identify and restore hope in a people whose past is replete with reasons to be hopeless, and whose present is disconnected from the existential portfolio of success and meaningfulness that epitomizes the American dream.” Black preaching is strong because God is at its core. God is alive and present in the text, in the sermon, and in the church. God is the focus of the sermon. Preaching the whole counsel or preaching about God’s involvement means that the theology of the Black church places God at its center. This preaching tradition has been the vehicle by which practical theology has been conveyed to the people in African American congregations.

There should be a thread running through the proclaimed word that stitches together liberation theologies and African American biblical interpretation into the words comprising the sermon message in the Black church. That thread is the common message of how God reveals God’s self to us as the daughters and sons of Africa, as former slaves, as the products of racial integration, and as participants in American society. The patches of the quilt from these threads emerge as pearls of wisdom from the preached word, serving to legitimate hearers, affirming them as the children of God. The Black church may be the greatest context for a health–faith praxis for impacting health disparities; however, failure to connect theory to praxis has led to a “loss in translation” that is felt throughout worship practices such as singing and praying, but most often in the chants, tunes, songs, and celebration of Black preaching. Black and womanist theologies and African American biblical interpretation place African ideals at the center of analysis of Christian theology in its public and persuasive mode.

Conclusion

Black clergy emerged as the prime leaders of Black communities nationwide in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. This was the case in religious matters as well as in politics, economics, education, and sociocultural activities. Three of the largest slave revolts in American history were led by Black preachers: Gabriel Prosser in 1800 in Richmond, Virginia; Denmark Vesey in 1822 in Charleston, South Carolina; and Nat Turner in 1831 in Southampton County, Virginia. Because of its central place in the community, the Black church was the location for Civil Rights

Movement activities during the 1950s and 1960s. In the year 2008, training African American faith leaders as leaders for change is a lofty task and tremendous responsibility for BCS.

In the academy, church, and community, BCS programs nationwide are capable of bridging this gap. It is at this intersection that the greatest opportunity exists for a social movement aimed at healing generations of unequal access, unfair treatment, and unjust care.

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Economic Justice and Globalization in Black Church Studies: Confronting the “Malignant Kingship” in the Post-Civil Rights Era

Juan M. Floyd-Thomas

On March 12, 2015, Rev. Creflo A. Dollar, a prominent televangelist and renowned mega church pastor, posted an online video soliciting charitable donations (“love gift of any amount”) from his followers and other potential donors in order to buy a Gulfstream G650 airplane worth an estimated \$65 million. According to the video presentation on Creflo Dollar Ministries website (which was quietly removed from the website a few days later), the ministry currently owns a private jet that was built in 1984 and acquired by Rev. Dollar in 1999. On the video, a ministry spokesperson reported that the plane traveled at least 4 million miles but was no longer safe. On a recent trip overseas, the ministry’s website states, one of the engines failed while the plane was in midair. Despite the great peril, the pilot was able to land safely and none of the passengers aboard was injured. As a result of this mishap, Dollar and his team made this statement:

[W]e are asking members, partners, and supporters of this ministry to assist us in acquiring a Gulfstream G650 airplane so that Pastors Creflo and Taffi [Dollar] and World Changers Church International can continue to blanket the globe with the Gospel of grace . . . We are believing for 200,000 people to give contributions of 300 US dollars or more to turn this dream into a reality.¹

Throughout the video, the rationale for this widespread donation request was linked to Dollar’s international ministry and missionary work rather than for his own personal use. They promote the value of this luxury jet as a means for evangelizing to an ever-growing populace of Christians from every continent on the globe, all of whom are desperate for Dollar’s particular approach to gospel ministry. Within a matter of days following a flurry of scathing criticism and furious ridicule about the fund-raising campaign—dubbed “Project G650”—a

spokesperson for Dollar's ministries abruptly informed the media as well as the general public that the campaign no longer existed.² At the time of this writing, even with this disclaimer in place, the church's donation link for Project G650 was still accessible.

Without question, Rev. Dollar is one of the most prominent African American preachers who have built successful ministries espousing the prosperity gospel. Dollar and his wife, Taffi, are co-pastors of World Changers International Church and have largely based their ministry on demonstrating how their own wealth and success are evidence that their theological doctrine works. Born and raised in College Park, a community in the southwestern sector of Atlanta, Dollar says he received a divine vision for the church in 1986. When Dollar first launched his fledgling ministry, he held the first worship service with eight people in an elementary school cafeteria. On December 24, 1995, his ministry grew quickly and the church moved into its current 8,500-seat sanctuary. At present, the church claims a current membership of 30,000 and has WCCI fellowship churches worldwide.³

The reason this incident has such resonant power is that it highlights Rev. Dollar's focus on money as a centerpiece of his identity and mission in ministry. In a 2007 interview with *The Associated Press*, Dollar told the interviewer that he renounced his full-time salary from World Changers Church. Instead, his income is derived largely from personal investments such as extensive real estate holdings, a horse breeding ranch, and other resources valued at upwards of \$27 million. Additionally, without any formal theological education, he has become a prolific author who has published over 30 books that endorse his religious worldview on everything from family matters to finances. Nevertheless, Dollar reportedly earns an honorarium as much as \$100,000 for a single appearance on his countless preaching engagements, a sizable sum of money by most people's standards.

When thinking about Rev. Dollar's visibility on the world's stage, it led me to reflect on both the attention and controversy surrounding another Black minister and native-born Atlantan, Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. In this instance, the distinction between Dollar and King is rooted in what they represent in their respective eras. Whereas Rev. Dollar has come to epitomize the consummate example of the prosperity gospel movement, Dr. King represented a prophetic Black Christianity for an earlier era. For instance, more than 50 years ago, spurred by the utopian challenge of King's "I Have a Dream" speech delivered during the 1963 March on Washington for jobs and freedom as well as the eventual passage of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 and Voting Rights Act of 1965, President Lyndon B. Johnson proclaimed a "war on poverty" that was intended to abolish human misery and economic hardship in modern America. Despite the sweeping social justice agenda advanced by Johnson's administration as a result of the morally driven mass protest movements across the nation, the US Congress lagged behind greatly in its support by withholding adequate appropriations for many government programs. In turn, this compromised the potential impact of these various programs thus rendering the president's declarations as little more than lip service.⁴

In light of this cynicism, coupled with the inertia of the federal government, marked American society's ultimate failure to live up to its post-war promises to ensure human welfare and inspired a significantly different call to mass action than the one begun in 1954. This is clearly demonstrated by the notable shift in the overall thinking amongst the acknowledged leadership of the civil rights movement in the years after 1965. King notes, "Many white Americans of good will have never connected bigotry with economic exploitation. They have deplored prejudice but tolerated or ignored economic injustice. But the Negro knows that these two evils have a malignant kinship."⁵ By outlining his position in this manner, King sharpens the focus of the civil rights organizations to the needs of the working poor and unemployed while also trying to muster support from wealthy and middle-class liberals who thought the struggle for justice and equality was over. My main concern in this examination is seeking to understand how the Black church tradition shifted away from looking for other Dr. Kings and chasing after Rev. Dollar. In other words, can the prophetic witness of Black Christianity regain

its voice and vision within a contemporary moment wherein economics and globalization are framed strictly in terms of prosperity?

By the dawn of the twenty-first century the growing disparity between the wealthiest and poorest Americans was still growing and most evident along racial lines. Although there has been a much-praised amelioration of the racial wealth and income divide in the United States, the statistical evidence tells a decidedly different story. In a study of median household net worth as an indication of US wealth distribution from 1989 to 2001, the typical white household's net worth (including home equity) went from \$97,800 in 1989 to \$121,000 in 2001 while the typical Black household's net worth shifted from \$5,300 to \$19,000 during the same period. Yet, sadly, the year 2001 seems like an eternity ago in economic terms. As recently as 2001, African Americans constituted 13 percent of the US population but only owned 3 percent of assets. Moreover, even though the median wealth of Blacks increased from 5 percent in 1989 to 16 percent in 2001 compared to the accumulated assets of whites, the shifting numbers only further highlight the persistent gap in income levels so many decades after the culmination of the civil rights movement.⁶ According to a number of reports based on recent US Census Bureau data, at such rates it would take until 2099 to approach parity in net wealth and an overall span of 581 years for African Americans to achieve parity in per capita income.⁷ What most analysts fail to stress about such figures, however, is that the specific duration of time presumes that white levels of wealth accumulation and income earnings remained permanently fixed at today's estimates, making even the best attempts to imagine an end to economic inequality in American society nothing more than a fiction. Put another way, 90 years is a mighty long time to wait for a moment that will never happen.

When compounded by three decades of a conservative political agenda at the state and federal levels, intent upon rolling back the gains of the civil rights movement, the racial wealth gap has expanded rather than shrank. From 2001 to 2004 there were three major tax cuts by the George W. Bush administration targeted to the benefit of the wealthiest 1 percent of American taxpayers (who overwhelmingly happen to be white) yet were authorized by both Democratic- and Republican-elected officials alike.⁸ This widening chasm of wealth and income also deepened during this period when it became increasingly evident that conservative policies (many backed by the Christian Right) were aggressively working to undermine the most venerated gains of the civil rights movement, namely securing equality of social access (results of *Brown v. Board of Education* and the Montgomery Bus Boycott) and guaranteeing equal opportunities for oppressed and underrepresented peoples (as proffered by "Affirmative Action" initiatives and other civil rights legislation of the 1960s) for the creation of the most inclusive middle-class society in the modern age. This reactionary backlash has had devastating repercussions for all Americans but it has struck the Black community most savagely. Since the official end of American slavery in 1865, with a greater level of enfranchisement and other rights of US citizenship, African Americans disproportionately depended on state and federal government for public services. Contrary to racist stereotypes, this was not symbolic of Black people's laziness or indolence but rather the logical consequence of a people having been robbed of wages and other assets for several generations due to centuries of race-based enslavement without any legal redress. Now, nearly a century and a half after the end of chattel slavery, when various state governments—especially the former Confederate states—are running massive fiscal deficits in their annual budgets and recklessly cutting funding to entitlement programs such as Social Security, Medicaid, Medicare, the Affordable Care Act (otherwise known as "Obamacare"), assistance and services for military veterans, child care subsidies, public education, and other vital public services, it is overwhelming the poor and working-class, many of whom are Black, who are directly harmed by this downturn.⁹

As King and the Black citizens of Montgomery, Alabama, were still embroiled in the bus boycott, he preached a sermon on November 4, 1956, in which he decried such a scenario by stating

they tell me that one tenth of one percent of the population controls more than forty percent of the wealth. Oh America, how often have you taken necessities from the masses to give luxuries to the classes . . . You can work within the framework of democracy to bring about a better distribution of wealth.

How shocked would Dr. King and all those fellow strivers in the Black freedom struggle be to realize that the dilemma has actually gotten worse rather than better in the half century since he uttered those prophetic words? How heartsick would those saints be in discovering the fact the Black church is largely standing mute and befuddled in the midst of the current war waged on the poor here and everywhere? Most importantly, how can the Black church be mobilized to speak to such a crisis once again?

To understand the concerns of the “poor” through the prism of Black Christianity means to reckon with economic poverty as well as spiritual poverty as an important facet of Black church tradition. Indeed, an understanding of faith without justice for the poor is a prophetic treatment of gospel that is full of gaping holes within the notion of Christianized capitalism reflected within the Word of Faith movement. In the wake of the Great Recession that began in late 2007,¹⁰ the visibility of poverty in the United States came to the forefront of the national consciousness. Even though there has always been a persistent—some might argue perpetual—segment of the American populace identified as the “old poor,” there has been an alarmingly growing number of our family members, friends, and fellow citizens who have become the “new poor”—those individuals who once were firmly ensconced as part of America’s middle class but have suffered deep levels of despair, disappointment, dispossession, and devastation in the wake of the 2007 economic downturn.¹¹ Ironically, as the nation’s poor and working class find themselves facing stifling impoverishment while the middle class face a future of diminishing returns and disappearing opportunities, the prospects of the wealthiest 1 percent of Americans have never looked better. According to recent data, the income of America’s richest 1 percent (those with annual earnings of \$380,000 or more) grew by 33 percent over the past two decades while wage growth for the remaining 99 percent of Americans experienced was virtually stagnant during that same period. By this token, Americans in the top 1 percentile “takes in an average of \$1.3 million per year, while the average American earns just \$33,000 per year.”¹²

As jarring as the existence of such huge disparities in wealth and income have been to the national economy in recent years, the most detrimental factors confronting the struggling middle class have been the implosion of the US housing market and staggering levels of job insecurity (this includes both unemployment and underemployment) contributing to overwhelming levels of anger and anxiety pervading the national mood.¹³ It is little wonder that collective political responses ranging from the TEA (Taxed Enough Already) Party on the extreme right and the Occupy Movement on the extreme left sprang up on the heels of the Great Recession. Although both groups have differed wildly in their philosophical outlook as well as pragmatic outcomes, at base they share a common origin, namely that they needed to speak up or else the economic future would be worse than the present. At either end of the ideological spectrum, deep-seated fears rooted in status anxiety, social hostility, and an uncertain future have marked the first two decades of the twenty-first century. Whereas the concept of the “middle class” was once the ubiquitous gold standard of American life and citizenship during the height of the US civil rights movement, the phrase now “has gone conspicuously missing from the 2016 campaign trail, as candidates and their strategists grasp for new terms for an unsettled economic era. The phrase, long synonymous with the American dream, now evokes anxiety, an uncertain future and a lifestyle that is increasingly out of reach.”¹⁴ In their book, *The Rich and the Rest of Us: A Poverty Manifesto*, Tavis Smiley and Cornel West indicate, if the United States ever hopes to restore some semblance of economic common ground,

we must first confront some cold, hard facts. Our chickens have come home to roost. While we maligned and ignored the poor and worked to separate them from those more fortunate, poverty snaked its way into mainstream America. As unemployment, corporate greed, and the divide between the rich and the rest of us grew exponentially in the 21st century, we held onto our stale 20th century habits.¹⁵

Further, they suggest that one way to combat poverty is to speak directly to the heart of the matter:

Those who control America's purse strings must be called out on the disingenuous and deceitful language used when they (rarely) broach the subject: Talk of a great economic comeback based on "minimum wage" jobs as opposed to "living wage" jobs; a "jobless recovery" without a "job-based recovery" plan and process; helping the "working poor" without a solid roadmap to help "poor people" find a way out of poverty. The lack of concrete, unequivocal, direct language employed when we try to address these problems underscores a lack of will and the political inability to provide real opportunities for the poor.¹⁶

The current state of Black Church Studies must contend with the dual concerns of economic justice and globalization in a direct, thoughtful, and straightforward manner. In countless seminary classrooms and university lecture halls, we have a steady and valid condemnation of gospel of prosperity, faith-based initiatives, "compassionate conservatism," and the formation of "Christianity Light" mega churches as threats that pervade too much of the contemporary theological and ecclesial energies within the Black community. Conversely, however, there is a frightening scarcity of alternative notions about how to confront this "name it and claim it" spirituality in a truly formidable way. In essence, those of us committed to Black Church Studies have spoken about what we **are against** but have not said what we **stand for**. For instance, instead of talking about mega churches as both a theological and sociological phenomenon, we need to focus on the prospect of "mega ministries." Unfortunately, maybe the naming of such ecclesial institutions ought not to be called "megachurches" but rather "megalomaniacal church" because of their preoccupation with a more materialistic, "me-first" theological perspective that seems more concerned with self-absorption and individualism than self-reflection and intercommunalism.

It is my contention that it is vitally important for all BCS programs to infuse elements of political economy and greater global awareness into their broader academic enterprise. As I have stated elsewhere, the concept of political economy, when stripped of any ideological/philosophical jargon, is the understanding of *who* gets *what*, *when*, *where*, and *how*. As our current point in history illustrates, leaders and congregations of the historic Black church tradition have the greatest need for this knowledge yet are often ill-equipped to discuss what is at stake for Black people in an era that is being overwhelmingly defined by the rampant consolidation of wealth and power in the midst of relentless misery and depravation. Moreover, even as Black Church Studies programs should position themselves to articulate the *who*, *what*, *when*, *where*, and *how* regarding the ways in which political economy works, only they have the moral resolve to ask *why* the unjust concentration and exploitation of natural resources, amassed wealth, and societal power has surpassed sound stewardship and fair distribution of the planet's plentiful blessings, both human and otherwise. In this way, BCS programs will provide an important platform for renewed moral vision and social action.¹⁷

In a similar manner, this chapter is intended to build on some of the issues that have already been raised regarding our acknowledging what it means to be a diasporic community. As a people, we should not need to read Thomas Piketty's *Capital in the 21st Century*, Barbara Ehrenreich's *Bait and Switch*, Steven Levitt and Stephen Dubner's *Freakonomics*, Thomas

Friedman's *The World Is Flat*, or the legendary broadsheet of the *Wall Street Journal* in order to understand the ramifications of globalization because we have lived this reality since the time of Christopher Columbus' first voyage across the Atlantic Ocean. What I am talking about in terms of globalization is the free-flowing movement of people, cultures, and ideas as well as goods, services, and knowledge across national borders and territorial zones. It is my belief that Black Church Studies programs can set a progressive theological agenda to prepare academic, ordained, and lay leaders who can embrace the multiracial, multiethnic, and multicultural realities of our surroundings, where mainstream approaches consistently fail.

When we think about the prospects and promises of merging political economy and globalization within Black Church Studies, we need to look at the example of Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. Even though King lived and died in an era before the existence of Black Church Studies as an academic field of study, I would contend that King's training and accomplishments reflect the best-case scenario for merging the church, academy, and community via an educated, activist, and compassionate ministry. I have neither the interest nor intention to reduce the potential vision of BCS programs and curricula to a rote rehashing of "Kingology 101" but it is undeniable from my view that there are some paradigmatic issues about King's education, ministry, and activism that are germane to this discussion and that are too often glossed over by his supporters and critics alike.

Asking the Real Question: Black Church Studies Reclaiming the Social Gospel in an Age of Prosperity

In a sermon at the National Cathedral in Washington, DC, on March 31, 1968, Dr. King said "there is nothing new about poverty. What is new is that we now have the techniques and the resources to get rid of poverty. The real question is whether we have the will." Making this statement just a few short days before his assassination, Dr. King stood tall as a visionary leader by articulating two key truths about modern American society. First, contrary to conventional wisdom about economic matters throughout the twentieth century, Dr. King asserts that the majority of hardships such as poverty, homelessness, education, unemployment, chronic illness, infant mortality, and imprisonment could be remedied by the affluence of post-war American society if popular will recognized they had the capability to end inequality and misery. Second and more important, King's bold assertion nearly five decades ago, that regardless of how dreadful things might seem, impoverishment and scarcity of resources is a human rather than divine creation. In other words, in a global context where virtually anything can be grown, manufactured, or repaired on demand, poverty is much more a maldistribution of the world's resources due to the wanton greed and reckless indifference of mortal beings than some curse from God.

When thinking about how to grapple with poverty in modern African American life and culture, it is important to reassess its relationship to prosperity as its real-lived and religious counterpart. Ethicist Jonathan Walton defines the prosperity gospel (also referred to as the Word of Faith movement) in its most fundamental definition as "the belief that material wealth is God's desire for the faithful."¹⁸ It is notable to assert that built into the prosperity gospel's theological perspective is an overt degree of political apathy. Jonathan Walton argues, however, that for prosperity gospel preachers "America's social systems are inconsequential. The magico-religious rituals of forming a covenant with God through the Word, positive confession, and seed sowing allow persons to reach a state of *metaphysical physicality* that surmounts the restrictions of America's capitalist economy."¹⁹ This observation about the willful disconnect of the prosperity gospel's chief proponents from any form of prophetic witness in the face of the prevailing economic order elicits two immediate responses. On the one hand, no degree of piety guarantees anyone protection against the ravages of a political economy run

amok. Conversely, on the other hand, financial poverty has never been—and should not have to be—synonymous with spiritual poverty in this world.

What these points suggest is that the deep-seated failure of the prosperity gospel to address economic justice must be considered more fully and forcefully within African American theological discourse and ministerial praxis. Ethicist Keri Day argues that there are inherent shortcomings within the prosperity gospel movement that hinder any genuine hopes of economic justice. First, Day notes, “Prosperity gospel teachings enable affluent persons, including multinational corporations and their extreme wealth in religious terms, linking God’s favor to their prosperity” yet those selfsame teachings “basically ignore the source and means of such profit.”²⁰ Moreover, she illustrates the magical thinking employed within the Word of Faith movement by arguing “a theology that celebrates wealth based on faith alone cannot effectively challenge the ways in which economic arrangements are built on the backs of the poor, reinforcing and intensifying their improvement.”²¹ Said another way, prayer alone—no matter how fervent and faithful—will not end structural and transgenerational poverty. The biblical injunction that “faith without works is dead” (James 2:20) is a particularly helpful corrective to the Word of Faith movement’s blind spot to the inherent malevolence and mendacity of the global economy.

There is a sad irony that the historic Black church tradition, forged out of the crucible of the inhuman bondage of slavery and the oppressive subjugation of racial segregation largely proscribed by economic and geopolitical realities, is so ill-equipped to address such issues in our contemporary context. The challenge lies in redefining BCS programs and curricula so that they can prepare people for the materialistic and mundane realities as well as the spiritual and esoteric concerns of our world. While there is a fairly broad representation of theological reflections and religious perspectives on economic matters within the ranks of white mainline Christendom (generally referred to herein as “the Social Gospel”), there are special and unique insights that can be derived from the experiences and critical awareness provided by Black Christians. Put another way, although the writings of white religious thinkers on various dimensions of the Social Gospel grappled with the tensions between Christianity and capitalism in ways that illuminate the radical, moderate, or reactionary views of the mainline Catholic and Protestant tradition, a comparable corpus of scholarship has yet to arise within the ranks of BCS programs and curricula.

The early Social Gospel movement came into existence at a very difficult historical moment for African Americans. Emerging during the late nineteenth century during a period often referred to as the “nadir of American race relations,”²² the Social Gospel advanced profound challenges to the political constraints and economic injustices that imposed paralyzing limits on marginalized people, namely people of color, women, the working poor, immigrants, and children among others. As an outgrowth of the Progressive era, the Social Gospel movement in urban America embraced a nascent social justice agenda that envisioned the federal government as the bona fide protector of constitutional rights and civil liberties, sought safeguards against the ravages of industrial capitalism, and wrestled with the nation’s adherence to avowed religious principles and moral values. At its height, the Social Gospel movement represented members of the Christian faith across racial, cultural, and denominational lines. According to Gary Dorrien, the Black Social Gospel

affirmed the dignity, sacred personhood, creativity, and moral agency of African Americans and responded to racial oppression. It asked what a new abolitionism should be and what role the churches should play within it . . . The full-fledged black social gospel combined an emphasis on black dignity and personhood with protest activism for racial justice, comprehensive social justice agenda, an insistence that authentic Christian faith is incompatible with racial prejudice, an emphasis on the social ethical teaching of Jesus, and an acceptance of modern scholarship and social consciousness.²³

Even though many contemporary Black Christians do not comprehend the depth of this movement's influence on the Black church tradition, it can be easily argued that the development of the King-led nonviolent civil rights movement, Black liberation theology, progressive Black theology, and womanist theology is perhaps unthinkable without the Black Social Gospel. That being said, it is incumbent upon the field of Black Church Studies to maintain this social justice dimension of Black Christianity not merely as a dusty museum artifact but as a vital and necessary element of African American religious life both in historical and contemporaneous terms.

This dearth of scholarly attention to such matters within many BCS programs and curricula is not for lack of either historical or contemporary examples of Black Christians who found practical and profound means to overcome crippling economic and geopolitical realities. Although the bulk of this chapter focuses on examples drawn from the life, thoughts, and ministry of Dr. King, it is important to note that he was part of a larger movement to establish economic justice and global harmony in meaningful ways. The emergence of independent Black churches in America during the late 1700s and early 1800s was a clear testament to this sort of vision. The pioneering efforts of Black evangelists, preachers, and pastors such as George Liele, David George, and Andrew Bryan in the south as well as Richard Allen Absalom Jones, and James Varick in the north made the reality of Black Baptist, Methodist, and Episcopal communities of faith possible by marshalling both significant spiritual as well as material resources. Even when contemporary analyses of slave narratives and the spirituals rightfully have begun to recognize these African American cultural productions as wonderful theological and moral resources, we often fail to appreciate these cultural expressions were also powerful and effective tools for undermining chattel slavery, the most lucrative economic engine and entrenched geopolitical concern in antebellum America. When Frederick Douglass, Solomon Northup, Harriet Jacobs and other authors of slave narratives wrote about the inhumane degradation, utter misery, and moral hypocrisy of white Christians enslaving Blacks or each time enslaved Blacks in the South sang "Wade in the Water," "Ride On King Jesus," and "Swing Low Sweet Chariot" with the purpose of helping those brave enough to make the dangerous trek to freedom in the north via the Underground Railroad, these were concerted efforts to defy the dominant political and economic elites of their day. When Callie House, leader of the Ex-Slave Reparations movement in the years following the Civil War, sought both legal redress and economic compensation for the 4 million formerly enslaved Black Southerners living in the United States at that time, it was Black churches that served as critical forums and bases for mobilization for this nascent challenge.²⁴ As African Americans moved from slavery to freedom, the growth and development of modern Black Christian denominations became vitally important to Black people's transition into urban, industrial America.²⁵ During the early twentieth century, there are examples such as Rev. Henry Hugh Proctor, Rev. George Washington Woodbey, and Bishop Reverdy Ransom offering their own perspectives that ranged from conventional Social Gospel thought to full-blown Christian Marxism.²⁶ Moreover, the missionary endeavors of the African Methodist Episcopal Church under the auspices of Bishop Henry McNeal Turner and the Lott Carey Convention by Black Baptists reflected a great interest by African American Christians to devote precious resources (especially money) to reconnect with their ancestral African homeland in ways that continue to the present. Throughout much of the twentieth century, there were estimable activist ministers such as the Revs. Adam Clayton Powell Sr. and Jr., Rev. C. L. Franklin, Rev. Leon H. Sullivan, Rev. Prathia Hall, Rev. Samuel D. Proctor, Rev. Cecil Williams, Rev. Wyatt T. Walker, Rev. Hosea Williams, Rev. Jesse L. Jackson Sr., and Rev. Dr. Jeremiah A. Wright Jr., to name a few who clearly bore witness to bold, multifaceted visions of economic empowerment and social justice steeped in the Black Christian tradition. With just these few examples of Black Christendom's constructive commitment to dealing with economic injustice, the void in scholarship addressing this wealth of Black theological insights and praxis is unconscionable, to say the least.

Confronting Poverty in Our Midst: The Poor People's Campaign and King's Christocentric Critique of Capitalism

In Mark 14:7 (and similarly Matthew 26:11), when a poor woman anoints Jesus' head, the apostles scream in shock and dismay that the woman wasted the expensive oil when, instead, "this ointment could have been sold for three hundred *denarii*, and the money given to the poor." In response to their criticism, Jesus praises the woman's "good work" in tending to him and declares to his apostles "For you have the poor with you always, and whenever you will you may do them good; but me you will not always have." While this is probably the most repeated biblical verse pertaining to the poor, most of us generally recite the passage's initial assertion without ever addressing the conditional statement that follows. Many of us have been trained and conditioned to think that poverty both here and abroad is so persistent and pernicious there is no compelling need to trouble ourselves about it. Moreover, for those of us whose lives are defined by our experiences in America, we are taught to think of poverty as an unfortunate yet inevitable condition that must be visited upon some portion of the world's populace. Alas, even those of us who may be one generation—or one paycheck—removed from the murderous clutches of debt and poverty, envision the poor as misbegotten creatures of a lesser god who serve as reminders of what we must avoid at all costs in our own lives. Saddest of all, given the continual mistreatment of the poor in the world, it seems that every human institution in this society—especially the church—guarantees that we will, indeed, always have the poor as an absolute reality of our social landscape.

Because King believed in freedom, justice, and equality, he sought to determine the means for struggle and survival the best way he could free of the encumbrances that come from ideological or political attachments like millions of other oppressed people of color around the world. Second, as King's notion of economic justice gradually evolved from the Montgomery Bus Boycott (Black economic might mobilized as a *means* of obtaining social justice) to the Poor People's Campaign (securing Black economic welfare as an *ends* unto itself), he used critical and often confounding dimensions of Marx's writings in ways that sharpened and strengthened his focus on Jesus' own mandate that we address the needs of "the least of these."

In 1968, Dr. King offered a brief rationale behind the Poor People's Campaign by stating, "We called our demonstration a campaign for jobs and income because we felt that the economic question was the most crucial that Black people, and poor people generally were confronting." The intervening years since Dr. King's assassination have seen a marked retreat from that trenchant assessment about the crisis of America's poorest members from all sectors of society. As an aside, whatever happened to the Poor People's Campaign and why isn't anyone talking about reviving this sort of Christian challenge to endemic structural poverty in America in the wake of the Occupy Wall Street movement? In light of the absence of a mass movement akin to the Poor People's Campaign, BCS programs and curricula can play a greater role in reinvigorating a preference for the poorest within the nation's collective moral conscience. Keri Day contends that although the Poor People's Campaign "was considered unsuccessful and is largely unfinished business today, it can be revived as a vibrant class-based vision of economic justice if the poor are to become contributing members of our society instead of second-class citizens."²⁷ Furthermore, Day asserts that Black churches can play a vital part in reconstituting the Poor People's Campaign but first they "must be willing to strengthen the democratic project in America by decrying how neoliberal capitalist institutions trick, oppress, and enslave the poor."²⁸

But even as I raise this issue, we do not need to focus on Marx to understand Black people's plight within the realm of political economy. In fact, we have plenty of examples and resources for this type of analysis and critique of capitalism from African American thinkers. For instance, at the height of the national strife surrounding the fate of African Americans trapped in the "peculiar institution" of chattel slavery during the 1850s, famed abolitionist

Frederick Douglass comments that the interests of Anglo and African American workers had been historically undermined because

both are plundered . . . by the same plunderers. The [enslaved] is robbed by his master, of all his earnings above what is required for his physical necessities; and the white man is robbed by the slave system, because he is flung into competition with a class of laborers who work without wages.²⁹

Reflecting on the status of the four million newly freed African Americans in the post-Civil War South who still bore the most immediate legacy of slavery W. E. B. Du Bois states in *The Souls of Black Folk* that “to be a poor [person] is hard, but to be a poor race in a land of dollars is the very bottom of hardships.”³⁰ In this simple yet poignant statement, Du Bois indicates quite obviously that there is a structural disadvantage at work when one has to reckon with the reality of race and class within a communal rather than individualistic reality. More recently, Black religious scholars including Cornel West, James Cone, Katie Cannon, Darryl Trimiew, Cheryl Townsend Gilkes, Peter Paris, Dwight Hopkins, and Michael Eric Dyson among others have offered varying degrees of race, class, and gender analysis within Black Church Studies in ways that describe power dynamics in a more culturally centered and organic fashion than previously deemed possible.

While attending a summit on overcoming poverty hosted at Georgetown University in May 2015, President Obama made an especially poignant appeal to the nation about the interconnection of race, class, and family dynamics within American society. As the nation’s first African American president, Obama felt it was necessary to openly defend his occasional practice of delivering public lectures aimed squarely at young African American men on the importance of demonstrating a commitment to raising children. His remarks served as a bulwark against conservatives’ claims about dysfunctional family structure amongst the Black underclass as the root of a presumed “culture of poverty.”³¹ Speaking out of his personal experience, President Obama said, “And the reason is . . . because I am a black man who grew up without a father and I know the cost that I paid for that . . . And I also know that I have the capacity to break that cycle, and as a consequence, I think my daughters are better off.”³² Quite frankly, it must be said that expectations for Obama’s two-term presidency were astronomically unrealistic both in terms of his personal profile and political skills to overcome our nation’s unrelenting commitment to white supremacy in its myriad forms. When taken as a whole, Obama was uniquely positioned as president of the United States to understand the trials and travails of marginalized people in the United States and also globally. As a biracial Black man who was raised by a single white mother who spent considerable portions of his childhood both in Hawaii as well as Indonesia, Obama’s life journey from his Ivy League education and community organizer to his celebrated role as Black husband and father and historic political ascendant made him the poster child for Black possibilities in the post-civil rights era.³³

Unlike all of his predecessors in the White House, Obama did not need to have dimensions of the modern African American experience translated for him because he has lived it. Throughout his presidency, Obama has demonstrated that he understands both intimately and intellectually the divisions among people of different racial, ethnic, cultural, gendered, sexual, religious, socioeconomic, and political backgrounds that stand as the most pivotal problems of our age. For much of his brief yet profound political career Obama has infused his speeches, campaign policy statements, op-ed pieces, and other writings with his vision of governmental action honed in accordance with democratic principles for a greater national unity and human equality.³⁴ However, what Obama’s presidency lacks is a rich and robust partnership with Black church leadership across the theological spectrum who could help shape the structures of both political action and accountability. Whereas, some Black religious leaders and thinkers have spoken *about* and *against* many of the administration’s policies (a totally reasonable practice

when based on legitimate differences of opinion in support of human freedom and flourishing rather than petty grievances), there have been very few who could speak *with* the president, legislators, and governmental agencies.

For Black Church Studies to actually provide the sort of prophetic witness that is necessary to get us beyond the sloganeering of “Prayer of Jabez,” “Favor Ain’t Fair,” and all the other props of the “gospel of prosperity” there are some issues that have to be dealt with: moving American society from an archaic minimum wage to an actual living wage; legislation at the state and/or federal level regarding the provision of universal education, housing, and health care for everyone; supporting elected political leaders in efforts to explore possible reparations schemes for slavery in United States; renouncing predatory credit/lending practices, endless tax cuts for the wealthy, outsourcing of jobs, and other unfair aspects of the American economy; abstaining from faith-based initiatives that are tied to partisanship, political patronage, prejudice, and paternalism; working towards defining a more responsive and balanced church-state relationship within society; providing advocacy on behalf of the tens of thousands of Black folks displaced and devastated by Hurricane Katrina, the Gulf Coast oil spill, Superstorm Sandy, and countless other disasters that befall the poor and disadvantaged; and demanding international debt relief for poor nations of color in the Two-Thirds World.

Strangers in the Land: King’s Merger of Economic Justice and Humane Globalization

As expressed in Leviticus 19:33–34, the Israelites were taught that “the strangers who sojourn with you shall be to you as the natives among you, and you shall love them as yourself; for you were strangers in the land of Egypt.” Whereas a more traditional interpretation of this passage by Hebrew Bible scholars tends to assert that the *ger toshav* (typically translated as “resident alien” or “the stranger who lives among us”) is the main focus of the text and must be a person of moral virtue and good legal standing, that conditional standard in no way dilutes or abrogates the absolute urgency of this directive to treat all people fairly and equally.

Towards this end, the reason why I see this issue of economic justice linked to globalization is because we are inherently a global people. Virtually every vestige of this society wishes to accentuate everything that divides people of African descent. We cannot act as if we have the option of being disconnected from the African Diaspora, which is tantamount to the whole world. As people descended from the victims and survivors of more than 400 years of forced migration, inhuman bondage, and broken lives caused by the Middle Passage we must recognize, reclaim, and ultimately redeem our legacy as heirs of the Black Atlantic. More than that, we do not have the choice to disengage from the large global community. As the saying goes, “We may have come in different ships but we are all in the same boat now!” Through the auspices of Black Church Studies programs and curricula, we have the potential to heal many of the wounds created by white supremacy as manifested in chattel slavery, segregation, imperialism, and a myriad of social sins.

What is most important at present, however, is that those of us who are committed to BCS must work ceaselessly to expunge the virulent strains of negative sentiment and xenophobia that are frustrating any genuine progress on this issue. Our utmost goal must be to strive to educate ourselves and our people about our many points of commonalty as well as differences in our communities, especially as those dynamics mirror what is happening in the larger human family. In Washington, DC, Atlanta, Houston, New York City, Boston, Philadelphia, and elsewhere across this nation, we have African Americans who are interacting with sisters and brothers from Eritrea, Nigeria, Ghana, Sudan, South Africa, Haiti, Jamaica, Trinidad and Tobago, the Dominican Republic, Panama, and Brazil just to name a few places across the African Diaspora. Being part of such a worldwide community raises a threefold concern. First, we need to transcend death-dealing notions of ethnicity and nationality in order to welcome

and encourage a greater level of fellowship and interaction among ourselves in our seminaries, our church sanctuaries, and our city streets. More than 50 years ago, Dr. King spoke most clearly about the interdependence of all peoples by stating that

every nation is an heir of a vast treasury of ideas and labor to which both the living and the dead of all nations have contributed. Whether we realize it or not, each of us lives eternally “in the red.” We are everlasting debtors to known and unknown men and women. When we arise in the morning, we go into the bathroom where we reach for a sponge provided for us by a Pacific Islander. We reach for soap that is created for us by a European. Then at a table we drink coffee which is provided for us by a South American, or tea by a Chinese, or cocoa by a West African. Before we leave for our jobs we are already beholden to more than half the world.³⁵

Secondly, as much as our time, resources, and opportunity will permit, persons of African descent born and raised in the United States must break out of the stifling confines of the American context physically, mentally, and spiritually to witness the truth that, in fact, the whole world is Africa. Finally, although I am keenly aware of all the local problems that any good pastor, professor, poet, and prophet has to be focused upon, we must be attuned now more than ever to the activities of supranational institutions such as the G8 Summit, World Bank, International Monetary Fund (IMF), and World Trade Organization (WTO) as well as the impact of the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA), General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT), and Central American Free Trade Agreement (CAFTA). Furthermore, Black Christendom has to become better informed about the growing debates over so-called “illegal immigration” in order to speak more knowledgeably and poignantly about the matter beyond the typically narrow focus of mainstream media and conservative pundits. The last time the United States had such lousy trade, labor, and immigration policies, millions of our African ancestors were being hauled across the ocean aboard ships called *Brotherhood*, *John the Baptist*, and the *Virgin Mary*!

Once again drawing upon the example of Dr. King, in and out of seminary, he represents a wonderful example of how and why a Black preacher should incorporate a global vision into her/his theory and praxis. For example, at the feet of Howard Thurman and others, King was deeply enamored with the strategies and struggles of Mahatma Gandhi’s nonviolent independence movement on the Indian subcontinent during the 1940s. While it is now second nature to mention this connection between the two great leaders, it often alludes us how many cultural misconceptions and conceptual barriers had to be overcome for King or anyone to find common ground with Gandhi and do so with such success and potency. Some years later, Dr. King, fresh out of graduate school and newly installed as pastor of Dexter Avenue Baptist Church, would have conversations with Rev. Ralph Abernathy about the 1955 Bandung Conference that brought together many African, Arab, and Asian nations in pursuit of freedom from the European colonial powers. This exchange, taking place months before these two men would make their own imprint on human history, helped them tap into a prophetic postcolonial imagination long before such a notion was even thought possible. One sees evidence of such global thinking in King’s book *Why We Can’t Wait*, wherein he directly links the southern phase of the civil rights movement to the decolonization struggles for liberation taking place in Africa and Asia.³⁶ Although he has never been lauded as a Pan-Africanist thinker like El Hajj Malik el Shabazz (Malcolm X), Kwame Ture (Stokely Carmichael), or Jaramogi Abebe Agyeman (Albert Cleage), Dr. King was acutely aware that the fate of African America was inextricably connected to the destiny of African peoples both on the continent and in the African Diaspora.

Most importantly, as he sailed against the tide of mainstream public opinion, Dr. King had the courage, conviction, and clarity to prophesy in his legendary “Beyond Vietnam” sermon

at the Riverside Church on April 4, 1967 that American military adventure in Vietnam would come to no good end and expose God's extreme displeasure with US imperialism as morally wrong. Although many folks tried to shout him down, Dr. King dared to think that his education, experiences, and even the awarding of the Nobel Peace Prize gave him the right to speak his mind on global debates of war and peace, especially when that immoral war pitted poor Black soldiers against poor Vietnamese citizens and billions of dollars siphoned from the needy and dispossessed here at home. Where is such a defiant voice within our Black churches in light of the fact that President George W. Bush—a self-professed “born-again” Christian and Compassionate Conservative—sent US military troops into Baghdad way too soon and sent FEMA relief teams into New Orleans way too late? If a person is to be judged by his or her deeds, a completely justified and full-throated denunciation of the Bush presidency should be emerging from Black pastors, congregations, scholars, and concerned citizens nationwide. Unfortunately, while the Bush White House enjoyed unfettered access to the sanctuaries and pulpits of numerous Black mega church pastors and called on their services for politically expediency, the vast majority of scholars, pastors, and congregations committed to the historic Black Christian tradition did not bring an effective condemnation of Bush's foreign policy debacles or domestic disasters. If BCS programs and curricula wish to remain true to their *raison d'être*, scholars and students alike have to be primed to ask such questions and ready to do the necessary work to find suitable answers in order to meet the needs of God's people.

In preparing women and men for meaningful lives devoted to enlightened ministry and engaged activism, BCS programs and curricula must provide individuals and communities with the necessary information to broach global issues with greater levels of sophistication, authority, and integrity. Presently, Black Christian leaders and congregations are largely excluded from raging debates about the American government's flagrant disregard for the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the Geneva Convention in pursuit of its global “War on Terror;” the perils of global climate change; the escalating threat of nuclear weapons proliferation; the spread of political unrest and genocide in Sudan, the Congo, and elsewhere on the African continent; incessant meddling by the United States in the political and economic affairs of its Caribbean and Latin American neighbors; and the still flourishing trade in “blood diamonds” from Sierra Leone and other parts of West Africa. These and other global matters should be of keen interest not just to people of African descent but to any person of good conscience. Unfortunately, many Black churches today are silenced and ineffective in contending with some of the most pressing issues of our time because the majority of graduate theological programs and seminaries do not equip them with the rudimentary skills to generate a global sensibility that is more insightful and incisive. Put simply, one cannot preach or teach what one does not know or understand.

To make matters worse, there are many members of the clergy and laity of Black churches who, in acknowledging their own lack of global awareness, defer all handling of such matters to the current crop of political leaders. A number of Black Christians have given dominion to incompetent and ruthless worldly leaders in compliance with Romans 13:1—“Every person is to be in subjection to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except God, and those which exist are established by God.” Like many other Pauline writings, this scriptural passage should be held up to the most intense scrutiny regarding its significance and implications for Black folks who have never had the luxury or opportunity to surrender our collective fate in blind faith to any earthly government. When BCS programs and curricula are operating at their fullest potential, they enable women and men to grapple with the powers and principalities of this world with a divine spirit of love and justice which demonstrates the truest essence of what good citizenship can be. Without any fixed allegiance to partisan politics, populist slogans, or ideological labels, BCS programs and curricula must dedicate themselves to preparing students and scholars who can provide a prophetic yet pragmatic challenge to the *status quo*.

Bringing Forth New Heavens and a New Earth: The Prophetic Mission of Black Church Studies in a Post-Civil Rights Era

In closing, Black Church Studies must incorporate elements of economic justice and globalization because our past, present, and future are tied to how well we cultivate these matters as related to the entire African Diaspora. As important as it is for us to become well-versed on world issues, it is equally necessary to share this information with our communities and with the love and urgency God has given us for such a time as this. Our preparation and willingness will be well met by the sheer hunger of our people for a way forward in spite of all the forces arrayed against us. In turn, we have to be receptive to the prospects of making connections to grassroots activists, public policy institutes, think tanks, and/or non-governmental organizations (NGOs) in an effort to find localized solutions to global problems.

In each of the instances mentioned above, it was not just what King learned about God in his seminary education that urged him to struggle for the liberation of all people, but his grasp of the role played by political and economic forces in the modern world that launched him on the path to grapple with the legions of white supremacy. When he did come to grips with them he knew the exact spot where they were most vulnerable; that is, he knew how to paralyze the economic life of Montgomery, Alabama, 50 years ago. It was a political and economic vision conjoined with moral and metaphysical insight that enabled King as a 26-year-old minister to galvanize the Montgomery Bus Boycott into a key phase of the global Black freedom struggle. So let us forsake all the arbitrary labels and false designations that keep us at odds with each other once and for all and let's dream freely of the sort of world that we want. For me, this vision of the ideal world is found in Isaiah 65: 17–24. God tells the prophet about the creation of “new heavens and a new earth” wherein:

there shall be no more thence an infant of days, nor an elderly person that does not fill their days for the child shall live to 100 years and anyone who dies before they are one hundred years old shall be considered cursed. And they shall build houses, and inhabit them and they shall plant vineyards and eat the fruit of them. They shall not build and another inhabit; they shall not plant, and another eat for as the days of a tree are the days of my people, and mine elect shall long enjoy the work of their hands. They shall not labor in vain nor bring forth for trouble; for they are the seed of the blessed of the Lord, and their offspring with them. And it shall come to pass that before they call, I will answer and while they are yet speaking, I will hear.

BCS programs and curricula must be at the forefront of establishing a covenant of economic justice and genuine globalization that fully embraces our shared humanity and uplifts our common dreams for the future. It should be the goal of Black Church Studies to prepare clergy and laity who are willing to risk all to make such a state of affairs the birthright of all people everywhere in the world.

Notes

1. “Megachurch Pastor Seeks Donations for Pricey Private Jet,” *New York Times*, March 13, 2015 <http://nyti.ms/1BZZJkw>
2. Abby Ohlheiser, “Creflo Dollar is No Longer Asking His Faithful to Fund a New, \$65 Million Private Jet,” *Washington Post*, March 17, 2015, <http://www.washingtonpost.com/news/acts-of-faith/wp/2015/03/17/creflo-dollar-private-jet/>
3. See Jonathan L. Walton, *Watch This!: The Ethics and Aesthetics of Black Televangelism* (New York: New York University Press, 2009), 145–165.

4. Nick Kotz, *Judgment Days: Lyndon Baines Johnson, Martin Luther King Jr. and the Laws That Changed America* (New York: Houghton Mifflin, 2005).
5. *The Words of Martin Luther King, Jr.*, Selected and With an Introduction by Coretta Scott King (New York: Newmarket Press, 1996), 45.
6. Arthur B. Kennickell, "A Rolling Tide: Changes in the Distribution of Wealth in the US, 1989–2001," *Levy Economics Institute*, Working Paper No. 393, November 2003.
7. US Department of Labor, Bureau of Labor Statistics, <http://www.bls.gov/news.release/empsit.t02.htm>; Arthur B. Kennickell, "A Rolling Tide"; Derrick Muhammad, Davis Attieno, Meizhu Lui, Betsy Leondar-Wright, *The State of the Dream 2004: Enduring Disparities in Black and White*. (Boston: United for a Fair Economy, 2004), 6–7.
8. Derrick Muhammad, et al. *The State of the Dream 2004*, 6–7.
9. "Many States Cut Budgets as Fiscal Squeeze Continues," *Center for Budget and Policy Priorities*, April 26, 2004; Jonathan Weisman, "2006 Cuts in Domestic Spending on Table," *Washington Post*, May 27, 2004; Derrick Muhammad, et al. "State of the Dream 2005," 6–7.
10. The term "Great Recession" has been used in more than 14,592 different articles according to Google News at the time of this writing. The definition and origins of term "Great Recession" can be traced at the following website: <http://www.davemanuel.com/investor-dictionary/the-great-recession/>.
11. See Paul Krugman, *The Return of Depression Economics and the Crisis of 2008* (New York: Norton, 2009).
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15. Tavis Smiley and Cornel West, *The Rich and the Rest of Us: A Poverty Manifesto*, (New York: SmileyBooks, 2012), 38.
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20. Keri Day, *Unfinished Business: Black Women, the Black Church, and the Struggle to Thrive in America* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2012), 111.
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26. Although the majority of early scholarship on the relationship between Marxism and Black Christianity focused more prominently upon two Black Baptist ministers, George Washington Woodbey and George W. Slater Jr., the earliest known person of African descent to join the ranks of American socialists is Peter Humphries Clark. In the 1870s, Clark's speeches and organizing efforts for the Workingman's Party and its subsequent offshoot, the Socialist Labor Party, were steeped in his own painful personal experiences with the growing inequalities between the wealthy and the poor in addition to propagating an antiracist agenda under the auspices of socialism. See Juan M. Floyd-Thomas, "Seeing Red in the Black Church:

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27. Keri Day, *Unfinished Business: Black Women, the Black Church, and the Struggle to Thrive in America* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2012), 149.
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 29. Frederick Douglass’s *My Bondage and My Freedom* (1855; New York: Dover Press, 1969), 310.
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 31. See William J. Wilson, *The Truly Disadvantaged: The Inner City, the Underclass, and Public Policy* (1987; Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012); Michael B. Katz, ed., *The “Underclass” Debate: Views from History* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1992); and Robin D. G. Kelley, *Yo’ Mama’s Disfunktional!: Fighting the Culture Wars in Urban America* (Boston, MA: Beacon Press, 1997).
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 33. In addition to President Barack H. Obama’s own monographs, *Dreams From My Father: A Story of Race and Inheritance* (New York: Random House, 1995) and *The Audacity of Hope: Thoughts on Reclaiming the American Dream* (New York: Random House, 2006), also see T. Denean Sharpley-Whiting, ed., *The Speech: Race and Barack Obama’s “A More Perfect Union”* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2009); Thomas J. Sugrue, *Not Even Past: Barack Obama and the Burden of Race* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2009); David Remnick, *The Bridge: The Life and Rise of Barack Obama* (New York: Knopf, 2010); Jonathan Alter, *The Promise: President Obama, Year One* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 2010); William Jelani Cobb, *The Substance of Hope: Barack Obama and the Paradox of Progress* (New York: Walker Books, 2010); Michael Tesler and David O. Sears, *Obama’s Race: The 2008 Election and the Dream of a Post-Racial America* (Chicago: University Of Chicago Press, 2010); Peniel E. Joseph, *Dark Days, Bright Nights: From Black Power to Barack Obama* (New York: Basic Civitas Books, 2010); James T. Kloppenberg, *Reading Obama: Dreams, Hope, and the American Political Tradition* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2011); Randall Kennedy, *The Persistence of the Color Line: Racial Politics and the Obama Presidency* (New York: Vintage, 2011); Fredrick Harris, *The Price of the Ticket: Barack Obama and Rise and Decline of Black Politics* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2012); Jodi Kantor, *The Obamas* (New York: Little Brown and Company, 2012); Janny Scott, *A Singular Woman: The Untold Story of Barack Obama’s Mother* (New York: Penguin, 2011); Sally H. Jacobs, *The Other Barack: The Bold and Reckless Life of President Obama’s Father* (New York: Public Affairs, 2011); David Maraniss, *Barack Obama: The Story* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2012); and Jonathan Alter, *The Center Holds: Obama and His Enemies* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2013).
 34. See John R. Talbott, *Obamanomics: How Bottom-Up Economic Prosperity Will Replace Trickle-Down Economics* (New York: Seven Stories, 2008).
 35. *The Words of Martin Luther King, Jr.*, selected and with an introduction by Coretta Scott King (New York: Newmarket Press, 1996), 18.
 36. Martin Luther King Jr., *Why We Can’t Wait* (1963; New York: Signet Classics, 2000), 8, 69, 76.

Epilogue: The Endarkenment: A Parable

Alton B. Pollard III

1 Peter 2: 1–10

En•dark•en•ment [en-dahrk-n-muh nt]

—noun (1) the act of endarkening. (2) the state of being endarkened. (3) **the Endarkenment**, a new *épistème* or way of knowing-and-being in the world, characterized by belief in the power of wisdom and by transformation of self, community and the larger world in the twenty-first century.

—verb (4) to endarken, to render opaque or certain, irreducibly human.

The Endarkenment movement is a *coincidentia oppositorum* and *sui generis* recognition, attesting to the meaning and value of peoples of African descent in particular, humankind in general, and reverence for all of life. The contrast is the intellectual ideological structure predominant in the Western world from the sixteenth through the eighteenth centuries called the Enlightenment. Strongly influenced by the rise of natural reason, the emergence of modern science, and symbolized by the global voyages of Christopher Columbus, human societies everywhere were quickly displaced one after another through the European encounter, and the succession of conquest, colonization, and enslavement. To this very day, in “post-modern” Europe and the United States of America, to be an enlightened individual is a consummate thing. There are countless people around the world—young women and young men, society’s neglected, the discarded, the alienated, the indigenous, persons of color, citizens of the two-thirds world—who are dreaming new dreams and seeing new visions of what it means to be human.

For countless ages and generations, parable has been used as a means to express sacred truth. At its best, parable instructs, disturbs, and ultimately invites its hearers and readers into intimations of the wholly possible. Parable disorients our reality in order that it may reorient us. It is disarmingly simple and deeply memorable. The initial imagery is often gentle but soon dismays. Parable is at once understated and paradigm shifting; it gives new meaning. Parable unmasks empire with exceeding power; it is counterhegemonic. Parable makes manifest new knowledge and insights; it changes lives. In the end these disruptive narratives, grounded in our experiences of the every day and the familiar, give rise to a radically pragmatic hope that makes people whole and sets humanity free.

For many people, the most prominent “for instance” of this literary genre are the New Testament parables of Jesus of Nazareth. Instructive for our purposes are the parables of the African American literary tradition. African American wisdom literature is filled with many wonderful and provocative parables penned by Langston Hughes, Alice Walker, Octavia Butler,

and Derrick Bell, among others. What follows is a parable of African American faith for the twenty-first century. I call this story "The Endarkenment."

Once in a time of great uncertainty and unrest, there was a pastor of a small congregation who sought to understand the secret of her ancestor's survival in this land. The minister thought that if she could only drink from the wellsprings of the distant past, touch the collective memories of her people, and glean something of the ancestral lineage that made her own life possible, then and there she would find the key to Black America's sustenance in the present age that was potential to the salvation of us all. Her quest led her into the radiantly cascading depths, into the nocturnal mystery the great mystic, prophet, preacher, and theologian Howard Thurman termed "the luminous darkness."¹ There she encountered the ancestors. She was renewed by the source of their strength in the midst of Maafa, in the maelstrom, madness, and misfortune of the new world: an ever-present help, a life-affirming God, an orienting culture, a resolute courage, a communal heart, a darkly radiant faith, a self-defining love.

Girded up with these spiritual tools this preacher, visionary, griot, daughter of thunder, holy one, began to teach the harsh lessons and heritage of being Black in North America—a history rife with injustice, inhumanity, oppression, murder, mutilation, rape, and brutality—and yet somehow also filled with great promise. Even more, she began to teach her parishioners about the wondrous depths and contours of Black life, about their unheralded heritage on the African continent and more recently in the United States of America and elsewhere throughout the diaspora, a legacy of wisdom, authenticity, grace, and truth. She named this primordial inheritance of Black people the *Endarkenment*²—the rich, deep, and unsung experience of her people, a great people, a proud people, a multihued people—cream, beige, tan, sepia, cinnamon, brown, ebony, blue blood, high yellow, red bone, honey-kissed brown, paper-bag brown, luscious caramel, dark chocolate, blue black, mulatto, quadroon, octoroon, colored, Negar, Negro, Moor, Nubian, black, indentured, involuntary, enslaved, free, immigrant, Afro-American, African American, African descended, people of the rainbow—who were once deemed "not a people but were now God's people" (1 Peter 2:10).

The members of this minister's congregation were utterly transformed by the power of the word that she shared. Some people passed out, others were slain in the Spirit, visited by the Orishas; all were overcome with ancestral power. They were amazed by the radical shift in their thinking and being. The *Sankofa* idea was simple and yet oh so exceedingly complex: "Return to your past in order to move forward."³ The words of ancestor Al Hajj Malik El-Shabazz (Malcolm X) took on renewed meaning: "those who forget their history are doomed to repeat it." They remembered the ancestral admonition of Ella Baker: "Strong people don't need strong leaders."

After a few weeks and months of intense study, the myriad marks of former oppression began to fall away from the congregation and an endarkened consciousness appeared. Not a particular religious doctrine, political philosophy, economic agenda, or any other formulaic creed, but the seldom-embraced and even less-remembered sacred heritage of her people was what this minister holy taught her church. From the peoples of West and Central and East and Southern Africa and from the transatlantic diaspora oral expressions, folk wisdom, slave narratives, conjuring, religions, literature, and more, they learned. Through prayer, praise, thanksgiving, poetry, imagery, music, sermon, art, dance, cooking, painting, sculpting, weaving, quilting, storytelling, testifying, and more, they learned. Through drumming, spirituals, ring shouts, work songs, lining hymns, jazz, blues, gospel, soul, reggae, dub poetry, rap, hip-hop, neo-soul, and spoken word, they learned. Through fervent and disciplined spiritual study, these believers rediscovered that theirs was a proud legacy of from "sun up to sun can't," of survival won against all odds. They reclaimed their neglected sacred inheritance of community, mutuality, nurture, struggle, resistance, liberation, healing, identity, and pride in "how we overcome." They experienced anew in their faith (*Imani*) and in their lives what it means

to be saved, not conventionally as “born again Christians” but more, as “born again African peoples.”⁴

Everyone—women and men, children and elders, left their Monday night covenant groups, Tuesday night healing services, Wednesday night prayer meetings, Thursday Nehemiah circles, Friday family fun nights, Saturday community outreach activities, and Sunday morning worship services, fired with a burning determination to achieve in ways that would forever justify the faith of their enslaved and freed forbears. They vowed to uphold the generations who held out when there was nothing to hold on to, who prayed when they couldn’t hear nobody pray, who hoped when all hope was gone, who had faith when the world was unfaithful, who believed even when they could find no earthly thing in which to believe.

What these believers learned, remembered, and reclaimed was their own transcendent sense of worth. They were the descendants of people whose primary motivation was not retaliation or revenge. They were the children of a people who did not wallow in self-pity, inferiority, or despair. They were born of a people who did not hold each other down like crabs in a barrel. They emerged from a people who did not turn their anger on one another first, last, or any other time. They arose from a people who did not seek to be “like white” or, for that matter, need to be superior to white. Their identity and self-esteem did not derive from “the ways of white folk” (to borrow a phrase from Langston Hughes), the *lex talionis* of an “eye for an eye” or a “tooth for a tooth,” but rather from a fierce and divine determination that “we will do this for ourselves.”⁵

In this spirit, equipped with an endarkening faith, Black folk who had previously been willing workers became fountains of creative (*Kuumba*) activity now. Anointed with a magnificent obsession, their lives became the very embodiment of purpose (*Nia*). Others joined them. Black men, who were once known to congregate in back alleys and gather in unsavory places, and Black women, who by virtue of circumstance were often in harm’s way, instead became the new architects of collective work and responsibility (*Ujima*). Word soon spread about the power of the people in this congregation, and the little church that could quickly outgrew its space.

At first, the church held its services in the sanctuary but was determined to spread the wealth even further, out in the clearings, to fully share the teachings in the spirit of unity (*Umoja*) with other faith and community leaders, and especially among the grassroots. The members became missionaries to the miseducated and evangelists to the emotionally and materially enslaved; they were spreading the good news about what it truly means to be saved. While the excitement grew in Black communities without respect of every religious communion, the popular media with rare exception ignored what they interpreted as just another insignificant activity from an inconsequential group.

Soon and very soon, however, there was no ignoring what was taking place in Black religious communions across North America. Black folk who had heard about the teachings, the healing and cleansing power of the meetings, but had not experienced them did not want to be left behind. They began to learn about African Continental and diasporan heritages and cultures on their own and saw a change come over themselves and in other Black folk. Like the tongues of fire on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:10), the transformation spread from one church to another, from one faith community to another, from one place to another, from the United States and Canada to the Caribbean and the Americas South and beyond to Africa and back again, to an entire believing people—one child, woman, man, and community at a time. Addiction, defeat, sickness, death, abuse, confusion, distrust, crime, despair, and self-hate were no more—as every Black person sought to be “filled more with the spirit.” They were able to “speak in new tongues,” to study, learn, and grow, to know self-determination (*Kujichagulia*), to excel in all things and “prove thyself worthy,” not in the eyes of a hegemonic deity, but a universal God.

The endarkenment spread. Black consciousness grew. The beauty of self-awareness had dawned. A healing was coming on. The unemployed found work. The underemployed

redefined supply and demand. All manner of community enterprise was encouraged and flourished in the spirit of cooperative economics (*Ujamaa*). Black faith institutions became libraries, lyceums, laboratories, mutual aid societies, social media platforms, and counterpublic spaces as in the days of old, when many things were done innovatively and in common. Many who had once been the recipients of public assistance programs began sending modest repayment checks to social service agencies.

Black family life strengthened as patriarchy, misogyny, heterosexism, homophobia, violence, noncommitment, and unwanted births became a thing of the past. Black men loved themselves in new and walk-worthy ways, reveling in their Black sisters, revering their Black brothers; they were no longer low down and no more living on the down low; they were keeping it real and keeping it right, assuming responsibility for raising their own beautiful Black children. Black women, meanwhile, loved as they had always loved, and will always love, with a magnificent love that would not let their Black brothers and sisters, mothers and fathers, children and elders go. Black women and men of diverse sexualities were loved without stigma and loved unreservedly; they were loved in their own right and they in turn loved, and rejoiced to be loved and received among their own kith and kin at last. Black elders were respected, honored, and cherished for their knowledge, goodness, and wisdom, and they taught the children well. Black children loved themselves, honored their parents and families, respected each other, excelled in academics, and attended newly opened community classes held in now-empty juke joints, pool halls, crack houses, and taverns. Black people of every gift and ability were affirmed without exception and a positive self-identity was extolled by all. *By making our separate past a present source of strength*, a new generation of women and men were being prepared to become the leaders and lovers of us all.

But that was not all. Believers also formed a spirited Black-led movement to eliminate poverty, inequality, and despair among the growing ranks of the disenchanting and disenfranchised in every community. Blacks were second to none and *primus inter pares*—first among equals—in test scores, academic scholarships, school achievements, professional certifications, job promotions, family stability, community development, quality of life, health promotion, political status, and social prestige—making broad gains by every indicator and in every arena except the military, sports, entertainment, and service sector economies—positions that Blacks did not at all dismiss but which no longer compared to the excitement of transforming and creating new and life-sustaining models of enterprise, industry, education, science, technology, faithfulness, and righteousness. Blacks were further empowered through apt participation in the political process and only purchased life-enhancing products made or otherwise given a vote of approval by the entire community.

For much of the white world it was absolutely unfathomable, unsettling, unpatriotic, undemocratic, Blacks not engaging in chronic crime, pathological wrongdoing, internecine violence, and self-destructive behaviors. The crack, tobacco, beer, malt liquor, pharmaceutical, and pork rind industries went under for lack of customers. Beauty supply stores and nail salons came under new ownership. Convenience stores, shopping malls, the five and dime, restaurants, and service stations, these too developed a new look and a new attitude. The health care, fast food, casino, games, and funeral industries faced a new crisis as Black people became nutritionally, emotionally, and spiritually whole and of one piece.

Affirmative action was discarded as powerful new coalitions with progressive whites, Asians, Latino/as, Native peoples, lesbians, gays, transgendered, the working poor, the poorest of the poor, the unruly poor, society's ignored, "the least of these" were forged and the earth itself was once again held inviolable and sacred. The criminal justice system fell into disorder, despair, and finally disrepair as penal institutions were transformed into empowerment zones, as jail-houses, prisons, detention centers, and halfway houses became campuses of higher learning. Black men were transformed en masse by the new movement in the Black community. Black

women, who had always been the child carriers, burden bearers, heavy load sharers, cultural transmitters, mules of the world, rocks of Gibraltar, pillars of faith, our all in all, were finally and at last able to exhale.

Black people were doing a new thing, with children, women, and men together and in concert hitting their stride, breaking their chains, decolonizing their minds, embracing the universe, forging a new future, fulfilling their destiny, finding their purpose, loving themselves deeply, doing justice, loving mercy, and walking humbly, self-determined, together and in equality, always and forever keeping the faith.

Christians, Muslims, people of all faiths, and those of no professed religious faith at all were as one. No more surrender, no more self-doubt, no more fear, no more emasculation, no more domestication, no more emulation, no more intimidation, no more incivility, no more disrespect, no more thieves in the temple, no more entertainment passing for religion, no more demeaning young people, no more disrespecting elders, no more abandoning families, no more violence, no more sexism, no more misogyny, no more homophobia, no more heterosexism, no more patriarchy, no more misanthropy, no more global warming, no more desecration of the earth, no more ethnocentrism, no more colorism, no more hatred, no more apologies, no more internalized oppression, no more fatalism, no more feeling sorry for ourselves, no more time for excuses, no more abuse, no more killings, no more dying, no more lies, no more, no more.

“The stones that the builders rejected”—African-descended children, women, and men—had turned to building a new city, one not made by hands. The faithful called it by many names: the new heaven and the new earth, the new Jerusalem, the promised land, Mecca, Zion, a place of peace, the global village, the world house, the reign of God, sweet communion, and the common wealth, where all there is, is One. They had become Africa’s *Praisesong*, Mahalia Jackson’s *Whole World*, Bob Marley’s *One Love*, Public Enemy’s *Black Planet*, Aretha’s *RESPECT*, Queen Latifah’s *UNITY*, Third World’s *Children of the World*, Audre Lorde’s *common cause*, Desmond Tutu’s *rainbow people*, Martin Luther King Jr.’s *beloved community*. Change does not wait for some other person or some other time. In the insurgent words of Sweet Honey in the Rock and adopted by then Senator Barack Obama, “we are the ones, we are the ones, we’ve been waiting for.”⁶ Endarkened, empowered, enabled, emboldened, embracing, including—we are the ones, our “own best selves,” the very embodiment of the presence of God.⁷ Amen. Ashé.

Notes

1. Howard Thurman, *The Luminous Darkness* (New York: Harper & Row, 1965).
2. Again, *Endarkenment* is a term I have long employed to refer to the heritage of peoples of African descent. To be *endarkened* is to glean from, be nurtured within, and transformed by the critical distillation of cultural wisdom found throughout Africa and the African diaspora in ways organic and learned. The opacity of the experience of African women, children, and men in the transatlantic world context especially illumines the need for indigenous critique, cultural counter, sustainable lifeways, and sacred alternatives to the imperialist capitalist white supremacist patriarchal forms of hegemony, which now demean life. For conceptualization, I have been inspired by a vast array of elders (and some not so elderly) from the above-named witnesses to my own mother and father and including, but not limited to, the artistry of Billie Holiday, Bessie Smith, John Coltrane, Mahalia Jackson, Lorraine Hansberry, Althea Gibson, James Baldwin, Nina Simone, James Brown, the O’Jays, Moms Mabley, Richard Pryor, Muhammad Ali, Marvin Gaye, Angela Davis, The Last Poets, Beah Richards, Julie Dash, Halie Gerima, Dianne Reaves, Sweet Honey in the Rock, Aretha Franklin, Stevie Wonder, Jill Scott, India Arie, Toni Morrison, Common, Nas, Mos Def, Ava Duvernay, and especially the many millions gone.
3. A popular term from the Akan of Ghana, West Africa.

4. The Swahili words throughout are from the *Nguzo Saba* or The Seven Principles as developed by Maulana Karenga, *Kwanzaa: A Celebration of Family, Community and Culture* (Los Angeles, CA: University of Sankore Press, 1998).
5. Langston Hughes, *The Ways of White Folk* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1934).
6. Lyrics from Sweet Honey in the Rock, "We Are the Ones We've Been Waiting For," *Twenty-Five*, 1998. See also my editorial, "President-Elect Barack Obama" in *U.S. News and World Report*, November 5, 2008.
7. I am here paraphrasing Paul D's concluding words to Sethe: "You your own best thing, Sethe. You are." Toni Morrison, *Beloved* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1987), 273.

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